

HARRY POTTER
AND THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS

BY

J.K. ROWLING

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BY J.K. ROWLING

THE UNIQUE ONLINE EXPERIENCE BUILT AROUND THE HARRY POTTER
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READ BY N.P.F. HARRIS,

GRANDWAY DRIVER AND FLYING-WEATHER FRIEND

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THE WERST BIRTHDAY

ET HER THE FIRST TIME, AN ARGUMENT HAD BROKEN OUT OVER BREAKFAST AT

NUMBER FOUR, PRIVET DRIVE. MR. VERNEEN OLDSLEY HAD BEEN WOKEN IN THE EARLY HOURS OF THE MORNING BY A CHILD, FLEEING NEARLY FROM HIS NEPHEW

HARRY S REEM.

THIRD TIME THIS WEEK? HE REMARKED ACROSS THE TABLE. IF YOU CAN T CENTRE

THAT END, IT LL HAVE THE CH?

HARRY TRIED, YET AGAIN, TO EXPLAIN.

SHE S SURE, HE SAID. SHE S USED TO FLYING AROUND OUTSIDE. IF I COULD

JUST LET HER OUT AT NIGHT

OH I WERE STUPID? SNARLED UNCLE VERNEEN, A BIT OF FRIED EGG DANGLED

FROM HIS SLIPSTICK. I KNOW WHAT LL HAPPEN IF THAT END S LET OUT.

HE EXCHANGED DARK WORDS WITH HIS WIFE, PETUNIA.

HARRY TRIED TO ARGUE BACK BUT HIS WORDS WERE DROWNED BY A LONG, LONG

RECK FROM THE OLDSLEYS SON, OLDSLEY.

I WANT MORE EATEN.

THERE S MORE IN THE FRYING PAN, SWEETLIPS, SAID AUNT PETUNIA, TURNING

MISTY EYES AND HER MASSIVE SHIN. HE MUST BLIND THEM UP WHILE WE'RE
GONE THE

CHANCE, . . . I DON'T LIKE THE SOUND OF THAT SCREAMING, . . .

NONSENSE, PETLINA, I NEVER WENT BLIND WHEN I WAS AT
SMELTING, SAID

UNCLE VERNEEN HEARTILY. DUDLEY GETS ENOUGH, DON'T YOU, SHEN?

DUDLEY, WHO WAS SEE LARGE HIS BROTHER DROPPED OVER EITHER SIDE OF
THE

KITCHEN CHAIR, GRINNED AND TURNED THE HARRY.

PASS THE FRYING PAN.

YOU'RE FORGOTTEN THE MAGIC WORD, SAID HARRY IRRITABLY.

THE EFFECT OF THIS SIMPLE SENTENCE ON THE REST OF THE FAMILY WAS
INCREDIBLE: DUDLEY GASPED AND FELL OFF HIS CHAIR WITH A CRASH THAT
SHOOK THE

WHOLE KITCHEN; MRS. DURSLEY GAVE A SMALL SCREAM AND CLAPPED HER
HANDS THE

HER MOUTH; MR. DURSLEY LIMPED THE HIS FEET, VEINS THROBBING IN HIS
TEMPLES.

I MEANT PLEASE! SAID HARRY HELICIOUSLY. I DIDN'T MEAN

WHAT HAVE I TOLD YOU, THUNDERED HIS UNCLE, SPRAYING
SPIT OVER

THE TABLE, ABELT SAYING THE M WORD IN HIS HELIOUS?

BUT I

HELD DARE YOU THREATEN DUDLEY? REARED UNCLE VERNEEN,
PUNTING THE TABLE WITH HIS FIST.

I LIST

I WARNED YOU: I WILL NOT TOLERATE MENTION OF
YOUR

ABNORMALITY UNDER THIS ROOF!

HARRY STARED FROM HIS PURPLE-FACED UNCLE TO HIS PALE AUNT, WHO WAS

TRYING TO HEAVE DULY TO HIS FEET.

ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY, ALL RIGHT...

UNCLE VERNON SAT BACK DOWN, BREATHING LIKE A WINDED RHINOCEROS AND

WATCHING HARRY CLOSELY OUT OF THE CORNERS OF HIS SMALL, SHARP EYES.

EVER SINCE HARRY HAD COME HOME FOR THE SUMMER HOLIDAYS, UNCLE VERNON HAD BEEN TREATING HIM LIKE A BOMB THAT MIGHT GO OFF AT ANY

MOMENT, BECAUSE HARRY POTTER WASN'T A NORMAL KID. AS A MATTER OF FACT, HE

WAS AS NOT NORMAL AS IT IS POSSIBLE TO BE.

HARRY POTTER WAS A WIZARD A WIZARD FRESH FROM HIS FIRST YEAR AT

HOGWARTS SCHOOL OF WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY, AND IF THE DURSLEYS WERE

UNHAPPY TO HAVE HIM BACK FOR THE HOLIDAYS, IT WAS NOTHING THE MORE HARRY

FEELT.

HE MISSED HOGWARTS SO MUCH IT WAS LIKE HAVING A CONSTANT STOMACHACHE. HE MISSED THE CASTLE, WITH ITS SECRET PASSAGEWAYS AND GHOSTS, HIS CLASSES (THOUGH PERHAPS NOT SNAPE, THE POTIONS MASTER), THE

MAIL ARRIVING BY HOWL, EATING SANDWICHES IN THE GREAT HALL, SLEEPING IN HIS

FOUR-POSTER BED IN THE TOWER DORMITORY, VISITING THE GAMEKEEPER, Hagrid, IN

HIS CARKIN NEXT TO THE FERRIDEN FEREST IN THE GRHLINDS, AND,
ESPECIALLY,

BLIDDITCH, THE MOST PEPLULAR SPORT IN THE WIZARDING WORLD (SIX
TALL

CHALPISTS, FHLR FLYING BALLS, AND FHLRTEEN PLAYERS EN KRHHMSTICKS).

ALL F-JARRY S SPELLKHHHS, HIS WAND, RHHKS, CALDRHEN, AND THE-OF-THE-
LINE

NIPKLS THE THHLISAND KRHHMSTICK HAD BEEN LOCKED IN A CLIPSHARD
LINDER

THE STAIRS BY LNKLE VERNEEN THE INSTANT F-JARRY HAD CHME F-HME.
WHAT DID THE

BLURSEYS CARE IF F-JARRY LHST HIS PLACE EN THE F-HLISE BLIDDITCH TEAM
BECAUSE

HE HADN T PRACTICED ALL SLIMPER? WHAT WAS IT THE THE BLURSEYS IF
F-JARRY WENT

BACK TH SC-HHL WITH-HLIT AND OF HIS F-HMELWHHX DEHN? THE BLURSEYS
WERE

WHAT WIZARDS CALLED MLEGLS (NHT A DRHP OF MAGICAL BLEHD IN THEIR
VEINS),

AND AS FAR AS THEY WERE CHNERNED, HAVING A WIZARD IN THE FAMILY
WAS A

MATTER OF DEEPEST SHAME. LNKLE VERNEEN HAD EVEN PABLISHED
F-JARRY S HHL,

F-JEDWIG, INSIDE HER CAGE, TH STHP HER FROM CARRYING MESSAGES TH
ANYHNE IN

THE WIZARDING WORLD,

F-JARRY LHHEDD NOTHING LIKE THE REST OF THE FAMILY. LNKLE VERNEEN
WAS LARGE

AND NEEDLESS, WITH AN ENHRRMHLIS BLACK MLSTACHE; AUNT PETLINIA
WAS F-HRSE-

PALED AND BURNED; DUDLEY WAS BURNED, PINK, AND PINKED, HARRY, IN THE
MOTHER

HAND, WAS SMALL AND SKINNY, WITH BRILLIANT GREEN EYES AND IET-BLACK
HAIR

THAT WAS ALWAYS LINTIDY, HE WERE REHLND GLASSES, AND IN HIS
MERE-HEAD WAS A

THIN, LIGHTNING-SHAPED SCAR.

IT WAS THIS SCAR THAT MADE HARRY SEE PARTICULARLY UNUSUAL, EVEN
FOR A

WIZARD. THIS SCAR WAS THE ONLY HINT OF HARRY'S VERY MYSTERIOUS
PAST, OF THE

REASON HE HAD BEEN LEFT IN THE DURSLEYS' CHERSTED ELEVEN YEARS
BEFORE.

AT THE AGE OF ONE YEAR OLD, HARRY HAD SOMEHOW SURVIVED A CURSE
FROM

THE GREATEST DARK SORCERER OF ALL TIME, LORD VOLDMORT, WHOSE
NAME MUST

WITCHES AND WIZARDS STILL FEARED THE SPARK. HARRY'S PARENTS HAD DIED
IN

VOLDMORT'S ATTACK, BUT HARRY HAD ESCAPED WITH HIS LIGHTNING
SCAR, AND

SOMEHOW NEARLY UNDERSTOOD WHY VOLDMORT'S POWERS HAD
BEEN

DESTROYED THE INSTANT HE HAD FAILED TO KILL HARRY.

SEE HARRY HAD BEEN BRUGHT UP BY HIS DEAD MOTHER'S SISTER AND HER
HUSBAND, HE HAD SPENT TEN YEARS WITH THE DURSLEYS, NEVER
UNDERSTANDING

WHY HE KEPT MAKING THE THINGS HAPPEN WITHOUT MEANING THEM,
BELIEVING THE

BLURBLEY'S STORY THAT HE HAD GOTTEN HIS SCAR IN THE CAR CRASH THAT HAD
KILLED HIS
PARENTS.

AND THEN, EXACTLY A YEAR AGO, FLEEWARTS HAD WRITTEN TO HARRY,
AND THE

WHOLE STORY HAD COME OUT. HARRY HAD TAKEN UP HIS PLACE AT WIZARD
SCHOOL,

WHERE HE AND HIS SCAR WERE FAMOUS . . . BUT NOW THE SCHOOL YEAR WAS
OVER,

AND HE WAS BACK WITH THE BLURBLEYS FOR THE SUMMER, BACK TO BEING
TREATED

LIKE A BOY THAT HAD REBELLED IN SOMEHOW STUPID.

THE BLURBLEYS HADN'T EVEN REMEMBERED THAT TODAY HAPPENED TO BE
HARRY'S TWELFTH BIRTHDAY. HE'LL WISE, HIS EXPECTATIONS HADN'T BEEN HIGH;
THEY'D

NEVER GIVEN HIM A REAL PRESENT, LET ALONE A CAR. BUT HE IGNORED
IT

COMPLETELY . . .

AT THAT MOMENT, UNCLE VERNON CLEARED HIS THROAT IMPORTANTLY
AND SAID,

NOW, AS WE ALL KNOW, TODAY IS A VERY IMPORTANT DAY.

HARRY LEECHES UP, HARDLY DARING TO BELIEVE IT.

"THIS COULD WELL BE THE DAY I MAKE THE BIGGEST DEAL OF MY CAREER,"
SAID

UNCLE VERNON.

HARRY WENT BACK TO HIS TEA. HE'LL WISE, HE THOUGHT BITTERLY,
UNCLE

VERNON WAS TALKING ABOUT THE STUPID DINNER PARTY. HE'D BEEN
TALKING OF

NOTHING ELSE FOR TWO WEEKS. SOME RICH KILDER AND HIS WIFE WERE
CHEERING THE

DINNER AND UNCLE VERNON WAS HELPING THE GET A FLYER ORDER FROM
HIM UNCLE

VERNON'S COMPANY MADE DRILLS!

I THINK WE SHOULD RUN THROUGH THE SCHEDULE HERE MORE TIME, SAID
UNCLE

VERNON, WE SHOULD ALL BE IN POSITION AT EIGHT O'CLOCK, PETLINIA,
WELL WILL BE

?

IN THE LIVING, SAID AUNT PETLINIA PREMPTLY, WAITING THE
WELCOME THEM

GRACIOUSLY THE ELIA HOME.

GOOD, GOOD, AND DUDLEY?

I WILL BE WAITING THE OPEN THE DEER, DUDLEY PUT HER A FEEL, SIMPERING
SMILE. MAY I TAKE YOUR CHATS, MR. AND MRS. MASHEN?

THEY WILL LOVE HIM? CRIED AUNT PETLINIA RAPTURELISLY,

EXCELLENT, DUDLEY, SAID UNCLE VERNON, THEN HE REELINED HER
HARRY,

AND WELL?

I WILL BE IN MY BEDROOM, MAKING NEW NEISE AND PRETENDING I'M NOT
THERE,

SAID HARRY TENSELESSLY,

EXACTLY, SAID UNCLE VERNON NASTILY, I WILL LEAD THEM INTO THE
LIVING,

INTRODUCE WELL, PETLINIA, AND PHILIP THEM DRINKS, AT EIGHT-FIFTEEN

I WILL ANNOUNCE DINNER, SAID AUNT PETLINIA,

AND, DUDLEY, WELL WILL SAY

MAY I TAKE YOU THROUGH THE THE DINING ROOM, MRS. MASHEN? SAID
DUDLEY,

HOPPING HIS FAT ARM THE AN INVISIBLE WOMAN,

MY PERFECT LITTLE GENTLEMAN? SNIPPED ALINT PETLINIA,

AND YOU? SAID LITTLE VERNON VICIOUSLY THE FARRY,

I LL BE IN MY ROOM, MAKING NE NEISE AND PRETENDING I M NOT
THERE,

SAID FARRY DULLY.

PRECISELY, NOW, WE SHOULD AIM TO GET IN A FEW GOOD COMPLIMENTS
AT

DINNER, PETLINIA, ANY IDEAS?

VERNON TELLS ME YOU RE A WONDERFUL CHEER, MR. MASHEN, ... DEE TELL
ME

WHERE YOU ENJOY YOUR DRESS, MRS. MASHEN, ...

PERFECT ... DUDLEY?

WELL ASKED WE HAD TO WRITE AN ESSAY ASKED HER HERE AT
SCHOOL, MR.

MASHEN, AND I WRITE ASKED YOU.

THIS WAS THE MUCH HER WITH ALINT PETLINIA AND FARRY, ALINT
PETLINIA FIRST

INTO TEARS AND HUGGED HER SON, WHILE FARRY DUCKED UNDER THE TABLE
SEE THEY

WOULDN T SEE HIM LAUGHING.

AND YOU, KID?

FARRY FELT THE DEEP HIS FACE STRAIGHT AS HE EMERGED.

I LL BE IN MY ROOM, MAKING NE NEISE AND PRETENDING I M NOT
THERE, HE

SAID.

THE RIGHT, SHELL WILL, SAID LUNCLE VERNON FIRCEFULLY, THE
MASHES BEEN T

KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT SHELL AND IT S GOING THE STAY THAT WAY, WHEN
DINNER S

EVER, SHELL TAKE MRS. MASHEN BACK THE THE BEHINDER PER CHAPER, PETLONIA,
AND I LL

BRING THE SUBJECT AROUND THE DRILLS, WITH ANY LUCK, I LL HAVE THE
DEAL SIGNED

AND SEALED BEFORE THE NEWS AT TEN, WE LL BE SHOPPING FOR A VACATION
HOME

IN MAHERCA THIS TIME THEMORROW.

HARRY COULDNT FEEL THE EXCITED ABOUT THIS, HE DIDNT THINK THE
DURABLES

WOULD LIKE HIM ANY BETTER IN MAHERCA THAN THEY DID HIS PRIVATE
DRIVE.

RIGHT I M OFF INTO THE TOWN THE PICK UP THE DINNER JACKET S FOR
DUDLEY AND

MR. AND SHELL, HE SNARLED AT HARRY, SHELL STAY HEAT IF SHELL ALINT S
WAY WHILE

SHE S CLEANING.

HARRY LEFT THROUGH THE BACK DOOR. IT WAS A BRILLIANT, SUNNY DAY,
HE

CROSSED THE LAWN, SLUMPED DOWN ON THE GARDEN BENCH, AND SANG
UNDER HIS

BREATH:

HAPPY BIRTHDAY THE MR ... HAPPY BIRTHDAY THE MR ...

NEW CARDS, NEW PRESENTS, AND HE WOULD BE SPENDING THE EVENING
PRETENDING

HENT THE EXIST, HE GAZED MISERABLY INTO THE HEDGE, HE HAD NEVER FELT
SEE

MENTLY, MORE THAN ANYTHING ELSE AT FLEGLARTS, MORE EVEN THAN PLAYING

FLUIDITCH, HARRY MISSED HIS BEST FRIENDS, RON WEASLEY AND HERMION

GRANGER. THEY, HOWEVER, DIDN'T SEEM TO BE MISSING HIM AT ALL. NEITHER OF

THEM HAD WRITTEN TO HIM ALL SUMMER, EVEN THOUGH RON HAD SAID HE WAS

GOING TO ASK HARRY TO COME AND STAY.

UNTIL LATE TIMES, HARRY HAD BEEN IN THE POINT OF UNLOCKING FREDWIG'S

LOCK BY MAGIC AND SENDING HER TO RON AND HERMION WITH A LETTER, BUT IT

WASN'T WORTH THE RISK. UNDERAGE WIZARDS WEREN'T ALLOWED THE USE OF MAGIC

HELTSIDE OF SCHOOL. HARRY HADN'T TOLD THE DURSLEYS THIS; HE KNEW IT WAS ONLY

THEIR TERROR THAT HE MIGHT TURN THEM ALL INTO OLIVE BEETLES THAT STOPPED THEM

FROM LOCKING HIM IN THE CLIPBOARD UNDER THE STAIRS WITH HIS WAND AND

CRUMMISTICK. FOR THE FIRST TIME IN YEARS BACK, HARRY HAD ENJOYED MUTTERING NONSENSE WORDS UNDER HIS BREATH AND WATCHING DUDLEY TEARING

HELT OF THE ROOM AS FAST AS HIS FAT LEGS WOULD CARRY HIM. BUT THE LONG SILENCE

FROM RON AND HERMION HAD MADE HARRY FEEL SHE WASN'T FROM THE MAGICAL

WORLD THAT EVEN TALTING DUDLEY HAD LOST ITS APPEAL AND NOW RON AND

HERMION HAD FORGOTTEN HIS BIRTHDAY.

WHAT WOULDNT HE GIVE NOW FOR A MESSAGE FROM HOGWARTS? FROM ANY

WITCH OR WIZARD? HE D ALMOST BE GLAD OF A SIGHT OF HIS ARCH-ENEMY, DRACO

MALFOY, JUST THE BE SURE IT HADNT ALL BEEN A DREAM. . .

JUST THAT HIS WHOLE YEAR AT HOGWARTS HAD BEEN FLIN. AT THE VERY END OF

LAST TERM, HARRY HAD COME FACE-TO-FACE WITH NONE OTHER THAN LORD

VOLDEMORT HIMSELF. VOLDEMORT MIGHT BE A SLIN OF HIS FORMER SELF, BUT HE

WAS STILL TERRIFYING, STILL CLANNING, STILL DETERMINED THE REGAIN POWER. HARRY

HAD SLIPPED THROUGH VOLDEMORT S CLUTCHES FOR A SECOND TIME, BUT IT HAD

BEEN A NARROW ESCAPE, AND EVEN NOW, WEEKS LATER, HARRY DEPT WAKING IN THE

NIGHT, DRENCHED IN COLD SWEAT, WONDERING WHERE VOLDEMORT WAS NOW,

REMEMBERING HIS LIVID FACE, HIS WIDE, MAD EYES

HARRY SLIDENLY SAT UP LIPRIGHT ON THE GARDEN BENCH. HE HAD BEEN

STARING ABSENT-MINDELY INTO THE HEDGE AND THE HEDGE WAS STARING BACK.

TWO ENORMOUS GREEN EYES HAD APPEARED AMONG THE LEAVES.

HARRY JUMPED THE HIS FEET JUST AS A IRERING VEHICLE FLEATED ACROSS THE LAWN.

I KNOW WHAT DAY IT IS, SANG DUDLEY, LADDLING TOWARD HIM.

THE BLUE EYES BLINKED AND VANISHED.

WHAT? SAID HARRY, NOT TAKING HIS EYES OFF THE SPOT WHERE THEY HAD

KEEN,

I KNOW WHAT DAY IT IS, DUDLEY REPEATED, CREEPING RIGHT UP TO HIM.

WELL THEN, SAID HARRY, SEE YELL YE FINALLY LEARNED THE DAYS OF THE

WEEK.

TODAY'S YELLER BIRTHDAY, SNIGGERED DUDLEY, B-HEN WHEN YELL HAVEN T GET

AND CARDS? HAVEN T YELL EVEN GET FRIENDS AT THAT FREAK PLACE?

BETTER NOT LET YELLER MOM HEAR YELL TALKING ABOUT MY SCHEM, SAID HARRY

CHHLLY.

DUDLEY HITCHED UP HIS TROUSERS, WHICH WERE SLIPPING DOWN HIS FAT BUTT.

WHY RE YELL STARRING AT THE FUDGE? HE SAID SUSPICIOUSLY.

I M TRYING TO DECIDE WHAT WOULD BE THE BEST SPELL TO SET IT ON FIRE, SAID

HARRY.

DUDLEY STUMBLERD BACKWARD AT ONCE, A LOOK OF PANIC ON HIS FAT FACE.

YELL I-CAN T DAD TELD YELL YELL RE NOT TO DO M-MAGIC HE SAID HE LI

CHLD YELL HLT OF THE FUDGE AND YELL HAVEN T GET ANYWHERE ELSE TO GO

YELL HAVEN T GET ANY FRIENDS TO TAKE YELL

IGGERY PEEERY! SAID HARRY IN A PIERCE VOICE. FHELLS PHELLS SHELLIGLY WIGGLY

MLLLLLLL! HEHED DUDLEY, TRIPPING OVER HIS FEET AS HE DASHED

BACK TOWARD THE FUDGE. MLLLLLL! HE S HEARD YELL KNOW WHAT?

FARRY PAID DEARLY FOR HIS MOMENT OF FLIN. AS NEITHER DUDLEY NEER
THE

HEDGE WAS IN ANY WAY HURT, ALINT PETLINIA KNEW HE HADN'T REALLY
DUNK

MAGIC, BUT HE STILL HAD THE BLICK AS SHE AIMED A HEAVY BLEW AT HIS
HEAD WITH

THE SHADY FRYING PAN. THEN SHE GAVE HIM WHERE THE OH, WITH THE
PROMISE HE

WOULDN'T EAT AGAIN UNTIL HE'D FINISHED.

WHILE DUDLEY LELLED AROUND WATCHING AND EATING ICE CREAM, FARRY
CLEANED THE WINDOWS, WASHED THE CAR, MOWED THE LAWN, TRIMMED THE
FLOWER

BEDS, PRUNED AND WATERED THE ROSES, AND REPAINTED THE GARDEN BENCH.
THE

SUN BLAZED OVERHEAD, BURNING THE BACK OF HIS NECK. FARRY KNEW HE
SHOULDN'T HAVE RISEN THE DUDLEY'S BAIT, BUT DUDLEY HAD SAID THE VERY
THING

FARRY HAD BEEN THINKING HIMSELF . . . MAYBE HE DIDN'T HAVE ANY
FRIENDS AT

THE CLARTS. . .

WITH THE CHILD SEE FATHERS FARRY PETER NEER, HE THOUGHT
SAVAGELY AS HE

SPREAD MANURE ON THE FLOWER BEDS, HIS BACK ACHING, SWEAT RUNNING
DOWN

HIS FACE.

IT WAS HALF PAST SEVEN IN THE EVENING WHEN AT LAST, EXHAUSTED, HE
HEARD

ALINT PETLINIA CALLING HIM.

GET IN HERE! AND WALK ON THE NEWSPAPER!

HARRY MOVED GLADLY INTO THE SHADE OF THE GLEAMING KITCHEN, AND
THEY WERE

THE FRIDGE STEWED TONIGHT'S PUDDING: A FLICKER OF WHIPPED
CREAM AND

SWEARED VIOLETS, A LEIN OF ROAST PORK WAS SIZZLING IN THE FRYER.

"AT LAST! THE MASTERS WILL BE HERE SOON!" SNAPPED ALICE
PETLINIA,

POINTING TO THE SLICES OF BREAD AND A LUMP OF BUTTER ON THE
KITCHEN TABLE.

SHE WAS ALREADY WEARING A SALMON-PINK CRESTED DRESS.

HARRY WASHED HIS HANDS AND RUSHED DOWN HIS PITHY SLIPPER. THE
MOMENT

HE HAD FINISHED, ALICE PETLINIA WHISKED AWAY HIS PLATE. UPSTAIRS?
HARRY?

AS HE PASSED THE DOOR TO THE LIVING ROOM, HARRY CAUGHT A GLIMPSE
OF

UNCLE VERNON AND DUDLEY IN KILT TIES AND DINNER JACKETS. HE HAD
ONLY JUST

REACHED THE UPSTAIRS LANDING WHEN THE DOORBELL RANG AND UNCLE
VERNON'S

FLORIDIAN FACE APPEARED AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS.

REMEMBER, KID HENK SHINE

HARRY CROSSED TO HIS BEDROOM AND TIP-TOE, SLIPPED INSIDE, CLOSED THE
DOOR,

AND TURNED TO COLLAPSE ON HIS BED.

THE TRICKLE WAS, THERE WAS ALREADY SOMEONE SITTING ON IT.

—

CHAPTER TWO

DEEKE'S WARNING

ARRY MANAGED NOT TO SEE THE SHINY EYE, BUT IT WAS A CLOSE THING. THE LITTLE

CREATURE ON THE BED HAD LARGE, BAT-LIKE EARS AND GLIMMERING GREEN EYES THE SIZE OF TENNIS BALLS. HARRY KNEW INSTANTLY THAT THIS WAS WHAT HAD BEEN

WATCHING HIM FROM THE GARDEN HEDGE THAT MORNING.

AS THEY STARED AT EACH OTHER, HARRY HEARD DUDLEY'S VOICE FROM THE HALL.

MAY I TAKE YOUR CHATS, MR. AND MRS. MASHEN?

THE CREATURE SLIPPED OFF THE BED AND RAN TO SEE WHY THAT THE END OF ITS

LEGS, THEN WHEN IT TOUCHED THE CARPET, HARRY NOTICED THAT IT WAS WEARING WHAT

LOOKED LIKE AN OLD PILLOWCASE, WITH RIPS FOR ARM- AND LEG-HOLES.

OR FELLER, SAID HARRY NERVOUSLY.

HARRY PETER? SAID THE CREATURE IN A HIGH-PITCHED VOICE HARRY WAS SURE

WOULD CARRY DOWN THE STAIRS. SHE HUNG HAS DEEKE WANTED TO MEET WITH,

SIR . . . SUCH AN EAGER IT IS . . .

TH-THANK YOU, SAID HARRY, EDGING ALONG THE WALL AND SINKING INTO HIS

DESK CHAIR, NEXT TO FREDDIE, WHO WAS ASLEEP IN HER LARGE CAGE. HE WANTED THE

ASK, WHAT ARE YOU? BUT THOUGHT IT WOULD BE THE WISE, SHE
INSTEAD HE

SAID, WHO ARE YOU?

DEERY, SIR, I'VE DEERY, DEERY THE FELLOW-ELF, SAID THE CREATURE,

HE REALLY? SAID HARRY, ER I DON'T WANT THE BE WISE HER
ANYTHING,

BUT THIS ISN'T A GREAT TIME FOR ME TO HAVE A FELLOW-ELF IN MY
BEDROOM,

ALONG PETLINA'S HIGH, PALE BALCONY BEHIND FROM THE LIVING ROOM,
THE ELF

HING HIS HEAD,

NEET THAT I'M NEET PLEASED TO MEET YOU, SAID HARRY HELICIOUSLY, BUT,
ER, IS

THERE ANY PARTICULAR REASON YOU'RE HERE?

HE, YES, SIR, SAID DEERY EARNESTLY, DEERY HAS COME TO TELL YOU,
SIR... IT IS DIFFICULT, SIR... DEERY WONDERS WHERE THE BEGIN...

SIT DOWN, SAID HARRY POLITELY, POINTING AT THE BED,
THE HIS FURROW, THE ELF BURST INTO TEARS VERY NOISY TEARS,
S-SIT DOWN! HE WAILED, NEVER... NEVER EVER...

HARRY THOUGHT HE HEARD THE VEHICLES DOWNSTAIRS FAULTER,

I'M SORRY, HE WHISPERED, I DON'T MEAN TO HURRY YOU HER
ANYTHING

HURRY DEERY? CHECKED THE ELF, DEERY HAS NEVER BEEN ASKED TO SIT
DOWN BY A WIZARD LIKE AN EEL!

HARRY, TRYING TO SAY S-H-H AND WINK CHIMPARTING AT THE SAME
TIME,

WHISPERED DEERY BACK INTO THE BED WHERE HE SAT HICHLIGHING,
WHISKING LIKE A

LARGE AND VERY LELY DEHL. AT LAST HE MANAGED THE CENTREHL HIMSELF,
AND SAT

WITH HIS GREAT EYES FIXED HEN HARRY IN AN EXPRESSIHN OF WATERY
ADERATION.

YELI CAN T HAVE MET MANY DECENT WIZARDS, SAID HARRY, TRYING THE
CHER
HIM UP.

DEKKY SHHHED HIS HEAD. THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, HE LEAPT UP AND
STARTED

RANGING HIS HEAD FLIRHELSY HEN THE WINDHLL, SHEHTING, RAD DEKKY?
RAD

DEKKY?

DEHN T WHAT ARE YELI DEHING? HARRY HISSED, SPRINGING UP AND
PULLING

DEKKY BACK HENTH THE BED HEDWIG HAD WHEREN UP WITH A
PARTICULARLY LEHL

STRECH AND WAS BEATING HER WINGS WILDBY AGAINST THE BARS OF HER
CAGE.

DEKKY HAD THE PLINISH HIMSELF, SIR, SAID THE EL, WHH HAD CHENE
SLIGHTLY

CRHSS-EYED, DEKKY ALMHST SPEER ILL OF HIS FAMILY, SIR, . . .

YELIR FAMILY?

THE WIZARD FAMILY DEKKY SERVES, SIR, . . . DEKKY IS A FHELSE-EL
BEHLND THE SERVE HNE FHELSE AND HNE FAMILY AHERVER, . . .

DEH THEY DEHEH YELI RE HERE? ASKED HARRY CLIRHELSY,
DEKKY SHLDBERED.

HH, NEH, SIR, NEH . . . DEKKY WILL HAVE THE PLINISH HIMSELF MEET
GRIFVHELSY

AFTER LEARNING THE SEE YELL, SIR, DICKY WILL HAVE THE SILENT HIS EARS IN THE HEAVEN

DEERER AFTER THIS, IF THEY EVER KNOW, SIR

BUT WHEN T THEY NOTICE IF YELL SILENT YELLER EARS IN THE HEAVEN DEERER?
DICKY BELIEVES IT, SIR, DICKY IS ALWAYS HAVING THE PUNISH HIMSELF AFTER
SOMETHING, SIR, THEY LETS DICKY GET ON WITH IT, SIR, SOMETIMES THEY
REMINDS ME THE DEE EXTRA PUNISHMENTS, . . .

BUT WHY DEER T YELL LEAVE? ESCAPE?

A FELLOW-ER MUST BE SET FREE, SIR, AND THE FAMILY WILL NEVER SET
DICKY

FREE . . . DICKY WILL SERVE THE FAMILY UNTIL HE DIES, SIR, . . .

HARRY STARED,

AND I THOUGHT I HAD IT BAD STAYING HERE AFTER ANOTHER FELLOW
WEEKS, HE

SAID, THIS MAKES THE DURSLEYS FEELING ALMOST HUMAN, CAN T ANYONE
HELP

YELL? CAN T IT

ALMOST AT ONCE, HARRY WISHED HE HADN T SPOKEN, DICKY DISAPPEARED
AGAIN

IN THE WAILS OF GRATITUDE,

PLEASE, HARRY WHISPERED FRANTICALLY, PLEASE BE SILENT, IF THE
DURSLEYS

HEAR ANYTHING, IF THEY KNOW YELL BE HERE

HARRY BETTER ASKS IF HE CAN HELP DICKY . . . DICKY HAS HEARD OF
YELLER

GREATNESS, SIR, BUT OF YELLER GOODNESS, DICKY NEVER KNOW, . . .

HARRY, WHO WAS FEELING DISTINCTLY HURT IN THE FACE, SAID, WHATEVER

WELL YE HEARD ABELT MY GREATNESS IS A LEAD OF BLISS- I M NOT EVEN
THEY M

MY DEAR AT ELEGANTS; THAT S HERMINE, SHE

BUT HE STOPPED QUICKLY, BECAUSE THINKING ABELT HERMINE WAS
PAINFUL.

HARRY POTTER IS HUMBLE AND MODEST, SAID DEEY REVERENTLY, HIS
HRS-

LIKE EYES AHEAD, HARRY POTTER SPEAKS NOT OF HIS TRIUMPH OVER
HE-WEH

MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED

WHEREMERT? SAID HARRY.

DEEY CLAPPED HIS HANDS OVER HIS BAT EARS AND MEANED, AH, SPEAK
NOT

THE NAME, SIR! SPEAK NOT THE NAME!

SIRRY, SAID HARRY QUICKLY, I KNOW LETS OF PEOPLE DENY T LIKE IT,
MY

FRIEND RHN

HE STOPPED AGAIN, THINKING ABELT RHN WAS PAINFUL, THEE.

DEEY LEANED TOWARD HARRY, HIS EYES WIDE AS HEADLIGHTS.

DEEY HEARD TELL, HE SAID HARSLEY, THAT HARRY POTTER MET THE
DARD

LEAD FOR A SECOND TIME, JUST WEEKS AGO . . . THAT HARRY POTTER
ESCAPED YET

AGAIN.

HARRY NEEDED AND DEEY S EYES SUDDENLY SHINE WITH TEARS.

AH, SIR, HE GASPED, DARTING HIS FACE WITH A CHINER OF THE GALLEY

PILLOWCASE HE WAS WEARING. HARRY POTTER IS VALIANT AND BRAVE! HE HAS

BRAVED SO MANY DANGERS ALREADY! BUT DEEPLY HAS COME THE PERFECT HARRY

POTTER, THE WARREN HIM, EVEN IF HE DOES HAVE THE SKILL HIS EARS IN THE EVEN DEER

LATER, . . . HARRY POTTER MUST NOT GO BACK THE HOGWARTS.

THERE WAS A SILENCE BROKEN ONLY BY THE CHIRP OF BIRDS AND FLOCKS FROM

DOWNSTAIRS AND THE DISTANT RUMBLE OF LINDA VERNON'S WHEEL.

WHAT? HARRY STAMMERED. BUT I'VE GOT TO GO BACK TERM STARTS IN

SEPTEMBER FIRST. IT'S ALL THAT'S KEEPING ME GOING. YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT IT'S

LIKE HERE, I DON'T BELONG HERE, I BELONG IN YOUR WORLD AT HOGWARTS.

NEE, NEE, NEE, SHAKED DEEPLY, SHAKING HIS HEAD SO HARD HIS EARS FLAPPED. HARRY POTTER MUST STAY WHERE HE IS SAFE, HE IS THE GREAT, THE

GOOD, THE BEST. IF HARRY POTTER GOES BACK THE HOGWARTS, HE WILL BE IN MENTAL

DANGER.

WHAT? SAID HARRY IN SURPRISE.

THERE IS A PLOT, HARRY POTTER, A PLOT THE MOST TERRIBLE THINGS

HAPPEN AT HOGWARTS SCHOOL OF WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY THIS YEAR,

WHISPERED DEEPLY, SUDDENLY TREMBLING ALL OVER. DEEPLY HAS KNOWN IT FOR

MEANTHE, SIR, HARRY BETTER MUST NOT PUT HIMSELF IN PERIL, HE IS
THE

IMPORTANT, SIR!

WHAT TERRIBLE THINGS? SAID HARRY AT ONCE. WHAT IS HAPPENING
THERE?

DEKKY MADE A FLINNY CHECKING NOISE AND THEN RAN HIS HEAD
FRANTICALLY

AGAINST THE WALL.

ALL RIGHT! CRIED HARRY, GRABBING THE END OF HIS ARM TO STOP HIM. YOU
CAN'T

TELL ME, I UNDERSTAND, BUT WHY ARE YOU WARNING ME? A SUDDEN,
UNPLEASANT

THOUGHT STRUCK HIM. HANG ON THIS HASN'T GOTTEN ANYTHING TO DO
WITH YOU-

SHRILL WITH YOU-DEAR-WHAT, HAS IT? YOU COULD JUST SHOUT
FOR HIM, HE

ADDED HASTILY AS DEKKY'S HEAD TILTED WHIRRYINGLY CLOSE TO THE WALL
AGAIN.

SLOWLY, DEKKY STOPPED HIS HEAD.

NOT NOT HE-WHICH MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED, SIR

BUT DEKKY'S EYES WERE WIDE AND HE SEEMED TO BE TRYING TO GIVE HARRY
A

HINT, HARRY, HOWEVER, WAS COMPLETELY LOST.

HE HASN'T GOT A BROTHER, HAS HE?

DEKKY STOPPED HIS HEAD, HIS EYES WIDER THAN EVER.

WELL THEN, I CAN'T THINK WHO ELSE WOULD HAVE A CHANCE OF MAKING
HORRIBLE THINGS HAPPEN AT HOGWARTS, SAID HARRY. I MEAN,
THERE'S

OLMPLEBHERE, FOR ONE THING YOU KNOW WHO OLMPLEBHERE IS, DON'T
YOU?

DURRY KNEW HIS HEAD,

ALAS DUMBLEDORE IS THE GREATEST HEADMASTER HOGWARTS HAS EVER HAD,

DURRY KNOWS IT, SIR, DURRY HAS HEARD DUMBLEDORE'S PHEWERS RIVAL THOSE OF

THE-ONE-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED AT THE HEIGHT OF HIS STRENGTH, BUT, SIR

DURRY'S VOICE DROPPED TO AN URGENT WHISPER THERE ARE PHEWERS DUMBLEDORE DOESN'T... PHEWERS ARE DECENT WIZARD...

AND BEFORE HARRY COULD STOP HIM, DURRY KNEWED OFF THE BED, SEIZED HARRY'S DESK LAMP, AND STARTED BEATING HIMSELF AGAINST THE HEAD WITH

EARSPLITTING YELPS,

A SUDDEN SILENCE FELL DOWNSTAIRS. TWO SECONDS LATER HARRY, HEART THROBBING MADLY, HEARD UNCLE VERNON CHIMING INTO THE HALL, CALLING, DUDLEY

MUST HAVE LEFT HIS TELEVISION ON AGAIN, THE LITTLE TYPIC

WITCH! IN THE CLOSET! HISSED HARRY, STUFFING DURRY IN, SPLITTING THE

DOOR, AND FLINGING HIMSELF INTO THE BED INSTANT AS THE DOOR HANDLE TURNED.

WHAT THE DEVIL ARE YOU DOING? SAID UNCLE VERNON

THROUGH GRITTED TEETH, HIS FACE HORRIBLY CLOSE TO HARRY'S, YOU'VE INST

RUINED THE PLUCK LINE OF MY JAPANESE GILDER DRESS... HURRY MORE SILENT AND

YOU'LL BE WISH YOU'D NEVER BEEN BORN, KID!

HE STAMPED FLAT-FOOTED FROM THE ROOM,

SHADING, HARRY LET DICKY HUNT IN THE CLOSET,

SEE WHAT IT S LIKE HERE? HE SAID. SEE WHY I VE GOTT THE CHEEKS THE
HOGWARTS? IT S THE ONLY PLACE I VE GOTT WELL, I THINK I VE GOTT
FRIENDS.

FRIENDS WHO DONT EVEN WRITE THE HARRY POTTER? SAID DICKY SLOWLY,
I EXPECT THEY VE JUST BEEN WAIT A MINUTE, SAID HARRY,
FEELING.

THEY DONT KNOW MY FRIENDS HAVEN T BEEN WRITING THE ME?
DICKY SHOOKED HIS FEET.

HARRY POTTER MUSTN T BE ANGRY WITH DICKY, DICKY DID IT FOR THE
BEST

HAVE YOU BEEN STEPPING MY LETTERS?

DICKY HAS THEM HERE, SIR, SAID THE ELF, STEPPING NICELY INTO
HARRY S

REACH, HE PULLED A THICK BUNDLE OF ENVELOPES FROM THE INSIDE OF THE
PILLOWCASE

HE WAS WEARING, HARRY COULD MAKE OUT HERMION S NEAT WRITING,
AND S

LOVELY SCRAWL, AND EVEN A SCRIBBLE THAT LOOKED AS THOUGH IT WAS
FROM THE

HOGWARTS GAMEKEEPER, HAGRID.

DICKY BLINKED ANXIOUSLY UP AT HARRY.

HARRY POTTER MUSTN T BE ANGRY, . . . DICKY HOPED . . . IF HARRY
POTTER

THOUGHT HIS FRIENDS HAD FORGOTTEN HIM . . . HARRY POTTER MIGHT
NOT WANT THE

CHEEKS THE SCHEM, SIR, . . .

HARRY WASN'T LISTENING. HE MADE A GRAB FOR THE LETTERS, BUT DICKY
JUMPED OUT OF REACH.

HARRY PETER WILL HAVE THEM, SIR, IF HE GIVES DICKY HIS WORD THAT HE

WILL NOT RETURN THE FLEWARTS. Ah, SIR, THIS IS A DANGER YOU MUST
NOT FACE!

SAY YOU WON'T GO BACK, SIR!

NO, SAID HARRY ANGRILY. GIVE ME MY FRIENDS' LETTERS!

THEN HARRY PETER LEAVES DICKY NO CHOICE, SAID THE ELF SADLY.
BEFORE HARRY COULD MOVE, DICKY HAD DARTED TO THE BEDROOM DOOR,
PULLED IT OPEN, AND SPRINTED DOWN THE STAIRS.

MOUTH DRY, STOMACH LURCHING, HARRY SPRANG AFTER HIM, TRYING
NOT TO

MAKE A SOUND. HE JUMPED THE LAST SIX STEPS, LANDING CATLIKE ON THE
HALL

CARPET, LEEDING AROUND FOR DICKY, FROM THE DINING ROOM HE HEARD
UNCLE

VERNON SAYING, ... TELL PETUNIA THAT VERY FLINDY STEAKS AREN'T
THESE

AMERICAN PILPERS, MR. MASHN. SHE'S BEEN DYING TO HEAR ...

HARRY RAN UP THE HALL INTO THE KITCHEN AND FELT HIS STOMACH
DISAPPEAR.

ALINT PETUNIA'S MASTERPIECE OF A PUDDING, THE MOUNTAIN OF CREAM
AND

SUGARED VIOLETS, WAS FLOATING UP NEAR THE CEILING. THEN THERE WAS A
CLIPBOARD IN

THE CORNER CRACKLED DICKY.

NO, CREAMED HARRY. PLEASE ... THEY'LL KILL ME ...

HARRY PETER MUST SAY HE'S NOT GOING BACK TO SCHOOL

DHKKY . . . PLEASE . . .

SAY IT, SIR

I CAN T

DHKKY GAVE HIM A TRAGIC LOOK.

THEN DHKKY MUST DO IT, SIR, FOR HARRY POTTER S OWN GOOD.

THE PLUDDING FELL TO THE FLOOR WITH A HEART-STOPPING CRASH. CREAM
SPLATTERED THE WINDOWS AND WALLS AS THE DISH SHATTERED, WITH A
CRACK LIKE A

WHIP, DHKKY VANISHED.

THERE WERE SCREAMS FROM THE DINING ROOM AND LUNCLE VERNON
FIRST INTO

THE KITCHEN TO FIND HARRY, RIGID WITH SHOCK, COVERED FROM HEAD TO
FEET IN

AUNT PETUNIA S PLUDDING.

AT FIRST, IT LOOKED AS THOUGH LUNCLE VERNON WOULD MANAGE TO
GLASS THE

WHOLE THING EVER, BUT JUST HIS NEPHEW VERY DISTURBED MEETING
STRANGERS UPSETS HIM, SO WE KEPT HIM UPSTAIRS. . . . HE SHOOK THE
SHOCKED MASHES BACK INTO THE DINING ROOM, PROMISED HARRY HE
WOULD PLAY

HIM THE WITHIN AN INCH OF HIS LIFE WHEN THE MASHES HAD LEFT, AND
HANDS HIM

A MHP, AUNT PETUNIA DID SOME ICE CREAM MELT IN THE FREEZER AND
HARRY, STILL

SHAKING, STARTED SCRUBBING THE KITCHEN CLEAN.

LUNCLE VERNON MIGHT STILL HAVE BEEN ABLE TO MAKE HIS DEAL IF IT
HADN T

BEEN FOR THE HILL.

AUNT PETUNIA WAS JUST PASSING AROUND A BOX OF AFTER-DINNER
MINTS WHEN A

FLICK BARN HAD SWEEPED THROUGH THE DINING ROOM WINDOW, DROPPED
A LETTER

ON MRS. MASHEN'S HEAD, AND SWEEPED BY AGAIN. MRS. MASHEN
SCREAMED LIKE

A BANSHEE AND RAN FROM THE FURIOUS SCREAMING ABOUT LUNATICS. MR.
MASHEN

STAYED JUST LONG ENOUGH TO TELL THE DURSLEYS THAT HIS WIFE WAS
MENTALLY

AFRAID OF BIRDS OF ALL SHAPES AND SIZES, AND THEN ASK WHETHER THIS WAS
THEIR

IDEA OF A MERE.

HARRY STOOD IN THE KITCHEN, CLUTCHING THE MESSY SLIPPER, AS
UNCLE

VERNON ADVANCED ON HIM, A DEMENTED GLINT IN HIS TINY EYES.

READ IT! HE HISSED EVILLY, BRANDISHING THE LETTER THAT HAD
DELIVERED.

GO ON READ IT!

HARRY THREW IT. IT DID NOT CONTAIN BIRTHDAY GREETINGS.

DEAR MR. POTTTER,

WE HAVE RECEIVED INTELLIGENCE THAT A FEVER CHARM WAS USED AT
YOUR

PLACE OF RESIDENCE THIS EVENING AT TWELVE MINUTES PAST NINE.

AS YOU KNOW, LINGERAGE WIZARDS ARE NOT PERMITTED TO PERFORM
SPELLS

HELTHSIDE SPELLS, AND FURTHER SPELLWORK ON YOUR PART MAY LEAD TO
EXPULSION FROM SAID SPELLS (DEAR AND THE REASONABLE RESTRICTION
OF

UNDERAGE SECRET, 1875, PARAGRAPH C.

WE WOULD ALSO ASK YOU TO REMEMBER THAT ANY MAGICAL ACTIVITY THAT
RISKS NOTICE BY MEMBERS OF THE NON-MAGICAL COMMUNITY (MUGGLES)
IS

A SERIOUS OFFENSE UNDER SECTION 12 OF THE INTERNATIONAL
CONFEDERATION

OF WARLOCKS' STATUTE OF SECRECY.

ENJOY YOUR HOLIDAYS!

YOURS SINCERELY,

MARALDA FLEEMSTER

IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC OFFICE

MINISTRY OF MAGIC

HARRY LEANED UP FROM THE LETTER AND CLIPPED.

HE DIDN'T TELL HIS PARENTS HE'D ALREADY TOLD THE USE OF MAGIC HELD SIDE
SCHEM.

Said Uncle Vernon, a mad gleam dancing in his eyes, "FORGET THE
MENTION

IT... SLIPPED YOUR MIND, I DARE SAY...

HE WAS BEARING DOWN ON HARRY LIKE A GREAT KILLING, ALL HIS TEETH
BARED.

Well, I've got news for you, boy... I'm looking you up...
YOU'RE NEVER

GOING BACK TO THAT SCHEM... NEVER... AND IF YOU TRY AND MAGIC
YOURSELF

HE'LL THEY'LL EXPULS YOU!

AND LAUGHING LIKE A MANIAC, HE DRAGGED HARRY BACK UPSTAIRS.

LITTLE VERNON WAS AS BAD AS HIS WORD. THE FOLLOWING MORNING, HE PAID A

MAN THE FIT KARS HEN HARRY S WINDEN. HE HIMSELF FITTED A CAT-FLAP IN THE

REDRETHY DEER, SEE THAT SMALL APERTURES HE FEED CHILD BE PUSHED INSIDE THERE

TIMES A DAY. THEY LET HARRY EAT THE LIP THE EAT-THREY MORNING AND EVENING.

ETHEREWISE, HE WAS LOCKED IN HIS ROOM AROUND THE CLOCK.

THREE DAYS LATER, THE DURSLEYS WERE SHOWING NO SIGN OF RELENTING, AND

HARRY COULDN T SEE ANY WAY OUT OF HIS SITUATION. HE LAY HEN HIS BED

WATCHING THE SUN SINKING BEHIND THE KARS HEN THE WINDEN AND WHISPERED

MISERABLY WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN TO HIM.

WHAT WAS THE CHANCE OF MAKING HIMSELF OUT OF HIS ROOM IF HEGLARTS

WOULD EXPUL HIM FOR BEING IT? YET LIFE AT PRIVET DRIVE HAD REACHED AN ALL-

TIME WELL, NEAR THAT THE DURSLEYS KNEW THEY WEREN T GOING TO MAKE UP AS

WIT KATS, HE HAD LOST HIS ONLY WEAPON. DEERLY MIGHT HAVE SAVED HARRY

FROM HORRIBLE HAPPENINGS AT HEGLARTS, BUT THE WAY THINGS WERE GOING, HE D

PREFERABLY STAVE THE DEATH ANYWAY.

THE CAT-FLAP RATTLED AND ALINT PETLONIA S HAND APPEARED, PUSHING A BOWL

HE CANNED SHLIP INTO THE ROOM. HARRY, WHOSE INSIDES WERE ACHING WITH

HUNGER, JUMPED OFF HIS BED AND SEIZED IT. THE SHLIP WAS STINK-CHLO, BUT HE

BRAND HAD HE IT IN ONE CLIP. THEN HE CROSSED THE ROOM TO FREDRIC S LAGE

AND TIPPED THE SHOGY VEGETABLES AT THE KITCHEN OF THE KENL INTO HER EMPTY

FEED TRAY. SHE RUFFLED HER FEATHERS AND GAVE HIM A LOOK OF DEEP DISGUST.

IT S NE GOOD TURNING YOUR BACK UP AT IT THAT S ALL WE VE GHT, SAID

HARRY GRIMLY.

HE PUT THE EMPTY KENL BACK ON THE FLOOR NEXT TO THE CAT-FLAP AND LAY

BACK DOWN ON THE BED, SOMEHOW EVEN HUNGRIER THAN HE HAD BEEN BEFORE THE

SHLIP.

SUPPOSING HE WAS STILL ALIVE IN ANOTHER FEW WEEKS, WHAT WOULD HAPPEN

IF HE DIDN T TURN UP AT FREDRICARTS? WOULD SOMEONE BE SENT TO SEE WHY HE

HADN T COME BACK? WOULD THEY BE ABLE TO MAKE THE OLDSLEYS LET HIM GO?

THE ROOM WAS GROWING DARK, EXHAUSTED, STOMACH RUMBLING, MIND SPINNING OVER THE SAME UNANSWERABLE QUESTIONS, HARRY FELL INTO AN UNLASSY

SLEEP.

HE DREAMED THAT HE WAS ON STAGE IN A THEATRE, WITH A CARD READING UNDERAGE

WIZARD ATTACHED TO HIS CAGE, PEOPLE GIGGLED THROUGH THE BARS AT HIM AS HE

LAY, STARVING AND WEAK, IN A BED OF STRAW. HE SAW DEDDY'S FACE IN THE

CRIB AND STUTTERED OUT, ASKING FOR HELP, BUT DEDDY CALLED, "HARRY POTTER IS

SLEEPING THERE, SIR!" AND VANISHED. THEN THE DURSLEYS APPEARED AND DUDLEY

RATTLED THE BARS OF THE CAGE, LAUGHING AT HIM.

"STOP IT," HARRY MUTTERED AS THE RATTLING POUNDED IN HIS SLEEPING HEAD.

"LEAVE ME ALONE . . . LET IT BE . . . I'M TRYING TO SLEEP . . ."

HE OPENED HIS EYES. MOONLIGHT WAS SHINING THROUGH THE BARS AND THE

WINDS. AND SOMEONE WAS GIGGLING THROUGH THE BARS AT HIM: A PRETTY-

FACED, RED-HAIRED, LONG-NECKED SOMEONE.

WHEN WEASLEY WAS OUTSIDE HARRY'S WINDS.

R

CHAPTER THREE

THE CLIMAX

HE OPENED HARRY, CREEPING TO THE WINDS AND PUSHING IT UP
SEE

THEY COULD TALK THROUGH THE EARS. THEN, HE DID SEE WHAT THE

?

HARRY'S MOUTH FELL OPEN AS THE FULL IMPACT OF WHAT HE WAS SEEING HIT

HIM. THEN WAS LEANING OUT OF THE BACK WINDOW OF AN OLD TWOWHEELER CAR,

WHICH WAS PARKED IN MIDAIR. GRINNING AT HARRY FROM THE FRONT SEATS WERE

FRED AND GEORGE, THEN'S ELDER TWIN BROTHERS.

ALL RIGHT, HARRY? ASKED GEORGE.

WHAT'S BEEN GOING ON? SAID THEN. WHY HAVEN'T YOU BEEN ANSWERING

MY LETTERS? I'VE ASKED YOU THE SAME ABOUT TWELVE TIMES, AND THEN DAD CAME

HOME AND SAID YOU'D GET AN OFFICIAL WARNING FOR USING MAGIC IN FRONT OF

MUGGLES

IT WASN'T ME AND HE DID HE KNOW?

HE WORKS FOR THE MINISTRY, SAID THEN. YOU KNOW WE'RE NOT SUPPOSED TO

DO SPELLS OUTSIDE SCHOOL

YOU SHOULD TALK, SAID HARRY, STARING AT THE FLOATING CAR.

HEH, THIS DOESN'T COUNT, SAID THEN. WE'RE ONLY EXPERIMENTING THIS. IT'S

DAD'S, WE DIDN'T ENCHANT IT, BUT DOING MAGIC IN FRONT OF THESE MUGGLES YOU

LIVE WITH

I TELL THEM, I DIDN'T BUT IT LL TAKE THEM LONG TO EXPLAIN THEM
LIES,

CAN YOU TELL THEM AT HOGWARTS THAT THE DURSLEYS HAVE LIKED ME
LIP AND

WHEN I LET ME COME BACK, AND EVENTUALLY I CAN'T MAGIC MYSELF OUT,
BECAUSE

THE MINISTRY LL THINK THAT'S THE SECOND SPELL I'VE DONE IN THREE
DAYS, SHE

STEP GIBBERING, SAID RON. WE'VE COME TO TAKE YOU HOME WITH
US,

BUT YOU CAN'T MAGIC ME OUT EITHER

WE DON'T NEED YOU, SAID RON, TUCKING HIS HEAD TOWARD THE FRONT
SEAT AND

GRINNING. YOU FORGET WHEN I'VE GOTTEN WITH ME,

THEY THAT AREN'T THE BARS, SAID FRED, THROWING THE END OF A ROPE
THE

HARRY,

IF THE DURSLEYS MAKE LIP, I'M DEAD, SAID HARRY AS HE TIED THE ROPE
TIGHTLY AROUND A BAR AND FRED REVVED UP THE CAR,

DON'T WORRY, SAID FRED, AND STAND BACK,

HARRY MOVED BACK INTO THE SHADELS NEXT TO FRED, WHO SEEMED TO
HAVE REALIZED HOW IMPORTANT THIS WAS AND KEPT STILL AND SILENT.
THE CAR

REVVED LULDER AND LULDER AND SUDDENLY, WITH A CRUNCHING NOISE, THE
BARS

WERE PULLED CLEAN OUT OF THE WINDOW AS FRED DROVE STRAIGHT UP IN
THE AIR,

HARRY RAN BACK TO THE WINDOW TO SEE THE BARS DANGLING A FEW FEET
ABOVE THE

GROINING, PANTING, REIN WHISTLED THEM UP INTO THE CAR. HARRY LISTENED

ANXIOUSLY, BUT THERE WAS NO SOUND FROM THE DURSLEY'S BEDROOM.

WHEN THE CARS WERE SAFELY IN THE BACK SEAT WITH REIN, FRED REVERSED AS

CLOSE AS POSSIBLE TO HARRY'S WINDOW.

GET IN, REIN SAID.

BUT ALL MY HOGWARTS STUFF MY WAND MY BROOMSTICK

WHERE IS IT?

LOOKED IN THE CLIPBOARD UNDER THE STAIRS, AND I CAN'T GET OUT OF THIS

ROOM

NO PROBLEM, SAID GEORGE FROM THE FRONT PASSENGER SEAT. HE'LL BE THE

WAY, HARRY.

FRED AND GEORGE CLIMBED CATLIKE THROUGH THE WINDOW INTO HARRY'S ROOM.

YELL HAD THE HAND IT TO THEM, TWELIGHT HARRY, AS GEORGE THREW AN ORDINARY

HAIRPIN FROM HIS POCKET AND STARTED TO PICK THE LOCK.

A LOT OF WIZARDS THINK IT'S A WASTE OF TIME, KNOWING THIS SORT OF MISCLE

TRICK, SAID FRED, BUT WE FEEL THEY'RE SKILLS WORTH LEARNING, EVEN IF THEY

ARE A BIT SLEAZY.

THERE WAS A SMALL CLICK AND THE DOOR SWUNG OPEN.

SEE WE'LL GET YOUR TRUNK YELL GRAB ANYTHING YELL NEED FROM YOUR

RHEM AND HAND IT FELT THE RHEM, WHISPERED GEORGE.

WATCH FELT THE RHEM STAIR IT CREAKS, HARRY WHISPERED
BACK AS

THE TWINS DISAPPEARED BENTH THE DARK LANDING.

HARRY DASHED AROUND HIS RHEM, COLLECTING HIS THINGS AND PASSING
THEM

FELT THE WINDOW THE RHEM, THEN HE WENT TO HELP FRED AND GEORGE
HAVE HIS

TRUNK UP THE STAIRS, HARRY HEARD LITTLE VERNEN CHUCKLE.

AT LAST, PARTING, THEY REACHED THE LANDING, THEN CARRIED THE TRUNK
THROUGH

HARRY & RHEM THE THE OPEN WINDOW, FRED CLIMBED BACK INTO THE CAR
THE PULL

WITH RHEM, AND HARRY AND GEORGE PUSHED FROM THE REAR RHEM SIDE,
INCH BY

INCH, THE TRUNK SLID THROUGH THE WINDOW.

LITTLE VERNEN CHUCKLED AGAIN.

A BIT MORE, PANTED FRED, WHO WAS PULLING FROM INSIDE THE CAR,
HUR

GOOD PUSH

HARRY AND GEORGE THREW THEIR SHOULDERS AGAINST THE TRUNK AND
IT SLID FELT

THE WINDOW INTO THE BACK SEAT OF THE CAR.

HURRY, LET'S GO, GEORGE WHISPERED.

BUT AS HARRY CLIMBED BENTH THE WINDOW SILL THERE CAME A SUDDEN LOUD
SCREECH FROM BEHIND HIM, FOLLOWED IMMEDIATELY BY THE THUNDER OF
LITTLE

VERNEN'S WHEEL.

THAT BLOODY HELL!

I VE FORGOTTEN FREDWIG!

HARRY THREW BACK ACROSS THE ROOM AS THE LANDING LIGHT CLICKED ON
HE

SNATCHED UP FREDWIG'S CAGE, DASHED TO THE WINDOW, AND PASSED IT OUT
THE

DOOR. HE WAS STRAGGLING BACK TOWARD THE CHEST OF DRAWERS WHEN
UNCLE

VERNON HAMMERED ON THE UNLOCKED DOOR AND IT CRASHED OPEN.

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, UNCLE VERNON STOOD FRAMED IN THE DOORWAY;
THEN HE

LET OUT A RELLER LIKE AN ANGRY BULL AND DIVED AT HARRY, GRABBING
HIM BY THE

ANKLE.

THEN, FRED, AND GEORGE SEIZED HARRY'S ARMS AND PULLED AS HARD AS
THEY

COULD.

PETUNIA! REARED UNCLE VERNON. HE'S GETTING AWAY! HE'S
GETTING

AWAY!

BUT THE WEASLEYS GAVE A GIGANTIC TUG AND HARRY'S LEG SLID OUT OF
UNCLE

VERNON'S GRASP. HARRY WAS IN THE CAR. HE'D SLAMMED THE DOOR
SHUT

PLUT THEIR FEET DOWN, FRED! YELLED RON, AND THE CAR SHEET SLIDDERLY
TOWARD THE FRONT.

HARRY COULDN'T BELIEVE IT. HE WAS FREE. HE REELLED DOWN THE
WINDOW, THE

NIGHT AIR WHIPPING HIS HAIR, AND LEANED BACK AT THE SHRINKING
REMEMBERS OF

PRIVATE DRIVE, UNCLE VERNON, AUNT PETUNIA, AND DUDLEY WERE ALL HANGING,

BLIMPSTRIKED, HILT OF HARRY'S WINDMILL,

SEE THEM NEXT SUMMER! HARRY YELLED,

THE WEASLEYS REARED WITH LAUGHTER AND HARRY SETTLED BACK IN HIS SEAT,

GRINNING FROM EAR TO EAR,

LET HERBIE HILT, HE TOLD THEM. SHE CAN FLY BEHIND US, SHE HASN'T HAD A

CHANCE TO STRETCH HER WINGS FOR AGES,

GEORGE HANDED THE HAIRPIN TO HERBIE AND, A MOMENT LATER, HERBIE SHARED

IMPULSIVELY HILT OF THE WINDMILL THEY GLIDE ALONGSIDE THEM LIKE A GHOST,

SEE WHAT'S THE STORY, HARRY? SAID HERBIE IMPATIENTLY. WHAT'S BEEN

HAPPENING?

HARRY TOLD THEM ALL ABOUT DUDLEY, THE WARNING HE'D GIVEN HARRY AND THE

FLASH OF THE VIOLET FLIPPING. THERE WAS A LONG, STICKED SILENCE WHEN HE

HAD FINISHED,

VERY FLESHY, SAID FRED FINALLY,

DEFINITELY DUDLEY, AGREED GEORGE. SEE HE WOULDN'T EVEN TELL THEM WHAT'S

SUPPOSED TO BE PLANNING ALL THIS STUFF?

I DON'T THINK HE COULD, SAID HARRY. I TOLD THEM, EVERY TIME HE GOT CLOSE

TO LETTING SOMETHING SLIP, HE STARTED BANGING HIS HEAD AGAINST THE WALL,

HE SAW FRED AND GEORGE LOOK AT EACH OTHER.

WHAT, YOU THINK HE WAS LYING TO ME? SAID HARRY.

WELL, SAID FRED, PUT IT THIS WAY FAMILIAR-FLIES HAVE GET PERMISSION

MAGIC OF THEIR OWN, BUT THEY CAN'T USUALLY USE IT WITHOUT THEIR MASTER'S

PERMISSION, I RECKON HED DEDDY WAS SENT THE STUPP YOU COMING BACK THE

HOGWARTS, SOMEONE'S IDEA OF A JOKE, CAN YOU THINK OF ANYONE AT SCHOOL

WITH A GRUDGE AGAINST YOU?

YES, SAID HARRY AND RON TOGETHER, INSTANTLY.

DRAKE MALFOY, HARRY EXPLAINED, HE HATES ME.

DRAKE MALFOY? SAID GEORGE, TURNING AROUND, NOT LUCIUS MALFOY'S

SON?

MUST BE, IT'S NOT A VERY COMMON NAME, IS IT? SAID HARRY, WHY?

I'VE HEARD DAD TALKING ABOUT HIM, SAID GEORGE, HE WAS A BIG SUPPORTER OF VULGAR-WEED.

AND WHEN VULGAR-WEED DISAPPEARED, SAID FRED, CRANING AROUND THE

LOOK AT HARRY, LUCIUS MALFOY CAME BACK SAYING HE'D NEVER MEANT ANY OF

IT, LEAD OF BLIND DAD RECKONS HE WAS RIGHT IN VULGAR-WEED'S INNER

CIRCLE.

HARRY HAD HEARD THESE RUMORS ABOUT MALFOY'S FAMILY BEFORE, AND THEY

DIDN'T SURPRISE HIM AT ALL. MALPHY MADE DUDLEY DURSLEY LOOK LIKE A
KIND,

THOUGHTFUL, AND SENSITIVE KID.

I DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER THE MALPHYS HAD A FOLLY-FLY, ... SAID
HARRY.

WELL, WHATEVER HELPS HIM WILL BE AN OLD WIZARDING FAMILY, AND
THEY LL

BE RICH, SAID FRED.

YEAH, MUM'S ALWAYS WISHING WE HAD A FOLLY-FLY THE DAY THE
TRAINING,

SAID GEORGE. BUT ALL WE'VE GOT IS A LITTLE OLD CHICK IN THE ATTIC
AND

ENEMIES ALL OVER THE GARDEN. FOLLY-FLIES COME WITH BIG OLD MANNERS
AND

CASTLES AND PLACES LIKE THAT; YOU WOULDNT CATCH ONE IN OUR FOLLY.
...

HARRY WAS SILENT, JUDGING BY THE FACT THAT DRAGON MALPHY USUALLY
HAD THE

BEST OF EVERYTHING, HIS FAMILY WAS REHILLING IN WIZARD CHILD; HE COULD
JUST SEE

MALPHY STRUTTING AROUND A LARGE MANNOR FOLLY, SENDING THE
FAMILY SERVANT

THE STEP HARRY FROM GOING BACK THE HOGWARTS ALSO SEEMED EXACTLY
LIKE THE

SHORT OF THING MALPHY WOULD BE. HAD HARRY BEEN STUPID THE TAKE
DEERS

SERIOUSLY?

I'M GLAD WE CAN'T GET YOU, ANYWAY, SAID PENE. I WAS GETTING
REALLY

WHIPPED WHEN YOU DIDN'T ANSWER ANY OF MY LETTERS. I THOUGHT IT
WAS PENE'S

FALLT AT FIRST

WHEN S RAN?

HEIR HEIL, HE S ANCIENT, IT WOULDNT BE THE FIRST TIME HE D COLLAPSED
HIN A

DELIVERY, SHE THEN I TRIED THE KIRKHEIL HERMES

WHEN?

THE HEIL MUM AND DAD RELIGHT PERCY WHEN HE WAS MADE PERFECT,
SAID

FRED FROM THE FRONT,

BUT PERCY WOULDNT T LEND HIM THE ME, SAID RENN, SAID HE NEEDED
HIM,

PERCY S BEEN ACTING VERY HEDLY THIS SLIMMER, SAID GEORGE,
PRELIMINE,

AND HE HAS BEEN SENDING A LIT OF LETTERS AND SPENDING A LEAD OF
TIME SHIT

LIP IN HIS REHM, . . . I MEAN, THERE S ONLY SHE MANY TIMES YELL CAN
PUBLISH A

PERFECT BADGE, . . . YELL RE DRIVING THEE FAR WEST, FRED, HE ADDED,
PHINTING AT

A COMPASS HIN THE DASHBOARD, FRED TWIDDED THE STEERING WHEEL,

SHE DEES YELLIR DAD DRINK YELL VE GET THE CAR? SAID HARRY,
CRESSING THE

ANSWER,

ER, NEH, SAID RENN, HE HAD THE WERD TONIGHT, HERPELILLY WE LL BE
ABLE THE

GET IT BACK IN THE GARAGE WITHHEIT MUM NOTICING WE FLEW IT,

WHAT DEES YELLIR DAD DEE AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, ANDLAW?

HE WERDS IN THE MEET KERING DEPARTMENT, SAID RENN, THE
MILISE OF

MUGGLE ARTIFACTS OFFICE.

THE WHAT?

IT'S ALL THE DEE WITH KIWITCHING THINGS THAT ARE MUGGLE-MADE, YELL
DREHL,

IN CASE THEY END UP BACK IN A MUGGLE SHOP HER HOUSE, LIKE, LAST
YEAR, SHE'S

HOLD WITCH DIED AND HER TEA SET WAS SHED THE AN ANTIHUES SHOP, THIS
MUGGLE

WHENMAN REELIGHT IT, THEED IT FHEE, AND TRIED THE SERVE HER FRIENDS TEA
IN IT, IT

WAS A NIGHTMARE DAD WAS WORKING EVERTIME FOR WEEKS,

WHAT HAPPENED?

THE TRAPSET WENT BERSERK AND SPILTED BOILING TEA ALL OVER THE
PLACE AND

HENE MAN ENDED UP IN THE HOSPITAL WITH THE SUGAR THINGS CLAMPED
THE HIS NECK.

DAD WAS GOING FRANTIC IT'S ONLY HIM AND AN OLD WARRICK CALLED
PERKINS

IN THE OFFICE AND THEY HAD THE DEE MEMPHY CHAIRS AND ALL SEETS
HE STUFF

THE COVER IT UP

BLIT YELLER DAD THIS CAR

FRED LAUGHED. YEAH, DAD'S CRAZY ABOUT EVERYTHING THE DEE WITH
MUGGLES;

ELLER SHED'S FULL OF MUGGLE STUFF, HE TAKES IT APART, PLITS SPELLS HEN
IT, AND PLITS

IT BACK TOGETHER AGAIN, IF HE RAIDED ELLER HOUSE HE'D HAVE THE PLIT
HIMSELF

LINDER ARREST, IT DRIVES MUM MAD,

THAT'S THE MAIN REAS, SAID GEORGE, PEERING DOWN THROUGH THE

WINDSFIELD. WE'LL BE THERE IN TEN MINUTES. . . . JUST AS WELL, IT'S
GETTING
LIGHT. . . .

A FAINT PINKISH GLOW WAS VISIBLE ALONG THE HORIZON TO THE EAST,
FRED BRIGHTENED THE CAR LIGHTS, AND HARRY SAW A DARK PATCHWORK OF
FIELDS

AND CLUMPS OF TREES.

WE'RE A LITTLE WAY OUTSIDE THE VILLAGE, SAID GEORGE, HATTERY ST.
CATCHPOLE.

LIGHTER AND LIGHTER WENT THE FLYING CAR. THE EDGE OF A BRILLIANT RED
SUN WAS

NOW GLIMMING THROUGH THE TREES.

TELLING THEM? SAID FRED AS, WITH A SLIGHT CLUMP, THEY HIT THE
GRILLING.

THEY HAD LANDED NEXT TO A TUMBLEDOWN GARAGE IN A SMALL YARD, AND
HARRY

SHOOKED HIS HEAD FOR THE FIRST TIME AT RICHARD'S FEELING.

IT SEEMED AS THOUGH IT HAD ONCE BEEN A LARGE STONE PIGEON, BUT
EXTRA

REPAIRS HAD BEEN ADDED HERE AND THERE UNTIL IT WAS SEVERAL STORIES
HIGH AND

SEE SEEMED IT SEEMED AS THOUGH IT WERE HELD UP BY MAGIC WHICH,
HARRY

REMINDED HIMSELF, IT PROBABLY WAS! FEELING HIS FIVE CHIMNEYS WERE
PERCHED

ON THE TOP OF THE RED ROOF. A UPSIDED SIGN STUCK IN THE GRILLING NEAR
THE

ENTRANCE READ, THE BLACKBURN. AROUND THE FRONT DOOR WAS A
LUMBER OF BLACK

EGGITS AND A VERY RUSTY CALIBRE. SEVERAL FAT ROBBEN CHICKENS WERE
PECKING

THEIR WAY AROUND THE YARD.

IT'S NOT MUCH, SAID RICH.

IT'S WONDERFUL, SAID HARRY HAPPILY, THINKING OF PRIVATE DRIVE.

THEY GOT OUT OF THE CAR.

WELL, WE'LL GO UPSTAIRS REALLY QUIETLY, SAID FRED, AND WAIT FOR
MUM TO

CALL US FOR BREAKFAST. THEN, RICH, YOU'LL COME BEHINDING DOWNSTAIRS
GOING.

MUM, WHEN SHE TURNED UP IN THE NIGHT? AND SHE'LL BE ALL PLEASED
TO SEE

HARRY AND SHE'LL NEVER NEED EVER KNOW WE FLEW THE CAR.

RIGHT, SAID RICH. COME ON, HARRY, I SLEEP AT THE AT THE TOP

RICH HAD GIVEN A NASTY GREENISH GLEAM, HIS EYES FIXED ON THE FLOOR.
THE

EITHER THREE WHEELED AROUND.

MRS. WEASLEY WAS MARCHING ACROSS THE YARD, SCATTERING CHICKENS,
AND FOR

A SHORT, PLUMP, KIND-FACED WOMAN, IT WAS REMARKABLE HOW MUCH SHE
LOOKED LIKE A SABBOT-TOOTHED TIGER.

AH, SAID FRED.

OH, DEAR, SAID GEORGE.

MRS. WEASLEY CAME TO A HALT IN FRONT OF THEM, HER HANDS ON HER
HIPS.

STARING FROM ONE GUILTY FACE TO THE NEXT. SHE WAS WEARING A
FLOWERED APRON

WITH A HAND STICKING OUT OF THE POCKET,

SEE, SHE SAID,

MORNING, MUM, SAID GEORGE, IN WHAT HE CLEARLY THOUGHT WAS A
CALM,

WINNING VOICE,

HAVE YOU ANY IDEA HOW WORRIED I'VE BEEN? SAID MRS. LEASLEY IN A
DEADLY WHISPER,

SHERRY, MUM, BUT SEE, WE HAD THE
ALL THREE OF MRS. LEASLEY'S SONS WERE TALLER THAN SHE WAS, BUT
THEY

BEHAVED AS HER RAGE BROKE OVER THEM,

BEDS EMPTY? NO NITE? CAR GONE CHILD HAD CRASHED OUT OF
MY

MIND WITH SHERRY DID YOU CARE? NEVER, AS LONG AS I'VE LIVED
YOU

WAIT UNTIL YOUR FATHER GETS HOME, WE NEVER HAD TROUBLE LIKE THIS
FROM BILL

THE CHARLIE THE PERCY

PERFECT PERCY, MUTTERED FRED,

YOU WOULD BE WITH TAKING A LEAF OUT OF PERCY'S
BOOK? YELLED MRS. LEASLEY, PUNCHED A FINGER IN FRED'S CHEST,
YOU

WOULD HAVE DIED, YOU WOULD HAVE BEEN SEEN, YOU WOULD HAVE MET
YOUR FATHER

HIS THE

IT SEEMED THE END FOR THEM, MRS. LEASLEY HAD SPLITTED HERSELF
HARSH

BEFORE SHE TURNED HER BACK, WHEN BACKED AWAY,

I M VERY PLEASED TH SEE YELL, HARRY, DEAR, SHE SAID, COME IN AND HAVE

SOME BREAKFAST.

SHE TURNED AND WALKED BACK INTO THE KITCHEN AND HARRY, AFTER A NERVOUS

GLANCE AT BEN, WHO NEEDED ENCOURAGINGLY, FOLLOWED HER.

THE KITCHEN WAS SMALL AND RATHER CRAMPED. THERE WAS A SCRIBBED WHEDEN TABLE AND CHAIRS IN THE MIDDLE, AND HARRY SAT DOWN ON THE EDGE OF

HIS SEAT, WHIRLING AROUND. HE HAD NEVER BEEN IN A WIZARD KITCHEN BEFORE.

THE CLOCK ON THE WALL OPPOSITE HIM HAD ONLY ONE HAND AND NO NUMBERS

AT ALL. WRITTEN AROUND THE EDGE WERE THINGS LIKE TIME THE MAGE TEA, TIME THE

FEED THE CHICKENS, AND YELL RE LATE. BREADS WERE STACKED THREE DEEP ON THE

MANTELPIECE, BREADS WITH TITLES LIKE CHARM YELLER ELEN CHERRY, ENCHANTMENT

IN BAKING, AND FINE MINUTE FEASTS IT S MAGIC! AND UNLESS HARRY S EARS

WERE DECEIVING HIM, THE OLD RADIO NEXT TO THE SINK HAD JUST ANNOUNCED THAT

CELESTINE WARRICK WAS SINGING YELLER, WITH THE POPULAR SINGING SHIRKRESS,

CELESTINE WARRICK.

MRS. LEASLEY WAS CLATTERING AROUND, CHECKING BREAKFAST A LITTLE

HAPHAZARDLY, THROWING DIRTY LOOKS AT HER SONS AS SHE THREW SALISAGES INTO

THE FRYING PAN, EVERY ONE AND THEN SHE MUTTERED THINGS LIKE
DIDN'T DENY

WHAT THEY WERE THINKING OF, AND NEVER WOULD HAVE BELIEVED IT,

I DIDN'T BLAME YOU, DEAR, SHE ASSURED HARRY, TIPPING RIGHT HER
NINE

SALISAGES ENTER HIS PLATE, ARTHUR AND I HAVE BEEN WORRIED ABOUT
YOU, THEN,

JUST LAST NIGHT WE WERE SAYING WE'D COME AND GET YOU OURSELVES IF
YOU

HADN'T WRITTEN BACK THE OTHER BY FRIDAY, BUT REALLY (SHE WAS NOW
ADDING

THREE FRIED EGGS TO HIS PLATE), FLYING AN ILLEGAL CAR HALFWAY ACROSS
THE

COUNTRY ANYONE COULD HAVE SEEN YOU

SHE FLICKED HER HAND CASUALLY AT THE DISHES IN THE SINK, WHICH
BEGAN TO

CLEAN THEMSELVES, CLINKING GENTLY IN THE BACKGROUND.

IT WAS CLEVER, MUM? SAID FRED.

YOU KEEP YOUR MOUTH CLOSED WHILE YOU'RE EATING? MRS. WEASLEY
SNAPPED,

THEY WERE STARVING HIM, MUM? SAID GEORGE.

AND YOU? SAID MRS. WEASLEY, BUT IT WAS WITH A SLIGHTLY STIFTED
EXPRESSION THAT SHE STARTED CUTTING HARRY'S BREAD AND BUTTERING IT
FOR HIM.

AT THAT MOMENT THERE WAS A DIVERSION IN THE FORM OF A SMALL,
RED-HEADED

FIGURE IN A LONG NIGHTDRESS, WHO APPEARED IN THE KITCHEN, GAVE A
SMALL

SHRILL, AND RAN OUT AGAIN.

GIRNY, SAID RENN IN AN UNDERSTANDING TONE. MY SISTER, SHE'S BEEN

TALKING ABOUT YOU ALL SUMMER.

Yeah, she'll be wanting your autograph, Harry, Fred said with a grin.

But he caught his mother's eye and bent his face over his plate without

another word. Nothing more was said until all their plates were clean,

which took a surprisingly short time.

Listen, I'm tired, yawned Fred, setting down his knife and fork at last. I think I'll go to bed and

you will, too, snapped Mrs. Weasley. It's your own fault you've been

up all night. You're going to de-gnome the garden for me; they're getting

completely out of hand again.

Oh, Mum

And you, too, she said, glaring at Ren and George. You can go to bed, dear,

she added to Harry. You didn't ask them the day that wretched

car

But Harry, who felt wide awake, said quickly, I'll help Ren. I've never

seen a de-gnoming

That's very sweet of you, dear, but it's dull work, said Mrs. Weasley.

Well, let's see what Lockhart's got to say on the subject

AND SHE PULLED A HEAVY KNEE FROM THE STACK IN THE MANTELPIECE,
CROOKED

CRANKED,

MUM, WE KNOW HOW TO DE-CRANK A GARDEN

HARRY LOOKED AT THE COVER OF MRS. WEASLEY'S KNEE, WRITTEN ACROSS
IT IN

PINKY CHILD LETTERS WERE THE WORDS GILBERT LICKHART'S GLIDE THE
FELLSHED

PESTS. THERE WAS A BIG PHOTOGRAPH IN THE FRONT OF A VERY CHILD-
LOOKING

WIZARD WITH WAVY REDDISH HAIR AND BRIGHT BLUE EYES. AS ALWAYS IN THE
WIZARDING WORLD, THE PHOTOGRAPH WAS MOVING; THE WIZARD, WHO
HARRY

SUPPOSED WAS GILBERT LICKHART, KEPT WINKING CHEERILY UP AT
THEM ALL.

MRS. WEASLEY BEAMED DOWN AT HIM.

HE, HE IS MARVELLOUS, SHE SAID. HE KNOWS HIS FELLSHED PESTS,
ALL

RIGHT, IT'S A WONDERFUL KNEE, ...

MUM THANKS HIM, SAID FRED, IN A VERY AUDIBLE WHISPER.

DON'T BE SO RIDICULOUS, FRED, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, HER CHEEKS RATHER
PINK. ALL RIGHT, IF YOU THINK YOU KNOW BETTER THAN LICKHART,
YOU CAN GO

AND GET ON WITH IT, AND WHEN YOU'RE DONE YOU IF THERE'S A SINGLE Gnome IN
THAT

GARDEN WHEN I COME BACK TO INSPECT IT.

PAUNING AND CRAWLING, THE WEASLEYS SHELTERED OUTSIDE WITH
HARRY

BEHIND THEM. THE GARDEN WAS LARGE, AND IN HARRY'S EYES, EXACTLY
WHAT A

GARDEN SHOULD BE. THE DURSLEYS WOULDN'T HAVE LIKED IT. THERE
WERE

PLENTY OF WEEDS, AND THE GRASS NEEDED CUTTING. BUT THERE WERE
GNARLED

TREES ALL AROUND THE WALLS, PLANTS HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN SPILLING
FROM EVERY

FLOWER BED, AND A BIG GREEN POND FULL OF FROGS.

MICELENS HAVE GARDEN Gnomes, THEN, YELL DUDLEY. HARRY TOLD RON
AS THEY

CROSSED THE LAWN.

Yeah, I've SEEN THOSE THINGS THEY THINK ARE Gnomes, SAID RON,
BENT

DEERLE WITH HIS HEAD IN A PONY SLUSH, LIKE FAT LITTLE SANTA
CLAUSES WITH

FISHING REELS, ...

THERE WAS A VIOLENT SCUFFLING NOISE, THE PONY SLUSH SLIDDERED,
AND RON

STRAIGHTENED UP. THIS IS A Gnome, HE SAID GRIMLY.

GRRRR? ME? GRRRR? ME? SEIZED THE Gnome.

IT WAS CERTAINLY NOTHING LIKE SANTA CLAUS. IT WAS SMALL AND
LEATHERY

LEERLING, WITH A LARGE, BONY, BOLD HEAD EXACTLY LIKE A PETAARD. RON
HELD IT

AT ARM'S LENGTH AS IT DICKED BLT AT HIM WITH ITS BONY LITTLE FEET;
HE GRASPED

IT AROUND THE ANKLES AND TURNED IT UPSIDE DOWN.

THIS IS WHAT THEY HAVE TO DO, HE SAID, HE RAISED THE GNOME ABOVE HIS

HEAD / GRRRRR ME! / AND STARTED TO SWING IT IN GREAT CIRCLES LIKE A LASER.

SEEING THE STICKED LEGS ON HARRY'S FACE, BEN ADDED, IT DOESN'T FLIRT THEM

THEY'VE JUST GOT TO MAKE THEM REALLY DIZZY SO THEY CAN'T FIND THEIR WAY

BACK TO THE GNOME-HEELS.

HE LET GO OF THE GNOME'S ANKLES: IT FLEW TWENTY FEET INTO THE AIR AND

LANDED WITH A THUD IN THE FIELD OVER THE HEDGE.

PITIFUL, SAID FRED, I BET I CAN GET MINE BEYOND THAT STUMP.

HARRY LEARNED QUICKLY NOT TO FEEL TOO SHY FOR THE GNOMES. HE DECIDED

JUST TO DROP THE FIRST ONE HE CALLED OVER THE HEDGE, BUT THE GNOME, SENSING

WEAKNESS, SANK ITS RAZOR-SHARP TEETH INTO HARRY'S FINGER AND HE HAD A HARD

TIME SHAKING IT OFF UNTIL

WELL, HARRY THAT MUST'VE BEEN FIFTY FEET. . .

THE AIR WAS THEN THICK WITH FLYING GNOMES.

SEE, THEY'RE NOT TOO BRIGHT, SAID GEORGE, SEIZING FIVE OR SIX GNOMES AT

ONCE. THE MOMENT THEY KNEW THE DE-GNOMING'S GOING ON THEY STORMED UP TO

HAVE A LOOK. THEY'D THINK THEY'D HAVE LEARNED BY NOW JUST TO STAY PUT.

THEN, THE CROWD OF GNOMES IN THE FIELD STARTED WALKING AWAY IN A STRAGGLING LINE, THEIR LITTLE SHOULDERS HINKED.

THEY'LL BE BACK, SAID JOHN AS THEY WATCHED THE Gnomes DISAPPEAR
INTO

THE HEDGE ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE FIELD. THEY LEAVE IT HERE, . . .
DAD'S THEM

SENT WITH THEM; HE THINKS THEY'RE FLINDY, . . .

JUST THEN, THE FRONT DOOR SLAMMED.

HE'S BACK? SAID GEORGE. DAD'S HOME?

THEY HURRIED THROUGH THE GARDEN AND BACK INTO THE HOUSE.

MR. WEASLEY WAS SLUMPED IN A KITCHEN CHAIR WITH HIS GLASSES OFF
AND HIS

EYES CLOSED. HE WAS A THIN MAN, GOING BALD, BUT THE LITTLE HAIR HE
HAD WAS

AS RED AS ANY OF HIS CHILDREN'S. HE WAS WEARING LONG GREEN TROUSERS,
WHICH

WERE DUSTY AND TRAVEL-WORN.

WHAT A NIGHT, HE MURMURED, GRIPPING AROUND THE TABLE AS THEY ALL
SAT DOWN

AROUND HIM. NINE RAIDS, NINE! AND MR. MUNDLING'S FLETCHER TRIED
THE PLANT

FROM HIM WHEN I HAD MY BACK TURNED, . . .

MR. WEASLEY THREW A LONG GLIMPSE OF TEA AND SIGHED.

FIND ANYTHING, DAD? SAID FRED EAGERLY.

ALL I GOT WERE A FEW SHRINKING BEAN KEYS AND A BITING BATTLE,
VALUED

MR. WEASLEY. THERE WAS SOME PRETTY NASTY STUFF THAT WASN'T MY
DEPARTMENT, HOWEVER. MERTLACK WAS TAKEN AWAY FOR INVESTIGATING
ABOUT SOME

EXTREMELY BAD PERVERTS, BUT THAT'S THE COMMITTEE ON EXPERIMENTAL
CHARMS.

THANKS CHILDREN, ...

WHY WOULD ANYONE RATHER MAKE THEIR KEYS SHRINK? SAID
GEORGE.

JUST MUGGLE-BAITING, SIGHED MR. WEASLEY. SELL THEM A KEY THAT
KEEPS

SHRINKING THE NOTHING SEE THEY CAN NEVER FIND IT WHEN THEY NEED IT,
... H?

CHURCH, IT'S VERY HARD TO CONVICT ANYONE BECAUSE NO MUGGLE WOULD
ADMIT

THEIR KEY KEYS SHRINKING THEY'LL INSIST THEY JUST KEEP LOSTING
IT. BLESS

THEM, THEY'LL GO TO ANY LENGTHS TO IGNORE MAGIC, EVEN IF IT'S
STARING THEM IN

THE FACE, ... BUT THE THINGS HE'VE LET HAVE TAKEN THE ENCHANTING, WELL
WOULDNT

RELIEVE

LIKE LARS, FEEL INSTANTLY

MRS. WEASLEY HAD APPEARED, HOLDING A LONG POKER LIKE A SWORD. MR.
WEASLEY'S EYES IMMEDIATELY OPENED. HE STARED GUILTILY AT HIS WIFE.

[LARS, MUMMY, DEAR?

YES, ARTHUR, LARS, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, HER EYES FLASHING. IMAGINE
A

WIZARD KIDNAPING A RUSTY OLD CAR AND TELLING HIS WIFE ALL HE WANTED THE
ONE WITH

IT WAS TAKE IT APART THE SEE HOW IT WORKED, WHILE REALLY HE WAS
ENCHANTING IT

THE MAKE IT FLY,

MR. WEASLEY BLINKED.

WELL, DEAR, I THINK WELL'LL FIND THAT HE WOULD BE WHITE WITHIN THE
LAW THE

DIE THAT, EVEN IF ER HE MAYBE WOULD HAVE BEEN BETTER THE LIP,
TELL HIS

WIFE THE TRUTH, ... THERE'S A BEEF-HEIR IN THE LAW, YELL'LL FIND, ...
AS LONG AS

HE WASN'T INTENDING THE FLY THE CAR, THE FACT THAT THE CAR WOULD FLY
WOULDN'T

ARTHUR WEASLEY, YELL' MADE SURE THERE WAS A BEEF-HEIR WHEN YELL
WROTE

THAT LAW? SEEMED MRS. WEASLEY. I'LL SEE YELL' WOULD CARRY HER
TINDERING

WITH ALL THAT MUGGLE ALKISH IN YELL' SHED? AND HER YELL' IN
INTERMATTEN,

HARRY ARRIVED THIS MORNING IN THE CAR YELL' WEREN'T INTENDING THE
FLY?

HARRY? SAID MR. WEASLEY BLANKLY. HARRY WITH
HE WHEEDED AROUND, SAW HARRY, AND LIMPED.

GOOD LORD, IS IT HARRY BETTER? VERY PLEASED THE MEET YELL', BEEN'S
THEO LJS

SEE MUCH ABLENT

YELL' SEENS FLEW THAT CAR THE HARRY'S FELLISZ AND BACK LAST NIGHT?
SEEMED

MRS. WEASLEY. WHAT HAVE YELL' GHT THE SAY ABLENT THAT, ER?

DID YELL' REALLY? SAID MR. WEASLEY EAGERLY. DID IT GO ALL RIGHT? I
I

MEAN, HE FALTERED AS SPARDS FLEW FROM MRS. WEASLEY'S EYES, THAT
THAT

WAS VERY WRING, KEYS VERY WRING INDEED, ...

LET'S LEAVE THEM TO IT, REHN MUTTERED TO HARRY AS MRS. WEASLEY
SMILED

LIKE A BUBBLE, [HE HEARD, I'LL STILL FEEL MY REDHEM,

THEY SLIPPED OUT OF THE KITCHEN AND DOWN A NARROW PASSAGEWAY
THE AND

UNEVEN STAIRCASE, WHICH WENT ITS WAY, ZIGZAGGING UP THROUGH
THE HOUSE,

IN THE THIRD LANDING, A DOOR STOOD Ajar, HARRY INSTANTLY CAUGHT SIGHT
OF A PAIR OF

BRIGHT GREEN EYES STARING AT HIM BEFORE IT CLOSED WITH A SNAP,

GINNY, SAID REHN, YOU DON'T KNOW HOW WEIRD IT IS FOR HER TO BE
THIS

SHY, SHE NEVER SHELTS UP NORMALLY

THEY CLIMBED TWO MORE FLIGHTS UNTIL THEY REACHED A DOOR WITH
PEELING

PAINT AND A SMALL PLaque ON IT, SAYING REYNOLD S REHN,

HARRY STEPPED IN, HIS HEAD ALMOST TOUCHING THE SLEEPING CEILING,
AND

BLINKED, IT WAS LIKE WALKING INTO A FLAMINGO: NEARLY EVERYTHING IN
REHN'S

ROOM SEEMED TO BE A VIBRANT SHADE OF ORANGE: THE REDSPREAD, THE
WALLS,

EVEN THE CEILING. THEN HARRY REALIZED THAT REHN HAD COVERED
NEARLY EVERY

INCH OF THE SHAGGY WALLPAPER WITH POSTERS OF THE SAME SEVEN
WITCHES AND

WIZARDS, ALL WEARING BRIGHT ORANGE ROBES, CARRYING BROOMSTICKS,
AND

MOVING ENERGETICALLY,

YELLY BILLYBITCH TEARY SAID HARRY,

THE CHILDRY CANNERS, SAID RENN, POINTING AT THE STRANGE
REDSPREAD,

WHICH WAS EMBLAZONED WITH TWO GIANT BLACK C'S AND A SPEEDING
CANNINKALL. NINTH IN THE LEAGUE.

RENN'S SEVEN SPELLBOOKS WERE STACKED NINTIDLY IN A CORNER, NEXT
THE A PILE

OF CHIMICS THAT ALL SEEMED THE FEATLURE THE ADVENTURES OF MARTIN
MIGGS, THE

MAD MUGGLE. RENN'S MAGIC WAND WAS LYING INN THEP OF A FISH TANK
FULL OF FROG

SPAWN INN THE WINDMILLS, NEXT THE HIS FAT GRAY RAT, SLACKERS, WHICH
WAS

SNEEZING IN A PATCH OF SLIM,

HARRY STEPPED OVER A PACK OF SELF-SHUFFLING PLAYING CARDS INN THE
FLOOR

AND BENDED ELIT OF THE TINY WINDMILL. IN THE FIELD FAR BEYOND HE COULD
SEE A

GANG OF Gnomes SNEAKING ONE BY ONE BACK THROUGH THE WEASLEYS
HEDGE.

THEN HE TURNED THE HEAD AT RENN, WHICH WAS WATCHING HIM ALMOST
NERVOUSLY, AS

THOUGH WAITING FOR HIS OPINION.

IT'S A KIT SMALL, SAID RENN BILICKLY. NOT LIKE THAT OTHER YELLY HAD
WITH THE

MUGGLES, AND I'M RIGHT UNDERNEATH THE GHELM IN THE ATTIC; HE'S
ALWAYS

RANGING INN THE PIPES AND GREAMING. . . .

BUT HARRY, GRINNING WIDELY, SAID, THIS IS THE BEST FEEUSE I'VE EVER
BEEN

IN.

RON'S EARS WENT PINK.

L

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

AT FLEETISH AND FLETT'S

LIFE AT THE BURROW WAS AS DIFFERENT AS POSSIBLE FROM LIFE IN PRIVET DRIVE. THE DURSLEYS LIKED EVERYTHING NEAT AND ORDERED; THE WEASLEYS FELT FIRST WITH THE STRANGE AND UNEXPECTED. HARRY GOT A SHEED

THE FIRST TIME HE LOOKED IN THE MIRROR OVER THE KITCHEN MANTELPIECE AND IT

SMILED. TUCK YOUR SHIRT IN, SCRUFFY! THE GHEM IN THE ATTIC

DROPPED PIPES WHENEVER HE FELT THINGS WERE GETTING TOO HEAVY, AND SMALL

EXPLOSIONS FROM FRED AND GEORGE'S BEDROOM WERE CONSIDERED PERFECTLY

NORMAL. WHAT HARRY FELT MOST UNUSUAL ABOUT LIFE AT RON'S, HOWEVER,

WASN'T THE TALKING MIRROR OR THE CLOAKING GHEM: IT WAS THE FACT THAT

EVERYBODY THERE SEEMED TO LIKE HIM.

MRS. WEASLEY GLANCED OVER THE STATE OF HIS SHOES AND TRIED TO PERCEIVE HIM THE

EAT FORTH HELPINGS AT EVERY MEAL, MR. WEASLEY LIKED HARRY THE SIT
NEXT THE

HIM AT THE DINNER TABLE SEE THAT HE CHILD HEARD HIM WITH
EYESHOTS ABOUT

LIFE WITH MUGGLES, ASKING HIM THE EXPLAIN HOW THINGS LIKE POLICE
AND THE

POSTAL SERVICE WORKED.

FASCINATING! HE WOULD SAY AS HARRY TALKED HIM THROUGH USING A
TELEPHONE. INCIDENTALLY, REALLY, HOW MANY WAYS MUGGLES HAVE
FOUND OF

GETTING ALONG WITHOUT MAGIC.

HARRY HEARD FROM HOGWARTS ONE SUNDAY MORNING ABOUT A WEEK
AFTER HE

HAD ARRIVED AT THE BURIAL. HE AND RON WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST THE
FIND MR.

AND MRS. WEASLEY AND GINNY ALREADY SITTING AT THE KITCHEN TABLE.
THE

MOMENT SHE SAW HARRY, GINNY ACCIDENTALLY BOUNCED HER PHURIDGE
KICK THE

THE FLOOR WITH A LITTLE CLATTER, GINNY SEEMED VERY PRONE THE
BENDING THINGS

EVER WHENEVER HARRY ENTERED A ROOM. SHE DIVED UNDER THE TABLE THE
RETRIEVE

THE KICK AND EMERGED WITH HER FACE GLOWING LIKE THE SETTING SUN.

PRETENDING HE HADN'T NOTICED THIS, HARRY SAT DOWN AND THREW THE
THEAT MRS.

WEASLEY OFFERED HIM.

LETTERS FROM SCHOOL, SAID MR. WEASLEY, PASSING HARRY AND RON
IDENTICAL ENVELOPES OF YELLOWISH PARCHMENT, ADDRESSED IN GREEN INK.

OLIVERWORME ALREADY KNOWS WHEN HE HERE, HARRY DOESN'T MISS A TRICK,

THAT MAN, WHEN YOU GET THEM, THEN, HE ADDED, AS FRED AND GEORGE AMBLED

IN, STILL IN THEIR PYJAMAS.

FOR A FEW MINUTES THERE WAS SILENCE AS THEY ALL READ THEIR LETTERS. HARRY'S

TOLD HIM THEY CATCH THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS AS USUAL FROM KING'S CROSS STATION

ON SEPTEMBER FIRST. THERE WAS ALSO A LIST OF THE NEW BOOKS HE'D NEED FOR

THE COMING YEAR.

SECOND-YEAR STUDENTS WILL REQUIRE:

THE STANDARD BOOK OF SPELLS, GRADE 2 BY MIRANDA GOSHAWK

BREAD WITH A KANSHER BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

CABBING WITH CABBLES BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

HOLIDAYS WITH HACS BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

TRAVELS WITH TRELLS BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

VENAGERS WITH VAMPIRES BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

WANDERINGS WITH WEREWOLVES BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

YEAR WITH THE YETI BY GILDERHOY LICKHART

FRED, WHEN HAD FINISHED HIS OWN LIST, PEERED OVER AT HARRY'S.

WHEN YOU BEEN TOLD THEY GET ALL LICKHART'S BOOKS, THEN? HE SAID. THE NEW

DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER MUST BE A FAN BET IT'S A WITCH.

AT THIS POINT, FRED CAUGHT HIS MOTHER'S EYE AND QUICKLY BLISHED
HIMSELF

WITH THE MARMALADE.

THAT LET WHEN T CAME CLEAP, SAID GEORGE, WITH A QUICK LEED AT
HIS

PARENTS. SECOND-HART'S SHEDS ARE REALLY EXPENSIVE. . . .

WELL, WE LL MANAGE, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, BUT SHE SHEDDED WHEEDED. I
EXPECT WE LL BE ABLE TO PICK UP A LOT OF CINDY'S THINGS
SECOND-HAND.

HEY, ARE YOU STARTING AT HEGHARTS THIS YEAR? HARRY ASKED
CINDY.

SHE NEEDED, BLISHING THE THE SHEETS OF HER FLAMING HAIR, AND PLIT
HER EKEEN

IN THE CLUTTER DISH. FORTUNATELY SHE HADN'T SAW THIS EXCEPT HARRY,
BECAUSE JUST

THEN RON'S ELDER BROTHER PERCY WALKED IN. HE WAS ALREADY DRESSED,
HIS

HEGHARTS PERFECT BADGE PINNED TO HIS SWEATER VEST.

MORNING, ALL, SAID PERCY CRISPLY. BEVELY DAY.

HE SAT DOWN IN THE ONLY REMAINING CHAIR BUT LEAPT UP AGAIN
ALMOST

IMMEDIATELY, PULLING FROM UNDERNEATH HIM A MELTING, GRAY FEATHER
BLISTER

AT LEAST, THAT WAS WHAT HARRY THOUGHT IT WAS, UNTIL HE SAW
THAT IT WAS

BREATHING.

CRUEL! SAID RON, TAKING THE LIMP HILL FROM PERCY AND EXTRACTING
A

LETTER FROM UNDER ITS WING. FINALLY HE'S GOT HERMIONE'S
ANSWER. I WRITE

THE HER SAYING WE WERE GOING TO TRY AND RESCUE YELL FROM THE
DURSLAYS.

HE CARRIED CAROL THE A PERCH ILIST INSIDE THE BACK DEER AND TRIED THE
STAND

HIM IN IT, BUT CAROL SLEPPED STRAIGHT OFF AGAIN SHE THEN LAID HIM IN
THE

DRAINING BARD INSTEAD, PLUTTERING, PATHETIC. THEN HE RIPPED
OPEN

HERMINE'S LETTER AND READ IT HEAT BOLD:

DEAR BEN, AND HARRY IF YOU'RE THERE,

I HOPE EVERYTHING WENT ALL RIGHT AND THAT HARRY IS OKAY AND
THAT YOU

DIDN'T DO ANYTHING ILLEGAL TO GET HIM OUT, BEN, BECAUSE THAT WOULD
GET

HARRY INTO TROUBLE, THEN, I'VE BEEN REALLY WORRIED AND IF HARRY IS
ALL RIGHT,

WILL YOU PLEASE LET ME KNOW AT ONCE, BUT PERHAPS IT WOULD BE BETTER
IF YOU

USED A DIFFERENT MAIL, BECAUSE I THINK ANOTHER DELIVERY MIGHT FINISH
YOUR

ONE OFF,

I'M VERY BUSY WITH SCHOOLWORK, OF COURSE YOU CAN SEE BY
SAID

THEN IN FURTHER, WE'RE ON VACATION! AND WE'RE GOING TO
LONDON NEXT

WEDNESDAY TO BUY MY NEW BOOKS, WHY DON'T WE MEET IN DIAGON
ALLEY?

LET ME KNOW WHAT'S HAPPENING AS SOON AS YOU CAN, LOVE FROM
HERMINE.

WELL, THAT FITS IN NICELY, WE CAN GO AND GET ALL OUR THINGS THEN,
THEY

SAID MRS. WEASLEY, STARTING TO CLEAR THE TABLE. WHAT ARE YOU ALL UP
TO

TODAY?

HARRY, RON, FRED, AND GEORGE WERE PLANNING TO GO UP THE HILL TO
A SMALL

PODDER THE WEASLEYS HAD. IT WAS SURROUNDED BY TREES THAT
BLINDED IT

FROM VIEW OF THE VILLAGE BELOW, MEANING THAT THEY COULD PRACTICE
FLUIDITY THERE, AS LONG AS THEY DIDN'T FLY TOO HIGH. THEY COULDN'T
USE REAL

FLUIDITY BALLS, WHICH WOULD HAVE BEEN HARD TO EXPLAIN IF THEY HAD
ESCAPED AND FLEW AWAY OVER THE VILLAGE; INSTEAD THEY THREW
APPLES FOR FUN

ANOTHER TWO LATCH. THEY THEN TURNED RIDING HARRY'S NIMBLE TWO
THOUSAND,

WHICH WAS EASILY THE BEST BREED; RON'S OLD SHOOTING STAR WAS
EIGHTEN

WASTED BY PASSING CLITTERALS.

FIVE MINUTES LATER THEY WERE MARCHING UP THE HILL, BREASTING
EVER

THEIR SHOULDERS. THEY HAD ASKED PERCY IF HE WANTED TO JOIN THEM,
BUT HE

HAD SAID HE WAS BUSY. HARRY HAD ONLY SEEN PERCY AT MEALTIMES FOR
FOR; HE

STAYED SEAT IN HIS ROOM THE REST OF THE TIME.

WISH I KNEW WHAT HE WAS UP TO, SAID FRED, FROWNING. HE'S NOT
HIMSELF, HIS EXAM RESULTS CAME THE DAY BEFORE YOU DID; TWELVE
EELS

AND HE HARDLY CHEATED AT ALL.

ORDINARY WIZARDING LEVELS, GEORGE EXPLAINED, SEEING HARRY'S
PUZZLED

WINK. BILL GIFT TWELVE, THEN. IF WE'RE NOT CAREFUL, WE'LL HAVE
ANOTHER HEAD

KEEP IN THE FAMILY, I DON'T THINK I COULD STAND THE SAME.

BILL WAS THE ELDEST WEASLEY BROTHER, HE AND THE NEXT BROTHER,
CHARLIE,

HAD ALREADY LEFT HOGWARTS. HARRY HAD NEVER MET EITHER OF THEM,
BUT KNEW

THAT CHARLIE WAS IN ROMANIA STUDYING DRAGONS AND BILL IN EGYPT
WORKING

FOR THE WIZARDS' BOND, GRINGETTS.

DINNER WITH MOM AND DAD ARE GOING TO AFFORD ALL YOUR SCHOOL STUFF
THIS

YEAR, SAID GEORGE AFTER A WHILE. FIVE SETS OF BEDDING, KITCHEN
AND CUPBOARD

NEEDS REPAIRS AND A WARD AND EVERYTHING. . . .

HARRY SAID NOTHING. HE FELT A KICK ABOARD, STARED IN AN
UNDERSTANDING

WALK AT GRINGETTS IN LONDON WAS A SMALL FEELING THAT HIS
PARENTS HAD LEFT

HIM. HE KNEW, IT WAS ONLY IN THE WIZARDING WORLD THAT HE HAD
MONEY, WELL

COULDN'T USE CALLIONS, SICKLES, AND KNITS IN Muggle shops. HE
HAD NEVER

MENTIONED HIS GRINGETTS BANK ACCOUNT TO THE DURSLEYS; HE DIDN'T
THINK

THEIR FATHER OF ANYTHING CONNECTED WITH MAGIC WOULD STRETCH THE
A LARGE PILE

HER CHILD.

MRS. WEASLEY WENT THEM ALL EARLY THE FOLLOWING WEDNESDAY, AFTER
A BRICK

HALF A DOZEN EACH SANDWICHES EACH, THEY PULLED ON THEIR COATS AND
MRS.

WEASLEY TOOK A FLEWERPOET OFF THE KITCHEN MANTELPIECE AND PEERED
INSIDE.

WE'RE RUNNING LOW, ARTHUR, SHE SIGHED. WE'LL HAVE THE BIRD SOME
MORE

TODAY. . . . AS WELL, GUESTS FIRST! AFTER YELL, HARRY DEAR!

AND SHE OFFERED HIM THE FLEWERPOET.

HARRY STARED AT THEM ALL WATCHING HIM.

W-WHAT AM I SUPPOSED TO DO? HE STAMMERED.

HE'S NEVER TRAVELED BY FLEWERPOET, SAID BEN SUDDENLY. SHIRRY,
HARRY,

I FORGET.

NEVER? SAID MR. WEASLEY. BUT HOW DID YELL GET THE DIAGONAL ALLEY
THE

BIRD YELLER SCHEMED THINGS LAST YEAR?

I WENT IN THE UNDERGROUND

REALLY? SAID MR. WEASLEY EAGERLY. WERE THERE ESCAPATORS? FLEW
EXACTLY

NOT NEAR, ARTHUR, SAID MRS. WEASLEY. FLEWERPOET'S A LEFT
BRICKER,

DEAR, BUT GOODNESS ME, IF YELL YOU NEVER USED IT BEFORE

HE'LL BE ALL RIGHT, MUM, SAID FRED. HARRY, WATCH US FIRST.

HE TOOK A PINCH OF GLITTERING POWDER OUT OF THE FLEWERPOET,
STEPPED UP THE

THE FIRE, AND THREW THE PHELDER INTO THE FLAMES.

WITH A REAR, THE FIRE TURNED EMERALD GREEN AND ROSE HIGHER THAN
FRED,

WHEN STEPPED RIGHT INTO IT, SCHELTED, DIAGEN ALLEY? AND VANISHED.

YELL MUST SPEAK CLEARLY, DEAR, MRS. WEASLEY TOLD HARRY AS
GERHGE

DIPPED HIS HAND INTO THE FLEWERPHEET, AND BE SURE THE GET ELIT AT THE
RIGHT

GRATE, . . .

THE RIGHT WHAT? SAID HARRY NERVILISLY AS THE FIRE REARED AND
WHIPPED

GERHGE ELIT HE SIGHT, THEN.

WELL, THERE ARE AN AWFUL LEFT HE WIZARD FIRES THE C-THOSE FROM, YELL
DNEHL,

ELIT AS LONG AS YELL YE SPEEKEN CLEARLY

HE LL BE FINE, MEHL, DEN T FLISS, SAID MR. WEASLEY, HELPING HIMSELF
THE

FLEHL PHELDER, THEN.

ELIT, DEAR, IF HE GET LEST, FHLW WELLD WE EVER EXPLAIN THE HIS ALINT
AND

WINKLE?

THEY WELLDN T MIND, HARRY REASSURED HER. DUBLEY WELLD THIND
IT WAS

A BRILLIANT IDEE IF I GET LEST LIP A CHIMNEY, DEN T WHRRY ASHLIT THAT

WELL . . . ALL RIGHT . . . YELL GE AFTER ARTHUR, SAID MRS. WEASLEY,
NHL,

WHEN YELL GET INTO THE FIRE, SAY WHERE YELL RE GEING

AND KEEP YELR EKEHS TUCKED IN, REEN ADVISED.

AND YELR EYES SHLT, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, THE SHEET

DEN'T FIDGET, SAID DEN. HER WHI MIGHT WELL FALL OUT OF THE WRING
FIREPLACE

BUT DEN'T PANIC AND GET OUT TOO EARLY; WAIT UNTIL WHI SEE FRED
AND

GEORGE.

TRYING HARD TO REAR ALL THIS IN MIND, HARRY TOOK A PINCH OF FLESH
POUNDER

AND WALKED TO THE EDGE OF THE FIRE. HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH, SCATTERED
THE

POUNDER INTO THE FLAMES, AND STEPPED FORWARD; THE FIRE FELT LIKE A
WARM

BREEZE; HE OPENED HIS MOUTH AND IMMEDIATELY SWALLOWED A LUMP OF
HOT ASH.

O-DIA-GHIN ALLEY, HE CHALLENGED.

IT FELT AS THOUGH HE WERE BEING SLIDED DOWN A GIANT DRAIN, HE
SEEMED TO

BE SPINNING VERY FAST THE WHIRLING IN HIS EARS WAS DEAFENING
HE TRIED

TO KEEP HIS EYES OPEN BUT THE WHIRL OF GREEN FLAMES MADE HIM FEEL
SICK

SOMETHING HARD BOUNCED HIS KNEE AND HE TUCKED IT IN TIGHTLY, STILL
SPINNING AND SPINNING WHEN IT FELT AS THOUGH CHILD HANDS WERE
SLAPPING

HIS FACE SWERVING THROUGH HIS GLASSES HE SAW A BLURRED STREAM
OF

FIREPLACES AND SNATCHED GLIMPSES OF THE ROOMS BEYOND HIS BACK

SANDWICHES WERE CHURNING INSIDE HIM HE CLOSED HIS EYES AGAIN
WISHING

IT WOULD STOP, AND THEN

HE FELL, FACE FORWARD, HEATH CHILD STONE AND FELT THE BRIDGE OF HIS GLASSES

SNAP,

DIZZY AND KILISED, COVERED IN SWEAT, HE GOT GINGERLY TO HIS FEET, FEELING

HIS BROKEN GLASSES UP TO HIS EYES, HE WAS BLIND ALONE, BUT WHERE HE WAS, HE

HAD NO IDEA, ALL HE COULD TELL WAS THAT HE WAS STANDING IN THE STONE

FIREPLACE OF WHAT SEEMED LIKE A LARGE, DIMLY LIT LIZARD'S SHEEP BUT

NOTHING IN THERE WAS EVER LIKELY TO BE IN A FLEWART'S SCHEMELIST,

A GLASS CASE NEARBY HELD A WITHERED HAND IN A CLIP-HORN, A BLEEDSTAINED

PACK OF CARDS, AND A STARING GLASS EYE, EVIL-LOOKING MASKS STARED DOWN

FROM THE WALLS, AN ASSORTMENT OF FILMAN KNIVES LAY UPON THE COUNTER, AND

BLISTY, SPIKED INSTRUMENTS HUNG FROM THE CEILING, EVEN WORSE, THE DARK,

NARROW STREET HARRY COULD SEE THROUGH THE BLISTY SHEEP WINDOW WAS

DEFINITELY NOT DIAGEN ALLEY,

THE SMOOTHER HE GOT BLIT OF HERE, THE BETTER, NEAR STILL STINGING WHERE IT HAD

HIT THE HEARTH, HARRY MADE HIS WAY SWIFTLY AND SILENTLY TOWARD THE DEER,

BUT BEFORE HE COULD GET HALFWAY TOWARD IT, TWO PEOPLE APPEARED IN THE EITHER

SIDE OF THE CLASS AND ONE OF THEM WAS THE VERY LAST PERSON
HARRY WANTED

THE MEET WHEN HE WAS LOST, COVERED IN SWEAT, AND WEARING BROKEN
GLASSES:

DRACH MALPHY,

HARRY WHISKED RELUCTANTLY AROUND AND SPOTTED A LARGE BLACK CABINET THE
HIS

LEFT; HE SHUT INSIDE IT AND PULLED THE DOORS CLOSED, LEAVING A SMALL
CRACK THE

PEER THROUGH. SECONDS LATER, A BELL RANGED, AND MALPHY STEPPED
INTO THE

SHOP,

THE MAN WHO RESEMBLED CHILD ONLY BE DRACH'S FATHER, HE HAD THE
SAME

PALE, PAINTED FACE AND IDENTICAL HAIR, GRAY EYES. MR. MALPHY CROSSED
THE

SHOP, LOOKING LAZILY AT THE ITEMS ON DISPLAY, AND RANG A BELL ON
THE CHINTZ

BEFORE TURNING THE HIS SIDE AND SAYING, "TALKING NOTHING, DRACH,

MALPHY, WHO HAD REACHED FOR THE GLASS OF, SAID, "I THOUGHT YOU
WERE

GIVING THE KID ME A PRESENT,

"I SAID I WOULD BUY YOU A RACING BROOM," SAID HIS FATHER, DRUMMING
HIS

FINGERS ON THE CHINTZ,

"WHAT'S THE GOOD OF THAT IF I'M NOT ON THE HOUSE TEAM?" SAID
MALPHY,

LOOKING SLIDY AND BAD-TEMPERED. HARRY BETTER GET A NIMBUS TWO

THOUSAND LAST YEAR. SPECIAL PERMISSION FROM DUMBLEDORE SEE HE
COULD PLAY

HER GRYPFINDER, HE S NEET EVEN THAT GOOD, IT S ILST BECALISE HE S
FAMHLS . . .

FAMHLS HER HAVING A STUPID STAR EN HIS FHEKE-HEAD, . . .

MALPHY BENT DEHN TH EXAMINE A SHELF FULL OF SKILLS,

. . . EVERYONE THINKS HE S SHE SMART, WHENDRLL PITTER WITH HIS
STAR AND

HIS BRHHHSTICK

YELI HAVE TELD ME THIS AT LEAST A DEZEN TIMES ALREADY, SAID MR.
MALPHY,

WITH A BELLING LEEK AT HIS SHN, AND I WELLD REMIND YELI THAT IT
IS NEET

PRUDENT TH APPEAR LESS THAN FEND OF F-JARRY PITTER, NEET WIKEN
MEET OF HLIR

KIND REGARD HIM AS THE FEREH W-TH MADE THE DARK LEHD DISAPPEAR
AH, MR.

BERGIN.

A STEEPING MAN HAD APPEARED BEHIND THE CHLINTER, SPEETHING HIS
GREASY

HAIR BACK FROM HIS FACE,

MR, MALPHY, WHAT A PLEASURE TH SEE YELI AGAIN, SAID MR, BERGIN
IN A

VEICE AS HILY AS HIS HAIR, DELIGHTED AND YELING MASTER MALPHY,
THEE

CHARMED, F-HEE MAY I BE OF ASSISTANCE? I MUST SE-HEE YELI, ILST IN
THEAY, AND

VERY REASONABLY PRICED

I M NEET BLYING THEAY, MR, BERGIN, KLT SELLING, SAID MR, MALPHY,

SELLING? THE SMILE FADED SLIGHTLY FROM MR, BERGIN S FACE,

YELL HAVE HEARD, HE CHURSE, THAT THE MINISTRY IS CONDUCTING MORE
RAIDS,

SAID MR. MALPHY, TAKING A REEL OF PARLIMENT FROM HIS INSIDE
POCKET AND

UNRAVELING IT FOR MR. BERGIN TO READ. I HAVE A FEW ALL ITEMS
AT HOME

THAT MIGHT EMBARRASS ME, IF THE MINISTRY WERE TO CALL. . . .

MR. BERGIN ADDED A PAIR OF PINCE-NEZ TO HIS NESE AND LOOKED DOWN
THE

LIST.

THE MINISTRY WOULDNT PRESUME TO TROUBLE YELL, SIR, WOULD?

MR. MALPHY S LIP CURLED.

I HAVE NOT BEEN VISITED YET. THE NAME MALPHY STILL DEMANDS A
CERTAIN

RESPECT, YET THE MINISTRY GROWS EVER MORE MEDDLESOME. THERE ARE
RUMORS

ABOUT A NEW MUGGLE PROTECTION ACT NOT BELIEVE THAT PLEA-KITTEN,
MUGGLE-

MOVING FROM ARTHUR WEASLEY IS BEHIND IT

HARRY FELT A FURT SLURGE OF ANGER.

AND AS YELL SEE, CERTAIN OF THESE PHISONS MIGHT MAKE IT APPEAR

I UNDERSTAND, SIR, HE CHURSE, SAID MR. BERGIN. LET ME SEE . . .

CAN I HAVE THAT? INTERRUPTED DRACE, POINTING AT THE WITHERED
HAND MEN

ITS CLISH-HEEN.

ALL THE HAND OF CLERY? SAID MR. BERGIN, ARRANGING MR.
MALPHY S LIST

AND SLURPING OVER THE DRACH. INSERT A CANDLE AND IT GIVES LIGHT
ONLY THE THE

FIELDER: BEST FRIEND OF THIEVES AND PLUNDERERS? YOUR SON HAS FINE
TASTE, SIR.

I HOPE MY SON WILL AMOUNT THE MORE THAN A THIEF OR A PLUNDERER,
BERGIN, SAID MR. MALPHY CHEERLY, AND MR. BERGIN SAID BLICKLY, NO
OFFENSE,

SIR, NO OFFENSE MEANT

THOUGH IF HIS GRADES DIDN'T PICK UP, SAID MR. MALPHY, MORE CHEERLY
STILL,

THAT MAY INDEED BE ALL HE IS FIT FOR

IT'S NOT MY FAULT, RETORTED DRACH. THE TEACHERS ALL HAVE
FAVORITES, THAT

HERMINE CRANGER

I WOULD HAVE THOUGHT YOU'D BE ASHAMED THAT A GIRL OF NO WIZARD
FAMILY

BEAT YOU IN EVERY EXAM, SNAPPED MR. MALPHY.

HA! SAID HARRY UNDER HIS BREATH, PLEASED TO SEE DRACH BLEEDING
BOTH

ASHAMED AND ANGRY.

IT'S THE SAME ALL OVER, SAID MR. BERGIN, IN HIS HOLY VOICE. WIZARD
BLEED IS CHLORINE FOR LESS EVERYWHERE

MEET WITH ME, SAID MR. MALPHY, HIS LONG NEUSTRILS FLARING.

NO, SIR, MEET WITH ME, SIR, SAID MR. BERGIN, WITH A DEEP KEEH.

IN THAT CASE, PERHAPS WE CAN RETURN THE MY LIST, SAID MR. MALPHY
SHORTLY.

I AM IN SOMETHING OF A HURRY, BERGIN, I HAVE IMPORTANT BUSINESS
ELSEWHERE TODAY

THEY STARTED THE HAGGLE. HARRY WATCHED NERVOUSLY AS DRACH DREW NEARER

AND NEARER THE HIS HIDING PLACE, EXAMINING THE OBJECTS FOR SALE. DRACH

PAUSED TO EXAMINE A LONG CHAIN OF HANGMAN'S REEPE AND THE READ, SMIRKING, THE

CARD PRESENTED HIM A MAGNIFICENT NECKLACE OF BEPALS, CALTHERN! DEE NEEET THELICH.

CURSED HAS CLAIMED THE LIVES OF NINETEEN MUGGLE OWNERS THE DATE.

DRACH TURNED AWAY AND SAW THE CABINET RIGHT IN FRONT OF HIM. HE WALKED

FORWARD HE STRETCHED OUT HIS HAND FOR THE HANDLE

BEHNE, SAID MR. MALPHEE AT THE CHLINTER. COME, DRACH

HARRY WIPED HIS FOREHEAD WITH HIS SLEEVE AS DRACH TURNED AWAY.

GOOD DAY TO YOU, MR. BERGIN. I WILL EXPECT YOU AT THE MANNER TEMPERANCE THE

PICK UP THE CHIEFS.

THE MOMENT THE DEER HAD CLOSED, MR. BERGIN DROPPED HIS MILY MANNER.

GOOD DAY YOURSELF, MISTER MALPHEE, AND IF THE STORIES ARE TRUE, YOU

HAVEN'T SEEN ME HALF OF WHAT IS HIDDEN IN YOUR MANNER. . . .

MUTTERING DARKLY, MR. BERGIN DISAPPEARED INTO A BACK ROOM. HARRY

WAITED FOR A MINUTE IN CASE HE CAME BACK, THEN, QUICKLY AS HE COULD,

SLIPPED OUT OF THE CABINET, PAST THE GLASS CASES, AND OUT OF THE SHOP DEER.

CLUTCHING HIS CRACKEN GLASSES TO HIS FACE, HARRY STARED AROUND, HE
HAD

EMERGED INTO A DINGY ALLEYWAY THAT SEEMED TO BE MADE UP ENTIRELY OF
STEPS DEVOTED TO THE DARK ARTS. THE ONE HE DIDN'T LEFT, KROGIN AND
KROGES,

LOOKED LIKE THE LARGEST, BUT OPPOSITE WAS A NASTY WINDY DISPLAY
OF

STRIKING HEADS AND, THE OTHERS DOWN, A LARGE CAGE WAS ALIVE WITH
GIGANTIC

BLACK SPIDERS. THE SHAKY-LOOKING WIZARDS WERE WATCHING HIM
FROM THE

SHADOWS OF A DEERWAY, MUTTERING TO EACH OTHER, FEELING ILMPY,
HARRY SET

OFF, TRYING TO HOLD HIS GLASSES UP STRAIGHT AND KEEPING AGAINST
THE ONE HE DID

ABLE TO FIND A WAY OUT OF HERE.

AN OLD WOODEN STREET SIGN HANGING OVER A SHOP SELLING
PHISHNUTS

CANDLES TOLD HIM HE WAS IN KROGTOWN ALLEY. THIS DIDN'T HELP, AS
HARRY HAD

NEVER HEARD OF SUCH A PLACE. HE SUPPOSED HE HADN'T SPENTEN CLEARLY
ENOUGH

THROUGH HIS MOUTHFUL OF ASHES BACK IN THE WEASLEYS' FIRE. TRYING
TO STAY

CALM, HE WONDERED WHAT TO DO.

WHAT BEST ARE YOU, MY DEAR? SAID A VOICE IN HIS EAR, MAKING HIM
JUMP.

AN AGED WITCH STOOD IN FRONT OF HIM, HOLDING A TRAY OF WHAT
LOOKED

HORRIBLY LIKE WHITE HUMAN FINGERNAILS. SHE LEERED AT HIM,
SMILING MISSEY

TEETH, HARRY RAN AWAY.

I'M FINE, THANKS, HE SAID. I'M LOST

HARRY: WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'RE DOING DOWN THERE?

HARRY'S HEART LEAPT. SHE DID THE WITCH! A LEAD OF FINGERNAILS
CASCADING

DOWN OVER HER FEET AND SHE CLIMBED AS THE MASSIVE FORM OF HAGRID,
THE

HOGWARTS GAMEKEEPER, CAME STRIDING TOWARD THEM, BEETLE-BLACK EYES
FLASHING OVER HIS GREAT BRISTLING BEARD.

HAGRID: HARRY CREAMED IN RELIEF. I WAS LOST FLEW FORWARD
HAGRID SEIZED HARRY BY THE SCUFF OF THE NECK AND PULLED HIM AWAY
FROM

THE WITCH, KNEELING THE TRAP RIGHT IN FRONT OF HER HANDS. HER SPRIES
PULLED

THEM ALL THE WAY ALONG THE TWISTING ALLEYWAY IN THE EIGHT
SLIGHT.

HARRY SAW A FAMILIAR, SNEL-WHITE MARBLE BUILDING IN THE DISTANCE

GRINGOTT'S BANK. HAGRID HAD STEERED HIM RIGHT INTO THE DRAGON ALLEY.

YOU'RE A MESS! SAID HAGRID GRUFFLY, KISSING HIMSELF HARRY SHE
PULLING

HE NEARLY KNEELED HIM INTO A BARREL OF DRAGON BONE IN THE SIDE AND
APPROACHING.

SKIDING AROUND DOWNSTAIRS ALLEY, I BLINDLY DROVE PLACE,
HARRY DOWN

WANT ME HERE TO SEE YOU DOWN THERE

I REALIZED THAT, SAID HARRY, BLINKING AS HAGRID MADE THE KISS HIM
HIM

AGAIN. I TOLD YOU, I WAS LOST WHAT WERE YOU DOING DOWN THERE,

ANDWAY?

I WAS LOOKIN FOR A FLESH-EATING SLUG REPELLENT, GROWLED F-LACRID.

THEY'RE ALIVIN THE SCHEERH CARRAGES, YER NEET EN YER ELIN?

I'M STAYING WITH THE WEASLEYS BUT WE GOT SEPARATED, F-HARRY EXPLAINED.

I'VE GOT THE CH AND FIND THEM, . . .

THEY SET OFF TOGETHER DOWN THE STREET.

FEEL THEM YER NEVER WRITE BACK TER ME? SAID F-LACRID AS F-HARRY HEGGED

ALONGSIDE HIM HE HAD TO TAKE THREE STEPS THE EVERY STRIDE OF F-LACRID'S

ENTHRALLING KICKS!, F-HARRY EXPLAINED ALL ABOUT DICKY AND THE DURSLEYS.

LELISY MUGGLES, GROWLED F-LACRID. IF I'D VE KNOWN

F-HARRY: F-HARRY: HEYER HERE!

F-HARRY LEANED UP AND SAW HERMIONE GRANGER STANDING AT THE TOP OF THE

WHITE FLIGHT OF STEPS THE GRINGETTS. SHE RAN DOWN TO MEET THEM, HER KISS-IF

KNOWN HAIR FLYING BEHIND HER.

WHAT HAPPENED TO YOUR GLASSES? F-HELL, F-LACRID EH, IT'S WHENDRILL THE

SEE YOU TWO AGAIN ARE YOU COMING INTO GRINGETTS, F-HARRY?

AS SOON AS I'VE FOUND THE WEASLEYS, SAID F-HARRY.

YER WHEN I HAVE TIME TER WAIT, F-LACRID SAID WITH A GRIN.

F-HARRY AND HERMIONE LEANED AHEAD! SPRINTING UP THE CROOKED STREET

WERE BEN, FRED, GEORGE, PERCY, AND MR. WEASLEY.

HARRY, MR. WEASLEY PANTED. HE HOPED THEY'D ONLY GIVE HIM
GRATE THEM

FAR... HE MOVED HIS GLISTENING BALD PATCH. MERRY & FRANTIC
SHE'S

CHIMING NEW

WHERE DID THEY COME FROM? RICH ASKED.

KNIGHTLAWN ALLEY, SAID HARRY GRIMLY.

EXCELLENT! SAID FRED AND GEORGE TOGETHER.

WE'VE NEVER BEEN ALLOWED IN, SAID RICH ENVIOUSLY.

I SHOULD REALLY WELL THINK NOT, GRIELED HARRY.

MRS. WEASLEY NEW CAME CALLING IN THE VIEW, HER HANDS
SWINGING

WILDLY IN HER HAND, GINNY JUST CLINGING BETWEEN THE OTHER.

HEY, HARRY HEY, MY DEAR THEY COULD HAVE BEEN ANYWHERE
GASPING FOR BREATH, SHE PULLED A LARGE CLOTHES BASKET OUT OF HER
BAG AND

BEGAN SLEEPING OFF THE SHEET HARRY HADN'T MANAGED TO BEAT AWAY,
MR.

WEASLEY THREW HARRY'S GLASSES, GAVE THEM A TAP ON HIS WARD, AND
RETURNED

THEM, CHEER AS NEW.

WELL, GETTA BE OFF, SAID HARRY, WHO WAS HAVING HIS HAND WRLING
BY

MRS. WEASLEY! KNIGHTLAWN ALLEY? IF THEY HADN'T FOUND HIM,
HARRY? !.

SEE HER AT HOGWARTS? AND HE STRODE AWAY, HEAD AND SHOULDERS
TALLER THAN

ANYONE ELSE IN THE PACKED STREET.

GUESS WHO I SAW IN BURGON AND BURKES? HARRY ASKED RICH AND

HERMIONE AS THEY CLIMBED THE GRINGETTS STEPS. MALPHY AND HIS FATHER.

DID LUKILIS MALPHY BUY ANYTHING? SAID MR. WEASLEY SHARPLY BEHIND

THEM.

NO, HE WAS SELLING

SEE HE'S WEARRIED, SAID MR. WEASLEY WITH GRIM SATISFACTION. EH, I'D

NEVER THOUGHT LUKILIS MALPHY FOR SOMETHING. . . .

THEY'RE CAREFUL, ARTFUL, SAID MRS. WEASLEY SHARPLY AS THEY WERE KEENED

INTO THE HAND BY A CHILIN AT THE DEER. THAT FAMILY'S TERRIBLE. DON'T GO

BITING OFF MORE THAN THEY CAN CHIEF

SEE THEY DON'T THINK I'M A MATCH FOR LUKILIS MALPHY? SAID MR. WEASLEY

INDIGNANTLY, BUT HE WAS DISTRACTED ALMOST AT ONCE BY THE SIGHT OF HERMIONE'S PARENTS, WHO WERE STANDING NERVOUSLY AT THE CHILINTER THAT RAN

ALL ALONG THE GREAT MARBLE HALL, WAITING FOR HERMIONE TO INTRODUCED THEM.

BUT THEY'RE MUGGLES? SAID MR. WEASLEY DELIGHTEDLY. WE MUST HAVE A

DRINK! WHAT'S THAT THEY'RE GET THERE? EH, THEY'RE CHANGING MUGGLE MINDS.

WELL, WELL! HE POINTED EXCITEDLY AT THE TEN-PHILING NOTES IN MR. GRANGER'S

HAND.

MEET THEM BACK HERE, JOHN SAID THE HERMITAGE AS THE WEASLEYS AND
HARRY

WERE LED OFF TO THEIR LINDERGRUND VALUITS BY ANOTHER CRINGHTTS
GHEKIN.

THE VALUITS WERE REACHED BY MEANS OF SMALL, GHEKIN-DRIVEN CARTS
THAT

SPED ALONG MINIATURE TRAIN TRACKS THROUGH THE SAND &
LINDERGRUND TUNNELS.

HARRY ENJOYED THE BREADCRUMB JOURNEY DOWN TO THE WEASLEYS
VALUIT, BUT FELT

DREADFUL, FAR WORSE THAN HE HAD IN DOWNSTOWN ALLEY, WHEN IT WAS
HAPPENED.

THERE WAS A VERY SMALL PILE OF SILVER DICKLES INSIDE, AND JUST ONE
CHILD

CALLING. MRS. WEASLEY FELT RIGHT INTO THE CORNERS BEFORE SWEEPING
THE

WHELE LEFT INTO HER BAG. HARRY FELT EVEN WORSE WHEN THEY REACHED
HIS VALUIT.

HE TRIED TO BLIND THE CONTENTS FROM VIEW AS HE HASTILY SHIPPED
HANDFULS OF

COINS INTO A LEATHER BAG.

BACK HILLSIDE ON THE MARBLE STEPS, THEY ALL SEPARATED. PERCY
MUTTERED

VAGUELY ABOUT NEEDING A NEW HILL. FRED AND GEORGE HAD SPOTTED
THEIR

FRIEND FROM HIGGLARTS, LEE JORDAN. MRS. WEASLEY AND GINNY WERE
GOING TO

A SECOND-HAND RICE SHOP. MR. WEASLEY WAS INSISTING ON TAKING THE
STRANGERS

OFF TO THE LEADY CALIBREIN FOR A DRINK.

WE'LL ALL MEET AT FLEETWICH AND BLITTS IN AN HOUR THE LADY FELIX
SCHEERKEHRS, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, SETTING OFF WITH GINNY, AND NOT
HURRY

STEP DOWN DOWNSTAIRS ALLEY? SHE SMILED AT THE TWINS
RETREATING BACKS.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE STROLLED OFF ALONG THE WINDING, CHECKED
STREET.

THE BAG OF GOLD, SILVER, AND BRONZE JINGLING CHEERFULLY IN HARRY'S
POCKET

WAS CLAMORING THE HE SPENT, SHE HE BELIEVED THREE LARGE STRAWBERRY-
AND-

PEARL-GLITTER ICE CREAMS, WHICH THEY SLURPED HAPPILY AS THEY
WANDERED UP

THE ALLEY, EXAMINING THE FASCINATING SHOP WINDOWS, RON GAZED
LONGINGLY AT

A FULL SET OF CHILDREN'S CLOTHES IN THE WINDOWS OF QUALITY
FLODDITCH

SLIPPIES UNTIL HERMIONIE DRAGGED THEM OFF THE LADY INDEX AND
PARLAMENT NEXT

DEER, IN GAMMA AND LARS WIZARDING INDEX SHOP, THEY MET FRED,
GEORGE,

AND LEE JORDAN, WHO WERE STOPPING UP FOR DR. FLEETWICH'S PARLOR
LET-

START, NEW-HEAT FIREWORKS, AND IN A TINY LANE SHOP FULL OF BROWN
WANDS,

HEXSIDED BRASS SCALES, AND OLD CHAIRS COVERED IN POTION STAINS THEY
FELIX

PERCY, DEEPLY IMMERSED IN A SMALL AND DEEPLY BEARING BOOK CALLED
PERFECTS

WHICH GAINED POWER.

A STUDY OF HEGWARTS PERFECTS AND THEIR LATER CAREERS. PERCY READ
ALoud

OFF THE BACK COVER. THAT SEEMS FASCINATING. . . .

GO AWAY, PERCY SNAPPED.

HOWEVER, HE'S VERY AMBITIOUS, PERCY, HE'S GOT IT ALL PLANNED OUT. . .
HE

WANTS TO BE MINISTER OF MAGIC. . . PERCY TOLD HARRY AND HERMIONE
IN AN

UNDERSTANDING AS THEY LEFT PERCY TO IT.

AN HOUR LATER, THEY HEADED FOR FLEET STREET AND BLOOMSBURY. THEY WERE BY
NOW

MEANS THE ONLY ONES MAKING THEIR WAY TO THE BARRISTERS. AS THEY
APPROACHED IT, THEY SAW TO THEIR SURPRISE A LARGE CROWD GATHERING
OUTSIDE THE

DOORS, TRYING TO GET IN. THE REASON FOR THIS WAS PROCLAIMED BY A
LARGE

BANNER STRETCHED ACROSS THE UPPER WINDOWS:

GILDEROY LOCKHART

WILL BE SIGNING COPIES OF HIS AUTOGRAPH

MAGICAL ME

TODAY 12:00 P.M. TO 4:00 P.M.

WE CAN ACTUALLY MEET HIM? HERMIONE SEIZED. I MEAN, HE'S
WRITTEN

ALMOST THE WHOLE BOOKLIST?

THE CROWD SEEMED TO BE MADE UP MOSTLY OF WITCHES AROUND MRS.
WEASLEY'S AGE. A HARASSED-LOOKING WIZARD STOOD AT THE FRONT,
SAYING,

CALMLY, PLEASE, LADIES, . . . DON'T PUSH, THERE . . . MIND THE BOOKS,
NOW, . . .

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE SEIZED INSIDE. A LONG LINE WOUND
RIGHT TO

THE BACK OF THE SHOP, WHERE GILDEROY LOCKHART WAS SIGNING HIS
BOOKS.

THEY EACH GRABBED A COPY OF THE STANDARD BOOK OF SPELLS, GRADE 7
AND

SNEAKED UP THE LINE TO WHERE THE REST OF THE WEASLEYS WERE
STANDING WITH

MR. AND MRS. GRANGER.

OH, THERE YOU ARE, CHILD, SAID MRS. WEASLEY. SHE SMILED
BREATHLESS

AND KEPT PATTING HER HAIR. WE'LL BE ABLE TO SEE HIM IN A MINUTE, . . .
,

GILDEROY LOCKHART CAME SLEENLY INTO VIEW, SEATED AT A TABLE
SURROUNDED

BY LARGE PICTURES OF HIS OWN FACE, ALL SMILING AND FLASHING
DAZZLINGLY

WHITE TEETH AT THE CROWD. THE REAL LOCKHART WAS WEARING RINGS OF
PERPET-

PERPET BLUE THAT EXACTLY MATCHED HIS EYES; HIS PAINTED WIZARD'S
HAT WAS SET

AT A LAZYT ANGLE IN HIS WAVY HAIR,

A SHORT, IRRITABLE-LOOKING MAN WAS DANCING AROUND TAKING
PHOTOGRAPHS

WITH A LARGE BLACK CAMERA THAT EMITTED PUFFS OF PURPLE SMOKE WITH
EVERY

BLINDING FLASH.

OUT OF THE WAY, THERE, HE SNARLED AT BEN, MOVING BACK TO GET A
BETTER

SHOT. THIS IS FOR THE DAILY PROPHECY

BIG DEAL, SAID BEN, RUBBING HIS SHIRT WHERE THE PHOTOGRAPHER HAD
STEPPED IN IT.

GILBERT LICKHART HEARD HIM. HE LICKED LIP, HE SAW BEN AND
THEN HE

SAW HARRY. HE STARED. THEN HE LEAPT TO HIS FEET AND POSITIVELY
SHOUTED. IT

CAN'T BE HARRY PETER?

THE CROWD PARTED, WHISPERING EXCITEDLY; LICKHART DIVED FORWARD,
SEIZED

HARRY'S ARM, AND PULLED HIM TO THE FRONT. THE CROWD BURST INTO
APPLAUSE.

HARRY'S FACE BURNED AS LICKHART SEIZED HIS HAND FOR THE
PHOTOGRAPHER, WHO

WAS CLICKING AWAY MADLY, WAFTING THICK SMOKE OVER THE LEASLIES.

NICE BIG SMILE, HARRY, SAID LICKHART, THROUGH HIS EYES GRACING
TEETH.

TOGETHER, YOU AND I ARE WORTHY THE FRONT PAGE.

WHEN HE FINALLY LET GO OF HARRY'S HAND, HARRY COULD HARDLY FEEL
HIS

FINGERS, HE TRIED THE SIDE BACK OVER THE THE WEASLEYS, BUT LICKHART
THREW AN

ARM AROUND HIS SHOULDERS AND CLAMPED HIM TIGHTLY TO HIS SIDE.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, HE SAID BEHOLD, HAVING FOR ELIOT. WHAT
AN

EXTRAORDINARY MOMENT THIS IS! THE PERFECT MOMENT FOR ME TO MAKE
A LITTLE

ANNOUNCEMENT I'VE BEEN SITTING ON FOR SOME TIME!

WHEN YOUNG HARRY HERE STEPPED INTO FLEWISH AND BLETTS TODAY,
HE ONLY

WANTED THE COPY MY AUTOGRAPH - WHICH I SHALL BE HAPPY TO
PRESENT HIM

NOW, FREE OF CHARGE THE CROWD APPLAUSED AGAIN. HE HAD NO
IDEA,

LICKHART CONTINUED, GIVING HARRY A LITTLE SHAKE THAT MADE HIS
GLASSES SLIP

THE THE END OF HIS NOSE, THAT HE WOULD SHORTLY BE GETTING MUCH,
MUCH MORE

THAN MY BEHE, MAGICAL ME. HE AND HIS SCHELMATES WILL, IN FACT, BE
GETTING THE REAL MAGICAL ME. YES, LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, I HAVE GREAT
PLEASURE AND PRIDE IN ANNOUNCING THAT THIS SEPTEMBER, I WILL BE
TAKING UP

THE POST OF DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER AT FLEWARTS
SCHOOL OF

WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY!

THE CROWD CHEERED AND CLAPPED AND HARRY FELT HIMSELF BEING
PRESENTED WITH THE ENTIRE WEIGHTS OF GILBERT LICKHART,
STAGGERING SLIGHTLY

UNDER THEIR WEIGHT, HE MANAGED TO MAKE HIS WAY OUT OF THE
LIMELIGHT THE THE

EDGE OF THE BEACH, WHERE GINNY WAS STANDING NEXT TO HER NEW
CALIBREIN.

WELL HAVE THESE, HARRY PLUNKED THE HER, TIPPING THE BEARDS INTO
THE

CALIBREIN. I LL KID MY HEIN

BUT WELL LIKED THAT, DIDN T WELL, PETER? SAID A VOICE HARRY HAD
NEH

TREMBLE RECOGNIZING, HE STRAIGHTENED UP AND FEELING HIMSELF FACE-
THE-FACE

WITH DRACE MALPHY, WHO WAS WEARING HIS USUAL SMILE.

FAMELIS HARRY PETER, SAID MALPHY, CAN T EVEN GET INTO A
BEARDSHIP

WITHOUT MAKING THE FRONT PAGE.

LEAVE HIM ALONE, HE DIDN T WANT ALL THAT? SAID GINNY, IT WAS THE
FIRST

TIME SHE HAD SPOKEN IN FRONT OF HARRY. SHE WAS GLARING AT
MALPHY.

PETER, WELL VE GET YOURSELF A GIRLFRIEND? DRAINED MALPHY, GINNY
WENT

SCARLET AS ROHN AND HERMIONE FELT THEIR WAY OVER, BOTH
CLUTCHING STAFFS

OF BLOODHART S BEARDS.

HEH, IT S WELL, SAID ROHN, LOOKING AT MALPHY AS IF HE WERE
SOMETHING

UNPLEASANT FOR THE SILENCE OF HIS SILENCE. BUT WELL BE SURPRISED TO SEE
HARRY HERE,

HEY

NOT AS SURPRISED AS I AM TO SEE WELL IN A SILENCE, WEASLEY, RETORTED

MALPHEE. I SUPPOSE YOUR PARENTS WILL BE HUNGRY FOR A MONTH THE
PAY FOR ALL

THESE.

JOHN WENT AS RED AS CINDY. HE DROPPED HIS KNEES INTO THE
CALIBRENS, THEN

AND STARTED TOWARD MALPHEE, BUT HARRY AND FERMINE GRABBED THE
BACK OF

HIS JACKET.

JOHN SAID MR. WEASLEY, STRUGGLING EVER WITH FRED AND GEORGE.
WHAT

ARE YOU DOING? IT'S THE CRIMINALS IN HERE, LET'S GO OUTSIDE.

WELL, WELL, WELL ARTHUR WEASLEY.

IT WAS MR. MALPHEE, HE STOOD WITH HIS HAND ON DORCEY'S SHOULDER,
SMILING

IN JUST THE SAME WAY.

LOOKS, SAID MR. WEASLEY, NODDING COLDLY.

BUSY TIME AT THE MINISTRY, I HEAR, SAID MR. MALPHEE. ALL THESE
RAIDS...

I HOPE THEY'RE PAYING YOU EVERYTIME?

HE REACHED INTO CINDY'S CALIBRENS AND EXTRACTED, FROM AMID THE
GLEESY

BLACK-HART KNEES, A VERY OLD, VERY BATTERED COPY OF A BEGINNER'S
GUIDE TO

TRANSFIGURATION.

HEAVENLY NO! MR. MALPHEE SAID. DEAR ME, WHAT'S THE USE OF
BEING A

DISGRACE TO THE NAME OF WIZARD IF THEY DON'T EVEN PAY YOU WELL FOR
IT?

MR. WEASLEY FLISHED DARKER THAN EITHER JOHN OR CINDY.

WE HAVE A VERY DIFFERENT IDEA OF WHAT DISGRACES THE NAME OF
WIZARD,

MALFEY, HE SAID,

CLEARLY, SAID MR. MALFEY, HIS PALE EYES STRAYING TO MR. AND MRS.
GRANGER, WHO WERE WATCHING APPREHENSIVELY. THE COMPANY WENT
DEEP,

WEASLEY . . . AND I THOUGHT THEIR FAMILY CHILD SINK NEARLY

THERE WAS A TING OF METAL AS GINNY'S CHILDREN WENT FLYING; MR.
WEASLEY

HAD THROWN HIMSELF AT MR. MALFEY, KNEELING HIM BACKWARD INTO A
BUNCH OF HEAVY SPELLBOOKS CAME THUNDERING DOWN ON
ALL THEIR

HEADS; THERE WAS A YELL OF, GET HIM, DAD! FROM FRED AND GEORGE;
MRS.

WEASLEY WAS SCREAMING, NE, ARTHUR, NE; THE CREW STAMPEDED
BACKWARD,

KNEELING MORE SILENTLY EVER; GENTLEMEN, PLEASE PLEASE; CRIED
THE

ASSISTANT, AND THEN, LOUDER THAN ALL

BREAD IT UP, THERE, GENTS, BREAD IT UP

HAGRID WAS WADING TOWARD THEM THROUGH THE SEA OF BOOKS, IN AN
INSTANT

HE HAD PULLED MR. WEASLEY AND MR. MALFEY APART, MR. WEASLEY HAD
A CLUT UP

AND MR. MALFEY HAD BEEN HIT IN THE EYE BY AN ENCYCLOPEDIA OF
THUNDERBOLTS,

HE WAS STILL HOLDING GINNY'S OLD TRANSLUCENT BOOK, HE
THROW IT AT HER,

HIS EYES GLITTERING WITH MALICE,

HERE, GIRL TAKE YOUR SEAT IT IS THE BEST YOUR FATHER CAN
GIVE YOU

PULLING HIMSELF UP HE GRABED A GRIP HE RECOVERED THE BRACE AND
SWEPT

FROM THE SEAT.

YOU SHOULD VE IGNORED HIM, ARTHUR, SAID JACKIE, ALMOST LIFTING
MR.

WEASLEY OFF HIS FEET AS HE STRAIGHTENED HIS REEKS, ROTTEN TER THE
CHIEF, THE

WHILE FAMILY, EVERYONE KNOWS THAT THE MARCHES ARE WORTH
LISTENING TO

AND KNOW, THAT IS WHAT IT IS COME ON NOW LET US GET OUTTA
HERE.

THE ASSISTANT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WANTED THE SEAT THEM LEAVING,
BUT HE

BARELY CAME UP TO JACKIE'S WAIST AND SEEMED TO THINK BETTER OF IT,
THEY

HURRIED UP THE STREET, THE STRANGERS SHAKING WITH FRIGHT AND MRS.
WEASLEY

RESIDE HERSELF WITH FLURY.

A FINE EXAMPLE THE SET FOR YOUR CHILDREN ... CRAWLING IN PUBLIC ...
WHAT

GILBERT LEONARD MUST VE THOUGHT

HE WAS PLEASED, SAID FRED, DIDN'T YOU HEAR HIM AS WE WERE
LEAVING?

HE WAS ASKING THAT BLUNDER FROM THE DAILY PROPHET IF HE D BE ABLE TO
WHICH

THE FIGHT INTO HIS REPORT SAID IT WAS ALL PUBLICITY

BUT IT WAS A SLEDDING CRUISE THAT HEADED BACK TO THE FIRESIDE IN THE
LEADY

CALIFORNIA, WHERE HARRY, THE WEASLEYS, AND ALL THEIR SHOPPING
WOULD BE

TRAVELING BACK TO THE BURNING LIVING ROOM FLOOR. THEY SAID GOOD-
BYE TO THE

GRANGERS, WHO WERE LEAVING THE PLAZA FOR THE MIDDLE STREET AND THE
OTHER

SIDE. MR. WEASLEY STARTED TO ASK THEM HOW HIS STEPS WEREN'T, BUT
STOPPED

ABRUPTLY AT THE LOOK ON MRS. WEASLEY'S FACE.

HARRY TOOK OFF HIS GLASSES AND PUT THEM SAFELY IN HIS POCKET
BEFORE

HELPING HIMSELF TO THE FLOOR. IT DEFINITELY WASN'T HIS FAVORITE
WAY TO

TRAVEL.

T

CHAPTER FIVE

THE WEEPING WILLOW

THE END OF THE SUMMER VACATION CAME TOO QUICKLY FOR HARRY'S
LIKING.

HE WAS LOOKING FORWARD TO GETTING BACK TO HOGWARTS, BUT HIS
MIND

AT THE BURNING HAD BEEN THE HAPPIEST OF HIS LIFE. IT WAS DIFFICULT
NOT TO FEEL

TRASHY OF THEM WHEN HE THOUGHT OF THE DURSLEYS AND THE SORT OF
WELCOME HE

WOULD EXPECT NEXT TIME HE TURNED UP IN PRIVET DRIVE.

IN THEIR LAST EVENING, MRS. WEASLEY CELEBRATED UP A SUMPTUOUS
DINNER

THAT INCLUDED ALL OF HARRY'S FAVORITE THINGS, ENDING WITH A
MELT-WATERING

TREACLE PUDDING. FRED AND GEORGE REFINED THE EVENING WITH A
DISPLAY

OF FIKILISTER FIREWORKS; THEY FILLED THE KITCHEN WITH RED AND BLUE
STARS THAT

REOUNDED FROM CEILING TO WALL FOR AT LEAST HALF AN HOUR. THEN IT
WAS TIME FOR

A LAST MUG OF HOT CHOCOLATE AND RED.

IT TOOK A LONG WHILE TO GET STARTED NEXT MORNING. THEY WERE UP
AT DAWN,

BUT SOMEHOW THEY STILL SEEMED TO HAVE A GREAT DEAL TO DO. MRS.
WEASLEY

DASHED ABOUT IN A BAD MOOD CHECKING HER SPARE SEEDS AND BILLS;
PEOPLE KEPT

CRASHING IN THE STAIRS, HALF-DRESSED WITH BITS OF TEAST IN THEIR
HANDS; AND

MR. WEASLEY NEARLY BROKE HIS NECK, TRIPPING OVER A STRAY CHICKEN
AS HE

CROSSED THE YARD CARRYING GINNY'S TRUNK TO THE CAR.

HARRY COULDN'T SEE HOW RIGHT PEOPLE, SIX LARGE TRUNKS, TWO BOWLS,
AND A

RAT WERE GOING TO FIT INTO THE SMALL FORD ANGELIA. HE HAD RECKONED,
HE

HOWEVER, WITHOUT THE SPECIAL FEATURES THAT MR. WEASLEY HAD ADDED,

NOT A WORD TO MARY. HE WHISPERED TO HARRY AS HE OPENED THE
TRUNK

AND SHELED HIM HOW IT HAD BEEN MAGICALLY EXPANDED SEE THAT THE
LUGGAGE

FITTED EASILY.

WHEN AT LAST THEY WERE ALL IN THE CAR, MRS. WEASLEY GLANCED INTO THE
THE

BACK SEAT, WHERE HARRY, RON, FRED, GEORGE, AND PERCY WERE ALL
SITTING

COMFORTABLY SIDE BY SIDE, AND SAID, MUGGLES DO KNOW MORE THAN WE
GIVE

THEM CREDIT PER, DON'T THEY? SHE AND GINNY GET INTO THE FRONT
SEAT, WHICH

HAD BEEN STRETCHED SEE THAT IT RESEMBLED A PARK BENCH. I MEAN, WHO'D
NEVER

KNOWN IT WAS THIS ROOMY FROM THE HILLSIDE, WOULD WHO?

MR. WEASLEY STARTED UP THE ENGINE AND THEY TRUNDLED OUT OF THE
YARD,

HARRY TURNING BACK FOR A LAST LOOK AT THE HOUSE. HE BARELY HAD
TIME TO

WONDER WHEN HE'D SEE IT AGAIN WHEN THEY WERE BACK. GEORGE HAD
FORGOTTEN HIS BOX OF FLICKSTER FIREWORKS, FIVE MINUTES AFTER THAT,
THEY

SKIDDED TO A HALT IN THE YARD SEE THAT FRED COULD RUN IN FOR HIS
BROOMSTICK.

THEY HAD ALMOST REACHED THE HIGHWAY WHEN GINNY SHRIEKED THAT
SHE'D LEFT

HER DIARY, BY THE TIME SHE HAD CLAMBERED BACK INTO THE CAR, THEY
WERE

RUNNING VERY FAST, AND TEMPERE WERE RUNNING HIGH.

MR. WEASLEY GLANCED AT HIS WATCH AND THEN AT HIS WIFE.

MERRY, DEAR

NEE, ARTHELIAR

NEE HENE WOULD SEE THIS LITTLE KITTEN HERE IS AN INVISIBILITY
BROOMSTICK I

INSTALLED THAT I GET US UP IN THE AIR THEN WE FLY ABOVE THE
CLOUDS.

WE D BE THERE IN TEN MINUTES AND NEE HENE WOULD BE AND THE WISER

I SAID NEE, ARTHELIAR, NOT IN BROAD DAYLIGHT

THEY REACHED KING'S CROSS AT A QUARTER TEN ELEVEN. MR. WEASLEY
DASHED

ACROSS THE ROAD TO GET THE LILLYS FOR THEIR TRUNKS AND THEY ALL
FLURRIED INTO THE

STATION.

HARRY HAD CAUGHT THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS THE PREVIOUS YEAR. THE
TRICKY

PART WAS GETTING ON THE PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS, WHICH
WASN'T

VISIBLE TO THE MUGGLE EYE. WHAT YELL HAD THE ONE WAS WALK THROUGH
THE SHIELD

BARRIER DIVIDING PLATFORMS NINE AND TEN. IT DIDN'T FLIRT, BUT IT HAD
THE BE DONE

CAREFULLY SEE THAT NONE OF THE MUGGLES NOTICED YELL VANISHING.

PERCY FIRST, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, LEEDING NERVOUSLY AT THE CLOCK
OVERHEAD, WHICH SHOWED THEY HAD ONLY FIVE MINUTES TO DISAPPEAR
CASUALLY

THROUGH THE BARRIER.

PERCY STRODE BRISKLY FORWARD AND VANISHED. MR. WEASLEY WENT NEXT;
FRED

AND GEORGE FOLLOWED.

I LL TAKE GINNY AND YELL WHEN COME RIGHT AFTER US, MRS. WEALEY
TOLD

HARRY AND RHN, GRABBING GINNY S HAND AND SETTING HER IN THE
BLIND HER AN

FOR THEY WERE GOING.

LET S GO TOGETHER, WE VE ONLY GOT A MINUTE, RHN SAID TO HARRY.
HARRY MADE SURE THAT FREDIE S CAGE WAS SAFELY WEDGED IN THE HER
HIS

TRUNK AND WHEELED HIS TRUNKY AROUND THE FACE THE BARRIER, HE FELT
PERFECTLY

CONFIDENT; THIS WASN T NEARLY AS UNCOMFORTABLE AS LISTING FLENN
PUNDER, RHN

HER THEM SENT WHEN EVER THE HANDLES HER THEIR TRUNKS AND WALKED
PURPOSEFULLY TOWARD THE BARRIER, GATHERING SPEED, A FEW FEET AWAY
FROM IT,

THEY BROKE INTO A RUN AND

CRASH!

RHN TRUNKS HIT THE BARRIER AND REBOUNDED BACKWARD; RHN S TRUNK
FELL HER

WITH A HEAVY THUMP, HARRY WAS KNOCKED OFF HIS FEET, AND FREDIE S
CAGE

REBOUNDED INTO THE SHINY FLENN, AND SHE ROLLED AWAY, SPRINGING
INDIGNANTLY;

PEOPLE ALL AROUND THEM STARED AND A GUARD NEARBY YELLED, WHAT IN
BLAZES

D YOU THINK YOU RE DOING?

LAST CENTRE OF THE TRUNK, HARRY GASPED, CLUTCHING HIS RIBS AS
HE GOT

LIP, RON RAN THE PICK UP HEDWIG, WHO WAS CAUSING SUCH A SCENE
THAT THERE

WAS A LOT OF MUTTERING ABOUT CRUELTY TO ANIMALS FROM THE
SURROUNDING

CROWD.

WHY CAN'T WE GET THROUGH? HARRY HISSED TO RON.

I DON'T

RON LOOKED WILDLY AROUND, A DOZEN CURIOUS PEOPLE WERE STILL
WATCHING

THEM.

WE'RE GOING TO MISS THE TRAIN, RON WHISPERED. I DON'T
UNDERSTAND

WHY THE GATEWAY'S SEALED ITSELF

HARRY LOOKED UP AT THE GIANT CLERK WITH A SICKENING FEELING IN
THE PIT OF

HIS STOMACH. TEN SECONDS . . . NINE SECONDS . . .

HE WHEELED HIS TROLLEY FORWARD CALIBRILLY UNTIL IT WAS RIGHT
AGAINST THE

BARRIER AND PUSHED WITH ALL HIS MIGHT. THE METAL REMAINED SHED.

THREE SECONDS . . . TWO SECONDS . . . ONE SECOND . . .

IT'S GONE, SAID RON, SOUNDING STUNNED. THE TRAIN'S LEFT. WHAT IF
MUM

AND DAD CAN'T GET BACK THROUGH THE LIFT? HAVE YOU GOT ANY MAGIC
MINNIE?

HARRY GAVE A HEAVY LAUGH. THE DURSLEYS HAVEN'T GIVEN ME
PHOENIX

MINNIE FOR ABOUT SIX YEARS.

RON PRESSED HIS EAR TO THE CHILD BARRIER.

CAN'T HEAR A THING, HE SAID TENSELY. WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO? I
DON'T

KNOW FEEL LIKE IT LL TAKE MOM AND DAD TH GET BACK TH LIS.

THEY LOOKED AROUND, PEOPLE WERE STILL WATCHING THEM, MAINLY
BECAUSE

OF FREDWIG S CONTINUING SCREECHES.

I THINK WE D BETTER GO AND WAIT BY THE CAR, SAID HARRY. WE RE
ATTRACTING TOO MUCH ATTEN

HARRY? SAID RON, HIS EYES GLAMING. THE CAR?

WHAT ABOUT IT?

WE CAN FLY THE CAR TH HOGWARTS?

BUT I THOUGHT

WE RE STUCK, RIGHT? AND WE VE GOT TH GET TH SCHOOL, HAVEN T WE?
AND

EVEN LINGERAGE WIZARDS ARE ALLOWED TH USE MAGIC IF IT S A REAL
EMERGENCY,

SECTION NINETEEN OR SOMETHING OF THE RESTRICTION OF THINGS

BUT YOUR MOM AND DAD ... SAID HARRY, PUSHING AGAINST THE
BARRIER

AGAIN IN THE VAIN HOPE THAT IT WOULD GIVE WAY. FEEL WILL THEY GET
HERE?

THEY DON T NEED THE CAR? SAID RON IMPATIENTLY. THEY KNOW FEEL
THE

APPARATE? YES KNOW, JUST VANISH AND REAPPEAR AT HERE? THEY
ONLY EITHER

WITH FLAME PHOENIX AND THE CAR BECAUSE WE RE ALL LINGERAGE AND WE RE
NOT

ALLOWED TH APPARATE YET, ...

HARRY S FEELING OF PANIC TURNED SUDDENLY TH EXCITEMENT.

CAN YOU FLY IT?

NO PROBLEM, SAID RON, WHIPPING HIS TRUNKY AROUND THE FACE THE EXIT.

[MNN, LET S GO. IF WE HURRY WE LL BE ABLE TO FOLLOW THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS

AND THEY MARCHED OFF THROUGH THE CROWD OF CURIOUS MUGGLES, OUT OF THE

STATION AND BACK INTO THE SIDE ROAD WHERE THE OLD FORD ANGELIA WAS PARKED.

RON UNLOCKED THE CAVERNELLS TRUNK WITH A SERIES OF TAPS FROM HIS WAND.

THEY HEAVED THEIR LUGGAGE BACK IN, PUT HERDIE IN THE BACK SEAT, AND GOT

INTO THE FRONT.

CHECK THAT NO ONE S WATCHING, SAID RON, STARTING THE IGNITION WITH

ANOTHER TAP OF HIS WAND. HARRY STUCK HIS HEAD OUT OF THE WINDOW: TRAFFIC

WAS RINKLING ALONG THE MAIN ROAD AHEAD, BUT THEIR STREET WAS EMPTY.

HEY, HE SAID.

RON PRESSED A TINY SILVER BUTTON IN THE DASHBOARD. THE CAR AROUND THEM

VANISHED AND SO DID THEY. HARRY COULD FEEL THE SEAT VIBRATING BENEATH

HIM, HEAR THE ENGINE, FEEL HIS HANDS IN HIS KNEES AND HIS GLASSES IN HIS

NECK, BUT FOR ALL HE COULD SEE, HE HAD BECOME A PAIR OF EYEBALLS, FLOATING A

FEW FEET ABOVE THE GROUND IN A DINGY STREET FULL OF PARKED CARS.

LET S GO, SAID RON S VOICE FROM HIS RIGHT.

AND THE GRHLND AND THE DIRTY KLILBINGS HEN EITHER SIDE FELL AWAY,
DREPPING BLT HF SIGHT AS THE CAR RESE; IN SECONDS, THE WHEEL HF
LHNDEN LAY,

SMEDY AND GLITTERING, KEELN THEM.

THEN THERE WAS A PEEPPING NEISE AND THE CAR, HARRY, AND REN
REAPPEARED,

LE-HH, SAID REN, LAKING AT THE INVISIBILITY REESTER. IT S PALITY

KEITH HF THEM PLUMPELLED IT. THE CAR VANISHED, THEN IT FLICKERED BACK
AGAIN,

H-HH H-H; REN YELLED, AND HE SLAMPED HIS FEET HEN THE ACCELERATHER;
THEY

SEHT STRAIGHT INTEH THE WEL, WHEELY CLELDS AND EVERYTHING TURNED
BLK AND

PEGGY,

WHEN WHAT? SAID HARRY, BLINKING AT THE SEHID MASS HF CLELD
PRESSING IN

HEN THEM FROM ALL SIDES,

WE NEED TEH SEE THE TRAIN TEH KNEL WHAT DIRECTION TEH GE IN, SAID
REN,

DIP BACK DEELN AGAIN ELWICKLY

THEY DREPPED BACK BENEATH THE CLELDS AND TWISTED AROUND IN THEIR
SEATS,

SEHLINTING AT THE GRHLND,

I CAN SEE IT; HARRY YELLED, RIGHT AHEAD THERE;

THE HEGHARTS EXPRESS WAS STREAKING ALONG KEELN THEM LIKE A
SCARLET

SNAKE.

BLUE NORTH, SAID REIN, CHECKING THE COMPASS AND THE DASH-BOARD,
HARD,

WE MUST HAVE THE CHECK AND IT EVERY HALF HOUR AND SEE HOLD AND

AND THEY SET UP THROUGH THE CLOUDS. A MINUTE LATER, THEY BURST
OUT INTO

A BLAZE OF SUNLIGHT.

IT WAS A DIFFERENT WORLD. THE WHEELS OF THE CAR SKIMMED THE SEA OF
FLUFFY

CLOUD, THE SKY A BRIGHT, ENDLESS BLUE UNDER THE BLINDING WHITE SUN.

ALL WE VE GOT THE WHIRRY ABOUT NOW ARE AIRPLANES, SAID REIN.

THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER AND STARTED THE LAUGH; FOR A LONG TIME,
THEY

COULDN'T STOP.

IT WAS AS THOUGH THEY HAD BEEN PLUNGED INTO A FAIRYLAND DREAM.
THIS,

THEIR LIGHT FLARE, WAS SURELY THE ONLY WAY THE TRAVEL FAST SWIRLS
AND TWIRLS

OF SNEEZY CLOUD, IN A CAR FULL OF HOT, BRIGHT SUNLIGHT, WITH A FAT
PACK OF

THEIRS IN THE GLOVE COMPARTMENT, AND THE PROSPECT OF SEEING
FRED AND

GEORGE'S IRISH FACES WHEN THEY LANDED SMOOTHLY AND
SPECTACULARLY IN

THE SWEEPING LAWN IN FRONT OF HOGWARTS CASTLE.

THEY MADE REGULAR CHECKS IN THE TRAIN AS THEY FLEW FARTHER AND
FARTHER

NORTH, EACH DIPPED BENEATH THE CLOUDS SHOWING THEM A DIFFERENT VIEW,
LONDON

WAS SEEN FAR BEHIND THEM, REPLACED BY NEAT GREEN FIELDS THAT GAVE WAY IN

TURN THE WIDE, PURPLISH MEERS, A GREAT CITY ALIVE WITH CARS LIKE MULTICOLORED

ANTS, VILLAGES WITH TINY TINY CHURCHES.

SEVERAL UNEXPECTED FEELERS LATER, HOWEVER, HARRY HAD TO ADMIT THAT SOME

OF THE FLIN WAS WEARING OFF, THE THEFTS HAD MADE THEM EXTREMELY THIRSTY

AND THEY HAD NOTHING TO DRINK. HE AND RENN HAD PULLED OFF THEIR SWEATERS,

BUT HARRY'S T-SHIRT WAS STICKING TO THE BACK OF HIS SEAT AND HIS GLASSES KEPT

SLIDING DOWN THE THE END OF HIS SWEATY NECK. HE HAD STOPPED NOTHING THE

FANTASTIC CHILD SHAPES NEAR AND WAS THINKING LONGINGLY OF THE TRAIN MILES

BELOW, WHERE THEY COULD BUY ICE-COLD PUMPKIN JUICE FROM A TRELLY PUSHER

BY A PLUMP WITCH. WHY HADN'T THEY BEEN ABLE TO GET FIFTEEN PLATFORM NINE AND

THREE-QUARTERS?

CAN'T BE MUCH FURTHER, CAN IT? CREAMED RENN, FEELERS LATER STILL, AS THE

SLIN STARTED TO SINK INTO THEIR FLESH OF CLOTH, STAINING IT A DEEP PINK. READY

FOR ANOTHER CHECK ON THE TRAIN?

IT WAS STILL RIGHT BELOW THEM, WINDING ITS WAY PAST A SNELCAPPED MOUNTAIN. IT WAS MUCH DARKER BENEATH THE CANOPY OF CLOTHS.

RENN PUT HIS FEET ON THE ACCELERATOR AND DROVE THEM UPWARD AGAIN, BUT AS

HE DID SEE, THE ENGINE BEGAN THE WHINE.

HARRY AND RON EXCHANGED NERVOUS GLANCES.

IT'S PROBABLY JUST TIRED, SAID RON. IT'S NEVER BEEN THIS FAR BEFORE. . . .

AND THEY BOTH PRETENDED NOT TO NOTICE THE WHINING GROWLING
BEHIND AND

BEHIND AS THE SKY BECAME STEADILY DARKER. STARS WERE GLEAMING IN
THE

DARKNESS. HARRY PULLED HIS SWEATER BACK ON, TRYING TO IGNORE THE
WAY THE

WINDSHIELD WIPERS WERE NOW WAVING FREELY, AS THOUGH IN PROTEST.

NOT FAR, SAID RON, MORE THAN THE CAR THAN THE HARRY, NOT FAR
NOW, AND HE

PATTED THE DASHBOARD NERVOUSLY.

WHEN THEY FLEW BACK BENEATH THE CLOUDS A LITTLE WHILE LATER, THEY
HAD THE

SHLINT THROUGH THE DARKNESS FOR A LANDMARK THEY KNEW.

THERE! HARRY SHOUTED, MAKING RON AND HERMION JUMP. STRAIGHT
AHEAD!

SILHOUETTED IN THE DARK HORIZON, HIGH IN THE CLIFF OVER THE LAKE,
STOOD

THE MANY TOWERS AND TOWERS OF HOGWARTS CASTLE.

BUT THE CAR HAD BEGUN TO SLIP AND WAS LOSING SPEED.

COME ON, RON SAID CALMLY, GIVING THE STEERING WHEEL A LITTLE
SHAKE.

NEARLY THERE, CAME ON

THE ENGINE GRIEDED. DARKENED ITS OWN STEAM WERE ISSUING FROM
UNDER THE

HEARD, HARRY FELT HIMSELF GRIPPING THE EDGES OF HIS SEAT VERY HARD AS THEY

WENT TOWARD THE LAKE.

THE CAR GAVE A NASTY WHEEZE. GLANCING LEFT OF HIS WINDSHIELD, HARRY SAW THE

SMOOTH, BLACK, GLASSY SURFACE OF THE WATER, A MILE BEHIND. THEN S

WERE WHITE ON THE STEERING WHEEL. THE CAR WHEELED AGAIN.

COME ON, THEN MUTTERED.

THEY WERE OVER THE LAKE THE CASTLE WAS RIGHT AHEAD THEN PLAT HIS

FEET DOWN.

THERE WAS A WHILD CLUNK, A SPOLLTER, AND THE ENGINE DIED COMPLETELY.

WHEN, SAID THEN, INTO THE SILENCE.

THE NOISE OF THE CAR DROPPED. THEY WERE FALLING, GATHERING SPEED, HEADING STRAIGHT FOR THE SHED CASTLE WALL.

NNNNNNNNN! THEN YELLED, SWINGING THE STEERING WHEEL AROUND; THEY

MISSSED THE DARK STONE WALL BY INCHES AS THE CAR TURNED IN A GREAT ARC,

SHARING OVER THE DARK GREEN HILLS, THEN THE VEGETABLE PATCH, AND THEN HLT

OVER THE BLACK LAWS, LBSING ALTITUDE ALL THE TIME.

THEN LET GO OF THE STEERING WHEEL COMPLETELY AND PULLED HIS HAND LEFT OF

HIS BACK POCKET

STEED! STEED! HE YELLED, LEAVING THE DASH-BOARD AND THE WINDSHIELD,

BUT THEY WERE STILL PLUMMETING, THE GRIELIND FLYING UP TOWARD THEM

WATTS FELT FEEL THAT TREE! HARRY BELLEVED, LUNGING FOR THE

STEERING WHEEL, BUT TOO LATE

CRASH.

WITH AN EARSPLITTING BANG OF METAL ON WOOD, THEY HIT THE THICK TREE TRUNK

AND DROPPED THE GRIELIND WITH A HEAVY THUD. STEAM WAS RISING FROM

UNDER THE CRUMPLED HOOD; FREDWIG WAS SHRIEKING IN TERROR; A GOLF-BALL-

SIZED LUMP WAS THROBBING ON HARRY'S HEAD WHERE HE HAD HIT THE

WINDSHIELD; AND THEN HIS RIGHT, RON LET OUT A WAIL, DESPAIRING CRIAN.

ARE YOU OKAY? HARRY SAID URGENTLY.

MY WAND, SAID RON, IN A SHAKY VOICE. LOOK AT MY WAND

IT HAD SNAPPED, ALMOST IN TWO; THE TIP WAS DANGLING LIMPLY, HELD ON BY A

FEW SPLINTERS.

HARRY OPENED HIS MOUTH TO SAY HE WAS SURE THEY'D BE ABLE TO MEND IT UP

AT THE SCHEEL, BUT HE NEVER EVEN GOT STARTED. AT THAT VERY MOMENT, SOMETHING HIT HIS SIDE OF THE CAR WITH THE FORCE OF A CHARGING BULL, SENDING

HIM LURCHING SIDEWAYS INTO RON, JUST AS AN ENORMOUSLY HEAVY BLEN HIT THE REAR.

WHAT'S HAPPEN ?

RENN GASPED, STARING THROUGH THE WINDSHIELD, AND HARRY LEECHES
AROUND

JUST IN TIME TO SEE A BRANCH AS THICK AS A PYTHON SMASH INTO IT,
THE TREE

THEY HAD HIT WAS ATTACKING THEM. ITS TRUNK WAS BENT ALMOST
DOUBLE, AND ITS

CHARRED BULGERS WERE PLUMMETING EVERY INCH OF THE CAR IT COULD
REACH.

SAATCHI? SAID RENN AS ANOTHER TWISTED LIMB PUNCHED A LARGE DENT
INTO

HIS DECK. THE WINDSHIELD WAS NOW TREMLING UNDER A HAIL OF BLENDS
FROM

BRULCHER-LIKE TWIGS AND A BRANCH AS THICK AS A BATTERING RAM WAS
PEELING

FLIRTELISLY FROM THE REAR, WHICH SEEMED TO BE LAYING

DOWN FOR IT? RENN SCHELTED, THROWING HIS FULL WEIGHT AGAINST HIS
DECK, BUT

NEXT SECOND HE HAD BEEN KNUCKLED BACKWARD INTO HARRY'S LAP BY A
VICIOUS

UPPERCUT FROM ANOTHER BRANCH.

WE'RE DONE FOR? HE MEEANED AS THE CEILING SAGGED, BUT SLIDENLY THE
FLOOR OF THE CAR WAS VIBRATING THE ENGINE HAD RESTARTED,

REVERSE? HARRY YELLED, AND THE CAR SHOT BACKWARD. THE TREE WAS
STILL

TRYING TO HIT THEM. THEY COULD HEAR ITS TIRES CREAKING AS IT
ALMOST RIPPED

ITSELF UP, LASHING OUT AT THEM AS THEY SPED OUT OF REACH.

THAT, PANTED RENN, WAS CLOSE. WELL DONE, CAR

THE CAR, HOWEVER, HAD REACHED THE END OF ITS TETHER, WITH TWO SHARP

CLUNKS, THE DOORS FLEW OPEN AND HARRY FELT HIS SEAT TIP SIDEWAYS: NEXT

THING HE KNEW HE WAS SPRAWLED ON THE DAMP GRASS, LEHD THUDS TOLD HIM

THAT THE CAR WAS EJECTING THEIR LUGGAGE FROM THE TRUNK: FREDNIE'S BAG FLEW

THROUGH THE AIR AND BURST OPEN; SHE ROSE HLIT UP IT WITH AN ANGRY SCREECH AND

SPED OFF TOWARD THE CASTLE WITHOUT A BACKWARD LOOK. THEN, DENTED, SCRATCHED, AND STEAMING, THE CAR RUMBLLED OFF INTO THE DARKNESS, ITS REAR

LIGHTS BLAZING ANGRILY.

COME BACK! BEEN YELLED AFTER IT, BRANDISHING HIS CRACKEN WAND, DAD LI

KILL ME!

BUT THE CAR DISAPPEARED FROM VIEW WITH ONE LAST SNORT FROM ITS EXHAUST,

CAN YOU BELIEVE HOW LUCKY? SAID BEEN MISERABLY, BENDING DOWN THE PICK

UP STAIRS, IF ALL THE TREES WE COULD VE HIT, WE HAD THE GET ONE THAT HITS

BACK,

HE GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER AT THE ANCIENT TREE, WHICH WAS STILL FLAILING

ITS BRANCHES THREATENINGLY,

COME ON, SAID HARRY WEARILY, WE'D BETTER GET UP THE THE SCALES...

,

IT WASN'T AT ALL THE TRIUMPHANT ARRIVAL THEY HAD PICTURED. STIFF,
COLD, AND

GRIMED, THEY SEIZED THE ENDS OF THEIR TRUNKS AND BEGAN DRAGGING
THEM UP

THE GRASSY SLOPE, TOWARD THE GREAT HALL FRONT DOORS.

I THINK THE FEAST IS ALREADY STARTED, SAID RON, DRIPPING HIS
TRUNK AT THE

FEET OF THE FRONT STEPS AND CREEPING QUIETLY TO LEAVE THROUGH A
BRIGHTLY LIT

WINDOW. THEY HARRY CAME AND LEAVE IT'S THE STARTING!

HARRY HURRIED OVER AND, TOGETHER, HE AND RON PEERED IN AT THE
GREAT HALL.

INNUMERABLE CANDLES WERE FLICKERING IN MIDAIR OVER THEIR HEADS,
ILLUMINATED

TABLES, MAKING THE GOLDEN PLATES AND CHILDS SPARKLE. EVERYWHERE,
THE

GLITTERING CEILING, WHICH ALWAYS MIMICRED THE SKY OUTSIDE, SPARKLED
WITH

STARS.

THROUGH THE FOREST OF POINTED BLACK HOGWARTS HATS, HARRY SAW A
LINE

LINE OF STARTLED-LOOKING FIRST YEARS FILING INTO THE HALL. GINNY WAS
AMONG

THEM, EASILY VISIBLE BECAUSE OF HER VIVID REDDISH HAIR. MEANWHILE,
PROFESSOR McGONAGALL, A RESPECTABLE WITCH WITH HER HAIR IN A
TIGHT BUN,

WAS PLACING THE FAMOUS HOGWARTS STARTING HAT ON A STEEL SHELVE
THE

NEWCOMERS.

EVERY YEAR, THIS AGED OLD HAT, PATCHED, FRAYED, AND DIRTY, SORTED NEW

STUDENTS INTO THE FOUR HOUSES (Gryffindor, Hufflepuff, Ravenclaw, and Slytherin). Harry well remembered putting it on, exactly

ONE YEAR AGO, AND WAITING, PETRIFIED, FOR ITS DECISION AS IT MUTTERED ALOUD IN

HIS EAR, FOR A FEW HORRIBLE SECONDS HE HAD FEARED THAT THE HAT WAS CHOOSING THE

PUT HIM IN SLYTHERIN, THE HOUSE THAT HAD TURNED OUT MORE DARK WITCHES AND

WIZARDS THAN ANY OTHER BUT HE HAD ENDED UP IN GRYFFINDOR, ALONG WITH

RON, HERMION, AND THE REST OF THE WEASLEYS. LAST TERM, HARRY AND RON

HAD HELPED GRYFFINDOR WIN THE HOUSE CHAMPIONSHIP, BEATING SLYTHERIN FOR

THE FIRST TIME IN SEVEN YEARS.

A VERY SMALL, MEELY-FAIRED BOY HAD BEEN CALLED FORWARD TO PLACE THE

HAT ON HIS HEAD. HARRY'S EYES WANDERED PAST HIM TO WHERE PROFESSOR

DUMBLEDORE, THE HEADMASTER, SAT WATCHING THE SEATING FROM THE STAFF TABLE,

HIS LONG SILVER BEARD AND HALF-MOON GLASSES SHINING BRIGHTLY IN THE

CANDLELIGHT. SEVERAL SEATS ALONG, HARRY SAW GILBERT LECHEART, DRESSED IN

ROBES OF AMBARIAN, AND THERE AT THE END WAS HAGRID, FILGY AND HARRY,

DRINKING DEEPLY FROM HIS GUGLET.

HANG ON . . . HARRY MUTTERED THE REIN. THERE S AN EMPTY CHAIR
AT THE

STAFF TABLE. . . . WHERE S SNAPE?

PROFESSOR SEVERUS SNAPE WAS HARRY S LEAST FAVORITE TEACHER.
HARRY ALSO

HAPPENED THE RE SNAPE S LEAST FAVORITE STUDENT. COLD, SARCASTIC, AND
DISLIKED

BY EVERYBODY EXCEPT THE STUDENTS FROM HIS OWN HOUSE (SLOTHERIN),
SNAPE

TALIGHT PETTENS.

MAYBE HE S ILL? SAID REIN ENTHUSIASTICALLY.

MAYBE HE S LEFT, SAID HARRY, BECAUSE HE MISSED HIM IN THE
DEFENSE

AGAINST THE DARK ARTS THE AGAIN?

HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN SACRED? SAID REIN ENTHUSIASTICALLY. I
MEAN,

EVERYONE HATES HIM

HE MAYBE, SAID A VERY CHILD VOICE RIGHT BEHIND THEM. HE S WAITING
THE

HEAR WHY WHY THE DIDN T ARRIVE IN THE SCHOOL TRAIN.

HARRY SPUN AROUND. THERE, HIS BLACK CLOAKS RIPPLING IN A COLD
BREEZE,

STOOD SEVERUS SNAPE. HE WAS A THIN MAN WITH PALE SKIN, A
THIN NECK,

AND GREASY, SHOULDER-LENGTH BLACK HAIR, AND AT THIS MOMENT, HE WAS
SMILING

IN A WAY THAT TOLD HARRY HE AND REIN WERE IN VERY DEEP TROUBLE.

WELL, SAID SNAPE.

NEED DARING EVEN THE LOOK AT EACH OTHER, HARRY AND REIN FELLED
SNAPE LIP

THE STEPS INTO THE VAST, ECHOING ENTRANCE HALL, WHICH WAS LIT WITH
FLAMING

THIRDS, A DELICIOUS SMELL OF MEAT WAS WAITING FROM THE GREAT
HALL, BUT

SNAPE LED THEM AWAY FROM THE WARMTH AND LIGHT, DOWN A NARROW
STONE

STAIRCASE THAT LED INTO THE DUNGEONS.

IN HE SAID, OPENING A DARK PASSAGE DOWN THE CHILD PASSAGEWAY
AND

POINTING.

THEY ENTERED SNAPE'S OFFICE, SHIVERING. THE SHADELESS WALLS WERE
LINED

WITH SHELVES OF LARGE GLASS JARS, IN WHICH FLOATED ALL MANNER OF
REVOLTING

THINGS. HARRY DIDN'T REALLY WANT TO KNOW THE NAME OF AT THE
MOMENT. THE

FIREPLACE WAS DARK AND EMPTY. SNAPE CLOSED THE DOOR AND TURNED THE
HEAD AT

THEM.

SEE, HE SAID SEFTLY, THE TRAIN ISN'T GOOD ENOUGH FOR THE FAMOUS
HARRY

POTTER AND HIS FAITHFUL SIDEKICK WEASLEY. WANTED TO ARRIVE WITH A
BANG, DID

WE, KIDS?

NO, SIR, IT WAS THE BARRIER AT KING'S CROSS, IT

SILENCE! SAID SNAPE COLDLY. WHAT HAVE YOU BEEN WITH THE CAR?
BEN CLIPED. THIS WASN'T THE FIRST TIME SNAPE HAD GIVEN HARRY
THE

IMPRESSION OF BEING ABLE TO READ MINDS, BUT A MOMENT LATER, HE

UNDERSTOOD, AS SNAPE UNFOLDED TODAY'S ISSUE OF THE EVENING
PROPHET.

THEY WERE SEEN, HE HISSED, STEERING THEM THE HEADLINE: FLYING
FLEET

ANGELIA MYSTIFIES MUGGLES, HE BEGAN TO READ ALOUD: THE
MUGGLES

IN LONDON, CONVINCED THEY SAW AN OLD CAR FLYING OVER THE POST
OFFICE

TELEPHONER . . . AT NINE IN DORSET, MRS. BETTY RADLIS, WHILE HANGING
UP HER

WASHING . . . MR. ANGUS FLEET, OF PERKES, REPORTED TO POLICE . . . SIX
HIS

SEVEN MUGGLES IN ALL, I BELIEVE THEIR FATHER WROTE IN THE MISUSE OF
MUGGLE

ARTIFACTS OFFICE? HE SAID, LEANING UP AT REIN AND SMILING STILL
MORE

NASTILY. DEAR, DEAR . . . HIS EYES SHIN . . .

HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE HAD JUST BEEN KICKED IN THE STOMACH BY
ONE OF

THE MAD TREE'S LARGER BRANCHES. IF ANYONE FELT THAT MR. WEASLEY
HAD

BELITCHED THE CAR . . . HE HADN'T THOUGHT OF THAT. . . .

I REMEMBERED, IN MY SEARCH OF THE PARK, THAT CONSIDERABLE DAMAGE
SEEMS TO

HAVE BEEN DONE TO A VERY VALUABLE WHIPPING WILLOW. SNAPE
WENT ON.

THAT TREE DID MORE DAMAGE TO US THAN WE REIN ALLIED HIM.

SILENCE? SNAPPED SNAPE AGAIN. MUST UNFORTUNATELY, THEY ARE
NOT IN MY

HOUSE AND THE DECISION TO EXPEL THEM DOES NOT REST WITH ME. I SHALL
GO AND

FETCH THE PEOPLE WHO DO HAVE THAT HAPPY POWER, SHE'LL WAIT
HERE.

HARRY AND RON STARED AT EACH OTHER, WHITE-FACED. HARRY DIDN'T FEEL
HUNGRY ANYMORE. HE NOW FELT EXTREMELY SICK. HE TRIED NOT TO LOOK
AT A

LARGE, SLIMY SOMETHING SLIDDED IN GREEN LIGHTS AND A SHELF BEHIND
SNAPE'S DESK. IF SNAPE HAD GONE TO THE FETCH PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL,
HEAD OF

GRYFFINDOR HOUSE, THEY WERE HARDLY ANY BETTER OFF. SHE MIGHT BE
FAIRER

THAN SNAPE, BUT SHE WAS STILL EXTREMELY STRICT.

TEN MINUTES LATER, SNAPE RETURNED, AND SURE ENOUGH IT WAS
PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL WHO ACCOMPANIED HIM. HARRY HAD SEEN PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL

ANGRY ON SEVERAL OCCASIONS, BUT EITHER HE HAD FORGOTTEN JUST HOW
THIN HER

NEETH CHILD GO, OR HE HAD NEVER SEEN HER THIS ANGRY BEFORE. SHE
RAISED HER

WAND THE MOMENT SHE ENTERED. HARRY AND RON BOTH FLINCHED, BUT
SHE

MERELY POINTED IT AT THE EMPTY FIREPLACE, WHERE FLAMES SUDDENLY
ERUPTED.

SIT, SHE SAID, AND THEY BOTH RACED INTO CHAIRS BY THE FIRE.

EXPLAIN, SHE SAID, HER GLASSES GLINTING HARMONIOUSLY.

RON LAUNCHED INTO THE STORY, STARTING WITH THE BARRIER AT THE
STATION

REFUSING TO LET THEM THROUGH.

SEE WE HAD NO CHOICE, PROFESSOR, WE COULDN'T GET ON THE TRAIN.

WHY DIDN'T YOU SEND US A LETTER BY HELL? I BELIEVE YOU HAVE AN HELL?

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SAID COLDLY TO HARRY,

HARRY GAZED AT HER, WHEN SHE SAID IT, THAT SEEMED THE HEAVENLY THING THE

HAVE BEEN.

I I DIDN'T THINK

THAT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, IS HEAVENLY.

THERE WAS A DINNER IN THE HALL DINNER AND SNACK, WHEN LOOKING HAPPIER

THAN EVER, OPENED IT, THERE STOOD THE HEADMASTER, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE.

HARRY'S LITTLE BODY WENT NINE. DUMBLEDORE WAS LOOKING UNUSUALLY GRAY. HE STARED DOWN HIS VERY CRINKLED NECK AT THEM, AND HARRY SUDDENLY

FOUND HIMSELF WISHING HE AND RON WERE STILL BEING BEATEN UP BY THE

WHIPPING WILLIE.

THERE WAS A LONG SILENCE. THEN DUMBLEDORE SAID, PLEASE EXPLAIN WHY

YOU DID THIS.

IT WOULD HAVE BEEN BETTER IF HE HAD SHELLED, HARRY HATED THE DISAPPOINTMENT IN HIS VOICE. FOR SOME REASON, HE WAS UNABLE TO

DUMBLEDORE IN THE EYES, AND SPARE INSTEAD TO HIS DUNKS. HE TOLD DUMBLEDORE EVERYTHING EXCEPT THAT MR. WEASLEY OWNED THE BOWTIE CAR,

MAKING IT SEEM AS THOUGH HE AND RON HAD HAPPENED TO FIND A FLYING CAR

PARKED OUTSIDE THE STATION. HE KNEW DUMBLEDOORE WOULD SEE
THROUGH THIS AT

HENCE, BUT DUMBLEDOORE ASKED ONE QUESTION ABOUT THE CAR, WHEN
HARRY HAD

FINISHED, HE MERELY CONTINUED TO PEER AT THEM THROUGH HIS
SPECTACLES.

WE'LL GO AND GET OUR STUFF, SAID RON IN A FEEBLESS SHOUT OF VIOLENCE.

WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT, WEASLEY? BARKED PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL.

WELL, YOU'RE EXPELLING US, AREN'T YOU? SAID RON.

HARRY LOOKED QUICKLY AT DUMBLEDOORE.

NOT TODAY, MR. WEASLEY, SAID DUMBLEDOORE. BUT I MUST IMPRESS
UPON

YOU THE SERIOUSNESS OF WHAT YOU HAVE DONE. I WILL BE
WRITING THE

OTHER YOUR FAMILIES TONIGHT. I MUST ALSO WARN YOU THAT IF YOU DO
ANYTHING

LIKE THIS AGAIN, I WILL HAVE NO CHOICE BUT TO EXPEL YOU.

SNAPPE LOOKED AS THOUGH CHRISTMAS HAD BEEN CANCELLED. HE CLEARED
HIS

THROAT AND SAID, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDOORE, THESE BOYS HAVE ABUSED THE

DECREE FOR THE RESTRICTION OF LINGERAGE WIZARDRY, CAUSED SERIOUS
DAMAGE

THE AN OLD AND VALUABLE TREE. SURELY ACTS OF THIS NATURE

IT WILL BE FOR PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TO DECIDE ON THESE BOYS

PUNISHMENTS, SEVERUS, SAID DUMBLEDOORE CALMLY. THEY ARE IN HER
HANDS

AND ARE THEREFORE HER RESPONSIBILITY. HE TURNED TO PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL.

I MUST GO BACK TO THE FEAST, MINERVA, I'VE GOT TO GIVE HER A FEW
NOTICES.

CHEER, SEVERUS, THERE'S A DELICIOUS-LOOKING CUSTARD TART I WANT THE
SAMPLE

SNAPE SEETH A LITTLE OF PURE VENOM AT HARRY AND RON AS HE
ALIGNED

HIMSELF TO BE SWEPT UP BY HIS OFFICE, LEAVING THEM ALONE WITH
PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL, WHO WAS STILL DYING THEM LIKE A WRATHFUL EAGLE.

YOU'D BETTER GET ALONG TO THE HOSPITAL WING, WEASLEY, YOU'RE
BLEEDING.

NOT MUCH, SAID RON, HASTILY WIPING THE CLUT OVER HIS EYE WITH
HIS

SLEEVE. PROFESSOR, I WANTED TO WATCH MY SISTER BEING SHIRTED

THE SHIRTING CEREMONY IS OVER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.
YOU'VE

SISTER IS ALSO IN GRYFFINDOR.

OH, GOOD, SAID RON.

AND SPEAKING OF GRYFFINDOR PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SAID
SHARPLY,

CLUT HARRY CLUT IN: PROFESSOR, WHEN WE THREW THE CAR, TERM HADN'T
STARTED, SHE

SHE GRYFFINDOR SHOULD'N'T REALLY HAVE POINTS TAKEN FROM IT
SHOULD IT?

HE FINISHED, WATCHING HER ANXIOUSLY.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL GAVE HIM A PIERCING LOOK, BUT HE WAS SURE
SHE

HAD ALMOST SMILED. HER MOUTH LOOKED LESS THAN, ANYWAY.

I WILL NOT TAKE ANY POINTS FROM GRYPFINDER, SHE SAID, AND
HARRY'S HEART

LIGHTENED CONSIDERABLY, BUT YET WILL BOTH GET A DETENTION.

IT WAS BETTER THAN HARRY HAD EXPECTED, AS THE DUMBLEDORE'S
WRITING THE

THE DURSLEYS, THAT WAS NOTHING, HARRY KNEW PERFECTLY WELL THEY'D
JUST BE

DISAPPOINTED THAT THE WHIPPING WILLIE HADN'T SHLASHED HIM
FLAT.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL RAISED HER HAND AGAIN AND POINTED IT AT
SNAPE'S

DESK, A LARGE PLATE OF SANDWICHES, TWO SILVER CUPLETS, AND A ILG OF
ICE

PLUMPKIN ILICE APPEARED WITH A PEEP.

YET WILL EAT IN HERE AND THEN GO STRAIGHT UP THE YELLY
DORMITORY, SHE

SAID, I MUST ALSO RETURN THE THE PEAST.

WHEN THE DEER HAD CLOSED BEHIND HER, REIN LET OUT A LONG, LOW
WHISTLE.

I THOUGHT WE'D HAD IT, HE SAID, GRABbing A SANDWICH.

SHE DID I, SAID HARRY, TAKING ONE, THEN.

CAN YET BELIEVE HER LICK, THOUGHT? SAID REIN THICKLY THROUGH A
MOUTHFUL OF CHICKEN AND HAM. FRED AND GEORGE MUST VE BEEN
THAT CAR

FIVE OR SIX TIMES AND NEH MUGGLE EVER SAW THEM. HE SWALLOWED AND
THEN

ANOTHER FLICE RITE. WHY COULDN'T WE GET THROUGH THE BARRIER?

HARRY SPOLICED, WE'LL HAVE THE WATCH HER STEP FROM NEH EN,
THOUGHT, HE

SAID, TAKING A GRATEFUL SWIG OF PUMPKIN JUICE. WISH WE COULD VE
GONE UP

THE FEAST, . . .

SHE DIDN'T WANT US SEEING HER, SAID PENELOPE. DOESN'T WANT
PEOPLE THING IT'S CLEVER, ARRIVING BY FLYING CAR.

WHEN THEY HAD EATEN AS MANY SANDWICHES AS THEY COULD THE PLATE
KEPT

REFILLING ITSELF, THEY ROSE AND LEFT THE HALL, TREADING THE FAMILIAR
PATH THE

GRYFFINDOR TOWER. THE CASTLE WAS QUIET; IT SEEMED THAT THE FEAST
WAS OVER.

THEY WALKED PAST MURDERING PORTRAITS AND CREAKING SLITS OF
ARMOR, AND

CLIMBED NARROW FLIGHTS OF STONE STAIRS, UNTIL AT LAST THEY REACHED
THE

PASSAGE WHERE THE SECRET ENTRANCE TO GRYFFINDOR TOWER WAS
HIDDEN, BEHIND

AN OIL PAINTING OF A VERY FAT WOMAN IN A PINK SILK DRESS.

PASSWORD? SHE SAID AS THEY APPROACHED.

ER SAID HARRY.

THEY DIDN'T KNOW THE NEW YEAR'S PASSWORD, NOT HAVING MET A
GRYFFINDOR

PREFECT YET, BUT HELP CAME ALMOST IMMEDIATELY; THEY HEARD FLURRYING
FEET

BEHIND THEM AND TURNED TO SEE HERMION DASHING TOWARD THEM.

THERE YOU ARE! WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN? THE MOST RIDICULOUS
RUMORS

SOMEONE SAID YOU'D BEEN EXPELLED FOR CRASHING A FLYING CAR

WELL, WE HAVEN'T BEEN EXPELLED, HARRY ASSURED HER.

YOU'RE NOT TELLING ME YOU DID FLY HERE? SAID HERMION, SEEMING

ALMOST AS SEVERE AS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

SKIP THE LECTURE, SAID RON IMPATIENTLY, AND TELL US THE NEW
PASSWORD.

IT'S WATTLEBIRD, SAID HERMIONE IMPATIENTLY, BUT THAT'S NOT THE
PHINT

HER WORDS WERE CUT SHORT, HOWEVER, AS THE PORTRAIT OF THE FAT LADY
SWUNG

OPEN AND THERE WAS A SUDDEN STORM OF CLAPPING. IT LOOKED AS
THOUGH THE

WHEEL OF GRYFFINDOR HOUSE WAS STILL AWAKE, PULSED INTO THE
CIRCULAR

COMMON ROOM, STANDING ON THE UPSIDE TABLES AND SEELASHY
ARMCHAIRS,

WAITING FOR THEM TO ARRIVE. ARMS REACHED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT
LIKE THE PULL

HARRY AND RON INSIDE, LEAVING HERMIONE TO SCRAMBLE IN AFTER
THEM.

BRILLIANT! YELLED LEE JORDAN. INSPIRED! WHAT AN ENTRANCE!
FLYING A

CAR RIGHT INTO THE WHUMPING WILHELM, PEOPLE WERE TALKING ABOUT
THAT ONE

FIVE YEARS

GOOD FOR YOU, SAID A FIFTH YEAR HARRY HAD NEVER SPENDEN THE
SOMETHING

WAS PATTING HIM ON THE BACK AS THOUGH HE'D JUST WON A
MARATHON; FRED AND

GEORGE POLISHED THEIR WAY TO THE FRONT OF THE CROWD AND SAID
TOGETHER, WHY

CHILDREN TALKED TO THEM IN THE CAR, BUT REHN WAS SCARLET IN THE FACE,
GRINNING

EMBARRASSEDLY, BUT HARRY COULD SEE HOW PERSONALLY HE DIDN'T SEEM
HAPPY AT

ALL. PERCY WAS VISIBLE OVER THE HEADS OF SOME EXCITED FIRST YEARS,
AND HE

SEEMED TO BE TRYING TO GET NEAR ENOUGH TO START TELLING THEM HOW,
HARRY

NUDGED REHN IN THE RIBS AND NODDED IN PERCY'S DIRECTION. REHN GOT
THE POINT

AT ONCE.

GET THE GET UPSTAIRS KIT TIED, HE SAID, AND THE TWO OF THEM
STARTED

PUSHING THEIR WAY TOWARD THE DEER IN THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ROOM,
WHICH LED

TO A SPIRAL STAIRCASE AND THE HERMITAGES.

NIGHT, HARRY CALLED BACK THE HERMION, WHO WAS WEARING A
SCHOOL ILST

LIKE PERCY'S.

THEY MANAGED TO GET TO THE OTHER SIDE OF THE COMMON ROOM, STILL
HAVING

THEIR BACKS SLAPPED, AND GAINED THE PEACE OF THE STAIRCASE. THEY
FLURRIED UP

IT, RIGHT TO THE TOP, AND AT LAST REACHED THE DEER OF THEIR OLD
HERMITAGE,

WHICH NOW HAD A SIGN IN IT SAYING SECOND YEARS. THEY ENTERED
THE

FAMILIAR, CIRCULAR ROOM, WITH ITS FIVE FLOOR-POSTERS HUNG WITH RED
VELVET AND

ITS HIGH, NARROW WINDOWS. THEIR TRUNKS HAD BEEN BRILLIANT UP FOR
THEM AND

STOOD AT THE ENDS OF THEIR SEES,

REN GRINNED GUILTILY AT HARRY,

I KNOW I SHOULDNT VE KNOWNED THAT FOR ANYTHING, BUT

THE HERMITAGE DOOR FLEW OPEN AND IN CAME THE ENTIRE SECOND YEAR
GRYFFINDOR SEES, SEAMUS FINNIGAN, DEAN THOMAS, AND NEVILLE
LONGBOTTOM.

UNBELIEVABLE! KEAMED SEAMUS,

HELL, SAID DEAN,

AMAZING, SAID NEVILLE, AWESTRUCK,

HARRY COULDNT HELP IT, HE GRINNED, THEN,

T

CHAPTER SIX

GILDEROYS WEEK-END

THE NEXT DAY, HOWEVER, HARRY BARELY GRINNED SINCE, THINGS STARTED
THE

THE DELICIOUS FROM BREAKFAST IN THE GREAT HALL, THE FEELING BEING
FEELING

TABLES WERE LADEN WITH TURRETS OF PIERRIDGE, PLATES OF DIPPER,
MOUNTAINS OF

MEAT, AND DISHES OF EGGS AND BACON, BENEATH THE ENCHANTED CEILING
(THE DAY, A

BLISS, MELISSA GRAY), HARRY AND REN SAT DOWN AT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE
NEXT THE

HERMIONE, WHO HAD HER COPY OF VOYAGES WITH VAMPIRES PREPARED
HAPPEN

AGAINST A MILK ICE. THERE WAS A SLIGHT STIFFNESS IN THE WAY SHE
SAID

MORNING, WHICH TOLD HARRY THAT SHE WAS STILL DISAPPROVING OF
THE WAY

THEY HAD ARRIVED. NEVILLE LONGBOTT, ON THE OTHER HAND, GREETED
THEM

CHEERFULLY. NEVILLE WAS A REDDISH-FACED AND ACCIDENT-PRONE BOY WITH
THE

Worst MEMORY OF ANYONE HARRY HAD EVER MET.

MAIL IS BLUE AND MINUTE I THINK GRAN IS SENDING A FEW THINGS I
FORGET.

HARRY HAD ONLY JUST STARTED HIS PERTRIDGE WHEN, SUDDENLY,
THERE WAS A

RUSSIAN SHIELD OVERHEAD AND A HUNDRED OR SO EGGS STREAMED IN,
CIRCLING THE

HALL AND DROPPING LETTERS AND PACKAGES INTO THE CHATTERING CREEK.
A BIG,

LIMPY PACKAGE BOUNCED OFF NEVILLE'S HEAD AND, A SECOND LATER,
SOMETHING

LARGE AND GRAY FELL INTO HERMIONE'S ICE, SPRAYING THEM ALL WITH
MILK AND

FEATHERS.

KRUEL! SAID RON, PULLING THE REDRAGGLED HELL HELT BY THE FEET. KRUEL
SLUMPED, LUNCHESLIPS, HONTER THE TABLE, HIS LEGS IN THE AIR AND A
DAMP RED

ENVELOPE IN HIS GRASP.

HI, NE RON GASPED.

IT'S ALL RIGHT, HE'S STILL ALIVE, SAID FERMINE, PRESSING CAROL GENTLY

WITH THE TIP OF HER FINGER.

IT'S NOT THAT IT'S THAT.

REN WAS POINTING AT THE RED ENVELOPE. IT LOOKED WHITE ORDINARY TO HARRY,

BUT REN AND NEVILLE WERE BOTH LOOKING AT IT AS THOUGH THEY EXPECTED IT TO

EXPLODE.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? SAID HARRY.

SHE'S SHE'S SENT ME A LETTER, SAID REN FAINTLY.

YOU'D BETTER OPEN IT, REN, SAID NEVILLE IN A TIMID WHISPER. IT LL BE

WORSER IF YOU DON'T. MY GRAN SENT ME ONE ONCE, AND I IGNORED IT AND HE

GLIMPED IT WAS TERRIBLE.

HARRY LOOKED FROM THEIR PETRIFIED FACES TO THE RED ENVELOPE.

WHAT'S A LETTER? HE SAID.

BUT REN'S WHOLE ATTENTION WAS FIXED ON THE LETTER, WHICH HAD BEGUN TO

SMOKE AT THE CORNERS.

OPEN IT, NEVILLE URGED. IT LL ALL BE OVER IN A FEW MINUTES

REN STRETCHED OUT A SHAKING HAND, LASED THE ENVELOPE FROM CAROL'S REACH,

AND SLIT IT OPEN. NEVILLE STUFFED HIS FINGERS IN HIS EARS. A SPLIT SECOND LATER,

HARRY KNEW WHY. HE THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT IT HAD EXPLODED; A REAR OF

SHEDD FILLED THE HUGER HALL, SHAKING DUST FROM THE CEILING.

STRAILING THE CAR, I WOULDN'T HAVE BEEN
SURPRISED IF

THEY'D EXPLODED YET, YET WAIT TILL I GET HEED OF
YET, I

DIDN'T SLIPPER YET STEPPED THE THING WHAT YET
FATHER AND

I WENT THROUGH WHEN WE SAW IT WAS GONE

MRS. WEASLEY'S YET, A HUNDRED TIMES LARGER THAN USUAL, MADE THE
PLATES

AND SPINNERS RATTLE ON THE TABLE, AND RATTLED DEAFENINGLY OFF THE
STONE WALLS.

PEOPLE THROUGHOUT THE HALL WERE SWIVELING AROUND TO SEE WHO
HAD RECEIVED

THE HELLER, AND THEN SANDY SEE HIM IN HIS CHAIR THAT ONLY HIS
CRIMSON

THREE-HEAD CHILD BE SEEN.

LETTER FROM DUMBLEDORE LAST NIGHT, I THOUGHT
YET

FATHER WOULD DIE OF STROKE, WE DIDN'T BRING YET UP
THE

BEHAVE LIKE THIS, YET AND HARRY CHILD BOTH HAVE
DIED

HARRY HAD BEEN WANDERING WHEN HIS NAME WAS GOING TO CREEP UP.
HE

TRIED VERY HARD TO BREATHE AS THOUGH HE COULDN'T HEAR THE VOICE THAT
WAS

MAKING HIS CARDINALS THERE.

ABSOLUTELY DISGUSTED YET FATHER'S FACING
AND

INQUIRY AT LENGTH, IT'S ENTIRELY YOUR FAULT AND IF
YOU'LL PLS

ANOTHER THE END OF LINE WE'LL BRING YOU
STRAIGHT BACK

HEMP.

A RINGING SILENCE FELL. THE RED ENVELOPE, WHICH HAD DROPPED FROM
RON'S

HAND, BURST INTO FLAMES AND CLINKED INTO ASHES. HARRY AND RON SAT
STUNNED.

AS THOUGH A TIDAL WAVE HAD JUST PASSED OVER THEM, A FEW PEOPLE
LAUGHED

AND, GRADUALLY, A BATTLE OF TALK BROKE OUT AGAIN.

HERMIONIE CLOSED HER EYES WITH VAMPIRES AND LINED DOWN AT THE
TOP OF

RON'S HEAD.

WELL, I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT YOU EXPECTED, RON, BUT YOU

DIDN'T TELL ME I DESERVED IT, SNAPPED RON.

HARRY PUSHED HIS CHAIR BACK AWAY. HIS INSIDES WERE BURNING WITH
GUILT.

MR. WEASLEY WAS FACING AN INQUIRY AT LENGTH. AFTER ALL MR. AND
MRS. WEASLEY

HAD BEEN FOR HIM OVER THE SUMMER...

BUT HE HAD NO TIME TO DWELL ON THIS; PROFESSOR McGONAGALL WAS
MOVING

ALONG THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE, HANDING OUT CHURCH SCHEDULES. HARRY
THREW HIS

AND SAW THAT THEY HAD DEALER HERMIONIE WITH THE FLIPPERPLAYS
FIRST.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE LEFT THE CASTLE TOGETHER, CROSSED THE
VEGETABLE

PATCH, AND MADE FOR THE GREEN-HOUSES, WHERE THE MAGICAL PLANTS
WERE KEPT.

AT LEAST THE FELLOW HAD DONE ONE GOOD THING: HERMIONIE SEEMED TO
THINK

THEY HAD NOW BEEN PUNISHED ENOUGH AND WAS BEING PERFECTLY
FRIENDLY

AGAIN.

AS THEY NEARED THE GREEN-HOUSES THEY SAW THE REST OF THE CLASS
STANDING

ELTISE, WAITING FOR PROFESSOR SPRUIT. HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE
HAD ONLY

JUST THOUGHT THEM WHEN SHE CAME STRIDING INTO VIEW ACROSS THE
LAWN.

ACCOMPANIED BY GILBERT LEECHART, PROFESSOR SPRUIT'S ARMS WERE
FULL OF

BANDAGES, AND WITH ANOTHER TWINGE OF GUILT, HARRY SPOTTED THE
LIMPPING

WILLOW IN THE DISTANCE, SEVERAL OF ITS BRANCHES NOW IN SLINGS.

PROFESSOR SPRUIT WAS A SHEET-LITTLE WITCH WHO WORE A PATCHED
HAT EVER

HER ALWAYS-FAIR; THERE WAS USUALLY A LARGE AMPLANT OF EARTH-ON
HER CLOTHES

AND HER FINGERNAILS WOULD HAVE MADE ALINT PETUNIA PAINT.
GILBERT

LEECHART, HOWEVER, WAS IMMACULATE IN SLIPPING SHOES OF
TWINKLE-GLASS, HIS

GOLDEN HAIR SHINING UNDER A PERFECTLY PERFECTED TWINKLE-GLASS HAT
WITH GOLD

TRIMMING.

HEY, HELLO THERE? HE CALLED, BEAMING AROUND AT THE ASSEMBLED STUDENTS.

I'VE BEEN FOLLOWING PROFESSOR SPREHLT THE RIGHT WAY THE OTHER A WHIMPERING

WILLIAM? BUT I DON'T WANT YOU RUNNING AWAY WITH THE IDEA THAT I'M BETTER AT

HERMINE? THAN SHE IS? I JUST HAPPEN TO HAVE MET SEVERAL OF THESE EXOTIC

PLANTS IN MY TRAVELS . . .

GREENHOUSE THREE TODAY, CHAPS? SAID PROFESSOR SPREHLT, WHO WAS

LOOKING DISTINCTLY DISORIENTED, NOT AT ALL HER USUAL CHEERFUL SELF.

THERE WAS A MURMUR OF INTEREST. THEY HAD ONLY EVER WORKED IN

GREENHOUSE ONE BEFORE GREENHOUSE THREE FELT FAR MORE INTERESTING

AND DANGEROUS PLANTS. PROFESSOR SPREHLT TOOK A LARGE KEY FROM HER BELT AND

UNLOCKED THE DOOR. HARRY CALLED A WHIFF OF DAMP EARTH AND FERTILIZER

MINGLING WITH THE HEAVY PERLIME OF SOME GIANT, UMBRELLA-SIZED FLOWERS

DANGLING FROM THE CEILING. HE WAS ABOUT TO FOLLOW RON AND HERMINE

INSIDE WHEN LUCIFART'S HAND STOPPED HIM.

HARRY? I'VE BEEN WANTING A WORD YOU DON'T MIND IF HE'S A CHIMP? OF

MINUTES LATE, OH YOU, PROFESSOR SPREHLT?

JUDGING BY PROFESSOR SPREHLT'S SCHOOL, SHE DID MIND, BUT LUCIFART SAID,

THAT'S THE TICKET, AND CHESED THE GREEN-GLASS DINNER IN HER FACE.

HARRY, SAID LICKHART, HIS LARGE WHITE TEETH GLEAMING IN THE
SLDLIGHT AS

HE SHOOK HIS HEAD. HARRY, HARRY, HARRY.

COMPLETELY UNHAPPY, HARRY SAID NOTHING.

WHEN I HEARD WELL, HE CHURCH, IT WAS ALL MY FAULT, I WOULD HAVE
KICKED

MYSELF,

HARRY HAD NO IDEA WHAT HE WAS TALKING ABOUT. HE WAS ABOUT THE
SAY SEE

WHEN LICKHART WENT ON, THEN T DINNER WHEN I VE BEEN MORE
SHOCKED.

FLYING A CAR THE HIGHERS? WELL, HE CHURCH, I DINNER AT HOME WHY
WILL D DINNER

IT, STOOD OUT A MILE. HARRY, HARRY, HARRY.

IT WAS REMARKABLE THAT HE WOULD SEE EVERY ONE OF THESE BRILLIANT
TEETH

EVEN WHEN HE WASN'T TALKING.

GAVE WILL A TASTE FOR PUBLICITY, DIDN'T IT? SAID LICKHART. GAVE
WILL THE

ONE, WILL GET INTO THE FRONT PAGE OF THE PAPER WITH ME AND WILL
WILL DON'T

WAIT THE SEE IT AGAIN.

HE, NEH, PROFESSOR, SEE

HARRY, HARRY, HARRY, SAID LICKHART, REACHING OUT AND
GRASPING HIS

SHOULDER. I UNDERSTAND, NATURAL THE WANT A KIT MORE WHEN WILL VE
HAD THAT

FIRST TASTE AND I BLAME MYSELF FOR GIVING YOU THAT, BECAUSE IT WAS KILLING

THE GIVE THE OTHER HEAD BUT SEE HERE, YOUNG MAN, YOU CAN'T START FLYING CARS

THE TRY AND GET YOURSELF NOTICED. JUST CALM DOWN, ALL RIGHT? PLENTY OF TIME

FOR ALL THAT WHEN YOU'RE OLDER. YES, YES, I KNOW WHAT YOU'RE THINKING! IT'S

ALL RIGHT FOR HIM, HE'S AN INTERNATIONALLY FAMOUS WIZARD ALREADY! BUT WHEN

I WAS TWELVE, I WAS JUST AS MUCH OF A NEERDOY AS YOU ARE NOW. IN FACT, I'D

SAY I WAS EVEN MORE OF A NEERDOY! I MEAN, A FEW PEOPLE HAVE HEARD OF YOU,

HAVEN'T THEY? ALL THAT BUSINESS WITH THE WEE-MIST-DEET-RE-NAMED! HE

GLANCED AT THE LIGHTNING SCAR ON HARRY'S FOREHEAD. I KNOW, I KNOW IT'S

NOT WHITE AS GOOD AS WINNING WITCH WEEKLY'S MOST-CHARMING-SMILE AWARD

FIVE TIMES IN A ROW, AS I HAVE BUT IT'S A START, HARRY, IT'S A START,

HE GAVE HARRY A HEARTY WINK AND STRODE OFF, HARRY STEAD STUNNED FOR A

Few seconds, then, remembering he was supposed to be in the GREENHOUSE,

he opened the door and slid inside.

PROFESSOR SPRUIT WAS STANDING BEHIND A TRESTLE BENCH IN THE CENTER OF THE

GREENHOUSE, ABOUT TWENTY PAIRS OF DIFFERENT-COLOURED CLOTHES WERE LYING

ON THE BENCH, WHEN HARRY HAD TAKEN HIS PLACE BETWEEN RON AND HERMION,

SHE SAID, WE'LL BE REPETTING MANDRAGES TODAY, NOW, WHO CAN TELL ME THE

PROPERTIES OF THE MANDRAGE?

THE NOBODY'S SURPRISE, HERMION'S HAND WAS FIRST INTO THE AIR.

MANDRAGE, OR MANDRAGORA, IS A POWERFUL RESTORATIVE, SAID HERMION,

SOUNDING AS USUAL AS THOUGH SHE HAD SWALLOWED THE TEXTBOOK. IT IS USED TO

RETURN PEOPLE WHO HAVE BEEN TRANSFIGURED OR CURSED TO THEIR ORIGINAL STATE.

EXCELLENT, TEN POINTS TO GRYPFINDER, SAID PROFESSOR SPRENT, THE

MANDRAGE FORMS AN ESSENTIAL PART OF MOST ANTIDOTES. IT IS ALSO, HOWEVER,

DANGEROUS, WHO CAN TELL ME WHY?

HERMION'S HAND NARROWLY MISSED HARRY'S GLASSES AS IT SET UP AGAIN.

THE CRY OF THE MANDRAGE IS FATAL TO ANYONE WHO HEARS IT, SHE SAID

PROMPTLY.

PRECISELY, TAKE ANOTHER TEN POINTS, SAID PROFESSOR SPRENT, NOW, THE

MANDRAGES WE HAVE HERE ARE STILL VERY YOUNG.

SHE POINTED TO A ROW OF DEEP TRAYS AS SHE SPOKE, AND EVERYONE STILLED

FORWARD FOR A BETTER VIEW. A HUNDRED OR SO TWISTY LITTLE PLANTS, PURPLISH-GREEN

IN CHAIR, WERE GRIMING THERE IN REELS. THEY WHISKED ELITE
UNREMARKABLE THE

HARRY, WHO DIDN'T HAVE THE SLIGHTEST IDEA WHAT FERMINE MEANT BY
THE

CRY OF THE MANDRILL.

EVERYONE TOOK A PAIR OF EARMUFFS, SAID PROFESSOR SPRELL.

THERE WAS A SCRAMBLE AS EVERYONE TRIED TO SEIZE A PAIR THAT WASN'T
PINK

AND FLUFFY.

WHEN I TELL YOU THE PLAN THEM MEN, MAKE SURE YOUR EARS ARE
COMPLETELY

COVERED, SAID PROFESSOR SPRELL. WHEN IT IS SAFE TO REMOVE THEM,
I WILL

GIVE YOU THE THINKS-LIP, RIGHT EARMUFFS MEN.

HARRY SNAPPED THE EARMUFFS OVER HIS EARS. THEY SLIT HIM SELF
COMPLETELY. PROFESSOR SPRELL PUT THE PINK, FLUFFY PAIR OVER HER
OWN EARS.

ROLLED UP THE SLEEVES OF HER ROBES, GRASPED ONE OF THE TWISTY PLANTS
FIRMLY,

AND PULLED HARD.

HARRY LET HIM A GASP OF SURPRISE THAT NO ONE COULD HEAR.

INSTEAD OF ROARS, A SMALL, MILD, AND EXTREMELY LOW RAY PHEEPED
HIM

THE EARTH. THE LEAVES WERE GRIMING RIGHT HIM OF HIS HEAD. HE HAD
PALE

GREEN, MITTLED SKIN, AND WAS CLEARLY BAWLING AT THE TOP OF HIS
LUNGS.

PROFESSOR SPRELL THREW A LARGE PLANT POT FROM UNDER THE TABLE
AND PLUNGED

THE MANDRAKE INTO IT, KIDNAPING HIM IN DARK, DAMP CHEMPEST UNTIL
ONLY THE

TWISTED LEAVES WERE VISIBLE. PROFESSOR SPREHLT DLISTED OFF HER HANDS,
GAVE

THEM ALL THE TALKS-UP, AND REMOVED HER ELIN EAPPLIFFS.

AS ELIN MANDRAKES ARE ONLY SEEDLINGS, THEIR CRIES WEN T KILL YET,
SHE

SAID CALMLY AS THOUGH SHE D ILST DENE NOTHING MORE EXCITING THAN
WATER A

EGENIA. HOWEVER, THEY WILL DNEED YELI ELIT FOR SEVERAL FEELRS,
AND AS I M

SLRE DENE IF YELI WANT TE MISS YELIR FIRST DAY BACK, MAKE SLRE
YELIR

EAPPLIFFS ARE SECURELY IN PLACE WHILE YELI WHRE. I WILL ATTRACT YELIR
ATTENTION

WHEN IT IS TIME TE PACK UP.

FEELR TE A TRAY THERE IS A LARGE SUPPLY IF PETS HERE
CHEMPEST IN THE

SACKS EVER THERE AND RE CAREFUL IF THE VERMITHUS TENTACULA,
IT S

TEETHING.

SHE GAVE A SHARP SLAP TE A SPIKY, DARK RED PLANT AS SHE SPERE,
MAKING IT

DRAW IN THE LONG FEELERS THAT HAD BEEN INCHING SNEAKILY EVER HER
SEHLDER.

FARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE WERE IHINED AT THEIR TRAY BY A CLRLY-
HAIRD

FLAPPLIFF REY FARRY DNEW BY SIGHT ELIT HAD NEVER SPEDEN TE.

JUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHER, HE SAID BRIGTHLY, SHAKING FARRY BY THE
HAND.

DOWN WITH THEM ARE, OF COURSE, THE FAMILIES HARRY POTTER, . . . AND
THEY ARE

HERMIONE GRANGER ALWAYS THERE IN EVERYTHING HERMIONE
BEAMED AS SHE

HAD HER HAND SHAKEN THEM! AND BEEN WEASLEY, WASN'T THAT THEIR
FLYING
CART?

ROBIN DIDN'T SMILE. THE FLYER WAS HEVILISLY STILL IN HIS MIND.

THAT BUCKLEBART'S SOMETHING, ISN'T HEY? SAID ILUSTIN HAPPILY AS
THEY BEGAN

FILLING THEIR PLANT POTS WITH DRAGON BONE COMPOST. AWFULLY
BRAVE CHAP.

HAVE YOU READ HIS BOOKS? I'D HAVE DIED OF FEAR IF I'D BEEN CORNERED
IN A

TELEPHONE BOOTH BY A WEREWOLF, BUT HE STAYED CHEER AND ZAP
ILUST

FANTASTIC.

MY NAME WAS DOWN FOR THEM, YOU KNOW, I CAN'T TELL YOU HOW GLAD
I AM

I CAME HERE INSTEAD. OF COURSE, MOTHER WAS SLIGHTLY DISAPPOINTED,
BUT

SINCE I MADE HER READ BUCKLEBART'S BOOKS I THINK SHE'S BEGINNING TO SEE
THEM

USEFUL IT WILL BE THEY HAVE A FULLY TRAINED WIZARD IN THE FAMILY, . . .

AFTER THAT THEY DIDN'T HAVE MUCH CHANCE THE TALK. THEIR FAMILIES
WERE

BACK IN AND THEY NEEDED TO CONCENTRATE ON THE MANDRAGES.
PROFESSOR

SPOREBIT HAD MADE IT SEEM EXTREMELY EASY, BUT IT WASN'T. THE
MANDRAGES

DIDN'T LIKE CHIMPING OUT OF THE EARTH, BUT DIDN'T SEEM TO WANT THEM BACK IN THE

IT EITHER. THEY SQUELLED, KICKED, FLAILED THEIR SHARP LITTLE FISTS, AND GRASPED

THEIR TEETH. HARRY SPENT TEN WHOLE MINUTES TRYING TO SQUELCH A PARTICULARLY

FAT ONE INTO A PEEVY.

BY THE END OF THE CLASS, HARRY, LIKE EVERYONE ELSE, WAS SWEATY, ACHING,

AND COVERED IN EARTH. EVERYONE TRAIPSED BACK TO THE CASTLE FOR A HELD WASH

AND THEN THE GRYFFINDERS FLURRIED OFF TO TRANSFIGURATION.

PROFESSOR MCGRACALL'S CLASSES WERE ALWAYS HARD WORK, BUT TODAY WAS

ESPECIALLY DIFFICULT. EVERYTHING HARRY HAD LEARNED LAST YEAR SEEMED TO HAVE

LEAKED OUT OF HIS HEAD DURING THE SUMMER. HE WAS SLIPPED TO THE TURNING A

BEETLE INTO A BLOTTER, BUT ALL HE MANAGED TO DO WAS GIVE HIS BEETLE A LIFT OF

EXERCISE AS IT SCUTTLED OVER THE DESKTOP AVOIDING HIS HAND.

HEEN WAS HAVING FAR WORSE PROBLEMS. HE HAD PATCHED UP HIS HAND WITH

SOME KITCHENED SPELLTAPES, BUT IT SEEMED TO BE DAMAGED BEYOND REPAIR. IT

KEPT CRACKLING AND SPARKING AT THE MOMENTS, AND EVERY TIME HEEN TRIED TO

TRANSFIGURE HIS BEETLE IT ENVELOPED HIM IN THICK GRAY SMOKE THAT SMELLED OF

CRITTEN EGGS, UNABLE TO SEE WHAT HE WAS DOING, RON ACCIDENTALLY
SHOULDERED

HIS BEETLE WITH HIS ELBOW AND HAD TO ASK FOR A NEW ONE. PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL WASN'T PLEASED.

HARRY WAS RELIEVED TO HEAR THE LUNCH BELL. HIS BRAIN FELT LIKE A
WHEELING

SPRINGER. EVERYONE FILED OUT OF THE CLASSROOM EXCEPT HIM AND RON,
WHO WAS

WIPING HIS HAND FLURRIEDLY ON THE DESK.

STUPID USELESS THING

WRITE HOME FOR ANOTHER ONE. HARRY SUGGESTED AS THE WAND LET
OFF A

WHISPER OF RANGS LIKE A FIRECRACKER.

EH, YEAH, AND GET ANOTHER BELLER BACK, SAID RON, STOPPING THE
NEW

MISSING WAND INTO HIS BAG. IT SQUELLED AWAY AS THE WAND GOT
SNAPPED

THEY WENT DOWN THE LUNCH, WHERE RON'S MIND WAS NOT IMPROVED BY
HERMION'S SHOWING THEM THE HANDFUL OF PERFECT CHOCOLATES SHE
HAD

PRODUCED IN TRANSFIGURATION.

WHAT WE'VE GOT THIS AFTERNOON? SAID HARRY, HASTILY CHANGING
THE

SUBJECT.

DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, SAID HERMION AT ONCE.

WHY, DEMANDED RON, SEIZING HER SCHEDULE, HAVE YOU OUTLINED ALL
BLACKHART'S LESSONS IN LITTLE HEARTS?

HERMIONE SNATCHED THE SCHEDULE BACK, BUSHING FLURRIEDLY.

THEY FINISHED LUNCH AND WENT OUTSIDE INTO THE HYPERCAST
COURTYARD.

HERMIONE SAT BEHIND HER A STONE STEP AND CLUTTERED HER NECK IN
VEHAGES WITH

VAMPIRES AGAIN. HARRY AND RON STOOD TALKING ABOUT Hagrid's
FOR SEVERAL

MINUTES BEFORE HARRY BECAME AWARE THAT HE WAS BEING CLOSELY
WATCHED.

LOOKING UP, HE SAW THE VERY SMALL, MEELY-FAIRED BOY HE'D SEEN
TRYING HIM

THE SHIRTING HAT LAST NIGHT STARING AT HARRY AS THOUGH
TRANSFIXED. HE WAS

CLUTCHING WHAT LOOKED LIKE AN ORDINARY MUGGLE CAMERA, AND THE
MOMENT

HARRY LOOKED AT HIM, HE WENT BRIGHT RED.

ALL RIGHT, HARRY? I'M I'M LILLY CREEPER, HE SAID BREATHELESSLY,
TAKING A TENTATIVE STEP FORWARD. I'M IN Gryffindor, THEE'D BETTER
THINK

WOULD IT BE ALL RIGHT IF CAN I HAVE A PICTURE? HE SAID, RAISING
THE CAMERA

HEPPELWICK.

A PICTURE? HARRY REPEATED BLANKLY.

SEE I CAN PROVE I'VE MET YOU, SAID LILLY CREEPER EAGERLY, EDGING
FURTHER FORWARD. I KNOW ALL ABOUT YOU, EVERYTHING I TOLD ME, ABOUT
HIM

YOU SURVIVED WHEN YOU-KNEW-WHEN TRIED TO KILL YOU AND THEN HE
DISAPPEARED AND EVERYTHING AND THEN YOU'VE STILL GOT A LIGHTNING
SCAR ON

YOUR FOREHEAD (HIS EYES RACED HARRY'S HAIRLINE) AND A BOY IN MY

DERMITHY SAID IF I DEVELOPED THE FILM IN THE RIGHT POSITION, THE PICTURES W

MYE. CELIN DREW A GREAT SHLDDERING BREATH OF EXCITEMENT AND SAID, IT S

AMAZING HERE, ISN T IT? I NEVER DENEW ALL THE EDD STUFF I CELLD BE WAS MAGIC

TILL I GHT THE LETTER FROM F-HEGLARTS. MY DAD S A MILDMAN, HE CELLDN T

RELIEVE IT EITHER. SEE I M TAKING LEADS OF PICTURES TH SEND HOME TH HIM, AND

IT D BE REALLY GOOD IF I HAD ONE OF YELL HE LEMED IMPLYINGLY AT HARRY

MAYBE YELLR FRIEND CELLD TAKE IT AND I CELLD STAND NEXT THE YELL AND

THEN, CELLD YELL SIGN IT?

SIGNED P-ETTES? YELL RE GIVING HLT SIGNED P-ETTES, P-ETTER?

LELD AND SLATHING, DRACE MALPHY S VEHICLE RCHED AROUND THE CELRTYARD,

HE HAD STEPPED RIGHT BEHIND CELIN, FLANKED, AS HE ALWAYS WAS AT F-HEGLARTS,

BY HIS LARGE AND THUGGISH CRENIES, CRABBE AND GEDLE,

EVERYONE LING LIP! MALPHY REARED TH THE CRELD, HARRY P-ETTER S GIVING

HLT SIGNED P-ETTES?

NEE, I M NEET, SAID HARRY ANGERILY, HIS FISTS CLENCHING, SHLT LIP, MALPHY,

YELL RE ILST IEALHLS, PIPED LIP CELIN, WHISE ENTIRE BODY WAS ARLIT AS

THICK AS CRABBE S NECK,

LEASLEY? SAID MALPHY, WHEN DIDN'T NEED THE SHELTER ANYMORE! HALF
THE

CHURTYARD WAS LISTENING IN. HE WHAT? I DIDN'T WANT A FEEL SCAR
RIGHT ACROSS

MY HEAD, THANKS. I DIDN'T THINK GETTING YOUR HEAD CUT OPEN MAKES
YOU THAT

SPECIAL, MYSELF.

CRACK AND CRACK WERE SNIGGERING STUPIDLY.

RAT SLUGS, MALPHY, SAID BEEN ANGRILY. CRACK STEPPED LAUGHING
AND

STARTED RUBBING HIS KNUCKLES IN A MENACING WAY.

BE CAREFUL, LEASLEY, SNIGGERED MALPHY, YOU DIDN'T WANT THE START
AND

THINKING FOR YOUR MINDS LL HAVE THE CHANCE AND TAKE YOU AWAY FROM
SHELL.

HE PUT ON A SHILL, PIERCING VOICE. IF YOU PUT ANOTHER THE HLT
HE LINE

A DENT HE SLYTHERIN FIFTY YEARS NEARLY LAUGHED HEEDLY AT THIS.

LEASLEY WOULD LIKE A SIGNED PHEITH, PHTTER, SMIRKED MALPHY. IT D
BE

WORTH MORE THAN HIS FAMILY'S WORTH FEELER

THEN WHIPPED HLT HIS SPELLTAPED WARD, BUT FERMINEK SALT
VEVAGES WITH

VAMPIRES WITH A SNAP AND WHISPERED, LEMER HLT?

WHAT'S ALL THIS, WHAT'S ALL THIS? GILDERED LEMERHART WAS
STRIDING TOWARD

THEM, HIS TURRELHISE REEKS SWIRLING BEHIND HIM. WHEN'S GIVING HLT
SIGNED

PHEITHS?

HARRY STARTED THE SPEECH BUT HE WAS CUT SHORT AS LEECHHEART FILING AN ARM

ARMING HIS SHOULDERS AND THUNDERED HEAVILY, SHOULDN'T HAVE ASKED! WE

MEET AGAIN, HARRY!

PINNED THE LEECHHEART'S SIDE AND CLIPPING WITH HUMILIATION, HARRY SAW

MALPHEUS SLIDE SMIRKING BACK INTO THE CIRCLE,

THEY HAD THEN, MR. CREEVEY, SAID LEECHHEART, BEARING AT CHLIN. A DELICATE PORTRAIT, CAN'T DO BETTER THAN THAT, AND WE'LL BOTH SIGN IT FOR YOU.

CHLIN FLICKED FOR HIS CAMERA AND THREW THE PICTURE AS THE BELL RANG BEHIND THEM, SIGNALING THE START OF AFTERNOON CLASSES.

OFF YOU GO, MOVE ALONG THERE, LEECHHEART CALLED THE THE CIRCLE, AND HE

SET OFF BACK THE THE CASTLE WITH HARRY, WHO WAS WISHING HE KNEW A GOOD

VANISHING SPELL, STILL CLASPED THE HIS SIDE.

A WARD THE THE WISE, HARRY, SAID LEECHHEART PATERNALLY AS THEY ENTERED

THE BUILDING THROUGH A SIDE DOOR. I COVERED UP FOR YOU BACK THERE WITH

FEELING CREEVEY IF HE WAS PHOTOGRAPHING ME, THEN, YOUR SCHEMATES

WHEN I THINK YOU'RE SETTING YOURSELF UP SO MUCH...

DEAR THE HARRY'S STAMMERS, LEECHHEART SWEEP HIM DOWN A CORRIDOR LINED

WITH STARING STUDENTS AND UP A STAIRCASE.

LET ME JUST SAY THAT HANDING HLT SIGNED PICTURES AT THIS STAGE OF YOUR

CAREER ISN'T SENSIBLE LOOKS A TAD RIG-HEADED, HARRY, THE RE FRANK,
THERE

MAY WELL COME A TIME WHEN, LIKE ME, YOU'LL NEED THE DEEP & STABLE
HANDS

WHEREVER YOU GO, BUT HE GAVE A LITTLE CHERTLE I DON'T
THINK YOU'RE

ELITE THERE YET.

THEY HAD REACHED LOCKHART'S CLASSROOM AND HE LET HARRY GO AT
LAST.

HARRY YANDED HIS REINS STRAIGHT AND HEADED FOR A SEAT AT THE VERY
BACK OF

THE CLASS, WHERE HE ELISED HIMSELF WITH PILING ALL SEVEN OF
LOCKHART'S

BOOKS IN FRONT OF HIM, SO THAT HE COULD AVOID LOOKING AT THE REAL
THING.

THE REST OF THE CLASS CAME CLATTERING IN, AND REIN AND FERMINE
SAT DOWN

ON EITHER SIDE OF HARRY.

YOU COULD VE FIRED AN EGG IN YOUR FACE, SAID REIN. YOU'D BETTER
HIDE

CREEVEY DOESN'T MEET GINNY, OR THEY'LL BE STARTING A HARRY POTTER
FAN

CLUB.

SHUT UP, SNAPPED HARRY. THE LAST THING HE NEEDED WAS FOR
LOCKHART TO

HEAR THE PHRASE HARRY POTTER FAN CLUB.

WHEN THE WHOLE CLASS WAS SEATED, LOCKHART CLEARED HIS THROAT
LOUDLY AND

SILENCE FELL. HE REACHED FORWARD, PICKED UP NEVILLE LONGBOTT'S
COPY OF

TRAVELS WITH TRELLS, AND HELD IT UP TO SHOW HIS ELN, WINDING
PORTRAIT IN THE

PRESENT.

MR. HE SAID, POINTING AT IT AND WINDING AS WELL. GILDERHY
LEEDHART,

HERD OF MERLIN, THIRD CLASS, FIFTEENTH MEMBER OF THE DARK FORCE

DEFENSE LEAGUE, AND FIVE-TIME WINNER OF WITCH WEEKLY'S MOST-
CHARMING-

SMILE AWAY BUT I DIDN'T TALK ABOUT THAT, I DIDN'T GET RID OF THE
RANDOM

RANSOM BY SMILING AT HER?

HE WAITED FOR THEM TO LAUGH; A FEW PEOPLE SMILED WEARILY.

I SEE YOU'VE ALL RECEIVED A COMPLETE SET OF MY BOOKS WELL DONE, I
THOUGHT WE'D START TODAY WITH A LITTLE ELIZ, NOTHING TOO WHIRLY
ABOUT JUST

THE CHECK FILED WELL YOU'VE READ THEM, HOW MUCH YOU'VE TAKEN IN

WHEN HE HAD HANDLED OUT THE TEST PAPERS HE RETURNED TO THE FRONT
OF THE

CLASS AND SAID, YOU HAVE THIRTY MINUTES START NOW!

HARRY LEANED DOWN AT HIS PAPER AND READ:

1. WHAT IS GILDERHY LEEDHART'S FAVORITE COLOR?

2. WHAT IS GILDERHY LEEDHART'S SECRET AMBITION?

3. WHAT, IN YOUR OPINION, IS GILDERHY LEEDHART'S GREATEST
ACHIEVEMENT

THE DATE?

FIN AND FIN IT WENT, EVER THREE SIDES OF PAPER, RIGHT DOWN THE:

SA, WHEN IS GILBERT'S BIRTHDAY, AND WHAT WOULD HIS
IDEAL

GIFT BE?

HALF AN HOUR LATER, LEECHART COLLECTED THE PAPERS AND RIFLED
THROUGH

THEM IN FRONT OF THE CLASS.

TLT, TLT HARDLY ANY OF THEM REMEMBERED THAT MY FAVORITE COLOR
IS

BLUE. I SAY SEE IN YEAR WITH THE PETI, AND A FEW OF THEM NEED THE READ
WANDERINGS WITH WEREWOLVES MORE CAREFULLY I CLEARLY STATE IN
CHAPTER

TWELVE THAT MY IDEAL BIRTHDAY GIFT WOULD BE HARMONY BETWEEN ALL
MAGIC

AND NON-MAGIC PEOPLES THROUGH I WOULDN'T SAY SEE THE A LARGE
BOTTLE OF

EDEN'S OLD FIREWISKEY?

HE GAVE THEM ANOTHER REGLISH WINK, REEN WAS NOW STARING AT
LEECHART

WITH AN EXPRESSION OF DISBELIEF ON HIS FACE; SEAMUS FINNIGAN AND
DEAN

THOMAS, WHO WERE SITTING IN FRONT, WERE SHAKING WITH SILENT
LAUGHTER.

BERMINE, ON THE OTHER HAND, WAS LISTENING TO LEECHART WITH
RAPT ATTENTION

AND GAVE A START WHEN HE MENTIONED HER NAME.

... BUT MISS HERMION GRANGER KNEW MY SECRET AMBITION IS TO RID
THE

WORLD OF EVIL AND MARKET MY OWN RANGE OF HAIR-CARE PRODUCTS
GOOD GIRL?

IN FACT HE FLIPPED HER PAPER OVER ALL MARCHES? WHERE IS
MISS

HERMION GRANGER?

HERMION RAISED A TREMBLING HAND.

EXCELLENT? BEAMED LUCIFART. EXCELLENT? TAKE TEN PHOTOS
FOR

GRYFFINDOR? AND SEE THE BUSINESS

HE BENT DOWN BEHIND HIS DESK AND LIFTED A LARGE, COVERED CASE FROM
IT.

WELL HE WARNED? IT IS MY JOB THE ARMY WILL AGAINST THE FINEST
CREATURES KNOWN THE WIZARDING? YOU MAY FIND YOURSELVES FACING
YOUR

WORST FEARS IN THIS ROOM. KNOW ONLY THAT MY FARM CAN RECALL YOU
WHILE I

AM HERE. ALL I ASK IS THAT YOU REMAIN CALM.

IN SPITE OF HIMSELF, HARRY LEANED AROUND HIS PILE OF BOOKS FOR A
BETTER

LOOK AT THE CASE. LUCIFART PLACED A HAND ON THE COVER. DEAN AND
SEamus

HAD STOPPED LAUGHING WELL. NEVILLE WAS CHUCKLING IN HIS FRONT WHEEL
SEAT.

I MUST ASK YOU NOT THE SCREAM, SAID LUCIFART IN A LOW VOICE. IT
MIGHT

PURSUDE THEM.

AS THE WHOLE CLASS HELD ITS BREATH, LHECKHART WHIPPED OFF THE
CHEYER.

YES, HE SAID DRAMATICALLY, FRESHLY CAUGHT GHOULISH PIXIES,
SEAMUS FINNICAN CHILDRN T CENTREED HIMSELF, HE LET HEUT A SHORT OF
LAUGHTER

THAT EVEN LHECKHART CHILDRN T MISTAKE HER A SCREAM OF TERROR.

YES? HE SMILED AT SEAMUS.

WELL, THEY RE NEET THEY RE NEET VERY DANGEROUS, ARE THEY?
SEAMUS

CHUCKED.

DON T BE SO SURE? SAID LHECKHART, WAGGLING A FINGER ANNOYINGLY
AT

SEAMUS. DEVILISH TRICKY LITTLE BLIGHTERS THEY CAN BE?

THE PIXIES WERE ELECTRIC BLUE AND ABOUT EIGHT INCHES HIGH, WITH
PINKED

FASES AND WHICKS SHE SHRILL IT WAS LIKE LISTENING TH A LOT OF BLDGIES
ANGELINE.

THE MOMENT THE CHEYER HAD BEEN REMOVED, THEY HAD STARTED
JARRING AND

RECKETING AROUND, RATTLING THE EARS AND MAKING KIZARRR FACES AT
THE PEOPLE

NEAREST THEM.

RIGHT, THEN, LHECKHART SAID LULLABY, LET S SEE WHAT YOU MADE OF
THEM?

AND HE OPENED THE CAGE.

IT WAS PANDEMONIUM. THE PIXIES SHEET IN EVERY DIRECTION LIKE
RECKETS.

THEY H THEM SEIZED NEVILLE BY THE EARS AND LIFTED HIM INTO THE AIR.
SEVERAL

SHOT STRAIGHT THROUGH THE WINDOW, SHOWERING THE BACK ROW WITH
RIVEN

GLASS. THE REST PROCEEDED TO WRECK THE CLASSROOM MORE EFFECTIVELY
THAN A

RAMPAGING RHINO. THEY CRACKED INK BOTTLES AND SPRAYED THE CLASS
WITH

THEM, SHREDDED BOOKS AND PAPERS, THREW PICTURES FROM THE WALLS,
UPENDED

THE WASTEBASKET, CRACKED BAGS AND BOOKS AND THREW THEM OUT OF THE
SMASHED WINDOW; WITHIN MINUTES, HALF THE CLASS WAS SHELTERING
UNDER

DESKS AND NEVILLE WAS SWINGING FROM THE IRON CHANDELIER IN THE
CEILING.

COME ON NOW REELING THEM UP, REELING THEM UP, THEY'RE ONLY
PIXIES,

LOCKHART SMILED.

HE REELLED UP HIS SLEEVES, BRANDISHED HIS WAND, AND BELLEWD,
PESSIMISTI

PESTERMENT!

IT HAD ABSOLUTELY NO EFFECT; ONE OF THE PIXIES SEIZED HIS WAND AND
THREW

IT OUT OF THE WINDOW, THEN, LOCKHART CLIMBED AND DROVE UNDER HIS
ELDER DESK,

NARROWLY AVOIDING BEING SWASTICKED BY NEVILLE, WHO FELL A SECOND
LATER AS

THE CHANDELIER GAVE WAY.

THE BELL RANG AND THERE WAS A MAD RUSH TOWARD THE EXIT. IN THE
RELATIVE

CALM THAT FOLLOWED, LOCKHART STRAIGHTENED UP, TOOKT SIGHT OF
HARRY, THEN,

AND HERMINE, WHO WERE ALMOST AT THE DEER, AND SAID, WELL, I LL
ASK YOU

THAT THE ILST PUT THE REST OF THEM BACK INTO THEIR CAGE. HE SWEPT
PAST THEM

AND SHUT THE DEER QUICKLY BEHIND HIM.

CAN YOU BELIEVE HIM? HEARD BEEN AS ONE OF THE REMAINING PIXIES
KIT

HIM PAINFULLY IN THE EAR.

HE ILST WANTS TO GIVE US SOME HANDS-ON EXPERIENCE, SAID
HERMINE,

IMPRISONING TWO PIXIES AT ONCE WITH A CLEVER FREEZING CHARM AND
STUFFING THEM BACK INTO THEIR CAGE.

HANDS ON? SAID HARRY, WHO WAS TRYING TO GRAB A PIXIE DANCING
OUT OF

REACH WITH ITS TENGUE OUT. HERMINE, HE DIDN'T HAVE A CLUE WHAT
HE WAS

DOING

QUICKLY, SAID HERMINE. YOU VE READ HIS BOOKS WHEN AT ALL
THESE

AMAZING THINGS HE S DOING

HE SAYS HE S DOING, BEEN MUTTERED.

~

CHAPTER SEVEN

MIDWINTERS AND MIMMERS

HARRY SPENT A LOT OF TIME OVER THE NEXT FEW DAYS DECIDING WHAT HE
SIGHT

WHENEVER HE SAW GILBERT LICKHART CHIMING DOWN A CORRIDOR,
HARDER THE AVOID WAS CELIN CREEPY, WHO SEEMED TO HAVE MEMORIZED
HARRY'S SCHEDULE. NOTHING SEEMED TO GIVE CELIN A BIGGER THRILL
THAN THE SAY,

ALL RIGHT, HARRY? SIX OR SEVEN TIMES A DAY AND HEAR, TELL
CELIN, BACK,

HOWEVER EXASPERATED HARRY BECAME WHEN HE SAID IT,

HEDWIG WAS STILL ANGRY WITH HARRY ABOUT THE DISASTROUS CAR
INCIDENT AND

HERO'S HAND WAS STILL MALFUNCTIONING, SURPASSING ITSELF ON FRIDAY
MORNING

BY SHOOTING WHAT HE HERO'S HAND IN CHAIRS AND HITTING TINY OLD
PROFESSOR

FLITWICK SEEMEDLY BETWEEN THE EYES, CREATING A LARGE, THROBBING
GREEN HILL

WHERE IT HAD STRUCK. SHE WITH ONE THING AND ANOTHER, HARRY WAS
WHITE GLAD TO

REACH THE WEEKEND. HE, HERO, AND HERMIONE WERE PLANNING THE VISIT
HAGRID

ON SATURDAY MORNING, HARRY, HOWEVER, WAS SHAKEN AWAKE SEVERAL
HOURS

EARLIER THAN HE WOULD HAVE LIKED BY OLIVER WOOD, CAPTAIN OF THE
GRYFFINDOR QUIDDITCH TEAM,

WHAT MATTER? SAID HARRY GREGGILY,

QUIDDITCH PRACTICE? SAID WOOD, COME ON!

HARRY SHOOKED AT THE WINDOW. THERE WAS A THIN MIST HANGING
ACROSS THE

PINK-AND-GILD SKY, WHEN THAT HE WAS AWAKE, HE COULDN'T UNDERSTAND HOW HE

COULD HAVE SLEPT THROUGH THE RACKET THE BIRDS WERE MAKING.

HILVER, HARRY CREAMED. IT'S THE CRACK OF DAWN.

EXACTLY, SAID WHEED, HE WAS A TALL AND SLIMLY SIXTY-SEVEN YEAR OLD, AT THE

MOMENT, HIS EYES WERE GLAMING WITH A CRAZED ENTHUSIASM. IT'S PART OF

THEIR NEW TRAINING PROGRAM. COME ON, GRAB YOUR RIFLES, AND LET'S GO, SAID

WHEED HEARTILY. WHEN OF THE OTHER TEAMS HAVE STARTED TRAINING YET? WE'RE

GOING TO BE FIRST OF THE MARK THIS YEAR

SHAKING AND SHIVERING SLIGHTLY, HARRY CLIMBED OUT OF BED AND TRIED TO

FIND HIS SLIDBITCH RIFLES.

GOOD MAN, SAID WHEED. MEET WITH ME IN THE FIELD IN FIFTEEN MINUTES. WHEN HE'D FOUND HIS SCARLET TEAM RIFLES AND PULLED ON HIS LEAD COAT

WARMTH, HARRY SCRIBBLED A NOTE TO JOHN EXPLAINING WHERE HE'D GOING AND

WENT DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE TO THE CHAMBER ROOM, HIS NOSE TINGLING

THOUSANDS OF HIS SHOULDERS. HE HAD JUST REACHED THE PORTRAIT HALL WHEN THERE

WAS A CLATTER BEHIND HIM AND JOHN CREEVEY CAME DASHING DOWN THE SPIRAL

STAIRCASE, HIS CAMERA SWINGING MADLY AROUND HIS NECK AND SOMETHING

CLUTCHED IN HIS HAND.

I HEARD SOMEONE SAYING YOUR NAME IN THE STAIRS, HARRY? LEHED
WHAT I VE

GET HERE? I VE HAD IT DEVELOPED, I WANTED THE STILL YOU

HARRY LEHED REMISSLY AT THE PHOTOGRAPHY CELIN WAS BRANDISHING
UNDER

HIS NESE.

A MOVING, BLACK-AND-WHITE LEHEDART WAS TUGGING HARD IN AN ARM
HARRY

RECOGNIZED AS HIS OWN. HE WAS PLEASED TO SEE THAT HIS
PHOTOGRAPHIC SELF

WAS PUTTING UP A GOOD FIGHT AND REFUSING TO BE DRAGGED INTO THE VIEW,
AS HARRY

WATCHED, LEHEDART GAVE UP AND SLUMPED, PANTING, AGAINST THE
WHITE EDGE OF

THE PICTURE.

WILL YOU SIGN IT? SAID CELIN EAGERLY.

NO, SAID HARRY FLATLY, GLANCING AROUND THE CORNER THAT THE ROOM
WAS

REALLY DESERTED. SURELY, CELIN, I M IN A FLURRY ELIDITCH
PRACTICE

HE CLIMBED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT FRAME.

EH, WELL? WAIT FOR ME? I VE NEVER WATCHED A ELIDITCH GAME
BEFORE?

CELIN SCRAMBLED THROUGH THE FRAME AFTER HIM.

IT LL BE REALLY BERRING, HARRY SAID ELICELY, BUT CELIN IGNORED HIM,
HIS

FACE SHINING WITH EXCITEMENT.

YOU WERE THE YOUNGEST EELISE PLAYER IN A HUNDRED YEARS, WEREN T
YOU,

HARRY? WHEN T HEY? SAID LILIN, TRIPPING ALONGSIDE HIM. HEY
MUST BE

BRILLIANT, I VE NEVER SEEN. IS IT EASY? IS THAT HEY HEY HEY? IS
THAT THE

BEST ONE THERE IS?

HARRY DIDN T KNOW HEY THE GET RID OF HIM. IT WAS LIKE HAVING AN
EXTREMELY TALKATIVE SHADEN.

I DIDN T REALLY UNDERSTAND HEYBITCH, SAID LILIN BREATHELESSLY. IS
IT TRUE

THERE ARE HEY BILLS? AND THEN HEY THEM FLY AROUND TRYING THE OTHER
PEOPLE

HEY THEIR HEYBILLS?

YES, SAID HARRY HEAVILY, RESIGNED TO EXPLAINING THE COMPLICATED
RULES

HEY HEYBITCH. THEY RE CALLED BILDCERS. THERE ARE TWO BEATERS IN
EACH

TEAM WHICH CARRY CLUBS TO BEAT THE BILDCERS AWAY FROM THEIR SIDE.
FRED AND

GEORGE WEASLEY ARE THE GRYFFINDOR BEATERS.

AND WHAT ARE THE OTHER BILLS HEY? LILIN ASKED, TRIPPING DOWN A
CHURCH

HEY STEPS BECAUSE HE WAS GAZING OPEN-MOUTHED AT HARRY.

WELL, THE HEYBILLS THAT S THE BIGGEST RED ONE IS THE ONE THAT
SCORES

GOALS. THREE CHASERS IN EACH TEAM THROW THE HEYBILLS THE EACH
OTHER AND TRY

AND GET IT THROUGH THE GOALPOSTS AT THE END OF THE PITCH
THEY RE THREE

LONG POLES WITH HEYBILLS IN THE END.

AND THE TWELFTH BALL

IS THE GOLDEN SNITCH, SAID HARRY, AND IT'S VERY SMALL, VERY FAST, AND

DIFFICULT TO CATCH, BUT THAT'S WHAT THE SEEKER'S GOT TO DO, BECAUSE A GAME OF

QUIDDITCH DOESN'T END UNTIL THE SNITCH HAS BEEN CAUGHT, AND WHICHEVER

TEAM'S SEEKER GETS THE SNITCH EARNS HIS TEAM AN EXTRA HUNDRED AND FIFTY

POINTS.

AND WHO'RE THE GRYFFINDOR SEEKER, AREN'T THEY? SAID CELIN IN AWE.

YES, SAID HARRY AS THEY LEFT THE CASTLE AND STARTED ACROSS THE BURN-

BRENCHED GRASS, AND THERE'S THE KEEPER, THEN, HE GUARDS THE CHAMPIONS.

THAT'S IT, REALLY.

BUT CELIN DIDN'T STOP BELIEVING HARRY ALL THE WAY DOWN THE SLEEPING

LAWS THE THE HURDITCH FIELD, AND HARRY ONLY SEEN HIM OFF WHEN HE

REACHED THE CHANGING ROOMS; CELIN CALLED AFTER HIM IN A PIPING VOICE, I'LL

GO AND GET A GOOD SEAT, HARRY! AND HURRIED OFF TO THE STANDS.

THE REST OF THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM WERE ALREADY IN THE CHANGING ROOM.

WHO WAS THE ONLY PERSON WHO WISHED TRULY AWAY, FRED AND GEORGE

WEASLEY WERE SITTING, POLY-POYED AND THIRTY-THIRTY, NEXT THE THIRTY-THIRTY YEAR

ALICIA SPINNET, WHO SEEMED TO BE NODDING OFF AGAINST THE WALL BEHIND HER.

HER FELLOW CHASERS, RATTIE BELL AND ANGELINA JEFFERSON, WERE VALUING SIDE

BY SIDE OPPOSITE THEM.

THERE YELL ARE, HARRY, WHAT KEPT YELL? SAID WEND BRISKLY. WHEN, I

WANTED A HELIX TALK WITH YELL ALL BEFORE WE ACTUALLY GET INTO THE FIELD,

BECAUSE I SPENT THE SUMMER DEVISING A WHOLE NEW TRAINING PROGRAM, WHICH

I REALLY THINK WILL MAKE ALL THE DIFFERENCE. . . .

WEND WAS HOLDING UP A LARGE DIAGRAM OF A HILDBITCH FIELD, IN WHICH

WERE DRAWN MANY LINES, ARROWS, AND CROSSES IN DIFFERENT-COLOURED INKS, THE

THINK FELT HIS HAND, TAPPED THE BOARD, AND THE ARROWS BEGAN TO WIGGLE EVER

THE DIAGRAM LIKE CATERPILLARS. AS WEND LAUNCHED INTO A SPEECH ABOUT HIS

NEW TACTICS, FRED WEASLEY'S HEAD DROPPED RIGHT INTO ALICIA SPINNET'S

SHOULDER AND HE BEGAN TO SNEER.

THE FIRST BOARD THINK NEARLY TWENTY MINUTES TO EXPLAIN, BUT THERE WAS

ANOTHER BOARD UNDER THAT, AND A THIRD UNDER THAT ONE. HARRY SAND INTO A

STUPOR AS WEND DRENCH HIM AND HIM.

SHE SAID WENN, AT LENGTH LAST, PERDING FARRY FROM A WISTFUL
FANTASY ABOUT

WHAT HE COULD BE EATING FOR BREAKFAST AT THIS VERY MOMENT UP AT
THE CASTLE.

IS THAT CLEAR? AND ELDESTHENS?

I VE GOT A ELDESTHEN, ELIVER, SAID GEORGE, WHO HAD WOKEN WITH A
START.

WED CHILDEN T YEL HAVE TELD US ALL THIS YESTERDAY WHEN WE WERE
AWAKE?

WENN WASN T PLEASED.

WEL, LISTEN HERE, YEL LIT, HE SAID, GLENNING AT THEM ALL. WE
SHOULD

HAVE BEEN THE ELWIDITH CLIP LAST YEAR. WE RE EASILY THE BEST TEAM.
BUT

UNFORTUNATELY BEING THE CIRCUMSTANCES BEYOND OUR CONTROL
FARRY SHIFTED GUILTILY IN HIS SEAT. HE HAD BEEN LINCENSTHENS IN THE
HOSPITAL WING FOR THE FINAL MATCH OF THE PREVIOUS YEAR, MEANING
THAT

GRYFFINDOR HAD BEEN A PLAYER SHORT AND HAD SUFFERED THEIR WORST
DEFEAT IN

THREE HUNDRED YEARS.

WENN THREW A MOMENT TO REGAIN CONTROL OF HIMSELF. THEIR LAST
DEFEAT WAS

CLEARLY STILL TORTURING HIM.

SEE THIS YEAR, WE TRAIN HARDER THAN EVER BEFORE. . . . TODAY, LET US GO
AND PUT

OUR NEW THEORIES INTO PRACTICE! WENN SMILED, SEIZING HIS
BROOMSTICK AND

LEADING THE WAY OUT OF THE LOCKER ROOMS. STIFF-LEGGED AND STILL
YAWNING, HIS

TEAM APPEARED.

THEY HAD BEEN IN THE LOCKER ROOM SEEING THAT THE SUN WAS UP
COMPLETELY NEW, ALTHOUGH REMNANTS OF MIST FLOW OVER THE GRASS
IN THE

STADIUM. AS HARRY WALKED INTO THE FIELD, HE SAW RON AND
HERMIONIE SITTING

IN THE STANDS.

AREN'T YOU FINISHED YET? CALLED RON INCREDULOUSLY.

HAVEN'T EVEN STARTED, SAID HARRY, LEERING JEALOUSLY AT THE
THOAT AND

MARMALADE RON AND HERMIONIE HAD BRIGHTENED UP THE GREAT HALL.
WEND S

BEEN TEACHING HIS NEW MOVES.

HE PULLED HIS KNEEMASTER AND KICKED AT THE GROUND, SHARING UP
IN THE

THE AIR. THE COLD MORNING AIR WHIPPED HIS FACE, MAKING HIM FAR
MORE

EFFECTIVELY THAN WEND S HAD TALK. IT FELT WONDERFUL TO BE BACK IN
THE

SLUDGITCH FIELD. HE SHARED RIGHT AROUND THE STADIUM AT FULL SPEED,
RACING

FRED AND GEORGE.

WHAT'S THAT FLINDY CLIPPING NOISE? CALLED FRED AS THEY FLIRTED
AROUND

THE CORNER.

HARRY WHEEZED INTO THE STANDS. CELIN WAS SITTING IN ONE OF THE
HIGHEST

SEATS, HIS CAMERA RAISED, TAKING PICTURE AFTER PICTURE. THE SOUND
STRANGELY

MAGNIFIED IN THE DESERTED STADIUM.

WHEED THIS WAY, HARRY? THIS WAY? HE CRIED SCREAMING.

WHAT IS THAT? SAID FRED.

NEW IDEA, HARRY LIES, PUTTING HIM A SPURT OF SPEED THAT THREW HIM
AS FAR

AWAY AS POSSIBLE FROM CELIN.

WHAT IS GOING ON? SAID WHEED, PRELIMINING, AS HE SKIPPED THROUGH
THE AIR

THEYARD THEM. WHY IS THAT FIRST YEAR TAKING PICTURES? I DON'T LIKE
IT, HE

COULD BE A SLYTHERIN SPY, TRYING TO FIND OUT ABOUT THEIR NEW
TRAINING

PROGRAM.

HE IS IN GRYFFINDOR, SAID HARRY BOLDLY.

AND THE SLYTHERINS DON'T NEED A SPY, ELIVER, SAID GEORGE.

WHAT MAKES YOU SAY THAT? SAID WHEED TESTILY.

BECAUSE THEY'RE HERE IN PERSON, SAID GEORGE, POINTING.

SEVERAL PEOPLE IN GREEN ROBES WERE WALKING ABOUT THE FIELD,
BROOMSTICKS

IN THEIR HANDS.

I DON'T BELIEVE IT! WHEED HISSED IN OUTRAGE. I KNEWED THE FIELD FOR
TODAY! WE'LL SEE ABOUT THIS!

WHEED SHEET TOWARD THE GOALING, LANDING RATHER HARDER THAN HE
MEANT TO IN

HIS ANGER, STAGGERING SLIGHTLY AS HE DISMOUNTED, HARRY, FRED, AND
GEORGE

WHEELED.

FLINT: WEED BELIEVED AT THE SLYTHERIN CAPTAIN. THIS IS OUR PRACTICE

TIME! WE GET UP SPECIALLY! WE CAN CLEAR OFF NOW!

MARCUS FLINT WAS EVEN LARGER THAN WEED. HE HAD A LOOK OF TRELLISH

CLIPPING HIS FACE AS HE REPLIED, PLENTY OF ROOM FOR ALL OF US, WEED,

ANGELINA, ALICIA, AND KATIE HAD COME OVER, THEN, THERE WERE NEW GIRLS

THE SLYTHERIN TEAM, WITH STEADY SHOULDER TO SHOULDER, FACING THE GRYPFINDERS, LEAVING THE A MAN,

BUT I REMEMBERED THE FIELD! SAID WEED, POSITIVELY SPITTING WITH RAGE. I

REMEMBERED IT!

AH, SAID FLINT, BUT I'VE GOT A SPECIALLY SIGNED NOTE HERE FROM PROFESSOR SNAPE. I, PROFESSOR S. SNAPE, GIVE THE SLYTHERIN TEAM PERMISSION

THE PRACTICE TODAY IN THE HOLLIDITCH FIELD BEING THE THE NEED THE TRAIN THEIR

NEW SPOKER,

WE'VE GOT A NEW SPOKER? SAID WEED, DISTRACTED, WHERE?

AND FROM BEHIND THE SIX LARGE FIGURES BEHIND THEM CAME A SEVENTH, SMALLER ONE, SMIRKING ALL OVER HIS PALE, PAINTED FACE. IT WAS DRACH MALFOY.

AREN'T YOU LILLY'S MALFOY'S SON? SAID FRED, LEERING AT MALFOY WITH

DISLIKE.

FLINDY YOU SHOULD MENTION DRACH'S FATHER, SAID FLINT AS THE WHILE

SLOTHERIN TEAM SMILED STILL MORE BROADLY. LET ME SHOW YOU THE
GENERAL'S

GIFT HE'S MADE THE SLOTHERIN TEAM.

ALL SEVEN OF THEM HELD UP THEIR BROOMSTICKS, SEVEN HIGHLY
POLISHED,

BRAND-NEW HANDLES AND SEVEN SETS OF FINE GOLD LETTERING SPELLING
THE WORDS

NINKUS TWO THOUSAND AND FIVE CLEANED UNDER THE GRYFFINDERS
NESES IN

THE EARLY MORNING SUN.

VERY LATEST MODEL. ONLY CAME OUT LAST MONTH, SAID FLINT
CARELESSLY,

FLICKING A SPECK OF DUST FROM THE END OF HIS WAND. I BELIEVE IT
OUTSTRIPS THE

OLD TWO THOUSAND SERIES BY A CONSIDERABLE AMOUNT. AS FOR THE OLD
CLEANSWEEPS HE SMILED NAUGHTILY AT FRED AND GEORGE, WHO WERE
BOTH

CLUTCHING CLEANSWEEP FIVES SWEEPS THE BEARD WITH THEM.

NONE OF THE GRYFFINDER TEAM COULD THINK OF ANYTHING TO SAY FOR
A

MOMENT. MALFOY WAS SMIRKING SEE BROADLY HIS CHILD EYES WERE REDDED
THE

SLITS.

HE, THEN, SAID FLINT, A FIELD INVASION.

RON AND HERMIONE WERE CROSSING THE GRASS TO SEE WHAT WAS GOING
ON.

WHAT'S HAPPENING? RON ASKED HARRY. WHY AREN'T YOU
PLAYING? AND

WHAT'S HE DOING HERE?

HE WAS LEERING AT MALPHY, TAKING IN HIS SLOTHERIN FLUIDITCH
RINGS.

I'M THE NEW SLOTHERIN SEEKER, LEASLEY, SAID MALPHY, SMUGLY.
EVERYONE'S JUST BEEN ADMIRING THE KREEMS MY FATHER'S BELIEFT
HURL TEAM.

REIN GAZED, HYPNOMELTHED, AT THE SEVEN SLIPPER KREEMSTICKS IN
FRONT OF

HIM.

CHUD, AREN'T THEY? SAID MALPHY SMEEETLY. BUT PERHAPS THE
GRYFFINDOR

TEAM WILL BE ABLE TO RAISE SOME CHUD AND GET NEW KREEMS, THEN, YELL
CHUD

RAFFLE OFF THESE CLEANSWEEP FIVES; I EXPECT A MUSELYM WOULD BID FOR
THEM.

THE SLOTHERIN TEAM BOWLED WITH LAUGHTER.

AT LEAST NOW HERE ARE THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM HAD THE KEY THEIR WAY
IN, SAID

BERMINE SHARPLY. THEY GOT IN THE PURE TALENT.

THE SMILE BEHIND MALPHY'S FACE FLICKERED.

NOW HERE ASKED YELLER HYPNOMELTHED, YELL FIFTY LITTLE MUDBLOOD, HE SPAT.
HARRY KNEW AT ONCE THAT MALPHY HAD SAID SOMETHING REALLY BAD
BECAUSE

THERE WAS AN INSTANT LIPREAR AT HIS WORDS. FLINT HAD THE DIVE IN
FRONT OF

MALPHY THE STEEP FRED AND GEORGE LIMPING IN HIM, ALICIA SHRIEKED,
YELL

DARE YELL? , AND REIN PLUNGED HIS HAND INTO HIS RINGS, PULLED OUT
HIS HAND,

YELLING, YELL LL PAY FOR THAT ONE, MALPHY? AND POINTED IT
FLURIELLY UNDER

FLINT'S ARM AT MALPHY'S FACE.

A LOUD BANG ECHOED AROUND THE STADIUM AND A RED GREEN LIGHT
SHOT OUT

OF THE WRING END OF RICH'S HAND, HITTING HIM IN THE STOMACH AND
SENDING

HIM REELING BACKWARD INTO THE GRASS.

"RICH! RICH! ARE YOU ALL RIGHT?" SHOUTED HERMIONE.

RICH OPENED HIS MOUTH THE SPARK, BUT NO WORDS CAME OUT. INSTEAD
HE GAVE

AN ALMIGHTY BELCH AND SEVERAL SLUGS DRIPPED OUT OF HIS MOUTH
INTO HIS LAP.

THE SLYTHERIN TEAM WERE PARALYZED WITH LAUGHTER. FLINT WAS
DROPPED UP.

HANGING INTO HIS NEW KNEELING FOR SLIPPER, MALPHY WAS IN ALL
FEELS.

BANGING THE GROUND WITH HIS FIST. THE CRYSTALERS WERE GATHERED
AROUND

RICH, WHO KEPT BELCHING LARGE, GLISTENING SLUGS. NOBODY SEEMED TO
WANT TO

TALK TO HIM.

"WE'D BETTER GET HIM THE HAGRID'S, IT'S NEAREST," SAID HARRY TO
HERMIONE.

WHO NEEDED BRAVELY, AND THE PAIR OF THEM PULLED RICH UP BY THE
ARMS.

"WHAT HAPPENED, HARRY? WHAT HAPPENED? IS HE ILL? BUT YOU CAN
CLARE

HIM, CAN'T YOU?" LILLY HAD RUN DOWN FROM HIS SEAT AND WAS NOW
DARKING

ALONGSIDE THEM AS THEY LEFT THE FIELD, RICH GAVE A BIGGER HEAVE AND
MORE

SLICES DRIZZLED DOWN HIS FRONT.

HEHEH, SAID LELIN, FASCINATED AND RAISING HIS CAMERA. CAN YOU
HOLD

HIM STILL, HARRY?

GET OUT OF THE WAY, LELIN! SAID HARRY ANGRILY. HE AND HERMIONE
SLIPPERED DOWN OUT OF THE STAIRS AND ACROSS THE GRILINDS TOWARD
THE EDGE

OF THE FOREST.

NEARLY THERE, THEN, SAID HERMIONE AS THE CAMERAMAN & LELIN
CAME

INTO VIEW. YOU LL BE ALL RIGHT IN A MINUTE ALMOST THERE

THEY WERE WITHIN TWENTY FEET OF HAGRID & HEARD WHEN THE FRONT
DOOR

OPENED, BUT IT WASN'T HAGRID WHO EMERGED. GILDEROY LOCKHART,
WEARING

ROBES OF PALEST MALVE TINT, CAME STRIDING OUT.

HEARD, BEHIND HER, HARRY HISSED, DRAGGING THEN BEHIND A NEARBY
BUSH.

HERMIONE GULLED, SOMETWHAT RELUCTANTLY.

IT'S A SIMPLE MATTER IF YOU KNOW WHAT YOU'RE DOING! LOCKHART
WAS

SAYING BOLDLY TO HAGRID. IF YOU NEED HELP, YOU KNOW WHERE I AM!
I LL LET

YOU HAVE A COPY OF MY BOOK, I'M SURPRISED YOU HAVEN'T ALREADY
GOT ONE

I LL SIGN ONE TONIGHT AND SEND IT OVER. WELL, GOOD-BYE! AND HE
STRODE AWAY

TOWARD THE CASTLE.

ELARRY WAITED UNTIL LIECHART WAS OUT OF SIGHT, THEN PULLED RENN
OUT OF THE

ELISH AND UP THE ELACRID'S FRONT DOOR. THEY KNOCKED URGENTLY.

ELACRID APPEARED AT ONCE, LOOKING VERY GRIMLY, BUT HIS
EXPRESSION

BRIGHTENED WHEN HE SAW WHO IT WAS.

KIN WANDERING WHEN YOU'D COME TO SEE ME COME IN, COME IN
THELIGHT YOU MIGHTA KIN PROFESSOR LIECHART BACK AGAIN

ELARRY AND ERMINE SUPPORTED RENN OVER THE THRESHOLD INTO THE
HALL-

HEATED CLOSET, WHICH HAD AN ENORMOUS BED IN ONE CORNER, A FIRE
CRACKLING

MERRILY IN THE HEARTH. ELACRID DIDN'T SEEM PERTURBED BY RENN'S SLUG
PROBLEM,

WHICH ELARRY HASTILY EXPLAINED AS HE LED RENN INTO A CHAIR.

BETTER OUT THAN IN, HE SAID CHEERFULLY, PULLING A LARGE CHIFFON
BATHING

FRONT OF HIM. GET EM ALL UP, RENN.

I DON'T THINK THERE'S ANYTHING TO DO EXCEPT WAIT FOR IT THE STEP,
SAID

ERMINE ANXIOUSLY, WATCHING RENN KEND OVER THE BATHING. THAT'S
A DIFFICULT

CLOSE THE DOOR AT THE BEST OF TIMES, BUT WITH A SHAKEN HAND

ELACRID WAS BUSTLING AROUND MAKING THEM TEA. HIS SHAKEN HAND,
FANG, WAS

SHAKING OVER ELARRY.

WHAT DID LIECHART WANT WITH YOU, ELACRID? ELARRY ASKED,
SCRATCHING

PAGE 5 EARS.

GIVIN ME ADVICE HEN GETTIN BELPERS HLT HP A WELL, CRINKLED
FACRID,

MEEVING A HALF-PLUCKED REEHESTER HPF HIS STRICKED TABLE AND SETTING
DEHN THE

TEAPHT. LIKE I DEN DNEHL, AN RANGIN HEN ABHLT SEHE RANSH-EE HE
BANISHED, IF HNE WHRD HP IT WAS TRUE, I LL EAT MY BETTLE.

IT WAS MEET UNLIKE FACRID TH CRITILIZE A FHEGWARTS TEACHER, AND
FARRY

LEHED AT HIM IN SURPRISE, FHERMINE, FHEWYER, SAID IN A VHIKE
SEHEW-AT

HIGHER THAN USUAL, I THINK YHL RE BEING A KIT UNFAIR, PROFESSER
DUMKEDHERE

HEVTHLSY THEHIGHT HE WAS THE BEST MAN FHR THE IHE

HE WAS THE HEN Y MAN FHR THE IHE, SAID FACRID, HPPERING THEM A
PLATE HP

TREACLE THEPER, WHILE DEN CHLGHED SEHEPCHLY INTH HIS BASIN. AN I
MEAN

THE HEN Y HNE, GETTIN VERY DIFFILIT TER FIND ANYHNE FER THE DARK
ARTS IHE.

PEOPLE AREN T THEE BEEN TER TAKE IT HEN, SEE, THEY RE STARTIN TER
THIND IT S

IINKED, NHE HNE S LASTED LEHNG FER A WHILE NEHL, SHE TELL ME, SAID
FACRID,

IERKING HIS HEAD AT DEN, WHH WAS HE TRYIN TER CLRSE?

MALTHEY CALLED FHERMINE SEHEPETHING IT MLST VE BEEN REALLY BAD,
BEALISE EVERYHNE WENT WILD,

IT WAS BAD, SAID DEN FHEARSELY, EMERGING EVER THE TABLETHEP
LEHDKING PALE

AND SWEATY, MALPHY CALLED HER MILDREDD, FJAGRID

REIN DIVED INTO HIS SIGHT AGAIN AS A FRESH WAVE OF SLUGS MADE THEIR APPEARANCE, FJAGRID LOOKED ELTRAGED,

HE DIDN'T HE GRIELED AT FJERMINE,

HE DID, SHE SAID, BUT I DON'T KNOW WHAT IT MEANS, I COULD TELL IT WAS

REALLY RUDE, HE CHIRSE

IT'S ABOUT THE MOST INSULTING THING HE COULD THINK OF, GASTED REIN,

CHIMING BACK UP, MILDREDD IS A REALLY FOLLY NAME FOR SOMEONE WHO IS

MUGGLE-BORN WHO KNOWS, NON-MAGIC PARENTS, THERE ARE SOME WIZARDS

LIKE MALPHY'S FAMILY WHO THINK THEY'RE BETTER THAN EVERYONE ELSE

BECAUSE THEY'RE WHAT PEOPLE CALL PURE-BLOOD, HE GAVE A SMALL CLIP, AND A

SINGLE SLUG FELL INTO HIS ELTSTRETCHED HAND, HE THREW IT INTO THE BASIN AND

CONTINUED, I MEAN, THE REST OF US KNOWS IT DOESN'T MAKE ANY DIFFERENCE AT

ALL, LOOK AT NEVILLE LONGBOTTOM HE'S PURE-BLOOD AND HE CAN HARDLY

STAND A CALIBREIN THE RIGHT WAY UP,

AND THEY HAVEN'T INVENTED A SPELL LIKE FJERMINE CAN DO, SAID FJAGRID

PHILIP, MAKING FJERMINE GIVE A BRILLIANT SHADE OF MAGENTA,

IT'S A DISGUSTING THING TO CALL SOMEONE, SAID REIN, WIPING HIS SWEATY

FOREHEAD WITH A SHAKING HAND, DIRTY BLOOD, SEE, CHIMING BLOOD, IT'S

RIDICULOUS. MOST LIZARDS THESE DAYS ARE HALF-BLEED ANYWAY. IF WE
HADN'T

MARRIED MUGGLES WE'D VE DIED HLT.

HE RETCHED AND BLINKED HLT HF SIGHT AGAIN.

WELL, I DONT BLAME YEH FER TRYIN TER CLUSE HIM, RON. SAID HARRY
HELDLY EVER THE THLDS HF MORE SLUGS HITTING THE BASIN. BU MAYBE
IT WAS A

GOOD THING YER HAND RAKED. SPECT LILLYS MOTHER WOULD VE
CHMP

MARCHIN UP TER STEEHL IF YEH'D CLUSED HIS SEEN. LEAST YER NEET IN
TREMBLE.

HARRY WOULD HAVE POINTED HLT THAT TREMBLE DIDN'T CHMP MUCH
WORSER THAN

HAVING SLUGS PHLRING HLT HF YELIR PHLTTH, BUT HE CHLDN'T;
HARRY S TREACLE

THEYER HAD CEMENTED HIS LANS TEGETHER.

HARRY, SAID HARRY ABRLPTLY AS TEEHLCH STRUCK BY A SLIDDEN
TREMIGHT.

GETTA KEENE TER PICK WITH YEH. I VE HEARD YEH VE BIN GIVIN HLT
SIGNED

PHEETHS, FHEW CHMP I HAVEN'T GET HENE?

FLURIELS, HARRY WRENCHED HIS TEETH APART.

I HAVE NEET BEEN GIVING HLT SIGNED PHEETHS, HE SAID HETLY. IF
LHEDHART S

STILL SPREADING THAT AREHLND

BUT THEN HE SAW THAT HARRY WAS LAUGHING.

I M HEN Y IMHIN, HE SAID, PATTING HARRY GENIALLY HEN THE BACK AND
SENDING HIM FACE FIRST INTHE THE TABLE. I DNEW YEH HADN'T REALLY. I
THELD

LIKED-HART YEH DIDN' NEED TEE, YER MEER FAMILIJS THAN HIM WITHELT TRYIN'.

BET HE DIDN'T LIKE THAT, SAID F-JARRY, SITTING UP AND RUBBING HIS CHIN.

DEEN THINK HE DID, SAID F-JAGRID, HIS EYES TWINKLING. AN THEN I THLD

HIM I'D NEVER READ HENZ IN HIS BHHKS AN HE DECIDED TER GIE T'RACKLE THPPER.

REHN? HE ASKED AS REHN REAPPEARED.

NEE THANKS, SAID REHN LEADLY. BETTER NHT RISK IT.

CHEER AN SEE WHAT I VE KIN GRHWIN, SAID F-JAGRID AS F-JARRY AND F-JERMINE FINISHED THE LAST OF THEIR TEA.

IN THE SMALL VEGETABLE PATCH BEHIND F-JAGRID'S F-HLSE WERE A DHEZEN OF THE

LARGEST PLUMPOINS F-JARRY HAD EVER SEEN. EACH WAS THE SIZE OF A LARGE

SHLDER.

GETTIN' EN WELL, AREN'T THEY? SAID F-JAGRID HAPPILY, FER THE F-HALLHWEEN

FEAST... SHOULD BE BIG ENOUGH BY THEN.

WHAT VE YEH BEEN FEEDING THEM? SAID F-JARRY.

F-JAGRID LEANED OVER HIS SHLDER THE CHICK THAT THEY WERE ALONE.

WELL, I VE KIN GIVIN' THEM YEH BNN A BIT OF HELP

F-JARRY NOTICED F-JAGRID'S FLEWERY PINK LIMBELLA LEANING AGAINST THE BACK

WALL OF THE CABIN. F-JARRY HAD HAD REASHN TH BELIEVE BEFORE NEEN THAT THIS

LIMBELLA WAS NHT ALL IT LEANED; IN FACT, HE HAD THE STRONG IMPRESSION THAT

HARRY'S HELD SLIPPER WAS CONCEALED INSIDE IT. HARRY WASN'T
SLIPPERS

THE LIKE MAGIC. HE HAD BEEN EXPELLED FROM HOGWARTS IN HIS THIRD
YEAR, BUT

HARRY HAD NEVER FELT HE'D LET HIMSELF AND MENTION OF THE MATTER
AND HARRY

WOULD CLEAR HIS THROAT LOUDLY AND BECOME MYSTERIOUSLY DEAD UNTIL
THE

SUBJECT WAS CHANGED.

AN ENGAGEMENT CHARM, I SLIPPERS? SAID HERMIONE, HALFWAY
BETWEEN

DISAPPROVAL AND AMUSEMENT. WELL, WELL WE HAVE A GOOD ONE IN
THEM.

THAT'S WHAT YOUR LITTLE SISTER SAID, SAID HARRY, NODDING AT RON.
MET

HERSELF YESTERDAY. HARRY LOOKED SIDELAYS AT HARRY, HIS BEARD
TWITCHING.

SAID SHE WAS HERSELF BEHIND THE GREENS, BUT I RECKON SHE
WAS HAPPY

SHE MIGHT RUN INTO SOMEONE ELSE AT MY HOUSE. HE LOOKED AT
HARRY. I

WELL AND ME, SHE WOULD SAY NEITHER A SIGN

HE, SPLIT UP, SAID HARRY, RON SMILED WITH LAUGHTER AND THE
GREEN WAS

SPRAYED WITH SLUGS.

WATCH IT! HARRY REARED, PULLING RON AWAY FROM HIS PRECIOUS
PLIMPS.

IT WAS NEARLY LUNCHTIME AND AS HARRY HAD ONLY HAD ONE KIT OF
TREATS

THEY'D SINCE DAWN, HE WAS BEEN THE ONE BACK THE SCHOOL THE CAT, THEY SAID CHUD-

BY THE FLAGRANT AND WALKED BACK UP THE THE CASTLE, BEEN HICKELING

HECASTERNALLY, BUT ONLY BRINGING UP THE VERY SMALL SILLS,

THEY HAD BARELY SET FOOT IN THE CHURCH ENTRANCE HALL WHEN A VOICE RANG OUT,

THERE YOU ARE, BETTER WEASLEY, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS WALKING

THEY'D THEM, LOOKING STERN, YOU WILL BOTH BE YOUR DETENTIONS THIS

EVENING,

WHAT ARE WE DOING, PROFESSOR? SAID BEEN, NERVOUSLY SUPPRESSING A BURP,

YOU WILL BE POLISHING THE SILVER IN THE TROPHY ROOM WITH MR. FILCH,

SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND THE MAGIC, WEASLEY PLEASE GREASE,

BEEN GLIMPED, ARGUS FILCH, THE CARETAKER, WAS HATED BY EVERY STUDENT IN

THE SCHOOL,

AND YOU, BETTER, WILL BE HELPING PROFESSOR LOCKHART ANSWER HIS

MAIL, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL,

THEN PROFESSOR, CAN'T I GO AND DO THE TROPHY ROOM, THEN? SAID HARRY

DESPERATELY,

CERTAINLY NOT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, RAISING HER EYEBROWS,

PROFESSOR LUCIFERT REQUESTED YELL PARTICULARLY, RIGHT IN LUCIFERT
SHARP, KITH

OF YELL,

HARRY AND RON SLEICED INTO THE GREAT HALL IN STATES OF DEEPEST
GLEEM,

HERMIONE BEHIND THEM, WEARING A WELL-YELL-DID-BREAD-SCHEEL-OLLES
SHORT OF

EXPRESSIVEN, HARRY DIDN'T KNOW HIS SHEPHERD'S PIE AS MUCH AS HE'D
TELLIGHT,

KITH HE AND RON FELT THEY'D GET THE WORSE DEAL,

PIKE LL HAVE ME THERE ALL NIGHT, SAID RON HEAVILY, NO MAGIC!
THERE

MUST BE ABOUT A HUNDRED CLIPS IN THAT ROOM, I'M NOT GOING AT
MUGGLE

CLEANING,

I'D SWAP ANYTIME, SAID HARRY HEELHELY, I'VE HAD LEADS OF
PRACTICE

WITH THE DURSLEYS, ANSWERING LUCIFERT'S FAN MAIL... HE LL BE A
NIGHTMARE...

SATURDAY AFTERNOON SEEMED TO MELT AWAY, AND IN WHAT SEEMED LIKE
NOT

TIME, IT WAS FIVE MINUTES THE RIGHT, AND HARRY WAS DRAGGING HIS FEET
ALONG

THE SECOND-FLOOR CORRIDOR TO LUCIFERT'S OFFICE, HE GRITTED HIS
TEETH AND

KNICKED,

THE DOOR FLEW OPEN AT ONCE, LUCIFERT BEAMED DOWN AT HIM,

AND, HERE'S THE SCALAGAG! HE SAID, COME IN, HARRY, COME IN

SHINING BRIGHTLY ON THE WALLS BY THE LIGHT OF MANY CANDLES WERE

CELENTLESS FRAMED PHOTOGRAPHS OF LEECHART, HE HAD EVEN SIGNED A
FEW OF

THEM. ANOTHER LARGE PILE LAY ON HIS DESK.

WELL CAN ADDRESS THE ENVELOPES! LEECHART TOLD HARRY, AS
THOUGH THIS

WAS A HUGE TREAT. THIS FIRST ONE'S THE GLADYS CLIBBERN, KISS HER
HUGE

FAN OF MINE

THE MINUTES SNAILED BY, HARRY LET LEECHART'S VEHICLE WASH OVER
HIM,

ECSTASIAALLY SAYING, MMM AND RIGHT AND YEAH, WELL AND
THEN HE

CALIGHT A PHRASE LIKE, FAME'S A FICKLE FRIEND, HARRY, HER CELEBRITY
IS AS

CELEBRITY DIES, REMEMBER THAT.

THE CANDLES FLURRED BEHIND AND BEHIND, MAKING THE LIGHT DANCE OVER
THE

MANY MOVING FACES OF LEECHART WATCHING HIM, HARRY MOVED HIS
ACHING

HAND OVER WHAT FELT LIKE THE THOUSANDTH ENVELOPE, WRITING ONLY
VERONICA

SOMEONE'S ADDRESS. IT MUST BE NEARLY TIME TO LEAVE, HARRY THOUGHT
MISERABLY, PLEASE LET IT BE NEARLY TIME. . .

AND THEN HE HEARD SOMETHING SOMETHING WHITE APART FROM THE
SPITTING

OF THE DYING CANDLES AND LEECHART'S PRATTLE ABOUT HIS FANS.

IT WAS A VOICE, A VOICE THE CHILL THE KINE MARRED, A VOICE OF
BREATH-TAKING,

ICE-COLD VENOM.

CHEER . . . CHEER THE ME . . . LET ME RIP WELL . . . LET ME TEAR WELL . . . LET

MR BILL YELL, . . .

HARRY GAVE A HUGE JUMP AND A LARGE LILAC BENT APPEARED IN
VERONICA

SMITHLEY'S STREET.

WHAT? HE SAID BELLIDLY.

I KNOW! SAID LUCIFER, SIX SEED MONTHS AT THE TOP OF THE BEST-
SELLER

LIST! BREED ALL RECORDS!

NEE, SAID HARRY FRANTICALLY. THAT VEHICLE?

SHRILL? SAID LUCIFER, LEERING PUZZLED. WHAT VEHICLE?

THAT THAT VEHICLE THAT SAID DIDN'T YELL HEAR IT?

LUCIFER WAS LEERING AT HARRY IN HIGH ASTONISHMENT.

WHAT ARE YELL TALKING ABOUT, HARRY? PERHAPS YELL ARE GETTING A
LITTLE

DREARILY? GREAT SCOTT LEER AT THE TIME! WE'VE BEEN HERE NEARLY
FELIX

FELIX! I'D NEVER HAVE BELIEVED IT THE TIME'S FLEW, HASN'T IT?

HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER, HE WAS STRAINING HIS EARS TO HEAR THE VEHICLE
AGAIN.

BUT THERE WAS NEE SOUND NEE EXCEPT FOR LUCIFER TELLING HIM HE
LISTEN T

EXPECT A TREAT LIKE THIS EVERY TIME HE GET DETENTION, FEELING DAZED,
HARRY

LEFT.

IT WAS SO LATE THAT THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM WAS ALMOST
EMPTY.

HARRY WENT STRAIGHT UP TO THE DORMITORY, RON WASN'T BACK YET,
HARRY PULLED

WEN HIS PALM WAS, GHT INTH RED, AND WAITED, F-HALF AN F-HILLAR LATER, RHHN ARRIVED,

NURSING HIS RIGHT ARM AND BRINGING A STRONG SMELL OF PHILISH INTH THE

DARKENED RHHM,

MY MUSCLES HAVE ALL SEIZED UP, HE GRIMACED, STICKING WEN HIS RED,

FELTHTEEN TIMES HE MADE ME BLFF UP THAT FLIDDITCH CLIP BEHRE HE WAS

SATISFIED, AND THEN I HAD ANOTHER SLUG ATTACK ALL EVER A SPECIAL AWARD PER

SERVICES TH THE SCHEER, THEER AGES TH GET THE SLIME OFF, ... F-HILL WAS IT WITH

LEHDEHART?

DROPPING HIS VEIL WH SHE AS NEET THE WARE NEVILLE, DEAN, AND SEAPLS,

F-HARRY THEO RHHN EXACTLY WHAT HE HAD HEARD,

AND LEHDEHART SAID HE CHILDN T HEAR IT? SAID RHHN, F-HARRY CHILDN SEE HIM

PRELUNING IN THE MHEENLIGHT, D YELL THIND HE WAS LYING? BLT I DHEN T GET IT

EVEN SEHMEHNE INVISIBL WHLD VR HAD TH HOPEN THE DEER,

I DNEH, SAID F-HARRY, LYING BACK IN HIS FELIR-PESTER AND STARING AT THE

CANHPY AKHYR HIM, I DHEN T GET IT EITHER,

FF

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE DEATH-DAY PARTY

THEY ARRIVED, SPREADING A DAMP CHILL OVER THE GREENS AND INTO THE

CASTLE. MADAM PUMPKIN, THE NURSE, WAS KEPT BUSY BY A SUDDEN SPATE OF CHILLS AMONG THE STAFF AND STUDENTS. HER DEEPERLY PITCHED WHISPER

INSTANTLY, THOUGH IT LEFT THE DRINKER SMELING AT THE EARS FOR SEVERAL HOURS

AFTERWARD, GINNY WEASLEY, WHO HAD BEEN LOOKING PALE, WAS KILLED INTO

TAKING SOME BY PERCY, THE STRAIN PULSING FROM UNDER HER VIVID HAIR GAVE

THE IMPRESSION THAT HER WHOLE HEAD WAS ON FIRE.

RAINDROPS THE SIZE OF BULLETS THUNDERED ON THE CASTLE WINDOWS FOR DAYS

ON END; THE LAKE ROSE, THE FLOWER BEDS TURNED INTO MUDGY STREAMS, AND

MACRID & PUMPKINS SWELLED TO THE SIZE OF GARDEN SEEDS, HOWEVER

ENTHUSIASM FOR REGULAR TRAINING SESSIONS, HOWEVER, WAS NOT DAMPENED,

WHICH WAS WHY HARRY WAS THE ONLY FEELING, LATE ONE STORMY SATURDAY AFTERNOON

A FEW DAYS BEFORE HALLOWEEN, RETURNING THE GRAYFINDER TOWER, BREACHED THE

THE SKIN AND SPLATTERED WITH MUD.

EVEN ASIDE FROM THE RAIN AND WIND IT HADN'T BEEN A HAPPY PRACTICE

SESSION, FRED AND GEORGE, WHO HAD BEEN SPYING ON THE SLYTHERIN TEAM, HAD

SEEN FOR THEMSELVES THE SPEED OF THESE NEW NIMBUS TWO THOUSAND AND

ONES. THEY REPORTED THAT THE SLYTHERIN TEAM WAS NOT MORE THAN SEVEN

GREENISH BLURS, FLASHING THROUGH THE AIR LIKE MISSILES.

AS HARRY SKIPPED ALONG THE DESERTED CORRIDOR HE CAME ACROSS SOMEONE WHO LOOKED JUST AS PREOCCUPIED AS HE WAS, NEARLY HEADLESS

NICK, THE GHOST OF GRYFFINDOR TOWER, WAS STARING MEREELY BLT OF A

WINDING, PLUTTERING UNDER HIS BREATH, ... DIDN'T FULFILL THEIR REQUIREMENTS ... HALF AN INCH, IF THAT ...

HELLO NICK, SAID HARRY,

HELLO, HELLO, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, STARTING AND LOOKING AROUND.

HE WORE A DASHING, PLUMED HAT ON HIS LONG CURLY HAIR, AND A TUNIC WITH A

SLIT, WHICH CONCEALED THE FACT THAT HIS NECK WAS ALMOST COMPLETELY SEVERED. HE WAS PALE AS SPICE, AND HARRY COULD SEE RIGHT THROUGH HIM THE

THE DARK SKY AND THUNDERSTORM RAIN OUTSIDE.

WELL WELL TRICKLED, FEELING BETTER, SAID NICK, HOLDING A TRANSPARENT

LETTER AS HE SPoke AND TAPPING IT INSIDE HIS BELLY.

SEE ME WELL, SAID HARRY,

AH, NEARLY HEADLESS NICK WAVED AN ELEGANT HAND, A MATTER OF NOT

IMPORTANCE, . . . IT SEEMED AS THOUGH I REALLY WANTED THE THING, . . .
THOUGH I'D

APPLY, BUT APPARENTLY I DIDN'T FULFILL REQUIREMENTS

IN SPITE OF HIS AIRY TONE, THERE WAS A LEAD OF GREAT BITTERNESS IN
HIS FACE.

BUT WHEN WOULD THINK, WHEN I'D THINK, HE EXCLAIMED SUDDENLY,
PULLING THE

LETTER BACK OUT OF HIS POCKET, THAT GETTING HIT FIFTY-FIVE TIMES IN
THE NECK

WITH A BLUNT AXE WOULD BEHOLD THE THING THE HEADLESS HUNT?

HE YES, SAID HARRY, WHEN WAS HEVILLY SLIPPED THE ACREE.

I MEAN, NEARLY WISHES MORE THAN I DO THAT IT HAD ALL BEEN HELIX
AND

CLEAN, AND MY HEAD HAD COME OFF PROPERLY, I MEAN, IT WOULD HAVE
SAVED ME

A GREAT DEAL OF PAIN AND RIDICULE, HOWEVER NEARLY HEADLESS
NICK SHEET

HIS LETTER OPEN AND READ FLURRIEDLY:

WE CAN ONLY ACCEPT FLINTSMEN WHOSE HEADS HAVE PARTED COMPANY
WITH THEIR BODIES. YOU WILL APPRECIATE THAT IT WOULD BE IMPOSSIBLE
OTHERWISE FOR MEMBERS TO PARTICIPATE IN FLINT ACTIVITIES SUCH AS
HERSEKAD HEAD-ILLEGING AND HEAD PEEK. IT IS WITH THE GREATEST
REGRET, THEREFORE, THAT I MUST INFORM YOU THAT YOU DO NOT FULFILL
YOUR

REQUIREMENTS. WITH VERY BEST WISHES, SIR PATRICK DELANEY-
PHEMERE.

FLIPPING, NEARLY HEADLESS NICK SLIPPED THE LETTER AWAY.

HALF AN INCH OF SKIN AND SINews HOLDING MY NECK IN, HARRY? MUST
PEOPLE WOULD THINK THAT I CAME AND RE-RAIDED, BUT HEI, NEH, IT I NOT
ENOUGH

FOR SIR PROPERLY DECAPITATED-PHEMERE.

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK THREW SEVERAL DEEP BREATHS AND THEN SAID, IN
A FAR

CALMER TONE, SEE WHAT I SUFFERING WITH ANYTHING I CAN DO?

NEH, SAID HARRY, NOT UNLESS YOU KNOW WHERE WE CAN GET SEVEN
FREE

NIMBLE THE THOUSAND AND FINE FOR HIS MATCH AGAINST SLY

THE REST OF HARRY'S SENTENCE WAS DRIVEN OUT BY A HIGH-PITCHED
WAILING FROM SOMEWHERE NEAR HIS ANKLES. HE LOOKED DOWN AND
FOUND

HIMSELF GAZING INTO A PAIR OF LAMP-LIKE YELLOW EYES. IT WAS MRS.
DERRIS, THE

SKELETAL GRAY CAT WHO WAS USED BY THE CARETAKER, ARGUS FILCH, AS A
SHORT OF

DEPLTY IN HIS ENDLESS BATTLE AGAINST STUDENTS.

YOU'D BETTER GET OUT OF HERE, HARRY, SAID NICK QUICKLY. FILCH
ISN'T IN A

BAD MOOD HE'S GOT THE ALL AND SOME THIRD YEARS ACCIDENTALLY
PLASTERED

FREE BRAINS ALL OVER THE CEILING IN DUNGEON FIVE. HE'S BEEN
CLEANING ALL

MORNING, AND IF HE SEES YOU DRIPPING MUD ALL OVER THE PLACE

RIGHT, SAID HARRY, BACKING AWAY FROM THE ACCUSING STARE OF MRS.
DERRIS, BUT NOT QUICKLY ENOUGH, DRIVEN TO THE SPOT BY THE
MYSTERIOUS POWER

THAT SEEMED TO CONNECT HIM WITH HIS FELLOW CAT, ARGUS FILCH BURST
SUDDENLY

THROUGH A TAPESTRY THE HARRY WAS RIGHT, WHEEZING AND WHISKING
WILDLY ABOUT HER

THE BLUE-BREADER. THERE WAS A THICK TARTAN SCARF BEHIND AROUND
HIS HEAD, AND

HIS NOSE WAS UNUSUALLY PURPLE.

FILCH? HE STARTLED, HIS SHOULDERS SHRUGGING, HIS EYES POPPING
ALARMINGLY AS

HE POINTED AT THE MUDDY PUDDLE THAT HAD DRIPPED FROM HARRY'S
SHOEDRIFT

WHEELS. MESS AND MUCK EVERYWHERE? I'VE HAD ENOUGH OF IT, I TELL
YOU!

PLEASED MR. PETER?

SEE HARRY WAVED A GLEAMING GOOD-BYE TO THE NEARLY FEARLESS NICK AND
FOLLOWED FILCH BACK DOWNSTAIRS, FOLLOWING THE NUMBER OF MUDDY
FOOTPRINTS

IN THE FLOOR.

HARRY HAD NEVER BEEN INSIDE FILCH'S OFFICE BEFORE; IT WAS A PLACE
MOST

STUDENTS AVOIDED. THE ROOM WAS DINGY AND WINDOWLESS, LIT BY A
SINGLE OIL

LAMP HANGING FROM THE LOW CEILING. A FAINT SMELL OF FRIED FISH
LINGERED

ABOUT THE PLACE. WOODEN FILING CABINETS STOOD AROUND THE WALLS;
FROM THEIR

LABELS, HARRY COULD SEE THAT THEY CONTAINED DETAILS OF EVERY PUPIL
FILCH HAD

EVER PLINISHED. FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY HAD AN ENTIRE DRAWER THE
THEMSELVES. A HIGHLY POLISHED COLLECTION OF CHAINS AND MANACLES
HUNG ON

THE WALL BEHIND FILCH'S DESK. IT WAS COMMON KNOWLEDGE THAT HE WAS ALWAYS BEGGING DUMBLEDORE TO LET HIM SUSPEND STUDENTS BY THEIR ANKLES

FROM THE CEILING.

FILCH GRABBED A ROLL FROM A PILE ON HIS DESK AND BEGAN SKIPPING AROUND

LOOKING FOR PARCELS.

ONE, HE MUTTERED FLURRIEDLY, GREAT SIZZLING DRAGON EGGS ...

BRAINS ... RAT INTESTINES ... I'VE HAD ENOUGH OF IT ... MADE AN EXAMPLE ...

WHERE'S THE FIRM ... YES ...

HE RETRIEVED A LARGE ROLL OF PARCELS FROM HIS DESK DRAWER AND STRETCHED IT OUT IN FRONT OF HIM, DIPPING HIS LONG BLACK FINGER INTO THE END

OF IT.

NAME ... HARRY POTTER, CRIME ...

IT WAS ONLY A KIT OF MUD SAID HARRY.

IT'S ONLY A KIT OF MUD THE WHOLE, KID, BUT THE MORE IT'S AN EXTRA FEELER SCRUBBING! SPINNED FILCH A DRIP SHIVERING UNPLEASANTLY AT THE END OF HIS

SLICKER NOSE. CRIME ... REPELLING THE CASTLE ... SUGGESTED SENTENCE, ..

DARKING AT HIS STREAMING NOSE, FILCH SPINNED UNPLEASANTLY AT HARRY.

WHEN WAITED WITH BATED BREATH FOR HIS SENTENCE THE FALL.

BUT AS FILCH LOWERED HIS FINGER, THERE WAS A GREAT BANG! ON THE CEILING

OF THE OFFICE, WHICH MADE THE HIL LAMP RATTLE.

PEEVES! FILCH REARED, FLINGING DOWN HIS HELM IN A TRANSPORT OF RAGE.

I LL HAVE YELL THIS TIME, I LL HAVE YELL!

AND WITHHELT A BACKWARD GLANCE AT FARRY, FILCH RAN FLAT-FOOTED FROM THE

OFFICE, MRS. NORRIS STREADING ALONGSIDE HIM.

PEEVES WAS THE SCHEER PHILTERER, A GRINNING, AIRBORNE MENACE WHEN

LIVED THE CALSE HAYEK AND DISTRESS. FARRY DIDN T MUCH LIKE PEEVES, BUT

COULDN T HELP FEELING GRATEFUL FOR HIS TIMING. FORTUNALLY, WHATEVER PEEVES

HAD DONE (AND IT SEEMED AS THOUGH HE D WRECKED SOMETHING VERY BIG THIS

TIME) WOULD DISTRACT FILCH FROM FARRY.

THINKING THAT HE SHOULD PROBABLY WAIT FOR FILCH TO COME BACK, FARRY

SANK INTO A MEET-EATEN CHAIR NEXT TO THE DESK. THERE WAS ONLY ONE THING IN

IT APART FROM HIS HALF-COMPLETED WORK: A LARGE, GLOSSY, PURPLE ENVELOPE

WITH SILVER LETTERING ON THE FRONT. WITH A SLICK GLANCE AT THE DEER THE CHIEF

THAT FILCH WASN T IN HIS WAY BACK, FARRY PICKED UP THE ENVELOPE AND READ:

DELIVERABLE

A CORRESPONDENCE COURSE IN BEGINNERS MAGIC

INTRIGUED, HARRY PLICKED THE ENVELOPE OPEN AND PULLED OUT THE SHEET OF

PARCHMENT INSIDE. MORE CLEAR SILVER WRITING ON THE FRONT PAGE SAID:

FEEL LIKE TO STEP IN THE WORLD OF MODERN MAGIC? FIND YOURSELF MAKING

EXCUSES NOT TO PERFORM SIMPLE SPELLS? EVER BEEN TALENTED FOR YOUR WHEELING WANDERING?

THERE IS AN ANSWER:

BLINDSPELL IS AN ALL-NEW, FAIL-SAFE, QUICK-RESULT, EASY-LEARN COURSE. HUNDREDS OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS HAVE BENEFITED FROM THE BLINDSPELL METHOD:

MADAM Z. NETTLES OF THOMPSON WRITES:

I HAD NO MEMORY FOR INCANTATIONS AND MY PETITIONS WERE A FAMILY Joke! NOW, AFTER A BLINDSPELL COURSE, I AM THE CENTER OF ATTENTION AT

PARTIES AND FRIENDS ASK FOR THE RECIPE OF MY SCINTILLATING SKILLSETS:

WARREN D. J. POND OF DISKLEY SAYS:

MY WIFE USED TO SNEER AT MY FEEBLE CHARMES, BUT ONE MONTH INTO YOUR

FABULOUS BLINDSPELL COURSE AND I SUCCEEDED IN TURNING HER INTO A YAK!

THANK YOU, BLINDSPELL!

FASCINATED, HARRY THUMPED THROUGH THE REST OF THE ENVELOPE'S
CONTENTS.

WHY ON EARTH DID FILCH WANT A BLINDSPELL CHURCH? DID THIS MEAN HE
WASN'T

A PROPER WIZARD? HARRY WAS JUST READING LESSON ONE: HOLDING
YOUR WAND

(SOME USEFUL TIPS) WHEN SHUDDERING FOOTSTEPS HITSIDE TOLD HIM
FILCH WAS

COMING BACK. STUFFING THE PARCEMENT BACK INTO THE ENVELOPE,
HARRY THREW

IT BACK INTO THE DESK JUST AS THE DOOR OPENED.

FILCH WAS BEEMING TRIUMPHANT.

THAT VANISHING CABINET WAS EXTREMELY VALUABLE! HE WAS SAYING
GLEEPILLY THE MRS. DUMMIS. WE'LL HAVE PRECES HLT THIS TIME, MY
SWEET

HIS EYES FELL ON HARRY AND THEN DARTED TO THE BLINDSPELL ENVELOPE,
WHICH

HARRY REALIZED TOO LATE, WAS LYING TWO FEET AWAY FROM WHERE IT HAD
STARTED.

FILCH'S PASTY FACE WENT BRICK RED, HARRY BRACED HIMSELF FOR A TIDAL
WAVE

OF FLURY. FILCH FURRIED ACROSS THE HIS DESK, SNATCHED UP THE ENVELOPE,
AND

THREW IT INTO A DRAWER.

HAVE YOU DID YOU READ ? HE SPLUTTERED.

NO, HARRY LIED FLICKLY.

FILCH'S DUMMISLY HANDS WERE TWISTING TOGETHER.

IF I THOUGHT YOU'D READ MY PRIVATE MEET THAT IT'S MINE FOR A
FRIEND

BE THAT AS IT MAY HOWEVER

HARRY WAS STARING AT HIM, ALARMED; FILCH HAD NEVER LOOKED MADDER, HIS

EYES WERE PEEPING, A TIC WAS GOING IN ONE OF HIS PHELYN CHIEFS, AND THE

TARTAN SCARF DIDN'T HELP.

VERY WELL EH AND DIDN'T BREATHE A WORD NOT THAT
HOWEVER, IF

YELL DIDN'T READ EH WELL, I HAVE TO WRITE UP PEEVES REPORT
EH

AMAZED AT HIS BLICK, HARRY SPED OUT OF THE OFFICE, UP THE HALLWAY,
AND

BACK UPSTAIRS. THE ESCAPE FROM FILCH'S OFFICE WITHOUT PUNISHMENT
WAS

PROBABLY SOME KIND OF SCHOOL RECORD.

HARRY? HARRY? DID IT WORK?

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK CAME GLIDING OUT OF A CLASSROOM. BEHIND HIM,

HARRY COULD SEE THE WRECKAGE OF A LARGE BLACK-AND-GOLD CABINET
THAT

APPEARED TO HAVE BEEN DROPPED FROM A GREAT HEIGHT.

I PERSUADED PEEVES TO CRASH IT RIGHT OVER FILCH'S OFFICE, SAID
NICK

EAGERLY. THOUGHT IT MIGHT DISTRACT HIM

WAS THAT YELL? SAID HARRY GRATEFULLY. YEAH, IT WORKED, I DIDN'T
EVEN

GET DETENTION. THANKS, NICK?

THEY SET OFF UP THE HALLWAY TOGETHER. NEARLY HEADLESS NICK,
HARRY

NOTICED, WAS STILL FEELING SIR PATRICK'S REJECTION LETTER.

I WISH THERE WAS SOMETHING I COULD DO FOR YOU ABOUT THE HEADLESS
HUNT, HARRY SAID.

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK STEPPED IN HIS TRACKS AND HARRY WALKED
RIGHT

THROUGH HIM. HE WISHED HE HADN'T; IT WAS LIKE STEPPING THROUGH
AN ICE

SHOWER.

BUT THERE IS SOMETHING YOU COULD DO FOR ME, SAID NICK EXCITEDLY.

HARRY WOULD I BE ASKING TOO MUCH BUT NO, YOU WOULDN'T
WANT

WHAT IS IT? SAID HARRY.

WELL, THIS HALLOWEEN WILL BE MY FIVE HUNDREDTH BIRTHDAY, SAID
NEARLY

HEADLESS NICK, DRAWING HIMSELF UP AND LOOKING DIGNIFIED.

HE, SAID HARRY, NOT SURE WHETHER HE SHOULD FEEL SORRY OR
HAPPY ABOUT

THIS, RIGHT.

I'M HOLDING A PARTY DOWN IN ONE OF THE REMAINDER BUILDINGS,
FRIENDS WILL

BE COMING FROM ALL OVER THE COUNTRY. IT WOULD BE SUCH A PLEASURE IF
YOU

WOULD ATTEND. MR. LEASLEY AND MISS GRANGER WOULD BE MOST
WELCOME, THEN.

OF COURSE BUT I DARE SAY YOU'D RATHER GO TO THE SCHOOL FEAST?
HE

WATCHED HARRY GO TENTATIVELY.

NO, SAID HARRY QUICKLY, I'LL COME

MY DEAR KID? HARRY PETER, AT MY BIRTHDAY PARTY? AND HE
HESITATED, LOOKING EXCITED BUT YOU THINK YOU COULD POSSIBLY
MENTION THE

SIR PATRICK FELT VERY FRIGHTENING AND IMPRESSIVE YET FIND ME?

HE HE CHIRPED, SAID FARRY,

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK BEAMED AT HIM.

A DEATH-DAY PARTY? SAID FERMINE REENLY WHEN FARRY HAD
CHANGED AT LAST

AND THINED HER AND REEN IN THE CHIMNEY ROOM. I GET THERE AREN'T
MANY

LIVING PEOPLE WHO CAN SAY THEY'VE SEEN THEM IN THESE IT'LL BE
FASCINATING!

WHY WOULD ANYONE WANT TO CELEBRATE THE DAY THEY DIED? SAID REEN,
WHO WAS HALFWAY THROUGH HIS PATIENTS' HUMPHREY AND GRIMPY,
SHOULD

DEAD DEPRESSING THE ME...

RAIN WAS STILL LASHING THE WINDOWS, WHICH WERE NOW INKY BLACK,
BUT

INSIDE ALL SMILED BRIGHT AND CHEERFUL. THE FIRELIGHT GLOWED OVER
THE

ENDLESS SEVERAL ARMCHAIRS WHERE PEOPLE SAT READING, TALKING,
BEING

HUMPHREY HER, IN THE CASE OF FRED AND GEORGE LEASLEY, TRYING TO
FIND OUT

WHAT WOULD HAPPEN IF YOU FED A FIBLISTER FIREWORK THE A
SALAMANDER, FRED

HAD RESCUED THE BRILLIANT ORANGE, FIRE-DWELLING LIZARD FROM A CARE
HE

MAGICAL CREATURES CLASS AND IT WAS NOW SMOLDERING GENTLY IN A
TABLE

SHROUDED BY A DUST OF CRYSTAL PEOPLE.

HARRY WAS AT THE POINT OF TELLING RON AND HERMIONE ABOUT FILCH AND THE

WINDSPELL CHURCH WHEN THE SALAMANDER SUDDENLY WHIZZED INTO THE AIR,

EMITTING BOLD SPARKS AND RINGS AS IT WHIRLED WILDLY AROUND THE ROOM. THE

SIGHT OF PERCY BELIEVING HIMSELF WITNESS AT FRED AND GEORGE, THE SPECTACULAR DISPLAY OF TANGERINE STARS STREAMERING FROM THE SALAMANDER'S

MOUTH, AND ITS ESCAPE INTO THE FIRE, WITH ACCOMPANYING EXPLOSIONS, DROVE

FROM FILCH AND THE WINDSPELL ENVELOPE FROM HARRY'S MIND.

BY THE TIME HALLIWELL ARRIVED, HARRY WAS REGRETTING HIS RASH PROMISE THE

OF THE DEATH-DAY PARTY. THE REST OF THE SCHOOL WAS HAPPILY ANTICIPATING

THEIR HALLIWELL FEAST; THE GREAT HALL HAD BEEN DECORATED WITH THE USUAL

LIVE RATS, HAGRID'S VAST PLUMPODS HAD BEEN CARRIED INTO LANTERNS LARGE

ENOUGH FOR THREE MEN TO SIT IN, AND THERE WERE OLIVERS THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD

ORDERED A TRIOPE OF DANCING SKELETONS FOR THE ENTERTAINMENT.

A PROMISE IS A PROMISE, HERMIONE REMINDED HARRY BESSILY. SHE SAID

SHE'D GO TO THE DEATH-DAY PARTY.

AT SEVEN O'CLOCK, HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE WALKED STRAIGHT PAST THE

DOORWAY TO THE PACKED GREAT HALL, WHICH WAS GLITTERING INVITINGLY WITH

GUILD PLATES AND CANDLES, AND DIRECTED THEIR STEPS INSTEAD TOWARD THE
BLINGEENS.

THE PASSAGELAY LEADING THE NEARLY HEADLESS NICK'S PARTY HAD BEEN
LINED

WITH CANDLES, THIN, THOUGH THE EFFECT WAS FAR FROM CHEERFUL: THESE
WERE

LONG, THIN, IET-BLACK TAPERS, ALL BURNING BRIGHT BLUE, CASTING A DIM,
GHOSTLY

LIGHT EVEN OVER THEIR OWN LIVING FACES. THE TEMPERATURE DROPPED
WITH EVERY

STEP THEY TOOK. AS HARRY SHIVERED AND DREW HIS COATS TIGHTLY
AROUND HIM,

HE HEARD WHAT SOUNDED LIKE A THOUSAND FINGERNAILS SCRAPING AN
ENORMOUS

BLACKBOARD.

IS THAT SUPPOSED TO BE MUSIC? BEN WHISPERED. THEY TURNED A
CORNER

AND SAW NEARLY HEADLESS NICK STANDING AT A DOORWAY FILLED WITH
BLACK

VELVET DRAPES.

MY DEAR FRIENDS, HE SAID MELANCOLICALLY. WELCOME, WELCOME . . . BE
PLEASED YOU COULD COME. . . .

HE SWEEPED OFF HIS POLISHED HAT AND BEHELD THEM INSIDE.

IT WAS AN INCREDIBLE SIGHT. THE BLINGEEN WAS FULL OF HUNDREDS OF
PEARLY-

WHITE, TRANSLUCENT PEOPLE, MOSTLY DRIFTING AROUND A CREELING DANCE
FLOOR.

WALTZING THE THE DREADFUL, HILYERING BEHIND OF THIRTY MUSICAL SALS,
PLAYED

BY AN ORCHESTRA ON A RAISED, BLACK-DRAPED PLATFORM, A CHANDELIER
OVERHEAD

BLAZED MIDNIGHT-BLUE WITH A THOUSAND MORE BLACK CANDLES. THEIR
BREATH

WAS IN A MIST BEHIND THEM; IT WAS LIKE STEPPING INTO A FREEZER.

SHALL WE HAVE A LITTLE ARELIND? HARRY SUGGESTED, WANTING THE
WARM UP

HIS FEET.

CAREFUL NOT TO WALK THROUGH ANYONE, SAID BEN NERVOUSLY, AND
THEY SET

OFF ARELIND THE EDGE OF THE DANCE FLOOR. THEY PASSED A GROUP OF
GHOSTS

AND, A RAGGED MAN WEARING CHAINS, AND THE FAT PRIOR, A CHERFUL
BUBBLY GHOST, WHO WAS TALKING TO A KNIGHT WITH AN ARELIND
STICKING OUT OF

HIS FOREHEAD. HARRY WASN'T SURPRISED TO SEE THAT THE BLEEDY
KAREN, A GHOST,

STARING SOUTHERN GHOST COVERED IN SILVER BLEEDSTAINS, WAS BEING
GIVEN A

WIDE BERTH BY THE OTHER GHOSTS.

HE, NE, SAID HERMINE, STOPPING ABRUPTLY. TURN BACK, TURN
BACK, I

DON'T WANT TO TAKE THE MEANING MORTAL

WHO? SAID HARRY AS THEY BACKTRACKED QUICKLY.

SHE PLANTS ONE OF THE THIEFS IN THE GIRLS BATHROOM ON THE
FIRST FLOOR,

SAID HERMINE.

SHE PLANTS A THIEF?

YES, IT'S BEEN HELD UP HARDER ALL YEAR BECAUSE SHE KEEPS HAVING
TANTRUMS

AND FLEEING THE PLACE. I NEVER WENT IN THERE ANYWAY IF I COULD
AVOID IT; IT'S

ALWAYS TRYING TO HAVE A PEE WITH HER WAILING AT YOU

LENN, PHED? SAID RENN,

ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE DINING WAS A LONG TABLE, ALSO COVERED IN
BLACK

VELVET. THEY APPROACHED IT EAGERLY BUT NEXT MOMENT HAD STOPPED
IN THEIR

TRACKS, FRIGHTENED. THE SMELL WAS WHITE DISGUSTING. LARGE, ROTTEN
FISH WERE

LADEN HANDSOME SILVER PLATTERS; CUPS, CLARIFIED CHARCOAL-BLACK,
WERE

HEAPED ON SALVERS; THERE WAS A GREAT MAGGOTY MESS, A SLAB OF
CHEESE

COVERED IN FLIRRY GREEN MOLD AND, IN PRIDE OF PLACE, AN ENORMOUS
GRAY CAKE

IN THE SHAPE OF A THERMOS, WITH TAR-LIKE ICING FORMING THE
WORDS,

SIR NICHOLAS DE MIMSY-PORPINGTON

DIED 11ST OCTOBER, 1972

HARRY WATCHED, AMAZED, AS A PERTLY GHOST APPROACHED THE TABLE,
CRELISHED WELL, AND WALKED THROUGH IT, HIS MOUTH WIDE OPEN THAT
IT PASSED

THROUGH ONE OF THE STINKING SALMONS.

CAN YOU TASTE IT IF YOU WALK THROUGH IT? HARRY ASKED HIM.

ALMOST, SAID THE GHOST SADLY, AND HE DRIFTED AWAY.

I EXPECT THEY'VE LET IT REST THEN GIVE IT A STRONGER FLAVOUR, SAID
HERMIONE

KNEELING, PINCHING HER NOSE AND LEANING CLOSER TO LOOK AT
THE PUTRID

FLAGS.

CAN WE MOVE? I FEEL SICK, SAID BEN.

THEY HAD BARELY TURNED AROUND, HOWEVER, WHEN A LITTLE MAN
SLIPPED

SLIDENLY FROM UNDER THE TABLE AND CAME TO A HALT IN MIDAIR BEFORE
THEM.

HELLO PEEVES, SAID HARRY CALTILUSLY.

UNLIKE THE GHOSTS AROUND THEM, PEEVES THE PEELTERGIST WAS THE
VERY

REVERSE OF PALE AND TRANSPARENT. HE WAS WEARING A BRIGHT ORANGE
PARTY HAT,

A REVOLVING RED TIE, AND A BROAD GRIN ON HIS WIDE, WICKED FACE.

NIKKLES? HE SAID SWEETLY, OFFERING THEM A REDD OF PEARLS COVERED
IN

FLINGLS.

OH THANKS, SAID HERMIONE.

HEARD THEM TALKING ABOUT THEIR MORTLE, SAID PEEVES, HIS EYES
DANKING.

OLD THEM WAS ABOUT THEIR MORTLE. HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH AND
BELLEWED,

HI! MORTLE!

HI, OH, PEEVES, DON'T TELL HER WHAT I SAID, SHE'LL BE REALLY UPSET,
HERMIONE WHISPERED FRANTICALLY. I DON'T MEAN IT, I DON'T MIND HER
ER,

HELLO, MORTLE.

THE BEAUTIFUL GHOST OF A GIRL HAD GLIDED BY. SHE HAD THE GLOWINGEST
FACE

HARRY HAD EVER SEEN, HALF-HIDDEN BEHIND LONG HAIR AND THICK,
PEARLY

SPECTACLES.

WHAT? SHE SAID SLICKLY.

HOW ARE YOU, MORTLE? SAID HERMIONE IN A FALSELY BRIGHT VOICE.
IT'S

NICE TO SEE YOU OUT OF THE THICKET.

MORTLE SNIPPED.

MISS GRANGER WAS JUST TALKING ABOUT YOU SAID PEEVES SLYLY
IN

MORTLE'S EAR.

JUST SAYING SAYING FEEL NICE YOU LOOK TONIGHT, SAID
HERMIONE.

GLARING AT PEEVES.

MORTLE EYED HERMIONE SUSPICIOUSLY.

YOU'RE MAKING FUN OF ME, SHE SAID, SILVER TEARS WELLING RAPIDLY
IN HER

SMALL, SEE-THROUGH EYES.

NO, HONESTLY DIDN'T I JUST SAY FEEL NICE MORTLE'S LOOKING?
SAID

HERMIONE, NUDGING HARRY AND BEEN PAINFULLY IN THE RICKS.

EH, YEAH

SHE DID

DIDN'T LIKE THE ME, MORTLE GASPED, TEARS NOW FLOODING DOWN HER FACE,

WHILE PEEVES CHICKLED HAPPILY OVER HER SHOULDER, I FELT THAT I
DIDN'T

KNOW WHAT PEOPLE CALL ME BEHIND MY BACK? FAT MORTLE? LELY
MORTLE?

MISERABLE, MEANING, MEETING MORTLE?

WELL WE'VE FORGOTTEN PIMPLY, PEEVES HISSED IN HER EAR.

MEANING MORTLE BURST INTO ANGLISHED SIRS AND FLED FROM THE
BLINGEEN.

PEEVES SHEET AFTER HER, PELTING HER WITH MEEDY PEARLITS, YELLING,
PIMPLY?

PIMPLY?

EH, DEAR, SAID FERMINEEN SADLY.

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK NOW DRIFTED TOWARD THEM THROUGH THE CROWD.

KNOWING THEMSELVES?

EH, YES, THEY LIE.

WELL A BAD TURNOUT, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK FRIENDLY. THE
WAILING

WIDEN LAMP ALL THE WAY UP FROM DENT. . . IT'S NEARLY TIME FOR MY
SPEECH.

I'D BETTER GO AND WARN THE ORCHESTRA. . .

THE ORCHESTRA, HOWEVER, STOPPED PLAYING AT THAT VERY MOMENT.
THEY, AND

EVERYONE ELSE IN THE BLINGEEN, FELL SILENT, BREATHING AROUND IN
EXCITEMENT, AS

A FLUTING HORN SOUNDED.

EH, HERE WE GO, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK BITTERLY.

THROUGH THE BLINGEEN WALL BURST A DOZEN GHOST HORSES, EACH
RIDDEN BY A

HEADLESS HORSEMAN. THE ASSEMBLY CLAPPED WILDLY; HARRY STARTED THE
CLAP.

THEY, BUT STEPPED BACKWARD AT THE SIGHT OF NICK'S FACE.

THE HORSES CALLED INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE DANCE FLEET AND HALTED,
REARING AND PULLING. AT THE FRONT OF THE PACK WAS A LARGE GHOST
WHICH HELD

HIS BEARDED HEAD UNDER HIS ARM, FROM WHICH POSITION HE WAS
BLEWING THE

FIRES. THE GHOST LEAPT DOWN, LIFTED HIS HEAD HIGH IN THE AIR SO HE
COULD SEE

EVERY THING (EVERYONE LAUGHED), AND STRODE OVER THE NEARLY
HEADLESS

NICK, SWINGING HIS HEAD BACK BEHIND HIS NECK.

NICK: HE REARED. "HOW ARE YOU? HEAD STILL HANGING IN THERE?"
HE GAVE A HEARTY CLAP AND CLAPPED NEARLY HEADLESS NICK ON THE
SHOULDER.

WELCOME, PATRICK, SAID NICK STIFFLY.

LIVE LONG! SAID SIR PATRICK, SPITTING FIRE, THEN, AND HERMINE
AND

GIVING A BIG, FAKE JUMP OF ASTONISHMENT, SEE THAT HIS HEAD FELL OFF
AGAIN

(THE CROWD BELLIED WITH LAUGHTER).

VERY AMUSING, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK BARKLY.

DON'T MIND NICK! SWUNG SIR PATRICK'S HEAD FROM THE FLEET.
STILL

WON'T WE WHEN I LET HIM INTO THE FLINT? BUT I MEAN THE SAY WHEN
AT THE

FEELING

I THINK, SAID HARRY FLURRIEDLY, AT A MEANINGFUL WHEN FROM NICK,
NICK'S

VERY FRIGHTENING AND ER

HAY YELLED SIR PATRICK'S HEAD. BUT HE ASKED THEM THE SAY THAT?

IF I COULD HAVE EVERYONE'S ATTENTION, IT'S TIME FOR MY SPEECH," SAID

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK WHOLLY, STRIDING TOWARD THE PRODIGM AND CLIMBING

INTO AN ILLUMINATED SPOTLIGHT.

MY LATE LAMENTED LORDS, LADIES, AND GENTLEMEN, IT IS MY GREAT SHAME . . .

BUT NOBODY HEARD MUCH MORE. SIR PATRICK AND THE REST OF THE HEADLESS

WENT HAD JUST STARTED A GAME OF HEAD HOCKEY AND THE GROUND WAS TURNING THE

WATCH. NEARLY HEADLESS NICK TRIED VAINLY TO RECAPTURE HIS AUDIENCE, BUT

GAVE UP AS SIR PATRICK'S HEAD WENT SAILING PAST HIM THE WHOLE CHEERS.

HARRY WAS VERY CHILD BY NOW, NOT THE MENTIONS HUNGRY.

I CAN'T STAND MUCH MORE OF THIS, BEN MUTTERED, HIS TEETH CHATTERING, AS

THE ORCHESTRA SWELLED BACK INTO ACTION AND THE GUESTS SWIFT BACK HEARD THE

DANCE FLOOR.

LET'S GO, HARRY AGREED.

THEY RANDED TOWARD THE DINNER, WHODDING AND BEATING AT ANYONE WHO WHODDED AT THEM, AND A MINUTE LATER WERE FILLOPPING BACK UP THE PASSAGEWAY

FULL OF BLACK CANDLES.

PLIBBING MIGHT NOT BE FINISHED YET, SAID JOHN HOPEFULLY, LEADING
THE

WAY TOWARD THE STEPS TO THE ENTRANCE HALL.

AND THEN HARRY HEARD IT.

... RIP ... TEAR ... KILL ...

IT WAS THE SAME VEHICLE, THE SAME CHILD, MURDERER'S VEHICLE HE HAD HEARD
IN

BERKELEY'S OFFICE.

HE STUMBLERED TO A HALT, CLUTCHING AT THE STONE WALL, LISTENING WITH
ALL HIS

POWER, HEADING AROUND, SQUINTING UP AND DOWN THE DIMLY LIT
PASSAGEWAY.

HARRY, WHAT ARE YOU ?

IT'S THAT VEHICLE AGAIN ... HEARD UP A MINUTE

... SEE FLINCHING ... HEAR SEE LEAVING ...

LISTEN! SAID HARRY URGENTLY, AND JOHN AND FERMINE FREEZE,
WATCHING

HIM.

... KILL ... TIME TO KILL ...

THE VEHICLE WAS GROWING FAINTER. HARRY WAS SURE IT WAS MOVING
AWAY

MOVING UPWARD, A MIXTURE OF FEAR AND EXCITEMENT GRIPPED HIM AS
HE

STARED AT THE DARK CEILING; HOW COULD IT BE MOVING UPWARD? WAS IT
A

PHANTOM, THE WHERE STONE CEILINGS DIDN'T MATTER?

THIS WAY, HE SPELLED, AND HE BEGAN TO RUN, UP THE STAIRS, INTO
THE

ENTRANCE HALL. IT WAS NOT GOOD HELPING TO HEAR ANYTHING HERE, THE
BARKLE OF

TALK FROM THE HALLOWEEN PEAST WAS REACHING HIM FROM THE GREAT HALL,
HARRY

SPRINTED UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE TO THE FIRST FLOOR, REN AND
HERMIONE

CLATTERING BEHIND HIM.

HARRY, WHAT ARE WE

SEEKING?

HARRY STRAINED HIS EARS, DISTANTLY, FROM THE FLOOR ABOVE, AND
GROANING

FAINTER STILL, HE HEARD THE VOICE: ... I SMELL BLEED, ... I SMELL
BLEED!

HIS STOMACH LURCHED

IT'S GOING TO KILL SOMEONE! HE SHOUTED, AND IGNORING REN'S AND
HERMIONE'S BEMUSED FACES, HE RAN UP THE NEXT FLIGHT OF STEPS
THREE AT A

TIME, TRYING TO LISTEN OVER HIS OWN POUNDING HEARTBEAT

HARRY FLUTTERED AROUND THE CORNER OF THE SECOND FLOOR, REN AND
HERMIONE

PARTING BEHIND HIM, NOT STOPPING UNTIL THEY TURNED A CORNER
INTO THE LAST,

DESERTED PASSAGE.

HARRY, WHAT WAS THAT ALL ABOUT? SAID REN, WIPING SWEAT FROM HIS
FACE. I

COULDN'T HEAR ANYTHING...

BUT HERMIONE GAVE A SUDDEN GASP, POINTING DOWN THE CORRIDOR.

BLEED!

SOMETHING WAS SHINING ON THE WALL AHEAD. THEY APPROACHED
SILENTLY,

SEELING THROUGH THE DARKNESS, FEET-HIGH WERDS HAD BEEN BALKE
HEN THE

WALL BETWEEN THE WINDERS, SHIMMERING IN THE LIGHT CAST BY THE
FLAMING

THEIR.

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS HAS BEEN OPENED, ENEMIES OF
THE

FOR, BLANK.

WHAT IS THAT THING HANGING UNDERNEATH? SAID BEN, A SLIGHT
ELIVER IN

HIS VEHICLE.

AS THEY EDGED NEARER, HARRY ALMOST SLIPPED THERE WAS A LARGE
PLIDDLE

OF WATER IN THE PLUM; BEN AND HERMIONE GRABBED HIM, AND THEY
INCHED

THEYARD THE MESSAGE, EYES FIXED ON A DARK SHADEW BENEATH IT. ALL
THREE OF

THEY REALIZED WHAT IT WAS AT ONCE, AND LEAPT BACKWARD WITH A
SPLASH.

MRS. NEHRIS, THE CARETAKER'S CAT, WAS HANGING BY HER TAIL FROM THE
THEIR

BRACKET. SHE WAS STIFF AS A BOARD, HER EYES WIDE AND STARING.

FOR A FEW SECONDS, THEY DIDN'T MOVE. THEN BEN SAID, LET'S GET HELT
OF

HERE.

SHOULDN'T WE TRY AND HELP HARRY BEGAN ALREADY.

TRUST ME, SAID REIN. WE DIDN'T WANT THEM HERE,
BUT IT WAS TOO LATE. A RUMBLE, AS THOUGH AN DISTANT THUNDER, TOLD
THEM

THAT THE FEAST HAD JUST ENDED, FROM EITHER END OF THE CORRIDOR
WHERE THEY

STEPPED CAME THE SOUND OF HUNDREDS OF FEET CLIMBING THE STAIRS, AND
THEY HEARD,

HAPPY TALK OF WELL-FED PEOPLE; NEXT MOMENT, STUDENTS WERE
CRASHING INTO

THE PASSAGE FROM BOTH ENDS.

THE CHATTER, THE RUSTLE, THE NOISE DIED SUDDENLY AS THE PEOPLE IN
FRONT

SPOTTED THE HANGING CAT, HARRY, REIN, AND HERMIONE STEPPED AHEAD,
IN THE

MIDDLE OF THE CORRIDOR, AS SILENCE FELL AMONG THE MASS OF STUDENTS
PRESSING

FORWARD TO SEE THE GRISLY SIGHT.

THEN SOMEONE SPELLED THROUGH THE MIST.

ENEMIES OF THE FAIR, BEWARE! DEATH IS NEXT, MURDERERS!

IT WAS DRAGON MALFOY, HE HAD PUSHED THE FRONT OF THE CROWD, HIS
HAND

EYES ALIVE, HIS USUALLY BLEEDLESS FACE FLUSHED, AS HE GRINNED AT THE
SIGHT OF

THE HANGING, IMMENSE CAT.

Q

CHAPTER NINE

THE WRITING ON THE WALL

WHAT IS GOING ON HERE? WHAT IS GOING ON?

ATTRACTED AND DILLECT BY MALPHE'S SILENT, ARGUS FILCH CAME

STUMBLED HIS WAY THROUGH THE CROWD, THEN HE SAW MRS. DUMBLEDORE AND FELL

BACK, CLUTCHING HIS FACE IN PAIN.

MY CAT! MY CAT! WHAT IS HAPPENING TO MRS. DUMBLEDORE? HE SCREAMED, AND HIS POPPING EYES FELL ON HARRY.

YES! HE SCREAMED, YES! YES! YOU MURDERED MY CAT! YES! YOU KILLED HER!

I WILL KILL YOU! I WILL

ARGUS!

DUMBLEDORE HAD ARRIVED ON THE SCENE, FOLLOWED BY A NUMBER OF OTHER TEACHERS. IN SECONDS, HE HAD SWIFT PAST HARRY, RON, AND HERMION AND

DETACHED MRS. DUMBLEDORE FROM THE TIGHT GRAB.

COME WITH ME, ARGUS, HE SAID THE FILCH. YES, THEN, MR. POTTER, MR. WEASLEY, MISS GRANGER.

DUMBLEDORE STEPPED FORWARD RABLY.

MY OFFICE IS NEAREST, HEADMASTER JUST UPSTAIRS PLEASE FEEL FREE

THANK YOU, GILBERT, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

THE SILENT CROWD PARTED TO LET THEM PASS, DUMBLEDORE, LOOKING EXCITED AND

IMPORTANT, HURRIED AFTER DUMBLEDORE; SHE DID PROFESSORS
MCGONAGALL AND

SNAPE.

AS THEY ENTERED LUCIFART'S DARKENED OFFICE THERE WAS A FLURRY OF
MOVEMENT ACROSS THE WALLS; HARRY SAW SEVERAL OF THE LUCIFARTS
IN THE

PICTURES HIDING OUT OF SIGHT, THEIR HAIR IN ROLLERS. THE REAL
LUCIFART LIT THE

CANDLES IN HIS DESK AND STOOD BACK. DUMBLEDORE LAID MRS. NEHRIS IN
THE

POLISHED SURFACE AND BEGAN TO EXAMINE HER. HARRY, RON, AND
HERMIONIE

EXCHANGED TENSE GLANCES AND SANK INTO CHAIRS OUTSIDE THE POOL OF
CANDLELIGHT,

WATCHING.

THE TIP OF DUMBLEDORE'S LONG, CREASED NOSE WAS BARELY AN INCH
FROM

MRS. NEHRIS'S FLIP. HE WAS LOOKING AT HER CLOSELY THROUGH HIS
HALF-MOON

SPECTACLES, HIS LONG FINGERS GENTLY PRESSING AND PEEKING.
PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL WAS BENT ALMOST AS CLOSE, HER EYES NARROWED. SNAPE
LEERED

BEHIND THEM, HALF IN SHADE, WEARING A MOST PECULIAR EXPRESSION;
IT WAS AS

THOUGH HE WAS TRYING HARD NOT TO SMILE. AND LUCIFART WAS
HURRYING AROUND

ALL OF THEM, MAKING SUGGESTIONS.

IT WAS DEFINITELY A CLUSE THAT KILLED HER PREHABLY THE
TRANSMIGRIAN

TURTLE I'VE SEEN IT USED MANY TIMES, SHE LIKELY I WASN'T THERE, I KNOW

THE VERY COUNTEREASE THAT WOULD HAVE SAVED HER, ...

LEONHART'S COMMENTS WERE PLACATED BY FILCH'S DRY, RACKING SNEEZE

WAS SLUMPED IN A CHAIR BY THE DESK, UNABLE TO LEAN AT MRS. NERVIS, HIS FACE

IN HIS HANDS, MUCH AS HE DETESTED FILCH, HARRY COULDN'T HELP FEELING A BIT

SHRUG FOR HIM, THOUGH NOT NEARLY AS SHRUG AS HE FELT FOR HIMSELF, IF

OLMPEDERE BELIEVED FILCH, HE WOULD BE EXPELLED FOR SURE.

OLMPEDERE WAS NOW MUTTERING STRANGE WORDS UNDER HIS BREATH AND

TAPPING MRS. NERVIS WITH HIS HAND, BUT NOTHING HAPPENED; SHE CONTINUED

THE WORDS AS THOUGH SHE HAD BEEN RECENTLY STUPID.

... I REMEMBER SOMETHING VERY SIMILAR HAPPENING IN ELIACADICHEL,

SAID LEONHART, A SERIES OF ATTACKS, THE FULL STORY'S IN MY AUTOBIOGRAPHY, I

WAS ABLE TO PROVIDE THE THINGS WITH VARIOUS AMULETS, WHICH CLEARED THE

MATTER UP AT ONCE, ...

THE PHOTOGRAPHS OF LEONHART ON THE WALLS WERE ALL NODDING IN AGREEMENT AS HE TALKED, ONE OF THEM HAD FORGOTTEN TO REMOVE HIS HAIR NET,

AT LAST OLMPEDERE STRAIGHTENED UP,

SHE'S NOT DEAD, ANGUS, HE SAID SMILY,

LEICHHART STEPPED ABRUPTLY IN THE MIDDLE OF CELEBRATING THE NUMBER
OF

MURDERS HE HAD PREVENTED.

NOT DEAD? CHECKED FILCH, LEERING THROUGH HIS FINGERS AT MRS.
NEHRIS.

BUT WHY? SHE ALL ALL STIFF AND FREEZEN?

SHE HAS BEEN PETRIFIED, SAID DUMBLEDORE. AH? I THOUGHT SHE SAID
LEICHHART!. BUT WELL, I CANNOT SAY. . .

ASK HIM? STRIKED FILCH, TURNING HIS BLEETCHED AND TEARSTAINED
FACE TO

HARRY.

THE SECOND YEAR CHILD HAVE DONE THIS, SAID DUMBLEDORE FIRMLY. IT
WOULD TAKE DARK MAGIC OF THE MOST ADVANCED

HE DID IT, HE DID IT? FILCH SPAT, HIS PEELED FACE PURPLING. WELL
SAY

WHAT HE WROTE ON THE WALL? HE FEELING IN MY OFFICE HE KNOWS
I M A

I M A FILCH'S FACE WHISKED HORRIBLY. HE KNOWS I M A SERPENT? HE
FINISHED.

I NEVER THOUGHT MRS. NEHRIS? HARRY SAID LAUDLY, LINCHPOHRTABLY
ALARE

OF EVERYONE LEERING AT HIM, INCLUDING ALL THE LEICHHARTS ON THE
WALLS. AND

I DIDN'T EVEN KNOW WHAT A SERPENT IS.

BLINKING? SNARLED FILCH. HE SAW MY BLINDSPELL LETTER?

IF I MIGHT SPEAK, HEADMASTER, SAID SNAPE FROM THE SHADOWS, AND
HARRY'S SENSE OF ANTHROPODING INCREASED; HE WAS SURE NOTHING SNAPE
HAD THE

SAY WAS GOING TO SEE HIM AND GIVE,

PETER AND HIS FRIENDS MAY HAVE SIMPLY BEEN IN THE WRONG PLACE
AT THE

WRONG TIME, HE SAID, A SLIGHT SMILE CURLING HIS MOUTH AS THOUGH HE

DELETED IT. BUT WE DO HAVE A SET OF SUSPICIOUS CIRCUMSTANCES HERE.
WHY

WAS HE IN THE UPSTAIRS HALLWAY AT ALL? WHY WASN'T HE AT THE
HALLOWEEN

FEAST?

HARRY, RON AND HERMION ALL LAUNCHED INTO AN EXPLANATION
ABOUT THE

BIRTHDAY PARTY. ... THERE WERE HUNDREDS OF GHOSTS, THEY WOULD TELL YOU
WE

WERE THERE

BUT WHY NOT JOIN THE FEAST AFTERWARD? SAID SNAPE, HIS BLACK EYES
GLITTERING IN THE CANDLELIGHT. WHY GO UP THE STAIRS?
RON AND HERMION LOOKED AT HARRY,

BECAUSE BECAUSE HARRY SAID, HIS HEART THUMPING VERY FAST;
SOMETHING TOLD HIM IT WOULD SOUND VERY FAR-FETCHED IF HE TOLD THEM
HE HAD

BEEN LED THERE BY A RIDICULOUS VOICE AND HE BUT HE COULD HEAR, BECAUSE
WE

WERE TIRED AND WANTED TO GO TO BED, HE SAID.

WITHOUT ANY SLIPPER? SAID SNAPE, A TRIUMPHANT SMILE FLICKERING
ACROSS

HIS CALM FACE. I DIDN'T THINK GHOSTS PROVIDED FOOD FIT FOR LIVING
PEOPLE AT

THEIR PARTIES.

WE WEREN'T HUNGRY, SAID RON BOLDLY AS HIS STOMACH GAVE A FLICK

BLINKLE.

SNAPE'S NASTY SMILE WIDENED.

I SUGGEST, HEADMASTER, THAT PETER IS NOT BEING ENTIRELY
TRUTHFUL. HE

SAID. IT MIGHT BE A GOOD IDEA IF HE WERE DEPRIVED OF CERTAIN
PRIVILEGES

UNTIL HE IS READY TO TELL US THE WHOLE STORY. I PERSONALLY FEEL HE
SHOULD BE

TAKEN OFF THE GRYFFINDOR CHLIDITCH TEAM UNTIL HE IS READY TO BE
HONEST.

REALLY, SEVERUS, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SHARPLY, I SEE NO
REASON

TO STOP THE KID PLAYING CHLIDITCH. THIS CAT WASN'T HIT OVER THE
HEAD WITH A

BROOMSTICK. THERE IS NO EVIDENCE AT ALL THAT PETER HAS DONE
ANYTHING

WRONG.

DUMBLEDORE WAS GIVING HARRY A SEARCHING LOOK. HIS TWINKLING
LIGHT-BLUE

GAZE MADE HARRY FEEL AS THOUGH HE WERE BEING X-RAYED.

INNOCENT UNTIL PROVEN GUILTY, SEVERUS, HE SAID FIRMLY.

SNAPE LOOKED FLURRIED. SHE DID FLICK.

MY CAT HAS BEEN PETRIED? HE SHRIEKED, HIS EYES POPPING. I WANT
THE

SEE SOME PUNISHMENT?

WE WILL BE ABLE TO CURE HER, ANGUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE PATIENTLY.

PROFESSOR SPRELLT RECENTLY MANAGED TO PRELUCE SOME MANDRAKES,
AS SHEEN

AS THEY HAVE REACHED THEIR FULL SIZE, I WILL HAVE A POTION MADE THAT WILL

REVIVE MRS. DUMBLEDORE.

I'LL MAKE IT, LUCIFER HISSED IN. I MUST HAVE DONE IT A HUNDRED TIMES.

I COULD WHIP UP A MANDRAGE RESTORATIVE DRAUGHT IN MY SLEEP

EXCUSE ME, SAID SNAPE ICILY, BUT I BELIEVE I AM THE POTION'S MASTER AT

THIS SCHOOL.

THERE WAS A VERY ALLEGED PALSE.

THEY MAY GO, DUMBLEDORE SAID THE HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE.

THEY WENT, AS QUICKLY AS THEY COULD WITHOUT ACTUALLY RUNNING. WHEN

THEY WERE A FEET UP FROM LUCIFER'S OFFICE, THEY TURNED INTO AN EMPTY

CLASSROOM AND CLOSED THE DOOR QUIETLY BEHIND THEM. HARRY SHOOK AT HIS

FRIENDS' DARKENED FACES.

DID YOU THINK I SHOULD HAVE TOLD THEM ABOUT THAT VOICE I HEARD?

NO, SAID RON, WITHOUT HESITATION. HEARING VOICES IS ONE ELSE CAN HEAR

ISN'T A GOOD SIGN, EVEN IN THE WIZARDING WORLD.

SOMETHING IN RON'S VOICE MADE HARRY ASK, DID YOU BELIEVE ME, DIDN'T

YOU?

COURSE I DO, SAID RON QUICKLY, BUT YOU MUST ADMIT IT'S WEIRD...

I KNOW IT'S WEIRD, SAID HARRY. THE WHOLE THING'S WEIRD, WHAT WAS THAT

WRITING ON THE WALL ABOUT? THE CHAMBER HAS BEEN OPENED, ... WHAT'S THAT

SLIPPED THE MEAN?

WELL, KNOW, IT RINGS A BELL OF BELL, SAID RON SILENTLY. I THINK SOMETHING

TELL ME A STORY ABOUT A SECRET CHAMBER AT HOGWARTS MIGHT ... MIGHT BE

BEEN KILL, ...

AND WHAT ON EARTH'S A SNEAK? SAID HARRY.

THE HIS SURPRISE, RON STIFLED A SNIGGLE.

WELL IT'S NOT ALREADY REALLY BUT AS IT'S FILCH, HE SAID, A SNEAK IS

SOMETHING WHICH WAS KNOWN INTO A WIZARDING FAMILY BUT HADN'T GOTTEN ANY MAGIC

POWERS. KIND OF THE OPPOSITE OF MUGGLE-BORN WIZARDS, BUT SNEAKS ARE ELITE

UNUSUAL. IF FILCH'S TRYING TO LEARN MAGIC FROM A BLOOD-DRINKER CHILD, I RECKON

HE MUST BE A SNEAK. IT WOULD EXPLAIN A LOT, LIKE WHY HE HATES STUDENTS WHO

MILK. RON GAVE A SATISFIED SMILE. HE'S BITTER.

A CUCKER CHIMED SOMEWHERE.

MIDNIGHT, SAID HARRY. WE'D BETTER GET THE RED BATHROOM SNAP CHIMES ALONG AND TRY THE FRAME LIES FOR SOMETHING ELSE.

FOR A FEW DAYS, THE SCHOOL CHILD TALKED OF LITTLE ELSE BUT THE ATTACK ON MRS.

DEERIS. FILCH KEPT IT FRESH IN EVERYONE'S MINDS BY PACING THE SPEECH WHERE

SHE HAD BEEN ATTACKED, AS THOUGH HE THOUGHT THE ATTACKER MIGHT
COME BACK.

HARRY HAD SEEN HIM SCRIBBLING THE MESSAGE IN THE WALL WITH MRS.
SPRINGER'S

ALL-PURPOSE MAGICAL MESS REMOVER, BUT THE NEW EFFECT; THE WORDS
STILL

GLARED AS BRIGHTLY AS EVER IN THE STONE. WHEN FILCH WASN'T
GUARDING THE

SCENE OF THE CRIME, HE WAS SKULKING RED-EYED THROUGH THE
CORRIDORS,

LINGERING HINT AT UNSUSPECTING STUDENTS AND TRYING TO PUT THEM IN
DETENTION

FOR THINGS LIKE BREATHING LOUDLY AND SMILING HAPPY.

CINNY WEASLEY SEEMED VERY DISTURBED BY MRS. SPRINGER'S FATE.
ACCORDING

TO HER, SHE WAS A GREAT CAT LOVER.

BUT SHE HADN'T REALLY MET THE DEAR MRS. SPRINGER. HER TALK
BRACELY. HONESTLY, WE'RE MUCH BETTER OFF WITHOUT HER. CINNY'S
LIP

TREMLED. STUFF LIKE THIS DOESN'T OFTEN HAPPEN AT HOGWARTS. HER
ASSURED

HER. THEY'LL CATCH THE MANIAC WHEN HE DOES IT AND HAVE HIM OUT OF
HERE IN NO

TIME. I JUST HOPE HE'S GET TIME THE PETRIFF FILCH BEFORE HE'S EXPELLED.
I'M

ONLY THINKING HER ADDING HASTILY AS CINNY BLANCHED.

THE ATTACK HAD ALSO HAD AN EFFECT ON HERMION. IT WAS WHITE
LISIAL FOR

HERMION SHE SPEND A LOT OF TIME READING, BUT SHE WAS NOW BEING
ALMOST

NOTHING ELSE. HER CHILD HARRY AND REN GET MUCH RESPONSE FROM HER WHEN

THEY ASKED WHAT SHE WAS UP TO, AND NOT UNTIL THE FOLLOWING WEDNESDAY DID

THEY FIND OUT.

HARRY HAD BEEN HELD BACK IN PENTHERS, WHERE SNAPE HAD MADE HIM STAY

BEHIND THE SCRAPES TWELFTHS OFF THE DESKS. AFTER A FLURRIED LUNCH, HE WENT

UPSTAIRS TO MEET REN IN THE LIBRARY, AND SAW IUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHLEY, THE

FLURFLUFF BOY FROM HERKLELEY, CREEPING TOWARD HIM. HARRY HAD JUST

OPENED HIS MOUTH TO SAY HELLO WHEN IUSTIN CAUGHT SIGHT OF HIM, TURNED

ABRUPTLY, AND SPED OFF IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION.

HARRY FEELING REN AT THE BACK OF THE LIBRARY, MEASURING HIS HISTORY OF

MAGIC HEMLOCK. PROFESSOR KINNS HAD ASKED HER A THREE-FEET-LENG

COMPOSITION ON THE MEDICAL ASSEMBLY OF EUROPEAN WIZARDS.

I DON'T BELIEVE IT, I'M STILL EIGHT INCHES SHORT,... SAID REN FLURRILLY,

LETTING GO OF HIS PARCHEMENT, WHICH SPRANG BACK INTO A ROLL. AND

HERMIONE'S DUNE FEELER FEET SEVEN INCHES AND HER WRITING'S TINY.

WHERE IS SHE? ASKED HARRY, GRABBING THE TAPE MEASURE AND UNROLLING

HIS ELAN HEMLOCK.

SOMEWHERE OVER THERE, SAID REN, POINTING ALONG THE SHELVES.

LOOKING FOR ANOTHER BOOK, I THINK SHE'S TRYING TO READ THE
WHEEL LIBRARY
BEFORE CHRISTMAS.

HARRY TOLD RON ABOUT JUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHER RUNNING AWAY FROM
HIM.

BLINDLY WHY WOULD CARE, I THOUGHT HE WAS A BIT OF AN IDIOT, SAID
RON,

STRIKING AWAY, MAKING HIS WRITING AS LARGE AS POSSIBLE. ALL THAT
INDICATES

ABOUT BOOKSHELF BEING THE GREAT

HERMIONIE EMERGED FROM BETWEEN THE BOOKSHELVES. SHE LOOKED
IRRITABLE

AND AT LAST SEEMED READY TO TALK TO THEM.

ALL THE COPIES OF THE GILBERTS: A HISTORY HAVE BEEN TAKEN OUT,
SHE SAID,

SITTING DOWN NEXT TO HARRY AND RON. AND THERE'S A TWO-WEEK
WAITING LIST. I

WISH I HADN'T LEFT MY COPY AT HOME, BUT I COULDN'T FIT IT IN MY
TRUNK WITH

ALL THE BOOKSHELF BOOKS.

WHY DO YOU WANT IT? SAID HARRY.

THE SAME REASON EVERYONE ELSE WANTS IT, SAID HERMIONIE, TO READ
UP

ON THE LEGEND OF THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS.

WHAT'S THAT? SAID HARRY QUICKLY.

THAT'S JUST IT, I CAN'T REMEMBER, SAID HERMIONIE, BITING HER LIP.
AND I

CAN'T FIND THE STORY ANYWHERE ELSE

HERMIONIE, LET ME READ YOUR COMPOSITION, SAID RON DESPERATELY,

CHECKING HIS WATCH,

WHEN I WHEN T, SAID HERMINE, SUDDENLY SEVERE. YOU'VE HAD TEN
DAYS THE

FINISH IT

I ONLY NEED ANOTHER TWO INCHES, CAME HE

THE BELL RANG, REIN AND HERMINE LED THE WAY THE HISTORY OF MAGIC,
KICKING.

HISTORY OF MAGIC WAS THE Dullest SUBJECT IN THEIR SCHEDULE,
PROFESSOR

KINGS, WHEN TAUGHT IT, WAS THEIR ONLY GHOST TEACHER, AND THE MOST
EXCITING

THING THAT EVER HAPPENED IN HIS CLASSES WAS HIS ENTERING THE
ROOM THROUGH

THE BLACKBOARD, ANCIENT AND STRIVEL, MANY PEOPLE SAID HE HADN'T
NOTICED

HE WAS DEAD, HE HAD SIMPLY GOTTEN UP THE TRICK ONE DAY AND LEFT HIS
BODY

BEHIND HIM IN AN ARMCHAIR IN FRONT OF THE STAFFROOM FIRE; HIS
RELATIVE HAD

NOT VARIED IN THE SLIGHTEST SINCE.

TODAY WAS AS BIRING AS EVER, PROFESSOR KINGS OPENED HIS BOOKS
AND

BEGAN TO READ IN A FLAT DRONE LIKE AN OLD VACUUM CLEANER UNTIL
NEARLY

EVERYONE IN THE CLASS WAS IN A DEEP SLUMBER, OCCASIONALLY CHIRING
THE LONG

ENOUGH TO COPY DOWN A NAME OR DATE, THEN FALLING ASLEEP AGAIN,
HE HAD

BEEN SPREADING HER HALF AN EILIN WHEN SOMETHING HAPPENED THAT
HAD NEVER

HAPPENED BEFORE, HERMINE PUT UP HER HAND,

PROFESSOR KINGS, GLANCING UP IN THE MIDDLE OF A DEADLY DULL LECTURE
HIN

THE INTERNATIONAL WARDLOCK CONVENTION OF 1287, LOOKED AMAZED,

MISS ER ?

GRANGER, PROFESSOR, I WAS WONDERING IF YOU COULD TELL US
ANYTHING ABOUT

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, SAID HERMINE IN A CLEAR VOICE,

DEAN THOMAS, WHO HAD BEEN SITTING WITH HIS MOUTH HANGING OPEN,

GAZING OUT OF THE WINDOW, JERKED OUT OF HIS TRANCE; LAVENDER
BRENN'S HEAD

CAME UP OFF HER ARMS AND NEVILLE SLINGBOTTEN'S EYES SLIPPED OFF
HIS

DESK,

PROFESSOR KINGS BLINKED,

MY SUBJECT IS HISTORY OF MAGIC, HE SAID IN HIS DRY, WHEEZY VOICE,
I

DEAL WITH FACTS, MISS GRANGER, NOT MYTHS AND LEGENDS. HE CLEARED
HIS

THROAT WITH A SMALL NOISE LIKE CHALK SNAPPING AND CONTINUED, IN

SEPTEMBER OF THAT YEAR, A SLICHTMITTER OF SARDINIAN SHREKERS

HE STUTTERED TO A HALT, HERMINE'S HAND WAS LAYING IN THE AIR
AGAIN,

MISS GRANT?

PLEASE, SIR, DON'T LEGENDS ALWAYS HAVE A BASIS IN FACT?

PROFESSOR KINGS WAS LOOKING AT HER IN SUCH AMAZEMENT, HARRY
WAS SURE

NONE STUDENT HAD EVER INTERRUPTED HIM BEFORE, ALIVE OR DEAD.

WELL, SAID PROFESSOR KINGS SILENTLY, YES, ONE CHILD ABOVE THAT, I
SUPPOSE. HE PEERED AT HERMIONE AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER SEEN A
STUDENT

PROPERLY BEFORE. HOWEVER, THE LEGEND OF WHICH SHE SPEAKS IS SUCH
A VERY

SENSATIONAL, EVEN LUDICROUS TALE

BUT THE WHOLE CLASS WAS NOW HANGING ON PROFESSOR KINGS'S EVERY
WORD.

HE LOOKED DIMLY AT THEM ALL, EVERY FACE TURNED TO HIS. HARRY COULD
TELL HE

WAS COMPLETELY THROWN BY SUCH AN UNUSUAL SHOW OF INTEREST.

EH, VERY WELL, HE SAID SILENTLY. LET ME SEE . . . THE CHAMBER OF
SECRETS . . .

SHE ALL KNEW, OF COURSE, THAT HOGWARTS WAS FOUNDED OVER A
THOUSAND

YEARS AGO THE PRECISE DATE IS UNCERTAIN BY THE FEW GREATEST
WITCHES

AND WIZARDS OF THE AGE. THE FEW SEVEN HOUSES ARE NAMED AFTER
THEM:

GODRIC GOFFINDOR, HERICA HUFFLEPUFF, ROLANDA RAVENCLAW, AND
SALAZAR

SLYTHERIN. THEY BUILT THIS CASTLE TOGETHER, FAR FROM PRYING
MUGGLE EYES, AND

IT WAS AN AGE WHEN MAGIC WAS FEARED BY COMMON PEOPLE, AND WITCHES
AND

WIZARDS SUFFERED MUCH PERSECUTION.

HE PAUSED, GAZED CLEARLY AROUND THE ROOM, AND CONTINUED.

FOR A FEW YEARS, THE PHOENIXES LIVED IN HARMONY TOGETHER,
SEEKING HLT

PHOENIXES WERE SHOWN SIGNS OF MAGIC AND BRINGING THEM TO THE
CASTLE THE

BE EDUCATED, BUT THEN DISAGREEMENTS SPRANG UP BETWEEN THEM, A RIFT
BEGAN

THE GROW BETWEEN SLYTHERIN AND THE OTHERS, SLYTHERIN WISHED THE BE
MORE

SELECTIVE ABOUT THE STUDENTS ADMITTED TO HOGWARTS, HE BELIEVED
THAT

MAGICAL LEARNING SHOULD BE KEPT WITHIN ALL-MAGIC FAMILIES, HE
DISLIKED

TAKING STUDENTS OF MISCLE PARENTAGE, BELIEVING THEM TO BE
UNWORTHY.

AFTER A WHILE, THERE WAS A SERIOUS ARGUMENT IN THE SILENT
BETWEEN

SLYTHERIN AND GRYFFINDOR, AND SLYTHERIN LEFT THE SCHOOL.

PROFESSOR KINGS PALSED AGAIN, PURSING HIS LIPS, LOOKING LIKE A
WRINKLED

HAD THEREFORE.

RELIABLE HISTORICAL SOURCES TELL US THIS MUCH, HE SAID, BUT THESE
FINEST FACTS HAVE BEEN MISLEAD BY THE FANCFUL LEGEND OF THE
CHAMBER OF

SECRETS. THE STORY GOES THAT SLYTHERIN HAD BUILT A HIDDEN CHAMBER
IN THE

CASTLE, OF WHICH THE OTHER PHOENIXES KNEW NOTHING.

SLYTHERIN, ACCORDING TO THE LEGEND, SEALED THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS
SO

THAT NONE WOULD BE ABLE TO OPEN IT UNTIL HIS HEIR TOOK HIS
ARRIVED AT THE

SCHEEL. THE FAIR ALONE WOULD BE ABLE TO UNSEAL THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS,

UNLEASH THE HORROR WITHIN, AND USE IT TO PURGE THE SCHEEL OF ALL WHO WERE

UNWORTHY OF THE STARRY MAGIC.

THERE WAS SILENCE AS HE FINISHED TELLING THE STORY, BUT IT WASN'T THE USUAL,

SLEEPY SILENCE THAT FILLED PROFESSOR KINN'S CLASSES. THERE WAS UNREST IN

THE AIR AS EVERYONE CONTINUED TO WATCH HIM, HOPING FOR MORE. PROFESSOR

KINN'S LOOKED FAINTLY ANNOYED.

THE WHOLE THING IS ARRANT NONSENSE, HE CHURSE, HE SAID. NATURALLY, THE

SCHEEL HAS BEEN SEARCHED FOR EVIDENCE OF SUCH A CHAMBER, MANY TIMES, BY

THE MOST LEARNED WITCHES AND WIZARDS. IT DOES NOT EXIST. A TALE TOLD TO

FRIGHTEN THE GULLIBLE.

BERMINE'S HAND WAS BACK IN THE AIR.

SIR WHAT EXACTLY DO YOU MEAN BY THE HORROR WITHIN THE CHAMBER?

THAT IS BELIEVED TO BE SOME SORT OF MINSTER, WHICH THE FAIR OF SLOTHERIN ALONE CAN CONTROL, SAID PROFESSOR KINN IN HIS DRY, REBBY VOICE.

THE CLASS EXCHANGED NERVIOUS LOOKS.

I TELL YOU, THE THING DOES NOT EXIST, SAID PROFESSOR KINN, SHAKING HIS

HEADS. THERE IS NO CHAMBER AND NO MINSTER.

BLIT, SIR, SAID SEAMUS FINNIGAN, IF THE CHAMBER CAN ONLY BE
OPENED

BY SLYTHERIN'S TRICK HEIR, NO ONE ELSE WOULD BE ABLE TO FIND IT, WOULD
THEY?

NONSENSE, HE FLAHERTY, SAID PROFESSOR KINNS IN AN AGGRAVATED
TONE. IF

A LONG SUCCESSION OF HOGWARTS HEADMASTERS AND HEADMISTRESSES
HAVEN'T

FOUND THE THING

BLIT, PROFESSOR, PIPED UP PARYATI PATIL, WHO'D PROBABLY HAVE THE
USE

DARK MAGIC TO OPEN IT

JUST BECAUSE A WIZARD DOESN'T USE DARK MAGIC DOESN'T MEAN HE
CAN'T,

MISS PENDLEFEATHER, SNAPPED PROFESSOR KINNS, I REPEAT, IF THE
LIVES OF

BLIMPEDHERE

BLIT MAYBE WHO'VE GOTTEN TO BE RELATED TO SLYTHERIN, SEE BLIMPEDHERE
CHILDREN TO REGAN DEAN THOMAS, BLIT PROFESSOR KINNS HAD HAD
ENOUGH.

THAT WILL DO, HE SAID SHARPLY. IT IS A MYTH! IT DOES NOT EXIST!
THERE IS

NOT A SHRED OF EVIDENCE THAT SLYTHERIN EVER EXISTED SUCH AS A
SECRET ROOM

CLIPBOARD! I REGRET TELLING WHO SUCH A FOOLISH STORY! WE WILL
RETURN, IF WHO

PLEASE, THE HISTORY, THE SOUND, RELIABLE, VERIFIABLE FACT!

AND WITHIN FIVE MINUTES, THE CLASS HAD SLID BACK INTO ITS USUAL
THROPEL.

I ALWAYS KNEW SALAZAR SLYTHERIN WAS A TWISTED OLD LIEKIN', BEEN
THEO HARRY

AND HERMIONE AS THEY FUGHT THEIR WAY THROUGH THE TORMING
CORRIDORS AT

THE END OF THE LESSON THE DREIF OFF THEIR BAGS BEFORE DINNER, BUT I
NEVER

KNEW HE STARTED ALL THIS PURE-BLOOD STUFF, I WOULDNT T BE IN HIS
FELISE IF YELL

PAID ME, HONESTLY, IF THE SHITTING HAT HAD TRIED THE PLT ME IN
SLYTHERIN,

I D VE GHT THE TRAIN STRAIGHT BACK HOME. . . .

HERMIONE NEEDED PERVENTLY, BUT HARRY DIDNT T SAY ANYTHING, HIS
STOMACH

HAD JUST DREPPED UNPLEASANTLY,

HARRY HAD NEVER THEO BEEN AND HERMIONE THAT THE SHITTING HAT
HAD

SERIOUSLY CONSIDERED PLTTING HIM IN SLYTHERIN, HE COULD REMEMBER,
AS

THOUGH IT WERE YESTERDAY, THE SMALL VEHICLE THAT HAD SPEDEN IN HIS
EAR WHEN

HE D PLACED THE HAT ON HIS HEAD A YEAR BEFORE: YELL COULD BE GREAT,
YELL

KNEW, IT S ALL HERE IN YELLER HEAD, AND SLYTHERIN WOULD HELP YELL ON
THE WAY THE

GREATNESS, NEH DEHLET ABHUT THAT. . . .

BUT HARRY, WHO HAD ALREADY HEARD OF SLYTHERIN FELISE S
REPLTATION FOR

TURNING HLT DARK WIZARDS, HAD THUGHT DESPERATELY, NEET
SLYTHERIN? AND THE

HAT HAD SAID, HEH, WELL, IF YELL RE SURE . . . BETTER BE GRAY INDEED. . . .

AS THEY WERE SHUNTED ALONG IN THE TRENCH, CELIN CREEPY WENT PAST.

HIDA, HARRY?

HELLO, CELIN, SAID HARRY ALTERNATIVELY.

HARRY HARRY A KID IN MY CLASS HAS BEEN SAYING YELL RE BUT CELIN WAS SEE SMALL HE CHILDEN T FIGHT AGAINST THE TIDE OF PEOPLE BEARING HIM TOWARD THE GREAT HALL; THEY HEARD HIM SHLEAK, SEE YELL,

HARRY? AND HE WAS GONE.

WHAT S A KID IN HIS CLASS SAYING ABELT YELL? HERMININE WANDERED.

THAT I M SLYTHERIN S KID, I EXPECT, SAID HARRY, HIS STOMACH DROPPING

ANOTHER INCH FOR SEE AS HE SLIDENLY REMEMBERED THE WAY JUSTIN FINCH

FLETCHER HAD RUN AWAY FROM HIM AT BLINK-TIME.

PEOPLE HERE LL BELIEVE ANYTHING, SAID RHN IN DISBELIT.

THE CREED THINNED AND THEY WERE ABLE TO CLIMB THE NEXT STAIRCASE WITHOUT DIFFICULTY.

D YELL REALLY THINK THERE S A CHAMBER OF SECRETS? RHN ASKED HERMININE.

I DONT KNOW, SHE SAID, PREHENSIVE. SOMEWHERE CHILDEN T CLIMB MRS. DERRIS, AND THAT MAKES ME THINK THAT WHATEVER ATTACKED HER MIGHT MEET EE

WELL FILMAN.

AS SHE SPED, THEY TURNED A CORNER AND FOUND THEMSELVES AT THE
END OF

THE VERY HALLWAY WHERE THE ATTACK HAD HAPPENED. THEY STOPPED
AND LISTENED.

THE SCENE WAS JUST AS IT HAD BEEN THAT NIGHT, EXCEPT THAT THERE
WAS NO STIFF

WALL HANGING FROM THE TREE BRACKET, AND AN EMPTY CHAIR STOOD
AGAINST THE

WALL BEARING THE MESSAGE THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS HAD BEEN
OPENED.

THAT IS WHERE FILCH HAS BEEN KEEPING GUARD, RON MUTTERED.
THEY LISTENED AT EACH OTHER. THE HALLWAY WAS DESERTED.

CAN'T HEAR THEM HAVE A PHONE CONVERSATION, SAID HARRY, DROPPING HIS
BAG AND

GETTING UP HIS HANDS AND KNEES SO THAT HE COULD CRAWL ALONG,
SEARCHING FOR

CLUES.

SEARCH MARKS? HE SAID. HERE AND HERE

COME AND LOOK AT THIS? SAID HERMION. THIS IS FLIPPY...

HARRY GOT UP AND CROSSED TO THE WINDOW NEXT TO THE MESSAGE ON
THE WALL.

HERMION WAS POINTING AT THE THIRTIETH FLOOR, WHERE ABOUT
TWENTY SPIDERS

WERE SLITHERING, APPARENTLY FIGHTING TO GET THROUGH A SMALL CRACK.
A LONG,

SILVERY THREAD WAS DANGLING LIKE A ROPE, AS THOUGH THEY HAD ALL
CLIMBED IT

IN THEIR HURRY TO GET OUTSIDE.

HAVE YOU EVER SEEN SPIDERS ACT LIKE THAT? SAID HERMIONE WHISPERINGLY.

NO, SAID HARRY, HAVE YOU, RON? RON?

HE LOOKED OVER HIS SHOULDER, RON WAS STANDING WELL BACK AND SEEMED TO

BE FIGHTING THE IMPULSE TO RUN.

WHAT IS IT? SAID HARRY.

I DON'T LIKE SPIDERS, SAID RON TENSELY.

I NEVER KNEW THAT, SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING AT RON IN SURPRISE. YOU'VE

USED SPIDERS IN POTION'S LEADS OF TIMES, ...

I DON'T MIND THEM DEAD, SAID RON, WHO WAS CAREFULLY LOOKING ANYWHERE BUT AT THE WINDHILL. I JUST DON'T LIKE THE WAY THEY MOVE, . . .

HERMIONE GIGGLED.

IT'S NOT FUNNY, SAID RON, FIERCELY. IF YOU MUST KNOW, WHEN I WAS THREE,

FRED TURNED MY MY TEDDY BEAR INTO A GREAT BIG FILTHY SPIDER BECAUSE I

KNOCKED HIS THY BROOMSTICK, ... YOU WOULDN'T LIKE THEM EITHER IF YOU'D BEEN

HOLDING YOUR BEAR AND SUDDENLY IT HAD THREE HUNDRED LEGS AND ...

HE KROOK OFF, SLIDDERING, HERMIONE WAS HEAVILY STILL TRYING NOT TO

LAUGH, FEELING THEY HAD BETTER GET OFF THE SUBJECT, HARRY SAID, REMEMBER

ALL THAT WATER IN THE FLEET? WHERE DID THAT COME FROM? SOMEONE'S MURDERED

IT UP.

IT WAS ABSENT HERE, SAID RENN, RECOVERING HIMSELF THE WALK A FEW PACE

PAST FILCH'S CHAIR AND PHINTING, LEVEL WITH THIS DEER,

HE REACHED FOR THE BRASS ~~DEERDOOR~~ BUT SLIDDERLY WITHDREW HIS HAND AS

THOUGH HE'D BEEN BURNED.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? SAID FARRY,

CAN'T GET IN THERE, SAID RENN GRUFFLY. THAT'S A GIRL'S THING.

EH, RENN, THERE WON'T BE ANYONE IN THERE, SAID FERMINE, STANDING UP

AND CHIMPING OVER. THAT'S MEANING MORTLE'S PLACE, COME ON, LET'S HAVE A

LOOK.

AND IGNORING THE LARGE ELITE OF HORROR SIGN, SHE OPENED THE DEER,

IT WAS THE GLEAMIER, MOST DEPRESSING RATH-THAN FARRY HAD EVER SET FOOT

IN. UNDER A LARGE, CRACKED, AND SPOTTED MIRROR WERE A ROW OF CHIPPED SINKS,

THE FLOOR WAS DAMP AND REFLECTED THE DULL LIGHT GIVEN OFF BY THE STUBS OF A

FEW CANDLES, CLIPPING LIES IN THEIR HOLDERS; THE WOODEN DEERS THE THE STALLS

WERE FLAKING AND SCRATCHED AND ONE OF THEM WAS DANGLING OFF ITS HINGES,

FERMINE PLIT HER FINGERS THE HER LIPS AND SET OFF TOWARD THE END STALL,

WHEN SHE REACHED IT SHE SAID, HELLO, MORTLE, HOW ARE YOU?

HARRY AND REEN WENT THE LEHED, MEANING MYRTLE WAS FLEEING ABOVE
THE

TAKING UP THE THEILET, PICKING A SPOT IN HER CHIN.

THIS IS A GIRLS BATHROOM, SHE SAID, EYING REEN AND HARRY
SUSPICIOUSLY. THEY ARE NOT GIRLS.

NO, HERMIONE AGREED. I JUST WANTED TO SEE THEM FEEL FOR
NICE

IT IS IN HERE.

SHE WAVES VAGUELY AT THE DIRTY OLD MIRROR AND THE DAMP FLOOR.

ASK HER IF SHE SAW ANYTHING, HARRY MURMURED AT HERMIONE.

WHAT ARE YOU WHISPERING? SAID MYRTLE, STARING AT HIM.

NOTHING, SAID HARRY BLICKLY. WE WANTED TO ASK

I WISH PEOPLE WOULD STOP TALKING BEHIND MY BACK! SAID MYRTLE, IN
A

VOICE CRIMED WITH TEARS. I DO HAVE FEELINGS, YOU KNOW, EVEN IF I
AM DEAD

MYRTLE, SHE HERE WANTS THE LIPSET YOU, SAID HERMIONE. HARRY
ONLY

NO ONE WANTS THE LIPSET ME! THAT'S A GOOD ONE! HOWLED MYRTLE.
MY

LIFE WAS NOTHING BUT MISERY AT THIS PLACE AND NOW PEOPLE COME
ALONG

RUINING MY DEATH!

WE WANTED THE ASK YOU IF YOU VE SEEN ANYTHING FLINDY LATELY, SAID
HERMIONE BLICKLY. BECAUSE A CAT WAS ATTACKED RIGHT OUTSIDE YOUR
FRONT

BEHIND THE HALLWAY.

DID YOU SEE ANYONE NEAR HERE THAT NIGHT? SAID HARRY.

I WASN'T PAYING ATTENTION, SAID MYRTLE DRAMATICALLY. PEEVES
LIPSET ME

SEE MUCH I CAME IN HERE AND TRIED TO KILL MYSELF. THEN, OF COURSE, I
REMEMBERED THAT I'M THAT I'M

ALREADY DEAD, SAID REEN HELPFULLY.

MYRTLE GAVE A TRAGIC SIGH, ROSE UP IN THE AIR, TURNED OVER, AND DROVE
HEADFIRST INTO THE TUB, SPLASHING WATER ALL OVER THEM AND
VANISHING FROM

SIGHT, ALTHOUGH FROM THE DIRECTION OF HER MURDERED SIBS, SHE HAD
LEFT THEM

REST SOMEWHERE IN THE L-REND.

HARRY AND REEN STOOD WITH THEIR MOUTHS OPEN, BUT HERMIONE
SHRUGGED

WEARILY AND SAID, HONESTLY, THAT WAS ALMOST CHEERFUL FOR MYRTLE, .
.. THERE

HEN, LET'S GO.

HARRY HAD BARELY CLOSED THE DOOR WHEN MYRTLE'S CLINGING SIBS WENT
A WHIRL

WHICH MADE ALL THREE OF THEM JUMP.

REEN:

PERCY WEASLEY HAD STOPPED DEAD AT THE HEAD OF THE STAIRS, PERFECT
RAGE

AGONY, AN EXPRESSION OF COMPLETE STUNNED IN HIS FACE.

THAT'S A GIRL'S BATHROOM? HE GASPED. WHAT WERE YOU ?

JUST HAVING A WHIRL AROUND, REEN SHRUGGED. LIES, YOU KNOW

PERCY SWELLED IN A MANNER THAT REMINDED HARRY FERCEFULLY OF MRS.
WEASLEY.

GET AWAY FROM THEM THERE PERCY SAID, STRIDING TOWARD THEM AND

STARTING THE BUSTLE THEM ALONG, FLAPPING HIS ARMS. DONT YOU CARE WHAT THIS

LOOKS LIKE? COMING BACK HERE WHILE EVERYONE IS AT DINNER

WHY SHOULDNT WE BE HERE? SAID RON HEFTILY, STOPPING SHORT AND CLARING

AT PERCY. LISTEN, WE NEVER LAID A FINGER ON THAT CAT

THAT IS WHAT I TOLD GINNY, SAID PERCY FIERCELY, BUT SHE STILL SEEMS TO

THINK YOU ARE GOING TO BE EXPELLED, I VE NEVER SEEN HER SET LIPS, CRYING HER

EYES SHUT, YOU MIGHT THINK OF HER, ALL THE FIRST YEARS ARE TERRIBLY

OVEREXCITED BY THIS BUSINESS

YOU DONT CARE ABOUT GINNY, SAID RON, WHOSE EARS WERE NOW REDDENING. YOU ARE JUST WORRIED I M GOING TO MISS MY CHANCES OF

BEING HEAD BOY

FIVE POINTS FROM GRYPFINDER! PERCY SAID TERSELY, FINGERING HIS PEEPER

BADGE. AND I HOPE IT TEACHES YOU A LESSON! SHE MORE DETECTIVE WORK, HE ILL

WRITE THE MUM

AND HE STRODE OFF, THE BACK OF HIS NECK AS RED AS RONS EARS.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE TOOK SEATS AS FAR AS POSSIBLE FROM PERCY IN THE

COMMON ROOM THAT NIGHT. RON WAS STILL IN A VERY BAD TEMPER AND KEPT

SLITTING HIS CLOTHES THEMSELVES. WHEN HE REACHED ABSENTLY FOR HIS
WAND THE

REMOVE THE SPIDERS, IT IGNITED THE PARLAMENT, FLAMING ALMOST AS
MUCH AS

HIS THEMSELVES, THEN SLAMMED THE STANDARD BOOK OF SPELLS, GRADE 2
SHUT.

THE HARRY'S SURPRISE, HERMIONE FELLERED SLIT.

WHEN CAN IT BE, TELLER? SHE SAID IN A QUIET VOICE, AS TELLER
CONTINUING

A CONVERSATION THEY HAD JUST BEEN HAVING. WHEN I WANT THE
FRIGHTEN ALL THE

SHIRTS AND MUGGLE-BOOKS LEFT OF HERMANS?

LET'S THINK, SAID THEN IN MUCH PUZZLEMENT. WHEN DID WE KNOW
WHEN

THINGS MUGGLE-BOOKS ARE SLIM?

HE LOOKED AT HERMIONE, HERMIONE LOOKED BACK, UNCONVINCED.

IF YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT MALFOY

OF COURSE I AM! SAID THEN. YOU HEARD HIM YOU'LL BE NEXT,

MURDERERS? COME ON, YOU'VE ONLY GOT THE LOOK AT HIS FOLLY RAT
FACE THE

KNOW IT'S HIM

MALFOY, THE HEIR OF SLYTHERIN? SAID HERMIONE SKEPTICALLY.

LOOK AT HIS FAMILY, SAID HARRY, CLOSING HIS EYES, THEN. THE
WHOLE LEFT

IF THEY HAVE BEEN IN SLYTHERIN, HE'S ALWAYS BRAGGING ABOUT IT.
THEY COULD

EASILY BE SLYTHERIN'S DESCENDANTS. HIS FATHER'S DEFINITELY EVIL
ENOUGH.

THEY COULD'VE HAD THE KEY TO THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS FOR
CENTURIES!

SAID REEN, FLANDING IT DEHN, FATHER TEE SHN, . . .

WELL, SAID HERMIONE CALTHERLY, I SUPPOSE IT S POSSIBLE, . . .

BUT FEEL DEE WE PROVE IT? SAID HARRY DARDLY.

THERE MIGHT BE A WAY, SAID HERMIONE SLEELY, DREPPING HER VHIKE STILL

FLRTHER WITH A FLICK GLANCE ACROSS THE ROOM AT PERCY, HP CHLUSE, IT WOULD

BE DIFFICULT, AND DANGEROUS, VERY DANGEROUS, WE D BE BREAKING ABOUT FIFTY

SCHOOL RULES, I EXPECT

IF, IN A MONTH OR SO, YOU FEEL LIKE EXPLAINING, YOU WILL LET US KNOW,

WHEN T YOU? SAID REEN IRRITABLY.

ALL RIGHT, SAID HERMIONE COLDLY, WHAT WE D NEED TH DEE IS THE GET INSIDE THE SLYTHERIN COMMON ROOM AND ASK MALFOY A FEW QUESTIONS

WITHOUT HIM REALIZING IT S US,

BUT THAT S IMPOSSIBLE, HARRY SAID AS REEN LAUGHED.

NEH, IT S NOT, SAID HERMIONE, ALL WE D NEED WOULD BE SOME PERJURY

PETITION,

WHAT S THAT? SAID REEN AND HARRY TOGETHER.

SNAPE MENTIONED IT IN CLASS A FEW WEEKS AGO

D YOU THINK WE VE GOT NOTHING BETTER TH DEE IN PETITIONS THAN LISTEN THE

SNAPE? MUTTERED REEN.

IT TRANSFORMS YOU INTO SOMEBODY ELSE, THINK ABOUT IT! WE COULD CHANGE

IN THE THREE OF THE SLOTHERINS, ONE HAD WOULD KNOW IT WAS US,
MAYBE WOULD

PROBABLY TELL US ANYTHING, BUT I PROBABLY REASTING ABOUT IT IN THE
SLOTHERIN

CERTAINLY THEM RIGHT NOW, IF ONLY WE COULD HEAR HIM.

THIS POLYILICE STUFF SEEMS A BIT DODGY THE MR. SAID THEN,
PRELIMINARY.

WHAT IF WE WERE STILL LOOKING LIKE THREE OF THE SLOTHERINS
HEREVER?

IT TAKES OFF AFTER A WHILE, SAID HERMIONE, LAYING HER HAND
IMPATIENTLY, BUT GETTING HOLD OF THE RECIPE WILL BE VERY DIFFICULT.
SNAP

SAID IT WAS IN A BOOK CALLED MEISTER PENTATE PENTHENS AND IT IS BEING
THE BE IN

THE RESTRICTED SECTION OF THE LIBRARY.

THERE WAS ONLY ONE WAY THE GET INTO A BOOK FROM THE RESTRICTED
SECTION:

YOU NEEDED A SIGNED NOTE OF PERMISSION FROM A TEACHER.

HARD THE SEE WHY WE D WANT THE BOOK, REALLY, SAID THEN, IF WE
WEREN'T

GOING TO TRY AND MAKE ONE OF THE PENTHENS.

I THINK, SAID HERMIONE, THAT IF WE MADE IT SEEM AS THOUGH WE
WERE

JUST INTERESTED IN THE THEORY, WE MIGHT STAND A CHANCE. . . .

OH, COME ON, ONE TEACHER IS GOING TO FALL FOR THAT, SAID THEN.
THEY D

HAVE THE BE REALLY THICK. . . .

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CHAPTER TEN

THE REBEL BLOOD

SINCE THE DISASTROUS EPISODE OF THE PIXIES, PROFESSOR LUCIFERT HAD NOT

BRIGHTENED UP THE CLASS. INSTEAD, HE READ PASSAGES FROM HIS BOOKS TO THEM, AND SOMETIMES REENACTED SOME OF THE MORE DRAMATIC BITS.

HE USUALLY PICKED HARRY TO HELP HIM WITH THESE RECONSTRUCTIONS, SEEING THAT

HARRY HAD BEEN FORCED TO PLAY A SIMPLE TRANSYLVANIAN VILLAGER WHEN

LUCIFERT HAD CHOSEN HIM A BARBIC BARRE, A YETI WITH A HEAD CHIEF, AND A

VAMPIRE WHO HAD BEEN UNABLE TO EAT ANYTHING EXCEPT LETTUCE SINCE LUCIFERT HAD DEALT WITH HIM.

HARRY WAS CHOSEN TO BE THE FRONT OF THE CLASS DURING THEIR VERY NEXT DEFENSE

AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON, THIS TIME ACTING AS A WEREWOLF. IF HE HADN'T HAD

A VERY GOOD REASON FOR KEEPING LUCIFERT IN A GOOD MOOD, HE WOULD HAVE

REFUSED TO DO IT.

NICE WORK, HARRY, EXACTLY AND THEN, IF YOU WILL BELIEVE IT, I

FEELING LIKE THIS SLAPPED HIM ON THE CHEEK THIS WITH

HAND, I MANAGED TO HOLD HIM DOWN WITH MY OTHER, I PLIT MY WAND
THAT

I THEN SCREWED UP MY REMAINING STRENGTH AND
PERFORMED THE

IMMENSELY COMPLEX FINGERFLEIS CHARM HE LET OUT A PITEOUS
MEAN

EN, HARRY HIGHER THAN THAT GHEE THE FLIR VANISHED
THE FANGS

STRAND AND HE TURNED BACK INTO A MAN, SIMPLE, YET EFFECTIVE
AND

ANOTHER VILLAGE WILL REMEMBER ME FOREVER AS THE HERO WHO
DELIVERED THEM

FROM THE MONTHLY TERROR OF WEREWOLF ATTACKS.

THE BELL RANG AND LOCKHART GOT TO HIS FEET.

HERMIOND COMPOSED A POEM ABOUT MY DEFEAT OF THE WAGGA
WAGGA

WEREWOLF: SIGNED COPIES OF MAGICAL ME TO THE ALTHOR OF THE REST
HNE

THE CLASS BEGAN THE LEAVE, HARRY RETURNED TO THE BACK OF THE ROOM,
WHERE

RON AND HERMIONE WERE WAITING.

READY? HARRY MUTTERED.

WAIT TILL EVERYONE'S GONE, SAID HERMIONE NERVOUSLY. ALL RIGHT
...

SHE APPROACHED LOCKHART'S DESK, A PIECE OF PAPER CLUTCHED TIGHTLY
IN HER

HAND, HARRY AND RON RIGHT BEHIND HER.

ER PROFESSOR LOCKHART? HERMIONE STAMMERED. I WANTED TO
THE

GET THIS BOOK OUT OF THE LIBRARY, JUST FOR BACKGROUND READING,
SHE HELD OUT

THE PIECE OF PAPER, HER HAND SHAKING SLIGHTLY. BUT THE THING IS,
IT'S IN THE

RESTRICTED SECTION OF THE LIBRARY, SO I NEED A TEACHER TO SIGN FOR IT
I'M

SURE IT WOULD HELP ME UNDERSTAND WHAT YOU SAY IN CHATTING WITH
CHILDREN

ABOUT SHOW-ACTING VIDEOS

AND CHATTING WITH CHILDREN? SAID LUCIFER, TAKING THE NOTE FROM
HERMIONE AND SMILING WIDELY AT HER. POSSIBLY MY VERY FAVORITE
BOOK, YOU

ENJOYED IT?

OH, YES, SAID HERMIONE EAGERLY. SHE CLEVER, THE WAY YOU TRAPPED
THAT

LAST ONE WITH THE TEA-STRAINER

WELL, I'M SURE SHE'LL MIND ME GIVING THE BEST STUDENT OF THE
YEAR

A LITTLE EXTRA HELP, SAID LUCIFER WARMLY, AND HE PLUCKED OUT AN
ENVELOPE

PEACHES WILL, YES, NICE, ISN'T IT? HE SAID, MISREADING THE REVEALED
BOOK

ON HER FACE. I USUALLY SAVE IT FOR BOOK SIGNINGS.

HE SCRAWLED AN ENVELOPE SIGNATURE ON THE NOTE AND HANDED
IT

BACK TO HERMIONE.

SEE, FARRY, SAID LUCIFER, WHILE HERMIONE HELD THE NOTE WITH
FUMBLING FINGERS AND SLIPPED IT INTO HER BAG. THERE'S THE
FIRST

FLUIDDITCH MATCH OF THE SEASON, I BELIEVE? GRYPFINDER AGAINST
SLYTHERIN, IS

IT MEET? I HEAR YOU'RE A USEFUL PLAYER, I WAS A SEEKER, THEN, I WAS
ASKED TO TRY

FOR THE NATIONAL SELEAD, BUT PREFERRED TO DEDICATE MY LIFE TO THE
ERADICATION

OF THE DARK FORCES, STILL, IF EVER YOU FEEL THE NEED FOR A LITTLE
PRIVATE

TRAINING, DON'T HESITATE TO ASK, ALWAYS HAPPY TO PASS ON MY
EXPERTISE TO

LESS ABLE PLAYERS, ...

HARRY MADE AN INDISTINCT NOISE IN HIS THROAT AND THEN FLURRIED OFF
AFTER

RON AND HERMIONE.

I DON'T BELIEVE IT, HE SAID AS THE THREE OF THEM EXAMINED THE
SIGNATURE

ON THE NOTE, HE DIDN'T EVEN LOOK AT THE NAME HE WANTED,

THAT'S BECAUSE HE'S A BRAINLESS GIT, SAID RON, BUT WITH CARES,
WE'VE

GET WHAT WE NEEDED

HE IS NOT A BRAINLESS GIT, SAID HERMIONE SPRILLY AS THEY HALF RAN
TOWARD

THE LIBRARY,

JUST BECAUSE HE SAID YOU WERE THE BEST STUDENT OF THE YEAR

THEY DROPPED THEIR VEHICLES AS THEY ENTERED THE MUFFLED STILLNESS OF
THE

LIBRARY, MADAM PINCE, THE LIBRARIAN, WAS A THIN, IRRITABLE WOMAN
WHO

BEHEADED LIKE AN UNDERSTUD VULTURE,

MERE PETENT PETITIONS? SHE REPEATED SUSPICIOUSLY, TRYING THE
TACK THE

NOTE FROM FERMINE; BUT FERMINE WOULDNT LET GO.

I WAS WONDERING IF I COULD KEEP IT, SHE SAID BREATHLESSLY.

EH, CHEE EH, SAID BEN, WRENCHING IT FROM HER GRASP AND
TWISTING IT AT

MADAM PINK. WE LL GET YOU ANOTHER ALTHOUGH, SHED-HART LL
SIGN ANYTHING

IF IT STANDS STILL LONG ENOUGH.

MADAM PINK HELD THE NOTE UP TO THE LIGHT, AS THOUGH DETERMINED
THE

DETECT A FINGER, BUT IT PASSED THE TEST. SHE STALKED AWAY BETWEEN
THE LEFT

SHELVES AND RETURNED SEVERAL MINUTES LATER CARRYING A LARGE AND
MILD-

LEAVING BEHIND, FERMINE PUT IT CAREFULLY INTO HER BAG AND THEY
LEFT, TRYING

NOT TO WALK TOO QUICKLY FOR BEHIND THE GUILTY.

FIVE MINUTES LATER, THEY WERE BARRICADED IN MEANING MYRTLE S ELLI-
ER-

ORDER KATH-REEM HENCE AGAIN. FERMINE HAD OVERRIDDEN BEN S
OBJECTIONS BY

POINTING OUT THAT IT WAS THE LAST PLACE ANYONE IN THEIR RIGHT
MINDS WOULD

GO, SEE THEY WERE GUARANTEED SOME PRIVACY, MEANING MYRTLE WAS
CRYING

NEARLY IN HER STALL, BUT THEY WERE IGNORING HER, AND SHE THEM.

HERMINE OPENED MOST PETENT PETITIONS CAREFULLY, AND THE THREE
OF

THEY SENT OVER THE DAMP-SPOTTED PAGES. IT WAS CLEAR FROM A GLANCE
WHY IT

RELINQUISHED IN THE RESTRICTED SECTION. SOME OF THE PETITIONS HAD EFFECTS
ALMOST

THEY CALLED THE THING AHEAD, AND THERE WERE SOME VERY
UNPLEASANT

ILLUSTRATIONS, WHICH INCLUDED A MAN WHO SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN
TURNED INSIDE

OUT AND A WITCH SPREADING SEVERAL EXTRA PAIRS OF ARMS OUT OF HER
HEAD.

HERE IT IS, SAID HERMINE EXCITEDLY AS SHE FLIPPED THE PAGE HEADED
THE

PHYSICAL PETITION. IT WAS DECORATED WITH DRAWINGS OF PEOPLE
HALLWAY

THROUGH TRANSFORMING INTO EITHER PEOPLE. HARRY SINCERELY HOPED
THE ARTIST

HAD IMAGINED THE LOOKS OF INTENSE PAIN ON THEIR FACES.

THIS IS THE MOST COMPLICATED PETITION I'VE EVER SEEN, SAID
HERMINE AS

THEY SCANNED THE RECIPE. LACKING FLIES, LECTURES, ALLKNEED, AND
KNIGHTGRASS, SHE MURMURED, RUNNING HER FINGER DOWN THE LIST OF
INGREDIENTS.

WELL, THEY'RE EASY ENOUGH, THEY'RE IN THE STUDENT STORE-CLIQUEARD,
WE CAN

HELP OURSELVES. . . . HMMM, LOOK, POUNDERED MEAT OF A KITCHEN
DINN T DINNER

WHERE WE'RE GOING TO GET THAT SHREDDED SKIN OF A KHEMISLAND
THAT IS

BE TRICKY, THEN AND HE CHOOSE A BIT OF WHATEVER WE WANT THE CHANGE
INTEH.

EXCUSE ME? SAID BENN SHARPLY. WHAT D YELL MEAN, A BIT OF
WHATEVER

WE RE CHANGING INTEH? I M DRINKING NOTHING WITH CRABBE S THERNAILS
IN IT

HERMINEE CONTINUED AS THOUGH SHE HADN T HEARD HIM.

WE DENN T HAVE THE WHERRY ABELT THAT YET, THOUGH, BECAUSE WE ADD
THESE

KITS LAST. . . .

BENN TURNED, SPEECHLESS, THE HARRY, WHO HAD ANOTHER WHERRY.

D YELL REALIZE HOW MUCH WE RE GOING TO HAVE TO STEAL, HERMINEE?
SKINNED SKIN OF A KHEMISLANE, THAT S DEFINITELY NOT IN THE
STUDENT S

CLIPBOARD, WHAT RE WE GOING TO DO, BREAD INTEH SNARE S PRIVATE
STRESS? I

DENN T KNOW IF THIS IS A GOOD IDEA. . . .

HERMINEE SHUT THE KHEM WITH A SNAP.

WELL, IF YELL TWO ARE GOING TO CHICKEN EAT, FINE, SHE SAID. THERE
WERE

BRIGHT PINK PATCHES ON HER CHEEKS AND HER EYES WERE BRIGHTER
THAN USUAL. I

DENN T WANT THE BREAD RULES, YELL KNOW, I THINK THREATENING
MUGGLE-BURNS IS

FAR WORSER THAN BREWING UP A DIFFICULT POTION, BUT IF YELL DENN T
WANT THE FINE

EAT IF IT S MALT, I M GO STRAIGHT TO MADAM PINK NELL AND HAND
THE KHEM

BACK IN

I NEVER THOUGHT I'D SEE THE DAY WHEN YOU'D BE PERSUADING US THE
WISER.

WELL, SAID RON, ALL RIGHT, WE'LL DO IT, BUT NOT TONIGHT, OKAY?

HOW LONG WILL IT TAKE TO MAKE, ANYWAY? SAID HARRY AS
HERMIONIE,

LOOKING HAPPIER, OPENED THE CLOSET AGAIN.

WELL, SINCE THE ALLOWANCE HAS GOTTEN BE PICKED AT THE FULL MOON AND
THE

WITCHES HAVE GOTTEN BE STEWED FOR TWENTY-THREE DAYS... I'D SAY IT'D
BE

READY IN ABOUT A MONTH, IF WE CAN GET ALL THE INGREDIENTS.

A MONTH? SAID RON, MALFOY COULD HAVE ATTACKED HALF THE
MUGGLE-

ROOMS IN THE SCHOOL BY THEN! BUT HERMIONIE'S EYES NARROWED
DANGEROUSLY

AGAIN, AND HE ADDED SLIGHTLY, BUT IT'S THE BEST PLAN WE'VE GOT, SHE'LL
STAY

AHEAD, I SAY.

HOWEVER, WHILE HERMIONIE WAS CHECKING THAT THE COAST WAS CLEAR
FOR

THEM TO LEAVE THE BATHROOM, RON MUTTERED TO HARRY, IT'LL BE A LITTLE
LESS

WASTeful IF YOU CAN JUST DROVE MALFOY OFF HIS ROOM THEMSELVES.

HARRY WROTE EARLY ON SATURDAY MORNING AND LAY FOR A WHILE
THINKING ABOUT

THE UPCOMING CRUDDITCH MATCH. HE WAS NERVOUS, MAINLY AT THE
THOUGHT OF

WHAT WEHND WEHLND SAY IF GRYFFINDER WIST, BLIT ALSEH AT THE IDEA HF
FACING A

TEAM MELINTED HEN THE FASTEST RACING BROOMS CHILD CHULD RLY, HE HAD
NEVER

WANTED THE BEAT SLYTHERIN SEE BADLY, AFTER HALF AN HELLER HF LYING
THERE WITH HIS

INSIDES FLURNING, HE GET UP, DRESSED, AND WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST
EARLY,

WHERE HE FEHND THE REST HF THE GRYFFINDER TEAM FLIDDED AT THE
LENG, EMPTY

TABLE, ALL BLEEDING LFTIGHT AND NEET SPREADING MICH,

AS ELEVEN EE CLECK APPROACHED, THE WEHLE SCHEEL STARTED THE MAKE
ITS WAY

DOWN THE THE FLIDDITCH STADILM, IT WAS A MLEGGY SHRT HF DAY WITH A
HINT HF

THUNDER IN THE AIR, ROHN AND HERMIONE CAME FLIRRYING HYER THE
WISH HARRY

CHUD BLCK AS HE ENTERED THE LICKER ROOMS, THE TEAM PULLED HEN
THEIR SCARLET

GRYFFINDER BREEK, THEN SAT DOWN THE LISTEN THE WEHND S USUAL PRE-
MATCH PREP

TALK,

SLYTHERIN HAS BETTER BROOMS THAN US, HE BEGAN, NEE PHINT
DENYING IT,

BLIT WE VE GET BETTER PRHOPLE HEN HELLER BROOMS, WE VE TRAINED HARDER
THAN THEY

HAVE, WE VE BEEN FLYING IN ALL WEATHERS } THEE TRUE, MUITTERED
GEHREK

WEASLEY, I HAVEN T BEEN PROPERLY DRY SINCE AUGUST (AND
WE RE CHING

THEY MADE THEM RISE THE DAY THEY LET THAT LITTLE KIT OF SLIME, MALFOY,
ENJOY HIS

WAS HINTED THEIR TEAM,

CHEST HEAVING WITH EXHILITATION, WEED TURNED THE HARRY,

IT WAS BEHIND THE VEIL, HARRY, THE SILENCE TOLD THEM THAT A SEEKER HAD THE
FAVOUR

SOMETHING MORE THAN A RICH FATHER, GET THE THAT SNITCH BEFORE
MALFOY HAD HIM

TRYING, HARRY, BECAUSE WE'VE GOT THE WIN TODAY, WE'VE GOT THE

THE NEW PRESSURE, HARRY, SAID FRED, WINKING AT HIM,

AS THEY WALKED ALONG HINTED THE PITCH, A REAR OF NOISE GREETED THEM;
MAINLY

CHIEFS, BECAUSE RAVENCLAW AND HUFFLEPUFF WERE ANNOYED THE SEE
SLITHERING

BEATEN, BUT THE SLITHERING IN THE CROWD MADE THEIR RISES AND HISSES
HEARD,

THEY, MADAM EWE, THE HILLOTTIE TEACHER, ASKED FLINT AND WEED THE
SHADE

HANDS, WHICH THEY DID, GIVING EACH OTHER THREATENING STARES AND
GRIPPING

RATHER HARDER THAN WAS NECESSARY,

END MY WHISTLE, SAID MADAM EWE, THREE ... TWO ... ONE ...

WITH A REAR FROM THE CROWD THE SPEED THEM UPWARD, THE FORTY-SEVEN
PLAYERS

RACE TOWARD THE LEADEN SKY, HARRY FLEW HIGHER THAN ANY OF THEM,
SILENTLY

ARRIVING FOR THE SNITCH.

ALL RIGHT THERE, SCARHEAD? YELLED MALFOY, SMILING UNDERNEATH
HIM AS

THOUGH THE SILENCE OF THE SPEED OF HIS BREATH.

HARRY HAD NO TIME TO REPLY, AT THAT VERY MOMENT, A HEAVY BLACK
BLUDGE

CAME PELTING TOWARD HIM; HE AVOIDED IT SO CLOSELY THAT HE FELT IT
RIPPLE HIS

HAIR AS IT PASSED.

THESE HUR, HARRY? SAID GEORGE, STREAMING PAST HIM WITH HIS CLUB
IN HIS

HAND, READY TO BOUNCE THE BLUDGE BACK TOWARD A SLYTHERIN. HARRY
SAW

GEORGE GIVE THE BLUDGE A PERCUSSIVE WHACK IN THE DIRECTION OF
ADRIAN

POLEY, BUT THE BLUDGE CHANGED DIRECTION IN MIDAIR AND SHOT
STRAIGHT FOR

HARRY AGAIN.

HARRY DROPPED QUICKLY TO AVOID IT, AND GEORGE MANAGED TO HIT IT
HARD

TOWARD MALFOY. HENCE AGAIN, THE BLUDGE SWERVED LIKE A BOomerang
AND

SHOT AT HARRY'S HEAD.

HARRY PUT ON A BURST OF SPEED AND ZOOMED TOWARD THE OTHER END OF
THE

PITCH. HE COULD HEAR THE BLUDGE WHISTLING ALONG BEHIND HIM.
WHAT WAS

GOING ON? BLUDGES NEVER CONCENTRATED ON ONE PLAYER LIKE THIS; IT
WAS THEIR

JOB TO TRY AND LOSE AT AS MANY PEOPLE AS POSSIBLE. . . .

FRED WEASLEY WAS WAITING FOR THE BLUDGE AT THE OTHER END. HARRY

BLINKED AS FRED SWUNG AT THE BLUDGE WITH ALL HIS MIGHT; THE
BLUDGE WAS

DOWNHOLDING HIMSELF.

GEORGE: FRED YELLED HAPPILY, BUT HE WAS WRINGING AS THOUGH IT WAS
MAGNETICALLY ATTRACTED THE HARRY, THE BLOODER PELTED AFTER HIM SINCE
MERE

AND HARRY WAS FORCED THE FLY OFF AT FULL SPEED.

IT HAD STARTED THE RAIN; HARRY FELT HEAVY DROPS FALL AGAINST HIS FACE,
SPLATTERING AGAINST HIS GLASSES. HE DIDN'T HAVE A CLUE WHAT WAS
GOING ON IN THE

REST OF THE GAME UNTIL HE HEARD LEE JORDAN, WHO WAS
COMMENTATING, SAY,

SLYTHERIN LEAD, SIXTY POINTS THE ZERO

THE SLYTHERINS SUPERIOR SKILLS WERE CLEARLY BEING THEIR THINGS,
AND

MEANWHILE THE MAD BLOODER WAS BEING ALL IT COULD THE DOWNED HARRY
HELT UP

THE AIR, FRED AND GEORGE WERE NOW FLYING SEE CLEAR THE HIM AND EITHER
SIDE

THAT HARRY COULD SEE NOTHING AT ALL EXCEPT THEIR FLAILING ARMS
AND HAD NO

CHANCE THE WOULD FOR THE SNITCH, LET ALONE CATCH IT.

SOMEONE'S TAMPERED WITH THIS BLOODER FRED
GROINED,

SWINGING HIS BAT WITH ALL HIS MIGHT AT IT AS IT LAUNCHED A NEW
ATTACK ON

HARRY.

WE NEED TIME HELT, SAID GEORGE, TRYING THE SIGNAL THE WOULD AND
STEP THE

BLOODER BREAKING HARRY'S NECK AT THE SAME TIME.

WEED HAD ANXIOUSLY GOTTEN THE MESSAGE. MADAM ELMOR'S WHISTLE RANG
LOUD

AND HARRY, FRED, AND GEORGE DIVED FOR THE GROUND, STILL TRYING TO
AVOID THE

MAD BUDGER.

WHAT'S GOING ON? SAID WEED AS THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM Huddled
TOGETHER.

WHILE SLYTHERINS IN THE GROUND KEPT. WE'RE BEING FLATTENED, FRED,
GEORGE.

WHERE WERE YOU WHEN THAT BUDGER STOPPED ANGELINA SCORING?

WE WERE TWENTY FEET ABOVE HER, STOPPING THE OTHER BUDGER FROM
MURDERING HARRY, ELIVER, SAID GEORGE ANGRILY. SOMEONE'S FIXED
IT IT

WHEN I LEAVE HARRY ALONE, IT HASN'T GONE FOR ANYONE ELSE ALL GAME.
THE

SLYTHERINS MUST HAVE DONE SOMETHING TO IT.

BUT THE BUDGERS HAVE BEEN LOCKED IN MADAM ELMOR'S OFFICE SINCE
ELIV

LAST PRACTICE, AND THERE WAS NOTHING WRONG WITH THEM THEN. . . .
SAID WEED,

ANXIOUSLY.

MADAM ELMOR WAS WALKING TOWARD THEM, EVER HER SNEEDER,
HARRY

COULD SEE THE SLYTHERIN TEAM KEERING AND POINTING IN HIS
DIRECTION.

LISTEN, SAID HARRY AS SHE CAME NEARER AND NEARER, WITH YOU
THE

FLYING AROUND ME ALL THE TIME THE ONLY WAY I'M GOING TO CATCH THE
SNITCH IS

IF IT FLIES UP MY SLEEVE. GO BACK TO THE REST OF THE TEAM AND LET ME
DEAL

WITH THE REGLER HIRE.

DON'T BE THICK, SAID FRED. IT LL TAKE YOUR HEAD OFF,

WEED WAS BLEEDING FROM HARRY THE THE WEASLEYS.

ELIVER, THIS IS INSANE, SAID ALICIA SPINNET ANGRILY, YOU CAN T
LET HARRY

DEAL WITH THAT THING HEN HIS HEN, LET S ASK HER AN INELJIRY

IF WE STOP NOW, WE LL HAVE THE PERPETIT THE MATCH? SAID HARRY,
AND

WE RE NOT LHSING THE SLYTHERIN ILST BECAUSE OF A CRAZY BLUDGE?
COME HEN,

ELIVER, TELL THEM THE LEAVE ME ALONE?

THIS IS ALL YOUR FAULT, GEORGE SAID ANGRILY THE WEED. GET THE
SNITCH

HER DIT TRYING, WHAT A STUPID THING THE TELL HIM

MADAM FHECH HAD IHINED THEM,

READY THE RESUME PLAY? SHE ASKED WEED,

WEED LOOKED AT THE DETERMINED WEED HEN HARRY S FACE,

ALL RIGHT, HE SAID. FRED, GEORGE, YOU HEARD HARRY LEAVE HIM
ALONE

AND LET HIM DEAL WITH THE BLUDGE HEN HIS HEN,

THE RAIN WAS FALLING MORE HEAVILY NOW, HEN MADAM FHECH S
WHISTLE,

HARRY KICKED HARD INTO THE AIR AND HEARD THE TELLTAL WEHESH OF
THE BLUDGE

BEHIND HIM. HIGHER AND HIGHER HARRY CLIMED; HE LEAPED AND
SWHEPPED,

SPIRALED, ZIGZAGGED, AND REELLED. SLIGHTLY DIZZY, HE NEVERTHELESS KEPT
HIS

EYES WIDE OPEN, RAIN WAS SPECKLING HIS GLASSES AND RAN UP HIS
NECKSTRIPS AS HE

FLUNG UPSIDE DOWN, AVOIDING ANOTHER FIERCE DIVE FROM THE BLUDGE,
HE

COULD HEAR LAUGHTER FROM THE CROWD; HE KNEW HE MUST BECOME VERY
STUPID, BUT

THE HEAVY BLUDGE WAS HEAVY AND COULDN'T CHANGE DIRECTION AS
EASILY AS

HARRY COULD; HE BEGAN A KIND OF ROLLER-COASTER RIDE AROUND THE
EDGES OF THE

STADIUM, SWIRLING THROUGH THE SILVER SHEETS OF RAIN TILL THE
GRASSHOPPER

CHALPHETS, WHERE ADRIAN PUKY WAS TRYING TO GET PAST WHEN

A WHISTLING IN HARRY'S EAR TOLD HIM THE BLUDGE HAD JUST MISSED
HIM

AGAIN; HE TURNED RIGHT AROUND AND SPED IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION.

TRAINING FOR THE BULLET, BETTER? YELLED MALPHY AS HARRY WAS
FORCED TO

BE A STUPID KIND OF TWIRL IN MIDAIR TILL BEHIND THE BLUDGE, AND HE FLED,
THE

BLUDGE TRAILING A FEW FEET BEHIND HIM; AND THEN, GLARING BACK AT
MALPHY IN

HATRED, HE SAW IT THE GOLDEN SNITCH. IT WAS FLEETING INCHES
ABOVE

MALPHY'S LEFT EAR AND MALPHY, BUSY LAUGHING AT HARRY, HADN'T
SEEN IT.

FOR AN AGONIZING MOMENT, HARRY FLEW IN MIDAIR, NOT DARING THE
SPEED

TOWARD MALPHY IN CASE HE LOOKED UP AND SAW THE SNITCH.

W-H-A-M.

HE HAD STAYED STILL A SECOND TIME LONG. THE BLUDGE HAD HIT HIM AT LAST,

SMASHED INTO HIS KNEE, AND HARRY FELT HIS ARM BREAK. DIMLY, DAZED BY THE

SEARING PAIN IN HIS ARM, HE SLID SIDELWAYS ON HIS RAIN-DRENCHED KNEE, HERE

DROPE STILL CRASHED OVER IT, HIS RIGHT ARM DANGLING USELESS AT HIS SIDE THE

BLUDGE CAME PELTING BACK FOR A SECOND ATTACK, THIS TIME AIMING AT HIS FACE

HARRY SWERVED AWAY THE WAY, HIS IDEA FIRMLY LEDGED IN HIS MIND

BRAIN: GET THE MALICE,

THROUGH A HAZE OF RAIN AND PAIN HE DIVED FOR THE SHIMMERING, SNEERING

FACE BEHIND HIM AND SAW ITS EYES WIDEN WITH FEAR: MALICE THOUGHT HARRY

WAS ATTACKING HIM,

WHAT THE HE GASPED, CARENING AWAY HARRY'S WAY,

HARRY THREW HIS REMAINING HAND OFF HIS KNEE AND MADE A WILD SNATCH: HE

FELT HIS FINGERS CLOSE ON THE COLD SNITCH BUT WAS NEARLY GRIPPING THE

KNEE WITH HIS LEGS, AND THERE WAS A YELL FROM THE CIRCLE BEHIND AS HE

HEADED STRAIGHT FOR THE CIRCLE, TRYING HARD NOT TO PASS AWAY,

WITH A SPLATTERING THUD HE HIT THE MUD AND REELLED OFF HIS KNEE, HIS ARM

WAS HANGING AT A VERY STRANGE ANGLE; RIBBED WITH PAIN, HE HEARD, AS THOUGH

FROM A DISTANCE, A GOOD DEAL OF WHISTLING AND SNEEZING, HE FELT
HIS

SMITH CLUTCHED IN HIS GOOD HAND,

ALIA, HE SAID VAGUELY. WE'RE HERE,

AND HE PAINTED,

HE CAME AROUND, RAIN FALLING ON HIS FACE, STILL LYING ON THE FIELD,
WITH

SOMEONE LEANING OVER HIM. HE SAW A GLITTER OF TEETH.

HE, NE, NEET YEL, HE MEANT,

DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HE WAS SAYING, SAID LUCIFER LULLABY THE THE
AND THE

CHILD OF CRYSTAL PRESSING AROUND THEM. NEET THE WINDY,
HARRY, I'M

ABOUT THE FIVE YEAR ARM,

NEE SAID HARRY, I'LL KEEP IT LIKE THIS, THANKS, ...

HE TRIED THE SIT UP, BUT THE PAIN WAS TERRIBLE. HE HEARD A FAMILIAR
CLICKING

WHILE NEARBY,

I DON'T WANT A PILETH OF THIS, LULU, HE SAID LULLABY,

LIE BACK, HARRY, SAID LUCIFER SNEEZINGLY. IT'S A SIMPLE CHARM
I'VE

USED COUNTLESS TIMES

WHY CAN'T I JUST GET THE THE HOSPITAL WING? SAID HARRY THROUGH
CLUTCHED

TEETH,

HE SHOULD REALLY, PROFESSOR, SAID A MILDLY WINDY, WITH CHILDREN T
HELP

GRINNING EVEN THOUGH HIS SPEAKER WAS INJURED. GREAT CAPTURE,
HARRY, REALLY

SPECTACULAR, YOUR BEST YET, I'D SAY

THROUGH THE THICKET OF LEGS AROUND HIM, HARRY SPOTTED FRED AND
GEORGE

WEASLEY, WRESTLING THE REGLER BLUDGEON INTO A KNEE. IT WAS STILL
PUTTING UP A

TERRIFIC FIGHT.

STAND BACK, SAID LUCIFERT, WHO WAS REHILLING UP HIS LADY-GREEN
SLEEVES.

NEE DEEN T SAID HARRY WEADLY, BUT LUCIFERT WAS TWIRLING
HIS HAND

AND A SECOND LATER HAD DIRECTED IT STRAIGHT AT HARRY'S ARM.

A STRANGE AND UNPLEASANT SENSATION STARTED AT HARRY'S SHOULDER
AND

SPREAD ALL THE WAY DOWN THE FINGERTIPS. IT FELT AS THOUGH HIS
ARM WAS

BEING DEFLATED. HE DIDN'T DARE LOOK AT WHAT WAS HAPPENING. HE HAD
SHUT HIS

EYES. HIS FACE TURNED AWAY FROM HIS ARM, BUT HIS WORST FEARS WERE
REALIZED

AS THE PEOPLE AROUND HIM GASPED AND CHILIN CREEPY BEGAN CLICKING
AWAY

MADLY. HIS ARM DIDN'T FLIRT ANYMORE NEAR DID IT FEEL REMOTELY LIKE
AN

ARM.

AH, SAID LUCIFERT. YES, WELL, THAT CAN SOMETIMES HAPPEN, BUT
THE

POINT IS, THE REINS ARE NO LONGER KNOWN. THAT'S THE THING THE
BEAR IN MIND.

SEE, HARRY, I'VE TROUBLE WITH THE HOSPITAL WING AND MR. LEASLEY,
MISS

GRANGER, WOULD YOU EXCUSE HIM? AND MADAM PEMFREY WILL BE ABLE
TO

BE TIDY UP A BIT.

AS HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET, HE FELT STRANGELY WEPSIDED, TAKING A DEEP
BREATH

HE WHEEZED DOWN AT HIS RIGHT SIDE. WHAT HE SAW NEARLY MADE HIM
PASS OUT

AGAIN.

PEERING OUT OF THE END OF HIS NOSE WAS WHAT WHEEZED LIKE A THICK,
FLESH-

CHINNED RUBBER GLOVE. HE TRIED TO MOVE HIS FINGERS. NOTHING
HAPPENED.

BLACKHART HADN'T MENDED HARRY'S KNEES, HE HAD REMOVED THEM.

MADAM PEMFREY WASN'T AT ALL PLEASED.

YOU SHOULD HAVE COME STRAIGHT TO ME! SHE RAGED, HOLDING UP THE
SAD,

LIMP REMAINDER OF WHAT, HALF AN HOUR BEFORE, HAD BEEN A WORKING
ARM. I

CAN MEND KNEES IN A SECOND BUT GROWING THEM BACK

YOU WILL BE ABLE TO, WHEN I DO! SAID HARRY DESPERATELY.

I WILL BE ABLE TO, CERTAINLY, BUT IT WILL BE PAINFUL, SAID MADAM
PEMFREY

GRIMLY, THROWING HARRY A PAIR OF PALANQUINS. YOU WILL HAVE TO STAY
THE

NIGHT, ...

HERMIONE WAITED ELTISIDE THE CURTAIN DRAWN AHELD HARRY S RED
WHILE

REN HELPED HIM INTHE HIS PALMAS, IT THEE A WHILE THE STUFF THE
RUBBER,

RENELESS ARM INTHE A SLEEP.

THE CAN THE STICK UP HER BACK-HART THE, HERMIONE, E-H REN
CALLED

THREHGH THE CURTAIN AS HE PULLED HARRY S LIMP FINGERS THREHGH
THE CLIP. IF

HARRY HAD WANTED DEHEVING HE WOULD HAVE ASKED.

ANYONE CAN MAKE A MISTAKE, SAID HERMIONE, AND IT DEESN T
ELRT

ANYWHERE, DEES IT, HARRY?

NEH, SAID HARRY, GETTING INTHE RED, ELT IT DEESN T DEE ANYTHING
ELSE

ELTHER,

AS HE SWLING HIMSELF ENTHE THE RED, HIS ARM FLAPPED PHINTLESSLY,

HERMIONE AND MADAM PEMFREY CAME AHELD THE CURTAIN, MADAM
PEMFREY WAS HLDING A LARGE KETTLE OF SOMETHING LABELED SKEL-
GREH,

THE RE IN HER A REHGH NIGHT, SHE SAID, PEHLING ELT A STREAMING
READERFLI

AND HANDING IT THE HIM. REHEHNG REHES IS A NASTY ELISNESS,

THE WAS TAKING THE SKEL-GREH, IT ELRNEH HARRY S MEHLEH AND
THREHAT AS IT

WENT DEHN, MAKING HIM ELUGH AND SPLITTER, STILL TLT-TLTTING
AHELT

DANGEREHLS SPEHRTS AND INEPT TEACHERS, MADAM PEMFREY RETREATED,
LEAVING

RHEN AND HERMIONE THE HELP HARRY CLIMB DOWN SOME WATER,

WE WHEN, THERECH, SAID RHEN, A GRIN SPREADING ACROSS HIS FACE,
THAT WAS

SOME CATCH WELL MADE, MALPHY'S FACE . . . HE LOOKED READY THE KILL . . .

I WANT THE DRINK WELL HE FIXED THAT BUDGET, SAID HERMIONE
BARDLY,

WE CAN ADD THAT THE THE LIST OF QUESTIONS WE LL ASK HIM WHEN
WE VE

TAKEN THE PHEWILICE PHTHEN, SAID HARRY, SINKING BACK INTO HIS
PILLOWS. I

HOPE IT TASTES BETTER THAN THIS STUFF . . .

IF IT'S GET RITS OF SLYTHERINS IN IT? WELL VE GET THE BE THINKING, SAID
RHEN,

THE DEER OF THE HOSPITAL WING FIRST OPEN AT THAT MOMENT, FILTHY
AND

SHAKING WET, THE REST OF THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM HAD ARRIVED THE SEE
HARRY,

UNBELIEVABLE FLYING, HARRY, SAID GEORGE. I VE JUST SEEN MARCUS
FLINT

PELLING AT MALPHY, SOMETHING ABOUT HAVING THE SNITCH IN THE OF
HIS HEAD

AND NOT NOTHING, MALPHY DIDN'T SEEM THE HAPPY,

THEY HAD BRIGHT CANDLES, SWEETS, AND BOTTLES OF PLIMPOIN JUICE;
THEY

GATHERED AROUND HARRY'S BED AND WERE JUST GETTING STARTED WHEN
WHAT

PROMISED THE BE A GOOD PARTY WHEN MADAM POMFREY CAME STORMING
EVER,

SHOUTING, THIS KID NEEDS REST, HE'S GET THIRTY-THREE HOURS THE
RECENTLY ELLT?

ELLT?

AND HARRY WAS LEFT ALONE, WITH NOTHING TO DISTRACT HIM FROM THE STARKING

PAINS IN HIS LIMP ARM.

FELTORS AND FEELORS LATER, HARRY WERE ELITE SLIDDERLY IN THE PITCH BLACKNESS

AND GAVE A SMALL YELP OF PAIN: HIS ARM WHEN FELT FULL OF LARGE SPLINTERS. PER

A SECOND, HE THOUGHT THAT WAS WHAT HAD WOKEN HIM. THEN, WITH A THRILL OF

FHRRRR, HE REALIZED THAT SOMEONE WAS SPRINGING HIS FHRFHAD IN THE DARK.

GET OFF? HE SAID LELDLY, AND THEN, DEERY?

THE FHLSE-PL'S GEGGLING TENNIS BALL EYES WERE PEERING AT HARRY THROUGH

THE DARKNESS, A SINGLE TEAR WAS RUNNING DOWN HIS LEGS, PEINTED NICE.

HARRY PHTTER CAME BACK THE SCHEEL, HE WHISPERED MISERABLY, DEERY

WARNED AND WARNED HARRY PHTTER, AH SIR, WHY DIDN'T YELI FEED DEERY? WHY

DIDN'T HARRY PHTTER GO BACK HOME WHEN HE MISSED THE TRAIN?

HARRY HEAVED HIMSELF UP ON HIS PILLELS AND PUSHD DEERY'S SPRING

ALAY.

WHAT'RE YELI DOING HERE? HE SAID, AND FHL DID YELI KNHEW I MISSED

THE TRAIN?

DEERY'S LIP TREMBLED AND HARRY WAS SEIZED BY A SLIDEN SUSPICION.

IT WAS YELL! HE SAID SILENTLY. YELL STOPPED THE BARRIER FROM
LETTING US
THROUGH!

INDEED YES, SIR, SAID DEKKY, NODDING HIS HEAD VIGOROUSLY, EARS
FLAPPING. DEKKY HID AND WATCHED HER HARRY PETER AND SEALED THE
GATEWAY

AND DEKKY HAD TO IRON HIS HANDS AFTERWARD HE STHEWED HARRY
TEN LONG,

RANDAGED FINGERS BUT DEKKY DIDN'T CARE, SIR, FOR HE THOUGHT
HARRY

PETER WAS SAFE, AND NEVER DID DEKKY DREAM THAT HARRY PETER
WOULD GET THE

SOMEHOW ANOTHER WAY!

HE WAS RECKING BACKWARD AND FORWARD, SHAKING HIS UGLY HEAD.

DEKKY WAS SHE SHOOKED WHEN HE HEARD HARRY PETER WAS BACK AT
HIGHTWARTS, HE LET HIS MASTER'S DINNER BURN! SUCH A FLEEING DEKKY
NEVER

HAD, SIR, . . .

HARRY SLUMPED BACK INTO HIS PILLOWS.

YELL NEARLY GOT RUN AND ME EXPELLED, HE SAID FIERCELY. YELL O
BETTER

GET LEFT BEFORE MY KNEES COME BACK, DEKKY, FOR I MIGHT STRANGLE YELL.
DEKKY SMILED WEARILY.

DEKKY IS USED THE DEATH THREATS, SIR, DEKKY GETS THEM FIVE TIMES A DAY
AT

HIMSELF.

HE BLEW HIS NOSE IN A CORNER OF THE FILTHY PILLOWCASE HE WORE,
LEAVING

SEE PATHETIC THAT HARRY FELT HIS ANGER ERE AWAY IN SPITE OF HIMSELF,

WHY D YOU WEAR THAT THING, DEKKY? HE ASKED CLIMBILISLY,

THIS, SIR? SAID DEKKY, PLUCKING AT THE PILLBOXCASE. 'TIS A MARK OF
THE

HOUSE-ELF'S ENSLAVEMENT, SIR, DEKKY CAN ONLY BE FREED IF HIS MASTERS
PRESENT HIM WITH CLOTHES, SIR, THE FAMILY IS CAREFUL NOT TO PASS
DEKKY EVEN

A SHOCK, SIR, AND THEN HE WOULD BE FREE TO LEAVE THEIR HOUSE
ANYWHERE,

DEKKY MIPPED HIS CLINGING EYES AND SAID SLIDDERLY, HARRY BETTER
LIST

OH HOME? DEKKY THOUGHT HIS BILDBER WOULD BE ENOUGH TO MAKE

YELIA BILDBER? SAID HARRY, ANGER RISING HENCE MORE. WHAT D YOU
MEAN,

YELIA BILDBER? YOU MADE THAT BILDBER TRY AND KILL ME?

NOT WILL YOU, SIR, NEVER WILL YOU? SAID DEKKY, SHOCKED, DEKKY
WANTS

THE SAVE HARRY BETTER'S LIFE? BETTER SENT HOME, GRIEVOUSLY INJURED,
THAN

REMAIN HERE, SIR? DEKKY ONLY WANTED HARRY BETTER FIRST ENOUGH TO
BE SENT

HOME?

EH, IS THAT ALL? SAID HARRY ANGRILY, I DONT SUPPOSE YOU'RE
GIVING THE

TELL ME WHY YOU WANTED ME SENT HOME IN PIECES?

AH, IF HARRY BETTER ONLY KNEW? DEKKY GRIEVED, MORE TEARS
DRIPPING

INTO HIS RAGGED PILLBOXCASE. IF HE KNEW WHAT HE MEANS THE LIS, THE
THE LILLY,

THE ENSLAVED, WE DRESS OF THE MAGICAL WORLD? DEKKY REMEMBERS WHEN IT

WAS WHEN THE-WE-H-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED WAS AT THE HEIGHT OF HIS
POWERS,

SIR! WE HELLER-ELVES WERE TREATED LIKE VERMIN, SIR! HE CHLIRSE, DEKKY
IS STILL

TREATED LIKE THAT, SIR, HE ADMITTED, DRYING HIS FACE IN THE
PILLOWCASE. BLIT

MEETLY, SIR, LIFE HAS IMPROVED FOR MY KIND SINCE YOU TRIUMPHED
OVER THE-

WE-H-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED, HARRY POTTER SURVIVED, AND THE DARK
LORD IS

POWER WAS BROKEN, AND IT WAS A NEW DAWN, SIR, AND HARRY POTTER
SEEMED LIKE

A BEACH OF HOPE FOR THOSE OF US WHO THOUGHT THE DARK DAYS
WOULD NEVER

END, SIR, . . . AND NOW, AT HOGWARTS, TERRIBLE THINGS ARE BE HAPPEN,
ARE

PERHAPS HAPPENING ALREADY, AND DEKKY CANNOT LET HARRY POTTER
STAY HERE

NOW THAT HISTORY IS BE REPEAT ITSELF, NOW THAT THE CHAMBER OF
SECRETS IS

OPEN ONCE MORE

DEKKY FREEZE, HERRERSTOLKE, THEN CRACKED HARRY'S WATER ILIC FROM
HIS

BEDSIDE TABLE AND CRACKED IT OVER HIS OWN HEAD, THROPPING BLIT OF
SIGHT, A

SECOND LATER, HE CRAWLED BACK INTO THE BED, CROSS-EYED, MUTTERING,
BAD

DEKKY, VERY BAD DEKKY . . .

SEE THERE IS A CHAMBER OF SECRETS? HARRY WHISPERED, AND DID
PHIL

SAY IT'S BEEN OPENED BEFORE? TELL ME, DEKKY?

HE SEIZED THE ELF'S BONY WRIST AS DEKKY'S HAND INCHED TOWARD THE
WATER

ILG, BUT I'M NOT MUGGLE-BORN HOW CAN I BE IN DANGER FROM THE
CHAMBER?

AH, SIR, ASK ME MORE, ASK ME MORE OF PETER DEKKY, STAMPERED THE
ELF,

HIS EYES FLICK IN THE DARK. DARK DEEDS ARE PLANNED IN THIS PLACE,
BUT HARRY

PETER MUST NOT BE HERE WHEN THEY HAPPEN. OH FINE, HARRY
PETER, OH

FINE, HARRY PETER MUST NOT MEDDLE IN THIS, SIR, IT'S THE
DANGEROUS

WHAT IS IT, DEKKY? HARRY SAID, KEEPING A FIRM HOLD ON DEKKY'S
WRIST THE

STEP HIM FROM HITTING HIMSELF WITH THE WATER ILG AGAIN. WHAT'S
HAPPENED IT?

WHAT HAPPENED IT LAST TIME?

DEKKY CAN'T, SIR, DEKKY CAN'T, DEKKY MUSTN'T TELL! SHEARED THE ELF,

OH FINE, HARRY PETER, OH FINE!

I'M NOT GOING ANYWHERE! SAID HARRY FIRMLY. ONE OF MY BEST
FRIENDS

IS MUGGLE-BORN; SHE'LL BE FIRST IN LINE IF THE CHAMBER REALLY HAS
BEEN

HAPPENED

HARRY PETER RISKS HIS OWN LIFE FOR HIS FRIENDS! MEANED DEKKY IN
A

KIND OF MISERABLE ECSTASY. SEE NECK! SEE VALIANT! BUT HE MUST SAVE

HIMSELF, HE MUST, HARRY POTTER MUST MEET

DEKKY SUDDENLY FREEZE, HIS BAT EARS HULVERING, HARRY HEARD IT, THEN, THERE

WERE FEETSTEPS COMING DOWN THE PASSAGELAY ELTIDE,

DEKKY MUST CHEE BREATHE THE EL, TERRIFIED, THERE WAS A HELD CRACK, AND HARRY S FIST WAS SUDDENLY CLENCHED IN THIN AIR, HE SLUMPED BACK INTO

RED, HIS EYES IN THE DARK DEERWAY THE THE HOSPITAL WING AS THE FEETSTEPS

DREW NEARER,

NEXT MOMENT, OLIMPEDERE WAS BACKING INTO THE DEERMITERY, WEARING A

LONG WHILLY DRESSING GOWN AND A NIGHTCAP, HE WAS CARRYING ONE END OF

WHAT LOOKED LIKE A STATUE, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL APPEARED A SECOND LATER,

CARRYING ITS FEET, TOGETHER, THEY HEAVED IT INTO A RED,

GET MADAM PEMFREY, WHISPERED OLIMPEDERE, AND PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL FLURRIED PAST THE END OF HARRY S RED UNTIL HE SIGHT, HARRY LAY

ELITE STILL, PRETENDING TO BE ASLEEP, HE HEARD URGENT VEHICLES, AND THEN

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SWIFT BACK INTO VIEW, CLOSELY FOLLOWED BY MADAM

PEMFREY, WHO WAS PULLING A CARDIGAN OVER HER NIGHTDRESS, HE HEARD A

SHARP INTAKE OF BREATH,

WHAT HAPPENED? MADAM PEMFREY WHISPERED TO OLIMPEDERE, BENDING

EVER THE STATUE IN THE RED.

ANOTHER ATTACK, SAID DUMKEDDRE. MINERYA FELT HIM IN THE STAIRS.

THERE WAS A BUNCH OF GRAPES NEXT TO HIM, SAID PROFESSOR MCGENAGALL.

WE THINK HE WAS TRYING TO SNEAK UP HERE TO VISIT BETTER.

HARRY'S STOMACH GAVE A TERRIBLE LURCH. SILENTLY AND CAREFULLY, HE RAISED

HIMSELF A FEW INCHES SO HE COULD LOOK AT THE STATUE IN THE RED. A RAY OF

MIDNIGHT LAY ACROSS ITS STARING FACE.

IT WAS CELIN CREEVEY. HIS EYES WERE WIDE AND HIS HANDS WERE STUCK UP IN

FRONT OF HIM, HOLDING HIS CAMERA.

PETRIFIED? WHISPERED MADAM PEMFREY.

YES, SAID PROFESSOR MCGENAGALL. BUT I SHOULDER TO THINK... IF

HADN'T BEEN IN THE WAY DOWNSTAIRS FOR THE CHELATE WE

MIGHT HAVE

THE THREE OF THEM STARED DOWN AT CELIN. THEN DUMKEDDRE LEANED FORWARD AND WRENCHED THE CAMERA AWAY FROM CELIN'S RIGID GRIP.

WELL DIDN'T THINK HE MANAGED TO GET A PICTURE OF HIS ATTACKER? SAID

PROFESSOR MCGENAGALL RAGERLY.

DUMKEDDRE DIDN'T ANSWER. HE OPENED THE BACK OF THE CAMERA.

GOOD GRACIES! SAID MADAM PEMFREY.

AS IF THE STEAM HAD HISSED OUT OF THE CAMERA, FARRY, THREE REDS
AWAY,

CALIGHT THE ACRID SMELL OF BURNING PLASTIC.

MELTED, SAID MADAM PEMFREY WANDERINGLY. ALL MELTED ...

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN, ARLIS? PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL ASKED
URGENTLY.

IT MEANS, SAID DUMKLEBHERE, THAT THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS IS INDEED
OPEN AGAIN.

MADAM PEMFREY CLAPPED A HAND TO HER MOUTH. PROFESSOR
MCGINNAGALL

STARED AT DUMKLEBHERE.

BUT, ARLIS ... SURELY ... WHEN?

THE QUESTION IS NOT WHEN, SAID DUMKLEBHERE, HIS EYES WERE FLEETING.
THE

QUESTION IS, WHEN, ...

AND FROM WHAT FARRY COULD SEE OF PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL'S
SHADENESS

FACE, SHE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND THIS ANY BETTER THAN HE DID.

—

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE DULCINE CLUB

ARRY WOKED UP ON SUNDAY MORNING TO FIND THE DORMITORY BLAZING
WITH

WINTER SUNLIGHT AND HIS ARM REHEARD BUT VERY STIFF. HE SAT UP

SLICKLY AND WHIPPED OVER AT CHERIN'S BED, BUT IT HAD BEEN KICKED FROM
VIEW

BY THE HIGH CURTAINS HARRY HAD CHANGED BEDDING YESTERDAY, SEEING
THAT HE

WAS AWAKE, MADAM POMFREY CAME KLITING OVER WITH A BREAKFAST
TRAY AND

THEN BEGAN BENDING AND STRETCHING HIS ARM AND FINGERS,

ALL IN ORDER, SHE SAID AS HE CLUMSILY FED HIMSELF PERRIDGE LEFT-
HANDED,

WHEN YOU'VE FINISHED EATING, YOU MAY LEAVE,

HARRY DRESSED AS SLICKLY AS HE COULD AND HURRIED OFF THE
GRYFFINDOR

TOILET, DESPERATE TO TELL RON AND HERMIONIE ABOUT CHERIN AND DEEKE,
BUT

THEY WEREN'T THERE, HARRY LEFT THE LOCK FOR THEM, WONDERING WHERE
THEY

COULD HAVE GOTTEN AND FEELING SLIGHTLY HURT THAT THEY WEREN'T
INTERESTED IN

WHETHER HE HAD HIS KNEES BACK FOR HIM,

AS HARRY PASSED THE LIBRARY, PERCY WEASLEY STROLLLED UP IT,
LOOKING IN

FAR BETTER SPIRITS THAN LAST TIME THEY'D MET,

HEY, HELLO, HARRY, HE SAID, EXCELLENT FLYING YESTERDAY, REALLY
EXCELLENT,

GRYFFINDOR HAS JUST TAKEN THE LEAD FOR THE HOUSE CUP YOU
EARNED FIFTY

POINTS?

YOU HAVEN'T SEEN RON OR HERMIONIE, HAVE YOU? SAID HARRY,

NO, I HAVEN'T, SAID PERCY, HIS SMILE FADING, I HOPE RON'S NOT IN

ANOTHER GIRLS THIEF,...

HARRY PERCEIVED A LAUGH, WATCHED PERCY WALK OUT OF SIGHT, AND THEN
HEADED

STRAIGHT FOR MEANING MORTLE'S BATHROOM, HE COULDN'T SEE WHY
RHN AND

HERMIONE WOULD BE IN THERE AGAIN, BUT AFTER MAKING SURE THAT
NEITHER FILCH

AND PROFFERS WERE AROUND, HE OPENED THE DOOR AND HEARD THEIR
VEHICLES

COMING FROM A LOCKED STALL.

IT'S ME, HE SAID, CRESTING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM. THERE WAS A CLUNK,
A

SPLASH, AND A GASP FROM WITHIN THE STALL AND HE SAW HERMIONE'S
EYE PEERING

THROUGH THE KEYHOLE.

HARRY? SHE SAID. WELL GAVE US SUCH A FRIGHT COME IN
HERE'S YOUR

ARMY

FINE, SAID HARRY, SLEEPING INTO THE STALL. AN OLD CALIBREEN WAS
PERCHED ON THE THIEF, AND A CRACKLING FROM UNDER THE RIM TOLD
HARRY THEY

HAD LIT A FIRE BENEATH IT. CHIMING UP PERTABLY, WATERPROOF FIRES
WAS A

SPECIALITY OF HERMIONE'S.

WE'D WE COME TO MEET YOU, BUT WE DECIDED TO GET STARTED ON THE
PENALTY PENITENCE. RHN EXPLAINED AS HARRY, WITH DIFFICULTY, LOCKED
THE STALL

AGAIN. WE'VE DECIDED THIS IS THE SAFEST PLACE TO HIDE IT.

HARRY STARTED TO TELL THEM ABOUT THE PLAN, BUT HERMIONE INTERRUPTED.

WE ALREADY KNOW WE HEARD PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TELLING
PROFESSOR

FLITWICK THIS MORNING, THAT'S WHY WE DECIDED WE'D BETTER GET GOING

THE SOONER WE GET A CONFESSOR HELT BY MALFOY, THE BETTER,
SNARLED RON.

DID YOU KNOW WHAT I THINK? HE WAS IN SUCH A FURRY TEMPER AFTER
THE

SLURDITCH MATCH, HE THOUGHT IT HELT HIM DOWN.

THERE'S SOMETHING ELSE, SAID HARRY, WATCHING HERMION'S TEARING
BLINDLES OF DUNTERGRASS AND THROWING THEM INTO THE POTION. DROPPY
CAME TO

VISIT ME IN THE MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT.

RON AND HERMION'S MOUTHED UP, AMAZED. HARRY TOLD THEM EVERYTHING
DROPPY HAD TOLD HIM HE HADN'T TOLD HIM. HERMION AND RON
LISTENED

WITH THEIR MOUTHS OPEN.

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS HAS BEEN OPENED BEFORE? HERMION SAID.

THIS SETTLES IT, SAID RON IN A TRIUMPHANT VOICE. LUCIUS MALFOY
MUST'VE OPENED THE CHAMBER WHEN HE WAS AT SCHOOL HERE AND NOW
HE'S

TOLD DRACON HED DRACON HED THE DO IT. IT'S OBVIOUS, WISH DROPPY'D TOLD
YOU WHAT

KIND OF MINSTER'S IN THERE, HOWEVER, I WANT TO KNOW HOW COME
NONE OF US

NOTICED IT SNEAKING AROUND THE SCHOOL.

MAYBE IT CAN MAKE ITSELF INVISIBLE, SAID HERMION, PRODDING
BOOKS

THE THE RITTHEN OF THE CALIDREN. HER MAKE IT CAN DISGUISE ITSELF
PRETEND

THE BE A SLIT OF ARMOR HER SOMETHING I VE READ ABOUT CHAMBERN
CHILD

YELL READ THE MUCH, FERMINE, SAID DEN, FEELING DEAD LACKINGS
HEN

THEP OF THE LEECHES, HE CRUMPLED UP THE EMPTY LACKING BAG AND
LIMBED AT

HARRY,

SEE DEKEY STOPPED US FROM GETTING HIM THE TRAIN AND KNEED YELL
ARM, ... HE STOOD HIS HEAD. YELL KNOW WHAT, HARRY? IF HE
DESEN T STEP

TRYING THE SAVE YELL LIFE HE S CHING THE KILL YELL,

THE NEWS THAT LILIN CREEVEY HAD BEEN ATTACKED AND WAS NOW LYING
AS

THOUGH DEAD IN THE HOSPITAL WING HAD SPREAD THROUGH THE ENTIRE
SCHOOL BY

MONDAY MORNING, THE AIR WAS SUDDENLY THICK WITH RUMOR AND
SUSPICION.

THE FIRST YEARS WERE NOW MOVING AROUND THE CASTLE IN TIGHT-KNIT
GRIPS, AS

THOUGH SCARED THEY WOULD BE ATTACKED IF THEY VENTURED FORTH
ALONE.

GINNY WEASLEY, WHO SAT NEXT THE LILIN CREEVEY IN CHAIRS, WAS
DISTRAUGHT, BUT HARRY FELT THAT FRED AND GEORGE WERE CHING THE
WRONG WAY

ABOUT CHEERING HER UP. THEY WERE TAKING TURNS COVERING
THEMSELVES WITH

FOR HER KILLS AND LIMPING HLT AT HER FROM BEHIND STATUES. THEY
ONLY STOPPED

WHEN PERCY, APPROPRIATE WITH RAGE, TOLD THEM HE WAS GOING TO WRITE
THE MRS.

WEASLEY AND TELL HER GINNY WAS HAVING NIGHTMARES.

MEANWHILE, HIDDEN FROM THE TEACHERS, A REPAIRING TRADE IN TALISMANS,
AMULETS, AND OTHER PROTECTIVE DEVICES WAS SWEPTING THE SCHOOL.
NEVILLE

LONGHEATHEN BRUGHT A LARGE, EVIL-SMELLING GREEN HORNED, A PAINTED
PURPLE

CRYSTAL, AND A ROTTING NEWT TAIL BEHIND THE OTHER CROPPINGHORNS
PRINTED

HELT THAT HE WAS IN NEW DANGER; HE WAS A PURPLEHEAD, AND THEREFORE
UNLIKELY THE

BE ATTACKED.

THEY WENT FOR FILCH FIRST, NEVILLE SAID, HIS REDDISH FACE FEARFUL,
AND

EVERYONE KNOWS I'M ALMOST A SELLER.

IN THE SECOND WEEK OF DECEMBER PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CAME
ARRIVING AS

USUAL, COLLECTING NAMES OF THOSE WHO WOULD BE STAYING AT SCHOOL
FOR

CHRISTMAS, HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE SIGNED HER LIST; THEY HAD
HEARD THAT

MALFOY WAS STAYING, WHICH STRUCK THEM AS VERY SUSPICIOUS. THE
HOLIDAYS

WOULD BE THE PERFECT TIME TO USE THE POLYLUX POTION AND TRY TO
WHISK A

CONFESSION HELT OF HIM.

UNFORTUNATELY, THE POTION WAS ONLY HALF FINISHED. THEY STILL
NEEDED THE

RICHARD HERN AND THE RHINOSLAVE SKIN, AND THE ONLY PLACE THEY WERE
GOING TO

GET THEM WAS FROM SNAPE'S PRIVATE STORES. HARRY PRIVATELY FELT
HE'D RATHER

FACE SLYTHERIN'S LEGENDARY MINSTER THAN LET SNAPE CATCH HIM
RECKING HIS

OFFICE.

WHAT WE NEED, SAID HERMIONE BRISKLY AS THURSDAY AFTERNOON'S
DELIVER

POTIONS LESSON BEHEM NEARER, IS A DIVERSION. THEN HERE WE CAN
SNEAK

INTO SNAPE'S OFFICE AND TAKE WHAT WE NEED.

HARRY AND RON LOOKED AT HER NERVOUSLY.

I THINK I'D BETTER DO THE ACTUAL STEALING, HERMIONE CONTINUED IN
A

MATTER-OF-FACT TONE. YOU TWO WILL BE EXPELLED IF YOU GET INTO ANY
MORE

TROUBLE, AND I'VE GOT A CLEAN RECORD. SEE ALL YOU NEED TO DO IS CALISE
ENOUGH

MAYHEM TO KEEP SNAPE BUSY FOR FIVE MINUTES FOR ME.

HARRY SMILED PEELY, DELIBERATELY CALLING MAYHEM IN SNAPE'S
POTIONS

CLASS WAS ASHELT AS SAFE AS PICKING A SLEEPING DRAGON IN THE EYE.

POTIONS LESSONS TOOK PLACE IN ONE OF THE LARGE DUNGEONS,
THURSDAY

AFTERNOON'S LESSON PROCEEDED IN THE USUAL WAY. TWENTY CALIBRENS
STEED

STEAMING BETWEEN THE WOODEN DESKS, IN WHICH STEED BRASS SCALES
AND IARS

HE INGREDIENTS. SNAPE PREHELD THROUGH THE FLAMES, MAKING WASPISH REMARKS

ABEELT THE GRYFFINDERS WHOX WHILE THE SLYTHERINS SNIGGERED APPRECIATIVELY.

DRACH MALPBY, WHO WAS SNAPE S FAVORITE STUDENT, KEPT FLICKING PLIPPER-FISH

EYES AT REIN AND HARRY, WHO KNEW THAT IF THEY RETALIATED THEY WOULD GET

DETENTION FASTER THAN YELL COULD SAY LINGER.

HARRY S SWELLING SHELLTINN WAS FAR THEE BLINDY, BUT HE HAD HIS MIND ON

MORE IMPORTANT THINGS. HE WAS WAITING FOR HERMIONE S SIGNAL, AND HE

HARDLY LISTENED AS SNAPE PALSED THE SNEER AT HIS WATERY PETITION. WHEN SNAPE

TURNED AND WALKED OFF THE KILLY NEVILLE, HERMIONE CALIGHT HARRY S EYE AND

NEEDED.

HARRY BLICKED SWIFTLY BEHIND HIS CALIBREIN, PULLED ONE OF FRED S

FILIKSTER FIREWERKS OUT OF HIS POCKET, AND GAVE IT A HELICK PRED WITH HIS

WAND. THE FIREWERK BEGAN THE FIZZ AND SPLITTER, KNOWING HE HAD ONLY

SECONDS, HARRY STRAIGHTENED UP, THEE AIM, AND LERKED IT INTO THE AIR. IT

LANDED RIGHT ON TARGET IN CHOYLE S CALIBREIN.

CHOYLE S PETITION EXPLODED, SHOWERING THE WHOLE CLASS. PEOPLE SHRIEKED AS

SPLASHES OF THE SWELLING SHELLTINN HIT THEM. MALPBY GOT A FACEFLA AND HIS

NEVER BEGAN THE SWELL LIKE A ROLLING SEA, GEORGE ROLLERED AROUND, HIS HANDS FLYING

HIS EYES, WHICH HAD EXPANDED THE SIZE OF A DINNER PLATE
SNAPPE WAS

TRYING THE RESTORE CALM AND FIND OUT WHAT HAD HAPPENED, THROUGH
THE

CONVULSION, HARRY SAW HERMION SLIP QUIETLY INTO SNAPPE'S OFFICE.

SILENCE! SILENCE! SNAPPE REARED, ANYONE WHO HAS BEEN
SPLASHED,

COME HERE FOR A DEFLATING DRAUGHT WHEN I FIND OUT WHO DID THIS

HARRY TRIED NOT TO LAUGH AS HE WATCHED MALFOY HURRY FORWARD,
HIS HEAD

BREATHING WITH THE WEIGHT OF A NECK LIKE A SMALL MULE, AS HALF
THE CLASS

BLINKED UP THE SNAPPE'S DESK, SOME WEIGHTED DOWN WITH ARMS LIKE
CLUBS,

EITHERS UNABLE TO TALK THROUGH GIGANTIC PUFFED-UP LIPS, HARRY
SAW HERMION

SLIDE BACK INTO THE DUNGEON, THE FRONT OF HER REARS CLINGING.

WHEN EVERYONE HAD TAKEN A SLUG OF ANTIDOTE AND THE VARIOUS
SWELLINGS

HAD SUBSIDED, SNAPPE SWEEPED OVER THE GEORGE'S CALLOUS AND SCHEPPE
OUT THE

TWISTED BLACK REMAINS OF THE FIREWORK. THERE WAS A SUDDEN FLUSH.

IF I EVER FIND OUT WHO THREW THIS, SNAPPE WHISPERED, I SHALL
MAKE SURE

THAT PERSON IS EXPELLED.

HARRY ARRANGED HIS FACE INTO WHAT HE FEELT WAS A PUZZLED
EXPRESSION.

SNAPE WAS LEERING RIGHT AT HIM, AND THE BELL THAT RANG TEN MINUTES LATER

COULD NOT HAVE BEEN MORE WELCOME.

HE KNEW IT WAS ME, HARRY TOLD RON AND HERMION AS THEY FLURRIED

BACK THE MEANING MYRTLE'S KATHREEN. I COULD TELL.

HERMION THREW THE NEW INGREDIENTS INTO THE CALIBREIN AND BEGAN THE STIR

FEVERISHLY.

IT LL BE READY IN TWO WEEKS, SHE SAID HAPPILY.

SNAPE CAN'T PROVE IT WAS YOU, SAID RON REASSURINGLY TO HARRY. WHAT

CAN HE DO?

KNOWING SNAPE, SOMETHING FEEL, SAID HARRY AS THE POTTERN FRETTED AND

CLICKED.

A WEEK LATER, HARRY, RON, AND HERMION WERE WALKING ACROSS THE ENTRANCE

HALL WHEN THEY SAW A SMALL KNIGHT OF PEOPLE GATHERED AROUND THE NOTICE

BOARD, READING A PIECE OF PARCEMENT THAT HAD JUST BEEN PINNED UP. SEAMUS

FINNIGAN AND DEAN THOMAS RECKENED THEM EVER, LEERING EXCITED.

THEY'RE STARTING A DUELING CLUB? SAID SEAMUS. FIRST MEETING TONIGHT?

I WOULDN'T MIND DUELING LESSONS; THEY MIGHT COME IN HANDY ONE OF THESE

DAYS, . . .

WHAT, YOU RECKON SLYTHERIN'S MENSTER CAN DUEL? SAID RON, BUT HE, THEN,

READ THE SIGN WITH INTEREST.

CHILD BE USEFUL, HE SAID TO HARRY AND HERMIONE AS THEY WENT INTO

DINNER. SHALL WE GO?

HARRY AND HERMIONE WERE ALL FOR IT, SEE AT RIGHT HE CHECKED THAT EVENING THEY

HURRIED BACK TO THE GREAT HALL. THE LONG DINING TABLES HAD VANISHED AND A

GOLDEN STAGE HAD APPEARED ALONG ONE WALL, LIT BY THOUSANDS OF CANDLES

FLASHING OVERHEAD. THE CEILING WAS VELVET BLACK AND THERE AND NEARBY

THE SEATERS SEEMED TO BE PACKED BENEATH IT, ALL CARRYING THEIR HANDS AND

LOOKING EXCITED.

I WONDER WHO WILL BE TEACHING US? SAID HERMIONE AS THEY EDGED INTO THE

CHATTERING CROWD. SOMEONE TOLD ME FLITWICK WAS A DWELING CHAMPION

WHEN HE WAS YOUNG. MAYBE IT WILL BE HIM.

AS LONG AS IT'S NOT HARRY BEGAN, BUT HE ENDED HIM A GRIMACE GILDERHOY

LEIGHTON WAS WALKING DOWN THE STAGE, RESPLENDENT IN RICHES OF DEEP PURPLE

AND ACCOMPANIED BY NONE OTHER THAN SNAPE, WEARING HIS USUAL BLACK.

LEIGHTON WAIVED AN ARM FOR SILENCE AND CALLED, GATHER AROUND, GATHER

AROUND! CAN EVERYONE SEE ME? CAN YOU ALL HEAR ME? EXCELLENT!

Now, Professor Dumbledore has granted me permission to start this

little blinking club, the train will all in case will ever need to defend themselves as I myself have done on countless occasions for all

details, see my published works.

Let me introduce my assistant, Professor Snape, said Lockhart, flashing a wide smile. He tells me he knows a tiny little bit about blinking

himself and has sportingly agreed to help me with a short demonstration

before we begin. Now, I don't want any of you youngsters to worry

you'll still have your petting master when I'm through with him, never

fear!

Wouldn't it be good if they finished each other off? Ron muttered in

Harry's ear.

Snape's upper lip was curling. Harry wondered why Lockhart was still

smiling; if Snape had been looking at him like that he'd have been running

as fast as he could in the opposite direction.

Lockhart and Snape turned the face each other and smiled; at least, Lockhart did, with much twirling of his hands, whereas Snape

knocked his head irritably. Then they raised their wands like swords in front of them.

AS YOU SEE, WE ARE HOLDING OUR WANDS IN THE ACCEPTED COMBATIVE POSITION, LUCIFART THROU THE SILENT CROWD. IN THE COUNT OF THREE, WE WILL

CAST OUR FIRST SPELLS. NEITHER OF US WILL BE AIMING TO KILL, OF COURSE.

I WOULDN'T BET ON THAT, HARRY MURMURED, WATCHING SNAPE Baring his

TEETH.

ONE TWO THREE

BOTH OF THEM SWUNG THEIR WANDS ABOVE THEIR HEADS AND POINTED THEM AT

THEIR OPPONENT; SNAPE CRIED: EXPELLIARMUS! THERE WAS A DAZZLING FLASH

OF SCARLET LIGHT AND LUCIFART WAS BLASTED OFF HIS FEET: HE FLEW BACKWARD

OFF THE STAGE, SMASHED INTO THE WALL, AND SLID DOWN IT TO SPRAWL ON THE

FLOOR.

MALFOY AND SOME OF THE OTHER SLYTHERINS CHEERED. HERMIONE WAS DANCING ON TIPTOES. DO YOU THINK HE'S ALL RIGHT? SHE SEEMED THROUGH HER

FINGERS.

WE'LL CARE? SAID HARRY AND RON TOGETHER.

LUCIFART WAS GETTING UNSTEADILY ON HIS FEET. HIS HAT HAD FALLEN OFF AND

HIS WAVY HAIR WAS STANDING ON END.

WELL, THERE YOU HAVE IT! HE SAID, TITTERING BACK TOWARD THE PLATFORM.

THAT WAS A DISARMING CHARM AS YOU SEE, I'VE LOST MY WAND AL-

THANK YOU, MISS BROWN YES, AN EXCELLENT IDEA THE SHEW THEM
THAT,

PROFESSOR SNAPE, BUT IF YOU DONT MIND MY SAYING SO, IT WAS VERY
HEAVILY

WHAT YOU WERE ABOUT TO DO. IF I HAD WANTED THE STEP YOU IT WOULD
HAVE BEEN

ONLY THE EASY HOWEVER, I FELT IT WOULD BE INSTRUCTIVE THE LET
THEM SEE ...

SNAPE WAS LOOKING MURDEROUS, POSSIBLY LUCIFART HAD NOTICED,
BECAUSE

HE SAID, ENOUGH DEMONSTRATING! I M GOING TO COME AMONGST YOU
NOW AND

PUT YOU ALL INTO PAIRS, PROFESSOR SNAPE, IF YOU D LIKE TO HELP ME

THEY MOVED THROUGH THE CROWD, MATCHING UP PARTNERS, LUCIFART
TEAMED

NEVILLE WITH JUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHER, BUT SNAPE REACHED HARRY AND
RON

FIRST,

TIME TO SPLIT UP THE DREAM TEAM, I THINK, HE SNEERED. WEASLEY,
YOU

CAN PARTNER FINNIGAN, BETTER

HARRY MOVED ALTERNATIVELY TOWARD HERMIONE.

I DONT THINK SO, SAID SNAPE, SMILING COLDLY. MR. MALFOY, COME
EVER

HERE, LET S SEE WHAT YOU MAKE OF THE FAMILIAR BETTER, AND YOU,
MISS

GRANGER YOU CAN PARTNER MISS BLUSTON.

MALFOY STRUTTED EVER, SMIRKING, BEHIND HIM WALKED A SLYTHERIN
GIRL WHO

REMINDED HARRY OF A PICTURE HE'D SEEN IN HOLIDAYS WITH JACS. SHE WAS

LARGE AND SLENDER AND HER HEAVY LIDS LITTED AGGRESSIVELY. HERMIONE GAVE HER

A WEADE SMILE THAT SHE DID NOT RETURN.

FACE THEIR PARTNERS? CALLED LUCIFERT, BACK IN THE PLATHEM.
AND

HELD?

HARRY AND MALFOY BARELY INCLINED THEIR HEADS, NOT TAKING THEIR EYES OFF

EACH OTHER.

WANDS AT THE READY? SHELLT LUCIFERT. WHEN I CHLINT THE THREE, LAST

THEIR CHAMS THE DISARM THEIR OPPONENTS ONLY THE DISARM THEM
WE

DEN'T WANT ANY ACCIDENTS ONE ... TWO ... THREE

HARRY SWUNG HIS WAND HIGH, BUT MALFOY HAD ALREADY STARTED HIS
TWO :

HIS SPELL HIT HARRY SHE HARD HE FELT AS THOUGH HE'D BEEN HIT OVER THE HEAD

WITH A SALLERAN. HE STUMBLER, BUT EVERYTHING STILL SEEMED TO BE WHIRLING.

AND WASTING NO MORE TIME, HARRY POINTED HIS WAND STRAIGHT AT MALFOY AND

SHELLT, RITLISEMPRA?

A JET OF SILVER LIGHT HIT MALFOY IN THE STOMACH AND HE DUKLED UP, WHIZZING.

I SAID DISARM ONLY? LUCIFERT SHELLT IN ALARM OVER THE HEADS OF THE

BATTLING CRIED, AS MALFOY SAND THE HIS KNEES; HARRY HAD HIT HIM WITH A

TICKLING CHARM, AND HE COULD BARELY MOVE HER LAUGHING, HARRY FLYING BACK,

WITH A VAGUE FEELING IT WOULD BE UNSPORTING THE REWITCH MALFOY WHILE HE

WAS IN THE FLEET, BUT THIS WAS A MISTAKE; GASPING FOR BREATH, MALFOY

POINTED HIS HAND AT HARRY'S KNEES, CHIEF, TARANTALLERA! AND THE NEXT

SECOND HARRY'S LEGS BEGAN THE IRK AND HE FELT OF HIS CENTRE IN A KIND OF

WILKINSTEP,

STEP! STEP! SCREAMED LUCIFER, BUT SNAPE THEM CHARGE,

FINITE INCANTATEM! HE SHOUTED; HARRY'S FEET STOPPED DANCING, MALFOY

STOPPED LAUGHING, AND THEY WERE ABLE TO WEND UP,

A HAZE OF GREENISH SMOKE WAS HEAVING OVER THE SCENE, BOTH NEVILLE

AND JUSTIN WERE LYING IN THE FLEET, PANTING; REIN WAS FEELING UP AN ASHEN-

FADED SCARLS, APPEALING HER WHATEVER HIS KNEEDEN HAND HAD DONE; BUT

HERMIONE AND MILLICENT BULSTREDE WERE STILL MOVING; MILLICENT HAD

HERMIONE IN A HEADLOCK AND HERMIONE WAS WHIMPERING IN PAIN; BOTH THEIR

HANDS LAY FORTHETEN IN THE FLEET, HARRY LEAPT FORWARD AND PULLED MILLICENT

OFF, IT WAS DIFFICULT! SHE WAS A BIT BIGGER THAN HE WAS,

DEAR, DEAR, SAID LUCIFERT, SKITTERING THROUGH THE CREEP,
LEEDING AT THE

AFTERMATH OF THE DUELS. UP SHE GO, MACMILLAN, ... CAREFUL THERE,
MISS

FALCETT, ... PINCH IT HARD, IT LL STOP BLEEDING IN A SECOND, BENT

I THINK I D BETTER TEACH YOU FEEL THE BLOOD UNFRIENDLY SPELLS, SAID
LUCIFERT, STANDING ALISTERED IN THE MIDST OF THE HALL, HE GLANCED
AT SNAPE,

WHOSE BLACK EYES GLINTED, AND LEEDED QUICKLY AWAY. LET S HAVE A
VOLUNTEER PAIR LUCIFERTHEM AND FINCH-FLETCHLEY, FEEL ABILITY
YOU

A BAD IDEA, PROFESSOR LUCIFERT, SAID SNAPE, GLIDING EVER LIKE A
LARGE

AND MALEVOLENT BAT. LUCIFERTHEM CAUSES DEVASTATION WITH THE
SIMPLEST

SPELLS, WE LL BE SENDING WHAT S LEFT OF FINCH-FLETCHLEY UP THE THE
HOSPITAL

WING IN A MATCH-BOX, NEVILLE S REHIND, PINK FACE WENT PINKER,
FEEL ABILITY

MALFOY AND PITTERY SAID SNAPE WITH A TWISTED SMILE,

EXCELLENT IDEA! SAID LUCIFERT, CESTLING HARRY AND MALFOY INTO
THE

MIDDLE OF THE HALL AS THE CREEP BACKED AWAY THE GIVE THEM ROOM,

WELL, HARRY, SAID LUCIFERT, WHEN DRACE POINTS HIS HAND AT
YOU, YOU

DO THIS,

HE RAISED HIS OWN WAND, ATTEMPTED A COMPLICATED SORT OF WIGGLING ACTION, AND DROPPED IT. SNAPE SMIRKED AS LUCIFERTART QUICKLY PICKED IT UP,

SAYING, WEEHHS MY WAND IS A LITTLE OVEREXCITED

SNAPE MOVED CLOSER TO MALFOY, BENT DOWN, AND WHISPERED SOMETHING IN

HIS EAR. MALFOY SMIRKED, THEN, HARRY LOOKED UP NERVOUSLY AT LUCIFERTART AND

SAID, PROFESSOR, COULD YOU SHOW ME THAT BLOODY THING AGAIN?

STARED? MUTTERED MALFOY, SEE THAT LUCIFERTART COULDN'T HEAR HIM.

YOU WISH, SAID HARRY OUT OF THE CORNER OF HIS MOUTH.

LUCIFERTART CLIPPED HARRY MERRILY ON THE SHOULDER. I'LL SEE WHAT I DID,

HARRY?

WHAT, DROP MY WAND?

BUT LUCIFERTART WASN'T LISTENING.

THREE TWO ONE GO! HE SHOUTED.

MALFOY RAISED HIS WAND QUICKLY AND BELLEHED, SERPENSERTIA!

THE END OF HIS WAND EXPLODED. HARRY WATCHED, AGAST, AS A LONG BLACK

SNAKE SHOT OUT OF IT, FELL HEAVILY INTO THE FLEET BETWEEN THEM, AND RAISED

ITSELF, READY TO STRIKE. THERE WERE SCREAMS AS THE CROWD BACKED SWIFTLY

AWAY, CLEARING THE FLEET.

DON'T MOVE, PITTER, SAID SNAPE LAZILY, CLEARLY ENJOYING THE SIGHT OF

HARRY STANDING MEETHESS, EYE TO EYE WITH THE ANGRY SNAKE. I'LL GET RID OF

IT, . . .

ALLHEW ME? SEEMED LIKED-HART, HE BRANDISHED HIS HAND AT THE
SNAKE AND

THERE WAS A LUDIC RANG; THE SNAKE, INSTEAD OF VANISHING, FLEW TEN
FEET INTO

THE AIR AND FELL BACK TO THE FLOOR WITH A LUDIC SMACK. ENRAGED,
HISSING

FLURRIEDLY, IT SLITHERED STRAIGHT TOWARD JUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHER AND
RAISED

ITSELF AGAIN, FANGS EXPOSED, POISED TO STRIKE.

HARRY WASN'T SURE WHAT MADE HIM DO IT, HE WASN'T EVEN AWARE OF
DECIDING TO DO IT. ALL HE KNEW WAS THAT HIS LEGS WERE CARRYING HIM
FORWARD

AS THOUGH HE WAS HIS MASTER AND THAT HE HAD SEEMED STUPIDLY AT
THE SNAKE,

LEAVE HIM ALONE! AND MIRACULOUSLY INEXPLICABLY THE
SNAKE

SLUMPED TO THE FLOOR, DEFILE AS A THICK, BLACK GARDEN FEESE, ITS EYES
NEED HIS

HARRY, HARRY FELT THE FEAR DRAIN OUT OF HIM, HE KNEW THE SNAKE
WOULDN'T

ATTACK ANYONE NEAR, THOUGH HEW HE KNEW IT, HE COULDN'T HAVE
EXPLAINED.

HE WHISKED UP AT JUSTIN, GRINNING, EXPECTING TO SEE JUSTIN WHISKING
RELIEVED, OR PUZZLED, OR EVEN GRATEFUL BUT CERTAINLY NOT ANGRY
AND
STARED.

WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'RE PLAYING AT? HE SEEMED, AND THERE
HARRY

CHILD SAY ANYTHING, LUSTIN HAD TURNED AND STORMED OUT OF THE HALL, SNAPE STEPPED FORWARD, WAVED HIS HAND, AND THE SNAPE VANISHED IN A

SMALL PUFF OF BLACK SMOKE. SNAPE, THEN, WAS LOOKING AT HARRY IN AN UNEXPECTED WAY: IT WAS A STERN AND CALCULATING LOOK, AND HARRY DIDN'T

LIKE IT. HE WAS ALSO DIMLY AWARE OF AN EMINENTLY MUTTERING ALL AROUND THE

WALLS. THEN HE FELT A TUGGING ON THE BACK OF HIS REEKS.

COME ON, SAID RON'S VOICE IN HIS EAR. MOVE COME ON RON STEPPED HIM OUT OF THE HALL, HERMIONE FLIRRYING ALONGSIDE THEM. AS

THEY WENT THROUGH THE DOORS, THE PEOPLE ON EITHER SIDE DREW AWAY AS

THOUGH THEY WERE FRIGHTENED BY CATCHING SOMETHING. HARRY DIDN'T HAVE A

CLUE WHAT WAS GOING ON, AND NEITHER RON NOR HERMIONE EXPLAINED ANYTHING

UNTIL THEY HAD DRAGGED HIM ALL THE WAY UP THE THE EMPTY GRYFFINDOR

COMMON ROOM. THEN RON PUSHED HARRY INTO AN ARMCHAIR AND SAID, WELL RE

A PARSELMOUTH. WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL US?

I'M A WHAT? SAID HARRY.

A PARSELMOUTH? SAID RON. YOU CAN TALK THE SNAKES?

I DON'T, SAID HARRY. I MEAN, THAT'S ONLY THE SECOND TIME I'VE EVER DONE

IT. I ACCIDENTALLY SET A KRAK CHURSTICKER ON MY CHRISTMAS DUCK AT THE TIME SINCE

LEUNG STERRY BUT IT WAS TELLING ME IT HAD NEVER SEEN BRAZIL AND
I SHUT UP

SET IT FREE WITHOUT MEANING THE THAT WAS BEFORE I KNEW I WAS A
WIZARD

A REA CONSTRUCTOR TOLD YELL IT HAD NEVER SEEN BRAZIL? THEN
REPEATED

FAINTLY.

SEE? SAID HARRY, I GET LEADS IF PEOPLE HERE CAN DO IT.

HEY, NO THEY CAN'T, SAID RON. IT'S NOT A VERY COMMON GIFT.
HARRY, THIS

IS BAD.

WHAT'S BAD? SAID HARRY, STARTING TO FEEL SLIGHTLY ANGRY. WHAT'S
WRONG

WITH EVERYBODY? LISTEN, IF I HADN'T TOLD THAT SNAKE NOT TO ATTACK
JUSTIN

HEY, THAT'S WHAT YELL SAID TO IT?

WHAT'D YELL MEAN? YELL WERE THERE YELL HEARD ME

I HEARD YELL SPEAKING PARSELTONGUE, SAID RON. SNAKE LANGUAGE.
YELL

COULD HAVE BEEN SAYING ANYTHING NO WHENEVER JUSTIN PANICKED,
YELL

SEEMED LIKE YELL WERE TELLING THE SNAKE HE'D HEARD SOMETHING IT
WAS CREEPY.

YELL KNEW

HARRY GAZED AT HIM.

I SPEAK A DIFFERENT LANGUAGE? BUT I DIDN'T REALIZE HOW CAN I
SPEAK

A LANGUAGE WITHOUT KNOWING I CAN SPEAK IT?

RON SHOOK HIS HEAD, BOTH HE AND HERMIONNE WERE LOOKING AS
THOUGH

SOMEONE HAD DIED, HARRY COULDN'T SEE WHAT WAS SO TERRIBLE.

DO YOU WANT ME TO TELL YOU WHAT'S GOING ON WITH STOPPING A MASSIVE
SNAKE

BITING OFF LUSTIN'S HEAD? HE SAID, WHAT DOES IT MATTER WHEN I DID IT
AS LONG

AS LUSTIN DOESN'T HAVE THE IDEA OF THE HEADLESS FLINT?

IT MATTERS, SAID FERMINE, SPEAKING AT LAST IN A FLISHED VOICE,

BECAUSE BEING ABLE TO TALK TO SNAKES WAS WHAT SALAZAR SLYTHERIN
WAS

FAMILY'S FOR. THAT'S WHY THE SYMBOL OF SLYTHERIN HOUSE IS A
SERPENT.

HARRY'S MOUTH FELL OPEN.

EXACTLY, SAID RHN. AND WHEN THE WHOLE SCHOOL'S GOING TO THINK
YOU'RE

HIS GREAT-GREAT-GREAT-GREAT-GRANDSON FOR SOMETHING

BUT I'M NOT, SAID HARRY, WITH A PANIC HE COULDN'T ELITE EXPLAIN.

YOU'LL FIND THAT HARD TO BELIEVE, SAID FERMINE. HE LIVED ABOUT
A

THOUSAND YEARS AGO; FOR ALL WE KNOW, YOU COULD BE.

HARRY LAY AWAKE FOR HOURS THAT NIGHT, THROUGH A GAP IN THE
CURTAINS HEARD

HIS FLOOR-BOARD HE WATCHED SNEAK STARTING THE DRIFT PAST THE TOWER
WINDING

AND WANDERED ...

COULD HE BE A DESCENDANT OF SALAZAR SLYTHERIN? HE DIDN'T KNOW
ANYTHING

ABOUT HIS FATHER'S FAMILY, AFTER ALL. THE DURSLEYS HAD ALWAYS
FORBIDDEN

EVERYTHING ABOUT HIS WIZARDING RELATIVES.

INSTANTLY, HARRY TRIED TO SAY SOMETHING IN PARSELTONGUE. THE
WORDS

WOULDN'T COME. IT SEEMED HE HAD THE BE FACE-TO-FACE WITH A SNAKE THE
DID IT.

BUT I'M IN GRYFFINDOR, HARRY THOUGHT. THE SORTING HAT WOULDN'T
HAVE PUT

ME IN HERE IF I HAD SLYTHERIN BLOOD. . . .

AH, SAID A NASTY LITTLE VOICE IN HIS BRAIN, BUT THE SORTING HAT
WANTED THE

PUT YOU IN SLYTHERIN, DIDN'T YOU REMEMBER?

HARRY TURNED AROUND, HE DID SEE JUSTIN THE NEXT DAY IN HERKLELEY AND
HE DID

EXPLAIN THAT HE DID BEEN CALLING THE SNAKE OFF, NOT KEEING IT ON,
WHICH HE

THOUGHT ANGRILY, PLUMPELING HIS PILLLOW AND FEELING HE SHOULD HAVE
REALIZED.

BY NEXT MORNING, HOWEVER, THE SNOW THAT HAD BEGUN IN THE NIGHT
HAD

TURNED INTO A BLIZZARD SO THICK THAT THE LAST HERKLELEY LESSON OF
THE TERM

WAS CANCELLED: PROFESSOR SPRELLT WANTED THE FIT SEEDS AND SCARVES
ON THE

MANDRAGES, A TRICKY OPERATION SHE WOULD ENTRUST THE NEW ONE ELSE,
NEW THAT IT

WAS SO IMPORTANT FOR THE MANDRAGES TO GROW QUICKLY AND REVIVE
MRS.

NEHRIS AND CELIN CREEVEY.

HARRY FRETTER ABOUT THIS NEXT TO THE FIRE IN THE GRYFFINDOR
COMMON ROOM,

WHILE RON AND HERMIONIE USED THEIR TIME OFF TO PLAY A GAME OF
WIZARD

CHESS.

FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, HARRY, SAID FERMINE, EXASPERATED, AS ONE OF
THEIR

KISSEES WRESTLED HER KNIGHT OFF HIS HORSE AND DRAGGED HIM OFF THE
BOARD.

GEE AND FIND ILUSTIN IF IT'S SO IMPORTANT TO YOU.

SEE HARRY GET UP AND LEFT THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HALL, WANDERING
WHERE

ILUSTIN MIGHT BE.

THE CASTLE WAS DARKER THAN IT USUALLY WAS IN DAYTIME BECAUSE OF
THE

THICK, SWIRLING GRAY SMOKE AT EVERY WINDOW. SHIVERING, HARRY
WALKED PAST

CLASSROOMS WHERE LESSONS WERE TAKING PLACE, CATCHING SNATCHES OF
WHAT

WAS HAPPENING WITHIN. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS SPEAKING AT
SOMEONE

WHEN, BY THE SOUND OF IT, HAD TURNED HIS FRIEND INTO A BADGER.
RESISTING THE

LURE TO TAKE A LOOK, HARRY WALKED ON BY, THINKING THAT ILUSTIN
MIGHT BE

USING HIS FREE TIME TO CATCH UP ON SOME WORK, AND DECIDING TO
CHECK THE

LIBRARY FIRST.

A GROUP OF THE FILLEPULPS WHO SHOULD HAVE BEEN IN HERMELBY
WERE

INDEED SITTING AT THE BACK OF THE LIBRARY, BUT THEY DIDN'T SEEM TO BE
WORKING. BETWEEN THE LONG LINES OF HIGH SHELVES, HARRY COULD
SEE THAT

THEIR HEADS WERE CLOSE TOGETHER AND THEY WERE HAVING WHAT SEEMED
LIKE AN

ASSEMBLING CONVERSATION, HE COULDN'T SEE WHETHER JUSTIN WAS
AMONG THEM.

HE WAS WALKING TOWARD THEM WHEN SOMETHING OF WHAT THEY WERE
SAYING

MET HIS EARS, AND HE PAUSED TO LISTEN, HIDDEN IN THE INVISIBILITY
SECTION.

THE ANYWAY, A STEALTH KID WAS SAYING, I TOLD JUSTIN TO HIDE UP IN
HIS

DEERMITHERY, I MEAN THE SAY, IF PETER'S MARKED HIM DOWN AS HIS NEXT
VICTIM,

IT'S BEST IF HE KEEPS A LOW PROFILE FOR A WHILE, HE CHURCH, JUSTIN'S
BEEN

WAITING FOR SOMETHING LIKE THIS TO HAPPEN EVER SINCE HE LET SLIP
THE PETER HE

WAS MUGGLE-BORN, JUSTIN ACTUALLY TOLD HIM HE'D BEEN DOWN FOR
THEN, THAT'S

NOT THE KIND OF THING YELL BARRY ASKED WITH SLOTHERIN'S FIRM AND
THE HOUSE, IS

IT?

YELL DEFINITELY THINK IT IS PETER, THEN, ERNIE? SAID A GIRL WITH
BLIND

PICTAILS ANXIOUSLY,

HARRY, SAID THE STEALTH KID SERIOUSLY, HE'S A PARSELMOUTH.
EVERYONE

KNOWS THAT'S THE MARK OF A DARK WIZARD, I'VE YELL EVER HEARD OF A
DECENT

HERE WITH CHILD TALK THE SNAKES? THEY CALLED SLYTHERIN HIMSELF
SERPENT-

THENCE.

THERE WAS SOME HEAVY MURMURING AT THIS, AND ERNIE WENT ON,

REMEMBER WHAT WAS WRITTEN ON THE WALL? ENEMIES OF THE FAIR,
BEWARE.

PETTER HAD SOME SORT OF RUN-IN WITH FILCH. NEXT THING WE KNOW,
FILCH'S CAT'S

ATTACKED. THAT FIRST YEAR, CREEVEY, WAS ANNOYING PETTER AT THE
HOLIDITCH

MATCH, TAKING PICTURES OF HIM WHILE HE WAS LYING IN THE MUD. NEXT
THING

WE KNOW CREEVEY'S BEEN ATTACKED.

HE ALWAYS SEEMS SO NICE, TRILCH, SAID HARRY UNCERTAINLY,
AND, WELL,

HE'S THE ONE WHO MADE YEL-DWELL-WELL DISAPPEAR. HE CAN'T BE ALL
BAD, CAN

HE?

ERNIE LOWERED HIS VOICE MYSTERIOUSLY, THE FLUFFLEPUSSES BEAT CHEER,
AND

HARRY EDGED NEARER SO THAT HE COULD CATCH ERNIE'S WORDS.

THE ONE WHO'S BEEN HE SURVIVED THAT ATTACK BY YEL-DWELL-WELL,
I MEAN

THE SAY, HE WAS ONLY A BABY WHEN IT HAPPENED, HE SHOULD HAVE BEEN
BLASTED

INTO SMITHERENS. ONLY A REALLY POWERFUL DARK WIZARD COULD HAVE
SURVIVED

A CURSE LIKE THAT. HE DROPPED HIS VOICE UNTIL IT WAS BARELY MORE
THAN A

WHISPER, AND SAID, THAT S PROBABLY WHY YELL-DONN-LEE WANTED THE KILL

HIM IN THE FIRST PLACE, DIDN T WANT ANOTHER DARK LORD COMPETING WITH HIM.

I WONDER WHAT EITHER PHEWERS BETTER S BEEN HIDING?

HARRY CHLIDN T TAKE ANYMORE, CLEARING HIS THROAT LOUDLY, HE STEPPED HLJT

FROM BEHIND THE BHHHSH-ELVES, IF HE HADN T BEEN FEELING SH ANGRY, HE WOULD

HAVE FOUND THE SIGHT THAT GREETED HIM PLINDY! EVERY ONE OF THE FLAPPLEPLIFFS

WHEEED AS THOUGH THEY HAD BEEN PETRIED BY THE SIGHT OF HIM, AND THE CHLHR

WAS DRAINING HLJT OF ERNIE S FACE.

HELLE, SAID HARRY, I M WHEEING FOR ILUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHER, THE FLAPPLEPLIFFS WHEST FEARS HAD CLEARLY BEEN CONFIRMED, THEY ALL WHEEED FEARFULLY AT ERNIE.

WHAT DHE YELL WANT WITH HIM? SAID ERNIE IN A HLLAYERING VOICE.

I WANTED THE TELL HIM WHAT REALLY HAPPENED WITH THAT SNAKE AT THE

DWELING CLLE, SAID HARRY.

ERNIE BIT HIS WHITE LIPS AND THEN, TAKING A DEEP BREATH, SAID, WE WERE

ALL THERE, WE SAW WHAT HAPPENED.

THEN YELL NOTICED THAT AFTER I SPEKE THE IT, THE SNAKE RACKED HPP? SAID

HARRY.

ALL I SAW, SAID ERNIE STLEKHHONLY, THOUGH HE WAS TREMBLING AS HE SPEKE,

WAS YELL SPEAKING PARSELTONGUE AND CHASING THE SNAKE TOWARD
JUSTIN.

I DIDN'T CHASE IT AT HIM? HARRY SAID, HIS VOICE SHAKING WITH
ANGER. IT

DIDN'T EVEN TOUCH HIM?

IT WAS A VERY NEAR MISS, SAID ERNIE. AND IN CASE YELL BE GETTING
IDEAS, HE ADDED HASTILY, I MIGHT TELL YELL THAT YELL CAN TRACE MY
FAMILY

BACK THROUGH NINE GENERATIONS OF WITCHES AND WARRIORS AND MY
KIND IS AS

POWER AS ANYONE'S, SHE

I DIDN'T CARE WHAT SORT OF KIND YELL YE GET? SAID HARRY FIERCELY.
WHY

WOULD I WANT THE ATTACK MUGGLE-KINDS?

I VE HEARD YELL HATE THESE MUGGLES YELL LIVE WITH, SAID ERNIE
SWIFTLY.

IT S NOT POSSIBLE TH LIVE WITH THE DURSLEYS AND NOT HATE THEM,
SAID

HARRY. I D LIKE TH SEE YELL TRY IT.

HE TURNED ON HIS HEEL AND STORMED OUT OF THE LIBRARY, EARNING
HIMSELF A

REPROVING GLARE FROM MADAM PINK, WHO WAS PUBLISHING THE GILDED
LEVER OF

A LARGE SPELL BOOK.

HARRY BLUNDERED UP THE CORRIDOR, BARELY NOTICING WHERE HE WAS
GOING, HE

WAS IN SUCH A FLURRY. THE RESULT WAS THAT HE WALKED INTO SOMETHING
VERY LARGE

AND SOLID, WHICH BOUNCED HIM BACKWARD INTO THE FLOOR.

OH, FELLER, HARRY SAID, LEEDING UP.

FLACRID'S FACE WAS ENTIRELY HIDDEN BY A WHOLELY, SNOW-COVERED
BALACLAVA.

BUT IT COULDN'T POSSIBLY BE ANYONE ELSE, AS HE FILLED MOST OF THE
CORRIDOR IN

HIS MEREKIN HYPERCUT. A DEAD REESTER WAS HANGING FROM ONE OF
HIS

MASSIVE, GLOVED HANDS.

ALL RIGHT, HARRY? HE SAID, PULLING UP THE BALACLAVA SEE HE COULD
SPREAD.

WEY AREN'T YOU IN CLASS?

CANCELLED, SAID HARRY, GETTING UP. WHAT ARE YOU DOING IN HERE?

FLACRID HELD UP THE LIMP REESTER.

SECOND ONE KILLED THIS TERM, HE EXPLAINED. IT'S EITHER MEETS OR A
BLEED-SUCKIN' BUCKAR, AND I NEED THE HEADMASTER'S PERMISSION TO
PUT A

CLAMP AROUND THE PEN CREEP.

HE PEERED MORE CLOSELY AT HARRY FROM UNDER HIS THICK, SNOW-
FLECKED

EYEBROWS.

YOU SURE YOU'RE ALL RIGHT? YOU LOOK ALL RIGHT AND BOTHERED

HARRY COULDN'T BRING HIMSELF TO REPEAT WHAT ERNIE AND THE REST OF
THE

FLUFFLEPUFFS HAD BEEN SAYING ABOUT HIM.

IT'S NOTHING, HE SAID. I'D BETTER GET GOING, FLACRID, IT'S
TRANSFIGURATION

NEXT AND I'VE GOT TO PICK UP MY BOOKS.

HE WALKED OFF, HIS MIND STILL FULL OF WHAT ERNIE HAD SAID ABOUT HIM.

JUSTIN'S BEEN WAITING FOR SOMETHING LIKE THIS TO HAPPEN EVER SINCE HE

LET SLIP THE BETTER HE WAS MUGGLE-BORN. . . .

HARRY STAMPED UP THE STAIRS AND TURNED ALONG ANOTHER CORRIDOR, WHICH

WAS PARTICULARLY DARK; THE CERCERS HAD BEEN EXTINGUISHED BY A

DRAFT THAT WAS BLEWING THROUGH A LEASE WINDOWPANE. HE WAS

THE PASSAGE WHEN HE TRIPPED HEADLONG OVER SOMETHING LYING IN

THE FLOOR. HE TURNED THE SWINT AT WHAT HE'D FALLEN OVER AND FELT AS THOUGH

STOMACH HAD DISSOLVED.

JUSTIN FINCH-FLETCHER WAS LYING IN THE FLOOR, RIGID AND COLD, A

SHOCK FREEZEN IN HIS FACE, HIS EYES STARING BLANKLY AT THE CEILING,

WASN'T ALL. NEXT TO HIM WAS ANOTHER FIGURE, THE STRANGEST SIGHT

EVER SEEN.

IT WAS NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, NO LONGER PEARLY-WHITE AND

BUT BLACK AND SMOOZY, FLEATING IMPERIL AND HORIZONTAL, SIX INCHES

FLOOR. HIS HEAD WAS HALF OFF AND HIS FACE WORE AN EXPRESSION OF

IDENTICAL THE JUSTIN'S.

HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET, HIS BREATHING FAST AND SHALLOWS, HIS HEART

BIND HE DRUMMED AGAINST HIS RIBS, HE WHINNED WILDLY UP AND DOWN THE

DESERTED CORRIDOR AND SAW A LINE OF SPIDERS SLITHERING AS FAST AS THEY COULD

AWAY FROM THE BODIES. THE ONLY SOUNDS WERE THE MUFFLED VOICES OF TEACHERS FROM THE CLASSES ON EITHER SIDE.

HE COULD RUN, AND HE HAD NEVER BEFORE HE HAD BEEN THERE, BUT HE

COULDN'T JUST LEAVE THEM LYING HERE. . . . HE HAD TO GET HELP. . . .

ANYONE BELIEVE HE HADN'T HAD ANYTHING TO DO WITH THIS?

AS HE STOOD THERE, PANICKING, A DOOR RIGHT NEXT TO HIM OPENED WITH A

BANG. PEEVES THE PEELERIST CAME SCREAMING OUT.

WHY, IT'S BETTER LIKE BETTER? CALLED PEEVES, DRINKING HARRY'S GLASSES

ASAP AS HE REELINED PAST HIM. WHAT'S BETTER UP THE WHY'S BETTER LIVING

PEEVES STOPPED, HALFWAY THROUGH A MIDAIR SUMERSALT, UPSIDE DOWN, HE

SPOTTED JUSTIN AND NEARLY HEADLESS NICK. HE FLIPPED THE RIGHT WAY UP,

FILLED HIS LINGS AND, BEFORE HARRY COULD STOP HIM, SCREAMED, ATTACK!

ATTACK! ANOTHER ATTACK! NEH MEETAL HER CHEST IS SAFE!

RUN FOR YOUR LIVES! ATTAAAAA!

[CRASH CRASH CRASH DOOR AFTER DOOR FLEW OPEN ALONG THE CORRIDOR

AND PEOPLE FLEWED AWAY. FOR SEVERAL LONG MINUTES, THERE WAS A
SCENE OF

SUCH CONFUSION THAT JUSTIN WAS IN DANGER OF BEING SQUASHED AND
PEOPLE

KEPT STANDING IN NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, HARRY FEELING HIMSELF
PINNED

AGAINST THE WALL AS THE TEACHERS SHELTERED FOR AWAY. PROFESSOR
MCGREGGALL

CAME RUNNING, FOLLOWED BY HER OWN CLASS, ONE OF WHOM STILL HAD
BLACK-

AND-WHITE-STRIPED HAIR. SHE USED HER HAND TO SET OFF A LITTLE BANG,
WHICH

RESTORED SILENCE, AND ORDERED EVERYONE BACK INTO THEIR CLASSES. SHE
SHOOKER

HAD THE SCENE CLEARED SOMEWHAT THAN ERNIE THE FLYPAPER ARRIVED,
PANTING,

END THE SCENE.

CAUGHT IN THE ACT? ERNIE YELLED, HIS FACE STARK WHITE, POINTING
HIS

FINGER DRAMATICALLY AT HARRY.

THAT WILL DO, MACMILLAN! SAID PROFESSOR MCGREGGALL SHARPLY.
PEEVES WAS SHAKING HIS HEAD, NOW GRINNING WICKEDLY, SURVEYING
THE

SCENE. PEEVES ALWAYS LOVED CHAOS. AS THE TEACHERS RENT OVER JUSTIN
AND

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, EXAMINING THEM, PEEVES BROKE INTO A SMILE:

HH, PHTTER, YHLJ RHETTER, HH, WHAT HAVE YHLJ DHNE,
YHLJ RE DILLING HFF STUDENTS, YHLJ THINEK IT S GHED FLIN

THAT S KNEUGH, PEEVES! KARKED PROFESSOR MCGHAGALL, AND
PEEVES

ZHHHED AWAY BACKWARD, WITH HIS TENGLE HLT AT HARRY,

ILUSTIN WAS CARRIED UP THE THE HOSPITAL WING BY PROFESSOR FLITWICK
AND

PROFESSOR SINISTRA OF THE ASTREHNEY DEPARTMENT, ELT NEEHED
SEEMED THE

DNEHL WHAT THE DH FHR NEARLY HEADLESS NICK. IN THE END, PROFESSOR
MCGHAGALL CHENILRED A LARGE FAN HLT OF THIN AIR, WHICH SHE GAVE
THE ERNIK

WITH INSTRUCTIENS THE LAST NEARLY HEADLESS NICK UP THE STAIRS,
THIS ERNIK

DID, FANNING NICK ALONG LIKE A SILENT BLACK FEEVERCRAFT. THIS LEFT
HARRY AND

PROFESSOR MCGHAGALL ALONE TOGETHER.

THIS WAY, PHTTER, SHE SAID,

PROFESSOR, SAID HARRY AT ONCE, I SWEAR I DIDN T

THIS IS HLT OF MY HANDS, PHTTER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGHAGALL
CLUTLY,

THEY MARCHED IN SILENCE AROUND A CHORNER AND SHE STOPPED BEHRE A
LARGE

AND EXTREMELY LGLY STENE GARGHLE.

LEPHN DREH? SHE SAID, THIS WAS EVIDENTLY A PASSWEHD, BECAUSE THE
GARGHLE SPRANG SLIDDENLY THE LIFE AND FHEPPED ASIDE AS THE WALL
BEHIND HIM

SPLIT IN TWEE, EVEN FLIL OF DREAD FHR WHAT WAS CHMING, HARRY
CHELDN T FAIL THE

HE AMAZED. BEHIND THE WALL WAS A SPIRAL STAIRCASE THAT WAS MOVING

SMOOTHLY UPWARD, LIKE AN ESCALATOR. AS HE AND PROFESSOR
MCGENAGALL

STEPPED INTO IT, HARRY HEARD THE WALL BEGIN TO CLOSE BEHIND THEM.
THEY RISE

UPWARD IN CIRCLES, HIGHER AND HIGHER, UNTIL AT LAST, SLIGHTLY DIZZY,
HARRY SAW

A GLEAMING DOOR BEHIND THEM AHEAD, WITH A BRASS DOORKNOB IN THE SHAPE OF A
GRIFFIN.

HE KNEW NOW WHERE HE WAS BEING TAKEN. THIS MUST BE WHERE
DUMBLEDORE LIVED.

T

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE PRYLLICK POTION

THEY STEPPED OFF THE STONE STAIRCASE AT THE TOP, AND PROFESSOR
MCGENAGALL RAPPED ON THE DOOR. IT OPENED SILENTLY AND THEY
ENTERED.

PROFESSOR MCGENAGALL TOLD HARRY TO WAIT AND LEFT HIM THERE,
ALONE.

HARRY WHEEZED AROUND. ONE THING WAS CERTAIN: OF ALL THE TEACHERS
OFFICES

HARRY HAD VISITED SO FAR THIS YEAR, DUMBLEDORE'S WAS BY FAR THE
BEST

INTERESTING. IF HE HADN'T BEEN SCARED HE'DT OF HIS WITS THAT HE WAS
AREHNT THE RE

THREHNT HE'DT OF SCHEHNT, HE WOULD HAVE BEEN VERY PLEASED TH HAVE A
CHANCE TH

HEHNT AREHNT IT.

IT WAS A LARGE AND BEAUTIFUL CIRCULAR ROOM, FULL OF PLINY LITTLE
NEHNTS. A

NUMBER OF CURIOUS SILVER INSTRUMENTS STOOD ON SPINDLE-LEGGED
TABLES.

WHIRRING AND EMITTING LITTLE PLIPS OF SMOKE. THE WALLS WERE
COVERED WITH

PORTRAITS OF OLD HEADMASTERS AND HEADMISTRESSES, ALL OF WHOM WERE
SMILING GENTLY IN THEIR FRAMES. THERE WAS ALSO AN ENORMOUS,
CLAW-FEETED

DESK, AND, SITTING ON A SHELF BEHIND IT, A SEVERE, TATTERED WIZARD'S
HAT THE

SHEDDING HAT.

HARRY HESITATED. HE CAST A WARY EYE AREHNT THE SLEEPING WITCHES
AND

WIZARDS ON THE WALLS. SURELY IT COULDN'T HURT IF HE THREW THE HAT
DOWN AND

TRIED IT ON AGAIN. I'LL SEE... I'LL SEE. SURE IT HAD PUT HIM
IN THE

RIGHT PLACE

HE WALKED QUIETLY AREHNT THE DESK, LIFTED THE HAT FROM ITS SHELF,
AND

HELD IT SLEWLY INTH HIS HEAD. IT WAS MUCH THE LARGE AND SLIPPED
DOWN

EVER HIS EYES, I'LL AS IT HAD BEEN THE LAST TIME HE'D PUT IT ON.
HARRY STARED

AT THE BLACK INSIDE OF THE HAT, WAITING. THEN A SMALL VOICE SAID IN HIS EAR,

SEE IN YOUR KENNET, HARRY POTTER?

ER, YES, HARRY MUTTERED. ER SURELY THE EITHER WHEN I WANTED THE ASK

WHEN WE BEEN WONDERING WHETHER I PUT WHEN IN THE RIGHT HOUSE, SAID THE

HAT SMARTLY. YES . . . WHEN WERE PARTICULARLY DIFFICULT THE PLACE. BUT I STAND

BY WHAT I SAID BEFORE HARRY'S HEART LEAPT WHEN WOULD HAVE BEEN

WELL IN SLOTHERIN

HARRY'S STOMACH FLUMMETERED. HE GRABBED THE POINT OF THE HAT AND PULLED

IT OFF. IT FLEW LIMPLY IN HIS HAND, CRISPY AND FADED. HARRY PUSHED IT BACK

INTO ITS SHELF, FEELING SICK.

WHEN HE WROTE, HE SAID AHEAD THE THE STILL AND SILENT HAT. IT DIDN'T MOVE.

HARRY BACKED AWAY, WATCHING IT. THEN A STRANGER, GAGGING NOISE BEHIND HIM

MADE HIM WHEEL AROUND.

HE WASN'T ALONE AFTER ALL. STANDING BEHIND A CHILDREN PERCH BEHIND THE DOOR

WAS A DECEPIT-LOOKING BIRD THAT RESEMBLED A HALF-PALLED TURKEY. HARRY

STARED AT IT AND THE BIRD LOOKED RAPIDLY BACK, MAKING ITS GAGGING NOISE

AGAIN. HARRY THOUGHT IT LOOKED VERY ILL. ITS EYES WERE DULL AND, EVEN AS

HARRY WATCHED, A COUPLE MORE FEATHERS FELL OUT OF ITS TAIL.

HARRY WAS JUST THINKING THAT ALL HE NEEDED WAS HER DUMBLEDORE'S
PET

BIRD THEN DIE WHILE HE WAS ALONE IN THE OFFICE WITH IT, WHEN THE BIRD
BURST INTO

FLAMES.

HARRY YELLED IN SURPRISE AND RAN AWAY INTO THE DESK. HE LOOKED
FEVERISHLY AROUND IN CASE THERE WAS A GLASS OF WATER SOMEWHERE
BUT

COULDN'T SEE ONE; THE BIRD, MEANWHILE, HAD BECOME A FIREBALL; IT GAVE
HIM

HEAD STITCHES AND NEXT SECOND THERE WAS NOTHING BUT A SMOLDERING
PILE OF ASH

ON THE FLOOR.

THE OFFICE DOOR OPENED, DUMBLEDORE CAME IN, LOOKING VERY SERIOUS.

PROFESSOR, HARRY GASPED, YOUR BIRD I COULDN'T DO ANYTHING
HE

JUST CAUGHT FIRE

THE HARRY'S ASTONISHMENT, DUMBLEDORE SMILED.

ABOUT TIME, THEN, HE SAID. HE'S BEEN LOOKING DREADFUL FOR DAYS;
I'VE

BEEN TELLING HIM TO GET A MOVE ON.

HE CHUCKLED AT THE STUNNED LOOK ON HARRY'S FACE.

PARADES IS A PHOENIX, HARRY. PHOENIXES BURST INTO FLAME WHEN IT
IS TIME

FOR THEM TO DIE AND ARE REBORN FROM THE ASHES. WATCH HIM . . .

HARRY LOOKED DOWN IN TIME TO SEE A TINY, WRINKLED, NEWBORN BIRD
POPE ITS

HEAD HLIT HP THE ASHES. IT WAS HLITE AS LGLY AS THE HLD HNE.

IT S A SHAME YHL IAD TH SEE HIM HN A BLRNING DAY, SAID
OLMKEBHEE,

SEATING HIMSELF BEHIND HIS DESK. HE S REALLY VERY HANDSOME MEET
HP THE

TIME, WENDBRFL RED AND CHILD PLIMAGE, FASINATING CREATURES,
PHERNIXES,

THEY CAN CARRY IMPENSELY HEAVY LEADS, THEIR TEARS HAVE HEALING
PWNERS,

AND THEY MAKE HIGHLY FAITHFUL PETS,

IN THE SECK HP PALDES CATCHING FIRE, HARRY HAD FERGHTTEN WHAT
HE WAS

THERE FR, BLT IT ALL CAME BACK TH HIM AS OLMKEBHEE SETTLED HIMSELF
IN THE

HIGH CHAIR BEHIND THE DESK AND FIXED HARRY WITH HIS PENETRATING,
LIGHT-BLUE

STAR,

BEFORE OLMKEBHEE CHLD SPRAK ANETHER WIRD, HELEVER, THE DEER HP
THE

HPICE FLEW HPEN WITH AN ALMIGHTY RANG AND HAGRID BLRST IN, A WILD
WEND IN

HIS EYES, HIS BALACLAVA PERCHED HN THP HP HIS SHAGGY BLACK HEAD AND
THE

DEAD REHESTER STILL SWINGING FROM HIS HAND,

IT WASN HARRY, PROFESSOR OLMKEBHEE? SAID HAGRID URGENTLY, I
WAS

TALKIN TH HIM SECONDS BEFORE THAT BID WAS FEELND, HE NEVER HAD
TIME, SIR

DUMBLEDORE TRIED TO SAY SOMETHING, BUT FLAMMERS WENT RANTING ON,
WAVING

THE RHESTER AROUND IN HIS AGITATION, SENDING FEATHERS EVERYWHERE.

IT CAN'T BE HIM, I'LL SWEAR IT IN FRONT OF THE MINISTRY OF
MAGIC IF

I HAVE THE

FLAMMERS, I

YOU'VE GOT THE WRONG KEY, SIR, I KNOW FLAMMERS NEVER

FLAMMERS! SAID DUMBLEDORE BOLDLY. I DO NOT THINK THAT FLAMMERS
ATTACKED

THESE PEOPLE.

HE, SAID FLAMMERS, THE RHESTER FALLING LIMPLY AT HIS SIDE. RIGHT.
I'LL WAIT

ELTIDE THEN, HEADMASTER.

AND HE STAMPED ELTIDE BEHINDING EMBARRASSED.

YOU DON'T THINK IT WAS ME, PROFESSOR? FLAMMERS REPEATED
EMPHATICALLY AS

DUMBLEDORE KICKED RHESTER FEATHERS OFF HIS DESK.

NO, FLAMMERS, I DON'T, SAID DUMBLEDORE, THOUGH HIS FACE WAS SHAKING
AGAIN. BUT I STILL WANT TO TALK TO YOU.

FLAMMERS WAITED NERVOUSLY WHILE DUMBLEDORE CONSIDERED HIM, THE TIPS
OF

HIS LONG FINGERS TOGETHER.

I MUST ASK YOU, FLAMMERS, WHETHER THERE IS ANYTHING YOU'D LIKE TO
TELL ME,

HE SAID GENTLY. ANYTHING AT ALL.

FLAMMERS DIDN'T KNOW WHAT TO SAY, FOR THE FIRST TIME MALFOY SPEAKING,
YOU'LL

BE NEXT, MURDERERS! AND IF THE POLYGLIC PETITION SIMMERING AWAY
IN

MEANING MORTAL & BATHROOM, THEN HE THOUGHT OF THE DISMEMBERED
VEHICLE HE

HAD HEARD TWICE AND REMEMBERED WHAT RON HAD SAID: HEARING
VEHICLES NE

HEN ELSE CAN HEAR ISN'T A GOOD SIGN, EVEN IN THE WIZARDING WORLD,
HE

THOUGHT, THEN, ABOUT WHAT EVERYONE WAS SAYING ABOUT HIM, AND HIS
GROWING

DREAD THAT HE WAS SOMEHOW CONNECTED WITH SALAZAR SLYTHERIN, ...

NE, SAID HARRY, THERE ISN'T ANYTHING, PROFESSOR, ...

THE DEEPER ATTACK HEN ILUSTIN AND NEARLY HEADLESS NICK TURNED
WHAT HAD

HITHERTO BEEN NERVOUSNESS INTO REAL PANIC, CLIMBINGLY, IT WAS
NEARLY

HEADLESS NICK & FATE THAT SEEMED THE WHIRRY PEOPLE MEET, WHAT
CHILD

POSSIBLY BE THAT THE A GHOST? PEOPLE ASKED EACH OTHER: WHAT
TERRIBLE FEELER

CHILD HARM SOMEONE WHO WAS ALREADY DEAD? THERE WAS ALMOST A
STAMPED

THE BENCH SEATS HEN THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS SEE THAT STUDENTS CHILD BE
HIMSELF

CHRISTMAS,

AT THIS RATE, WE LL BE THE ONLY ONES LEFT, RON TOLD HARRY AND
TERMININE,

LS, MALFOY, CRABBE, AND GOYLE, WHAT A UGLY HOLIDAY IT'S GOING TO
BE,

CRABBE AND GOYLE, WHO ALWAYS DID WHATEVER MALFOY DID, HAD SIGNED UP

THEY STAY OVER THE HOLIDAYS, TOO, BUT HARRY WAS GLAD THAT MEET PEOPLE WERE

LEAVING. HE WAS TIRED OF PEOPLE SPIRITING AROUND HIM IN THE HALLWAYS, AS

THOUGH HE WERE ABLE TO SEE THE SPARKS AND HEARD THE WHISTLING, TIRED OF ALL THE

MUTTERING, WHISPERING, AND HISsing AS HE PASSED,

FRED AND GEORGE, HOWEVER, FEELING ALL THIS VERY FUNNY. THEY WENT INTO

THEIR WAY THE MORNING AFTER HARRY BEGAN THE HALLWAYS, SNEAKING, MAKING

WAY FOR THE FEEL OF SLYTHERIN, SERIOUSLY EVIL WIZARD CRYING THROUGH, . . .

PERCY WAS DEEPLY DISAPPOINTED OF THIS BEHAVIOR.

IT IS NOT A LAUGHING MATTER, HE SAID COLDLY.

HE, GET INTO THE WAY, PERCY, SAID FRED. HARRY IS IN A HURRY.

YES, HE IS OFF THE THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS FOR A LITTLE OF TEA WITH HIS FANCY SERVANT, SAID GEORGE, CHEERFULLY.

GINNY DIDN'T FIND IT AMUSING EITHER.

HE, THEN, SHE WALKED EVERY TIME FRED ASKED HARRY COLDLY WHO HE WAS

PLANNING THE ATTACK NEXT, AND WHEN GEORGE PRETENDED THE LORD HARRY OFF WITH

A LARGE CRY OF GRIEF WHEN THEY MET.

HARRY DIDN'T MIND; IT MADE HIM FEEL BETTER THAT FRED AND GEORGE, AT LEAST, THOUGHT THE IDEA OF HIS BEING SLYTHERIN WAS NOT A LITTLE BIT LAUGHABLE.

BUT THEIR ANTICS SEEMED TO BE AGGRAVATING DRACH MALPBY, WHO
WHIRLED

INCREASINGLY SILLY EACH TIME HE SAW THEM AT IT.

IT'S BECAUSE HE'S BLASTING THE SAY IT'S REALLY HIM, SAID BEN
DOWLING.

YELL DOWN HIM HE HATES ANYONE BEATING HIM AT ANYTHING, AND
YELL BE

GETTING ALL THE CREDIT FOR HIS DIRTY WORK.

NOT FOR LONG, SAID HERMIONE IN A SATISFIED TONE. THE PEELWICK
POTION'S NEARLY READY, WE'LL BE GETTING THE TRUTH OUT OF HIM ANY
DAY NOW.

AT LAST THE TERM ENDED, AND A SILENCE DEEP AS THE SNOW ON THE
GRILINDS

DESCENDED ON THE CASTLE, HARRY FEELING IT PEACEFUL, RATHER THAN
GLOOMY, AND

ENJOYED THE FACT THAT HE, HERMIONE, AND THE WEASLEYS HAD THE RUN
OF

GRYFFINDOR TOWER, WHICH MEANT THEY COULD PLAY EXPLODING SNAP
LIVELY

WITHOUT BOTHERING ANYONE, AND PRACTICE DUELING IN PRIVATE, FRED,
GEORGE,

AND GINNY HAD CHOSEN TO STAY AT SCHOOL RATHER THAN VISIT BILL IN
EGYPT WITH

MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY. PERCY, WHO WAS DISAPPROVED OF WHAT HE TERMED
THEIR

CHILDISH BEHAVIOUR, DIDN'T SPEND MUCH TIME IN THE GRYFFINDOR
COMMONS

ANYMORE, HE HAD ALREADY TOLD THEM PERPETUALLY THAT HE WAS ONLY
STAYING OVER

CHRISTMAS BECAUSE IT WAS HIS DUTY AS A PREFECT TO SUPERVISE THE
TEACHERS

During this troubled time,

Christmas morning dawned, cold and white, Harry and Rein, the only

ones left in their dormitory, were woken very early by Hermine, who

burst in, fully dressed and carrying presents for them both.

Wake up, she said loudly, pulling back the curtains at the window.

Hermine who he not supposed to be in here said Rein, shielding

his eyes against the light.

Merry Christmas to you, then, said Hermine, throwing him his present. I've been up for nearly an hour, adding more stockings to the

tree. It's ready.

Harry sat up, suddenly wide awake.

Are you sure?

Positive, said Hermine, shifting slippers the way she thought she

should in the end of Rein's chair-dresser. If we're going to do it, I

should be tonight.

At that moment, Hedwig swooped into the room, carrying a very small

package in her beak.

Well, said Harry happily as she landed on his bed, are you spreading

the net again?

SHE NICKLED HIS EAR IN AN AFFECTUATE SHORT OF WAY, WHICH WAS A FAR BETTER

PRESENT THAN THE ONE THAT SHE HAD BRIGHT HIM, WHICH TURNED OUT TO BE FROM

THE DURSLEYS. THEY HAD SENT HARRY A TOOTH-PICK AND A NOTE TELLING HIM TO

FIND OUT WHETHER HE COULD STAY AT HOGWARTS FOR THE SUMMER VACATION.

THE

THE REST OF HARRY'S CHRISTMAS PRESENTS WERE FAR MORE SATISFACTORY.

Hagrid had sent him a large tin of Treacle Toffee, which Harry decided to

eat by the fire before eating; Ron had given him a book called Flying

with the Carrows, a book of interesting facts about his favorite Hagrid

team, and Hermione had bright him a luxury eagle-feather quill. Harry

opened the last present to find a new, hand-knitted sweater from Mrs.

Weasley and a large plum cake. He read her card with a fresh

glint, thinking about Mr. Weasley's car which hadn't been seen since its

crash with the Whumping Willows, and the bit of rule-breaking he and

Ron were planning next.

Now he, not even someone reading taking Polyjuice Potion later, could

fail the evening Christmas dinner at Hogwarts.

THE GREAT HALL LOOKED MAGNIFICENT, NOT ONLY WERE THERE A DOZEN
FRESH-

COVERED CHRISTMAS TREES AND THICK STREAMERS OF HELLY AND MISTLETOE

CRISSCROSSING THE CEILING, BUT ENCHANTED SNOW WAS FALLING, WARM
AND DRY,

FROM THE CEILING, DUMBLEDOORE LED THEM IN A FEW OF HIS FAVORITE
CAROLS,

HARRY HUMMING MORE AND MORE LOUDLY WITH EVERY CHORUS OF SINGING
HE

CONSIDERED, PERCY, WHO HADN'T REMEMBERED THAT FRED HAD SWITCHED HIS
PREFECT

RATHER SEE THAT IT NOW READ PINKHEAD, KEPT ASKING THEM ALL WHAT
THEY WERE

SNIGGERING AT, HARRY DIDN'T EVEN CARE THAT DRACO MALFOY WAS
MAKING A FOOL

OF HIMSELF REMARKS ABOUT HIS NEW SWEATER FROM THE SLYTHERIN TABLE,
WITH A KIT

OF BLACK, MALFOY WOULD BE GETTING HIS COMPELLANCE IN A FEW HOURS
TIME,

HARRY AND RON HAD BARELY FINISHED THEIR THIRD HELPINGS OF
CHRISTMAS

PLUMMING WHEN HERMIONIE LISTENED THEM OUT OF THE HALL THE FINALIZE
THEIR

PLANS FOR THE EVENING,

WE STILL NEED A KIT OF THE PEOPLE WHO ARE CHANGING INTO, SAID
HERMIONIE

MATTER-OF-FACTLY, AS THOUGH SHE WERE SENDING THEM THE THE
SUPERMARKET FOR

LAUNDRY DETERGENT. AND HEVIELISLY, IT LL BE BEST IF YELL CAN GET
SOMETHING OF

CRABBE S AND GOYLE S; THEY RE MALFOY S BEST FRIENDS, HE LL TELL THEM
ANYTHING. AND WE ALSO NEED TH MAKE SURE THE REAL CRABBE AND
GOYLE CAN T

BURST IN ON US WHILE WE RE INTERROGATING HIM.

I VE GOT IT ALL WORKED OUT, SHE WENT ON SMUGGLY, IGNORING
HARRY S AND

HERN S STUPIDED FACES. SHE HELD UP TWO PLUMP CHERCHATE CAKES.
I VE FILLED

THESE WITH A SIMPLE SLEEPING DRAUGHT. ALL YELL HAVE TO DO IS MAKE
SURE

CRABBE AND GOYLE FIND THEM. YELL KNOW HOW GREEDY THEY ARE,
THEY RE

BEHIND THE EAT THEM. SINCE THEY RE ASLEEP, ILL CUT A FEW OF THEIR
HAIRS AND

HIDE THEM IN A BROOM CLOSET.

HARRY AND HERN LOOKED INCREDULOUSLY AT EACH OTHER.

HERMIONE, I DONT THINK

THAT CHILD CEN SERIOUSLY WITING

BUT HERMIONE HAD A STEELY GLINT IN HER EYE NOT UNLIKE THE HEN
PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL SOMETIMES HAD.

THE POTION WILL BE USELESS WITHOUT CRABBE S AND GOYLE S HAIR,
SHE SAID

STERNLY. YELL DO WANT TH INVESTIGATE MALFOY, DONT YELL?

EH, ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY. BUT WHAT ABOUT YELL?
WHOSE HAIR

ARE YELL RIPPING OUT?

I'VE ALREADY GOTTEN MINE! SAID HERMIONE BRIGHTLY, PULLING A TINY KITTLE

OUT OF HER POCKET AND SHOWING THEM THE SINGLE HAIR INSIDE IT.
REMEMBER

MILICENT BULSTROPE WRESTLING WITH ME AT THE DUELING CLUB? SHE LEFT THIS

IN MY REEKS WHEN SHE WAS TRYING TO STRANGLE ME? AND SHE'S GONE HOME FOR

CHRISTMAS. SHE MUST HAVE TOLD THE SLYTHERINS I'VE DECIDED TO COME BACK.

WHEN HERMIONE HAD LISTED OFF THE NAMES IN THE PEEVISH PATTERNS AGAIN,

RON TURNED THE HARRY WITH A DREAM-LADEN EXPRESSION.

HAVE YOU EVER HEARD OF A PLAN WHERE SHE MANDY THINGS COULD BE WRITTEN?

BUT THE HARRY'S AND RON'S LITTLE AMAZEMENT, STAGE ONE OF THE OPERATION WENT

JUST AS SMOOTHLY AS HERMIONE HAD SAID. THEY WALKED IN THE DESERTED

ENTRANCE HALL AFTER CHRISTMAS TEA, WAITING FOR CRABBE AND GOYLE WHEN HAD

REMAINED ALONE AT THE SLYTHERIN TABLE, SHEVING DOWN FEWORTHY HELPINGS OF

TRIPLE. HARRY HAD PERCHED THE CHOCOLATE CAKES IN THE END OF THE BANISTERS.

WHEN THEY SPOTTED CRABBE AND GOYLE COMING OUT OF THE GREAT HALL, HARRY

AND RON HID QUICKLY BEHIND A SLIT OF ARMCHAIR NEXT TO THE FRONT DOOR.

HOW THICK CAN YOU GET? RON WHISPERED ECSTATICALLY AS CRABBE

GLIMPSELY PRINTED HLT THE LAKES TH CHOLE AND CRACKED THEM,
GRINNING

STUPIDLY, THEY STUFFED THE LAKES LIKE INTO THEIR LARGE MOUTHS,
FEEL A

MOMENT, BOTH OF THEM CHEWED GREEDILY, LOOKS OF TRIUMPH ON THEIR
FACES,

THEN, WITHOUT THE SMALLEST CHANGE OF EXPRESSION, THEY BOTH
DROPPED OVER

BACKWARD INTO THE PILE.

BY FAR THE HARDEST PART WAS HIDING THEM IN THE CLOSET ACROSS THE
HALL,

SINCE THEY WERE SAFELY STEVED AMONG THE SLICKETS AND MEPS, HARRY
YANKED

HLT A CHUPL OF THE BRISTLES THAT COVERED CHOLE'S FOREHEAD AND
REIN PULLED

HLT SEVERAL OF CRACK'S HAIRS. THEY ALSO STEEL THEIR SHOULDERS, BECAUSE
THEIR

ELKS WERE FAR TOO SMALL FOR CRACK- AND CHOLE-SIZE FEET. THEN, STILL
STUNNED

AT WHAT THEY HAD JUST DONE, THEY SPRINTED UP THE MEANING MORTAL'S
BATHROOM.

THEY COULD HARDLY SEE FOR THE THICK BLACK SMOKE ISSUING FROM THE
STALL IN

WHICH HERMINE WAS STIRRING THE CALIBREIN, PULLING THEIR RECKS
UP OVER

THEIR FACES, HARRY AND REIN DROPPED SILENTLY ON THE DEER,

HERMINE?

THEY HEARD THE SCRAPE OF THE WOOD AND HERMINE EMERGED, SHINY-
FACED

AND WHISKING ANXIOUSLY, BEHIND HER THEY HEARD THE CLUMP CLUMP OF
THE

CLINKING, GLITTERING POTION. THREE GLASS TUMBLERS STOOD READY ON
THE TABLET

SEAT.

DID YOU GET THEM? HERMIONE ASKED BREATHELESSLY.

HARRY STHELED HER GEMLE S HAIR.

GEMLE, AND I SNEAKED THESE SPARE REELS HLT OF THE BALINDRY,
HERMIONE

SAID, HILDING UP A SMALL SACK. YOU LL NEED BIGGER SIZES HENCE YOU RE
CRACKER AND GEMLE.

THE THREE OF THEM STARED INTO THE CALIDOREN, CLESE UP, THE POTION
LHED

LIKE THICK, DARK MLD, CLINKING SLUGGISHLY.

I M SURE I VE DONE EVERYTHING RIGHT, SAID HERMIONE, NERVELISLY
REREADING THE SPLITCHED PAGE OF MISTE PHTENTE PHTIONS. IT LHEDS
LIKE THE

REHED SAYS IT SHULD , , , HENCE WE VE DRIND IT, WE LL HAVE EXACTLY AN
HHLIR

BEFORE WE CHANGE BACK INTO HIRSELVES.

WHY WHAT? REN WHISPERED.

WE SEPARATE IT INTO THREE GLASSES AND ADD THE HAIRS.

HERMIONE LABLED LARGE DEHLEPS OF THE POTION INTO EACH OF THE
GLASSES.

THEN, HER HAND TREMKING, SHE STHEED MILLICENT BLUSTREDE S HAIR
HLT OF ITS

BETTLER INTO THE FIRST GLASS.

THE POTION HISSED LELIBLY LIKE A RHILING KETTLE AND FREETHED MADLY.

☆

SECONDS LATER, IT HAD TURNED A SILK SHIRT OF YELLOW.

WELL— ESSENCE OF MILLICENT BULSTREED, SAID RON, EYING IT WITH
LEATHING. BUT IT TASTES DISGUSTING.

ADD PEELERS, THEN, SAID HERMION.

HARRY DROPPED GEORGE'S HAIR INTO THE MIDDLE CLASS AND RON PLIT
CRACKER'S

INTO THE LAST ONE. BOTH CLASSES HISSED AND FRETTLED: GEORGE'S TURNED
THE DIARY

CHILD OF A KEEPER, CRACKER'S A DARK, MILDLY BROWN.

HANG ON, SAID HARRY AS RON AND HERMION REACHED FOR THEIR
CLASSES.

WE'D BETTER MEET ALL DRINK THEM IN HERE... SINCE WE TURN INTO
CRACKER AND

GEORGE WE WON'T FIT, AND MILLICENT BULSTREED'S NEW PIRATE.

GOOD THINKING, SAID RON, UNLOCKING THE DEER. WE'LL TAKE
SEPARATE

STALLS.

CAREFUL NOT TO SPILL A DROP OF HIS PEELILIKE POTION, HARRY SLIPPED
INTO THE

MIDDLE STALL.

READY? HE CALLED.

READY, CAME RON'S AND HERMION'S VOICES.

ONE TWO THREE

PINCHING HIS NOSE, HARRY DROPPED THE POTION DOWN IN TWO LARGE
CLIPS. IT

TASTED LIKE HYPERCHARGED CABBAGE.

IMMEDIATELY, HIS INSIDES STARTED WRITHING AS THOUGH HE'D JUST
SWALLOWED

LIVE SNAKES BELIEVED UP, HE WONDERS WHETHER HE WAS GETTING THE RE
SIDE

THEN A BURNING SENSATION SPREAD RAPIDLY FROM HIS STOMACH THE
THE VERY

ENDS OF HIS FINGERS AND THUS NEXT, BRINGING HIM GASPING THE ALL
FEELING,

CAME A TERRIBLE MELTING FEELING, AS THE SKIN ALL OVER HIS BODY
BEGAN TO

FEEL LIKE AND BEFORE HIS EYES, HIS HANDS BEGAN TO GROW, THE
FINGERS

THICKENED, THE NAILS BROADENED, THE BONES WERE BULGING LIKE
KNOTS HIS

SHOULDERS STRETCHED PAINFULLY AND A PRICKLING ON HIS BACK-HEAD
TOLD HIM THAT

HAIR WAS CREEPING DOWN TOWARD HIS EYEBROWS HIS REEKS RIPPED
AS HIS

CHEST EXPANDED LIKE A BARREL BURSTING ITS SEAMS HIS FEET WERE
ACHING IN

SHOES FEEL SIZE TEN SMALL

AS SUDDENLY AS IT HAD STARTED, EVERYTHING STOPPED, HARRY LAY
FACE DOWN

ON THE STONE-CHUB PLANT, LISTENING THE MORTAL CLANGING MERRISLY IN
THE END

THREAT, WITH DIFFICULTY, HE ROLLED OFF HIS SHOES AND STOOD UP, SEE
THIS WAS

WHAT IT FELT LIKE, BEING GHOST, HIS LARGE HAND TREMBLING, HE PULLED
OFF HIS

OLD SHOES, WHICH WERE HANGING A FEET ABOVE HIS ANKLES, PULLED ON
THE SPARE

HENES, AND LACED UP GEORGE'S KHAKI SHIRTS, HE REACHED UP TO KIDNEY-
HIS HAIR

HIT OF HIS EYES AND MET ONLY THE SHORT GRUBBY WIRY BRISTLES,
WHICH ON HIS

FOREHEAD. THEN HE REALIZED THAT HIS GLASSES WERE HIDING HIS EYES
BECAUSE

GEORGE OBVIOUSLY DIDN'T NEED THEM. HE TOOK THEM OFF AND CALLED,
ARE

WELL THEN HOW? GEORGE'S LOW RASP OF A VOICE ISSUED FROM HIS
MOUTH.

YES, CAME THE DEEP GROWL OF CRABBE FROM HIS RIGHT.

HARRY UNLATCHED HIS DOOR AND STEPPED IN FRONT OF THE CRACKED
MIRROR.

GEORGE STARED BACK AT HIM WITH BLUE, DEEPSET EYES. HARRY SCRATCHED
HIS EAR.

HE DID GEORGE.

THEN'S DOOR OPENED. THEY STARED AT EACH OTHER, EXCEPT THAT HE
LOOKED PALE

AND SHOOKED. THEN WAS INDISTINGUISHABLE FROM CRABBE, FROM THE
PLIDDING-

BLACK HAIR CUT TO THE LENGTH, GRILLA ARMS.

THIS IS UNBELIEVABLE, SAID THEN, APPROACHING THE MIRROR AND
PREENDING

CRABBE'S FLAT NOSE. UNBELIEVABLE.

WE'D BETTER GET GOING, SAID HARRY, LOOSENSING THE LATCH THAT WAS
CLIPPING INTO GEORGE'S THICK WRIST. WE'RE STILL GOT THE FIND WITH
WHERE THE

SLOTTING IN BETWEEN THEM IS. I ONLY HOPE WE CAN FIND SOMEONE THE

FEELLED ...

RON, WHO HAD BEEN GAZING AT HARRY, SAID, YOU DON'T KNOW FEEL
BIZARRE

IT IS THE SEE PEOPLE THINKING. HE RANDED HIS HERMION'S DEER.
[MEN, WE

NEED THE CH

A HIGH-PITCHED VOICE ANSWERED HIM.

I I DON'T THINK I'M GOING TO COME AFTER ALL. YOU GO ON
WITHOUT ME.

HERMION, WE KNOW MILLICENT BULSTRODE'S LUCKY, SHE HAD'S GOING TO
KNOW

IT'S YOU

NO REALLY I DON'T THINK I'LL COME. YOU TWO HURRY UP,
YOU'RE

WASTING TIME

HARRY LOOKED AT RON, CONFUSED.

THAT LOOKS MORE LIKE GRYFF, SAID RON. THAT'S WHY HE LOOKS
EVERY

TIME A TEACHER ASKS HIM A QUESTION.

HERMION, ARE YOU READY? SAID HARRY THROUGH THE DEER.

FINE I'M FINE GO ON

HARRY LOOKED AT HIS WATCH. FIVE OF THEIR PRECIOUS SIXTY MINUTES
HAD

ALREADY PASSED.

WE'LL MEET YOU BACK HERE, ALL RIGHT? HE SAID.

HARRY AND RON OPENED THE DEER OF THE BATHROOM CAREFULLY,
CHECKED THAT

THE COAST WAS CLEAR, AND SET OFF.

DON'T SWING THEIR ARMS LIKE THAT, HARRY MUTTERED THE BOY.

HEY

CRABBE FEELS THEM SHORTER STIFF...

FEELS THIS?

YEAH, THAT'S BETTER...

THEY WENT DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE. ALL THEY NEEDED NOW WAS A
SLOTHERIN THAT THEY COULD FOLLOW THE SLOTHERIN CHAMPION THEM,
BUT THERE
WAS NOTHING AROUND.

ANY IDEAS? MUTTERED HARRY.

THE SLOTHERINS ALWAYS CAME UP THE BREAKFAST FROM EVER THERE,
SAID

BOY, NEEDING AT THE ENTRANCE THE THE DUNGEONS. THE WORDS HAD
BARELY LEFT

HIS MOUTH WHEN A GIRL WITH LONG, CURLY HAIR EMERGED FROM THE
ENTRANCE.

EXCUSE ME, SAID BOY, HURRYING UP TO HER. WE'VE FORGOTTEN THE
WAY THE

ELIX CHAMPION THEM.

I SEE YOUR PROBLEM? SAID THE GIRL STIFFLY. ELIX CHAMPION THEM? I'M
A

RAVENCLAW.

SHE WALKED AWAY, LOOKING SUSPICIOUSLY BACK AT THEM.

HARRY AND BOY HURRIED DOWN THE STONE STEPS INTO THE DARKNESS,
THEIR

FEETSTEPS ECHOING PARTICULARLY LOUDLY AS CRABBE'S AND GRAY'S
BIG FEET HIT

THE FLOOR, FEELING THAT THIS WASN'T GOING TO BE AS EASY AS THEY HAD
HOPED.

THE LABYRINTHINE PASSAGES WERE DESERTED. THEY WALKED DEEPER AND DEEPER UNDER THE STONE, CONSTANTLY CHECKING THEIR WATCHES TO SEE HOW

MUCH TIME THEY HAD LEFT. AFTER A WHILE THEY WERE JUST WHEN THEY WERE

GETTING DESPERATE, THEY HEARD A SUDDEN MOVEMENT AHEAD.

HEY SAID RICH EXCITEDLY. THERE'S ONE OF THEM NOW!

THE FIGURE WAS EMERGING FROM A SIDE ROOM. AS THEY HURRIED NEARER,

HOWEVER, THEIR HEARTS SANK. IT WASN'T A SLYTHERIN, IT WAS PERCY.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING DOWN HERE? SAID RICH IN SURPRISE.

PERCY LOOKED APPREHENDED.

THAT, HE SAID STIFFLY, IS NONE OF YOUR BUSINESS. IT'S CRASS, ISN'T IT?

WELL, YES, SAID RICH.

WELL, GET OFF THE SLYTHERIN PREMISES, SAID PERCY STERNLY. IT'S NOT SAFE THE

HE WANDERING AROUND DARK CORRIDORS THESE DAYS.

YOU ARE, RICH POINTED OUT.

I, SAID PERCY, DRAWING HIMSELF UP, AM A PREFECT. NOTHING'S ABLE TO

ATTACK ME.

A VEHICLE SUDDENLY ROLLED BEHIND HARRY AND RICH. BRACE MALFOY WAS STROLLING TOWARD THEM, AND FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE, HARRY WAS PLEASED

TO SEE HIM.

THERE YOU ARE, HE DRAWLED, LOOKING AT THEM. HAVE YOU TWO BEEN

PICKING HLIT IN THE GREAT HALL ALL THIS TIME? I VE BEEN WHISKING AER
YELL; I

WANT THE SHELL YELL SOMETHING REALLY FLINDY,

MALPHY GLANCED WITHERINGLY AT PERCY,

AND WHAT RE YELL BEING DOWN HERE, WEASLEY? HE SNEERED,

PERCY WHISKED HLITRAGED,

YELL WANT THE SHELL A BIT MORE RESPECT TH A SCHEEL PERFECT? HE
SAID, I

DEEN T LIKE YELLR ATTITUDE?

MALPHY SNEERED AND MENTHINED AER HARRY AND REN THE PHILLED HIM,
HARRY

ALMHET SAID SOMETHING APHELEGETIC TH PERCY BLIT CALIGHT HIMSELF ILIT
IN TIME,

HE AND REN HLIRIED AFTER MALPHY, WHE SAID AS THEY TURNED INTHE
THE NEXT

PASSAGE, THAT PETER WEASLEY

PERCY, REN CHRRCTED HIM ALTHETMATICALLY,

WHATEVER, SAID MALPHY, I VE NETHICED HIM SNEAKING ARELIND A LHT
LATELY,

AND I RET I DKNEL WHAT HE S LIP THE, HE THINKS HE S CHINE THE CATCH
SLYTHERIN S

HEIR SINGLE-HANDED,

HE GAVE A SHEHT, DERISIVE LALIGH, HARRY AND REN EXCHANGED EXCITED
LHEDS,

MALPHY PALISED BY A STRETCH HIF KARE, DAMP STHNE WALL,

WHAT S THE NEW PASSWEHD AGAIN? HE SAID THE HARRY,

ER SAID HARRY,

"EH, YEAAH PLURE-BLEED!" SAID MALFOY, NOT LISTENING, AND A STONE
DOOR

EMBEDDED IN THE WALL SLID OPEN. MALFOY MARCHED THROUGH IT, AND
HARRY AND

RON FOLLOWED HIM.

THE SLYTHERIN COMMON ROOM WAS A LONG, LOW UNDERGROUND ROOM
WITH

BRIGHT STONE WALLS AND CEILING FROM WHICH HUNG, GREENISH LAMPS
WERE

HANGING ON CHAINS. A FIRE WAS CRACKLING UNDER AN ELABORATELY
CARVED

MANTELPIECE AHEAD OF THEM, AND SEVERAL SLYTHERINS WERE
SILHOUETTED AROUND

IT IN HIGH-BACKED CHAIRS.

"WAIT HERE," SAID MALFOY TO HARRY AND RON, MENTIONING THEM TO A
PAIR OF

EMPTY CHAIRS SET BACK FROM THE FIRE. "I'LL GO AND GET IT" MY
FATHER'S LIST

SENT IT TO ME

WONDERING WHAT MALFOY WAS GOING TO SHOW THEM, HARRY AND RON
SAT

DOWN, BEING THEIR BEST TRYING AT HOME.

MALFOY CAME BACK A MINUTE LATER, HOLDING WHAT LOOKED LIKE A
NEWSPAPER

CLIPPING. HE THROUST IT UNDER RON'S NOSE.

"THAT'LL GIVE YOU A LAUGH," HE SAID.

HARRY SAW RON'S EYES WIDEN IN SHOCK. HE READ THE CLIPPING
EILICELY, GAVE

A VERY FORCED LAUGH, AND HANDED IT TO HARRY.

IT HAD BEEN CLIPPED OUT OF THE DAILY PROPHET, AND IT SAID:

INQUIRY AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC

ARTHUR WEASLEY, HEAD OF THE MISUSE OF MUGGLE ARTIFACTS OFFICE, WAS

TODAY FINED FIFTY GALLEONS FOR KIDNAPPING A MUGGLE CAR.

MR. LUCIUS MALFOY, A GOVERNOR OF HOGWARTS SCHOOL OF WITCHCRAFT

AND WIZARDRY, WHERE THE ENCHANTED CAR CRASHED EARLIER THIS YEAR, CALLED TODAY FOR MR. WEASLEY'S RESIGNATION.

WEASLEY HAS BROUGHT THE MINISTRY INTO DISREPUTE, MR. MALFOY TOLD

THE REPORTER. HE IS CLEARLY UNFIT TO HOLD HIS JOB AND HIS RIDICULOUS MUGGLE PROTECTION ACT SHOULD BE SCRAPPED IMMEDIATELY.

MR. WEASLEY WAS UNAVAILABLE FOR COMMENT, ALTHOUGH HIS WIFE TOLD REPORTERS THE CLARKE SHE DID SET THE FAMILY GOING ON THEM.

WELL? SAID MALFOY IMPATIENTLY AS HARRY HANDED THE CLIPPING BACK TO

HIM. DON'T YOU THINK IT'S FLINDY?

HA, HA, SAID HARRY BROADLY.

ARTHUR WEASLEY LOVES MUGGLES SO MUCH HE SHOULD SNAP HIS WAND IN

HALF AND GO AND JOIN THEM, SAID MALFOY SCORNFULLY. YOU'D NEVER KNOWN THE

WEASLEYS WERE PURPLEHEEDS, THE WAY THEY BEHAVE.

THEN? SHE RATHER, CRABBE'S FACE WAS CHINERED WITH FLRY.

WHAT'S UP WITH YOU, CRABBE? SNAPPED MALFOY.

STHEMACHACHIE, REHN GRUNTED.

WELL, GEE UP THE THE HOSPITAL WING AND GIVE ALL THESE MUDBLEEDS A KICK

FROM ME, SAID MALTHEY, SNICKERING. YELL BONEH, I M SURPRISED THE DAILY

PROPHET HASN T REPORTED ALL THESE ATTACKS YET, HE WENT HEN THOUGHTFULLY, I

SLIPPERE DUMBLEDORE S TRYING THE FLISH IT ALL UP, HE LL BE SAVED IF IT DEESN T

STEP SHEN, FATHER S ALLAYS SAID HED DUMBLEDORE S THE WORST THING THAT S

EVER HAPPENED THE THIS PLACE, HE LEVES MUGGLE-BURNS, A DECENT HEADMASTER

WELLD NEVER YE LET SLIME LIKE THAT CREEPY IN,

MALTHEY STARTED TAKING PICTURES WITH AN IMAGINARY CAMERA AND DID A CRUEL

BLT ACCURATE IMPRESSION OF CHLIN: BETTER, CAN I HAVE YELIR PICTURE, BETTER?

CAN I HAVE YELIR ALTHOGRAPH? CAN I LICK YELIR SHES, PLEASE, BETTER?

HE DROPPED HIS HANDS AND LEEKED AT HARRY AND REHN,

WHAT S THE MATTER WITH YELL THEN?

FOR THEE LATE, HARRY AND REHN FORCED THEMSELVES THE LAUGH, BLT MALTHEY

SEEMED SATISFIED; PERHAPS CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE ALWAYS SHEN HEN THE LIPTAKE,

SAINT BETTER, THE MUDBLEEDS FRIEND, SAID MALTHEY SLEENLY, HE S ANOTHER HEN WITH NE PROPER WIZARD FEELING, HEN HE WELLDN T GE ARELND WITH

THAT LIMPED-LIP CRANGER MURDERED, AND PEOPLE THINK HE'S
SLOTHFUL'S

HEIR?

HARRY AND RON WAITED WITH BATED BREATH: MALFOY WAS SURELY
SECOND'S

AWAY FROM TELLING THEM IT WAS HIM BUT THEN

I WISH I KNEW WHO IT IS, SAID MALFOY PETULANTLY, I COULD HELP
THEM.

RON'S JAW DROPPED SEE THAT CRACKER LOOKED EVEN MORE CLUELESS THAN
USUAL.

FORTUNATELY, MALFOY DIDN'T NOTICE, AND HARRY, THINKING FAST, SAID,
YES

MUST HAVE SOME IDEA WHO'S BEHIND IT ALL. . . .

YES KNOW I HAVEN'T, CHOKE, HOW MANY TIMES DO I HAVE TO TELL
YES?

SNAPPED MALFOY, AND FATHER WHEN'T TELL ME ANYTHING ABOUT THE
LAST TIME

THE CHAMBER WAS OPENED EITHER, HE BELIEVE, IT WAS FIFTY YEARS AGO,
SEE IT WAS

BEFORE HIS TIME, BUT HE KNOWS ALL ABOUT IT, AND HE SAYS THAT IT WAS
ALL DEPT

QUIET AND IT IS VERY SUSPICIOUS IF I KNOW THE MUCH ABOUT IT, BUT I
KNOW MORE

THING LAST TIME THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS WAS OPENED, A MURDERER
DIED.

SEE I GET IT'S A MATTER OF TIME BEFORE ONE OF THEM'S KILLED THIS TIME. .
. . I

WELL IT'S CRANGER, HE SAID WITH RELISH.

RON WAS CLENCHING CRACKER'S GIGANTIC FISTS, FEELING THAT IT WOULD BE
A BIT

HE A CIVILIAN? IF REIN PUNCHED MALFOY, HARRY SENT HIM A WARNING
LEWIS AND

SAID, I WILL KNOW IF THE PERSON WHO OPENED THE CHAMBER LAST TIME
WAS

CALCULATED?

EH, YEAH... WHATEVER IT WAS WAS EXPELLED, SAID MALFOY. THEY ARE
PROBABLY STILL IN AZKABAN.

AZKABAN? SAID HARRY, PLIZZLED.

AZKABAN THE WIZARD PRISON, GINNY, SAID MALFOY, LEERING AT
HIM IN

DISBELIEF. HONESTLY, IF YOU WERE ANY SLOWER, YOU'D BE GOING
BACKWARD.

HE SHIFTED RESTLESSLY IN HIS CHAIR AND SAID, FATHER SAYS TO KEEP MY
HEAD

DOWN AND LET THE FEAR OF SLYTHERIN GET HIM WITH IT. HE SAYS THE
SCHOOL NEEDS

RIDDING OF ALL THE MURDERED FILTH, BUT NOT THE GET MIXED UP IN IT. HE
CHUCKLE,

HE'S GOT A LIE ON HIS PLATE AT THE MOMENT, YOU KNOW THE
MINISTRY OF MAGIC

RAIDED HIS MANSION LAST WEEK?

HARRY TRIED TO FORCE GINNY'S BLIND FACE INTO A LEAN OF CONCERN.

YEAH... SAID MALFOY. LUCKILY, THEY DIDN'T FIND MUCH. FATHER'S
GOT

SOME VERY VALUABLE DARK ARTS STUFF, BUT LUCKILY, WE'VE GOT HIS
HIDDEN SECRET

CHAMBER UNDER THE DRAWING-ROOM FLOOR

HE? SAID REIN.

MALPHEE LOOKED AT HIM. SHE DID HARRY. RON BLISHED. EVEN HIS HAIR WAS

TURNING RED. HIS NECK WAS ALSO SLIGHTLY LENGTHENING THEIR HEELER WAS UP,

RON WAS TURNING BACK INTO HIMSELF, AND FROM THE LOOK OF HORROR HE WAS

SUDDENLY GIVING HARRY, HE MUST BE, THEM.

THEY BOTH LIMPED THE THEIR FEET.

MEDICINE FOR MY STOMACH. RON GRANTED, AND WITHOUT FURTHER ADH THEY

SPRINTED THE LENGTH OF THE SLOTTED IN BETWEEN THEM, FLUNG THEMSELVES AT

THE STONE WALL, AND DASHED UP THE PASSAGE, HOPING AGAINST BETTER THAT MALPHEE

HADN'T NOTICED ANYTHING. HARRY COULD FEEL HIS FEET SLIPPING AWAY IN

GRIP. S FLYER STEPS AND HAD THE FEELT UP HIS RIBS AS HE STRANDED; THEY

CRASHED UP THE STEPS INTO THE DARK ENTRANCE HALL, WHICH WAS FULL OF A

Muffled POUNDING COMING FROM THE CLOSET WHERE THEY'D BEEN CRACK AND

GRIP. LEAVING THEIR SHOES BESIDE THE CLOSET DOOR, THEY SPRINTED IN THEIR

SHOES UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE TOWARD MEANING MYRTLE'S BATHROOM.

WELL, IT WASN'T A COMPLETE WASTE OF TIME. RON PANTED, CHESTING THE BATHROOM DOOR BEHIND THEM. I KNOW WE STILL HAVEN'T FELT THE FEELT

BEHIND THE ATTACHES, BUT I'M GOING TO WRITE THE DAD THEMSELVES AND TELL HIM THE

THINGS UNDER THE MALPHEYS DRAINING THEM.

HARRY CHECKED HIS FACE IN THE CRACKED MIRROR. HE WAS BACK TO NORMAL. HE

PLUT HIS GLASSES ON AS BEN HAMMERED ON THE DOOR OF HERMIONE'S STALL.

HERMIONE, COME OUT, WE'VE GOT LEADS TO TELL YOU

GO AWAY! HERMIONE SQUEEZED.

HARRY AND BEN LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

WHAT'S THE MATTER? SAID BEN. YOU MUST BE BACK TO NORMAL BY NOW, WE

ARE

BUT MEANING MYRTLE GLIDED SILENTLY THROUGH THE STALL DOOR. HARRY HAD

NEVER SEEN HER LOOKING SO HAPPY.

HEHEHEHE, WAIT TILL YOU SEE, SHE SAID. IT'S AWFUL

THEY HEARD THE LOCK SLIDE BACK AND HERMIONE EMERGED, SHAKING, HER REEKS PULLED UP OVER HER HEAD.

WHAT'S UP? SAID BEN UNCERTAINLY. HAVE YOU STILL GOT MILLICENT'S NECK

OR SOMETHING?

HERMIONE LET HER REEKS FALL AND BEN RAN INTO THE SINK.

HER FACE WAS COVERED IN BLACK FLU. HER EYES HAD TURNED YELLOW AND THERE

WERE LONG, POINTED EARS PEERING THROUGH HER HAIR.

IT WAS A CAT HAIR! SHE REALIZED. M-MILLICENT BLUSTRODE MUST HAVE

A CAT! AND THE P-POTION ISN'T SUPPOSED TO BE USED FOR ANIMAL

TRANSFORMATION:

LEIGH, SAID RICH,

YELL LL BE TEASED SOMETHING DREADFUL, SAID MORTLE HAPPILY,

IT S HEAVY, ERMINE, SAID HARRY ELEGANTLY, WE LL TAKE YELL UP THE
THE

HOSPITAL WING, MADAM PHEMREY NEVER ASKS THE MAND ELEGANTS, . .

IT TAKES A LONG TIME TO PERSUADE ERMINE TO LEAVE THE BATHROOM,

MEANING MORTLE SPED THEM ON THEIR WAY WITH A HEARTY GLASS,

WAIT TILL

EVERYONE FINDS HELL YELL VE GOTT A TAIL!

~

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE VERY SECRET DIARY

ERMINE REMAINED IN THE HOSPITAL WING FOR SEVERAL WEEKS. THERE
WAS

A FLURRY OF RUMOR ABOUT HER DISAPPEARANCE WHEN THE REST OF THE
SCHOOL ARRIVED BACK FROM THEIR CHRISTMAS HOLIDAYS, BECAUSE OF
CHLORSE

EVERYONE REALIZED THAT SHE HAD BEEN ATTACKED. SEE MANY STUDENTS
FILED PAST

THE HOSPITAL WING TRYING TO CATCH A GLIMPSE OF HER THAT MADAM
PHEMREY

THEY HURT HER CURTAINS AGAIN AND PLACED THEM AROUND HERMIONE'S BED, THEN

SPARE HER THE SHAME OF BEING SEEN WITH A FLURRY FACE.

HARRY AND RON WENT TO VISIT HER EVERY EVENING. WHEN THE NEW TERM

STARTED, THEY BRUGHT HER EACH DAY'S LETTERS.

IF I'D SPARKLED WHISKERS, I'D TAKE A BREAK FROM WORK, SAID RON, TIPPING

A STACK OF BOOKS ONTO HERMIONE'S BEDSIDE TABLE ONE EVENING.

DON'T BE SILLY, RON, I'VE GOT TO KEEP UP, SAID HERMIONE BRISKLY. HER

SPIRITS WERE GREATLY IMPROVED BY THE FACT THAT ALL THE PAIN HAD GONE FROM

HER FACE AND HER EYES WERE TURNING SLOWLY BACK TO GREEN. I DON'T SUPPOSE

YOU'VE GOT ANY NEW LEADS? SHE ADDED IN A WHISPER, SHE THAT MADAM POMFREY WOULDN'T HEAR HER.

NOTHING, SAID HARRY GLENNILY.

I WAS SURE IT WAS MALFOY, SAID RON, HER ABOUT THE HUNDRETH TIME.

WHAT'S THAT? ASKED HARRY, POINTING TO SOMETHING CHILD STICKING OUT

FROM UNDER HERMIONE'S PILLOW.

JUST A GET WELL CARD, SAID HERMIONE HASTILY, TRYING TO PUSH IT OUT OF

SIGHT, BUT RON WAS THERE TO STOP HER. HE PULLED IT OUT, FLIPPED IT OPEN, AND

READ ALOUD:

THE MISS GRANGER, WISHING YELL A SPEEDY RECOVERY, FROM YELLER CONCERNED

TEACHER, PROFESSOR GILBERT LICKHART, HERD OF MERLIN, THIRD CLASS,

MEMBER OF THE DARK FORCE DEFENSE LEAGUE, AND FIVE-TIME WINNER OF WITCH WEEKLY'S MOST-CHARMING-SMILE AWARD.

REN LOOKED UP AT HERMIONE, DISGUSTED.

YELL SLEEP WITH THIS UNDER YELLER PILLOW

BUT HERMIONE WAS SPARED ANSWERING BY MADAM POMPREE SLEEPING EVER

WITH HER EVENING DOSE OF MEDICINE.

IS LICKHART THE SMARTEST BLOND YELL VE EVER MET, MR WHAT? REN SAID

THE HARRY AS THEY LEFT THE INFIRMARY AND STARTED UP THE STAIRS TOWARD

GROFFINDER TOWER. SNAPE HAD GIVEN THEM SEE MUCH HEMLOCK, HARRY

THOUGHT HE WAS LIKELY TO BE IN THE SIXTH YEAR BEFORE HE FINISHED IT. REN WAS

JUST SAYING HE WISHED HE HAD ASKED HERMIONE HOW MANY RAT TAILS YELL WERE

SLIPPED THE ADD THE A FAIR-RAISING PETITION WHEN AN ANGRY ELLIOTST FROM THE

FLIGHT ARMY REACHED THEIR EARS.

THAT'S FILCH, HARRY MUTTERED AS THEY FLURRIED UP THE STAIRS AND PALSED,

ELT OF SIGHT, LISTENING HARD.

YELL DIDN'T THINK SOMETHING ELSE'S BEEN ATTACKED? SAID REN TENSELY.

THEY STOOD STILL, THEIR HEADS INCLINED TOWARD FILCH'S VOICE, WHICH

SEEMED ELITE HYSTERICAL.

EVEN MORE WHEN HER MOUTH MIPPING ALL NIGHT, LIKE I HAVEN'T GOTTEN ENOUGH

THEY DIDN'T, THIS IS THE FINAL STRAW, I'M GOING TO DUMPKED

THIS FOOTSTEPS RECEDED ALONG THE HILT-UP-SIGHT CORRIDOR AND THEY HEARD A

DISTANT DOOR SLAM.

THEY PEEKED THEIR HEADS AROUND THE CORNER, FILCH HAD CLEARLY BEEN MANNING HIS USUAL WOODEN POST: THEY WERE BACK AGAIN IN THE SPOT WHERE

MRS. NORRIS HAD BEEN ATTACKED. THEY SAW AT A GLANCE WHAT FILCH HAD BEEN

SHOOTING ABOUT. A GREAT POND OF WATER STRETCHED OVER HALF THE CORRIDOR, AND

IT LOOKED AS THOUGH IT WAS STILL SEEPING FROM UNDER THE DOOR OF MEANING

MYRTLE'S BATHROOM. WHEN THAT FILCH HAD STOPPED SHOOTING, THEY COULD HEAR

MYRTLE'S WAILS ECHOING OFF THE BATHROOM WALLS.

WHEN WHAT'S UP WITH HER? SAID PHIL.

LET'S GO AND SEE, SAID HARRY, AND HOLDING THEIR BREATH OVER THEIR SHOULDERS

THEY STOPPED THROUGH THE GREAT WASH OF WATER TO THE DOOR BEARING ITS HILT OF

DOOR SIGN, IGNORED IT AS ALWAYS, AND ENTERED.

MEANING MYRTLE WAS CRYING, IF POSSIBLE, LOUDER AND HARDER THAN EVER

BEFORE. SHE SEEMED TO BE HIDING BEHIND HER USUAL THIEF. IT WAS DARK IN THE

BATHROOM BECAUSE THE CANDLES HAD BEEN EXTINGUISHED IN THE GREAT
HALL?

WATER THAT HAD LEFT BOTH WALLS AND FLOOR SHAKING WET.

WHAT'S UP, MYRTLE? SAID HARRY.

WHAT'S THAT? CALLED MYRTLE MISERABLY. CAME THE THREE
SOMETHING

ELSE AT ME?

HARRY WADED ACROSS THE FUR STALL AND SAID, WHY WOULD I THROW
SOMETHING AT YOU?

DON'T ASK ME, MYRTLE SCHELTED, EMERGING WITH A WAVE OF YET MORE
WATER, WHICH SPLASHED INTO THE ALREADY SHOPPING FLOOR. HERE I AM,
MINDING

MY OWN BUSINESS, AND SOMEONE THINKS IT'S FUNNY THE THREE A KICK
AT

ME. . . .

BUT IT CAN'T HURT YOU IF SOMEONE THROWS SOMETHING AT YOU, SAID
HARRY.

REASONABLY. I MEAN, IT'D JUST GO RIGHT THROUGH YOU, WOULDN'T IT?

HE HAD SAID THE WRONG THING. MYRTLE PLOPPED HERSELF UP AND
SHRIEKED.

LET'S ALL THREE KICKS AT MYRTLE, BECAUSE SHE CAN'T FEEL IT! TEN
POINTS IF

YOU CAN GET IT THROUGH HER STOMACH! FIFTY POINTS IF IT GOES
THROUGH HER

HEAD! WELL, HA, HA, HA! WHAT A LIVERY GAME, I DON'T THINK!

WHAT THREE IT AT YOU, ANYWAY? ASKED HARRY.

I DON'T KNOW. . . . I WAS JUST SITTING IN THE LOBBY, THINKING ABOUT
DEATH.

AND IT FELL RIGHT THROUGH THE TOP OF MY HEAD, SAID MORTLE, GLARING AT THEM.

IT'S OVER THERE, IT GET WASHED AWAY, . . .

HARRY AND RON LOOKED UNDER THE SINK WHERE MORTLE WAS POINTING. A

SMALL, THIN BEAK LAY THERE. IT HAD A SHINY BLACK CHEEK AND WAS AS WET AS

EVERYTHING ELSE IN THE BATHROOM. HARRY STEPPED FORWARD TO PICK IT UP, BUT

RON SUDDENLY FELL AWAY AN ARM THE OTHER HAD HIM BACK.

WHAT? SAID HARRY.

ARE YOU CRAZY? SAID RON. IT COULD BE DANGEROUS.

DANGEROUS? SAID HARRY, LAUGHING. COME OFF IT, HOW COULD IT BE DANGEROUS?

YOU'D BE SURPRISED, SAID RON, WHO WAS LOOKING APPREHENSIVELY AT THE

BEAK. SOME OF THE BEAKS THE MINISTRY'S CONFISCATED DAD'S TOLD ME

THERE WAS ONE THAT TURNED YOUR EYES AWAY, AND EVERYONE WHO READ SHUNNETS

OF A SERIOUS SPOKE IN LIMERICKS FOR THE REST OF THEIR LIVES, AND SOME HAD

WITCH IN BATH HAD A BEAK THAT YOU COULD NEVER STOP READING! YOU JUST HAD

THE WANDER AWAY WITH YOUR NOSE IN IT, TRYING TO DO EVERYTHING ONE-HANDED.

AND

ALL RIGHT, I'VE GOT THE PRINT, SAID HARRY.

THE LITTLE BEAK LAY ON THE FLOOR, NEARBY AND SILENT.

WELL, WE WHEN T FIND EELT UNLESS WE LEEK AT IT, HE SAID, AND HE
BLINKED

ARHLING REEN AND PICKED IT UP OFF THE FLEER.

HARRY SAW AT ENCE THAT IT WAS A DIARY, AND THE FADED YEAR EN THE
CEVER

TELD HIM IT WAS FIFTY YEARS ELD. HE OPENED IT EAGERLY, EN THE FIRST
PAGE HE

CELLO ILST MADE EELT THE NAME T. M. RIDDLE IN SMLDGED INK.

HANG EN, SAID REEN, WEH HAD APPREHACHED CALTIEHLISLY AND WAS
LEEHKING

EVER HARRY S S-EHLDER, I DNEH THAT NAME. . . T. M. RIDDLE GET AN
ALARD

AER SPECIAL SERVICES TEH THE SC-EHHL FIFTY YEARS AGEH.

EELH EN EARTH D YELH DNEH THAT? SAID HARRY IN AMAZEMENT.

RECALISE FILCH MADE ME PHLISH HIS S-EHLD AHELT FIFTY TIMES IN
DETENTHIN, SAID REEN RESENTFULLY. THAT WAS THE ENCE I KLUPED
SLUGS ALL EVER.

IF YELH D WIPED SLIME OFF A NAME AER AN E-EHLR, YELH D REMEMBER IT,
TEH.

HARRY PEELED THE WET PAGES APART. THEY WERE COMPLETELY BLANK.
THERE

WASN T THE FAINTEST TRACE OF WRITING EN ANY OF THEM, NEET EVEN
ALINTIE

MARKEL S BIRTH-DAY, HER DENTIST, HALF-PAST THREE.

HE NEVER WRITE IN IT, SAID HARRY, DISAPPEHNTED.

I WENDEH WEY SEHMEHNE WANTED TEH FLISH IT ALAY? SAID REEN
CLIRIEHLISLY.

HARRY TLURND TEH THE BACK CEVER OF THE EHEH AND SAW THE PRINTED
NAME OF

A VARIETY STORE HEN VALKIE-HALL ROAD, LONDON.

HE MUST VE BEEN MUGGLE-BORN, SAID HARRY TEHLIGHTFULLY. THE
HAYE

REHLIGHT A DIARY FROM VALKIE-HALL ROAD, ...

WELL, IT S NOT MUCH LIKE THE OTHER, SAID RON. HE DROPPED HIS VEIL.
FIFTY

PHINTS IF OTHER CAN GET IT THROUGH MORTLE S NESE.

HARRY, HOWEVER, PICKED IT.

HERMIONE LEFT THE HOSPITAL WING, DE-WEISDERED, TAIL-LESS, AND FLIR-
FREE, AT

THE BEGINNING OF FEBRUARY, HEN HER FIRST EVENING BACK IN
GRYFFINDOR TOWER.

HARRY SHOWED HER T. M. RIDDLE S DIARY AND TOLD HER THE STORY OF
HOW THEY

HAD FOUND IT.

HEHE, IT MIGHT HAVE HIDDEN POWERS, SAID HERMIONE
ENTHUSIASTICALLY.

TAKING THE DIARY AND LOOKING AT IT CLOSELY.

IF IT HAS, IT S HIDING THEM VERY WELL, SAID RON. MAYBE IT S SE-
DEN T

KNOW WHY OTHER DEN T CHUCK IT, HARRY.

I WISH I KNEW WHY SOMEONE DID TRY TO CHUCK IT, SAID HARRY. I
WOULDN T MIND KNOWING HOW RIDDLE GET AN AWARD FOR SPECIAL
SERVICES THE

HEGLARTS EITHER.

CHILD VE BEEN ANYTHING, SAID RON. MAYBE HE GET THIRTY H.L.L.S
HER

SAVED A TEACHER FROM THE GIANT SELLID, MAYBE HE MURDERED MORTLE;
THAT

WOULD WE BEBE EVERYONE A FAYER, . . .

BUT HARRY COULD TELL FROM THE ARRESTED LOOK ON HERMIONE'S FACE
THAT SHE

WAS THINKING WHAT HE WAS THINKING.

WHAT? SAID RON, LEERING FROM HER THE THE EITHER.

WELL, THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS WAS OPENED FIFTY YEARS AGO, WASN'T
IT?

HE SAID. THAT'S WHAT MALPUS SAID.

YEAH . . . SAID RON SLEELY.

AND THIS DIARY IS FIFTY YEARS OLD, SAID HERMIONE, TAPPING IT
EXCITEDLY.

SHE?

EH, RON, WAKE UP, SNAPPED HERMIONE. WE KNOW THE PERSON
WHO

OPENED THE CHAMBER LAST TIME WAS EXPELLED FIFTY YEARS AGO. WE
KNOW T. M.

RIDDLE GOT AN AWARD FOR SPECIAL SERVICES THE THE SEVEN FIFTY YEARS
AGO. WELL,

WHAT IF RIDDLE GOT HIS SPECIAL AWARD FOR CATCHING THE FIRM OF
SLITHERING HIS

DIARY WOULD PROBABLY TELL US EVERYTHING WHERE THE CHAMBER IS,
AND HOW

THE OPEN IT, AND WHAT SORT OF CREATURE LIVES IN IT THE PERSON
WHO'S BEHIND

THE ATTACKS THIS TIME WOULDNT WANT THAT LYING AROUND, WOULD
THEY?

THAT'S A BRILLIANT THEORY, HERMIONE, SAID RON, WITH ILST HER
TINY LITTLE

FLAW. THERE'S NOTHING WRITTEN IN HIS DIARY.

BUT HERMIONE WAS PULLING HER HAND OUT OF HER BAG.

IT MIGHT BE INVISIBLE INK! SHE WHISPERED.

SHE TAPPED THE DIARY THREE TIMES AND SAID, ~~SPARKILUM!~~

NOTHING HAPPENED, UNDAUNTED, HERMIONE SHEVED HER HAND BACK INTO HER

BAG AND PULLED OUT WHAT APPEARED TO BE A BRIGHT RED ERASER.

IT'S A REVEALER, I GOT IT IN DIAGON ALLEY, SHE SAID.

SHE RUBBED HARD ON JANUARY FIRST. NOTHING HAPPENED.

I'M TELLING YOU, THERE'S NOTHING TO FIND IN THERE, SAID RON.
RIDDLE ILST

GET A DIARY FOR CHRISTMAS AND CHILDREN TO BE EITHERED FILLING IT IN.

HARRY CHILDREN TO EXPLAIN, EVEN TO HIMSELF, WHY HE DIDN'T ILST THE
RIDDLE'S

DIARY AWAY. THE FACT WAS THAT EVEN THOUGH HE KNEW THE DIARY WAS
BLANK, HE

KEPT ABSENTMINDELY PICKING IT UP AND TURNING THE PAGES, AS
THOUGH IT WERE

A STORY HE WANTED TO FINISH, AND WHILE HARRY WAS SURE HE HAD
NEVER HEARD

THE NAME T. M. RIDDLE BEFORE, IT STILL SEEMED TO MEAN SOMETHING TO
HIM.

ALMOST AS THOUGH RIDDLE WAS A FRIEND HE'D HAD WHEN HE WAS VERY
SMALL,

AND HAD HALF-FORGOTTEN, BUT THIS WAS ABSURD, HE'D NEVER HAD FRIENDS
BEFORE

THEGLANTS, DUDLEY HAD MADE SURE OF THAT.

NEVERTHELESS, HARRY WAS DETERMINED TO FIND OUT MORE ABOUT RIDDLE,
SEE

NEXT DAY AT BREAK, HE HEADED FOR THE TROPHY ROOM TO EXAMINE
RIDDLE'S

SPECIAL AWARD, ACCOMPANIED BY AN INTERESTED HERMIONE AND A
TEHRRELGHLY

LINCENYINKED RHN, WHEE TELD THEM HE D SEEN ENOUGH OF THE TREFP-D
RHHM TE

LAST HIM A LIFETIME.

RIDDLE S KLIRNISHED GELD SHIELD WAS TUCKED AWAY IN A CERNER CABINET.
IT

DIDN T CARRY DETAILS OF WHY IT HAD BEEN GIVEN THE HIM I GHEE THING,
THEE, HR

IT D BE EVEN BIGGER AND I D STILL BE PUBLISHING IT, SAID RHN. HOWEVER,
THEY

DID FIND RIDDLE S NAME IN AN OLD MEDAL FOR MAGICAL MERIT, AND IN A
LIST OF

OLD HEAD RHYTS.

HE SEEMDS LIKE PERCY, SAID RHN, WRINKLING HIS NOSE IN DISGUST.

PERFECT, HEAD RHY ... PROBABLY THE OF EVERY CLASS

YELL SAY THAT LIKE IT S A BAD THING, SAID HERMIONE IN A SLIGHTLY
FLIRT

WHILE.

THE SUN HAD NEW BEGUN THE SHINE WRADLY IN FHEGLARTS AGAIN.
INSIDE THE

CASTLE, THE MHEE HAD GREEN MORE FHEPPLJ. THERE HAD BEEN NEW MORE
ATTACKS

SINCE THESE IN JUSTIN AND NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, AND MADAM
PHEMREY WAS

PLEASED THE REPORT THAT THE MANDRAGES WERE RECEIVING MHEEY AND
SECRETIVE,

MEANING THAT THEY WERE FAST LEAVING CHILDHOOD.

THE MOMENT THEIR ACNE CLEARS UP, THEY LL BE READY FOR REPENTING AGAIN,

HARRY HEARD HER TELLING FILCH KINDLY HINE AFTERNEEN, AND AFTER THAT, IT

WEN T BE LONG UNTIL WE RE CUTTING THEM UP AND STEALING THEM, WE LL HAVE

MRS. NERVIS BACK IN NE TIME,

PERHAPS THE FEAR OF SLOTHERIN HAD LEST HIS FOR HER NERVE, THOUGHT HARRY, IT

MUST BE GETTING RISKIER AND RISKIER TO OPEN THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, WITH

THE SCHOOL SO ALERT AND SUSPICIOUS, PERHAPS THE MINISTER, WHATEVER IT WAS,

WAS EVEN NOW SETTLING ITSELF DOWN THE HIGERDATE FOR ANOTHER FIFTY YEARS. . . .

ERNE MACMILLAN OF FLUFFLEPUFF DIDN T TAKE THIS CHEERFUL VIEW, HE WAS

STILL CONVINCED THAT HARRY WAS THE GUILTY HINE, THAT HE HAD GIVEN HIMSELF

AWAY AT THE DUELING CLUB, PEVES WASN T HELPING MATTERS; HE KEPT PEEPING UP IN THE CROWDED HALLWAYS SINGING EH, BETTER, YELL BETTER . . .

NOW WITH A DANCE ROUTINE TO MATCH,

GILBERT LEBRONART SEEMED TO THINK HE HIMSELF HAD MADE THE ATTACKS

STEP, HARRY OVERHEARD HIM TELLING PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SO WHILE THE

GRYFFINDORS WERE LINING UP FOR TRANSFIGURATION,

I DON T THINK THERE LL BE ANY MORE TRICKLE, MINERVA, HE SAID, TAPPING

HIS NOSE KNOWINGLY AND WINKING. I THINK THE CHAMBER HAS BEEN
CHECKED FOR

GOOD THIS TIME. THE CLERK MUST HAVE KNOWN IT WAS ONLY A
MATTER OF TIME

BEFORE I CALLED HIM. RATHER SENSIBLE THE STEP NOW, BEFORE I CAME
DOWN HARD

ON HIM.

WELL NOW, WHAT THE SCHEME NEEDS NOW IS A MENTAL-EXERCISE, WASH-
AWAY

THE MEMORIES OF LAST TERM? I WOULD SAY AND MORE ILUST NOW, BUT I
THINK I

KNOW ILUST THE THING. . . .

HE TAPPED HIS NOSE AGAIN AND STRIDE OFF.

LOCKHART'S IDEA OF A MENTAL-EXERCISE BECAME CLEAR AT BREAKFAST TIME
ON

FEBRUARY FIFTEENTH, HARRY HADN'T HAD MUCH SLEEP BECAUSE OF A
LATE-

RUNNING QUIDDITCH PRACTICE THE NIGHT BEFORE, AND HE FLURRIED DOWN
THE THE

GREAT HALL, SLIGHTLY LATE, HE THOUGHT, FOR A MOMENT, THAT HE'D
WALKED

THROUGH THE WIRING BEHINDS.

THE WALLS WERE ALL COVERED WITH LARGE, LURID PINK FLOWERS, WORSE
STILL,

HEART-SHAPED CHICKETTI WAS FALLING FROM THE PALE BLUE CEILING.
HARRY WENT

EVER THE THE GRYPFINDER TABLE, WHERE REIN WAS SITTING WHISKING
SICKENED, AND

HERMIONNE SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN OVERCOME WITH GIGGLES.

WHAT IS GOING ON? HARRY ASKED THEM, SITTING DOWN AND WIPING
CHENFETTI

OFF HIS EACHEN.

REIN POINTED THE THE TEACHERS TABLE, APPARENTLY THEY DISGUSTED THE
SPREAD.

LECKE-HART, WEARING LIVID PINK REERS THE MATCH THE DECORATIONS, WAS
LAYING

HER SILENCE. THE TEACHERS ON EITHER SIDE OF HIM WERE WHISKING
STEADY-FACED.

FROM WHERE HE SAT, HARRY COULD SEE A MISTLE GOING IN PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL'S CHEEK. SNAPE WHISKED AS THOUGH SOMETHING HAD JUST FOD
HIM A

LARGE BLADDER OF SWEET-CREAM.

HAPPY VALENTINE'S DAY! LECKE-HART SMILTED. AND MAY I THANK
THE

THIRTY-SIX PEOPLE WHO HAVE SO FAR SENT ME CARDS? YES, I HAVE TAKEN
THE

LIBERTY OF ARRANGING THIS LITTLE SURPRISE FOR YOU ALL AND IT
DOESN'T END

HERE!

LECKE-HART CLAPPED HIS HANDS AND THROUGH THE DOORS THE THE
ENTRANCE HALL

MARCHED A DOZEN SLIRLY-WHISKING BLARPS, NOT JUST ANY BLARPS,
HOWEVER.

LECKE-HART HAD THEM ALL WEARING CHILDEN WINGS AND CARRYING HARPS.

MY FRIENDLY, CARD-CARRYING CLIPIDS! BEAMED LECKE-HART. THEY WILL
BE

REIVING AROUND THE SCHOOL TODAY DELIVERING THEIR VALENTINES! AND
THEY WERE

DEESEN'T STOP HERE! I'M SURE MY COLLEAGUES WILL WANT TO ENTER INTO
THE SPIRIT

OF THE OCCASION! WHY NOT ASK PROFESSOR SNAPE THE SCHOOL WILL FEEL
THE WHIP UP

A LOVE POTION! AND WHILE THEY'RE AT IT, PROFESSOR FLITWICK KNOWS
MORE

ABOUT ENCHANTING ENCHANTMENTS THAN ANY WIZARD I'VE EVER MET,
THE SLY HOUND

DEG!

PROFESSOR FLITWICK BLINKED HIS FACE IN HIS HANDS. SNAPE WAS
LOOKING AS

THOUGH THE FIRST PERSON TO ASK HIM FOR A LOVE POTION WOULD BE
HARRY-PO

POISSON.

PLEASE, HERMIONE, TELL ME WHY WEREN'T THEY OF THE FIFTY-SIX, SAID
HERN

AS THEY LEFT THE GREAT HALL FOR THEIR FIRST LESSON, HERMIONE
SUDDENLY

BECAME VERY INTERESTED IN SEARCHING HER BAG FOR HER SCHEDULE AND
DIDN'T

ANSWER.

ALL DAY LONG, THE DWARFS KEPT BARGING INTO THEIR CLASSES TO DELIVER
VALENTINES, TO THE ANNOYANCE OF THE TEACHERS, AND LATE THAT
AFTERNOON AS THE

GRYFFINDORS WERE WALKING UPSTAIRS FOR CHARM, ONE OF THE DWARFS
CALLED

UP WITH HARRY.

HI, WELL? ARRY PITTER? SEEMED A PARTICULARLY GRIM-LOOKING
DWARF,

PLEADING PEOPLE HLT HP THE WAY TH GET TH HARRY,

HEET ALL EVER AT THE TWELIGHT HP BEING GIVEN A VALENTINE IN PRESENT
HP A LINK HP

FIRST YEARS, WHICH HAPPENED TH INCLUDE GINNY WEASLEY, HARRY TRIED
TH

ESCAPE. THE DWARF, HOWEVER, CUT HIS WAY THROUGH THE CROWD BY
KICKING

PEOPLE S SHINS, AND REACHED HIM BEFORE HE D GENE TWO PACE.

I VE GET A MUSICAL MESSAGE TH DELIVER TH ARRY PITTER IN PERSON,
HE

SAID, TWANGING HIS HARP IN A THREATENING SORT HP WAY,

NHT HERE, HARRY HISSED, TRYING TH ESCAPE,

STAY STILL? GRUNTED THE DWARF, GRABBING HILD HP HARRY S BAG AND
PULLING

HIM BACK.

LET ME GO? HARRY SNARLED, TUGGING.

WITH A LUD RIPPING NOISE, HIS BAG SPLIT IN TWO, HIS KNEES, HAND,
PARCHMENT, AND BILLS SPILLED BNTHE THE FLEET AND HIS INK BOTTLE
SMASHED EVER

EVERYTHING.

HARRY SCRAMBLED AROUND, TRYING TH PICK IT ALL UP BEFORE THE DWARF
STARTED

SINGING, CALSING SOMETHING HP A HEDLIP IN THE CORRIDOR.

WHAT S GOING ON HERE? CAME THE CHILD, DRAWLING VEICE HP DRACH
MALFOY, HARRY STARTED SLIPPING EVERYTHING FEVERISHLY INTO HIS
RIPPED BAG,

DESPERATE TO GET AWAY BEFORE MALFOY COULD HEAR HIS MUSICAL
VALENTINE.

WHAT IS ALL THIS CHATTERING? SAID ANOTHER FAMILIAR VOICE AS
PERCY

WEASLEY ARRIVED.

SHOOTING HIS HEAD, HARRY TRIED TO MAKE A RUN FOR IT, BUT THE DWARF
SEIZED

HIM AROUND THE WAIST AND KNEELIGHT HIM CRASHING TO THE FLOOR.

RIGHT, HE SAID, SITTING ON HARRY'S ANKLES. HERE IS YOUR SINGING
VALENTINE:

HIS EYES ARE AS GREEN AS A FRESH PICKLED TUNA,

HIS HAIR IS AS DARK AS A BLACKBOARD,

I WISH HE WAS MINE, HE'S REALLY DIVINE,

THE MORE WE CONSIDERED THE DARK LORD,

HARRY WOULD HAVE GIVEN ALL THE GOLD IN GRINGOTTS TO EVAPORATE
ON THE

SPOT. TRYING VALIANTLY TO LAUGH ALONG WITH EVERYONE ELSE, HE GOT
UP, HIS FEET

SLIP FROM THE WEIGHT OF THE DWARF, AS PERCY WEASLEY DID HIS BEST TO
DISPERSSE THE CROWD, SOME OF WHOM WERE CRYING WITH MIRTH.

OFF THEY GO, OFF THEY GO, THE BELL RANG FIVE MINUTES AGO, OFF THE
CLASS,

WELL, HE SAID, SMILING SOME OF THE YOUNGER STUDENTS AWAY, AND
WELL,

MALFOY

HARRY, GLANCING OVER, SAW MALFOY STEEP AND SNATCH UP
SOMETHING.

LEERING, HE STHEWED IT THE CRACK AND CHYLE, AND HARRY REALIZED THAT
HE'D

GET RIDDLE'S DIARY.

GIVE THAT BACK, SAID HARRY QUIETLY.

WHENEVER WHAT PETER'S WRITTEN IN THIS? SAID MALPHY, WHEN
HEVILLY

HADN'T NOTICED THE YEAR WHEN THE CRYER AND THELIGHT HE HAD HARRY'S
HOLD DIARY.

A FLUSH FELL OVER THE HUNTERS. GINNY WAS STARING FROM THE
DIARY THE HARRY.

WHENING TERRIFIED.

HAND IT OVER, MALPHY, SAID PERCY STERNLY.

WHEN I'VE HAD A LOOK, SAID MALPHY, LAYING THE DIARY TALKINGLY
AT

HARRY.

PERCY SAID, AS A SCHOOL PERFECT BUT HARRY HAD LOST HIS
TEMPER, HE

PULLED OUT HIS WAND AND SHOUTED, EXPPELLIARIS! AND INSTANT AS
SNAP HAD

DISARMED LUCIFERT, SEE MALPHY FEELING THE DIARY SHOOTING OUT OF HIS
HAND

INTO THE AIR, THEN, GRINNING BROADLY, CALIGHT IT.

HARRY? SAID PERCY LUDLY, NO MAGIC IN THE HALLWAYS, I'LL HAVE
THE

REPORT THIS, YELL BOWLS?

BUT HARRY DIDN'T CARE, HE WAS HUNG-UP ON MALPHY, AND THAT WAS
WORTH FIVE

POINTS FROM GRYFFINDOR ANY DAY. MALPHY WAS BEHINDING FLIRTELIS, AND
AS GINNY

PASSED HIM THE ENTER HER CLASSROOM, HE YELLED SPITEFULLY AFTER HER,
I DIDN'T

THINK PETER LIKED HER VALENTINE MUCH

GINDY COVERED HER FACE WITH HER HANDS AND RAN INTO CLASS,
SNARLING, THEN

PULLED OUT HIS WAND, THEN, BUT HARRY PULLED HIM AWAY. THEN DIDN'T
NEED THE

SPEND THE WHILE OF CHARMING BELCHING SLUGS.

IT WASN'T UNTIL THEY HAD REACHED PROFESSOR FLITWICK'S CLASS THAT
HARRY

NOTICED SOMETHING RATHER HAD ABOUT RIDDLE'S DIARY. ALL HIS OTHER
BOOKS

WERE DRENCHED IN SCARLET INK. THE DIARY, HOWEVER, WAS AS CLEAN AS IT
HAD

BEEN BEFORE THE INK BOTTLE HAD SMASHED ALL OVER IT. HE TRIED THE
POINT THIS

OUT THE THEN, BUT THEN WAS HAVING TROUBLE WITH HIS WAND AGAIN;
LARGE PURPLE

FLICKS WERE BLESSEING HIM AT THE END, AND HE WASN'T MUCH
INTERESTED IN

ANYTHING ELSE.

HARRY WENT THE BED BEFORE ANYONE ELSE IN HIS DORMITORY THAT NIGHT.
THIS WAS

PARTLY BECAUSE HE DIDN'T THINK HE COULD STAND FRED AND GEORGE
SINGING,

HIS EYES ARE AS GREEN AS A FRESH PICKLED THOAT ONE MORE TIME, AND
PARTLY

BECAUSE HE WANTED TO EXAMINE RIDDLE'S DIARY AGAIN, AND KNEW THAT
THEN

THOUGHT HE WAS WASTING HIS TIME.

HARRY SAT IN HIS FLEUR-DE-LIS AND FLICKED THROUGH THE BLANK PAGES, NOT ONE

OF WHICH HAD A TRACE OF SCARLET INK IN IT. THEN HE PULLED A NEW BOTTLE OUT OF

HIS BEDSIDE CABINET, DIPPED HIS QUILL INTO IT, AND DROPPED A BLEAT BENTH THE

FIRST PAGE OF THE DIARY.

THE INK SHONE BRIGHTLY IN THE PAPER FOR A SECOND AND THEN, AS THOUGH IT

WAS BEING SLIDED INTO THE PAGE, VANISHED. EXCITED, HARRY LEANED UP HIS

QUILL A SECOND TIME AND WROTE, MY NAME IS HARRY POTTER.

THE WORDS SHONE MOMENTARILY IN THE PAGE AND THEN, THEY, TOO, SAID WITH-OUT

TRACE. THEN, AT LAST, SOMETHING HAPPENED.

FLIPPING BACK OUT OF THE PAGE, IN HIS VERY OWN INK, CAME WORDS HARRY HAD

NEVER WRITTEN.

HELLO, HARRY POTTER. MY NAME IS TOM RIDDLE. HOW DID YOU COME BY MY

DIARY?

THESE WORDS, TOO, FADED AWAY, BUT NOT BEFORE HARRY HAD STARTED THE SCRIBBLE BACK.

SOMEONE TRIED TO FLUSH IT DOWN A TOILET.

HE WAITED EAGERLY FOR RIDDLE'S REPLY.

LUCKY THAT I RECOVERED MY MEMORIES IN SOME MORE LASTING WAY THAN INK.

BUT I ALWAYS KNEW THAT THERE WOULD BE THESE WHO WOULD NOT WANT THIS DIARY

READ.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? HARRY SCRAWLED, FLIPPING THE PAGE IN HIS EXCITEMENT.

I MEAN THAT THIS DIARY HELDS MEMORIES OF TERRIBLE THINGS, THINGS THAT

WERE KEPT UP, THINGS THAT HAPPENED AT HOGWARTS SCHOOL OF WITCHCRAFT

AND WIZARDRY.

THAT'S WHERE I AM NOW, HARRY WROTE QUICKLY. I'M AT HOGWARTS, AND

HORRIBLE STUFF'S BEEN HAPPENING. DO YOU KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT THE CHAMBER

OF SECRETS?

HIS HEART WAS HAMMERING. RIDDLE'S REPLY CAME QUICKLY, HIS WRITING BECOMING URGENT, AS THOUGH HE WAS HURRYING TO TELL ALL HE KNEW.

OF COURSE I KNOW ABOUT THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS. IN MY DAY, THEY TOLD US

IT WAS A LEGEND, THAT IT DID NOT EXIST, BUT THIS WAS A LIE. IN MY FIFTH YEAR, THE

CHAMBER WAS OPENED AND THE MONSTER ATTACKED SEVERAL STUDENTS, FINALLY

KILLING ONE. I CAUGHT THE PERSON WHO'D OPENED THE CHAMBER AND HE WAS

EXPULSED, BUT THE HEADMASTER, PROFESSOR DUMPLEY, ASKED THAT SUCH A THING

HAD HAPPENED AT HOGWARTS, PERHAPS HE'D TELL THE TRUTH. A STORY WAS GIVEN

ABOUT THE GIRL HAD DIED IN A FREAK ACCIDENT. THEY GAVE ME A NICE, SHINY,

ENGRAVED TRIPLE-~~Y~~ FOR MY TRULIKE AND WARNED ME TO KEEP MY MOUTH
SHUT. BUT

I KNEW IT COULD HAPPEN AGAIN. THE MINISTER LIVED HERE, AND THE ONE
WHO HAD

THE POWER TO RELEASE IT WAS NOT IMPRISONED.

HARRY NEARLY UPSAT HIS INK BOTTLE IN HIS HURRY TO WRITE BACK.

IT IS HAPPENING AGAIN NOW. THERE HAVE BEEN THREE ATTACKS AND ONE
HERE

SEEMS TO KNOW WHO IS BEHIND THEM. WHO WAS IT LAST TIME?

I CAN SHOW YOU, IF YOU LIKE, CAME RIDDLE'S REPLY. YOU DON'T HAVE
THE

TAKE MY WORD FOR IT. I CAN TAKE YOU INSIDE MY MEMORY OF THE NIGHT
WHEN I

CUGHT HIM.

HARRY HESITATED, HIS QUILL SUSPENDED OVER THE DIARY. WHAT DID
RIDDLE

MEAN? COULD HE BE TAKEN INSIDE SOMEONE ELSE'S MEMORY? HE

GLANCED NERVOUSLY AT THE DOOR TO THE DORMITORY, WHICH WAS
GROWING DARK.

WHEN HE LOOKED BACK AT THE DIARY, HE SAW FRESH WORDS FORMING.

LET ME SHOW YOU.

HARRY PAUSED FOR A FRACTION OF A SECOND AND THEN WROTE TWO
LETTERS.

END.

THE PAGES OF THE DIARY BEGAN TO BLEW AS THOUGH CUGHT IN A HIGH
WIND.

STEPPING HALFWAY THROUGH THE MOUTH OF ILK, MOUTH HANGING
OPEN, HARRY

SAW THAT THE LITTLE SQUARE FOR ILK THIRTEENTH SEEMED TO HAVE
TURNED INTO A

MINUSCULE TELEVISION SCREEN. HIS HANDS TREMBLING SLIGHTLY, HE
RAISED THE

BOOK THE PRESS HIS EYE AGAINST THE LITTLE WINDOW, AND BEFORE HE
KNEW WHAT

WAS HAPPENING, HE WAS TILTING FORWARD; THE WINDOW WAS WIDENING,
HE FELT

HIS BODY LEAVE HIS BED, AND HE WAS PITCHED HEADFIRST THROUGH THE
OPENING IN

THE PAGE, INTO A WHIRL OF CLOTH AND SHADOW.

HE FELT HIS FEET HIT SHED CLOTH, AND STOOD, SHAKING, AS THE KILNED
SHAPES AROUND HIM CAME SLIDENLY INTO VIEW.

HE KNEW IMMEDIATELY WHERE HE WAS. THIS CIRCULAR ROOM WITH THE
SLEEPING PORTRAITS WAS DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE BUT IT WASN'T
DUMBLEDORE

WHO WAS SITTING BEHIND THE DESK. A WIZENED, FRAIL-LOOKING WIZARD,
BALD

EXCEPT FOR A FEW WISPS OF WHITE HAIR, WAS READING A LETTER BY
CANDLELIGHT.

HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN THIS MAN BEFORE.

I'M SORRY, HE SAID SHAKILY. I DIDN'T MEAN THE BUTT IN
BUT THE WIZARD DIDN'T LIFT UP. HE CONTINUED TO READ, TREMBLING
SLIGHTLY.

HARRY DREW NEARER TO HIS DESK AND STAMMERED, ER I MUST GO,
SHALL I?

STILL THE WIZARD IGNORED HIM. HE DIDN'T SEEM EVEN TO HAVE HEARD
HIM.

THINKING THAT THE WIZARD MIGHT BE DEAF, HARRY RAISED HIS VOICE.

SORRY I DISTURBED YOU. I MUST GO NOW, HE HALF-SHOUTED.

THE WIZARD FOLDED UP THE LETTER WITH A SIGH, STOOD UP, WALKED PAST
HARRY

WITHOUT GLANCING AT HIM, AND WENT TO DRAW THE CURTAINS AT HIS
WINDOW.

THE SKY OUTSIDE THE WINDOW WAS RUBY-RED; IT SEEMED THE RED SUNSET.
THE

WIZARD WENT BACK TO THE DESK, SAT DOWN, AND TWIDDED HIS THUMBS,
WATCHING

THE DOOR.

HARRY WHEEZED AROUND THE OFFICE, DID FALLOWS THE PHEENIX AND
WHIRRING

SILVER CONTRAPTIONS. THIS WAS HOGWARTS AS RIDDLE HAD KNOWN IT,
MEANING

THAT THIS LONDONER WIZARD WAS HEADMASTER, NOT DUMBLEDORE, AND HE,
HARRY,

WAS LITTLE MORE THAN A PHANTOM, COMPLETELY INVISIBLE TO THE
PEOPLE OF FIFTY

YEARS AGO.

THERE WAS A KNOCK ON THE OFFICE DOOR.

ENTER, SAID THE OLD WIZARD IN A PEERLY VOICE.

A BOY OF ABOUT SIXTEEN ENTERED, TAKING OFF HIS POINTED HAT, A
SILVER

PREFECT'S BADGE WAS GLINTING ON HIS CHEST. HE WAS MUCH TALLER THAN
HARRY,

BUT HE, THEN, HAD IRT-BLACK HAIR.

AND RIDDLE, SAID THE HEADMASTER,

WELL WANTED TO SEE ME, PROFESSOR DUMPLEY? SAID RIDDLE. HE WHEEZED
NERVELIS.

SIT DOWN, SAID DIPPET, I VE JUST BEEN READING THE LETTER YOU SENT ME,

HE SAID RIDDLE, HE SAT DOWN, GRIPPING HIS HANDS TOGETHER VERY TIGHTLY,

MY DEAR KID, SAID DIPPET KINDLY, I CANNOT POSSIBLY LET YOU STAY AT

STEEPLE HENNER THE SUMMER, SURELY YOU WANT THE GEE HOME FOR THE HOLIDAYS?

NO, SAID RIDDLE AT ONCE, I D MUCH RATHER STAY AT HEEGLARTS THAN GEE

BACK THE THAT THE THAT

YOU LIVE IN A MUGGLE HOSPITAL DURING THE HOLIDAYS, I BELIEVE? SAID

DIPPET CLIMBLY,

YES, SIR, SAID RIDDLE, REDDENING SLIGHTLY,

YOU ARE MUGGLE-KID?

HALF-BLOOD, SIR, SAID RIDDLE, MUGGLE FATHER, WITCH MOTHER,

AND ARE BOTH YOUR PARENTS ?

MY MOTHER DIED JUST AFTER I WAS BORN, SIR, THEY TOLD ME AT THE HOSPITAL SHE LIVED JUST LONG ENOUGH TO NAME ME THEM AFTER MY FATHER,

MARYHEE AFTER MY GRANDFATHER,

DIPPET CLINKED HIS TONGUE SYMPATHETICALLY,

THE THING IS, THEM, HE SIGHED, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENTS MIGHT HAVE BEEN

MADE FOR YOU, BUT IN THE CURRENT CIRCUMSTANCES, ...

YOU MEAN ALL THESE ATTACKS, SIR? SAID RIDDLE, AND HARRY S HEART LEAPT,

AND HE MOVED CLOSER, SCARED HE MISSING ANYTHING,

PRECISELY, SAID THE HEADMASTER, MY DEAR KID, YOU MUST SEE HOW
FISHISH IT WOULD BE IF WE THE ALLEH YOU THE REMAIN AT THE CASTLE
WHEN TERM

ENDS, PARTICULARLY IN LIGHT OF THE RECENT TRAGEDY . . . THE DEATH OF
THAT POOR

LITTLE GIRL . . . YOU WILL BE SAFER BY FAR AT YOUR HOME-AGE, AS A
MATTER OF

FACT, THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC IS EVEN NOW TALKING ABOUT CLOSING THE
SCHOOL.

WE ARE NOW NEARER LOCATING THE ER SOURCE OF ALL THIS
UNPLEASANTNESS. . . .

RIDDLE'S EYES HAD WIDENED.

SIR IF THE PERSON WAS CALLED IF IT ALL STOPPED

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? SAID DIPPET WITH A SNEER IN HIS VOICE,
SITTING UP

IN HIS CHAIR, RIDDLE, DO YOU MEAN YOU KNOW SOMETHING ABOUT
THESE

ATTACKS?

NO, SIR, SAID RIDDLE QUICKLY.

BUT HARRY WAS SURE IT WAS THE SAME SORT OF NO THAT HE HIMSELF
HAD

GIVEN DUMBLEDORE.

DIPPET SANK BACK, LOOKING FAINTLY DISAPPOINTED.

YOU MAY GO, THEN. . . .

RIDDLE SLID OFF HIS CHAIR AND SNEEZED OUT OF THE ROOM, HARRY
FOLLOWED

HIM.

DOWN THE MOVING SPIRAL STAIRCASE THEY WENT, EMERGING NEXT TO THE

GARGOYLE IN THE DARKENING CORRIDOR, RIDDLE STOPPED, AND SHE DID
HARRY,

WATCHING HIM, HARRY COULD TELL THAT RIDDLE WAS DOING SOME SERIOUS
THINKING. HE WAS BITING HIS LIP, HIS THREE-HEAD FLUTTERED.

THEN, AS THOUGH HE HAD SUDDENLY REACHED A DECISION, HE FLURRIED
OFF,

HARRY GLIDING NEARLY BEHIND HIM. THEY DIDN'T SEE ANOTHER
PERSON UNTIL

THEY REACHED THE ENTRANCE HALL, WHEN A TALL WIZARD WITH LONG,
SWEEPING

ALBURN HAIR AND A BEARD CALLED THE RIDDLE FROM THE MARBLE STAIRCASE.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING, WANDERING AROUND THIS LATE, TERN?

HARRY GAZED AT THE WIZARD. HE WAS NEARLY FIFTY-YEARS-
OLD

SLURRY.

I HAD TO SEE THE HEADMASTER, SIR, SAID RIDDLE.

WELL, FLURRY OFF THE RED, SAID SLURRY, GIVING RIDDLE EXACTLY THE
KIND OF PENETRATING STARE HARRY KNEW SHE WELL. BEST NOT TO BE
THE

CORRIDORS THESE DAYS, NOT SINCE . . .

HE SIGHED HEAVILY, BARE RIDDLE GOOD NIGHT, AND STRODE OFF. RIDDLE

WATCHED HIM WALK OUT OF SIGHT AND THEN, MOVING QUICKLY, HEADED
STRAIGHT

DOWN THE STONE STEPS TO THE DUNGEONS, WITH HARRY IN HOT
PURSUIT.

BUT THE HARRY'S DISAPPOINTMENT, RIDDLE LED HIM NOT INTO A HIDDEN
PASSAGEWAY OR A SECRET TUNNEL BUT THE VERY DUNGEON IN WHICH
HARRY HAD

PHITHENS WITH SNAP. THE THICKETS HADN'T BEEN LIT, AND WHEN RIDDLE
PLISHED

THE DEER ALMOST CLESED, HARRY COULD ONLY JUST SEE HIM, STANDING
STEAD-STEAD

BY THE DEER, WATCHING THE PASSAGE HELTSIDE.

IT FELT THE HARRY THAT THEY WERE THERE FOR AT LEAST AN HOUR. ALL HE
COULD SEE

WAS THE FIGURE OF RIDDLE AT THE DEER, STARING THROUGH THE CRACK,
WAITING LIKE

A STATUE. AND JUST WHEN HARRY HAD STEPPED FEELING EXPECTANT AND
TENSE AND

STARTED WISHING HE COULD RETURN THE PRESENT, HE HEARD
SOMETHING MOVE

BEYOND THE DEER.

SOMETHING WAS CREEPING ALONG THE PASSAGE. HE HEARD WHEREVER IT
WAS PASS

THE BUNGLES WHERE HE AND RIDDLE WERE HIDDEN. RIDDLE, HEART AS A
SHADE,

EDGED THROUGH THE DEER AND FOLLOWED, HARRY TIGHTLY BEHIND HIM,
FORGETTING THAT HE COULDN'T BE HEARD.

FOR PERHAPS FIVE MINUTES THEY FOLLOWED THE FOOTSTEPS, UNTIL RIDDLE
STOPPED SUDDENLY, HIS HEAD INCLINED IN THE DIRECTION OF NEW NOISES.
HARRY

HEARD A DEER CRACK OPEN, AND THEN SOMETHING SPEAKING IN A HARSH
WHISPER.

[MEN ... GETTA GET YEH HETTA HERE ... [MEN NEW ... IN THE SHED ...
,

THERE WAS SOMETHING FAMILIAR ABOUT THAT VOICE ...

RIDDLE SUDDENLY JUMPED AROUND THE CORNER. HARRY STOPPED HEAT
BEHIND

HIM, HE COULD SEE THE DARK SILHOUETTE OF A FLICE WHO WAS
CLICKING IN

FRONT OF AN OPEN DOOR, A VERY LARGE ROOM NEXT TO IT.

EVENING, RIKELIS, SAID RIDDLE SHARPLY,

THEY SLAMMED THE DOOR SHUT AND STOOD UP.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE, THEN?

RIDDLE STEPPED CLOSER,

IT'S ALL OVER, HE SAID, I'M GOING TO HAVE TO TURN YOU IN,
RIKELIS,

THEY'RE TALKING ABOUT CHASING FLEEWARTS IF THE ATTACKS DON'T
STOP,

WHAT DO YOU

I DON'T THINK YOU MEANT TO KILL ANYONE, BUT MINISTERS DON'T MAKE
GOOD

PETS, I SUPPOSE YOU JUST LET IT RUN FOR EXERCISE AND

IT NEVER KILLED ANYONE? SAID THE LARGE FLY, BACKING AGAINST THE
CLOSED

DOOR, FROM BEHIND HIM, HARRY COULD HEAR A FLINDY RUSTLING AND
CLICKING,

COME ON, RIKELIS, SAID RIDDLE, MOVING YET CLOSER. THE DEAD GIRL'S
PARENTS WILL BE HERE TOMORROW. THE LEAST FLEEWARTS CAN DO IS
MAKE SURE

THAT THE THING THAT KILLED THEIR DAUGHTER IS SLAUGHTERED. . . .

IT WASN'T HIM? REARED THE FLY, HIS VOICE ECHOING IN THE DARK
PASSAGE.

HE WON'T : HE NEVER?

STAND ASIDE, SAID RIDDLE, DRAWING OUT HIS WAND,

HIS SPELL LIT THE CORRIDOR WITH A SUDDEN FLAMING LIGHT. THE DEER
BEHIND

THE LARGE DEER FLEW UPON WITH SUCH FORCE IT BOUNCED HIM INTO THE
WALL

OPPOSITE, AND FELT AS IT CAME SOMETHING THAT MADE HARRY LET OUT A
LONG,

PIERCING SCREAM UNHEARD BY ANYONE

A VAST, WHISPLING, HAIRY DEER AND A TANGLE OF BLACK LEGS; A GLEAM
OF

MANY EYES AND A PAIR OF RAZOR-SHARP PINNERS RIDDLE RAISED HIS
WAND

AGAIN, BUT HE WAS TOO LATE. THE THING BOUNCED HIM OVER AS IT
SCUTTLED AWAY,

TEARING UP THE CORRIDOR AND OUT OF SIGHT. RIDDLE SCRAMBLED ON HIS
FEET,

LEAPING AFTER IT; HE RAISED HIS WAND, BUT THE HUGE DEER LEAPT OVER
HIM, SEIZED

HIS WAND, AND THREW HIM BACK DOWN, YELLING, NEEEEEEEEEEEEEE!

THE SCENE WHIRLED, THE DARKNESS BECAME COMPLETE; HARRY FELT
HIMSELF

FALLING AND, WITH A CRASH, HE LANDED SPREAD-EAGLED ON HIS FLOOR-
PHESTER IN THE

GRIFFINDOR DORMITORY, RIDDLE'S DIARY LYING UPON HIS STOMACH.

BEFORE HE HAD HAD TIME TO REGAIN HIS BREATH, THE DORMITORY DEER
HOPPED

AND UPON CAME IN.

THERE YOU ARE, HE SAID.

HARRY SAT UP. HE WAS SWEATING AND SHAKING.

WHAT'S UP? SAID UPON, LEANING AT HIM WITH CONCERN.

IT WAS HAGRID, THEN, HAGRID OPENED THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS FIFTY YEARS

AGO.

H

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

THEIR LITTLE FLOCK

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE HAD ALWAYS KNOWN THAT HAGRID HAD AN UNFERTILIZED LIVING FOR LARGE AND MONSTRIOUS CREATURES, DURING THEIR

FIRST YEAR AT HOGWARTS HE HAD TRIED TO RAISE A DRAGON IN HIS LITTLE WHEDEN

HOUSE, AND IT WOULD BE A LONG TIME BEFORE THEY FORGOT THE GIANT, THREE-

HEADED BEAST HE HAD CHRISTENED FLUFFY, AND IF, AS A KID, HAGRID HAD HEARD

THAT A MONSTER WAS HIDDEN SOMEWHERE IN THE CASTLE, HARRY WAS SURE HE HAD

HAVE GONE THE ANY LENGTHS FOR A GLIMPSE OF IT. HE HAD PROBABLY THOUGHT IT WAS

A SHAME THAT THE MONSTER HAD BEEN CREEPED UP ON HIM, AND THOUGHT IT

DESERVED THE CHANCE TO STRETCH ITS MANY LEGS; HARRY COULD JUST IMAGINE THE

THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLD HARRY TRYING THE FIT A LEASH AND CHLOR HEN IT,
BUT HE WAS

REALLY CERTAIN THAT HARRY WOULD NEVER HAVE MEANT THE DEATH
ANYBODY,

HARRY HAD WISHED HE HADN'T FEELING FELT FEEL THE WHOLE RIDDLE'S
DIARY,

AGAIN AND AGAIN REEN AND HERMIONE MADE HIM RECHLINT WHAT HE'D
SEEN,

UNTIL HE WAS HEARTILY SICK OF TELLING THEM AND SICK OF THE LONG,
CIRCULAR

CONVERSATIONS THAT FOLLOWED.

RIDDLE MIGHT HAVE GOTTEN THE WRONG PERSON, SAID HERMIONE, MAYBE
IT

WAS SOME OTHER MINISTER THAT WAS ATTACKING PEOPLE...

HOW MANY MINISTERS DO YOU THINK THIS PLACE CAN HOLD? REEN ASKED
BILLY,

WE ALWAYS KNEW HARRY HAD BEEN EXPELLED, SAID HARRY MISERABLY,

AND THE ATTACKS MUST BE STOPPED AFTER HARRY WAS KICKED OUT,
OTHERWISE,

RIDDLE WOULDN'T HAVE GOTTEN HIS AWAY,

REEN TRIED A DIFFERENT TACK,

RIDDLE DOES SEEM LIKE PERCY WHEN ASKED HIM THE SEVERAL HEN
HARRY,

ANYWAY?

BUT THE MINISTER HAD KILLED SOMEONE, REEN, SAID HERMIONE,

AND RIDDLE WAS GOING TO GET BACK THE SAME MUGGLE EMPLOYMENT IF
THEY

CHESSED HIGGLARTS, SAID HARRY, I DON'T BLAME HIM FOR WANTING THE
STAY

HERE, . . .

WELL MET F-JAGRID BEHIN DORNDOTLWNN ALLEY, DIDN T WELL, F-JARRY?

HE WAS ELYING A FLESH-EATING SLUG REPELLENT, SAID F-JARRY
EULIDELY.

THE THREE OF THEM FELL SILENT, AFTER A LONG PAUSE, F-JERMINE VEHICED
THE

DORNDOTLWNN EULJESTHEN OF ALL IN A HESITANT VEHIC.

DID WELL THINK WE SHOULD GO AND ASK F-JAGRID ABOUT IT ALL?

THAT D BE A CHEERFUL VISIT, SAID BEN. F-JELMH, F-JAGRID, TELL US,
HAVE WELL

BEEN SETTING ANYTHING MAD AND HAIRY WHESE IN THE CASTLE LATELY?

IN THE END, THEY DECIDED THAT THEY WOULD NOT SAY ANYTHING THE
F-JAGRID

UNLESS THERE WAS ANOTHER ATTACK, AND AS MORE AND MORE DAYS WENT
BY WITH

NO WHISPER FROM THE DISMEMBERED VEHIC, THEY BECAME HOPEFUL THAT
THEY

WOULD NEVER NEED TO TALK TO HIM ABOUT WHY HE HAD BEEN EXPELLED, IT
WAS

NEARLY FIVE MONTHS SINCE ILUSTIN AND NEARLY HEADLESS NICK
HAD BEEN

PETRIFIED, AND NEARLY EVERYBODY SEEMED TO THINK THAT THE ATTACKER,
WHATEVER

IT WAS, HAD RETIRED FOR GOOD, PERVES HAD FINALLY GHT BORED OF HIS
WH,

BETTER, WELL BETTER SEING, ERNIE MACMILLAN ASKED F-JARRY EULITE
EULITELY THE

PASS A BLICKET OF LEAPING THADSTHEALS IN F-JERKEHECY FIVE DAY, AND IN
MARCH

SEVERAL OF THE MANDRAKES THREW A WILD AND RALICHLIS PARTY IN
GREENE-HLISE

THREE. THIS MADE PROFESSOR SPRELLT VERY HAPPY.

THE MOMENT THEY START TRYING THE MOVE INTO EACH OTHER'S POETS,
WE'LL

KNOW THEY'RE FULLY MATURE, SHE TOLD HARRY. THEN WE'LL BE ABLE TO
REVIVE

THESE OTHER PEOPLE IN THE HOSPITAL WING.

THE SECOND YEARS WERE GIVEN SOMETHING NEW TO THINK ABOUT
DURING THEIR

EASTER HOLIDAYS. THE TIME HAD COME TO CHOOSE THEIR SUBJECTS FOR
THE THIRD

YEAR, A MATTER THAT HERMIONE, AT LEAST, TOOK VERY SERIOUSLY.

IT COULD AFFECT HER WHOLE FUTURE, SHE TOLD HARRY AND RON AS
THEY PORED

OVER LISTS OF NEW SUBJECTS, MARKING THEM WITH CHECKS.

I MUST WANT TO GIVE UP POTIONS, SAID HARRY.

WE CAN'T, SAID RON GLENNILY. WE KEEP ALL OUR OLD SUBJECTS, FOR
I'D

ITCHED DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS.

BUT THAT'S VERY IMPORTANT! SAID HERMIONE, STERNLY.

NOT THE WAY LUCIFART TEACHES IT, SAID RON. I HAVEN'T LEARNED
ANYTHING

FROM HIM EXCEPT NOT TO SET PIXIES FREE.

NEVILLE LONGBOTTOM HAD BEEN SENT LETTERS FROM ALL THE WITCHES AND
WIZARDS IN HIS FAMILY, ALL GIVING HIM DIFFERENT ADVICE ON WHAT TO
CHOOSE.

CONFUSED AND HERRIED, HE SAT READING THE SUBJECT LISTS WITH HIS
THUMB

PICKING UP, ASKING PEOPLE WHETHER THEY THOUGHT ARITHMAGIC
SEEMED MORE

DIFFICULT THAN STUDY OF ANCIENT RUNES, DEAN THOMAS, WHO, LIKE
HARRY, HAD

GREEN UP WITH MUGGLE, ENDED UP CLOSING HIS EYES AND TAKING HIS
HAND AT

THE LIST, THEN PICKING THE SUBJECTS IT LANDED HIM, FERMINE THE
NEEDS S

ADVICE BUT SIGNED UP FOR EVERYTHING.

HARRY SMILED GRIMLY TO HIMSELF AT THE THOUGHT OF WHAT UNCLE
VERNON AND

AUNT PETUNIA WOULD SAY IF HE TRIED TO DISCUSS HIS CAREER IN
WIZARDRY WITH

THEM. NOT THAT HE DIDN'T GET ANY GUIDANCE: PERCY WEASLEY WAS
EAGER TO

SHARE HIS EXPERIENCE.

DEPENDS WHERE YOU WANT TO GO, HARRY, HE SAID. IT'S NEVER TOO
EARLY TO

THINK ABOUT THE FUTURE, SEE I'D RECOMMEND DIVINATION, PEOPLE SAY
MUGGLE

STUDIES IS A SHOT HEPTON, BUT I PERSONALLY THINK WIZARDS SHOULD
HAVE A

THOROUGH UNDERSTANDING OF THE NON-MAGICAL COMMUNITY,
PARTICULARLY IF

THEY'RE THINKING OF WORKING IN CLOSE CONTACT WITH THEM. WHEN
AT MY

FATHER, HE HAS THE DEAL WITH MUGGLE BUSINESS ALL THE TIME. MY
BROTHER

CHARLIE WAS ALWAYS MORE OF AN ELTON TYPE, SEE HE WENT FOR CARE
OF

MAGICAL CREATURES, PLAY THE OTHER STRENGTHS, HARRY.

BUT THE ONLY THING HARRY FELT HE WAS REALLY GOOD AT WAS
QUIDDITCH. IN THE

END, HE CHOSE THE SAME NEW SLICKETS AS RON, FEELING THAT IF HE WAS
LUCKY AT

THEM, AT LEAST HE'D HAVE SOMEONE FRIENDLY TO HELP HIM.

GRYFFINDOR'S NEXT QUIDDITCH MATCH WOULD BE AGAINST SLYTHERLY,
WHICH WAS

INSISTING HIS TEAM PRACTICES EVERY NIGHT AFTER DINNER, SEE THAT
HARRY RARELY

HAD TIME FOR ANYTHING BUT QUIDDITCH AND HOWLERS. HOWEVER, THE
TRAINING

SESSIONS WERE GETTING BETTER, HE AT LEAST DRIER, AND THE EVENING
REFERE

SATURDAY'S MATCH HE WENT UP TO HIS DORMITORY TO DRESS OFF HIS
KNEEMISTLE

FEELING GRYFFINDOR'S CHANCES FOR THE QUIDDITCH CUP HAD NEVER BEEN
BETTER.

BUT HIS CHEERFUL MOOD DIDN'T LAST LONG. AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS THE
THE

DORMITORY, HE MET NEVILLE LONGBOTT, WHO WAS BEHAVING FRANTIC.

HARRY I DON'T KNOW WHO DID IT I JUST FELT

WATCHING HARRY FEARFULLY, NEVILLE PUSHED OPEN THE DOOR.

THE CONTENTS OF HARRY'S TRUNK HAD BEEN THROWN EVERYWHERE. HIS
CLOAK

WAS RIPPED IN THE FLOOR. THE BEDCLOTHES HAD BEEN PULLED OFF HIS
FEET-POSTER

AND THE DRAWER HAD BEEN PULLED OUT OF HIS BEDSIDE CABINET, THE
CONTENTS

STREWN OVER THE MATTRESS.

HARRY WALKED OVER TO THE BED, HOPINGLY, TREADING ON A FEW
MESS

PAGES OF TRAVELS WITH TRELLS, AS HE AND NEVILLE PULLED THE
BLANKETS BACK

INTO HIS BED, RON, DEAN, AND SEamus CAME IN, DEAN SMILING BROADLY,

WHAT HAPPENED, HARRY?

NO IDEA, SAID HARRY, BUT RON WAS EXAMINING HARRY'S REEKS, ALL
THE

POCKETS WERE HANGING OUT,

SOMEONE'S BEEN LOOKING FOR SOMETHING, SAID RON, IS THERE
ANYTHING

MISSING?

HARRY STARTED TO PICK UP ALL HIS THINGS AND THROW THEM INTO HIS
TRUNK, IT

WAS ONLY AS HE THREW THE LAST OF THE BEDDING INTO IT
THAT HE

REALIZED WHAT WASN'T THERE,

RIDDLE'S DIARY'S GONE, HE SAID IN AN UNDERSTONE TONE, RON,

WHAT?

HARRY POKED HIS HEAD TOWARD THE DORMITORY DEER AND RON
SHOOKED HIM

OUT, THEY HURRIED DOWN THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM, WHICH
WAS HALF-

EMPTY, AND FOUND HERMION, WHO WAS SITTING ALONE, READING A BOOK
CALLED

ANCIENT RUNES MADE EASY,

HERMION LEANED AGAINST AT THE NEWS,

BUT ONLY A GRYFFINDOR CHILD HAD STOLEN NEITHER ELSE
KNOWS HOW

PASSING

EXACTLY, SAID HARRY,

THEY WERE THE NEXT DAY THE BRILLIANT SUNSHINE AND A LIGHT,
REFRESHING BREEZE.

PERFECT FLUIDITCH CONDITIONS! SAID WEED ENTHUSIASTICALLY AT THE
GRYFFINDOR TABLE, LEADING THE TEAM'S PLATES WITH SCRAMBLED EGGS.
HARRY,

CLICK LIP THERE, YOU NEED A DECENT BREAKFAST.

HARRY HAD BEEN STARING DOWN THE PACKED GRYFFINDOR TABLE,
WONDERING IF

THE NEW OWNER OF RIDDLE'S DIARY WAS RIGHT IN FRONT OF HIS EYES.
HERMION

HAD BEEN URGING HIM TO REPORT THE MURKERS, BUT HARRY DIDN'T LIKE
THE IDEA.

HE'D HAVE TO TELL A TEACHER ALL ABOUT THE DIARY, AND FEEL MANY
PEOPLE KNOW

WHY LACRIM HAD BEEN EXPELLED FIFTY YEARS AGO? HE DIDN'T WANT THE RE
THE

ONE WHEN BRILLIANT IT ALL UP AGAIN.

AS HE LEFT THE GREAT HALL WITH RON AND HERMION THE GEE AND
COLLECT HIS

FLUIDITCH THINGS, ANOTHER VERY SERIOUS WHIRL WAS ADDED THE
HARRY'S

GROWING LIST. HE HAD JUST SET FOOT IN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE WHEN HE
HEARD IT

YET AGAIN

KILL THIS TIME ... LET ME RIP ... TEAR ...

HE STEELTED AHEAD AND RON AND HERMIONE BOTH JUMPED AWAY FROM HIM IN

ALARM.

THE VEHICLE? SAID HARRY, LEERING OVER HIS SHOULDER. I JUST HEARD IT AGAIN

DIDN'T YOU?

RON SHOOK HIS HEAD, WIDE-EYED, HERMIONE, HOWEVER, CLAPPED A HAND TO

HER FOREHEAD.

HARRY I THINK I'VE JUST UNDERSTOOD SOMETHING! I'VE GOT THE CAR THE

LIBRARY!

AND SHE SPURTED AWAY, UP THE STAIRS.

WHAT DOES SHE UNDERSTAND? SAID HARRY DISTRACTEDLY, STILL LEERING AROUND, TRYING TO TELL WHERE THE VEHICLE HAD COME FROM.

HEADS MORE THAN I DO, SAID RON, SHAKING HIS HEAD.

BUT WHY? SHE GOT THE CAR THE THE LIBRARY?

BECAUSE THAT'S WHAT HERMIONE DOES, SAID RON, SHRUGGING. WHEN IN

DELUKT, SHE THE THE LIBRARY.

HARRY STOOD, IRRESOLUTELY, TRYING TO CATCH THE VEHICLE AGAIN, BUT PEOPLE WERE

NOW EMERGING FROM THE GREAT HALL BEHIND HIM, TALKING LUDICRously, EXITING

THROUGH THE FRONT DOORS ON THEIR WAY TO THE FLIMDITCH PITCH.

YOU'D BETTER GET MOVING, SAID RON. IT'S NEARLY ELEVEN THE MATCH

HARRY RACED UP THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER, COLLECTED HIS NICKLES THEN

THEIRLAND, AND IMINED THE LARGE CREED SWARMING ACROSS THE
GRHILDS, BUT

HIS MIND WAS STILL IN THE CASTLE ALONG WITH THE ENDLESS VEHICLE, AND
AS HE

PULLED IN HIS SCARLET REEKS IN THE LECKER REEM, HIS ONLY COMFORT
WAS THAT

EVERYONE WAS NOW HELTIDE THE WATCH THE GAME.

THE TEAMS WALKED INTO THE FIELD THE TUMULTUOUS APPLAUSE, ELIVER
WHEED

THEIR OFF FOR A WARM-UP FLIGHT AROUND THE CHALPETS; MADAM
FHEICH

RELEASED THE BALLS. THE FLIPPLEPLIPS, WHO PLAYED IN CANARY YELLOW,
WERE

STANDING IN A Huddle, HAVING A LAST-MINUTE DISCUSSION OF TACTICS.

HARRY WAS JUST MEDITATING HIS KREEM WHEN PROFESSOR MCGHINACALL
CAME

HALF MARCHING, HALF RUNNING ACROSS THE PITCH, CARRYING AN
ENORMOUS PURPLE

MEGAPHONE.

HARRY'S HEART DROPPED LIKE A STONE.

THIS MATCH HAS BEEN CANCELLED. PROFESSOR MCGHINACALL CALLED
THROUGH

THE MEGAPHONE, ADDRESSING THE PACKED STADIUM. THERE WERE KEES
AND

SHULTS, ELIVER WHEED, LOOKING DEVASTATED, LANDED AND RAN TOWARD
PROFESSOR

MCGHINACALL WITHOUT GETTING OFF HIS KREEMSTICK.

BUT, PROFESSOR! HE SHOUTED. WE VE GOT THE PLAY THE CLIP
GAVE INDER

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IGNORED HIM AND CONTINUED THE SPEECH THROUGH HER

MEGAPHONE:

ALL STUDENTS ARE TO MAKE THEIR WAY BACK TO THE FELIX CHAMBER REIMS,

WHERE THEIR HEADS OF FELICES WILL GIVE THEM FURTHER INFORMATION. AS

QUICKLY AS YOU CAN, PLEASE!

THEN SHE LOWERED THE MEGAPHONE AND RECOVERED HARRY FROM THE HER.

BETTER, I THINK YOU'D BETTER COME WITH ME, ...

WONDERING HOW SHE COULD POSSIBLY SUSPECT HIM THIS TIME, HARRY SAW

HER DETACH HIMSELF FROM THE COMPLAINING CROWD; HE CAME RUNNING UP THE

TOOK AS THEY SET OFF TOWARD THE CASTLE. THE HARRY'S SURPRISE, PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL DIDN'T EXPECT.

YES, PERHAPS YOU'D BETTER COME, THEN, WEASLEY, ...

SOME OF THE STUDENTS SWARMING AROUND THEM WERE GRIMACING ABOUT THE

MATCH BEING CANCELED; OTHERS LOOKED WORRIED. HARRY AND HER

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL BACK INTO THE SCHOOL AND UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE.

BUT THEY WEREN'T TAKEN TO ANYBODY'S OFFICE THIS TIME.

THIS WILL BE A BIT OF A SPEECH, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IN A SURPRISINGLY GENTLE VOICE AS THEY APPROACHED THE INFIRMARY.

THERE HAS

BEEN ANOTHER ATTACK, ... ANOTHER DELETERIOUS ATTACK.

HARRY'S INSIDES DID A TERRIBLE SHIVERSALIT. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL
PLISHED

THE DOOR OPEN AND HE AND RON ENTERED.

MADAM POMFREY WAS BENDING OVER A SIXTH-YEAR GIRL WITH LONG,
CLAY

FAIR. HARRY RECOGNIZED HER AS THE RAVENCLAW THEY'D ACCIDENTALLY
ASKED FOR

DIRECTIONS TO THE SLYTHERIN COMMON ROOM, AND IN THE END NEXT TO
HER WAS

HERMIONE! RON GRIELED.

HERMIONE WAS LITTERLY STILL, HER EYES OPEN AND GLASSY.

THEY WERE FEELING NEAR THE LIBRARY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.
I DON'T

SUPPOSE EITHER OF YOU CAN EXPLAIN THIS? IT WAS IN THE ROOM NEXT
TO

THEM. . . .

SHE WAS HOLDING UP A SMALL, CIRCULAR MIRROR.

HARRY AND RON SHOOK THEIR HEADS, BOTH STARING AT HERMIONE.

I WILL ESCORT YOU BACK TO GRYFFINDOR TOWER, SAID PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL HEAVILY. I NEED THE ADDRESS THE STUDENTS IN ANY CASE.

ALL STUDENTS WILL RETURN TO THEIR HOUSE COMMON ROOMS BY SIX
ON CLACK IN

THE EVENING. NO STUDENT IS TO LEAVE THE DORMITORIES AFTER THAT
TIME. YOU WILL

BE ESCORTED TO EACH LESSON BY A TEACHER. NO STUDENT IS TO USE THE
BATHROOMS

UNACCOMPANIED BY A TEACHER. ALL FURTHER FLUIDITCH TRAINING AND
MATCHES

ARE TO BE POSTPONED. THERE WILL BE NO MORE EVENING ACTIVITIES.

THE GRYPFINDERS PACKED INSIDE THE CHAIRMAN WHEN LISTENED THE PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL IN SILENCE. SHE REELLED UP THE PARCEMENT FROM WHICH SHE HAD

BEEN READING AND SAID IN A SEMPLE-AT CHEDD VEEIC, I NEED HARDLY ADD THAT

I HAVE RARELY BEEN SEE DISTRESSED. IT IS LIKELY THAT THE SCHEM WILL BE CLESED

UNLESS THE CLIPRIT BEHIND THESE ATTACKS IS CAUGHT. I WOULD WIZE ANYONE WHO

THINKS THEY MIGHT KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT THEM TO COME FORWARD.

SHE CLIMBED SEMPLE-AT ANDWARDLY ELIT UP THE PORTRAIT HILL, AND THE GRYPFINDERS BEGAN TALKING IMMEDIATELY.

THAT S THE GRYPFINDERS DEEDN, NOT CHLINTING A GRYPFINDER GHEST, HENE

RAVENCLAW, AND HENE FLUFFLEPLUFF, SAID THE WEASLEY TWINS FRIEND LEE JORDAN, CHLINTING HEN HIS FINGERS, FLAVEN T AND UP THE TEACHERS NOTICED THAT

THE SLYTHERINS ARE ALL SAFE? ISN T IT HEYVIELIS ALL THIS STUFF S CHMING FROM

SLYTHERIN? THE FLER UP SLYTHERIN, THE MINISTER UP SLYTHERIN WED DEEN T

THEY IUST CHLICK ALL THE SLYTHERINS ELTY? HE REHARED, THE NEEDS AND SCATTERED

APPLAUSE.

PERCY WEASLEY WAS SITTING IN A CHAIR BEHIND LEE, BUT FOR HENCE HE DIDN T

SEEM DEEN THE MAKE HIS VIELS HEARD, HE WAS WHEDDING PALE AND STUNNED.

PERCY'S IN SIGHT, GEORGE TOLD HARRY QUIETLY, THAT RAVENCLAW GIRL

PENELPE CLEARWATER SHE'S A PERFECT, I DIDN'T THINK HE THOUGHT THE

MINISTER WOULD DARE ATTACK A PERFECT,

BUT HARRY WAS ONLY HALF-LISTENING, HE DIDN'T SEEM TO BE ABLE TO GET RID

OF THE PICTURE OF HERMIONE, LYING IN THE HOSPITAL BED AS THOUGH CARVED INTO

OF STONE, AND IF THE CLIPRIT WASN'T CAUGHT SEEN, HE WAS LOOKING AT A

LIFETIME BACK WITH THE DURSLEYS, THEN RIDDLE HAD TURNED HARRY IN BECAUSE

HE WAS FACED WITH THE PROSPECT OF A MUGGLE HERFANAGE IF THE SCHEMEL CLOSED,

HARRY NOW KNEW EXACTLY HOW HE HAD FELT,

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO? SAID RON QUIETLY IN HARRY'S EAR, DO YOU THINK

THEY SUSPECT HARRY?

WE'VE GOT TO GO AND TALK TO HIM, SAID HARRY, MAKING UP HIS MIND, I

CAN'T BELIEVE IT'S HIM THIS TIME, BUT IF HE SET THE MINISTER FREE LAST TIME

HE'LL KNOW HOW TO GET INSIDE THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, AND THAT'S A START,

BUT MCGONAGALL SAID WE'VE GOT TO STAY IN OUR TUNES UNLESS WE'RE IN

CLASS

I THINK, SAID HARRY, MORE QUIETLY STILL, IT'S TIME TO GET MY DAD'S HELD

LEAD OUT AGAIN,

HARRY HAD INHERITED JUST ONE THING FROM HIS FATHER: A LONG AND SILVERY

INVISIBILITY CLOAK. IT WAS THEIR ONLY CHANCE OF SNEAKING INTO THE SCHOOL THE

VISIT Hagrid WITHOUT ANYONE KNOWING ABOUT IT. THEY WENT THE RED AT THE

USUAL TIME, WAITED UNTIL NEVILLE, DEAN, AND SEamus HAD STOPPED DISCUSSING

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS AND FINALLY FALLEN ASLEEP, THEN GET UP, DRESSED

AGAIN, AND THREW THE CLOAK OVER THEMSELVES.

THE JOLTER THROUGH THE DARK AND DESERTED CASTLE CORRIDORS WASN'T

ENJOYABLE. HARRY, WHO HAD WANDERED THE CASTLE AT NIGHT SEVERAL TIMES

BEFORE, HAD NEVER SEEN IT SO CROWDED AFTER SUNSET. TEACHERS, PREFECTS, AND

GUESTS WERE MARCHING THE CORRIDORS IN PAIRS, STARING AROUND FOR ANY

UNUSUAL ACTIVITY. THEIR INVISIBILITY CLOAK DIDN'T STOP THEM MAKING ANY

NOISE, AND THERE WAS A PARTICULARLY TENSE MOMENT WHEN RON STUCK HIS THE

ONLY YARDS FROM THE SPOT WHERE SNAPE WOULD BE STANDING GUARD. THANKFULLY,

SNAPE SNEEZED AT ALMOST EXACTLY THE MOMENT RON SPOKE. IT WAS WITH RELIEF

THAT THEY REACHED THE HALL FRONT DOORS AND PASED THEM OPEN.

IT WAS A CLEAR, STARRY NIGHT. THEY HURRIED TOWARD THE LIT WINDOWS OF

ELAGRID S FELLER AND PULLED OFF THE CHAIR ONLY WHEN THEY WERE
RIGHT HILTSIDE

HIS FRONT DEER.

SECONDS AFTER THEY HAD KNICKED, ELAGRID FELLING IT OPEN. THEY FELLING
THEMSELVES FACE-TO-FACE WITH HIM AIMING A CROSSBOW AT THEM, FANG
THE

SHARP-FELLING BARKED LOUDLY BEHIND HIM.

EH, HE SAID, WHEELING THE WEAPONS AND STARING AT THEM. WHAT RE
YELL

TWO DEER HERE?

WHAT S THAT MEY? SAID ELARRY, POINTING AT THE CROSSBOW AS THEY
STEPPED

INSIDE.

NEETHIN NEETHIN ELAGRID MUTTERED. I VE EIN EXPECTIN
DEERIN

MATTER SIT DEERIN I LL MAKE TEA

HE HARDLY SEEMED TO KNOW WHAT HE WAS DOING. HE NEARLY
EXTINGUISHED

THE FIRE, SPILLING WATER FROM THE KETTLE ON IT, AND THEN SMASHED THE
TEAPOT

WITH A NERVELESS IRR OF HIS MASSIVE HAND.

ARE YELL DEAD, ELAGRID? SAID ELARRY. DID YELL HEAR ABELT
TERMININE?

EH, I HEARD, ALL RIGHT, SAID ELAGRID, A SLIGHT KRAAK IN HIS VOICE.

HE KEPT GLANCING NERVEILLY AT THE WINDHILLS. HE PHEURED THEM BOTH
LARGE

MILES OF BOILING WATER (HE HAD FORGOTTEN TO ADD TEA BAGS) AND WAS
ILST

PLUTTING A SLAB OF FRUITLACE HEN A PLATE WHEN THERE WAS A LIND
DENSE HEN THE

DEER,

HAGRID DROPPED THE FRUITLACE, HARRY AND REIN EXCHANGED PANIC-
STRICKEN

LEADS, THEN THREW THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK EACH OVER THEMSELVES AND
RETIRED

INTO A CORNER, HAGRID CHECKED THAT THEY WERE HIDDEN, SEIZED HIS
CRESSKEL,

AND FLING OPEN HIS DEER HIDE MERE,

GHEE EVENING, HAGRID,

IT WAS DUMBLEDORE, HE ENTERED, LEEDING DEADLY SERIOUS, AND WAS
FOLLOWED BY A SECOND, VERY HED-LEEDING MAN,

THE STRANGER HAD RUMPLED GRAY HAIR AND AN ANXIOUS EXPRESSION,
AND WAS

WEARING A STRANGE MIXTURE OF CLOTHES: A PINSTRIPED SLIT, A SCARLET
TIE, A LING

BLACK CLOAK, AND PHEINTED PURPLE KHEETS, UNDER HIS ARM HE CARRIED A
LIME-

GREEN BELLER,

THAT S DAD S KESS? REIN BREATHEO, CHERNELILS FLIDGE, THE MINISTER
OF

MAGIC?

HARRY KHEELED REIN HARD THE MADE HIM SHUT UP,

HAGRID HAD GHEE PALE AND SWEATY, HE DROPPED INTO THE HNE OF HIS
CHAIRS AND

LEEDED FROM DUMBLEDORE TH CHERNELILS FLIDGE,

RAD BUSINESS, F-JAGRID, SAID FLUDGE IN RATHER CLIPPED TONES. VERY
RAD

BUSINESS, F-HAD THE CHURK, FEELER ATTACKS AND MUSCLE-KRONS. THINGS WERE
BEING PAID

ENGLISH. MINISTRY'S GET THE ACT.

I NEVER, SAID F-JAGRID, LEERING IMPLORINGLY AT DUMKEDDRE. FEEL
DREHN

I NEVER, PROFESSOR DUMKEDDRE, SIR

I WANT IT UNDERSTOOD, CHARNELIS, THAT F-JAGRID HAS MY FULL
CONFIDENCE,

SAID DUMKEDDRE, FREELING AT FLUDGE.

LEND, ARLIS, SAID FLUDGE, UNCOMFORTABLY. F-JAGRID'S RECTOR'S
AGAINST

HIM. MINISTRY'S GET THE DO SOMETHING THE SCHOOL GOVERNORS
HAVE BEEN IN

THEIR

YET AGAIN, CHARNELIS, I TELL YOU THAT TAKING F-JAGRID AWAY WILL
NOT HELP IN

THE SLIGHTEST, SAID DUMKEDDRE, HIS BLUE EYES WERE FULL OF A FIRE
F-JAGRID HAD

NEVER SEEN BEFORE.

LEND AT IT FROM MY POINT OF VIEW, SAID FLUDGE, FIDGETING WITH HIS
HEELS. I'M UNDER A LITTLE PRESSURE, GET THE BE SEEN THE BE DOING
SOMETHING.

IF IT TURNS OUT IT WASN'T F-JAGRID, HE'LL BE BACK AND NEH MERE SAID,
BUT I WOULD

GET THE TAKE HIM, GET THE, WOULDNT BE DOING MY DUTY

TAKE ME? SAID F-JAGRID, WHO WAS TREMBLING. TAKE ME WHERE?

FOR A SHORT STRETCH ONLY, SAID FLUDGE, NOT MEETING HAGRID'S EYES,
NOT A

PUNISHMENT, HAGRID, HERE A PRECAUTION. IF SOMEONE ELSE IS CAUGHT,
WELL

HE LET HIM WITH A FULL APPEAL

NOT ASKING? CREAKED HAGRID.

BEFORE FLUDGE COULD ANSWER, THERE WAS ANOTHER WILD RAP IN THE
DOOR.

DUMBLEDORE ANSWERED IT. IT WAS HARRY'S TURN FOR AN EYE IN THE
RICKS.

HE D LET HIM AN ALIBI CASE.

MRS. ELKILIS MALPHE STRODE INTO HAGRID'S HILT, SLATHERED IN A LONG
BLACK

TRAVELING CLOAK, SMILING A CHILD AND SATISFIED SMILE. FANG STARTED THE
GRIFFIN.

ALREADY HERE, FLUDGE, HE SAID APPROVINGLY, GOOD, GOOD ...

WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE? SAID HAGRID FLURRIEDLY, GET HIM TO MY
FELLS?

MY DEAR MAN, PLEASE BELIEVE ME, I HAVE NO PLEASURE AT ALL IN BEING
INSIDE YOUR ER D YOU CALL THIS A FELLS? SAID ELKILIS MALPHE,
SNEERING

AS HE WHEELED AROUND THE SMALL CARRIAGE. I SIMPLY CALLED AT THE SCHEM
AND WAS

THAT THE HEADMASTER WAS HERE.

AND WHAT EXACTLY DID YOU WANT WITH ME, ELKILIS? SAID DUMBLEDORE.
HE SPOKE POLITELY, BUT THE FIRE WAS STILL BLAZING IN HIS BLUE EYES.

DREADFUL THING, DUMBLEDORE, SAID MALPHE LAZILY, TAKING HIM A LONG
WELL

OF PARLAMENT, BUT THE GOVERNORS FEEL IT'S TIME FOR YOU TO STEP
ASIDE. THIS

IS AN ORDER OF SUSPENSION THEY WILL FIND ALL TWELVE SIGNATURES IN IT, I'M

AFRAID WE FEEL THEY'RE HIDING THEIR THICK, FEEL MANY ATTACKS HAVE THERE BEEN

NEED TWO MORE THIS AFTERNOON, WASN'T IT? AT THIS RATE, THERE WILL BE NONE

MUGGLE-BORN LEFT AT FINGWARTS, AND WE ALL KNOW WHAT AN AWFUL LOSS THAT

WOULD BE TO THE SCHOOL.

HEY, NEED SEE HERE, LUCIUS, SAID FLUDGE, LOOKING ALARMED, DUMBLEDORE

SUSPENDED NONE, NONE LAST THING WE WANT JUST NONE

THE APPOINTMENT OF SUSPENSION OF THE HEADMASTER IS A MATTER FOR

THE GOVERNORS, FLUDGE, SAID MR. MALFOY SMILINGLY, AND AS DUMBLEDORE

HAS FAILED TO STOP THESE ATTACKS

SEE HERE, MALFOY, IF DUMBLEDORE CAN'T STOP THEM, SAID FLUDGE, WHERE

UPPER LIP WAS SWEATING NONE, I MEAN THE SAY, WHERE CAN?

THAT REMAINS TO BE SEEN, SAID MR. MALFOY WITH A NASTY SMILE, BUT AS

ALL TWELVE OF US HAVE VOTED

FACRID LEAPT TO HIS FEET, HIS SHAGGY BLACK HEAD GRAZING THE CEILING,

AND FEEL MANY DID THEY HAVE TO THREATEN AN BLACKMAIL REFUSE THEY

AGREED, MALFOY, YES HE REARED,

DEAR, DEAR, THEY KNOW, THAT TEMPER OF THEIRS WILL LEAD THEM INTO TREASON

HERE OF THESE DAYS, HAGRID, SAID MR. MALFOY, I WOULD ADVISE YOU
NOT TO

SMILE AT THE AZKABAN GUARDS LIKE THAT, THEY WON'T LIKE IT AT ALL.

YOU CAN TAKE DUMBLEDORE? YELLED HAGRID, MAKING FANG THE
RHINO-HORNED CREATOR AND WHIMPER IN HIS BASKET. TAKE HIM AWAY, AND
THE

MUGGLE-BURNS WON STAND A CHANCE? THERE LL BE KILLIN' NEXT?

CALM YOURSELF, HAGRID, SAID DUMBLEDORE SHARPLY, HE LOOKED AT
LUCIUS

MALFOY,

IF THE GOVERNORS WANT MY REMOVAL, LUCIUS, I SHALL OF COURSE STEP
ASIDE

BUT STUTTERED FUDGE,

NEE? GROWLED HAGRID,

DUMBLEDORE HAD NOT TAKEN HIS BRIGHT BLUE EYES OFF LUCIUS MALFOY'S
CHILD

GRAY HINES,

HOWEVER, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SPEAKING VERY SILENTLY AND CLEARLY SHE
THAT

NEVER OF THEM COULD MISS A WORD, YOU WILL FIND THAT I WILL ONLY
TRULY HAVE

LEFT THIS SCHEME WHEN NONE HERE ARE WISE AS MR. YOU WILL ALSO
FIND THAT

HELP WILL ALWAYS BE GIVEN AT FINGWANTS THE THREE WE'VE ASK FOR IT,

FOR A SECOND, HARRY WAS ALMOST SURE DUMBLEDORE'S EYES FLICKERED

TOWARD THE CORNER WHERE HE AND RON STOOD HIDDEN.

ADMIRABLE SENTIMENTS, SAID MALPHEE, KHEWING. WE SHALL ALL MISS
YELIR

ER HIGHLY INDIVIDUAL WAY OF RUNNING THINGS, ABLIS, AND
ENJOY HIMSELF

THAT YELIR SUCCESSFUL WILL MANAGE TO PREVENT ANY
KILLINGS.

HE STOOD THE THE CARIN DEER, HE OPENED IT, AND KNEWED DUMKLEDEERE HLT.
FLIDGE, FIDDLING WITH HIS KEHLER, WAITED FOR HAGRID THE GO AHEAD OF
HIM, BUT

HAGRID STOOD HIS GROUND, TOOK A DEEP BREATH, AND SAID CAREFULLY, IF
ANYONE

WANTED TO FIND HLT SOME STUFF, ALL THEY'D HAVE TO DO WOULD BE TO
FOLLOW

THE SPIDERS. THAT'D LEAD EM RIGHT? THAT'S ALL I'M SAYING.

FLIDGE STARED AT HIM IN AMAZEMENT.

ALL RIGHT, I'M COMING, SAID HAGRID, PULLING HIM HIS MELESDIN
EVERCHART.

BUT AS HE WAS ABOUT TO FOLLOW FLIDGE THROUGH THE DEER, HE STOPPED
AGAIN

AND SAID LOUDLY, AN SOMEONE'LL NEED TO FEED FANG WHILE I'M
AWAY.

THE DEER BANGED SHUT AND BEN PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK.

WE'RE IN TROUBLE NOW, HE SAID HEARSLEY. SEE DUMKLEDEERE. THEY
MIGHT

AS WELL CLOSE THE SCREENS TONIGHT. THERE'LL BE AN ATTACK A DAY WITH
HIM

GENE.

FANG STARTED HOWLING, SCRATCHING AT THE CLOSED DEER.

\$

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

ARACHE

LIMPER WAS CREEPING OVER THE GREHLINDS AROUND THE CASTLE; SEX AND
LADY

ALICE TURNED PERILOUSLY BLUE AND FLOWERS LARGE AS CABBAGES BURST
INTO

BLOOM IN THE GREEN-HOUSES, BUT WITH THE FLAGRANT VISIBLE FROM THE
CASTLE

WINDMILLS, STRIDING THE GREHLINDS WITH FANG AT HIS HEELS, THE SCENE
DIDN'T LOOK

RIGHT THE HARRY; THE BETTER, IN FACT, THAN THE INSIDE OF THE CASTLE,
WHERE THINGS

WERE SO TERRIBLY WORSE.

HARRY AND JOHN HAD TRIED THE VISIT HERMIE, BUT VISITORS WERE
NOW BANNED

FROM THE HOSPITAL WING.

WE'RE TAKING THE MORE CHANCES, MADAM PERCY TOLD THEM
SEVERELY

THROUGH A CRACK IN THE INFIRMARY DOOR. THE, I'M SURE, THERE'S
EVERY CHANCE

THE ATTACKER MIGHT COME BACK THE FINISH THESE PEOPLE OFF, . . .

WITH DIMPLED EYES, FEAR HAD SPREAD AS NEVER BEFORE, SEE THAT THE
SLIN

WARMING THE CASTLE WALLS ELTISIDE SEEMED THE STEEP AT THE MILLIONED
WINDMILLS. THERE WAS RARELY A FACE TO BE SEEN IN THE SCENE THAT
DIDN'T LOOK

WHIRLED AND TENSE, AND ANY LAUGHTER THAT RANG THROUGH THE
CORRIDORS

SHUNDED SHRIIL AND UNNATURAL AND WAS QUICKLY STILLED,

HARRY CONSTANTLY REPEATED DUMBLEDORE'S FINAL WORDS TO HIMSELF. I
WILL

ONLY TRULY HAVE LEFT THIS SCHOOL WHEN NONE HERE ARE WYAL TO ME, .
. . HELP

WILL ALWAYS BE GIVEN AT HEGHARTS TO THOSE WHO ASK FOR IT. BUT
WHAT GOOD

WERE THESE WORDS? WHEN EXACTLY WERE THEY SUPPOSED TO ASK FOR
HELP, WHEN

EVERYONE WAS JUST AS CONFUSED AND SCARED AS THEY WERE?

HARRY'S HINT ABOUT THE SPIDERS WAS FAR EASIER TO UNDERSTAND
THE

TRULIKE WAS, THERE DIDN'T SEEM TO BE A SINGLE SPIDER LEFT IN THE CASTLE
THE

WHILE, HARRY SEARCHED EVERYWHERE HE WENT, HELPED (RATHER
RELUCTANTLY) BY

THEM. THEY WERE HAMPERED, OF COURSE, BY THE FACT THAT THEY WEREN'T
ALLOWED

TO WANDER OFF ON THEIR OWN BUT HAD THE MOVE AROUND THE CASTLE IN
A PACK

WITH THE OTHER GRYFFINDORS, MOST OF THEIR FELLOW STUDENTS SEEMED
GLAD THAT

THEY WERE BEING SHEPHERDED FROM CLASS TO CLASS BY TEACHERS, BUT
HARRY

FOUND IT VERY IRKSOME.

FIVE PERSONS, HOWEVER, SEEMED TO BE THOROUGHLY ENJOYING THE
ATMOSPHERE

OF TERROR AND SUSPICION. DRACH MALFOY WAS STROLLING AROUND THE
SCHOOL AS

THOUGH HE HAD JUST BEEN APPOINTED HEAD REE, HARRY DIDN'T REALIZE
WHAT HE

WAS SO PLEASED ABOUT UNTIL THE PENTHUS LESSON ABOUT TWO WEEKS
AFTER

DUMBLEDORE AND HAGRID HAD LEFT, WHEN, SITTING RIGHT BEHIND MALFOY,
HARRY

OVERHEARD HIM CHEATING THE CRABBE AND GOYLE.

I ALWAYS THOUGHT FATHER MIGHT BE THE ONE WHO GET RID OF
DUMBLEDORE,

HE SAID, NOT TRICKLING THE DEEP HIS VOICE DOWN. I THOUGHT HE
THINKS

DUMBLEDORE IS THE WORST HEADMASTER THE SCHOOL'S EVER HAD. MAYBE
WE'LL GET

A DECENT HEADMASTER NOW. SOMEONE WHO WON'T WANT THE CHAMBER OF
SECRETS CLOSED. MCGONAGALL WON'T LAST LONG, SHE'S ONLY FILLING IN. .
..

SNAPE SLID PAST HARRY, MAKING NO COMMENT ABOUT DETERMINING
EMPTY

SEAT AND CHILDREN.

SIR, SAID MALFOY LEISLY. SIR, WHY DIDN'T YOU APPLY FOR THE
HEADMASTER'S JOB?

NOW, NOW, MALFOY, SAID SNAPE, THOUGH HE COULDN'T SUPPRESS A
THIN-

LIPPED SMILE. PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE HAS ONLY BEEN SUSPENDED BY THE

GOVERNORS. I DARE SAY HE'LL BE BACK WITH HIS SEEN ENOUGH.

Yeah, RIGHT, SAID MALFOY, SMIRKING. I EXPECT YOU'D HAVE
FATHER'S

WHITE, SIR, IF YOU WANTED TO APPLY FOR THE JOB I'LL TELL FATHER
YOU'RE THE

BEST TEACHER HERE, SIR

SNAPE SMIRKED AS HE SWEEPED OFF AROUND THE DUNGEON, FORTUNATELY
NOT

SPOTTING SEAMUS FINNIGAN, WHO WAS PRETENDING TO WHISTLE INTO HIS
CLOTHES.

I'M SLIGHTLY SURPRISED THE MURDERERS HAVEN'T ALL PACKED THEIR BAGS
BY

NOW, MALFOY WENT ON. LET YOU FIVE GALLEONS THE NEXT TIME DICK,
PITY IT

WASN'T CRANER

THE BELL RANG AT THAT MOMENT, WHICH WAS LUCKY; AT MALFOY'S LAST
WORDS,

RON HAD LEAPT OFF HIS SEAT, AND IN THE SCRAMBLE TO COLLECT BAGS AND
BOOKS,

HIS ATTEMPTS TO REACH MALFOY WENT UNNOTICED.

LET ME AT HIM, RON GROWLED AS HARRY AND DEAN FLEW PAST HIS
ARMS. I

DON'T CARE, I DON'T NEED MY WAND, I'M GOING TO KILL HIM WITH MY BARE
HANDS

HURRY UP, I'VE GOT TO TAKE YOU ALL THE FORTRESS, BARKED SNAPE
OVER THE

CLASS'S HEADS, AND OFF THEY MARCHED, WITH HARRY, RON, AND DEAN
BRINGING

UP THE REAR, RON STILL TRYING TO GET LOOSE. IT WAS ONLY SAFE TO LET
GO OF HIM

WHEN SNAPE HAD SEEN THEM EXIT THE CASTLE AND THEY WERE MAKING
THEIR

WAY ACROSS THE VEGETABLE PATCH TOWARD THE GREEN-HOUSES.

THE HERMELBY CLASS WAS VERY SILENT; THERE WERE NOW TWO MISSING

FROM THEIR NUMBER, JUSTIN AND HERMINE.

PROFESSOR SPRELLT SET THEM ALL THE WORK PRUNING THE ARYSTINIAN SHRUBBERIES. HARRY WENT THE TIP AN ARMFUL OF WITHERED STALKS INTO THE

THICKEST BRUSH AND FOUND HIMSELF FACE-TO-FACE WITH ERNIE MACMILLAN. ERNIE

TOOK A DEEP BREATH AND SAID, VERY FIRMLY, I JUST WANT TO SAY, HARRY, THAT

I'M SORRY I EVER SUSPECTED YOU. I KNOW YOU'D NEVER ATTACK HERMINE

GRANGER, AND I APOLOGIZE FOR ALL THE STUFF I SAID. WE'RE ALL IN THE SAME BOAT

NOW, AND, WELL

HE HELD OUT A PLUMP HAND, AND HARRY SHOOK IT.

ERNIE AND HIS FRIEND HANNALY CAME THE WORK AT THE SAME SHRUBBERY AS

HARRY AND ERNIE.

THAT DRACE MALPHE CHARACTER, SAID ERNIE, BREAKING OFF DEAD TWIGS, HE

SEEMS VERY PLEASED ABOUT ALL THIS, DOESN'T HE? O YOU KNOW, I THINK HE

MIGHT BE SLYTHERIN'S HEIR.

THAT'S CLEVER OF YOU, SAID ERNIE, WHO DIDN'T SEEM TO HAVE FORGIVEN

ERNIE AS READILY AS HARRY.

DON'T YOU THINK IT'S MALPHE, HARRY? ERNIE ASKED.

NO, SAID HARRY, SHE FIRMLY THAT ERNIE AND HANNALY STARED.

A SECOND LATER, HARRY SPOTTED SOMETHING.

SEVERAL LARGE SPIDERS WERE SLITTLING OVER THE GRASS IN THE
EITHER SIDE OF

THE CLASS, MOVING IN AN UNNATURALLY STRAIGHT LINE AS THOUGH
TAKING THE

SHORTEST ROUTE TO A PREARRANGED MEETING. HARRY HIT RON OVER
THE HEAD WITH

HIS POLISHING SHEARS.

HELLO? WHAT ARE YOU

HARRY POINTED OUT THE SPIDERS, FOLLOWING THEIR PROGRESS WITH HIS
EYES

SCREWED UP AGAINST THE SUN.

EH, YEAH, SAID RON, TRYING, AND FAILING, TO LOOK PLEASED. BUT WE
CAN'T

SEE THEM NOW

RONIE AND HANNAH WERE LISTENING CURIOUSLY.

HARRY'S EYES NARROWED AS HE FOCUSED ON THE SPIDERS. IF THEY
PURSUED THEIR

FIXED COURSE, THERE WOULD BE NO DOUBT ABOUT WHERE THEY WOULD END
UP.

LOOKS LIKE THEY'RE HEADING FOR THE FORBIDDEN FOREST. . .

AND RON LOOKED EVEN LINE-UPPIER ABOUT THAT.

AT THE END OF THE LESSON PROFESSOR SPURRER ESCORTED THE CLASS TO
THEIR

DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON. HARRY AND RON LAGGED
BEHIND THE

EITHERS SEE THEY WOULD TALK ABOUT IT LATER.

WE'LL HAVE TO USE THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AGAIN, HARRY TOLD RON.
WE

CAN TAKE FANG WITH US. HE'S USED THE CHINESE IN THE FOREST WITH
FACRID, HE

MIGHT BE SOME HELP.

RIGHT, SAID REN, WHO WAS TWIRLING HIS WAND NERVOUSLY IN HIS
FINGERS.

ER AREN'T THERE AREN'T THERE SLIPPERS THEY'RE WEREWOLVES IN
THE

FOREST? HE ADDED AS THEY TOOK THEIR USUAL PLACES AT THE BACK OF
LEONHART'S

CLASSROOM.

PREFERRING NOT THE ANSWER THAT ELIZABETH, HARRY SAID, THERE ARE
GOOD

THINGS IN THERE, THE CENTALINS ARE ALL RIGHT, AND THE LINCHONS
...

REN HAD NEVER BEEN INTO THE FORGOTTEN FOREST BEFORE, HARRY HAD
ENTERED

IT ONLY ONCE AND HAD HELPED NEVER TO BE SEEN AGAIN.

LEONHART BEHIND IN THE ROOM AND THE CLASS STARED AT HIM. EVERY
OTHER

TEACHER IN THE PLACE WAS LOOKING GRIMPER THAN USUAL, BUT
LEONHART

APPEARED NOTHING ABOUT HIS EMBROID.

COME NOW, HE CRIED, BEARING AROUND HIM. WHY ALL THESE LONG
FACES?

PEOPLE SWAPPED EXHAUSTED LOOKS, BUT NOBODY ANSWERED.

DON'T YOU PEOPLE REALIZE, SAID LEONHART, SPEAKING SILENTLY, AS
THOUGH

THEY WERE ALL A BIT DIM, THE DANGER HAS PASSED! THE CULPRIT HAS
BEEN TAKEN

AWAY

SAYS WHEN? SAID DEAN THOMAS LELIPLY.

MY DEAR YELLING MAN, THE MINISTER OF MAGIC WOULDNT HAVE TAKEN
FACRID IF HE HADNT BEEN ONE HUNDRED PERCENT SURE THAT HE WAS
GUILTY, SAID

LOCKHART, IN THE TONE OF SOMEONE EXPLAINING THAT ONE AND ONE
MADE TWO.

EH, YES HE WOULD, SAID RON, EVEN MORE LELIPLY THAN DEAN.

I FLATTER MYSELF I KNOW A THICKER MERE ABOUT FACRID S ARREST THAN
YOU DO,

MR. WEASLEY, SAID LOCKHART IN A SELF-SATISFIED TONE.

RON STARTED TO SAY THAT HE DIDNT THINK SHE, SOMEHOW, BUT STOPPED
IN

MIDSENTENCE WHEN HARRY KICKED HIM HARD UNDER THE DESK.

WE WEREN T THERE, REMEMBER? HARRY MUTTERED.

BUT LOCKHART S DISGUSTING CHEERINESS, HIS HINTS THAT HE HAD
ALWAYS

THOUGHT FACRID WAS ONE GOOD, HIS CONFIDENCE THAT THE WHOLE
BUSINESS WAS

NEW AT AN END, IRRITATED HARRY SHE FELT THAT HE YEARNED THE THREE
CABBING

WITH GRIMLES RIGHT IN LOCKHART S STUPID FACE. INSTEAD HE CONTENTED
HIMSELF

WITH SCRAWLING A NOTE TO RON: LET S DO IT TONIGHT.

RON READ THE MESSAGE, SWALLOWED HARD, AND LOOKED SIDELWAYS AT THE
EMPTY SEAT USUALLY FILLED BY HERMIONE. THE SIGHT SEEMED TO STIFFEN
HIS

RESOLVE, AND HE NODDED.

THE GRYPFINDER CHIEFMIN RHEIN WAS ALWAYS VERY CREULDED THESE DAYS,

BECAUSE FROM SIX FEET UPWARD THE GRYFFINDORS HAD NOWHERE ELSE
TO GO.

THEY ALSO HAD PLenty OF TALK ABOUT, WITH THE RESULT THAT THE
COMMON ROOM

DIDN'T EMPTY UNTIL PAST MIDNIGHT.

HARRY WENT TO GET THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK OUT OF HIS TRUNK RIGHT
AFTER

DINNER, AND SPENT THE EVENING SITTING IN IT, WAITING FOR THE ROOM
TO CLEAR.

FRED AND GEORGE CHALLENGED HARRY AND RON TO A FEW GAMES OF
EXPLODING

SNAPE, AND GINNY SAT WATCHING THEM, VERY SLEEPIED IN HERMIONE'S
CHAIR.

HARRY AND RON KEPT LOSING IN PLOPPER, TRYING TO FINISH
THE GAMES

BEFORE, BUT EVEN SO, IT WAS WELL PAST MIDNIGHT WHEN FRED, GEORGE,
AND

GINNY FINALLY WENT TO BED.

HARRY AND RON WAITED FOR THE DISTANT SOUNDS OF TWO HERMITAGE
DORMS

CLOSING BEFORE SEIZING THE CLOAK, THERELING IT OVER THEMSELVES, AND
CLIMBING THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE.

IT WAS ANOTHER DIFFICULT JOURNEY THROUGH THE CASTLE, BEGGING ALL
THE

TEACHERS. AT LAST THEY REACHED THE ENTRANCE HALL, SLID BACK THE LOCK
ON THE

HAD FRONT DOORS, SQUEEZED BETWEEN THEM, TRYING TO STEP AND
CREAKING, AND

STEPPED OUT INTO THE MOONLIT GARDENS.

CELEBRATE, SAID RON ABRUPTLY AS THEY STRODE ACROSS THE BLACK GRASS, WE

MIGHT GET TO THE FOREST AND FIND THERE'S NOTHING TO FEAR. THESE SPIDERS

MIGHT NOT VE BEEN GOING THERE AT ALL. I KNOW IT SEEMED LIKE THEY WERE

MOVING IN THAT SORT OF GENERAL DIRECTION, BUT ...

HIS VOICE TRAILED AWAY HOPEFULLY.

THEY REACHED HAGRID'S HOUSE, SAD AND STONY-LOOKING WITH ITS BLANK

WINDOWS. WHEN HARRY PUSHED THE DOOR OPEN, FANG WENT MAD WITH HIM AT

THE SIGHT OF THEM. WHIRLED HE MIGHT HAVE EVERYONE AT THE CASTLE WITH HIS

DEEP, RUMMING BARKS, THEY HASTILY FED HIM TREATS THEY'VE FROM A TIN ON THE

MANTELPIECE, WHICH CALLED HIS TEETH TOGETHER.

HARRY LEFT THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK ON HAGRID'S TABLE. THERE WOULD BE NO

NEED FOR IT IN THE PITCH-DARK FOREST.

[MEAN, FANG, WE'RE GOING FOR A WALK, SAID HARRY, PATTING HIS LEG, AND

FANG ROLLED HAPPILY OUT OF THE HOUSE BEHIND THEM, DASHED TO THE EDGE OF

THE FOREST, AND LIFTED HIS LEG AGAINST A LARGE SYCAMORE TREE.

HARRY THEN HLT HIS HAND, MURMURED, LUMES? AND A TINY LIGHT APPEARED

AT THE END OF IT, JUST ENOUGH TO LET THEM WATCH THE PATH FOR SIGNS OF SPIDERS.

GOOD THINKING, SAID RON. I'D LIGHT MINE, THEN, BUT YOU KNOW IT'D

PRIORLY BLEW UP HER SOMETHING. . . .

HARRY TAPPED BEN ON THE SHOULDER, POINTING AT THE GRASS. THE
SOLITARY

SPIDERS WERE FLIRTING AWAY FROM THE HANDLIGHT INTO THE SHADE OF
THE TREES.

HEY, BEN SIGHED AS THOUGH RESIGNED TO THE WORST, I'M READY,
LET'S

GO.

SEE, WITH FANG SCAMPING AROUND THEM, SNIPPING TREE BUDS AND
LEAVES,

THEY ENTERED THE FOREST. BY THE GLEAM OF HARRY'S HAND, THEY
FOLLOWED THE

STEADY TRICKLE OF SPIDERS MOVING ALONG THE PATH. THEY WALKED
BEHIND THEM

AFTER ABOUT TWENTY MINUTES, NOT SPEAKING, LISTENING HARD FOR NOISES
EITHER

THAN BREAKING TWIGS AND RUSTLING LEAVES. THEN, WHEN THE TREES
HAD BECOME

THICKER THAN EVER, SEE THAT THE STARS OVERHEAD WERE NO LONGER
VISIBLE, AND

HARRY'S HAND SHINE ALONE IN THE SEA OF DARK, THEY SAW THEIR
SPIDER GLIDES

LEAVING THE PATH.

HARRY PAUSED, TRYING TO SEE WHERE THE SPIDERS WERE GOING, BUT
EVERYTHING

OUTSIDE HIS LITTLE SPHERE OF LIGHT WAS PITCH-BLACK. HE HAD NEVER
BEEN THIS

DEEP INTO THE FOREST BEFORE. HE COULD VIVIDLY REMEMBER JAGGED
ADVISING

HIM NOT TO LEAVE THE SHORTEST PATH LAST TIME HE'D BEEN IN HERE, BUT
F-ARRID

WAS MILES AWAY NOW, PROBABLY SITTING IN A CELL IN AZKABAN, AND HE
HAD ALSO

SAID THE FEELING THE SPIDERS.

SOMETHING LET THICKENED F-ARRY'S HAND AND HE JUMPED BACKWARD,
CRUSHING

REIN'S FEET, BUT IT WAS ONLY FANG'S NECK.

WHAT'D YOU RECKON? F-ARRY SAID TO REIN, WHOSE EYES HE COULD
JUST

MAKE OUT, REFLECTING THE LIGHT FROM HIS HAND.

WE'VE COME THIS FAR, SAID REIN.

SEE THEY FEELLED THE DARTING SHADOWS OF THE SPIDERS INTO THE
TREES. THEY

COULDNT MOVE VERY QUICKLY NOW; THERE WERE TREE TRUNKS AND
STUMPS IN THEIR

WAY, BARELY VISIBLE IN THE DEEP DARKNESS. F-ARRY COULD FEEL FANG'S
FEET

BREATH ON HIS HAND. MORE THAN ONCE, THEY HAD THE SENSE, SEE THAT
F-ARRY COULD

CRUNCH DOWN AND FIND THE SPIDERS IN THE DARKLIGHT.

THEY WALKED FOR WHAT SEEMED LIKE AT LEAST HALF AN HOUR, THEIR
NECKS

SNAGGING ON WHISPLING BRANCHES AND BRAMBLES. AFTER A WHILE, THEY
NOTICED

THAT THE GROUND SEEMED TO BE SLEEPING DOWNWARD, THROUGH THE TREES
WERE AS

THICK AS EVER.

THEN FANG SUDDENLY LET LOOSE A GREAT, CRASHING BARK, MAKING BOTH
F-ARRY

AND REN LIMP HLIT HF THEIR SKINS.

WHAT? SAID REN LELDLY, LEEDING AROUND INTO THE PITCH-DARK,
AND

GRIPPING HARRY S ELBOW VERY HARD.

THERE S SOMETHING MOVING OVER THERE, HARRY BREATHED. LISTEN,
..

SHLINDS LIKE SOMETHING BIG. . . .

THEY LISTENED. SOME DISTANCE TH THEIR RIGHT, THE SOMETHING BIG WAS
SNAPPING BRANCHES AS IT CARVED A PATH THROUGH THE TREES.

HH, NH, SAID REN. HH, NH, HH, NH, HH

SHLT LP, SAID HARRY FRANTICALLY. IT LL HEAR YELL.

HEAR ME? SAID REN IN AN UNNATURALLY HIGH VOICE. IT S ALREADY
HEARD

PANG:

THE DARKNESS SEEMED TH BE PRESSING HN THEIR EYEBALLS AS THEY STEHD,
TERRIFIED, WAITING. THERE WAS A STRANGE RUMBLING NOISE AND THEN
SILENCE.

WHAT D YELL THINK IT S DOING? SAID HARRY.

PROBABLY GETTING READY TH PHUNCE, SAID REN.

THEY WAITED, SHIVERING, HARDLY DARING TH MOVE.

D YELL THINK IT S GONE? HARRY WHISPERED.

BLINNH

THEN, TH THEIR RIGHT, CAME A SLIDEN BLAZE HF LIGHT, SH BRIGHT IN THE
DARKNESS THAT KEETH HF THEM FLLING LP THEIR HANDS TH SHIELD THEIR
EYES. PANG

YELPED AND TRIED TH RUN, BLT GET LEDGED IN A TANGLE HF THORNS AND
YELPED

EVEN BLINDER.

HARRY: REIN SMILTED, HIS VOICE BREAKING WITH RELIEF. HARRY, IT'S
HARRY

CAR:

WHAT?

COME ON:

HARRY BLUNDERED AFTER REIN TOWARD THE LIGHT, STUMBLING AND
TRIPPING, AND

A MOMENT LATER THEY HAD EMERGED INTO A CLEARING.

MR. WEASLEY'S CAR WAS STANDING, EMPTY, IN THE MIDDLE OF A CIRCLE OF
THICK

TREES UNDER A ROOF OF DENSE BRANCHES, ITS HEADLIGHTS ABLAZE. AS REIN
WALKED,

HE OPENED THE DOOR, TOWARD IT, IT MOVED SILENTLY TOWARD HIM, EXACTLY LIKE A
LARGE,

TWIRLING DANCE GREETING ITS OWNER.

IT'S BEEN HERE ALL THE TIME! SAID REIN DELIGHTEDLY, WALKING AROUND
THE

CAR. LOOK AT IT, THE FOREST'S TURNED IT WILD. . . .

THE SIDES OF THE CAR WERE SCRATCHED AND SMEARED WITH MUD.
APPARENTLY

IT HAD TAKEN THE TWIRLING DANCE AROUND THE FOREST AND ITS OWN. FANG
DIDN'T SEEM AT

ALL BEEN IN IT; HE KEPT CLOSE TO HARRY, WHO COULD FEEL HIM
SLITHERING. HIS

BREATHING SLOWLY BEGAN AGAIN, HARRY STUFFED HIS HAND BACK INTO
HIS POCKETS.

AND WE THOUGHT IT WAS GIVING THE ATTACK UP! SAID REIN, LEANING
AGAINST

THE CAR AND PATTING IT. I WONDERED WHERE IT HAD GONE?

HARRY SHUNTED AROUND IN THE FLASHLIGHT GRILLING FOR SIGNS OF MORE SPIDERS,

BUT THEY HAD ALL SCUTTLED AWAY FROM THE GLARE OF THE HEADLIGHTS.

WE'VE LOST THE TRAIL, HE SAID. I MEAN, LET'S GO AND FIND THEM.

REN DIDN'T SPEAK. HE DIDN'T MOVE. HIS EYES WERE FIXED ON A POINT SOME

TEN FEET ABOVE THE FOREST FLOOR, RIGHT BEHIND HARRY. HIS FACE WAS LIVID WITH

TERROR.

HARRY DIDN'T EVEN HAVE TIME TO TURN AROUND. THERE WAS A LOUD CLICKING

NOISE AND SUDDENLY HE FELT SOMETHING LONG AND HAIRY SEIZE HIM AROUND THE

MIDDLE AND LIFT HIM OFF THE GROUND, SEE THAT HE WAS HANGING FACE-DOWN.

STRUGGLING, TERRIFIED, HE HEARD MORE CLICKING, AND SAW REN'S LEGS LEAVE THE

GROUND, THEN HEARD FANG WHIMPERING AND HOWLING. NEXT MOMENT, HE WAS

BEING SWIFT AWAY INTO THE DARK TREES.

HEAD HANGING, HARRY SAW THAT WHAT HAD HELD UP HIM WAS MARCHING ON

SIX IMPENSELY LONG, HAIRY LEGS, THE FRONT TWO CLUTCHING HIM TIGHTLY BEHIND A

PAIR OF SHINING BLACK PINNERS. BEHIND HIM, HE COULD HEAR ANOTHER OF THE

CREATURES, NOW DELICATELY CARRYING REN. THEY WERE MOVING INTO THE VERY HEART OF

THE FOREST. HARRY COULD HEAR FANG FIGHTING TO FREE HIMSELF FROM A THIRD

MINISTER, WHINING LEBILLY, BUT HARRY COULDN'T HAVE BELIEVED EVEN IF HE HAD

WANTED THEM; HE SEEMED THEY HAD LEFT HIS VEHICLE BACK WITH THE CAR IN THE

CLEARING.

HE NEVER KNEW HOW LONG HE WAS IN THE CREATURE'S CLUTCHES; HE ONLY KNEW

THAT THE DARKNESS SUDDENLY LIFTED ENOUGH FOR HIM TO SEE THAT THE LEAF-STREWN

GROUND WAS NOW SWARMING WITH SPIDERS. CRANING HIS NECK SIDELWAYS, HE

REALIZED THAT THEY HAD REACHED THE RIDGE OF A VAST HILLSIDE, A HILLSIDE THAT HAD

BEEN CLEARED OF TREES, SO THAT THE STARS SHINE BRIGHTLY BENEATH THE WORST SCENE

HE HAD EVER LAID EYES ON.

SPIDERS. NOT TINY SPIDERS LIKE THESE SURGING OVER THE LEAVES BELOW.

SPIDERS THE SIZE OF CART-HORSES, EIGHT-EYED, EIGHT-LEGGED, BLACK, HAIRY,

GIGANTIC. THE MASSIVE SPECIMEN THAT WAS CARRYING HARRY MADE ITS WAY

DOWN THE STEEP SLOPE TOWARD A MISTY, DIMMED LEE IN THE VERY CENTER OF THE

HILLSIDE, WHILE ITS FELLOWS CROSSED IN ALL AROUND IT, CLICKING THEIR PINKERS

EXCITEDLY AT THE SIGHT OF ITS LEAD.

HARRY FELT THE GROUND MEN ALL FEELS AS THE SPIDER RELEASED HIM. THEN AND

PANG THROBDED DOWN NEXT TO HIM. PANG WASN'T FEELING ANYMORE, BUT

CHILDERN SILENTLY IN THE SPOT, THEN LEEDED EXACTLY LIKE F-HARRY FELT,
F-HIS

MOUTH WAS STRETCHED WIDE IN A KIND OF SILENT SCREAM AND HIS EYES
WERE

PEEPING.

F-HARRY SLIDDELY REALIZED THAT THE SPIDER THAT HAD DREPPED HIM WAS
SAYING

SOMETHING, IT HAD BEEN HARD TO TELL, BECAUSE HE CLICKED HIS PINCERS
WITH

EVERY WORD HE SPoke.

ARACHE! IT CALLED, ARACHE!

AND FROM THE MIDDLE OF THE MISTY, DENSED WEE, A SPIDER THE SIZE OF A
SMALL ELEPHANT EMERGED, VERY SLEELY, THERE WAS GRAY IN THE BLACK
OF HIS

BODY AND LEGS, AND EACH OF THE EYES IN HIS WELY, PINKERED HEAD WAS
MILKY

WHITE, HE WAS BLIND.

WHAT IS IT? HE SAID, CLICKING HIS PINCERS RAPIDLY.

MEN, CLICKED THE SPIDER WHEN HAD CALLED F-HARRY.

IS IT F-HARRY? SAID ARACHE, MOVING CLESER, HIS EIGHT MILKY EYES
WANDERING VAGUELY.

STRANGERS, CLICKED THE SPIDER WHEN HAD BRELIGHT REN.

DILL THEM, CLICKED ARACHE PRETULLY, I WAS SLEEPING. . . .

WE RE FRIENDS OF F-HARRY S, F-HARRY SEEMED, F-HIS HEART SEEMED TO
HAVE

LEFT HIS CHEST TO FEELING IN HIS THREAT.

CLICK, CLICK, CLICK WENT THE PINCERS OF THE SPIDERS ALL AROUND THE
FILLING.

ARACHE PALSED.

LAGRID HAS NEVER SENT MEN INTO THE HILLS BEHIND THERE, HE SAID
SHILLY.

LAGRID IS IN TROUBLE, SAID HARRY, BREATHING VERY FAST. THAT'S
WHY WE'RE
HERE.

IN TROUBLE? SAID THE AGED SPIDER, AND HARRY THOUGHT HE HEARD
CONCERN

BEHIND THE CLICKING PINKERS. BUT WHY HAS HE SENT YOU?

HARRY THOUGHT OF GETTING TO HIS FEET BUT DECIDED AGAINST IT; HE
DIDN'T

THINK HIS LEGS WOULD SUPPORT HIM. SEE HE SPED FROM THE GROUND,
AS CALMLY

AS HE COULD.

THEY THINK, UP AT THE SCHOOL, THAT LAGRID IS BEEN SETTING A A

SOMETHING FOR STUDENTS. THEY WERE TAKEN HIM TO THE AZDARAN.

ARACHE CLICKED HIS PINKERS FURIOUSLY, AND ALL AROUND THE HILLS
THE

SCHOOL WAS FILLED BY THE CRIES OF SPIDERS; IT WAS LIKE APPLAUSE,
EXCEPT

APPLAUSE DIDN'T USUALLY MAKE HARRY FEEL SICK WITH FEAR.

BUT THAT WAS YEARS AGO, SAID ARACHE FRETFULLY. YEARS AND YEARS
AGO, I

REMEMBER IT WELL. THAT'S WHY THEY MADE HIM LEAVE THE SCHOOL. THEY
BELIEVED THAT I WAS THE MINISTER THAT DWELLS IN WHAT THEY CALL THE
CHAMBER

OF SECRETS. THEY THOUGHT THAT LAGRID HAD OPENED THE CHAMBER AND
SET ME

FREE.

AND WHY . . . WHY DIDN'T COME FROM THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS? SAID
F-JARRY, WHOSE CHILD FEEL CHILD SWEAT ON HIS FOREHEAD.

I SAID AGRACE, CLICKING ANGERILY. I WAS NOT BORN IN THE CASTLE. I
CAME

FROM A DISTANT LAND. A TRAVELER GAVE ME THE F-JAGRID WHEN I WAS AN
EGG.

F-JAGRID WAS ONLY A KID, BUT HE CARED FOR ME, HIDDEN IN A CLIPBOARD IN
THE

CASTLE, FEEDING ME HIS SCRAPS FROM THE TABLE. F-JAGRID IS MY GOOD
FRIEND, AND

A GOOD MAN. WHEN I WAS DISCOVERED, AND BLAMED FOR THE DEATH OF A
GIRL, HE

PROTECTED ME. I HAVE LIVED HERE IN THE FOREST EVER SINCE, WHERE
F-JAGRID STILL

VISITS ME. HE EVEN FEELS ME A WIFE, MIESAG, AND WHY SEE HOW HE
FAMILY

HAS GROWN, ALL THROUGH F-JAGRID'S GOODNESS. . . .

F-JARRY SLIMMERED WHAT REMAINED OF HIS COURAGE.

SEE WHY NEVER NEVER ATTACKED ANYONE?

NEVER, CREAMED THE OLD SPIDER. IT WOULD HAVE BEEN MY INSTINCT,
BUT

BUT MY RESPECT FOR F-JAGRID, I NEVER HARMED A HUMAN. THE KID OF
THE GIRL

WHO WAS KILLED WAS DISCOVERED IN A BATHROOM. I NEVER SAW ANY PART
OF THE

CASTLE BUT THE CLIPBOARD IN WHICH I GREW UP, HEAR KIND LIKE THE
DARK AND THE

ELIOT. . . .

BUT THEN . . . OH WHY KNOW WHAT DID KILL THAT GIRL? SAID F-JARRY.

BECAUSE WHATEVER IT IS, IT'S BACK AND ATTACKING PEOPLE AGAIN
HIS EARS WERE DRIVEN BY A LOUD HINTEREAD OF CLICKING AND THE
RUSTLING
OF MANY LONG LEGS SHIFTING ANGRILY; LARGE BLACK SHAPES SHIFTED ALL
AROUND
HIM.

THE THING THAT LIVES IN THE CASTLE, SAID ARACHNE, IS AN ANCIENT
CREATURE

WE SPIDERS FEAR ABOVE ALL OTHERS. WELL DO I REMEMBER HOW I PLEADED
WITH

MACRIS TO LET ME GO, WHEN I SENSED THE BEAST MOVING ABOUT THE
SCHELL.

WHAT IS IT? SAID HARRY URGENTLY.

MORE LOUD CLICKING, MORE RUSTLING; THE SPIDERS SEEMED TO BE CLOSING
IN.

WE DO NOT SPEAK OF IT! SAID ARACHNE FIERCELY, WE DO NOT NAME IT!
I

NEVER EVEN TOLD MACRIS THE NAME OF THAT DREAD CREATURE, THOUGH
HE ASKED

ME, MANY TIMES.

HARRY DIDN'T WANT TO PRESS THE SUBJECT, NOT WITH THE SPIDERS
PRESSING

CLOSER FROM ALL SIDES. ARACHNE SEEMED TO BE TIRED OF TALKING. HE WAS
BACKING

SLIPLY INTO HIS DENSE WEB, BUT HIS FELLOW SPIDERS CONTINUED TO INCH
SLIPLY

TOWARD HARRY AND BEN.

WE MUST GO, THEN, HARRY CALLED DESPERATELY TO ARACHNE,
HEARING LEAVES

RUSTLING BEHIND HIM.

GEY SAID SPRACING SLEELY, I THINK NEET, . . .

BLIT BLIT

MY SONS AND DAUGHTERS DEE NEET HARM F-JACRID, EEN MY COMMAND, BLIT
I

CANNET DENY THEM FRESH MEAT, WHEN IT WANDERS SEE WILLINGLY INTHE
ELIR MIDST.

CHHO-KYE, FRIEND EE F-JACRID,

F-JARRY SPUN AROUND, FEET AWAY, THUNDERING ABOVE HIM, WAS A SHED
WALL EE

SPIDERS, CLICKING, THEIR MANY EYES GLAMING IN THEIR WELY BLACK
HEADS.

EVEN AS HE REACHED FOR HIS WAND, F-JARRY KNEW IT WAS NEE CHHO, THERE
WERE

THEE MANY EE THEM, BLIT AS HE TRIED THE STAND, READY THE DIE FIGHTING, A
LEHD,

LENG NITE SHLINED, AND A BLAZE EE LIGHT FLAMED THROUGH THE FILLLED.

MR. LEASLEY S CAR WAS THUNDERING DOWN THE SLOPE, HEADLIGHTS
GLARING, ITS

WHIRN SCREECHING, KNUCKLING SPIDERS ASIDE; SEVERAL WERE THROWN
INTHE THEIR

BACKS, THEIR ENDLESS LEGS WAVING IN THE AIR. THE CAR SCREECHED THE A
HALT IN

FRONT EE F-JARRY AND REIN AND THE DEERS FLEW UPEN.

GET FANG! F-JARRY YELLED, DIVING INTHE THE FRONT SEAT; REIN SEIZED
THE

REAR-HEELING AROUND THE MIDDLE AND THREW HIM, YELPING, INTHE THE
BACK EE THE

CAR THE DEERS SLAMMED SHUT REIN DIDN T TOUCH THE
ACCELERATEER BLIT THE

CAR DIDN'T NEED HIM; THE ENGINE REARED AND THEY WERE OFF, HITTING
MERE

SPIDERS, THEY SPED UP THE SLOPE, HURT BY THE BULLETS, AND THEY WERE
SEEN

CRASHING THROUGH THE FOREST, BRANCHES WHIPPING THE WINDOWS AS
THE CAR

WOUND ITS WAY CLEVERLY THROUGH THE WIDEST GAPS, FOLLOWING A PATH
IT

HEAVILY BENEATH.

HARRY LOOKED SIDELWAYS AT RICH, HIS MOUTH WAS STILL OPEN IN THE
SILENT

STREAM, BUT HIS EYES WEREN'T PEERING ANYWHERE.

ARE YOU READY?

RICH STARED STRAIGHT AHEAD, UNABLE TO SPEAK.

THEY SMASHED THEIR WAY THROUGH THE UNDERGROWTH, FANG BELLING
LOUDLY

IN THE BACK SEAT, AND HARRY SAW THE SIDE MIRROR SNAP OFF AS THEY
SHOOKED

PAST A LARGE HAD, AFTER TEN NEARLY, RICKY MINUTES, THE TREES
THINNED, AND

HARRY COULD AGAIN SEE PATCHES OF SKY.

THE CAR STOPPED SO SUDDENLY THAT THEY WERE NEARLY THROWN INTO
THE

WINDSHIELD. THEY HAD REACHED THE EDGE OF THE FOREST, FANG FLING
HIMSELF AT

THE WINDSHIELD IN HIS ANXIETY TO GET OUT, AND WHEN HARRY OPENED THE
DOOR, HE

SHOT OFF THROUGH THE TREES THE JAGGED SHELTER, TAIL BETWEEN HIS
LEGS. HARRY

GET OUT THEM, AND AFTER A MINUTE OR SO, RICH SEEMED TO REGAIN THE
FEELING IN

HIS LIMBS AND FEELINGS, STILL STIFF-NECKED AND STARING, HARRY GAVE THE CAR A

GRATEFUL PAT AS IT REVERSED BACK INTO THE FOREST AND DISAPPEARED FROM VIEW.

HARRY WENT BACK INTO HAGRID'S CLOAKS TO GET THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, FANG

WAS TREMBLING UNDER A BLANKET IN HIS BASKET, WHEN HARRY GOT OUTSIDE

AGAIN, HE FELT REIN BEING VIOLENTLY SICK IN THE PUMPKIN PATCH.

FEELING THE SPIDERS, SAID REIN WEARILY, WIPING HIS MOUTH ON HIS SLEEVE.

I'LL NEVER FORGIVE HAGRID, WE'RE LUCKY THEY'RE ALIVE.

I GET THE TWILIGHT STRAGGLE WHEN I MEET FRIENDS OF HIS, SAID HARRY.

THAT'S EXACTLY HAGRID'S PROBLEM! SAID REIN, THUMPING THE WALL OF THE

CLOAK. HE ALWAYS THINKS MINISTERS AREN'T AS BAD AS THEY'RE MADE OUT, AND

WHERE IT'S GET HIM? A CELL IN AZKABAN? HE WAS SHIVERING

UNCONTROLLABLY NOW. WHAT WAS THE POINT OF SENDING US IN THERE? WHAT

HAVE WE BEEN OUT, I'D LIKE TO KNOW?

THAT HAGRID NEVER OPENED THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, SAID HARRY, THROWING THE CLOAK OVER REIN AND PRODDING HIM IN THE ARM TO MAKE HIM

WALK. HE WAS INNOCENT.

REIN GAVE A BOLD SMILE, EVIDENTLY, HATCHING STRAGGLE IN A CLIFFHANGER WASN'T

HIS IDEA OF BEING INNOCENT.

AS THE CASTLE WHIMED NEARER HARRY TWITCHED THE CLOAK THE MADE
SURE THEIR

FEET WERE HIDDEN, THEN POLISHED THE CREAKING FRONT DOORS ALAR, THEY
WALKED

CAREFULLY BACK ACROSS THE ENTRANCE HALL AND UP THE MARBLE
STAIRCASE,

HOLDING THEIR BREATH AS THEY PASSED CORRIDORS WHERE WATCHFUL
SENTRIES WERE

WALKING, AT LAST THEY REACHED THE SAFETY OF THE GRYFFINDOR
COMMON ROOM,

WHERE THE FIRE HAD TURNED ITSELF INTO GLOWING ASH. THEY THREW OFF
THE CLOAK

AND CLIMBED THE WINDING STAIR TO THEIR DORMITORY,

RON FELL INTO HIS BED WITHOUT HESITATING TO GET UNDRESSED, HARRY,

HOWEVER, DIDN'T FEEL VERY SLEEPY, HE SAT ON THE EDGE OF HIS PILLOW-
POSTER,

THINKING HARD ABOUT EVERYTHING DRAGON HAD SAID,

THE CREATURE THAT WAS LURKING SOMEWHERE IN THE CASTLE, HE
THOUGHT,

SHEDDING LIKE A SKIN OF MONSTER VILDEMEHT EVEN OTHER MONSTERS
DIDN'T

WANT THE NAME IT, BUT HE AND RON WERE NOT CLOSER TO FINDING OUT
WHAT IT WAS,

HE FELT IT PETRIFIED ITS VICTIMS, EVEN Hagrid HAD NEVER KNOWN
WHAT WAS IN

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS,

HARRY STUNG HIS LEGS UP INTO HIS BED AND LEANED BACK AGAINST HIS
PILLOWS, WATCHING THE MOON GLINTING AT HIM THROUGH THE THICK
WINDERS,

THE CHILDREN T SEE WHAT ELSE THEY COULD SEE. THEY HAD HIT DEAD ENDS
EVERYWHERE. RIDDLE HAD CALLED THE WRITHING PERSON, THE GIRL HE
SLITHERED HAD

GET OFF, AND SHE HAD COULD TELL WHETHER IT WAS THE SAME PERSON, HER
A

DIFFERENT ONE, WHEN HAD OPENED THE CHAMBER THIS TIME. THERE WAS
NOBODY

ELSE TO ASK. HARRY WAS DEAD, STILL THINKING ABOUT WHAT ARACHE
HAD SAID.

HE WAS REACHING BACKWARDS WHEN WHAT SEEMED LIKE THEIR VERY LAST
HOPE

RECALLED TO HIM, AND HE SUDDENLY SAT UP UPRIGHT.

THEN, HE HISSED THROUGH THE DARK, THEN

THEN HEARD WITH A YELP LIKE PAIN, STARED WILDLY AROUND, AND SAW
HARRY.

THEN THAT GIRL WHO DIED, ARACHE SAID SHE WAS FEELING IN A
BATHROOM,

SAID HARRY, IGNORING NEVILLE'S SNIPPLING SPEARS FROM THE CORNER.
WHAT IF

SHE NEVER LEFT THE BATHROOM? WHAT IF SHE'S STILL THERE?

THEN ROLLED HIS EYES, FROWNING THROUGH THE MIDNIGHT, AND THEN
HE

UNDERSTOOD, THEN.

WELL THEN T THINK NOT MEANING MORTALLY?

A

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS

ALL THESE TIMES WE WERE IN THAT KATH-ROOM, AND SHE WAS JUST THREE
THIRTS AWAY, SAID BEEN BITTERLY AT BREAKFAST NEXT DAY, AND WE
COULD VE ASKED HER, AND NEEL...

IT HAD BEEN HARD ENOUGH TRYING TO LEED HER SPIDERS, ESCAPING
THEIR

TEACHERS BEING ENOUGH TO SNEAK INTO A GIRLS KATH-ROOM, THE GIRLS
KATH-ROOM,

NEVERTHELESS, RIGHT NEXT TO THE SCENE OF THE FIRST ATTACK, WAS GOING
TO BE ALMOST

IMPOSSIBLE.

BUT SOMETHING HAPPENED IN THEIR FIRST LESSON, TRANSFIGURATION,
THAT DAY

THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS FELT OF THEIR MINDS FOR THE FIRST TIME IN
WEEKS. TEN

MINUTES INTO THE CLASS, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TOLD THEM THAT
THEIR EXAMS

WOULD START ON THE FIRST OF JUNE, ONE WEEK FROM TODAY.

EXAMS? REPLIED SEAMUS FINNIGAN. WE'RE STILL GETTING EXAMS?
THERE WAS A LITTLE RANG BEHIND HARRY AS NEVILLE LONGBOTT'S
WAND

SLIPPED, VANISHING ONE OF THE LEGS ON HIS DESK, PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL

RESTORED IT WITH A WAVE OF HER HEAVY WAND, AND TURNED, FREELING, TO
SEAMUS.

THE WHOLE POINT OF KEEPING THE SCHOOL OPEN AT THIS TIME IS FOR
THEY

RECEIVE THEIR EDUCATION, SHE SAID STERNLY. THE EXAMS WILL
THEREFORE TAKE

PLACE AS USUAL, AND I TRUST YOU ARE ALL STUDYING HARD,

STUDYING HARD? IT HAD NEVER OCCURRED TO HARRY THAT THERE WOULD BE EXAMS

WITH THE CASTLE IN THIS STATE. THERE WAS A GREAT DEAL OF MOUNTAINS PLUTTERING

AROUND THE ROOM, WHICH MADE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SEEM EVEN MORE

DARKLY.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE'S INSTRUCTIONS WERE TO KEEP THE SCHOOL RUNNING

AS NORMALLY AS POSSIBLE, SHE SAID, AND THAT, I NEED HARDLY POINT OUT,

MEANS FINDING OUT HOW MUCH YOU HAVE LEARNED THIS YEAR.

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT THE PAIR OF WHITE RABBITS HE WAS SUPPOSED TO BE

TURNING INTO SLIPPERS. WHAT HAD HE LEARNED SO FAR THIS YEAR? HE COULDN'T

SEEM TO THINK OF ANYTHING THAT WOULD BE USEFUL IN AN EXAM.

HE LOOKED AS THOUGH HE DIDN'T EVEN THINK HE HAD THE CH AND LIVE IN THE

FORBIDDEN FOREST.

CAN YOU IMAGINE ME TAKING EXAMS WITH THIS? HE ASKED HARRY, HOLDING

UP HIS HAND, WHICH HAD JUST STARTED WHISTLING LOUDLY.

THREE DAYS BEFORE THEIR FIRST EXAM, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL MADE ANOTHER

ANNOUNCEMENT AT BREAKFAST.

I HAVE GOOD NEWS, SHE SAID, AND THE GREAT HALL, INSTEAD OF FALLING SILENT, ERUPTED.

OLIMPIADRE S CHMING KADK? SEVERAL PEOPLE YELLED HAPPILLY,

WHU VR CALGT THE F-HIR HP SLYTHERIN? SEHLEAED A GIRL AT THE
RAVENCLAW

TABLE,

BLIDDITCH MATCHES ARE KADK HN? REHARD WHEED EXCITEDLY,

WHEN THE FLIKELK HAD SLKSIDED, PROFESSHR MCGHINAGALL SAID,
PROFESSHR

SPREHIT HAS INFORMED ME THAT THE MANDRAGES ARE READY FOR
CLITTING AT LAST,

TENIGHT, WE WILL BE ABLE TO REVIVE THESE PEOPLE WHO HAVE BEEN
PETRIFIED, I

NEED HARDLY REMIND WHU ALL THAT HNR HP THEM MAY WELL BE ABLE TO
TELL US

WHO, HR WHAT, ATTACKED THEM, I AM HHEPEFUL THAT THIS DREADFUL YEAR
WILL END

WITH HHR CATCHING THE CLIPRIT,

THERE WAS AN EXPLOSION HP CHERRING, HARRY LEHDED HYER AT THE
SLYTHERIN

TABLE AND WASN T AT ALL SURPRISED TO SEE THAT DRACHE MALPHY HADN T
THINKED IN,

WHEN, HHEWEVER, WAS LEHDXING HAPPIER THAN HE D LEHDED IN DAYS,

IT WHEN T MATTER THAT WE NEVER ASKED MORTLE, THEN? HE SAID THE
HARRY,

HERMIONE LL PROHEABLY HAVE ALL THE ANSWERS WHEN THEY WAKE HER
UP? MIND

WHU, SHE LL GH CRAZY WHEN SHE FINDS HHT WE VR GHT EXAMS IN THREE
DAYS

TIME, SHE HASN T STUDIED, IT MIGHT BE KINDER TO LEAVE HER WHERE SHE
IS TILL

THEY'RE HERE.

JUST THEN, GINNY WEASLEY CAME HERE AND SAT DOWN NEXT TO RON. SHE

LOOKED TENSE AND NERVOUS, AND HARRY NOTICED THAT HER HANDS WERE TWISTING

IN HER LAP.

WHAT IS IT? SAID RON, HELPING HIMSELF TO MORE PERRIDGE.

GINNY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, BUT GLANCED UP AND DOWN THE GRYFFINDOR

TABLE WITH A SCARED LOOK ON HER FACE THAT REMINDED HARRY OF SOMEONE,

THOUGH HE COULDN'T THINK WHO.

SHE IT IS, SAID RON, WATCHING HER.

HARRY SUDDENLY REALIZED WHO GINNY LOOKED LIKE. SHE WAS RECKING BACKWARD AND FORWARD SLIGHTLY IN HER CHAIR, EXACTLY LIKE DUFFY DID WHEN

HE WAS TERTERING ON THE EDGE OF REVEALING FORBIDDEN INFORMATION.

I'VE GOT TO TELL YOU SOMETHING, GINNY MUMBLED, CAREFULLY NOT LOOKING

AT HARRY.

WHAT IS IT? SAID HARRY.

GINNY LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE COULDN'T FIND THE RIGHT WORDS.

WHAT? SAID RON.

GINNY OPENED HER MOUTH, BUT NO SOUND CAME OUT. HARRY LEANED FORWARD

AND SPEAKED QUIETLY, SO THAT ONLY GINNY AND RON COULD HEAR HIM.

IS IT SOMETHING ABOUT THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS? HAVE YOU SEEN SOMETHING? SOMEONE ACTING WEIRD?

GINNY DREW A DEEP BREATH AND, AT THAT PRECISE MOMENT, PERCY
LEASLEY

APPEARED, LOOKING TIRED AND WAN.

IF YOU'VE FINISHED EATING, I'LL TAKE THAT SEAT, GINNY. I'M STARVING,
I'VE

ONLY JUST COME OFF PATROL DUTY.

GINNY JUMPED UP AS THOUGH HER CHAIR HAD JUST BEEN ELECTRIFIED,
GAVE

PERCY A FLEETING, FRIGHTENED LOOK, AND SCAMPERS AWAY. PERCY SAT
DOWN AND

GRABBED A MUG FROM THE CENTER OF THE TABLE.

PERCY? SAID THEN ANGERILY. SHE WAS JUST ABOUT TO TELL US
SOMETHING

IMPORTANT?

HALFWAY THROUGH A GLIP OF TEA, PERCY CHECKED.

WHAT SORT OF THING? HE SAID, CHUCKLING.

I JUST ASKED HER IF SHE'D SEEN ANYTHING HAD, AND SHE STARTED TO SAY

THAT THAT'S NOTHING TO DO WITH THE CHAMBER OF
SECRETS, SAID

PERCY AT ONCE.

HOW DO YOU KNOW? SAID THEN, HIS EYEBROWS RAISED.

WELL, ER, IF YOU MUST KNOW, GINNY, ER, WALKED IN ON ME THE OTHER
DAY

WHEN I WAS WELL, NEVER MIND THE POINT IS, SHE SPOTTED ME
BEING

SOMETHING AND I, UH, I ASKED HER NOT TO MENTION IT TO ANYBODY. I
MUST SAY, I

DID THINK SHE'D KEEP HER WORD. IT'S NOTHING, REALLY, I'D JUST RATHER

HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN PERCY WHEN SHE LINED UP THE TABLE.

WHAT WERE YOU DOING, PERCY? SAID SHE, GRINNING. COME ON, TELL US, WE

WON'T LAUGH.

PERCY DIDN'T SMILE BACK.

PASS ME THOSE REELS, HARRY, I'M STARVING.

HARRY KNEW THE WHITE MISTERY MIGHT BE SOLVED THEMSELVES WITHOUT THEIR

HELP, BUT HE WASN'T ABOUT TO PASS UP A CHANCE TO SPREAD THE MISTERY IF IT

TURNED UP AND TO HIS DELIGHT IT DID, MIDMORNING, WHEN THEY WERE

LED TO THE HISTORY OF MAGIC BY GILBERT LECHEART.

LECHEART, WHO HAD SEEN OFTEN ASSURED THEM THAT ALL DANGER HAD

ONLY BEEN PREVENTED BY THE RIGHT WAY, WAS NOW UNHEARDINGLY

THAT IT WAS HARDLY WORTH THE TRAVEL TO SEE THEM SAFELY DOWN THE

THIS HADN'T AS SPEED AS USUAL; IT SEEMED HE HAD BEEN UP NEXT OF

NIGHT, PATROLLING THE FOURTH FLOOR.

MARCH MY WORDS, HE SAID, LISTENING THEM AROUND A CORNER. THE

WORDS HAD OF THESE OTHER PETRIFIED PEOPLE'S MOUTHES WILL BE IT WAS

FRANKLY, I'M ASTONISHED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL THINKS ALL THESE

MEASURES ARE NECESSARY.

I AGREE, SIR, SAID HARRY, MAKING RON DRIP HIS EYES IN SURPRISE.

THANK YOU, HARRY, SAID LUCIFER GRACIOUSLY WHILE THEY WAITED FOR A

LONG LINE OF FLUFFPOPS TO PASS. I MEAN, WE TEACHERS HAVE ELITE ENOUGH TO

BE GETTING ON WITH, WITHOUT WALKING STUDENTS THE CLASSES AND STANDING GUARD

ALL NIGHT. . . .

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID RON, CATCHING HIM. WHY DON'T YOU LEAVE US HERE, SIR,

WE'RE ONLY GETTING HERE FROM THE CORRIDOR THE GO

YOU KNOW, WEASLEY, I THINK I WILL, SAID LUCIFER. I REALLY SHOULD GO

AND PREPARE MY NEXT CLASS

AND HE HURRIED OFF.

PREPARE HIS CLASS, RON SNEAKED AFTER HIM. CHECK THE CLIP HIS HAIR, MORE

LIKE.

THEY LET THE REST OF THE GRYFFINDORS DRAW AHEAD OF THEM, THEN DARTED

DOWN A SIDE PASSAGE AND HURRIED OFF TOWARD MEANING MYRTLE'S KITCHEN.

BUT JUST AS THEY WERE CONGRATULATING EACH OTHER ON THEIR BRILLIANT SCHEME

PETER! WEASLEY! WHAT ARE YOU DOING?

IT WAS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND HER MOUTH WAS THE THINNEST OF THIN

LINE.

WE WERE WE WERE THEN STAMMERED, WE WERE GOING THE THE
GEE
AND SEE

HERMIONE, SAID HARRY, THEN AND PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL BOTH
LOOKED AT
HIM,

WE HAVEN'T SEEN HER FOR AGES, PROFESSOR, HARRY WENT ON
FLURRIEDLY,

TREADING ON RON'S FEET, AND HE THOUGHT HE'D STRAID INTO THE
HOSPITAL WING,

WELL DONE, AND TELL HER THE MANDRAGOLAS ARE NEARLY READY AND, ER,
MEET THE WHORRY

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS STILL STARING AT HIM, AND FOR A MOMENT,
HARRY

THOUGHT SHE WAS GOING TO EXPLODE, BUT WHEN SHE SPEAKED, IT WAS IN A
STRANGELY CREAKY VOICE,

OF COURSE, SHE SAID, AND HARRY, AMAZED, SAW A TEAR GLISTENING IN
HER

READY EYE. OF COURSE, I REALIZE THIS HAS ALL BEEN HARDEST FOR THE
FRIENDS OF

THESE WHO HAVE BEEN . . . I COMPLETELY UNDERSTAND, YES, BETTER, OF COURSE
WELL MAY

VISIT MISS GRANGER, I WILL INFORM PROFESSOR KINGS WHERE YOU'VE
GONE, TELL

MADAM POMFREY I HAVE GIVEN MY PERMISSION.

HARRY AND RON WALKED AWAY, HARDLY DARING TO BELIEVE THAT THEY'D
AVOIDED DETENTION, AS THEY TURNED THE CORNER, THEY DISTINCTLY
HEARD

PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL KNEW HER NEESE.

THAT, SAID RENN FERVENTLY, WAS THE BEST STORY SHE'VE EVER HEARD
OF

WITH.

THEY HAD NO CHOICE NOW BUT TO GO TO THE HOSPITAL WING AND TELL
MADAM

PERREY THAT THEY HAD PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL'S PERMISSION TO
VISIT

HERMINE.

MADAM PERREY LET THEM IN, BUT RELUCTANTLY.

THERE'S JUST ONE POINT ABOUT THE A PETRIFIED PERSON, SHE SAID,
AND THEY

HAD TO ADMIT SHE HAD A POINT WHEN THEY'D TAKEN THEIR SEATS NEXT
TO

HERMINE. IT WAS PLAIN THAT HERMINE DIDN'T HAVE THE FAINTEST
SUSPICION THAT

SHE HAD VISITORS, AND THAT THEY MIGHT JUST AS WELL TELL HER BEDSIDE
CABINET

WHAT THE WHOLE AFFAIR ALL THE MORE IT WOULD BE.

WHETHER IF SHE DID SEE THE ATTACKER, THOUGH? SAID RENN, LEERING
SADLY AT

HERMINE'S RIGID FACE. BECAUSE IF HE SNEAKED UP ON THEM ALL, HE
WOULD BE

EVER DONE, . . .

BUT HARRY WASN'T LEERING AT HERMINE'S FACE. HE WAS MORE
INTERESTED IN

HER RIGHT HAND. IT WAS CLUTCHED IN THE WRAP OF HER BLANKETS, AND BENDING
CLOSE,

HE SAW THAT A PIECE OF PAPER WAS SCRUNCHED INSIDE HER FIST.

MAKING SURE THAT MADAM PEMBERTON WAS NOWHERE NEAR, HE PHINTED THIS

BLIT THE REIN.

TRY AND GET IT BLIT, REIN WHISPERED, SHIFTING HIS CHAIR SEE THAT HE BLEEKED

HARRY FROM MADAM PEMBERTON'S VIEW.

IT WAS NOT EASY TASK, HERMIONE'S HAND WAS CLAMPED SEE TIGHTLY AROUND THE

PAPER THAT HARRY WAS SURE HE WAS GOING TO TEAR IT, WHILE REIN KEPT WATCH HE

TWEGED AND TWISTED, AND AT LAST, AFTER SEVERAL TENSE MINUTES, THE PAPER CAME

FREE.

IT WAS A PAGE TAKEN FROM A VERY OLD LIBRARY BOOK, HARRY SMEELED IT BLIT

EAGERLY AND REIN LEANED CLOSE TO READ IT, THEN.

OF THE MANY FEARFUL BEASTS AND MONSTERS THAT INHABIT OUR LAND, THERE

IS NONE MORE DREADFUL OR MORE DEADLY THAN THE BASILISK, KNOWN ALSO AS

THE KING OF SERPENTS. THIS SNAKE, WHICH MAY REACH GIGANTIC SIZE AND

LIVE MANY HUNDREDS OF YEARS, IS BORN FROM A CHICKEN'S EGG, HATCHED BENEATH A THUD. ITS METHODS OF KILLING ARE MOST HORRIBLE, FOR ASIDE FROM ITS DEADLY AND VENOMOUS FANGS, THE BASILISK HAS A MURDEROUS STARE, AND ALL WHO ARE FIXED WITH THE RAY OF ITS EYE SHALL SUFFER INSTANT DEATH. SPIDERS FLEE BEFORE THE BASILISK, FOR IT IS THEIR MORTAL

ENEMY, AND THE BASILISK FLEES ONLY FROM THE CRAWLING OF THE ROHSTER,

WHICH IS FATAL TO IT,

AND BENEATH THIS, A SINGLE WORD HAD BEEN WRITTEN, IN A HAND HARRY
RECOGNIZED AS HERMIONE S. PIPES.

IT WAS AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD JUST FLICKED A LIGHT ON IN HIS BRAIN.

THEN, HE BREATHED. THIS IS IT. THIS IS THE ANSWER. THE MONSTER
IN THE

CHAMBER IS A BASILISK A GIANT SERPENT! THAT'S WHY I'VE BEEN
HEARING THAT

WHILE ALL OVER THE PLACE, AND NOBODY ELSE HAS HEARD IT. IT'S BECAUSE I
UNDERSTAND PARSELTHINGLE, . . .

HARRY LEANED UP AT THE EDS AROUND HIM.

THE BASILISK KILLS PEOPLE BY LOOKING AT THEM, BUT NE HEN S DIED
BECAUSE NE HEN LOOKED IT STRAIGHT IN THE EYE. CHERIN SAW IT THROUGH
HIS

CAMERA. THE BASILISK SWUNG UP ALL THE FILM INSIDE IT, BUT CHERIN JUST
GOT

PETRIFIED. JUSTIN . . . JUSTIN MUST'VE SEEN THE BASILISK THROUGH
NEARLY

HEADLESS NICK! NICK GOT THE FULL BLAST OF IT, BUT HE COULDN'T DIE
AGAIN . . .

AND HERMIONE AND THAT RAVENCLAW PREET WERE FEELING WITH A
MIRROR NEXT

TO THEM. HERMIONE HAD JUST REALIZED THE MONSTER WAS A BASILISK. I
GET THAT

ANYTHING SHE WARNED THE FIRST PERSON SHE MET THE LOOKS AROUND
CORNERS WITH A

MIRROR FIRST! AND THAT GIRL PULLED OUT HER MIRROR AND

WHEN HIS LAW HAD DRIPPED.

AND MRS. DUNN? HE WHISPERED RAGERLY.

HARRY TRELLIGHT HAD, PICTURING THE SCENE IN THE NIGHT OF
HALLOWEEN.

THE WATER ... HE SAID SILENTLY. THE FLOOD FROM MEANING MYRTLE'S
BATHROOM. I GET WHY MRS. DUNN ONLY SAW THE REFLECTION. ...

HE SCANNED THE PAGE IN HIS HAND RAGERLY. THE MORE HE LOOKED AT IT,
THE

MORE IT MADE SENSE.

THE BASILISK FLEES ONLY FROM THE CREEPING OF THE RHINOCEROS, WHICH
IS FATAL

THE IT? HE READ ALOUD. HARRY'S RHINOCEROS WERE KILLED? THE FEAR OF
SLOTHERIN DIDN'T WANT HIM ANYWHERE NEAR THE CASTLE SINCE THE
CHAMBER WAS

OPENED? SPIDERS ARE KEPT IN THE BASILISK? IT ALL FITS?

BUT WHY'S THE BASILISK BEEN GETTING AROUND THE PLACE? SAID DUNN.
A

GIANT SNAKE ... SOMETHING WOULD BE SEEN ...

HARRY, HOWEVER, POINTED AT THE WORD HERMION HAD SCRIBBLED AT THE
BOTTOM

OF THE PAGE.

PIPES, HE SAID. PIPES ... DUNN, IT'S BEEN LISTING THE PLOTTING. I'VE
BEEN

HEARING THAT VOICE INSIDE THE WALLS. ...

DUNN SUDDENLY GRABBED HARRY'S ARM.

THE ENTRANCE TO THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS? HE SAID HARSHLY.
WHAT IF

IT'S A BATHROOM? WHAT IF IT'S IN

MEANING MYRTLE'S BATHROOM, SAID HARRY.

THEY SAT THERE, EXCITEMENT CHURRING THROUGH THEM, HARDLY ABLE TO BELIEVE

IT.

THIS MEANS, SAID HARRY, I CAN'T BE THE ONLY PARSELMOUTH IN THE SCHOOL. THE FACT OF SLYTHERIN'S HOLE, THEN, THAT'S HOW HE'S BEEN CONTROLLING

THE BASILISK.

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO? SAID RON, WHOSE EYES WERE FLASHING. SHOULD

WE GO STRAIGHT TO MCGONAGALL?

LET'S GO TO THE STAFFROOM, SAID HARRY, JUMPING UP. SHE'LL BE THERE IN

TEN MINUTES. IT'S NEARLY BREAK.

THEY RAN DOWNSTAIRS, NOT WANTING TO BE DISCOVERED HANGING AROUND IN

ANOTHER CORRIDOR. THEY WENT STRAIGHT INTO THE DESERTED STAFFROOM. IT WAS A

LARGE, PANELLED ROOM FULL OF DARK, WOODEN CHAIRS. HARRY AND RON PAVED

AROUND IT, THEN EXITED THE SIT DOWN.

BUT THE BELL THE SIGNAL BREAK NEVER CAME.

INSTEAD, RUSHING THROUGH THE CORRIDORS CAME PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S

VOICE, MAGICALLY MAGNIFIED.

ALL STUDENTS TO RETURN TO THEIR HOUSE DORMITORIES AT ONCE. ALL TEACHERS

RETURN TO THE STAFFROOM. IMMEDIATELY, PLEASE.

HARRY WHEELED AROUND THE STAIR AT RON.

NOT ANOTHER ATTACK? NOT NOW?

WHAT IS WE DO? SAID RON, AGHAST. GO BACK TO THE DORMITORY?

NO, SAID HARRY, GLANCING AROUND. THERE WAS AN UGLY SIGHT OF
WARDROBE

TO HIS LEFT, FULL OF THE TEACHERS CHAIRS. IN HERE, LET US HEAR WHAT
IT IS ALL

ABOUT. THEN WE CAN TELL THEM WHAT WE ARE FEELING ABOUT.

THEY HID THEMSELVES INSIDE IT, LISTENING TO THE RUMBLING OF
HUNDREDS OF

PEOPLE MOVING EVERYWHERE, AND THE STAFFROOM DOOR BANGING OPEN,
FROM

BETWEEN THE MISTY FIELDS OF THE CHAIRS, THEY WATCHED THE TEACHERS
FILTERING

INTO THE ROOM. SOME OF THEM WERE LOOKING PUZZLED, OTHERS
DOWNRIGHT

STARTED. THEN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ARRIVED.

IT HAS HAPPENED, SHE TOLD THE SILENT STAFFROOM. A STUDENT HAS
BEEN

TAKEN BY THE MINSTER, RIGHT INTO THE CHAMBER ITSELF.

PROFESSOR FLITWICK LET OUT A SILENT, PROFESSOR SPRUIT CLAPPED
HER HANDS

EVER HER MOUTH. SNAPE GRIPPED THE BACK OF A CHAIR VERY HARD AND
SAID,

HOW CAN YOU BE SURE?

THE HEIR OF SLYTHERIN, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WHO WAS
VERY

WHITE, LEFT ANOTHER MESSAGE, RIGHT UNDERNEATH THE FIRST ONE.
HER SKELETON

WILL LIE IN THE CHAMBER FOREVER.

PROFESSOR FLITWICK BURST INTO TEARS.

WHAT IS IT? SAID MADAM PITCHER, WHO HAD SLUNK, HEAD-DOWNED, INTO A CHAIR, WHICH STUDENT?

GINNY WEASLEY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

HARRY FELT HER SLIDE SILENTLY DOWN BENTH THE WARDROBE ALONG BESIDE HIM.

WE SHALL HAVE TO SEND ALL THE STUDENTS HOME THEMSELVES, SAID PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL. THIS IS THE END OF HOGWARTS. DUMBLEDORE ALWAYS SAID ...

THE STAFFROOM DOOR BANGED OPEN AGAIN, FOR ONE WILD MOMENT, HARRY

WAS SURE IT WOULD BE DUMBLEDORE, BUT IT WAS LUCIFART, AND HE WAS SCREAMING.

HE SHOOK OFF WHAT HAVE I MISSED?

HE DIDN'T SEEM TO NOTICE THAT THE OTHER TEACHERS WERE LOOKING AT HIM

WITH SOMETHING REMARKABLY LIKE HATRED. SNAPE STEPPED FORWARD.

LISTEN THE MAN, HE SAID. THE VERY MAN, A GIRL HAS BEEN SNATCHED BY THE

MINISTER, LUCIFART, TAKEN INTO THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS ITSELF. YOUR MOMENT

HAS COME AT LAST.

LUCIFART BLANCHED.

THAT'S RIGHT, GILDEROY, CHIPPED IN PROFESSOR SPRUIT. WEREN'T YOU

SAYING LISTEN LAST NIGHT THAT YOU'VE KNOWN ALL ALONG WHERE THE ENTRANCE TO THE

CHAMBER OF SECRETS IS?

I WELL, I SPLITTERED LICKDE-HART,

YES, DIDN'T YELL TELL ME YELL WERE SURE YELL KNEW WHAT WAS INSIDE IT?

PIPED UP PROFESSOR FLITWICK,

D-DID I? I DIDN'T RECALL

I CERTAINLY REMEMBER YELL SAYING YELL WERE SURE YELL HADN'T HAD A CRACK

AT THE MINISTER BEHIND L-JACOB WAS ARRESTED, SAID SNAPE, DIDN'T YELL SAY

THAT THE WHOLE AFFAIR HAD BEEN KUNGLED, AND THAT YELL SHOULD HAVE BEEN

GIVEN A FREE REIN FROM THE FIRST?

LICKDE-HART STARED AROUND AT HIS STONY-FACED COLLEAGUES,

I I REALLY NEVER YELL MAY HAVE MISUNDERSTOOD

WE'LL LEAVE IT TO YELL, THEN, GILDERHOY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL,

TONIGHT WILL BE AN EXCELLENT TIME TO DO IT, WE'LL MAKE SURE EVERYTHING'S SET

UP YOUR WAY, YELL'LL BE ABLE TO TACKLE THE MINISTER ALL BY YOURSELF, A FREE REIN

AT LAST,

LICKDE-HART GAZED DESPERATELY AROUND HIM, BUT NEITHER CAME THE THE RESCUE,

HE DIDN'T LOOK REMOTELY HANDSOME ANYMORE, HIS LIP WAS TREMBLING, AND IN

THE ABSENCE OF HIS USUAL THIEF'S GRIN, HE LOOKED WORN-OUT AND FEELER,

Y-VERY WELL, HE SAID, I'LL I'LL BE IN MY OFFICE, GETTING GETTING

READY,

AND HE LEFT THE ROOM,

RIGHT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WHOSE NESTRILS WERE FLARED,
THAT'S

GET HIM OUT FROM UNDER HIS FEET. THE HEADS OF HOUSES SHOULD BE
AND

INFORM THEIR STUDENTS WHAT HAS HAPPENED. TELL THEM THE
HOGWARTS EXPRESS

WILL TAKE THEM HOME FIRST THING TOMORROW. WILL THE REST OF YOU
PLEASE MAKE

SURE THE STUDENTS HAVE BEEN LEFT OUTSIDE THEIR DORMITORIES.

THE TEACHERS WERE AND LEFT, ONE BY ONE.

IT WAS PROBABLY THE WORST DAY OF HARRY'S ENTIRE LIFE. HE, RON, FRED,
AND

GEORGE SAT TOGETHER IN A CORNER OF THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM,
UNABLE TO

SAY ANYTHING TO EACH OTHER. PERCY WASN'T THERE. HE HAD GONE TO
SEND AN HOWL

THE MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY, THEN SHUT HIMSELF UP IN HIS DORMITORY.

THE AFTERNOON EVER LASTED AS LONG AS THAT ONE. THEY HAD GRYFFINDOR
THEIR

EVER BEEN SO CROWDED, YET SO QUIET. NEAR SUNSET, FRED AND GEORGE
WENT UP

THE BED, UNABLE TO SIT THERE ANY LONGER.

SHE KNEW SOMETHING, HARRY, SAID RON, SPEAKING FOR THE FIRST
TIME

SINCE THEY HAD ENTERED THE HALLWAY IN THE STAFFROOM. THAT'S WHY
SHE WAS

TAKEN, IT WASN'T SOME STUPID THING ABOUT PERCY AT ALL. SHE'D FEELING
HELT

SOMETHING ABOUT THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, THAT MUST BE WHY SHE
WAS

RENN BLINKED HIS EYES FRANTICALLY. I MEAN, SHE WAS A POLYBLEND,
THERE CAN'T

BE ANY OTHER REASON.

HARRY COULD SEE THE SUN SINKING, BLEED-RED, BEHIND THE SKYLINE.
THIS WAS

THE WORST HE HAD EVER FELT. IF ONLY THERE WAS SOMETHING THEY COULD
DO.

ANYTHING.

HARRY, SAID RENN. DO YOU THINK THERE'S ANY CHANCE AT ALL SHE'S
NOT

WELL KNOWN

HARRY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT THE SAY, HE COULDN'T SEE HOW GINNY COULD
STILL BE

ALIVE.

DO YOU KNOW WHAT? SAID RENN. I THINK WE SHOULD GO AND SEE
HITCHHART.

TELL HIM WHAT WE KNOW, HE'S GOING TO TRY AND GET INTO THE
CHAMBER, WE CAN

TELL HIM WHERE WE THINK IT IS, AND TELL HIM IT'S A BASILISK IN THERE.

BECAUSE HARRY COULDN'T THINK OF ANYTHING ELSE THE DO, AND BECAUSE
HE

WANTED THE DO SOMETHING, HE AGREED. THE GRYPFINDERS AREN'T
THEM

WERE SHE MISERABLE, AND FELT SHE SHOULD FOR THE WEASLEYS, THAT NEVER
TRIED THE

STEP THEM AS THEY GET UP, CROSSED THE ROOM, AND LEFT THROUGH THE
PORTRAIT

WHILE,

DARKNESS WAS FALLING AS THEY WALKED BEHIND THE LOCKHEART'S OFFICE,
THERE

SEEMED TO BE A LOT OF ACTIVITY GOING ON INSIDE IT. THEY COULD HEAR
SCRAPING,

THUMPS, AND HURRIED FOOTSTEPS,

HARRY KNOCKED AND THERE WAS A SUDDEN SILENCE FROM INSIDE. THEN
THE

DOOR OPENED THE TINIEST CRACK AND THEY SAW ONE OF LOCKHEART'S EYES
PEERING

THROUGH IT.

HE MR. PETER MR. LEASLEY HE SAID, OPENING THE DOOR
A BIT

WIDER. I'M RATHER BUSY AT THE MOMENT IF YOU WOULD BE SO KIND

PROFESSOR, WE'VE GOT SOME INFORMATION FOR YOU, SAID HARRY. WE
THINK

IT'LL HELP YOU.

ER WELL IT'S NOT TERRIBLY THE SIDE OF LOCKHEART'S FACE
THAT THEY

COULD SEE LOOKED VERY UNCOMFORTABLE. I MEAN WELL ALL RIGHT

HE OPENED THE DOOR AND THEY ENTERED.

HIS OFFICE HAD BEEN ALMOST COMPLETELY STRIPPED. TWO LARGE TRUNKS
STOOD

OPEN ON THE FLOOR. REDS, DARK-GREEN, LILAC, MIDNIGHT-BLUE, HAD BEEN
HASTILY

POUNDED INTO ONE OF THEM; BOOKS WERE LUMPED LINTIDLY INTO THE
OTHER. THE

PHOTOGRAPHS THAT HAD COVERED THE WALLS WERE NOW CRAMPED INTO
CRACKS IN

THE DESK.

ARE YOU GOING SOMEWHERE? SAID HARRY.

ER, WELL, YES, SAID LUCIFERT, RIPPING A LIFE-SIZE POSTER OF HIMSELF
FROM

THE BACK OF THE DOOR AS HE SPEAK AND STARTING TO REEL IT UP,
URGENT CALL

UNAVOIDABLE GET THE GO

WHAT ABOUT MY SISTER? SAID REEN IRRONICALLY.

WELL, AS THE THAT MUST UNFORTUNATE SAID LUCIFERT,
AVOIDING THEIR

EYES AS HE WRENCHED OPEN A DRAWER AND STARTED EMPTYING THE
CONTENTS INTO

A BAG. SHE HAD SECRETS MORE THAN I

YOU ARE THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER? SAID HARRY.
YOU

CAN'T SHE BE? NOT WITH ALL THE DARK STUFF GOING ON HERE?

WELL I MUST SAY WHEN I THINK THE THE LUCIFERT
MUTTERED, NOW

PILING STUFF ON TOP OF HIS BOOKS. NOTHING IN THE THE DESCRIPTION
DIDN'T

EXPECT

YOU MEAN YOU ARE RUNNING AWAY? SAID HARRY DISBELIEVINGLY.
AFTER ALL

THAT STUFF YOU DID IN YOUR ROOMS

ROOMS CAN BE MISLEADING, SAID LUCIFERT DELICATELY.

YOU WRITE THEM? HARRY SMILED.

MY DEAR KID, SAID LUCKHART, STRAIGHTENING UP AND FREELING AT
HARRY.

DON'T USE YOUR COMMON SENSE, MY KIDNERS WOULDN'T HAVE SHED HALF AS
WELL IF

PEOPLE DIDN'T THINK I'D DONE ALL THESE THINGS, DON'T EVEN WANT'S THE
READ ABOUT

THESE LUCKY OLD ARMENIAN WARRIORS, EVEN IF HE DID SAVE A VILLAGE FROM
WEREWOLVES, HE'D BEEN DREADFUL IN THE FRONT LINE, DON'T DRESS SENSE
AT ALL,

AND THE WITCH WHO KIDNAPED THE KIDNAP KIDNAPER HAD A FAIRY CHIN,
I MEAN,

COME ON

SEE WHY WE JUST BEEN TAKING CREDIT FOR WHAT A LEAD OF OTHER
PEOPLE HAVE

DON'T? SAID HARRY INCREDIBLY,

HARRY, HARRY, SAID LUCKHART, SHAKING HIS HEAD IMPATIENTLY,
IT'S NOT

NEARLY AS SIMPLE AS THAT, THERE WAS WORK INVOLVED, I HAD THE TRACK
THESE

PEOPLE DOWN, AND THEM EXACTLY HOW THEY MANAGED TO DO WHAT THEY
DID,

THEN I HAD THE PLAN A MEMORY CHARM FOR THEM SEE THEY WOULDN'T
REMEMBER

DOING IT, IF THERE'S ONE THING I PRIDE MYSELF ON, IT'S MY MEMORY
CHARMS,

DON'T, IT'S BEEN A LOT OF WORK, HARRY, IT'S NOT ALL KIDNAP SIGNINGS AND
PUBLICITY

PEOPLES, WHY DON'T, WHY WANT FAME, WHY HAVE THEM BE PREPARED FOR A
LONG HARD

SLUG,

HE RANGED THE LIDS OF HIS TRUNKS FLAT AND LOCKED THEM,

LET'S SEE, HE SAID. I THINK THAT'S EVERYTHING. YES, FINALLY ONE THING LEFT.

HE PULLED BACK HIS HAND AND TURNED THEM.

AWFULLY SORRY, REMY, BUT I'LL HAVE TO PUT A MEMORY CHARM ON YOU NOW.

CAN'T HAVE YOU BLABBING MY SECRETS ALL OVER THE PLACE. I'D NEVER SELL

ANOTHER REMY

HARRY REACHED HIS WAND JUST IN TIME. LUCIFER HAD BARELY RAISED HIS,

WHEN HARRY BELLEND, EXPELLIARMUS!

LUCIFER WAS BLASTED BACKWARD, FALLING OVER HIS TRUNK; HIS WAND FLEW

HIGH INTO THE AIR; REMY CALLED IT, AND FLYING IT HIT HIM THE OPEN WINDHOLE.

SHOULDN'T HAVE LET PROFESSOR SNAPE TEACH US THAT ONE, SAID HARRY

FLURRIEDLY, KICKING LUCIFER'S TRUNK ASIDE. LUCIFER WAS LEERING UP AT HIM,

PEEKER HENCE MORE. HARRY WAS STILL POINTING HIS WAND AT HIM.

WHAT'D YOU WANT ME TO DO? SAID LUCIFER WRAIDLY. I DON'T KNOW WHERE THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS IS. THERE'S NOTHING I CAN DO.

YOU'RE IN LUCK, SAID HARRY, PERKING LUCIFER THE HIS FEET AT WANDPOINT.

WE THINK WE KNOW WHERE IT IS, AND WHAT'S INSIDE IT. LET'S GO.

THEY MARCHED LUCIFER HIT HIM HIS OFFICE AND DOWN THE NEAREST STAIRS.

ALONG THE DARK CORRIDOR WHERE THE MESSAGES SPINE ON THE WALL, THE DEER

HE MEANING MYRTLE S KATE-HEHEH,

THEY SENT LEEDE-HART IN FIRST, FARRY WAS PLEASED THE SEE THAT HE WAS
SHADING,

MEANING MYRTLE WAS SITTING HEN THE TANK HE THE END THEKT,

HEH, IT S YELL, SHE SAID WHEN SHE SAW FARRY, WHAT DEE YELL WANT
THIS

TIMY?

THE ASK YELL FHEH YELL DIED, SAID FARRY,

MYRTLE S WHELE ASPECT CHANGED AT ONCE, SHE LEEHEED AS TEEHEGH SHE
HAD

NEVER BEEN ASKED SUCH A FLATTERING HLESTHEH,

HEHEHEH, IT WAS DREADFUL, SHE SAID WITH RELISH, IT HAPPENED RIGHT
IN

HERE, I DIED IN THIS VERY STALL, I REMEMBER IT SHE WELL, I D HIDDEN
KECALISE

HELYE FHEHNEY WAS TEASING ME ABELIT MY CLASSES, THE DEEH WAS
LEEHEED, AND

I WAS CRYING, AND THEN I HEARD SHEHEHEH COME IN, THEY SAID
SHEHEHEH

FLINDY, A DIFFERENT LANGUAGE, I THINK IT MUST HAVE BEEN, ANDWAY,
WHAT

REALLY GET ME WAS THAT IT WAS A KEY SPREADING, SHE I UNLEEHEED THE
DEEH, THE TELL

HIM THE GEE AND LEE HIS HEN THEKT, AND THEN MYRTLE SWELLED
IMPHERTANTLY,

HER FACE SHINING, I DIED,

FHEH? SAID FARRY,

DEE IDEA, SAID MYRTLE IN FLISHED THENES, I ILST REMEMBER SEEING A
PAIR

HE GREAT, BIG, YELLOW EYES. MY LITTLE BODY SHIRT HE SEIZED UP, AND THEN I WAS

FLUATING AWAY, . . . SHE LOOKED DREAMILY AT HARRY, AND THEN I CAME BACK

AGAIN. I WAS DETERMINED THE PALANT HEAVE HERBY, WELL SEE, HEH, SHE WAS SHIRRY

SHE D EVER LAUGHED AT MY GLASSES.

WHERE EXACTLY DID WELL SEE THE EYES? SAID HARRY.

SOMEWHERE THERE, SAID MORTLE, POINTING VAGUELY TOWARD THE SINK IN

FRONT OF HER THILET.

HARRY AND REEN FLURRIED OVER THE IT, LEONHEART WAS STANDING WELL BACK, A

LOOK OF LITTER TERROR ON HIS FACE.

IT LOOKED LIKE AN ORDINARY SINK. THEY EXAMINED EVERY INCH OF IT, INSIDE

AND OUT, INCLUDING THE PIPES BELOW. AND THEN HARRY SAW IT: SCRATCHED ON

THE SIDE OF ONE OF THE CHOPPER TAPS WAS A TINY SNARE.

THAT TAP I NEVER WENDED, SAID MORTLE BRIGHTLY AS HE TRIED THE TURN IT.

HARRY, SAID REEN. SAY SOMETHING. SOMETHING IN PARSELTONGUE.

BUT HARRY THOUGHT HARD. THE ONLY TIMES HE D EVER MANAGED THE

SPREAD PARSELTONGUE WERE WHEN HE D BEEN FACED WITH A REAL SNARE. HE STARED

HARD AT THE TINY ENGRAVING, TRYING THE IMAGINE IT WAS REAL.

OPEN UP, HE SAID.

HE LOOKED AT REEN, WHO SHOOK HIS HEAD.

ENGLISH, HE SAID.

HARRY LEEDED BACK AT THE SHADE, WILLING HIMSELF THE BELIEVE IT WAS ALIVE.

IF HE MOVED HIS HEAD, THE CANDLELIGHT MADE IT LOOK AS THOUGH IT WERE

MOVING.

OPEN UP, HE SAID.

EXCEPT THAT THE WORDS WEREN'T WHAT HE HEARD; A STRANGE HISsing HAD

ESCAPED HIM, AND AT ONCE THE TAP GLEWED WITH A BRILLIANT WHITE LIGHT AND

BEGAN THE SPIN. NEXT SECOND, THE SINK BEGAN THE MOVE; THE SINK, IN FACT, SANK,

RIGHT INTO HIS SIGHT, LEAVING A LARGE PIPE EXPOSED, A PIPE WIDE ENOUGH FOR A

MAN TO SLIDE INTO.

HARRY HEARD BEN GASP AND LEEDED UP AGAIN. HE HAD MADE UP HIS MIND

WHAT HE WAS GOING TO DO.

I'M GOING DOWN THERE, HE SAID.

HE COULDN'T NOT GO, NOT NOW. THEY HAD FEELING THE ENTRANCE TO THE CHAMBER, NOT IF THERE WAS EVEN THE FAINTEST, SLIMMEST, WILDEST CHANCE THAT

GINNY MIGHT BE ALIVE.

MR. TEE, SAID BEN.

THERE WAS A PAUSE.

WELL, YOU HARDLY SEEM TO NEED ME, SAID LEEDEHART, WITH A SHADE OF HIS

HIS EYES SMILE. I'LL JUST

HE PUT HIS HAND IN THE DEEP KNIFE, BUT THEN AND HARRY KEPT
POINTED THEIR
HANDS AT HIM.

WELL CAN GO FIRST, THEN SNARLED.

WHITE-FACED AND HANDLESS, LEECHART APPROACHED THE OPENING.

REDS, HE SAID, HIS VOICE FEELER. REDS, WHAT GOOD WILL IT DO?

HARRY LARRED HIM IN THE BACK WITH HIS WAND, LEECHART SLID HIS LEGS
INTO
THE PIPE.

I REALLY DONT THINK HE STARTED THE SAY, BUT THEN GAVE HIM A
PUSH, AND

HE SLID INTO THE SIGHT, HARRY FOLLOWED QUICKLY, HE LOWERED HIMSELF
SILENTLY

INTO THE PIPE, THEN LET GO.

IT WAS LIKE RUSHING DOWN AN ENDLESS, SLIMY, DARK SLIDE. HE COULD SEE
MORE PIPES BRANCHING OFF IN ALL DIRECTIONS, BUT NONE AS LARGE AS
THEIRS,

WHICH TWISTED AND TURNED, SLEEPING STEEPLY DOWNWARD, AND HE KNEW
THAT HE

WAS FALLING DEEPER BELOW THE SURFACE THAN EVEN THE DUNGEONS,
BEHIND HIM

HE COULD HEAR THEN, THUBBING SLIGHTLY AT THE CURVES.

AND THEN, JUST AS HE HAD REELIN THE WHIRRY ABOUT WHAT WOULD
HAPPEN WHEN

HE HIT THE GROUND, THE PIPE LEVELLED OUT, AND HE SAW INTO THE END
WITH A

WET THUD, LANDING ON THE DAMP FLOOR OF A DARK STONE TUNNEL LARGE
ENOUGH THE

STAND IN, LUCIFER WAS GETTING THE HIS FEET A LITTLE WAY'S AWAY,
COVERED IN

SLIME AND WHITE AS A GHOST, HARRY STOOD ASIDE AS RON CAME
WHIZZING OUT OF

THE PIPE, THEN,

WE MUST BE MILES UNDER THE SURFACE, SAID HARRY, HIS VOICE ECHOING
IN

THE BLACK TUNNEL.

UNDER THE LAKE, PROBABLY, SAID RON, SHLINTING AROUND AT THE
DARK,

SLIMY WALLS.

ALL THREE OF THEM TURNED THE STARE INTO THE DARKNESS AHEAD,

LIMITS? HARRY MUTTERED THE HIS HAND AND IT LIT AGAIN. [THEN, HE
SAID

THE RON AND LUCIFER, AND OFF THEY WENT, THEIR FEETSTEPS SLAPPING
LOUDLY IN

THE WET FLOOR.

THE TUNNEL WAS SO DARK THAT THEY COULD ONLY SEE A LITTLE DISTANCE
AHEAD.

THEIR SHADOWS IN THE WET WALLS BEHEADED MENSTRUALS IN THE
HANDLIGHT.

REMEMBER, HARRY SAID QUIETLY AS THEY WALKED CALIBRALLY
FORWARD,

AND SIGN OF MOVEMENT, CLOSE THEIR EYES RIGHT AWAY, . . .

BUT THE TUNNEL WAS QUIET AS THE GRAVE, AND THE FIRST UNEXPECTED
SOUND

THEY HEARD WAS A LOUD CRUNCH AS RON STEPPED IN WHAT TURNED OUT
TO BE A

RAT'S SKULL, HARRY HELD HIS HAND THE LIGHT AT THE FLOOR AND SAW
THAT IT WAS

LITTERED WITH SMALL ANIMAL BONES. TRYING VERY HARD NOT TO IMAGINE
WHAT

GINDY MIGHT LOOK LIKE IF THEY FOUND HER. HARRY LED THE WAY
FORWARD.

AROUND A DARK BEND IN THE TUNNEL.

HARRY THERE'S SOMETHING UP THERE SAID RAIN HEARSLY,
CRACKING

HARRY'S SHOULDER.

THEY FREEZE, WATCHING. HARRY COULD JUST SEE THE OUTLINE OF
SOMETHING

FLICK AND CURVED, LYING RIGHT ACROSS THE TUNNEL. IT WASN'T MOVING.

MAYBE IT'S ASLEEP. HE BREATHED, GLANCING BACK AT THE EITHER TWIN.
LUCIFER'S HANDS WERE PRESSED OVER HIS EYES. HARRY TURNED BACK
TO LOOK AT

THE THING, HIS HEART BEATING SO FAST IT HURT.

VERY SILENTLY, HIS EYES AS NARROW AS HE COULD MAKE THEM AND STILL
SEE.

HARRY EDGED FORWARD, HIS WAND HELD HIGH.

THE LIGHT SLID OVER A GIGANTIC SNAKE SKIN, OF A VIVID, PIERCING
GREEN.

LYING CURLED AND EMPTY ACROSS THE TUNNEL FLOOR. THE CREATURE THAT
HAD SHED

IT MUST HAVE BEEN TWENTY FEET LONG AT LEAST.

CLIMBY, SAID RAIN WEARILY.

THERE WAS A SUDDEN MOVEMENT BEHIND THEM. GILBERT LUCIFER'S
KNEES

HAD GIVEN WAY.

GET UP, SAID RAIN SHARPLY, POINTING HIS WAND AT LUCIFER.

LEICHHART GOT THE HIS FEET THEN HE DIVED AT REIN, KNEELING HIM
THE THE

GRINDING,

HARRY LIMPED FORWARD, BUT THE LATE LEICHHART WAS
STRAIGHTENING UP,

PARTING, REIN'S WAND IN HIS HAND AND A CREAMING SMILE BACK ON HIS
FACE.

THE ADVENTURE ENDS HERE, EH? HE SAID, I SHALL TAKE A BIT OF THIS
SKIN

BACK UP THE THE SCHEM, TELL THEM I WAS THE LATE THE SAVE THE GIRL,
AND THAT YELL

THE TRAGICALLY LOST YELLER MINDS AT THE SIGHT OF HER MANGLED BODY
SAY

GOOD-BYE THE YELLER MEMORIES?

HE RAISED REIN'S SPELLTAPED WAND HIGH OVER HIS HEAD AND YELLED,

RELIVATE?

THE WAND EXPLODED WITH THE FORCE OF A SMALL BOMB, HARRY FLINGING HIS
ARMS OVER HIS HEAD AND RAN, SLIPPING OVER THE CHILDS OF SNAKE SKIN,
HELT OF THE

WAY OF GREAT CHILDS OF TUNNEL CEILING THAT WERE THUNDERING THE
THE FLOOR,

NEXT MOMENT, HE WAS STANDING ALONE, GAZING AT A SHED WALL OF
BREKEN

RECK,

REIN? HE WHISTLED, ARE YELLER EH? REIN?

I'M HERE? CAME REIN'S MUFFLED VOICE FROM BEHIND THE RECKFALL, I'M
EH? THIS GOT'S NOT, THOUGH HE GOT BLASTED BY THE WAND
THERE WAS A DULL THUD AND A LULL EH? IT SEEMED AS THOUGH REIN
HAD

JUST KICKED LEICHHART IN THE SHINS.

WHAT NOW? REEN'S VOICE SAID, SOUNDING DESPERATE. WE CAN'T GET THROUGH IT LL TAKE AGES...

HARRY LEEDED UP AT THE TUNNEL CEILING, FLICK CRACKS HAD APPEARED IN IT.

HE HAD NEVER TRIED TO BREAK APART ANYTHING AS LARGE AS THESE ROCKS BY

MAGIC, AND NOW DIDN'T SEEM A GOOD MOMENT TO TRY WHAT IF THE

TUNNEL CAVED IN?

THERE WAS ANOTHER TUNNEL AND ANOTHER WAY FROM BEHIND THE ROCKS. THEY

WERE WASTING TIME. GINNY HAD ALREADY BEEN IN THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS FOR

HOURS... HARRY KNEW THERE WAS ONLY ONE THING TO DO.

WAIT THERE, HE CALLED TO REEN. WAIT WITH LEONHART. I LL GO NOW... I,

I M NOT BACK IN AN HOUR...

THERE WAS A VERY PREGNANT PAUSE.

I LL TRY AND SHIFT SOME OF THIS ROCK, SAID REEN, WHO SEEMED TO BE TRYING

TO KEEP HIS VOICE STEADY. SEE YOU CAN CAN GET BACK THROUGH. AND, HARRY

SEE YOU IN A BIT, SAID HARRY, TRYING TO INJECT SOME CONFIDENCE INTO HIS

SHAKING VOICE.

AND HE SET OFF ALONE PAST THE GIANT SNAKE SKIN.

THEN THE DISTANT WHISPER OF REEN STRAINING TO SHIFT THE ROCKS WAS GONE. THE

TUNNEL TURNED AND TURNED AGAIN. EVERY NERVE IN HARRY'S BODY WAS TINGLING.

UNPLEASANTLY, HE WANTED THE TUNNEL TO END, YET DREADED WHAT HE MIGHT FIND

WHEN IT DID. AND THEN, AT LAST, AS HE CROPT AROUND YET ANOTHER BEND, HE SAW

A SHED WALL AHEAD OF HIM WHICH TWO ENTWINED SERPENTS WERE CARVED, THEIR EYES

SET WITH GREAT, GLINTING EMERALDS.

HARRY APPROACHED, HIS THROAT VERY DRY. THERE WAS NO NEED TO PRETEND

THESE STONE SNAKES WERE REAL; THEIR EYES LOOKED STRANGELY ALIVE.

HE COULD GUESS WHAT HE HAD TO DO. HE CLEARED HIS THROAT, AND THE EMERALD

EYES SEEMED TO FLICKER.

OPEN, SAID HARRY, IN A LOW, FAINT HISS.

THE SERPENTS PARTED AS THE WALL CRACKED OPEN, THE HALVES SLID SMOOTHLY

OUT OF SIGHT, AND HARRY, SHAKING FREELY FROM HEAD TO FOOT, WALKED INSIDE.

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CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

THE HALL OF SLOTH

HE WAS STANDING AT THE END OF A VERY LONG, DIMLY LIT CHAMBER.

THELPERING STONE PILLARS ENTWINED WITH MORE CARVED SERPENTS RESE
TE

SLIPPERY A CEILING LOST IN DARKNESS, CASTING LONG, BLACK SHADOWS
THROUGH THE

HED, GREENISH GLEAM THAT FILLED THE PLACE.

HIS HEART BEATING VERY FAST, HARRY STEAD LISTENING THE THE CHILL
SILENCE.

CHILD THE BASILISK BE BIRDING IN A SHADY CHAMBER, BEHIND A PILLAR?
AND

WHERE WAS GINNY?

HE PULLED BELT HIS HAND AND MOVED FORWARD BETWEEN THE SERPENTINE
CELLINGS. EVERY CAREFUL FEETSTEP ECHOED LOUDLY OFF THE SHADY
WALLS. HE

KEPT HIS EYES NARROWED, READY TO CLAMP THEM SHUT AT THE SMALLEST
SIGN OF

MOVEMENT. THE HIDDEN EYE SOCKETS OF THE STONE SNAKES SEEMED TO BE
FOLLOWING HIM. MORE THAN ONCE, WITH A HEAT OF THE STOMACH, HE
THOUGHT HE
SAW ONE STIR.

THEN, AS HE DREW LEVEL WITH THE LAST PAIR OF PILLARS, A STATUE HIGH
AS THE

CHAMBER ITSELF BEHEMED INTO VIEW, STANDING AGAINST THE BACK WALL.

HARRY HAD THE CRANE HIS NECK TO LOOK UP INTO THE GIANT FACE
ABOVE. IT WAS

ANCIENT AND MENDEYISH, WITH A LONG, THIN BEARD THAT FELL ALMOST TO
THE

BOTTOM OF THE WIZARD'S SLEEPING STONE REEKS, WHERE TWO ENORMOUS
GRAY

FEET STOOD IN THE SMOOTH CHAMBER FLOOR, AND BETWEEN THE FEET,
FACEDOWN,

LAY A SMALL, BLACK-THROATED FIGURE WITH FLAMING-RED HAIR.

GINNY? HARRY MUTTERED, SPRINTING TOWARD HER AND DROPPING TO HIS
KNEES.

GINNY DON'T BE DEAD PLEASE DON'T BE DEAD HE RALLING HIS
HAND

ASIDE, GRABBED GINNY'S SHOULDERS, AND TURNED HER OVER. HER FACE WAS
WHITE

AS MARBLE, AND AS CHILD, YET HER EYES WERE CLOSED, SHE SHE WASN'T
PETRIFIED.

BUT THEN SHE MUST BE

GINNY, PLEASE WAKE UP, HARRY MUTTERED DESPERATELY, SHAKING
HER.

GINNY'S HEAD BULLED HELPLESSLY FROM SIDE TO SIDE.

SHE WOULDN'T WAKE, SAID A SOFT VOICE.

HARRY ILMPED AND SPUN AROUND IN HIS KNEES.

A TALL, BLACK-HAIRED MAN WAS LEANING AGAINST THE NEAREST PILLAR,
WATCHING.

HE WAS STRANGELY ILLUMINED AROUND THE EDGES, AS THOUGH HARRY WERE
HIDING

AT HIM THROUGH A MISTED WINDOW, BUT THERE WAS NO MISTAKING HIM

THEM THEM RIDDLE?

RIDDLE NEEDED, NOT TAKING HIS EYES OFF HARRY'S FACE.

WHAT DOES THAT MEAN, SHE WOULDN'T WAKE? HARRY SAID DESPERATELY.
SHE'S NOT

SHE'S NOT ?

SHE'S STILL ALIVE, SAID RIDDLE. BUT ONLY JUST.

HARRY STARED AT HIM. THE RIDDLE HAD BEEN AT HOGWARTS FIFTY YEARS AGO,

YET HERE HE STOOD, A WEIRD, MISTY LIGHT SHINING ABOUT HIM, NOT A DAY OLDER

THAN SIXTEEN.

ARE YOU A GHOST? HARRY SAID UNCERTAINLY.

A MEMORY, SAID RIDDLE QUIETLY. PRESERVED IN A DIARY FOR FIFTY YEARS.

HE POINTED TOWARD THE FLEET NEAR THE STATUE & GIANT TREES, LYING OPEN

THERE WAS THE LITTLE BLACK DIARY HARRY HAD FOUND IN MYRTHLE &

KATHRINE. FOR A SECOND, HARRY WANDERED HOW IT HAD GET THERE BUT THERE

WERE MORE PRESSING MATTERS TO DEAL WITH.

YOU'VE GOT TO HELP ME, THEN, HARRY SAID, RAISING GINNY'S HEAD AGAIN.

WE'VE GOT TO GET HER OUT OF HERE. THERE'S A BASILISK . . . I DON'T KNOW

WHERE IT IS, BUT IT COULD BE ALONE AND MEMENTO . . . PLEASE, HELP ME

RIDDLE DIDN'T MOVE. HARRY, SWEATING, MANAGED TO HOLD GINNY HALF OFF

THE FLEET, AND KENT TO PICK UP HIS WAND AGAIN.

BUT HIS WAND HAD GONE.

DID YOU SEE ?

HE LOOKED UP. RIDDLE WAS STILL WATCHING HIM TWIRLING HARRY'S WAND

BETWEEN HIS LONG FINGERS.

THANDS, SAID HARRY, STRETCHING ELIT HIS HAND AER IT,
 A SMILE CURLED THE CORNERS OF RIDDLE'S MOUTH, HE CONTINUED THE
 STARE AT
 HARRY, TWIRLING THE WAND IDLY.
 LISTEN, SAID HARRY URGENTLY, HIS KNEES SAGGING WITH GINNY'S
 DEAD
 WEIGHT. WE'VE GOT THE CHEST IF THE BASILISK COMES
 IT WON'T COME UNTIL IT IS CALLED, SAID RIDDLE CALMLY.
 HARRY WHISPERED GINNY BACK BENEATH THE FLOOR, UNABLE TO HOLD HER LIP
 ANY
 LONGER.
 WHAT DO YOU MEAN? HE SAID. LISTEN, GIVE ME MY WAND, I MIGHT NEED
 IT
 RIDDLE'S SMILE BROADENED.
 YOU WON'T BE NEEDING IT, HE SAID.
 HARRY STARED AT HIM.
 WHAT DO YOU MEAN, I WON'T BE ?
 I'VE WAITED A LONG TIME FOR THIS, HARRY BETTER, SAID RIDDLE. FOR
 THE
 CHANCE TO SEE YOU. THE SPREAD THE YOU.
 LISTEN, SAID HARRY, LOSTING PATIENCE, I DON'T THINK YOU GET IT.
 WE'RE IN
 THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS. WE CAN TALK LATER
 WE'RE GOING TO TALK NOW, SAID RIDDLE, STILL SMILING BROADLY, AND
 HE
 PHUCKED HARRY'S WAND.

HARRY STARED AT HIM. THERE WAS SOMETHING VERY FLINNY GOING ON
HERE. . . .

HOW DID GINNY GET LIKE THIS? HE ASKED SILENTLY.

WELL, THAT'S AN INTERESTING QUESTION, SAID RIDDLE PLEASANTLY.
AND ELITE

A LONG STORY. I SUPPOSE THE REAL REASON GINNY WEASLEY'S LIKE THIS
IS BECAUSE

SHE OPENED HER HEART AND SPILLED ALL HER SECRETS TO AN INVISIBLE
STRANGER.

WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT? SAID HARRY.

THE DIARY, SAID RIDDLE. MY DIARY. LITTLE GINNY'S BEEN WRITING IN
IT FOR

MONTHS AND MONTHS, TELLING ME ALL HER PITIFUL WHISPERS AND WHIS
PERS HER

BROTHERS TEASE HER, HOW SHE HAD THE CHEMISTRY WITH
SECOND-YEAR BOYS

AND KISSES, HOW RIDDLE'S EYES GLINTED HOW SHE DIDN'T THINK
FAMOUS, GOOD, GREAT HARRY POTTER WOULD EVER LIKE HER. . . .

ALL THE TIME HE SPOKE, RIDDLE'S EYES NEVER LEFT HARRY'S FACE. THERE
WAS

AN ALMOST HUNGRY LOOK IN THEM.

IT'S VERY KEENING, HAVING TO LISTEN TO THE SILLY LITTLE TRICKLES OF
AN ELEVEN-

YEAR-OLD GIRL. HE WENT ON. BUT I WAS PATIENT. I WROTE BACK. I WAS

SYMPATHETIC. I WAS KIND. GINNY SIMPLY LOVED ME. SHE HAD'S EVER
UNDERSTOOD

ME LIKE YOU, THEN. . . . I'M SO GLAD I'VE GOTTEN THIS DIARY TO CONFIDE IN. . .
. IT'S

LIKE HAVING A FRIEND I CAN CARRY AROUND IN MY POCKET, . . .

RIDDLE LAUGHED, A HIGH, CHILD LAUGH THAT DIDN'T SLIT HIM. IT MADE THE
HAIRS

STAND UP ON THE BACK OF HARRY'S NECK.

IF I SAY IT MYSELF, HARRY, I'VE ALWAYS BEEN ABLE TO CHARM THE
PEOPLE I

NEEDED. SHE GINNY PHELOD HURT HER SHOULDERS THE MORE, AND HER SHOULDERS
HAPPENED THE MORE

EXACTLY WHAT I WANTED. . . . I GREW STRONGER AND STRONGER IN A DIRT
OF HER

DEEPEST FEARS, HER DARKEST SECRETS. I GREW POWERFUL, FAR MORE
POWERFUL THAN

LITTLE MISS WEASLEY. POWERFUL ENOUGH TO START FEEDING MISS
WEASLEY A FEW

OF MY SECRETS, TO START FEELING A LITTLE OF MY SHOULDERS BACK INTO HER . .

,

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? SAID HARRY, WHOSE MOUTH HAD GONE VERY DRY.

HAVEN'T YOU GUESSED YET, HARRY PITTER? SAID RIDDLE SILENTLY.
GINNY

WEASLEY OPENED THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS. SHE STRANDED THE SCREAM
REHEARSERS

AND DALIED THREATENING MESSAGES ON THE WALLS. SHE SET THE SERPENT
OF

SLOTHERIN ON THEIR MIDLINGS, AND THE SHOULDERS CAT.

NO, HARRY WHISPERED.

YES, SAID RIDDLE CALMLY. OF COURSE, SHE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT SHE WAS
DOING AT FIRST. IT WAS VERY AMUSING. I WISH YOU COULD HAVE SEEN
HER NOW

DIARY ENTRIES . . . FAR MORE INTERESTING, THEY BECAME. . . DEAR THEM,
HE

RECITED, WATCHING HARRY'S FRIGHTENED FACE, I THINK I'M LOSING MY
MEMORY,

THERE ARE REHESTER FEATHERS ALL OVER MY REEKS AND I DON'T KNOW
HOW THEY GET

THERE, DEAR THEM, I CAN'T REMEMBER WHAT I DID IN THE NIGHT OF
HALLOWEEN,

BUT A CAT WAS ATTACKED AND I'VE GOT PAINT ALL DOWN MY FRONT, DEAR
THEM,

PERCY KEEPS TELLING ME I'M PALE AND I'M NOT MYSELF, I THINK HE
SUSPECTS

ME. . . THERE WAS ANOTHER ATTACK TODAY AND I DON'T KNOW WHERE I
WAS, THEM,

WHAT AM I GOING TO DO? I THINK I'M GOING MAD. . . I THINK I'M THE
ONE

ATTACKING EVERYONE, THEM?

HARRY'S FISTS WERE CLENCHED, THE NAILS DIGGING DEEP INTO HIS PALMS,

IT TOOK A VERY LONG TIME FOR STUPID LITTLE GINNY TO STOP
TROLLING HER

DIARY, SAID RIDDLE, BUT SHE FINALLY BECAME SUSPICIOUS AND TRIED TO
DISPENSE OF IT, AND THAT'S WHERE YELL CAME IN, HARRY, YELL HEARD IT,
AND I

COULDN'T HAVE BEEN MORE DELIGHTED, IF ALL THE PEOPLE WHO COULD
HAVE

PICKED IT UP, IT WAS YELL, THE VERY PERSON I WAS MOST ANXIOUS TO
MEET. . .

AND WHY DID YELL WANT TO MEET ME? SAID HARRY, ANGER WAS
CHURNING

THROUGH HIM, AND IT WAS AN EFFORT TO KEEP HIS VOICE STEADY,

WELL, YOU SEE, GINNY TOLD ME ALL ABOUT YOU, HARRY, SAID RIDDLE,
YOUR

WHILE FASCINATING HISTORY. HIS EYES REVED OVER THE LIGHTNING
SCAR EN

HARRY'S THREE-HEAD, AND THEIR EXPRESSIONS GREW HUNGRIER. I KNEW I
MUST FIND

HELT MORE ABOUT YOU, TOLD THE YOU, MEET YOU IF I COULD. SHE I DECIDED
THE SHEEN

YOU MY FATHER'S CAPTURE OF THAT GREAT MAP, HAGRID, THE GAIN YOUR
TRUST

HAGRID'S MY FRIEND, SAID HARRY, HIS VOICE NOW SHAKING. AND
YOU

FRAMED HIM, DIDN'T YOU? I THOUGHT YOU MADE A MISTAKE, BUT

RIDDLE LAUGHED HIS HIGH LAUGH AGAIN.

IT WAS MY WORD AGAINST HAGRID'S, HARRY, WELL, YOU CAN IMAGINE
HOW IT

LOOKED THE OLD ARMAND'S DIPPET. IN THE ONE HAND, THE RIDDLE, THE
BUT

BRILLIANT, PARENTLESS BUT SHE BRAVE, SHEEN PERFECT, MODEL STUDENT ...
IN THE

OTHER HAND, BIG, BULDERING HAGRID, IN TRAILER EVERY OTHER WEEK,
TRYING THE

RAISE WEREWOLF CLUES UNDER HIS BED, SNEAKING OFF THE THE FORGOTTEN
FEELST THE

WRESTLE TRELLS ... BUT I ADMIT, EVEN I WAS SURPRISED HOW WELL THE
PLAN

WORKED. I THOUGHT SOMEONE MUST REALIZE THAT HAGRID COULDN'T
POSSIBLY BE

THE HEIR OF SLYTHERIN. IT HAD TAKEN ME FIVE WHOLE YEARS THE FIND
HELT

EVERYTHING I COULD ABOUT THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS AND DISCOVER THE SECRET

ENTRANCE . . . AS THOUGH HARRY HAD THE BRAINS, NOT THE POWER!

ONLY THE TRANSFIGURATION TEACHER, DUMBLEDORE, SEEMED TO THINK HARRY

WAS INNOCENT. HE PERSUADED DIPPOT THE DEEP HARRY AND TRAIN HIM AS

GAMEREPPER. YES, I THINK DUMBLEDORE MIGHT HAVE GUESSED . . .

DUMBLEDORE NEVER SEEMED TO LIKE ME AS MUCH AS THE OTHER TEACHERS DID . . .

I BET DUMBLEDORE SAW RIGHT THROUGH ME, SAID HARRY, HIS TEETH GRITTED.

WELL, HE CERTAINLY KEPT AN APPROPRIATELY CLOSE WATCH ON ME AFTER HARRY

WAS EXPELLED, SAID RIDDLE CARELESSLY. I KNEW IT WOULDN'T BE SAFE TO OPEN

THE CHAMBER AGAIN WHILE I WAS STILL AT SCHOOL, BUT I WASN'T GIVING THE WASTE

THREE LONG YEARS I'D SPENT SEARCHING FOR IT. I DECIDED TO LEAVE BEHIND A

DIARY, PRESERVING MY SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLD SELF IN ITS PAGES, SO THAT ONE DAY,

WITH LUCK, I WOULD BE ABLE TO LEAD ANOTHER IN MY FOOTSTEPS, AND FINISH

SALAZAR SLYTHERIN'S NECKLINE.

WELL, YOU HAVEN'T FINISHED IT, SAID HARRY TRIUMPHANTLY. NEITHER S DID

THIS TIME, NOT EVEN THE CAT. IN A FEW HOURS THE MANDRAGON BREATH WILL BE

READY AND EVERYONE WHO WAS PETRIFIED WILL BE ALL RIGHT AGAIN

HAVEN'T I ALREADY TOLD YOU, SAID RIDDLE QUIETLY, THAT KILLING
MURDERERS DOESN'T MATTER TO ME ANYMORE? FOR MANY MONTHS NOW,
MY NEW

TARGET HAS BEEN YOU.

HARRY STARED AT HIM.

IMAGINE HOW ANGRY I WAS WHEN THE NEXT TIME MY DIARY WAS
OPENED, IT

WAS GINNY WHO WAS WRITING TO ME, NOT YOU. SHE SAW YOU WITH THE
DIARY,

YOU SEE, AND PANICKED, WHAT IF YOU WOULD ELIT FROM THE WORK IT, AND
I

REPEATED ALL HER SECRETS TO YOU? WHAT IF, EVEN WORSE, I TOLD YOU
WHO'D BEEN

STRANGLING REMESTERS? SEE THE FOOLISH LITTLE BRAT WAITED UNTIL YOUR
DEPARTURE

WAS DESERTED AND STEAL IT BACK. BUT I KNOW WHAT I MUST DO, IT WAS
CLEAR TO

ME THAT YOU WERE ON THE TRAIL OF SLYTHERIN'S HEIR, FROM
EVERYTHING GINNY

HAD TOLD ME ABOUT YOU, I KNOW YOU WOULD GO TO ANY LENGTHS TO
SOLVE THE

MYSTERY PARTICULARLY IF ONE OF YOUR BEST FRIENDS WAS ATTACKED,
AND

GINNY HAD TOLD ME THE WHOLE SCHEME WAS KLIZZING BECAUSE YOU WOULD
SPREAD

PARSLETONGUE. . . .

SEE I MADE GINNY WRITE HER OWN FAREWELL ON THE WALL AND COME
DOWN

HERE TO WAIT. SHE STRUGGLED AND CRIED AND BECAME VERY NOISY, BUT
THERE

ISN'T MUCH LIFE LEFT IN HER. . . SHE PUT THE MUCH INTO THE DIARY,
INTO ME.

ENOUGH TO LET ME LEAVE ITS PAGES AT LAST. . . I HAVE BEEN WAITING
FOR YOU TO

APPEAR SINCE WE ARRIVED HERE. I KNOW YOU'D COME. I HAVE MANY
QUESTIONS

FOR YOU, HARRY POTTER.

LIKE WHAT? HARRY SPAT, FISTS STILL CLENCHED.

WELL, SAID RIDDLE, SMILING PLEASANTLY, HOW IS IT THAT YOU A
SKINNY

KID WITH AN EXTRAORDINARY MAGICAL TALENT MANAGED TO DEFEAT
THE GREATEST

WIZARD OF ALL TIME? HOW DID YOU ESCAPE WITH NOTHING BUT A SCAR,
WHILE

YOUR VILDEMEHT'S POWERS WERE DESTROYED?

THERE WAS AN EERIE RED GLEAM IN HIS GLIMMERING EYES NOW.

WHY DID YOU CARE HOW I ESCAPED? SAID HARRY SLEELY. VILDEMEHT
WAS

AFTER YOUR TIME. . .

VILDEMEHT, SAID RIDDLE SLEETLY, IS MY PAST, PRESENT, AND FUTURE,
HARRY

POTTER. . .

HE PULLED HARRY'S HAND FROM HIS POCKET AND BEGAN TO TRACE IT
THROUGH

THE AIR, WRITING THREE SHIMMERING WORDS:

THE MARVELOUS RIDDLE

THEN HE WAIVED THE WAND AWAY, AND THE LETTERS OF HIS NAME
REARRANGED
THEMSELVES:

I AM LORD VOLDEMORT

WELL SEE? HE WHISPERED. IT WAS A NAME I WAS ALREADY USING AT
BEECHMARTS, THE MY DEAREST INTIMATE FRIENDS ONLY, MY CHURCH. WELL THINK
I WAS

GOING THE LIKE MY FILTHY MUGGLE FATHER'S NAME FOREVER? I, IN THESE
YEARS

ALONG THE BLOOD OF SALAZAR SLYTHERIN HIMSELF, THROUGH MY
MOTHER'S SIDE? I,

KEEP THE NAME OF A FOOL, CHRISTEN MUGGLE, WHO ABANDONED ME EVEN
BEFORE

I WAS BORN, JUST BECAUSE HE FOUND OUT HIS WIFE WAS A WITCH? NO,
HARRY I

FASHIONED MYSELF A NEW NAME, A NAME I KNEW WIZARDS EVERYWHERE
WOULD

HAVE DAY FEAR THE SPEAK, WHEN I HAD BECOME THE GREATEST SHREWER IN
THE

WORLD?

HARRY'S BRAIN SEEMED TO HAVE JAMMED, HE STARED BLINKING AT RIDDLE,
AT

THE HYPHANTED MAN WHO HAD GROWN UP THE MURDER HARRY'S OWN
PARENTS, AND SEE

MANY OTHERS, . . . AT LAST HE FORCED HIMSELF THE SPEAK,

WELL BE NEET, HE SAID, HIS EYES FULL OF HATRED,

NEET WHAT? SNAPPED RIDDLE.

NOT THE GREATEST SORCERER IN THE WORLD, SAID HARRY, BREATHING FAST.

HARRY THE DISAPPOINTED YELL AND ALL THAT, BUT THE GREATEST WIZARD IN THE WORLD

IS ALBUS DUMBLEDORE. EVERYONE SAYS SO. EVEN WHEN YELL WERE STRONG, YELL

DIDN'T DARE TRY AND TAKE HER AT HOGWARTS. DUMBLEDORE SAW THROUGH YELL

WHEN YELL WERE AT SCHOOL AND HE STILL FRIGHTENS YELL NOW, WHEREVER YELL ARE

HIDING THESE DAYS

THE SMILE HAD GONE FROM RIDDLE'S FACE, THE ONE REPLACED BY A VERY LONELY LOOK.

DUMBLEDORE'S BEEN DRIVEN OUT OF THIS CASTLE BY THE MERE MEMORY OF ME? HE HISSED.

HE'S NOT AS GOOD AS YELL MIGHT THINK? HARRY RETORTED. HE WAS SPEAKING

AT RANDOM, WANTING THE SCARY RIDDLE, WISHING RATHER THAN BELIEVING IT THE ONE

TRUE

RIDDLE OPENED HIS MOUTH, BUT FREEZE.

MUSIC WAS COMING FROM SOMEWHERE. RIDDLE WHIRLED AROUND THE STARE DOWN THE EMPTY CHAMBER. THE MUSIC WAS GROWING LOUDER. IT WAS Eerie,

SPINE-TINGLING, UNNATURALLY; IT LIFTED THE HAIR ON HARRY'S SCALP AND MADE HIS

HEART FEEL AS THOUGH IT WAS SWELLING THE TWICE ITS NORMAL SIZE. THEN, AS THE

MUSIC REACHED SUCH A PITCH THAT HARRY FELT IT VIBRATING INSIDE HIS
EARS RISE,

FLAMES ERUPTED AT THE TOP OF THE NEAREST PILLAR.

A CRIMSON BIRD THE SIZE OF A SWAN HAD APPEARED, PIPING ITS WEIRD
MUSIC

THEY VALIANTLY CEILING, IT HAD A GLITTERING GOLDEN TAIL AS LONG AS A
PEACHES

AND GLIMMERING GOLDEN TAILFEATHERS, WHICH WERE GRIPPING A RAGGED BLIND.

A SECOND LATER, THE BIRD WAS FLYING STRAIGHT AT HARRY. IT DROPPED
THE

RAGGED THING IT WAS CARRYING AT HIS FEET, THEN LANDED HEAVILY ON
HIS

SHOULDER. AS IT FOLDED ITS GREAT WINGS, HARRY LEANED UP AND SAW IT
HAD A

LONG, SHARP GOLDEN BEAK AND A BOLD BLACK EYE.

THE BIRD STOPPED SINGING. IT SAT STILL AND WARM NEXT TO HARRY'S
CHEEK,

GAZING STEADILY AT RIDDLE.

THAT'S A PHOENIX, ... SAID RIDDLE, STARING STAREWILDLY BACK AT IT.

FAWKS? HARRY BREATHED, AND HE FELT THE BIRD'S GOLDEN CLAWS
SHIVER

HIS SHOULDER GENTLY.

AND THAT SAID RIDDLE, WHEN EYING THE RAGGED THING THAT
FAWKS HAD

DROPPED, THAT'S THE OLD SCHEMEL SHUTTING THAT

SEE IT WAS, PATCHED, PRAYED, AND DIRTY, THE HAT LAY MENTHERLESS AT
HARRY'S

FEET.

RIDDLE BEGAN TO LAUGH AGAIN, HE LAUGHED SEE HARD THAT THE DARK
CHAMBER

RANG WITH IT, AS THOUGH TEN RIDDLES WERE LAUGHING AT HIM

THIS IS WHAT DUMBLEDORE SENDS HIS DEFENDER? A STUNGER AND AN OLD
HAT? DO YOU FEEL BRAVE, HARRY POTTER? DO YOU FEEL SAFE NOW?
HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER, HE MIGHT NOT SEE WHAT LIE FALLOWS HIM THE
SHIRTING

HAT WERE, BUT HE WAS NOW LINGER ALONE, AND HE WAITED FOR RIDDLE THE
STEP

LAUGHING WITH HIS COURAGE MELTING.

THE BUSINESS, HARRY, SAID RIDDLE, STILL SMILING BROADLY. TWICE
IN

YOUR PAST, IN MY FUTURE WE HAVE MET. AND TWICE I FAILED THE KILL
YOU, HARRY

DID YOU SURVIVE? TELL ME EVERYTHING. THE LINGER YOU TALK, HE
ADDED SHORTLY,

THE LINGER YOU STAY ALIVE.

HARRY WAS THINKING FAST, WEIGHING HIS CHANCES. RIDDLE HAD THE
WAND, HE

HARRY, HAD FALLOWS AND THE SHIRTING HAT, NEITHER OF WHICH WOULD
BE MUCH

GOOD IN A DUEL. IT SEEMED BAD, ALL RIGHT . . . BUT THE LINGER RIDDLE
STOOD

THERE, THE MORE LIFE WAS DIMINISHING BUT OF GINNY . . . AND IN THE
MEANTIME,

HARRY NOTICED SUDDENLY, RIDDLE'S OUTLINE WAS BECOMING CLEARER,
MORE

SHARP. . . IF IT HAD THE BE A FIGHT BETWEEN HIM AND RIDDLE, BETTER
SEEMER THAN

LATER,

THEY HAD KNOWN WHY THEY HAD LEFT THEIR PARENTS WHEN THEY ATTACKED ME, SAID

HARRY ABRUPTLY. I DIDN'T KNOW MYSELF, BUT I KNOW WHY THEY CHOOSE TO KILL

ME, BECAUSE MY MOTHER DIED TO SAVE ME. MY CUNTEN MUGGLE-BORN MOTHER, HE ADDED, SHAKING WITH SUPPRESSED RAGE. SHE STOPPED THEM KILLING

ME, AND I'VE SEEN THE REAL THEM, I SAW THEM LAST YEAR, THEY'RE A WRECK, THEY'RE

RARELY ALIVE. THAT'S WHERE ALL THEIR POWER GETS THEM, THEY'RE IN HIDING, THEY'RE

WEAK, THEY'RE FEEL

RIDDLE'S FACE CHANGED, THEN HE FORCED IT INTO AN AWFUL SMILE,

SEE, THEIR MOTHER DIED TO SAVE THEM, YES, THAT'S A POWERFUL CHANTER-

CHARM, I CAN SEE THEM... THERE IS NOTHING SPECIAL ABOUT THEM, AFTER ALL, I

WONDERED, THEY SEE, BECAUSE THERE ARE STRANGE LIKENESSES BETWEEN US, HARRY

BETTER, EVEN THEY MUST HAVE NOTICED, BOTH HALF-BLOODS, HERPAINS, RAISED BY

MUGGLES. PROBABLY THE ONLY TWO PARSELMOUTHS THE CHIEF THE HOGWARTS SINCE

THE GREAT SLYTHERIN HIMSELF, WE EVEN LOOK SOMETHING ALIKE... BUT AFTER

ALL, IT WAS MERELY A LUCKY CHANCE THAT SAVED THEM FROM ME, THAT'S ALL I

WANTED THE KNELL.

HARRY STEED, TENSE, WAITING FOR RIDDLE TO RAISE HIS HAND, BUT
RIDDLE'S

TWISTED SMILE WAS WIDENING AGAIN.

NEED, HARRY, I'M GIVING THE TRICKY YELL A LITTLE LESSON. LET'S MATCH
THE

POWERS OF LORD VOLDEMORT, HEIR OF SALAZAR SLYTHERIN, AGAINST
FAMOUS

HARRY POTTER, AND THE BEST WEAPONS DUMBLEDORE CAN GIVE HIM. . . .

HE CAST AN AMUSED EYE OVER FALCONES AND THE SHIRTING HAT, THEN
WALKED

AWAY. HARRY, FEAR SPREADING UP HIS NUMB LEGS, WATCHED RIDDLE STEP
BETWEEN THE HIGH PILLARS AND WEND UP INTO THE STONE FACE OF
SLYTHERIN, HIGH

ABOVE HIM IN THE HALF-DARKNESS. RIDDLE OPENED HIS MOUTH WIDE AND
HISSED

BUT HARRY UNDERSTOOD WHAT HE WAS SAYING. . . .

SPEAK THE ME, SLYTHERIN, GREATEST OF THE HOGWARTS PEER.

HARRY WHEELED AROUND THE WEND UP AT THE STATUE, FALCONES SLAYING
HIM HIS

SEMI-DEAD.

SLYTHERIN'S GIGANTIC STONE FACE WAS MOVING. JERKING, JERKING,
HARRY SAW HIS

MOUTH OPENING, WIDER AND WIDER, THEN MADE A HUGE BLACK HOLE.

AND SOMETHING WAS STIRRING INSIDE THE STATUE'S MOUTH. SOMETHING
WAS

SLITHERING UP FROM ITS DEPTHS.

HARRY RAN AWAY UNTIL HE HIT THE DARK CHAMBER WALL, AND AS HE
FELL

HIS EYES TIGHT HE FELT FALDER'S WING SWEEP HIS CHEEK AS HE THREW
FLIGHT.

HARRY WANTED THE SHIRT, DIDN'T LEAVE ME? BUT WHAT CHANCE DID A
PHEENIX

HAVE AGAINST THE KING OF SERPENTS?

SOMETHING FLICK HIT THE STONE FLOOR OF THE CHAMBER, HARRY FELT IT
SHLIDDER

HE KNEW WHAT WAS HAPPENING, HE COULD SENSE IT, COULD ALMOST
SEE THE

GIANT SERPENT UNCOILING ITSELF FROM SLYTHERIN'S MOUTH. THEN HE
HEARD

RIDDLE'S HISsing voice:

KILL HIM.

THE BASILISK WAS MOVING TOWARD HARRY; HE COULD HEAR ITS HEAVY
BODY

SLITHERING HEAVILY ACROSS THE DUSTY FLOOR. EYES STILL TIGHTLY SHUT,
HARRY

BEGAN THE RUN BLINDLY SIDEWAYS, HIS HANDS FLUTTERSTRETCHED, FEELING HIS
WAY

VERBEMENT WAS LAUGHING

HARRY TRIPPED, HE FELL HARD INTO THE STONE AND TASTED BLEED THE

SERPENT WAS BARELY FEET FROM HIM, HE COULD HEAR IT CREEPING

THERE WAS A MILD, EXPLOSIVE SPITTING SOUND RIGHT ABOVE HIM, AND
THEN

SOMETHING HEAVY HIT HARRY HE HAD THAT HE WAS SMASHED INTO THE
WALL.

WAITING FOR FANGS TO SINK THROUGH HIS BODY, HE HEARD MORE MAD
HISsing,

SOMETHING THRASHING WILDLY OFF THE PILLARS

HE COULDN'T HELP IT. HE OPENED HIS EYES WIDE ENOUGH TO SEE WHAT
AT WHAT

WAS GOING ON.

THE ENORMOUS SERPENT, BRIGHT, PHEASANT GREEN, THICK AS AN OAK
TRUNK,

HAD RAISED ITSELF HIGH IN THE AIR AND ITS GREAT BLIND HEAD WAS
WEAVING

DRUNKENLY BETWEEN THE PILLARS. AS HARRY TREMBLED, READY TO CLOSE
HIS EYES

IF IT TURNED, HE SAW WHAT HAD DISTRACTED THE SNAKE.

FALCON WAS SHARING AROUND ITS HEAD, AND THE BASTARD WAS
SNAPPING

FLURRIEDLY AT HIM WITH FANGS LONG AND THIN AS SWORDS

FALCON DIVERGED. HIS LONG CHISEL BEAK SAND HIT HIS SIGHT AND A SLIDING
SHOWER OF DARK BLOOD SPATTERED THE FLOOR. THE SNAKE'S TAIL
THRASHED,

NARROWLY MISSING HARRY, AND BEFORE HARRY COULD SHUT HIS EYES, IT
TURNED

HARRY LUNGED STRAIGHT INTO ITS FACE AND SAW THAT ITS EYES, BOTH ITS
GREAT,

BLINDLY YELLOW EYES, HAD BEEN PUNCTURED BY THE PHOENIX; BLOOD WAS
STREAMING THE FLOOR, AND THE SNAKE WAS SPITTING IN AGONY.

NEE! HARRY HEARD RIDDLE SCREAMING. LEAVE THE BIRD! LEAVE
THE BIRD! THE BIRD IS BEHIND YOU! YOU CAN STILL SPEAK
HIM!

KILL HIM!

THE BLIND SERPENT SLAYED, CHOKED, STILL DEADLY. FALCON WAS
CIRCLING

ITS HEAD, PIPING HIS PERIODIC SING, LARKING HERE AND THERE AT ITS SCALY
NECK AS

THE BLIND FELT ITS BLIND EYES.

HELP ME, HELP ME, HARRY MUTTERED WILDLY, SOMETHING ANYTHING

THE SNAKE'S TAIL WHIPPED ACROSS THE FLOOR AGAIN. HARRY BLINKED.
SOMETHING SOFT HIT HIS FACE.

THE BASILISK HAD SWIFTLY THROWN HAT INTO HARRY'S ARMS.
HARRY SEIZED

IT. IT WAS ALL HE HAD LEFT, HIS ONLY CHANCE. HE RAMMED IT BENTH HIS
HEAD AND

THREW HIMSELF FLAT BENTH THE FLOOR AS THE BASILISK'S TAIL SWUNG
OVER HIM

AGAIN.

HELP ME HELP ME HARRY THOUGHT, HIS EYES SCREAMED TIGHT
UNDER THE

HAT. PLEASE HELP ME

THERE WAS NO ANSWERING VOICE. INSTEAD, THE HAT CONTRACTED, AS
THOUGH AN

INVISIBLE HAND WAS SQUEEZING IT VERY TIGHTLY.

SOMETHING VERY HARD AND HEAVY THROD BENTH THE TOP OF HARRY'S
HEAD,

ALMOST CRUSHING HIM FLAT. STARS WINKING IN FRONT OF HIS EYES, HE
GRABBED

THE TOP OF THE HAT TO PULL IT OFF AND FELT SOMETHING LONG AND HARD
BENEATH IT.

A GLAMING SILVER SWORD HAD APPEARED INSIDE THE HAT, ITS HANDLE
GLITTERING WITH RUBIES THE SIZE OF EGGS.

KILL THE BIRD! LEAVE THE BIRD! THE BIRD IS BEHIND YOU!
SNIFF SNIFF HIM!

LEARRY WAS ON HIS FEET, READY. THE BASILISK'S HEAD WAS FALLING, ITS
BODY

WHIRLING AROUND, HITTING PILLARS AS IT TWISTED THE FACE HIM. HE COULD
SEE THE

VAST, BLEEDY EYE SOCKETS, SEE THE MOUTH STRETCHING WIDE, WIDE
ENOUGH THE

SWALLOW HIM WHOLE, LINED WITH FANGS LONG AS HIS SWORD, THIN,
GLITTERING,

VENOMOUS

IT LINGERED BLINDLY LEARRY DODGED AND IT HIT THE CHAMBER WALL. IT
LINGERED

AGAIN, AND ITS FURLED TONGUE LASHED LEARRY'S SIDE. HE RAISED THE
SWORD IN

WITH HIS HANDS

THE BASILISK LINGERED AGAIN, AND THIS TIME ITS AIM WAS TRUE
LEARRY THREW

HIS WHOLE WEIGHT BEHIND THE SWORD AND DROVE IT THE THE HILT INTO
THE REEF OF

THE SERPENT'S MOUTH

BUT AS WARM BLOOD DRENCHED LEARRY'S ARMS, HE FELT A SEARING PAIN
LIST

ABOVE HIS KNEE. ONE LONG, PISHISHISH FANG WAS SINKING DEEPER AND
DEEPER

INTO HIS ARM AND IT SPLINTERED AS THE BASILISK KEELER OVER SIDEWAYS
AND FELL,

TWITCHING, THE THE FLESH.

LEARRY SLID DOWN THE WALL. HE GRIPPED THE FANG THAT WAS SPREADING
PISHISH

THROUGH HIS BODY AND WRENCHED IT OUT OF HIS ARM. BUT HE KNEW IT
WAS THE

LATE, WHITE-FEET PAIN WAS SPREADING SLOWLY AND STEADILY FROM THE
WOUND,

EVEN AS HE DROPPED THE FANG AND WATCHED HIS BLOOD SHAKING
HIS REEKS,

HIS VISION WENT FOGGY, THE CLAMOR WAS DISSOLVING IN A WHIRL OF
BLIND CHAOS,

A PATCH OF SCARLET SLAM PAST, AND HARRY HEARD A SHOT CLATTER OF
CLAWS

BEHIND HIM,

FALDRES, SAID HARRY THICKLY, YELL WERE FANTASTIC, FALDRES, ... HE
FELT

THE BIRD LAY ITS BEAUTIFUL HEAD ON THE SPOT WHERE THE SERPENT'S
FANG HAD

PIERCED HIM,

HE COULD HEAR FLEETING FEETSTEPS AND THEN A DARK SHADE MOVED IN
FRONT

OF HIM,

YELL BE DEAD, HARRY PITTER, SAID RIDDLE'S VOICE ABOVE HIM, DEAD,

EVEN DUMBLEDORE'S BIRD KNOWS IT, DIE YELL SEE WHAT HE'S DOING,
PITTER?

HE'S CRYING,

HARRY BLINKED, FALDRES'S HEAD SLID IN AND FELT HIS PULS, THICK,
PEARLY

TEARS WERE TRICKLING DOWN THE GLOSSY FEATHERS,

I'M GOING TO SIT HERE AND WATCH YOU DIE, HARRY PITTER, TAKE
YOUR TIME,

I'M IN A HURRY,

HARRY FELT DREARILY, EVERYTHING AROUND HIM SEEMED TO BE SPINNING,

SHE ENDS THE FAMILIAR HARRY PITTER, SAID RIDDLE'S DISTANT VOICE,
ALONE

IN THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, BETRAYED BY HIS FRIENDS, DEFEATED AT LAST
BY THE

DARK LORD HE SHE LINEARLY CHALLENGED, WHO WAS BACK WITH THEIR
DEAR

MURDERED MOTHER SEEN, HARRY, . . . SHE BELIEVED WHO TWELVE YEARS OF
REVERSED TIME . . . BUT LORD VOLDEMORT GOT WHO IN THE END, AS WHO
KNEW HE
MIST, . . .

IF THIS IS DYING, TWELVE HARRY, IT'S NOT SHE BAD,
EVEN THE PAIN WAS LEAVING HIM, . . .

BUT WAS THIS DYING? INSTEAD OF GOING BLACK, THE CHAMBER SEEMED THE
BE

COMING BACK INTO WHO, HARRY GAVE HIS HEAD A LITTLE SHAKE AND
THERE WAS

PAIDES, STILL RESTING HIS HEAD ON HARRY'S ARM, A PEARLY PATCH OF
TEARS WAS

SHINING ALL AROUND THE WHOLE EXCEPT THAT THERE WAS NO WHOLE

GET AWAY, KID, SAID RIDDLE'S VOICE SUDDENLY, GET AWAY FROM HIM
I

SAID, GET AWAY

HARRY RAISED HIS HEAD, RIDDLE WAS POINTING HARRY'S HAND AT
PAIDES;

THERE WAS A BANG LIKE A GUN, AND PAIDES TOOK FLIGHT AGAIN IN A
WHIRL OF

GREEN AND SCARLET.

PERFECT TEARS . . . SAID RIDDLE QUIETLY, STARING AT HARRY'S ARM,
HE

WHOLE . . . HEALING POWERS . . . I FORGET . . .

HE WHIPPED INTO HARRY'S FACE. BUT IT MAKES NO DIFFERENCE. IN FACT, I
PREFER IT THIS WAY. JUST YOU AND ME, HARRY POTTER . . . YOU AND ME . . .

HE RAISED THE WAND

THEN, IN A FLASH OF WINGS, FALCONES HAD SHARED BACK OVERHEAD AND
SOMETHING FELL INTO HARRY'S LAP THE DIARY.

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, BOTH HARRY AND RIDDLE, WAND STILL RAISED, STARED
AT IT.

THEN, WITHOUT THINKING, WITHOUT CONSIDERING, AS THOUGH HE HAD
MEANT THE DEE

IT ALL ALONG, HARRY SEIZED THE BASILISK FANG IN THE FLESH NEXT TO
HIM AND

PLUNGED IT STRAIGHT INTO THE HEART OF THE BEAST.

THERE WAS A LONG, DREADFUL, PIERCING SCREAM. IND SPLUTTERED OUT OF
THE DIARY

IN THERRENTS, STREAMING OVER HARRY'S HANDS, BLEEDING THE FLESH.
RIDDLE WAS

WRITHING AND TWISTING, SCREAMING AND FLAILING AND THEN

HE HAD GONE. HARRY'S WAND FELL TO THE FLESH WITH A CLATTER AND
THERE WAS

SILENCE. SILENCE EXCEPT FOR THE STEADY DRIP DRIP OF IND STILL BEEZING
FROM THE

DIARY. THE BASILISK VENOM HAD BURST A SIZZLING HOLE RIGHT
THROUGH IT.

SHAKING ALL OVER, HARRY PULLED HIMSELF UP. HIS HEAD WAS SPINNING
AS

THOUGH HE DIDN'T TRAVEL MILES OF FLESH POWDER. SLEEPLY, HE
GATHERED

TOGETHER HIS WAND AND THE SHEDDING FLAT, AND, WITH A FLICK OF
RETRIEVED THE

GLITTERING SWORD FROM THE MOUTH OF THE BASILISK'S MOUTH.

THEN CAME A FAINT MEAN FROM THE END OF THE CHAMBER. GINNY WAS STIRRING. AS HARRY HURRIED TOWARD HER, SHE SAT UP, HER REMISED EYES

TRAVELED FROM THE FLICK FROM OF THE DEAD BASILISK, EVER HARRY, IN HIS BLEED-

SHAKED REELS, THEN THE THE DIARY IN HIS HAND. SHE DREW A GREAT, SHLIDDERING

CASP AND TEARS BEGAN THE PULLER DOWN HER FACE.

HARRY HEY, HARRY I TRIED THE TELL YOU AT B-BREAKFAST, BUT I C-CHILDEN T

SAY IT IN FRONT OF PERCY IT WAS ME, HARRY BUT I I S-SWEAR I D-DIDN T

MEAN THE R-RIDDLE MADE ME, HE T-THINK ME EVER AND HOW DID YOU

KILL THAT THAT THING? W-WHERE'S RIDDLE? THE LAST THING I R-REMEMBER IS

HIM CHIMING ME THE DIARY

IT'S ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY, HOLDING UP THE DIARY, AND STEERING GINNY THE

PANG FEEL. RIDDLE'S FINISHED, LEAVE HIM AND THE BASILISK, I MEAN, GINNY,

LET'S GET OUT OF HERE

I'M GOING TO BE EXPELLED! GINNY WEPT AS HARRY HELPED HER AWKWARDLY

THE HER FEET. I'VE LOOKED FORWARD THE CHIMING THE H-HOGWARTS EVER SINCE B-BILL

CAME AND N-NOW I LL HAVE THE LEAVE AND W-WHAT LL MUM AND DAD SAY?

FALDOES WAS WAITING FOR THEM, HEEVERING IN THE CHAMBER ENTRANCE, HARRY

LURGED GINNY FORWARD; THEY STEPPED OVER THE MOUTHLESS CHILDS OF THE DEAD

BASILISK, THROUGH THE ECHING GLEAM, AND BACK INTO THE TUNNEL, HARRY HEARD

THE STONE DOORS CLOSE BEHIND THEM WITH A SOFT HISS,

AFTER A FEW MINUTES PROGRESS UP THE DARK TUNNEL, A DISTANT SOUND OF

SLIDING SHIFTING ROCK REACHED HARRY S EARS,

REIN? HARRY YELLED, SPEEDING UP, GINNY S HEAD? I VE GOT HER? HE HEARD REIN GIVE A STRANGLED CHEER, AND THEY TURNED THE NEXT BEND THE

SEE HIS RAGER FACE STARING THROUGH THE SIZABLE GAP HE HAD MANAGED THE MAKE

IN THE ROCKFALL,

GINNY? REIN THRUST AN ARM THROUGH THE GAP IN THE ROCK THE PULL HER

THROUGH FIRST, SHELL BE ALIVE? I DONT BELIEVE IT? WHAT HAPPENED? SHELL

WHAT WERE DID THAT BIRD COME FROM?

FALDOES HAD SLIDDED THROUGH THE GAP AFTER GINNY,

HE S DIMPLED HERE S, SAID HARRY, SQUEEZING THROUGH HIMSELF,

SHELL COME SHELL VE GOT A SWORD? SAID REIN, GASPING AT THE GLITTERING

WEAPON IN HARRY S HAND,

I LL EXPLAIN WHEN WE GET HELT OF HERE, SAID HARRY WITH A SIDEWAYS

GLANCE AT GINNY, WHO WAS CRYING HARDER THAN EVER.

BLIT

LATER, HARRY SAID SHORTLY, HE DIDN'T THINK IT WAS A GOOD IDEA TO TELL

REIN YET WHO'D BEEN OPENING THE CHAMBER, NOT IN FRONT OF GINNY, ANYWAY.

WHERE'S LUCIFERTY?

BACK THERE, SAID REIN, STILL LOOKING PUZZLED BLIT TUCKING HIS HEAD UP THE

TUNNEL TOWARD THE PIPE. HE'S IN A BAD WAY, COME AND SEE.

LED BY FALDOES, WHOSE WIDE SCARLET WINGS EMITTED A SOFT GILDED GLOW IN

THE DARKNESS, THEY WALKED ALL THE WAY BACK TO THE MOUTH OF THE PIPE.

GILDERHOY LUCIFERTY WAS SITTING THERE, HUMMING PLACIDLY TO HIMSELF.

HIS MEMORY'S GONE, SAID REIN. THE MEMORY CHARM BACKFIRED, HIT HIM INSTEAD OF LIS. HASN'T GOTTEN A CLUE WHO HE IS, OR WHERE HE IS, OR WHO WE

ARE. I TOLD HIM TO COME AND WAIT HERE. HE'S A DANGER TO HIMSELF.

LUCIFERTY PEERED GOOD-NATUREDLY UP AT THEM ALL.

WELL, HE SAID. HODD SHORT OF PLACE, THIS, ISN'T IT? DO YOU YELL LIVE HERE?

NO, SAID REIN, RAISING HIS EYEBROWS AT HARRY.

HARRY BENT DOWN AND LOOKED UP THE LONG, DARK PIPE.

HAVE YOU THOUGHT HOW WE'RE GOING TO GET BACK UP THIS? HE SAID TO

REIN.

REIN SHOOK HIS HEAD, BLIT FALDOES THE PHOENIX HAD SLEEPS PAST HARRY

AND WAS NOW FLUTTERING IN FRONT OF HIM, HIS BOLD EYES BRIGHT IN THE DARK.

HE WAS WAVING HIS LONG CHILDEN TAIL FEATHERS, HARRY LOOKED UNCERTAINLY AT

HIM.

HE LOOKS LIKE HE WANTS YOU TO GRAB HIM . . . SAID BEN, LOOKING PERPLEXED. BUT YOU'RE MUCH TOO HEAVY FOR A BIRD TO PICK UP THERE

FASTER, SAID HARRY, ISN'T AN ORDINARY BIRD. HE TURNED SWIFTLY THE OTHER

WINGS. WE'VE GOT THE HIM IN THE EACH OTHER, GINNY, GRAB BEN'S HAND.

PROFESSOR LOCKHART

HE MEANS YOU, SAID BEN SHARPLY TO LOCKHART.

YOU'VE GOT GINNY'S OTHER HAND

HARRY TOOK THE SWORD AND THE SHIRTING HAT INTO HIS BELT, BEN THREW HIM

ON THE BACK OF HARRY'S NECK, AND HARRY REACHED OUT AND THREW HIM

FASTER'S STRANGELY FEET TAIL FEATHERS.

AN EXTRAORDINARY LIGHTNESS SEEMED TO SPREAD THROUGH HIS WHOLE BODY

AND THE NEXT SECOND, IN A FLASH OF WINGS, THEY WERE FLYING UPWARD THROUGH

THE PIPE. HARRY COULD HEAR LOCKHART DANGLING BELOW HIM, SAYING,

AMAZING! AMAZING! THIS IS JUST LIKE MAGIC! THE COLD AIR WAS WHIPPING

THROUGH HARRY'S HAIR, AND BEFORE HE'D STOPPED KNOWING THE RIDE, IT WAS

EVERY ALL FEELER OF THEM WERE HITTING THE WET FLOOR OF MEANING MYRTLE'S

BATHROOM, AND AS LUCIFERT STRAIGHTENED HIS HAT, THE SINK THAT HAD THE PIPE

WAS SLIDING BACK INTO PLACE.

MYRTLE GEELED AT THEM.

THEY'RE ALIVE, SHE SAID BLANDLY TO HARRY.

THERE'S NO NEED TO FEELING SHE DISAPPOINTED, HE SAID GRIMLY, WIPING

FLICKS OF BLOOD AND SLIME OFF HIS GLASSES.

HEH, WELL . . . I'D JUST BEEN THINKING . . . IF THEY HAD DIED, THEY'D HAVE BEEN

WELCHER THE SHARE OF THEFT, SAID MYRTLE, BELLISHING SILVER.

LUCIFERT SAID THEN AS THEY LEFT THE BATHROOM FOR THE DARK, DESERTED HALLWAY HILLSIDE. HARRY: I THINK MYRTLE'S GREEN AND OF THEM: THEY'VE GOT

COMPETITION, GINNY:

BUT TEARS WERE STILL FLOODING SILENTLY DOWN GINNY'S FACE.

WHERE NEXT? SAID THEN, WITH AN ANXIOUS LEER AT GINNY, HARRY PHINTED.

FALDER WAS LEADING THE WAY, CLEVERING GROUND ALONG THE HALLWAY. THEY

STRODE AFTER HIM, AND MOMENTS LATER, FINDING THEMSELVES HILLSIDE PROFESSOR

MCGINNACALL'S OFFICE.

HARRY KNEELED AND POLISHED THE DEER HORN.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

DEEPLY S REWARD

FOR A MOMENT THERE WAS SILENCE AS HARRY, RON, GINNY, AND
LUCIFER

STOOD IN THE HALLWAY, COVERED IN MILK AND SLIME AND (IN HARRY'S
CASE) BLOOD. THEN THERE WAS A SCREAM.

GINNY!

IT WAS MRS. WEASLEY, WHO HAD BEEN SITTING CRYING IN FRONT OF THE
FIRE. SHE

LEAPT TO HER FEET, CLOSELY FOLLOWED BY MR. WEASLEY, AND BOTH OF THEM
FELL

THEMSELVES ON THEIR DAUGHTER.

HARRY, HOWEVER, WAS RUNNING PAST THEM. PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WAS
STANDING BY THE MANTELPIECE, BEAMING, NEXT TO PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL, WHO

WAS TAKING GREAT, STRADDLING GASPS, CLUTCHING HER CHEST. PALMS
WENT

WHIZZING PAST HARRY'S EAR AND SETTLED ON DUMBLEDORE'S SHOULDER,
JUST AS

HARRY FELT HIMSELF AND RON BEING SWEEPED INTO MRS. WEASLEY'S
TIGHT

EMBRACE.

YOU SAVED HER! YOU SAVED HER! WHEN DID YOU DO IT?

I THINK WE'D ALL LIKE TO KNOW THAT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL
WEARILY.

MRS. LEASLEY LET GO OF HARRY, WHO HESITATED FOR A MOMENT, THEN
WALKED

OVER THE DESK AND LAID UPON IT THE SHIRTING BLOT, THE RUBY-
ENCRUSTED

SWORD, AND WHAT REMAINED OF RIDDLE'S DIARY.

THEN HE STARTED TELLING THEM EVERYTHING, FOR NEARLY A QUARTER OF
AN HOUR

HE SPoke INTO THE RAPT SILENCE: HE TOLD THEM ABOUT HEARING THE
DISMEMBERED

VOICE, HOW FERMINE HAD FINALLY REALIZED THAT HE WAS HEARING A
BASILISK IN

THE PIPES; HOW HE AND BEN HAD FOLLOWED THE SPIDERS INTO THE
FOREST, THAT

ARACHE HAD TOLD THEM WHERE THE LAST VICTIM OF THE BASILISK HAD
DIED; HOW

HE HAD GUESSED THAT MARIANNE MYRTLE HAD BEEN THE VICTIM, AND THAT
THE

ENTRANCE TO THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS MIGHT BE IN HER BATHROOM, . . .

VERY WELL, PROFESSOR MCKINACALL PREEMPTED HIM AS HE PAUSED,
SHE WENT

BEHIND HIM WHERE THE ENTRANCE WAS BREAKING A HUNDRED STEEL
RULES INTO

PIECES ALONG THE WAY, I MIGHT ADD BUT HOW HER EARTH DID GO ALL
GET HIM

IF THERE ALIVE, BETTER?

SHE HARRY, HIS VOICE NOW GROWING HARSH FROM ALL THIS TALKING,
TOLD THEM

ABOUT FALDORE'S TIMELY ARRIVAL AND ABOUT THE SHIRTING BLOT GIVING
HIM THE

SWORD, BUT THEN HE FALTERED, HE HAD SHE FAR AVOIDED MENTIONING
RIDDLE'S

DIARY HER CINNY. SHE WAS STANDING WITH HER HEAD AGAINST MRS. WEASLEY'S

SHOULDER, AND TEARS WERE STILL CHURSTING SILENTLY DOWN HER CHEEKS. WHAT IF

THEY EXPULSED HER? HARRY FLASHLIGHT IN PANIC. RIDDLE'S DIARY DIDN'T

ANYWHERE. . . . WHEN WOULD THEY PROVE IT HAD BEEN HE WHO'D MADE HER

ALL?

INSTINCTIVELY, HARRY LOOKED AT DUMBLEDORE, WHO SMILED FAINTLY, THE

WHAT INTERESTS ME MOST, SAID DUMBLEDORE GENTLY, IS HOW LORD

CURRENTLY IN HIDING IN THE FORESTS OF ALBANIA.

RELIEF WARM, SWEEPING, GLORIOUS RELIEF SWIFT OVER HARRY.

WHAT'S THAT? SAID MR. WEASLEY IN A STUNNED VOICE. WHY-

EN-ENCHANT CINNY? BUT CINNY'S NOT . . . CINNY HASN'T BEEN . . . HAS

IT WAS THIS DIARY, SAID HARRY QUICKLY, PICKING IT UP AND

DUMBLEDORE. RIDDLE WROTE IT WHEN HE WAS SIXTEEN. . . .

DUMBLEDORE TOOK THE DIARY FROM HARRY AND PEERED DEEPLY DOWN HIS

BRIGHT, HE SAID SILENTLY. OF COURSE, HE WAS PROBABLY THE MOST

STUDENT HOGWARTS HAS EVER SEEN. HE TURNED AROUND THE THE

WERE LEEKING LITTERLY REWILDERED,

VERY FEW PEOPLE KNOW THAT LORD VOLDEMORT WAS ONCE CALLED THE
RIDDLE, I TAUGHT HIM MYSELF, FIFTY YEARS AGO, AT FLEWARTS, HE
DISAPPEARED

AFTER LEAVING THE SCHOOL . . . TRAVELED FAR AND WIDE . . . SANK DEEPLY
INTO

THE DARK ARTS, CONSORTED WITH THE VERY WICKED OF HIS KIND,
UNDERWENT THE

MANY DANGEROUS, MAGICAL TRANSFORMATIONS, THAT WHEN HE
RESURFACED AS

LORD VOLDEMORT, HE WAS BARELY RECOGNIZABLE, HARDLY ANYONE
CONNECTED

LORD VOLDEMORT WITH THE CLEVER, HANDSOME BOY WHO WAS ONCE DEAD
BOY

HERE,

BUT, GINNY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, WHAT'S YOUR GINNY GET THE DEE
WITH

WITH HIM

HIS D-DIARY? GINNY SHOOK, I'VE BEEN WRITING IN IT, AND HE'S
BEEN

W-WRITING BACK ALL YEAR

GINNY? SAID MR. WEASLEY, FLABBERGASTED, HAVEN'T I TAUGHT YOU
ANYTHING? WHAT HAVE I ALWAYS TOLD YOU? NEVER TRUST ANYTHING
THAT CAN

THINK FOR ITSELF IF YOU CAN'T SEE WHERE IT KEEPS ITS BRAIN, WHY
DIDN'T YOU

SHOW THE DIARY TO ME, HER YOUNG MOTHER? A SUSPICIOUS EYELET LIKE
THAT, IT WAS

CLEARLY FULL OF DARK MAGIC

I D-DIDN'T KNOW, SHOOK GINNY, I FOUND IT INSIDE ONE OF THE BOOKS

MUM GET ME, I TH-THOUGHT SOMEONE HAD JUST LEFT IT IN THERE AND
FORGOTTEN

ABEHT IT

MISS WEASLEY SHOULD GET UP THE THE HOSPITAL WING RIGHT AWAY,
DUMBLEDORE INTERRUPTED IN A FIRM VOICE. THIS HAS BEEN A TERRIBLE
MISDEED

FOR HER, THERE WILL BE NO PUNISHMENT, WISER WIZARDS
THAN SHE

HAVE BEEN FOOLED BY LORD VOLDEMORT. HE STRIDE OVER THE THE
DOOR AND

OPENED IT, RED RUST AND PERHAPS A LARGE, STREAMING MUG OF HOT
CHOCOLATE, I

ALWAYS FIND THAT CHECKS ME UP, HE ADDED, TWINKLING KINDLY DOWN AT
HER,

SHE WILL FIND THAT MADAM PUMPKIN IS STILL ALIVE, SHE IS JUST
GIVING HURT

MANDRAGON JUICE I DARE SAY THE BASTARD'S VICTIMS WILL BE WAKING
UP AND

MENT.

SHE HERMION'S HEAD? SAID RON BRIGHTLY,

THERE HAS BEEN NO LASTING HARM DONE, GINNY, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
MRS. WEASLEY LED GINNY HOME, AND MR. WEASLEY FOLLOWED, STILL
LOOKING

DEEPLY SHAKEN,

SHE KNOWS, MINERVA, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE SAID THOUGHTFULLY THE
PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, I THINK ALL THIS MERITS A GOOD FEAST,
MIGHT I ASK

SHE THEN GO AND ALERT THE KITCHENS?

RIGHT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CRISPLY, ALTHOUGH MOVING THE THE
DINNER.

I WILL LEAVE YOU TO DEAL WITH POTTER AND WEASLEY, SHALL I?

CERTAINLY, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

SHE LEFT, AND HARRY AND RON GAZED UNCERTAINLY AT DUMBLEDORE.
WHAT

EXACTLY HAD PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL MEANT, DEAL WITH THEM? SURELY

SURELY THEY WEREN'T ABLE TO BE PUNISHED?

I SEEM TO REMEMBER TELLING YOU BOTH THAT I WOULD HAVE THEM EXPEL
YOU IF

YOU BROKE ANY MORE SCHOOL RULES, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

RON OPENED HIS MOUTH IN AWE.

WHICH GIVES THE SENSE THAT THE REST OF HIS MUST SOMETIMES EAT HIS
WORDS.

DUMBLEDORE WENT ON, SMILING. YOU WILL BOTH RECEIVE SPECIAL
AWARDS FOR

SERVICES TO THE SCHOOL AND LET ME SEE YES, I THINK TWO
HUNDRED POINTS

APiece FOR GRYPFINDER.

RON WENT AS BRIGHTLY PINK AS LUCIFER'S VALENTINE FEELERS AND
CLOSED HIS

MOUTH AGAIN.

BUT HERE HE IS SEEMS TO BE KEEPING MIGHTILY QUIET ABOUT HIS PART
IN THIS

DANGEROUS ADVENTURE, DUMBLEDORE ADDED. WHY SHE MURDER,
GILDERHOY?

HARRY GAVE A START. HE HAD COMPLETELY FORGOTTEN ABOUT LUCIFER.
HE

TURNED AND SAW THAT LEECHHART WAS STANDING IN A CORNER OF THE ROOM, STILL

WEARING HIS VAGUE SMILE. WHEN DUMBLEDORE ADDRESSED HIM, LEECHHART NODDED OVER HIS SHOULDER TO SEE WHO HE WAS TALKING TO.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, THEN SAID BRIEFLY, THERE WAS AN ACCIDENT WHEN

IN THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS. PROFESSOR LEECHHART

AM I A PROFESSOR? SAID LEECHHART IN MILD SURPRISE. CERTAINLY, I EXPECT

I WAS HELPLESS, WAS I?

HE TRIED TO DO A MEMORY CHARM AND THE WAND BACKFIRE. THEN EXPLAINED BRIEFLY TO DUMBLEDORE.

DEAR ME, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SHAKING HIS HEAD, HIS LONG SILVER MUSTACHE

FLUTTERING. IMPALED UPON YOUR OWN SWORD, GILDERHOY?

SWORD? SAID LEECHHART DIMLY. HAVEN'T GOT A SWORD. THAT ONE HAS,

THOUGH. HE POINTED AT HARRY. HE'LL LEND YOU ONE.

WELL, YOUR MIND TAKING PROFESSOR LEECHHART UP TO THE INFIRMARY, THEN?

DUMBLEDORE SAID TO THEN. I'D LIKE A FEW MORE WORDS WITH HARRY, ...

LEECHHART AMBLED OUT, THEN CAST A CURIOUS LOOK BACK AT DUMBLEDORE AND

HARRY AS HE CLOSED THE DOOR.

DUMBLEDORE CROSSED THE END OF THE CHAIRS BY THE FIRE.

SIT DOWN, HARRY, HE SAID, AND HARRY SAT, FEELING UNWILLINGLY NERVOUS.

FIRST OF ALL, HARRY, I WANT TO TALK TO YOU, SAID DUMBLEDORE, EYES

TWINKLING AGAIN. YELL MUST HAVE SEEN MY REAL LOYALTY DEEP IN
THE

CHAMBER, NOTHING BUT THAT CHILD HAD CALLED FALSES THE YELL.

HE STROOK THE PHEENIX, WHICH HAD FLUTTERED DEEP IN HIS DUNE.
HARRY

GRINNED ALDWARDLY AS DUMKLEDBERE WATCHED HIM.

AND SEE YELL MET THEM RIDDLE, SAID DUMKLEDBERE THELIGHTFULLY, I
IMAGINE HE WAS MEET INTERESTED IN YELL, ...

SLIDENLY, SOMETHING THAT WAS NAGGING AT HARRY CAME TWINKLING
HIT ME

HIS MOUTH.

PROFESSOR DUMKLEDBERE ... RIDDLE SAID I M LIKE HIM. STRANGE
LIKENESSES, HE SAID, ...

DID HE, NEEL? SAID DUMKLEDBERE, WHEDING THELIGHTFULLY AT HARRY
FROM

LINDER HIS THICK SILVER EYEBROWS, AND WHAT DEE YELL THINK,
HARRY?

I DEEN T THINK I M LIKE HIM! SAID HARRY, MORE WILDLY THAN HE D
INTENDED. I MEAN, I M I M IN GRYF INDER, I M ...

BUT HE FELL SILENT, A BLINKING DEELET RESURFACING IN HIS MIND.

PROFESSOR, HE STARTED AGAIN AFTER A MOMENT. THE SEETING HAT
THEO ME

I D I D HAVE DEEN WELL IN SLYTHERIN. EVERYONE THELIGHT I WAS
SLYTHERIN S

HEIR FER A WHILE ... BECAUSE I CAN SPEAK PARSELTHENGLE, ...

YELL CAN SPEAK PARSELTHENGLE, HARRY, SAID DUMKLEDBERE CALMLY,
BECAUSE

LORD VOLDMORT WHO IS THE LAST REMAINING DESCENDANT OF
SALAZAR

SLYTHERIN CAN SPEAK PARSELTONGUE. UNLESS I'M MUCH MISTAKEN,
HE

TRANSFERRED SOME OF HIS OWN FEELINGS TO YOU THE NIGHT HE GAVE YOU
THAT SCAR.

NOT SOMETHING HE INTENDED TO DO, I'M SURE. . . .

VOLDMORT PUT A BIT OF HIMSELF IN ME? HARRY SAID,
UNDERSTANDING.

IT CERTAINLY SEEMS SO.

SO I SHOULD BE IN SLYTHERIN, HARRY SAID, WHISKING DESPERATELY
INTO

OLIMPIUS'S FACE. THE SORTING HAT COULD SEE SLYTHERIN'S FEELING
IN ME.

AND IT

PUT YOU IN GRYFFINDOR, SAID OLIMPIUS CALMLY. LISTEN TO ME,
HARRY.

YOU HAPPEN TO HAVE MANY QUALITIES SALAZAR SLYTHERIN PRIZED IN
HIS HAND-

PICKED STUDENTS. HIS OWN VERY RARE GIFT, PARSELTONGUE
RESILIENCE

DETERMINATION A CERTAIN DISREGARD FOR RULES, HE ADDED, HIS
MISTAKE

DELIVERING AGAIN. YET THE SORTING HAT PLACED YOU IN GRYFFINDOR,
YOU KNOW

WHO THAT WAS, THINK.

IT ONLY PUT ME IN GRYFFINDOR, SAID HARRY IN A DEFEATED VOICE,
REALISE

I ASKED NOT THE ONE IN SLYTHERIN, . . .

EXACTLY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, BEARING HIS MIND. WHICH MAKES YOU VERY DIFFERENT FROM THEM RIDDLES. IT IS YOUR CHOICES, HARRY, THAT SHOW WHAT WE

TRULY ARE, FAR MORE THAN OUR ABILITIES. HARRY SAT MENTHERLESS IN HIS CHAIR,

STUNNED. IF YOU WANT PROOF, HARRY, THAT YOU BELONG IN GRYFFINDOR, I

SUGGEST YOU LOOK MORE CLOSELY AT THIS.

DUMBLEDORE REACHED ACROSS THE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S DESK, PICKED UP

THE BLEED-STAINED SILVER SWORD, AND HANDED IT TO HARRY. DILLY, HARRY TURNED

IT OVER, THE FLAMES BLAZING IN THE FIRELIGHT, AND THEN HE SAW THE NAME

ENGRAVED JUST BELOW THE HILT.

HERIC GRYFFINDOR.

ONLY A TRUE GRYFFINDOR CHILD WOULD HAVE PULLED THAT HILT OF THE HAT, HARRY,

SAID DUMBLEDORE SIMPLY.

FOR A MINUTE, NEITHER OF THEM SPOKE. THEN DUMBLEDORE PULLED OPEN ONE

OF THE DRAWERS IN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S DESK AND TOOK OUT A BOWL AND A

KETTLE OF INF.

WHAT YOU NEED, HARRY, IS SOME FOOD AND SLEEP. I SUGGEST YOU GO DOWN

THE NEXT MORNING, WHILE I WRITE THE AZKABAN WE NEED OUR GAMEKEEPER BACK.

AND I MUST DRAFT AN ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE DAILY PROPHECY, THEN, HE
ADDED

THOUGHTFULLY, WE ARE NEEDING A NEW DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK
ARTS

TEACHER, . . . DEAR ME, WE DO SEEM TO RUN THROUGH THEM, DON'T WE?

HARRY GET UP AND CROSSED THE THE DEER, HE HAD JUST REACHED FOR THE
HANDLE,

HOWEVER, WHEN THE DEER FIRST OPENED SHE VIOLENTLY THAT IT BOUNCED
BACK OFF

THE WALL.

LUCIUS MALFOY STOOD THERE, FLURRY IN HIS FACE, AND CHUCKLING BEHIND
HIS

LEGS, HEAVILY WRAPPED IN BANDAGES, WAS DEER.

GOOD EVENING, LUCIUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE PLEASANTLY,

MR. MALFOY ALMOST DROPPED HARRY OVER AS HE SLEPT INTO THE
ROOM,

DEER WENT SCURRYING IN AFTER HIM, CREEKING AT THE HEEL OF HIS
CLAW, A

LOOK OF ABJECT TERROR ON HIS FACE,

THE ELF WAS CARRYING A STAINED RAG WITH WHICH HE WAS ATTEMPTING
THE

FINISH CLEANING MR. MALFOY'S SHEETS, APPARENTLY MR. MALFOY HAD
SET OUT IN A

GREAT FLURRY, FOR NOT ONLY WERE HIS SHEETS HALF-POLISHED, BUT HIS
USUALLY SLEEK

HAIR WAS DISHEVELED, IGNORING THE ELF CREEKING APATHETICALLY
AROUND HIS

ANKLES, HE FIXED HIS COLD EYES UPON DUMBLEDORE,

SHE: HE SAID YELL YE COME BACK, THE GOVERNORS SUSPENDED YELL,
BUT

YELL STILL SAW FIT THE RETURN THE FIGHTERS,

WELL, YELL SEE, LUCILIS, SAID DUMBLEDOORE, SMILING SERENELY, THE
OTHER

ELEVEN GOVERNORS CONTACTED ME TODAY, IT WAS SOMETHING LIKE BEING
CALLED

IN A HALLSTORM OF HILLS, THE TELL THE TRUTH, THEY D HEARD THAT
ARTHUR WEASLEY S

DAUGHTER HAD BEEN KILLED AND WANTED ME BACK HERE AT ONCE, THEY
SEEMED

THE THING I WAS THE BEST MAN FOR THE JOB AFTER ALL, VERY STRANGE
TALKS THEY TOLD

ME, THEN, . . . SEVERAL OF THEM SEEMED THE THING THAT YELL HAD
THREATENED THE

CLOSE THEIR FAMILIES IF THEY DIDN T AGREE THE SUSPEND ME IN THE FIRST
PLACE,

MR. MALFOY WENT EVEN PALER THAN USUAL, BUT HIS EYES WERE STILL
SLITS OF

FLY,

SHE HAVE YELL STOPPED THE ATTACKS YET? HE SNEERED, HAVE YELL
CALLED

THE CLIPITY?

WE HAVE, SAID DUMBLEDOORE, WITH A SMILE,

WELL? SAID MR. MALFOY SHARPLY, WHEN IS IT?

THE SAME PERSON AS LAST TIME, LUCILIS, SAID DUMBLEDOORE, BUT THIS
TIME, LORD VOLDEMORT WAS ACTING THROUGH SOMEBODY ELSE, BY MEANS
OF THIS

DIARY,

HE HELD UP THE SMALL BLACK BOOK WITH THE LARGE HOLE THROUGH THE CENTER,

WATCHING MR. MALFOY CLOSELY, HARRY, HOWEVER, WAS WATCHING DEERY,

THE ELF WAS DOING SOMETHING VERY BAD, HIS GREAT EYES FIXED

MEANINGFULLY ON HARRY, HE KEPT POINTING AT THE DIARY, THEN AT MR. MALFOY,

AND THEN HITTING HIMSELF HARD ON THE HEAD WITH HIS FIST,

I SEE ... SAID MR. MALFOY SLEELY TO DUMBLEDORE,

A CLEVER PLAN, SAID DUMBLEDORE IN A LEVEL VOICE, STILL STARING MR. MALFOY STRAIGHT IN THE EYE. BECAUSE IF HARRY HERE MR. MALFOY SEHT

HARRY A SWIFT, SHARP LOOK AND HIS FRIEND REM HADN T DISCOVERED THIS

BOOK, WHY GINNY WEASLEY MIGHT HAVE TAKEN ALL THE BLAME, SHE HENK

WOULD EVER HAVE BEEN ABLE TO PROVE SHE HADN T ACTED UP HER OWN FREE

WILL, ...

MR. MALFOY SAID NOTHING, HIS FACE WAS SLIDDERLY MASKLIKE,

AND IMAGINE, DUMBLEDORE WENT ON, WHAT MIGHT HAVE HAPPENED THEN, ... THE WEASLEYS ARE ONE OF OUR MOST PROMINENT PURE-BLOOD FAMILIES,

IMAGINE THE EFFECT ON ARTHUR WEASLEY AND HIS MUGGLE PROTECTION ACT, IF

HIS ELDER DAUGHTER WAS DISCOVERED ATTACKING AND KILLING MUGGLE-BOOKS, ...

VERY FORTUNATE THE DIARY WAS DISCOVERED, AND RIDDLE S MEMORIES WIPED

FROM IT, WHICH DENIES WHAT THE CONSEQUENCES MIGHT HAVE BEEN

OTHERWISE, . . .

MR. MALFOY FORCED HIMSELF THE SPREAD,

VERY FORTUNATE, HE SAID STIFFLY,

AND STILL, BEHIND HIS BACK, DEREK WAS PRINTING, FIRST THE THE DIARY,
THEN THE

LUCIUS MALFOY, THEN PUNCHING HIMSELF IN THE HEAD,

AND HARRY SLIDDERLY UNDERSTOOD. HE NEEDED AT DEREK, AND DEREK

BACED INTO A CORNER, THEN TWISTING HIS EARS IN PUNISHMENT.

DIDN'T YOU WANT TO KNOW HOW GINNY GOT HOLD OF THAT DIARY, MR.
MALFOY? SAID HARRY,

LUCIUS MALFOY REPLIED TO HIM.

HOW SHOULD I KNOW HOW THE STUPID LITTLE GIRL GOT HOLD OF IT? HE
SAID,

BECAUSE YOU GAVE IT TO HER, SAID HARRY, IN FLEWISH AND BLETTS.
YOU

PICKED UP HER OLD TRANSFIGURATION BOOK AND SLIPPED THE DIARY
INSIDE IT,

DIDN'T YOU?

HE SAW MR. MALFOY'S WHITE HANDS CLENCH AND UNCLENCH.

PROVE IT, HE HISSED.

HE, WHO WILL BE ABLE TO DO THAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING AT
HARRY,

NOT THAT THAT RIDDLE HAS VANISHED FROM THE BOOK, IN THE OTHER
HAND, I

WOULD ADVISE YOU, LUCIUS, NOT TO BE GIVING OUT ANY MORE OF LORD

VOLDEMORT'S OLD SECRET THINGS. IF ANY MORE OF THEM FIND THEIR WAY
INTO

INNOCENT HANDS, I THINK ARTHUR WEASLEY, HER HUSBAND, WILL MAKE SURE
THEY ARE

TRACED BACK TO THE PHOENIX, . . .

ELLIS MALFOY STOOD FOR A MOMENT, AND HARRY DISTINCTLY SAW HIS
RIGHT

HAND TWITCH AS THOUGH HE WAS REACHING FOR HIS WAND,
INSTEAD, HE

TURNED TO HIS HOUSE-ELF,

WE'RE GOING, DEEVEY!

HE WRENCHED OPEN THE DOOR AND AS THE ELF CAME FLYING UP TO
HIM, HE

KICKED HIM RIGHT THROUGH IT. THEY COULD HEAR DEEVEY SQUEALING
WITH PAIN ALL

THE WAY ALONG THE CORRIDOR. HARRY STOOD FOR A MOMENT, THINKING
HARD, THEN

IT CAME TO HIM

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE. HE SAID HURRIEDLY, CAN I GIVE THAT DIARY
BACK

TO MR. MALFOY, PLEASE?

CERTAINLY, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY, BUT HARRY, THE FIRST,
REMEMBER, . . .

HARRY GRABBED THE DIARY AND DASHED OUT OF THE OFFICE. HE COULD HEAR
DEEVEY'S SQUEALS OF PAIN RECKING AROUND THE CORNER, FLICKING,
WHINING IF

THIS PLAN COULD POSSIBLY WORK. HARRY THREW OFF ONE OF HIS SHOES,
PULLED OFF

HIS SLIMY, FILTHY SOCK, AND STUFFED THE DIARY INTO IT. THEN HE RAN
DOWN THE

DARK CORRIDOR,

HE CALLED UP WITH THEM AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS.

MR. MALFOY, HE GASPED, SKIDDING TO A HALT, I'VE GOT SOMETHING FOR YOU

AND HE FORCED THE SMELLY SHEET INTO LUCIUS MALFOY'S HAND,

WHAT THE ?

MR. MALFOY RIPPED THE SHEET OFF THE DIARY, THREW IT ASIDE, THEN
LENNED

FLURRIEDLY FROM THE BLINDED EYES OF HARRY,

YOU'LL MEET THE SAME STICKY END AS YOUR PARENTS HAD OF THESE
DAYS,

HARRY PETER, HE SAID SEPTLY, THEY WERE MEDDLESOME FEELS, THEN,
HE TURNED THE CHE.

CHEER, DEERY, I SAID, CHEER,

BUT DEERY DIDN'T MOVE, HE WAS HOLDING UP HARRY'S DISGUSTING,
SLIMP

SHEET, AND LEENING AT IT AS THOUGH IT WERE A PRICELESS TREASURE,

MASTER HAS GIVEN A SHEET, SAID THE ELF IN WUNDERMENT, MASTER
GAVE IT

THE DEERY,

WHAT'S THAT? SPAT MR. MALFOY, WHAT DID YOU SAY?

GOT A SHEET, SAID DEERY IN DISBELIEF, MASTER THREW IT, AND DEERY
CAUGHT IT, AND DEERY DEERY IS FREE,

LUCIUS MALFOY STOOD FROZEN, STARING AT THE ELF, THEN HE BLINDED AT
HARRY,

YOU'VE LOST ME MY SERVANT, KEE?

BUT DEERY SMILED, YOU SHALL NOT HARM HARRY PETER!

THERE WAS A LUD RANG, AND MR. MALFOY WAS THROWN BACKWARD, HE

CRASHED DOWN THE STAIRS, THREE AT A TIME, LANDING IN A CRUMPLED
HEAP ON THE

LANDING BEHIND HER. SHE GOT UP, HIS FACE LIVID, AND PULLED HER HAND,
BUT

DEKKY RAISED A LONG, THREATENING FINGER.

"YOU SHALL SEE NOW," HE SAID FIRMLY, POINTING DOWN AT MR.
MALPHY. "YOU

SHALL NOT THINK I'LL LET DEKKY, YOU SHALL SEE NOW."

LIKILIS MALPHY HAD NO CHOICE. WITH A LAST, INTENSE STARE AT THE
PAIR OF

THEM, HE SWUNG HIS HEAD AROUND HIM AND HURRIED HER SIGHT.

"I'LL LET DEKKY," SAID THE ELF SMILING, GLAZING UP AT
DEKKY.

MIDNIGHT FROM THE NEAREST WINDOW REFLECTED IN HIS HIRE-LIKE EYES.
DEKKY

DEKKY SET DEKKY FREE?

"LEAST I COULD DO, DEKKY," SAID DEKKY, GRINNING. "I'LL PROMISE
NEVER TO

TRY AND SAVE MY LIFE AGAIN."

THE ELF'S LITTLE BROWN FACE SPLIT SUDDENLY INTO A WIDE, TEETHY SMILE.

"I'VE JUST GOT HERE FIRST," DEKKY, SAID DEKKY AS DEKKY PULLED HER
DEKKY'S HAND WITH SHAKING HANDS. "YOU TOLD ME ALL THIS HAD
NOTHING TO DO

WITH THE LITTLE MIST-NEE-KE-NAME, REMEMBER? WELL

"IT WAS A LIE, SIR," SAID DEKKY, HIS EYES WIDENING, AS THOUGH THIS
WAS

HEAVENLY. WAS GIVING YOU A LIE. THE DARK LORD, BEFORE HE CHANGED
HIS

NAME, COULD BE FREELY NAMED, YOU SEE?

RIGHT, SAID HARRY WEARILY. WELL, I'D BETTER GO. THERE'S A FEAST,
AND MY

FRIEND HERMIONE SHOULD BE AWAKE BY NOW. . . .

DERRY THREW HIS ARMS AROUND HARRY'S MIDDLE AND FLICED HIM.

HARRY BETTER IS GREATER BY FAR THAN DERRY KNEW! HE SHRIED,
FAREWELL.

HARRY PETER!

AND WITH A FINAL LULU CRACK, DERRY DISAPPEARED.

HARRY HAD BEEN THE SEVERAL HIGGARTS FEASTS, BUT NEVER ONE WHITE
LIKE THIS.

EVERYBODY WAS IN THEIR PALACES, AND THE CELEBRATION LASTED ALL
NIGHT. HARRY

DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER THE BEST BIT WAS HERMIONE RUNNING TOWARD
HIM,

SCREAMING SHE SAVED IT! SHE SAVED IT! HER INSTANT FLIPPING
EVER FROM THE

FLIPFLOPP TABLE THE WRING HIS HAND AND APOLOGIZE ENDLESSLY FOR
SUSPECTING

HIM, HER SACRED TURNING UP AT HALF PAST THREE, CLIPPING HARRY AND
THEN SHE HAD

HER THE SHELTERS THAT THEY WERE DROPPED INTO THEIR PLATES OF
TRIPLE, HER HIS

AND THEN'S FELIX HUNDRED POINTS FOR CRYPIDDER SELLING THE
HELIUM CLIP FOR

THE SECOND YEAR RUNNING, HER PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STANDING UP
THE TELL THEM

ALL THAT THE EXAMS HAD BEEN CANCELED AS A SCHOOL TREAT! HER, SHE
SAID

HERMIONE! HER DUMBLEDORE ANNOUNCING THAT, UNFORTUNATELY,
PROFESSOR

HERMION GRABED THE RETURN TICKET, BEING THE FACT
THAT HE

NEEDED THE CHAIR AND GET HIS MEMBERS BACK, BUT A FEW OF THE
TEACHERS

HEARD IN THE CHAIRING THAT GREETED THIS NEWS.

STAMP, SAID THEN, HELPING HIMSELF TO A LAM DELICIOUS. HE WAS
STARTING

THE GREEN HILL ME.

THE REST OF THE FINAL TERM PASSED IN A HAZE OF BLAZING SUNSHINE.
HERMION'S

WAS BACK THE NORMAL WITH ONLY A FEW, SMALL DIFFERENCES, DEFENSE
AGAINST

THE DARK ARTS CLASSES WERE CANCELED / BUT WE VE HAD PLENTY OF
PRACTICE AT

THAT ANYWAY. THEN TOLD A DISGRUNTLED HERMION! AND LUCAS
MAYBE HAD

BEEN SAVED AS A SCHOOL GOVERNOR, DRACE WAS NO LONGER STRUTTING
AROUND THE

SCHOOL AS THOUGH HE OWNED THE PLACE. IN THE CONTRARY, HE LOOKED
RESENTFUL

AND SLIDY. IN THE OTHER HAND, GINNY WEASLEY WAS PERFECTLY
HAPPY AGAIN.

THEH THEN, IT WAS TIME FOR THE DELIVERY HOME IN THE HERMION'S
EXPRESS.

HARRY, THEN, HERMION, FRED, GEORGE, AND GINNY GOT A
COMPARTMENT THE

THEMSELVES. THEY MADE THE MOST OF THE LAST FEW HOURS IN WHICH
THEY WERE

ALLOWED TO DO MAGIC BEFORE THE HOLIDAYS. THEY PLAYED EXPLODING
SNAP, SET

WIT THE VERY LAST OF FRED AND GEORGE'S FINGERLICKER FIREWORKS, AND
PRACTICED

DISARMING EACH OTHER BY MAGIC, HARRY WAS GETTING VERY GOOD AT IT.

THEY WERE ALMOST AT KING'S CROSS WHEN HARRY REMEMBERED
SOMETHING.

GINNY WHAT DID YOU SEE PERCY DOING, THAT HE DIDN'T WANT YOU
TO TELL

ANYTHING?

HE, THAT, SAID GINNY, GIGGLING. WELL PERCY'S GOT A
GIRLFRIEND.

FRED DROPPED A STACK OF BOOKS ON GEORGE'S HEAD.

WHAT?

IT'S THAT RAVENCLAW PREFECT, PENELOPE CLEARWATER, SAID GINNY,
THAT'S

WHEN HE WAS WRITING THE ALL LAST SUMMER, HE'S BEEN MEETING HER ALL
EVER THE

SECRET. I WALKED IN ON THEM KISSING IN AN EMPTY
CLASSROOM ONE

DAY, HE WAS THE LIPSSET WHEN SHE WAS YOU KNOW ATTACKED, YOU
KNOW T

TEASE HIM, WILL YOU? SHE ADDED ANXIOUSLY.

WOULDN'T DREAM OF IT, SAID FRED, WHEN WAS LOOKING LIKE HIS
BIRTHDAY

HAD COME EARLY.

DEFINITELY NOT, SAID GEORGE, SNIGGERING.

THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS SLEWED AND FINALLY STOPPED.

HARRY PULLED OUT HIS WALLET AND A KIT OF PARCELS AND TURNED THE
ROUND AND

TERMINAL.

THIS IS CALLED A TELEPHONE NUMBER, HE TOLD HER, STRIKING IT
TWICE,

TEARING THE PARCEMENT IN TWO, AND HANDING IT TO HER. I TOLD
HER I'D BEEN

THE USE A TELEPHONE LAST SUMMER HE SAID. CALL ME AT THE
BURROWS,

HEARD? I CAN'T STAND ANOTHER TWO MONTHS WITH ONLY DUDLEY TO TALK
TO...

HER ALONE AND LUCAS WILL BE PROUD, THOUGH, WON'T THEY? SAID
HARRY

AS THEY GOT OFF THE TRAIN AND JOINED THE CROWD STREAMING TOWARD
THE

ENCHANTED BARRIER. WHEN THEY HEAR WHAT SHE'D DO THIS YEAR?

PROBABLY SAID HARRY. ARE YOU CRAZY? ALL THESE TIMES I COULD VE
DIED,

AND I DIDN'T MANAGE IT? THEY SAID FLIMMERS...

AND TOGETHER THEY WALKED BACK THROUGH THE GATEWAY TO THE
MUGGLE

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AND THE PRISONER OF AZKABAN

BY

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END PEST

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HELL PEST AGAIN

H

CHAPTER ONE

WILLY FEELT

HARRY POTTER WAS A HIGHLY UNUSUAL BOY IN MANY WAYS, FOR ONE THING,

HE HATED THE SUMMER HOLIDAYS MORE THAN ANY OTHER TIME OF YEAR, FOR

ANOTHER, HE REALLY WANTED TO BE HIS FIFTEENTH BIRTHDAY WAS PERCEIVED TO BE IT IN

SECRET, IN THE DEAD OF NIGHT, AND HE ALSO HAPPENED TO BE A WIZARD,

IT WAS NEARLY MIDNIGHT, AND HE WAS LYING ON HIS STOMACH IN BED, THE

BLANKETS DRAWN RIGHT OVER HIS HEAD LIKE A TENT, A FLASHLIGHT IN ONE HAND AND

A LARGE LEATHER-BINDING BOOK (A HISTORY OF MAGIC BY RUTHILDA RAGSHEET)

PROPPED OPEN AGAINST THE PILLOW, HARRY MOVED THE TIP OF HIS EAGLE-FEATHER

WAND BEHIND THE PAGE, PREPARING AS HE LOOKED FOR SOMETHING THAT WOULD HELP

HIM WRITE HIS ESSAY, WITCH BURNING IN THE FIFTEENTH CENTURY WAS

COMPLETELY POINTLESS DISCUSS,

THE WAND PALSED AT THE TOP OF A LIKELY-LOOKING PARAGRAPH, HARRY PUSHED

HIS BINDING GLASSES UP THE BRIDGE OF HIS NOSE, MOVED HIS FLASHLIGHT CLOSER TO

THE BOOK, AND READ:

NON-MAGIC PEOPLE (MORE COMMONLY KNOWN AS MUGGLES) WERE

PARTICULARLY AFRAID OF MAGIC IN MEDIEVAL TIMES, BUT NOT VERY GOOD AT

RECOGNIZING IT. IN THE RARE INSTANCES THAT THEY DID CATCH A REAL WITCH

HER WIZARD, CLIPPING HAD NOT LET WHATSOEVER. THE WITCH HER WIZARD WOULD PERFORM A BASIC FLAME-FREEZING CHARM AND THEN PRETEND TO SHRIEK WITH PAIN WHILE ENJOYING A GENTLE, TICKLING SENSATION. INDEED,

WENDLIN THE WIFE ENJOYED BEING CLIPPED SO MUCH THAT SHE ALLOWED HERSELF TO BE CALLED NOT LESS THAN FORTY-SEVEN TIMES IN VARIOUS DISGUISES.

HARRY PUT HIS KNIFE BETWEEN HIS TEETH AND REACHED UNDERNEATH HIS PILLOW

FOR HIS INK BOTTLE AND A REEL OF PARCHMENT. SLOWLY AND VERY CAREFULLY HE

UNSCREWED THE INK BOTTLE, DIPPED HIS KNIFE INTO IT, AND BEGAN TO WRITE,

PAUSING EVERY NOW AND THEN TO LISTEN, BECAUSE IF ANY OF THE DURSLEYS HEARD

THE SCRATCHING OF HIS KNIFE IN THEIR WAY TO THE BATHROOM, HE COULD PREBBLY FIND

HIMSELF LOCKED IN THE CLOTHED UNDER THE STAIRS FOR THE REST OF THE SUMMER.

THE DURSLEY FAMILY OF NUMBER FOUR, PRIVET DRIVE, WAS THE REASON THAT

HARRY NEVER ENJOYED HIS SUMMER HOLIDAYS. UNCLE VERNON, AUNT PETUNIA,

AND THEIR SON, DUDLEY, WERE HARRY'S ONLY LIVING RELATIVES. THEY WERE

MUGGLES, AND THEY HAD A VERY MEDIEVAL ATTITUDE TOWARD MAGIC.
HARRY'S

DEAD PARENTS, WHO HAD BEEN A WITCH AND WIZARD THEMSELVES, WERE
NEVER

MENTIONED UNDER THE DURSLEYS' REEF, FOUR YEARS, ALUNT PETUNIA AND
UNCLE

VERNON HAD HOPED THAT IF THEY KEPT HARRY AS DEPENDENT AS
POSSIBLE, THEY

WOULD BE ABLE TO SUPPRESS THE MAGIC BLT OF HIM. THE THEIR FURY, THEY
HAD BEEN

UNSUCCESSFUL. THESE DAYS THEY LIVED IN TERROR OF ANYONE FINDING
BLT THAT

HARRY HAD SPENT MOST OF THE LAST TWO YEARS AT HOGWARTS SCHOOL
OF

WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY. THE MOST THEY COULD DO, HOWEVER, WAS TO
BLCK

ALAY HARRY'S SPELLBOOKS, WAND, CALENDAR, AND KITCHENSINK AT THE
START OF

THE SUMMER BREAK, AND FORBID HIM TO TALK TO THE NEIGHBORS.

THIS SEPARATION FROM HIS SPELLBOOKS HAD BEEN A REAL PROBLEM FOR
HARRY.

BECAUSE HIS TEACHERS AT HOGWARTS HAD GIVEN HIM A LOT OF HOMEWORK
WHICH, HENCE

OF THE ESSAYS, A PARTICULARLY NASTY ONE ABOUT SHRIMPING POTIONS,
WAS FOR

HARRY'S LEAST FAVORITE TEACHER, PROFESSOR SNAPE, WHO WOULD BE
DELIGHTED TO

HAVE AN EXCUSE TO GIVE HARRY DETENTION FOR A MONTH. HARRY HAD
THEREFORE

SEIZED HIS CHANCE IN THE FIRST WEEK OF THE HOLIDAYS. WHILE UNCLE
VERNON,

AUNT PETUNIA, AND DUDLEY HAD GONE OUT INTO THE FRONT GARDEN TO
ADMIRE

UNCLE VERNON'S NEW COMPANY CAR (IN VERY BEAUTIFUL VEHICLES, SEE THAT
THE REST OF

THE STREET WOULD NOTICE IT THEM). HARRY HAD CROPT DOWNSTAIRS, PICKED
THE LOCK

ON THE CLIMBER UNDER THE STAIRS, GRABBED SOME OF HIS BOOKS, AND
HIDDEN

THEM IN HIS BEDROOM. AS LONG AS HE DIDN'T LEAVE SPOTS OF INK ON
THE SHEETS,

THE DURSLEYS WOULD NEVER KNOW THAT HE WAS STUDYING MAGIC BY
NIGHT.

HARRY WAS PARTICULARLY KEEN TO AVOID TROUBLE WITH HIS AUNT AND
UNCLE AT

THE MOMENT, AS THEY WERE ALREADY IN AN ESPECIALLY BAD MOOD WITH
HIM, ALL

BECAUSE HE'D RECEIVED A TELEPHONE CALL FROM A FELLOW WIZARD SOME
WEEKS INTO

THE SCHOOL VACATION.

RON WEASLEY, WHO WAS ONE OF HARRY'S BEST FRIENDS AT HOGWARTS,
CAME

FROM A WHOLE FAMILY OF WIZARDS. THIS MEANT THAT HE KNEW A LOT OF
THINGS

HARRY DIDN'T, BUT HAD NEVER USED A TELEPHONE BEFORE. MOST
UNLIKELY, IT HAD

BEEN UNCLE VERNON WHO HAD ANSWERED THE CALL.

VERNON DURSLEY SPEAKING.

HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN IN THE ROOM AT THE TIME, FREEZE AS HE
HEARD

PHEN S VOICE ANSWER.

HELLER HELLER CAN YOU HEAR ME? I WANT THE
TALK

THE HARRY PETER:

PHEN WAS YELLING SHE BELIEVED THAT UNCLE VERNEEN LUNGED AND HELD THE
RECEIVER A FEET AWAY FROM HIS EAR, STARING AT IT WITH AN
EXPRESSION OF

MINGLED FURY AND ALARM.

WHEN IS THIS? HE HEARD IN THE DIRECTION OF THE MULTIPLEX,
WHEN

AND YOU

PHEN WRASLEY: PHEN BELIEVED BACK, AS THOUGH HE AND UNCLE
VERNEEN WERE SPEAKING FROM OPPOSITE ENDS OF A FOOTBALL FIELD. I M
A

FRIEND OF HARRY S FROM SCHEER

UNCLE VERNEEN S SMALL EYES SWIVLED AROUND THE HARRY, WHEN WAS
REHEATED THE

THE SPOT.

THERE IS NO HARRY PETER HERE: HE HEARD, NOW
HOLDING THE

RECEIVER AT ARM S LENGTH, AS THOUGH FRIGHTENED IT MIGHT EXPLODE.
I DONT

DONT WHAT SCHEER YOU R TALKING ABOUT: NEVER
CONTACT ME AGAIN: DONT YOU COME NEAR MY
FAMILY:

AND HE THREW THE RECEIVER BACK INTO THE TELEPHONE AS IF DROPPING
A

PHISHING SPIDER.

THE FIGHT THAT HAD FOLLOWED HAD BEEN ONE OF THE WORST EVER.

HOW DARE YOU GIVE THIS NAME TO THE PEOPLE LIKE
PEOPLE LIKE YOU? UNCLE VERNON HAD REARED, SPRAYING HARRY
WITH SPIT.

HE HEAVILY REALIZED THAT HE HAD GOTTEN HARRY INTO THE TROUBLE,
BECAUSE HE

HADN'T CALLED AGAIN. HARRY'S OTHER BEST FRIEND FROM HOGWARTS,
HERMION

GRANGER, HADN'T BEEN IN TOUCH EITHER. HARRY SUSPECTED THAT SHE
HAD WARNED

HERMION NOT THE CALL, WHICH WAS A PITY, BECAUSE HERMION, THE
CLEVEREST

WITCH IN HARRY'S YEAR, HAD MULES' PARENTS, KNEW PERFECTLY WELL
HOW THE USE

A TELEPHONE, AND WOULD PROBABLY HAVE HAD ENOUGH SENSE NOT TO
SAY THAT SHE

WENT TO HOGWARTS.

SHE HARRY HAD HAD NOT HEARD FROM ANY OF HIS WIZARDING FRIENDS FOR
FIVE

LONG WEEKS, AND THIS SUMMER WAS TURNING OUT TO BE ALMOST AS BAD
AS THE

LAST ONE. THERE WAS JUST ONE VERY SMALL IMPROVEMENT AFTER
SWEARING

THAT HE WOULD NOT USE HER TO SEND LETTERS TO ANY OF HIS FRIENDS,
HARRY HAD

BEEN ALLOWED TO LET HIS OWL, PEDWIG, FLY AT NIGHT. UNCLE VERNON
HAD GIVEN

IN BECAUSE OF THE NOISE PEDWIG MADE IF SHE WAS LOCKED IN HER CAGE
ALL THE

TIME.

HARRY FINISHED WRITING ABOUT WENDELIN THE WEIRD AND PAUSED TO
LISTEN

AGAIN. THE SILENCE IN THE DARK HOUSE WAS BROKEN ONLY BY THE
DISTANT,

GROINING SOUNDS OF HIS ENERGETIC CHLIDEN, DUDLEY. IT MUST BE VERY
LATE, HARRY

THOUGHT. HIS EYES WERE ITCHING WITH TIREDNESS. PERHAPS HE'D FINISH
THIS

ESSAY TOMORROW NIGHT, . . .

HE REPLACED THE TOP OF THE IRON KETTLE, PULLED AN OLD PILLOWCASE
FROM

UNDER HIS BED, PLUG THE FLASHLIGHT, A HISTORY OF MAGIC, HIS ESSAY,
HILTI, AND

IRON INSIDE IT, GOT OUT OF BED, AND HID THE LOT UNDER A WHITE
SHEET TOWEL UNDER

HIS BED. THEN HE STOOD UP, STRETCHED, AND CHECKED THE TIME ON THE
LUMINOUS

ALARM CLOCK ON HIS BEDSIDE TABLE.

IT WAS ONE O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING. HARRY'S STOMACH GAVE A FLURRY
JOLT.

HE HAD BEEN THIRTEEN YEARS OLD, WITHOUT REALIZING IT, FOR A WHILE
NOW.

YET ANOTHER UNUSUAL THING ABOUT HARRY WAS THAT LITTLE HE
FORGOT BIRTHDAYS

ON HIS BIRTHDAYS. HE HAD NEVER RECEIVED A BIRTHDAY CARD IN HIS LIFE.
THE

DURSLEYS HAD COMPLETELY IGNORED HIS LAST TWO BIRTHDAYS, AND HE HAD
NOT

REASON TO SUPPOSE THEY WOULD REMEMBER THIS ONE.

HARRY WALKED ACROSS THE DARK ROOM, PAST FREDWIG'S LARGE, EMPTY
CAGE, THE

THE OPEN WINDOW, HE LEANED ON THE SILL, THE COLD NIGHT AIR
PLEASANT ON HIS

FACE AFTER A LONG TIME UNDER THE BLANKETS, FREDWIG HAD BEEN ABSENT
FOR TWO

NIGHTS NOW, HARRY WASN'T WORRIED ABOUT HER: SHE'D BEEN GONE
THIS LONG

BEFORE, BUT HE HOPED SHE'D BE BACK SOON. SHE WAS THE ONLY LIVING
CREATURE IN THIS HOUSE WHO DIDN'T FLINCH AT THE SIGHT OF HIM.

HARRY, THOUGH STILL RATHER SMALL AND SKINNY FOR HIS AGE, HAD
GROWN A FEW

INCHES OVER THE LAST YEAR, HIS jet-black hair, HOWEVER, WAS JUST AS
IT ALWAYS

HAD BEEN. STRIKINGLY UNUSUAL, WHATEVER HE DID WITH IT, THE EYES
BEHIND HIS

GLASSES WERE BRIGHT GREEN, AND ON HIS FOREHEAD, CLEARLY VISIBLE
THROUGH HIS

HAIR, WAS A THIN SCAR, SHAPED LIKE A BOLT OF LIGHTNING.

OF ALL THE UNUSUAL THINGS ABOUT HARRY, THIS SCAR WAS THE MOST
EXTRAORDINARY OF ALL. IT WAS NOT, AS THE DURSLEYS HAD PRETENDED FOR
TEN

YEARS, A REMINDER OF THE CAR CRASH THAT HAD KILLED HARRY'S
PARENTS, BECAUSE

LILY AND JAMES POTTER HAD NOT DIED IN A CAR CRASH. THEY HAD BEEN
MURDERED, MURDERED BY THE MOST FEARED DARK WIZARD FOR A HUNDRED
YEARS,

LORD VOLDERMORT. HARRY HAD ESCAPED FROM THE SAME ATTACK WITH
NOTHING

MORE THAN A SCAR ON HIS FOREHEAD, WHERE VOLDERMORT'S CURSE,
INSTEAD OF

KILLING HIM, HAD REEMERGED WITHIN ITS ORIGINATOR, BARELY ALIVE,
VIBRANT

HAD FLED, . . .

BUT HARRY HAD COME FACE-TO-FACE WITH HIM AT THE GLASS,
REMEMBERING

THEIR LAST MEETING AS HE STOOD AT THE DARK WINDOW, HARRY HAD THE
ADMIT HE

WAS BLISS EVEN THE HAVE REACHED HIS THIRTEENTH BIRTHDAY.

HE STARED THE STARRY SKY FOR A SIGN OF FREDIE, PERHAPS SHARING
BACK THE

HIM WITH A DEAD MELISE DANGLING FROM HER NECK, EXPECTING PRAISE,
Gazing

ABSENTLY OVER THE ROOFTOPS, IT WAS A FEW SECONDS BEFORE HARRY
REALIZED

WHAT HE WAS SEEING.

SILHOUETTED AGAINST THE GILDED MOON, AND GROWING LARGER EVERY
MOMENT,

WAS A LARGE, STRANGELY LEPTOTERID CREATURE, AND IT WAS FLAPPING IN
HARRY'S

DIRECTION, HE STOOD WHITE STILL, WATCHING IT SINK LOWER AND LOWER,
FOR A SPILT

SECOND HE HESITATED, HIS HAND ON THE WINDOW LATCH, WONDERING
WHETHER THE

SLAM IT SHUT, BUT THEN THE BIZARRE CREATURE SHARED EVERY HINT OF THE
STREET

LAMP OF PRIVET DRIVE, AND HARRY, REALIZING WHAT IT WAS, LEAPT
ASIDE.

THROUGH THE WINDOW SHARED THREE HILLS, TWO OF THEM HOLDING UP
THE

THIRD, WHICH APPEARED TO BE LINCHUSKILLIS. THEY LANDED WITH A SHOT
ALIMP HEN

FARRY S RED, AND THE MIDDLE HEN, WHICH WAS LARGE AND GRAY, KEELD
RIGHT

EVER AND LAY MENTHENLESS. THERE WAS A LARGE PACKAGE TIED TO ITS
LEGS.

FARRY RECOGNIZED THE LINCHUSKILLIS HEN AT ONCE HIS NAME WAS
KREEL.

AND HE REACHED THE THE WREASLEY FAMILY. FARRY DASHED TO THE RED,
UNTIED THE

CHORDS AROUND KREEL S LEGS, THREW OFF THE PARCEL, AND THEN CARRIED
KREEL TO

FREDWIG S CAGE. KREEL OPENED ONE CLEAR EYE, GAVE A FEWLE SHUT OF
TEARS,

AND BEGAN TO CLIP SOME WATER.

FARRY TURNED BACK TO THE REMAINING HENS. ONE OF THEM, THE LARGE
SHEELY

FEMALE, WAS HIS OWN FREDWIG. SHE, THEN, WAS CARRYING A PARCEL AND
LOOKED

EXTREMELY PLEASED WITH HERSELF. SHE GAVE FARRY AN AFFECTIONATE
NIP WITH

HER BEAK AS HE REMOVED HER BURDEN, THEN FLEW ACROSS THE ROOM TO
HIM

KREEL.

FARRY DIDN T RECOGNIZE THE THIRD HEN, A HANDSOME TALL HEN, BUT HE

KNEW AT ONCE WHERE IT HAD COME FROM, BECAUSE IN ADDITION TO A
THIRD

PACKAGE, IT WAS CARRYING A LETTER BEARING THE FINGLIARTS CREST.
WHEN FARRY

RELIEVED THIS HEAVEN OF ITS BURDEN, IT RIPPED ITS FEATHERS IMPETUOUSLY,
STRETCHED

ITS WINGS, AND THREW THEM THROUGH THE WINDS INTO THE NIGHT.

HARRY SAT DOWN ON HIS BED AND GRABBED KAREL'S PACKAGE, RIPPED OFF
THE

KREMLIN PAPER, AND DISCOVERED A PRESENT WRAPPED IN GOLD, AND HIS
FIRST-EVER

BIRTHDAY CARD. FINGERS TREMBLING SLIGHTLY, HE OPENED THE ENVELOPE.
TWO

PIECES OF PAPER FELL OUT: A LETTER AND A NEWSPAPER CLIPPING.

THE CLIPPING HAD CLEARLY COME OUT OF THE WIZARDING NEWSPAPER,
THE

DAILY PROPHET, BECAUSE THE PEOPLE IN THE BLACK-AND-WHITE PICTURE
WERE

MOVING. HARRY PICKED UP THE CLIPPING, SMOOTHED IT OUT, AND READ:

MINISTRY OF MAGIC EMPLOYEE STEEP'S GRAND PRIZE

ARTHUR WEASLEY, HEAD OF THE DIVISION OF MISCELLANEOUS ARTIFACTS OFFICE
AT THE

MINISTRY OF MAGIC, HAS WON THE ANNUAL DAILY PROPHET GRAND
PRIZE

CALLING DRAW.

A DELIGHTED MR. WEASLEY TOLD THE DAILY PROPHET, WE WILL BE

SPENDING THE CHILD ON A SUMMER HOLIDAY IN EGYPT, WHERE HIS ELDEST
SON, BILL, WORKS AS A CLOTHES MAKER FOR GRINGOTT'S WIZARDING
BANK.

THE WEASLEY FAMILY WILL BE SPENDING A MONTH IN EGYPT, RETURNING
FOR THE START OF THE NEW SCHOOL YEAR AT HOGWARTS, WHICH FIVE OF
THE

WEASLEY CHILDREN CURRENTLY ATTEND.

HARRY SCANNED THE MOVING PICTOGRAPH, AND A GRIN SPREAD ACROSS HIS FACE

AS HE SAW ALL NINE OF THE WEASLEYS WAVING FLIRTELISLY AT HIM, STANDING IN

FRONT OF A LARGE PYRAMID. PLUMP LITTLE MRS. WEASLEY; TALL, BALDING MR.

WEASLEY; SIX SONS; AND ONE DAUGHTER, ALL (THOUGH THE BLACK-AND-WHITE

PICTURE DIDN'T SHOW IT) WITH FLAMING-RED HAIR, RIGHT IN THE MIDDLE OF THE

PICTURE WAS RON, TALL AND GAWLING, WITH HIS PET RAT, SCABBERS, ON HIS

SHOULDER AND HIS ARM AROUND HIS LITTLE SISTER, GINNY.

HARRY COULDN'T THINK OF ANYONE WHO DESERVED TO WIN A LARGE PILE OF GOLD

MORE THAN THE WEASLEYS, WHO WERE VERY NICE AND EXTREMELY POOR. HE

PICKED UP RON'S LETTER AND UNFOLDED IT.

DEAR HARRY,

HAPPY BIRTHDAY!

HEHE, I'M REALLY SORRY ABOUT THAT TELEPHONE CALL. I HOPE THE MUGGLES DIDN'T GIVE YOU A HARD TIME. I ASKED DAD, AND HE RECKONS I SHOULDN'T HAVE SHOUTED.

IT'S AMAZING HERE IN EGYPT. BILL'S TAKEN US AROUND ALL THE TEMPLES AND

YOU WOULDN'T BELIEVE THE CLASSES THERE HAD EGYPTIAN WIZARDS PUT ON THEM. MOM WOULDN'T LET GINNY COME IN THE LAST ONE. THERE WERE ALL

THESE MALIGNANT SKELETONS IN THERE, OF MUGGLES WHO'D DROPPED IN AND

GREEN EXTRA HEADS AND STUFF,

I COULDN'T BELIEVE IT WHEN DAD WENT THE DAILY PROPHET DRAW, SEVEN HUNDRED GALLEONS! MEET ME IT'S GONE IN THIS TRIP, BUT THEY'RE GOING TO

BUY ME A NEW WAND FOR NEXT YEAR.

HARRY REMEMBERED ONLY TOO WELL THE OCCASION WHEN RON'S OLD WAND HAD

SNAPPED. IT HAD HAPPENED WHEN THE CAR THE TWO OF THEM HAD BEEN FLYING THE

BEGLIANTS HAD CRASHED INTO A TREE IN THE SCREECHING GROUNDS.

WE'LL BE BACK ABOUT A WEEK BEFORE TERM STARTS AND WE'LL BE GOING UP TO LONDON TO GET MY WAND AND OUR NEW KIDS. ANY CHANCE OF MEETING YELL THERE?

DON'T LET THE MUGGLES GET YELL DOWN!

TRY AND CURE THE LONDON.

P.S. PERCY'S HEAD KEY. HE GOT THE LETTER LAST WEEK.

HARRY GLANCED BACK AT THE PHOTOGRAPH. PERCY, WHO WAS IN HIS SEVENTH AND

FINAL YEAR AT BEGLIANTS, WAS LOOKING PARTICULARLY SPLE. HE HAD PINNED HIS

HEAD KEY BADGE TO THE FEZ PERCHED ALAINTILY ON TOP OF HIS NEAT HAIR, HIS

THORN-RIMMED GLASSES FLASHING IN THE EGYPTIAN SUN.

HARRY NEEL TURNED TO HIS PRESENT AND UNWRAPPED IT. INSIDE WAS WHAT

LOOKED LIKE A MINIATURE GLASS SPINNING TOP. THERE WAS ANOTHER WHITE FROM

RON BENEATH IT.

HARRY THIS IS A PHEMET SNEAKESHOPE. IF THERE S SOMEONE
UNTRUSTWORTHY AROUND, IT S SLOPPED THE LIGHT UP AND SPIN. KILL
SAYS IT S
ALIKISH SHED HER LIZARD THELWISTS AND LSN T RELIABLE, BECAUSE IT KEPT
LIGHTING UP AT DINNER LAST NIGHT. BUT HE DIDN T REALIZE FRED AND
GEORGE
HAD PUT BEETLES IN HIS SHOULDER.

BYE

HARRY PUT THE PHEMET SNEAKESHOPE ON HIS BEDSIDE TABLE, WHERE IT
STOOD
GLITE STILL, BALANCED ON ITS POINT, REFLECTING THE LUMINOUS HANDS OF
HIS

CLOCK. HE LOOKED AT IT HAPPILY FOR A FEW SECONDS, THEN PICKED UP
THE PARCEL

HEDWIG HAD BROUGHT.

INSIDE THIS, THERE WAS A WRAPPED PRESENT, A CARD, AND A LETTER.
THIS

TIME FROM HERMIONE.

DEAR HARRY,

WHEN WRITE TO ME AND TELL ME ABOUT HIS PHONE CALL THE OTHER LITTLE
VERNON. I DO HOPE YOU ARE ALL RIGHT.

I M ON HOLIDAY IN FRANCE AT THE MOMENT AND I DIDN T KNOW HOW I
WAS GOING TO SEND THIS TO YOU WHAT IF THEY D OPENED IT AT
CUSTOMS?

BUT THEN HEDWIG TURNED UP! I THINK SHE WANTED TO MAKE SURE
YOU

GET SOMETHING FOR YOUR BIRTHDAY FOR A CHANGE, I REWROTE YOUR
PRESENT

BY HELL-HANDER, THERE WAS AN ADVERTISEMENT IN THE DAILY PROPHET
I'VE

BEEN GETTING IT DELIVERED, IT'S BEEN GOOD TO KEEP UP WITH WHAT'S
GOING ON

IN THE WIZARDING WORLD, DID YOU SEE THAT PICTURE OF RON AND HIS
FAMILY A WEEK AGO? I GET ME A LEARNING HEADS, I'M REALLY IMPRESSED
THE

ANCIENT EGYPTIAN WIZARDS WERE FASCINATING.

THERE'S SOME INTERESTING LOCAL HISTORY OF WITCHCRAFT HERE, TOO.
I'VE

REWRITTEN MY WHOLE HISTORY OF MAGIC ESSAY TO INCLUDE SOME OF THE
THINGS I'VE BEEN HEARD, I HOPE IT'S NOT TOO LONG IT'S TWO REELS
OF

PARCLEMENT MORE THAN PROFESSOR KINGS ASKED FOR.

RON SAYS HE'S GOING TO BE IN LONDON IN THE LAST WEEK OF THE
HOLIDAYS, CAN YOU MAKE IT? WILL YOUR AUNT AND UNCLE LET YOU
COME? I

REALLY HOPE YOU CAN, IF NOT, I'LL SEE YOU ON THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS
ON

SEPTEMBER FIRST!

LOVE FROM

P.S. RON SAYS PERCY'S HEAD BOY, I'LL GET PERCY'S REALLY PLEASED, RON
DIDN'T SEEM TOO HAPPY ABOUT IT.

HARRY LAUGHED AS HE PUT HERMIONE'S LETTER ASIDE AND PICKED UP
HIS

PRESENT. IT WAS VERY HEAVY, KNEELING HERMIONE, HE WAS SURE IT
WOULD BE A

LARGE BOOKS FULL OF VERY DIFFICULT SPELLS BUT IT WASN'T HIS HEART
GAVE A

FLICK BEHIND AS HE RIPPED BACK THE PAPER AND SAW A SLEEK BLACK
LEATHER CASE,

WITH SILVER LETTERS STAMPED ACROSS IT, READING BROOMSTICK SERVING
KIT.

WELL, FERMINE? HARRY WHISPERED, UNZIPPING THE CASE THE MOMENT
INSIDE.

THERE WAS A LARGE PAIR OF FLEETWHEELS & HIGH-FINISH HANDLE POKERS, A
PAIR

OF GLAMING SILVER TAIL-TWIG CLIPPERS, A TINY BRASS COMPASS THE
CLIP HAD BEEN

BROOMS FOR LONG HOURS, AND A HANDLEBROOM OF DEE-IT-YOURSELF
BROOMS.

APART FROM HIS FRIENDS, THE THING THAT HARRY MISSED MOST ABOUT
HOGWARTS WAS FLUIDITY, THE MOST POPULAR SPORT IN THE MAGICAL
WORLD

HIGHLY DANGEROUS, VERY EXCITING, AND PLAYED ON BROOMSTICKS.
HARRY

HAPPENED TO BE A VERY GOOD FLUIDITY PLAYER; HE HAD BEEN THE
BEST

PERSON IN A CENTURY TO BE PICKED FOR ONE OF THE HOGWARTS HOUSE
TEAMS, ONE

OF HARRY'S MOST PRIZED POSSESSIONS WAS HIS NIMBLE TWO
THOUSAND RACING

BROOM.

HARRY PUT THE LEATHER CASE ASIDE AND PICKED UP HIS LAST PARCEL, HE

RECOGNIZED THE WINTY SCRAWL ON THE BROWN PAPER AT ONCE: THIS
WAS FROM

HAGRID, THE HOGWARTS GAMEKEEPER, HE THREW OFF THE THIRD LAYER OF PAPER AND

GLIMPSED SOMETHING GREEN AND LEATHERY, BUT BEFORE HE COULD UNWRAP IT

PROPERLY, THE PARCEL GAVE A STRANGE SHIVER, AND WHATEVER WAS INSIDE IT

SNAPPED LOUDLY AS THOUGH IT HAD LIPS.

HARRY FREEZE. HE KNEW THAT HAGRID WOULD NEVER SEND HIM ANYTHING DANGEROUS FOR PURPOSE, BUT THEN, HAGRID DIDN'T HAVE A NORMAL PERSON'S VIEW

OF WHAT WAS DANGEROUS. HAGRID HAD BEEN KNOWN FOR KEEPING GIANT SPIDERS,

AND VIOLETS, THREE-HEADED DOGS FROM MEN IN BLACK, AND SNEAKING ILLEGAL DRAGONS

EGGS INTO HIS CARRIAGE.

HARRY PEEKED THE PARCEL NERVOUSLY. IT SNAPPED LOUDLY AGAIN. HARRY

REACHED FOR THE LAMP ON HIS BEDSIDE TABLE, GRIPPED IT FIRMLY IN ONE HAND,

AND RAISED IT OVER HIS HEAD, READY TO STRIKE. THEN HE SEIZED THE REST OF THE

WRAPPING PAPER IN HIS OTHER HAND AND PULLED.

AND HEIT FELT A SHOCK. HARRY HAD JUST HAD TIME TO REGISTER ITS HANDSOME

GREEN COVER, EMBELLISHED WITH THE GILDED TITLE THE MINISTER SHOCK

MINISTERS, BEFORE IT FLIPPED ON ITS EDGE AND SLITTLED SIDEWAYS ALONG THE

FLOOR LIKE SOME WEIRD CRAB.

WHEN HARRY MUTTERED,

THE KNEE THROPPED OFF THE BED WITH A HEAVY CLUNK AND SLIPPED RAPIDLY

ACROSS THE ROOM, HARRY FOLLOWED IT STEALTHILY. THE KNEE WAS HIDING IN THE

DARK SPACE UNDER HIS DESK, PRAYING THAT THE DURSLEYS WERE STILL FAST ASLEEP.

HARRY GOT DOWN ON HIS HANDS AND KNEES AND REACHED TOWARD IT.

CLICK!

THE KNEE SNAPPED SHUT ON HIS HAND AND THEN FLAPPED PAST HIM, STILL

SLUTTLING ON ITS LEVERS. HARRY STRAMBLED AROUND, THREW HIMSELF FORWARD,

AND MANAGED TO FLATTEN IT. LUCIE VERNEEN GAVE A HEAVY, SLEEPY GRUNT IN THE

ROOM NEXT DOOR.

HEDWIG AND KAREL WATCHED INTERESTEDLY AS HARRY CLAMPED THE STRUGGLING

KNEE TIGHTLY IN HIS ARMS, HURRIED TO HIS CHEST OF DRAWERS, AND PULLED OUT A

KEY, WHICH HE CLICKED TIGHTLY AROUND IT. THE MINSTER KNEE SHLOBBED

ANGRILY, BUT COULD NO LONGER FLAP AND SNAP, SEE HARRY THREW IT DOWN ON THE

BED AND REACHED FOR HARRY'S CARD.

DEAR HARRY,

HAPPY BIRTHDAY!

THEIR VELT MIGHT FIND THIS USEFUL FOR NEXT YEAR. WHEN I SAY NO MORE

HERE, TELL THEM WHEN I SEE THEM.

I HOPE THE MUGGLES ARE TREATING THEM RIGHT.

ALL THE BEST,

HARRY

IT STRUCK HARRY AS EMINENTLY THAT HARRY THEMSELVES A BITING REPLY
WOULD

COME IN USEFUL, BUT HE PUT HARRY'S CARD UP NEXT THE QUEEN'S AND
HERMION'S.

GRINNING MORE BROADLY THAN EVER, WHEN THERE WAS ONLY THE LETTER
FROM

HEGWARTS LEFT.

NOTING THAT IT WAS RATHER THICKER THAN USUAL, HARRY SLIT OPEN
THE

ENVELOPE, PULLED OUT THE FIRST PAGE OF PARCHMENT WITHIN, AND READ:

DEAR MR. POTTER,

PLEASE NOTE THAT THE NEW SCHOOL YEAR WILL BEGIN ON SEPTEMBER THE
FIRST. THE HEGWARTS EXPRESS WILL LEAVE FROM KING'S CROSS STATION,
PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS, AT ELEVEN O'CLOCK.

THIRD YEARS ARE PERMITTED TO VISIT THE VILLAGE OF HOGSMEADE ON
CERTAIN WEEKENDS. PLEASE GIVE THE ENCLOSED PERMISSION FROM THE
MUM

PARENT OR GUARDIAN THE SIGN.

A LIST OF BOOKS FOR NEXT YEAR IS ENCLOSED.

YOURS SINCERELY,

DEPUTY HEADMISTRESS

HARRY PULLED OUT THE HOGSMOORE PERMISSION FORM AND LOOKED AT IT,
NEE

LONGER GRINNING. IT WOULD BE WONDERFUL TO VISIT HOGSMOORE ON
WEEKENDS;

HE KNEW IT WAS AN ENTIRELY WIZARDING VILLAGE, AND HE HAD NEVER SET
FOOT

THERE, BUT HOW ON EARTH WAS HE GOING TO PERSUADE UNCLE VERNON
AND ALINT

PETUNIA TO SIGN THE FORM?

HE LOOKED OVER AT THE ALARM CLOCK. IT WAS NOW TWO IN THE
MORNING.

DECIDING THAT HE'D BETTER ASK THE HOGSMOORE FORM WHEN HE WOK
UP,

HARRY GOT BACK INTO BED AND REACHED UP TO CROSS OFF ANOTHER DAY
ON THE

CHART HE'D MADE FOR HIMSELF, CELEBRATING BEING THE DAYS LEFT UNTIL HIS
RETURN TO

HOGWARTS. THEN HE TOOK OFF HIS GLASSES AND LAY DOWN, EYES SHUT,
FACING HIS

THREE BIRTHDAY CARDS.

EXTREMELY UNUSUAL THOUGH HE WAS, AT THAT MOMENT HARRY POTTER
FELT JUST

LIKE EVERYONE ELSE GLAD, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE, THAT IT WAS
HIS

BIRTHDAY.

THE END OF HARRY POTTER AND THE PRISONER OF AZKABAN, AND ANY OF THE
OTHER

BOOKS IN THE HARRY POTTER SERIES, VISIT THE POTTERMORE SHOP.

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